PiCo
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Pico

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WELCOME TO PICO

Greetings, those-who-would-be-tiny-bugs,

And welcome to the full release of PICO! I'm Felix Isaacs, creator of *The Wildsea* and *Wild Words Engine* and, now, this!

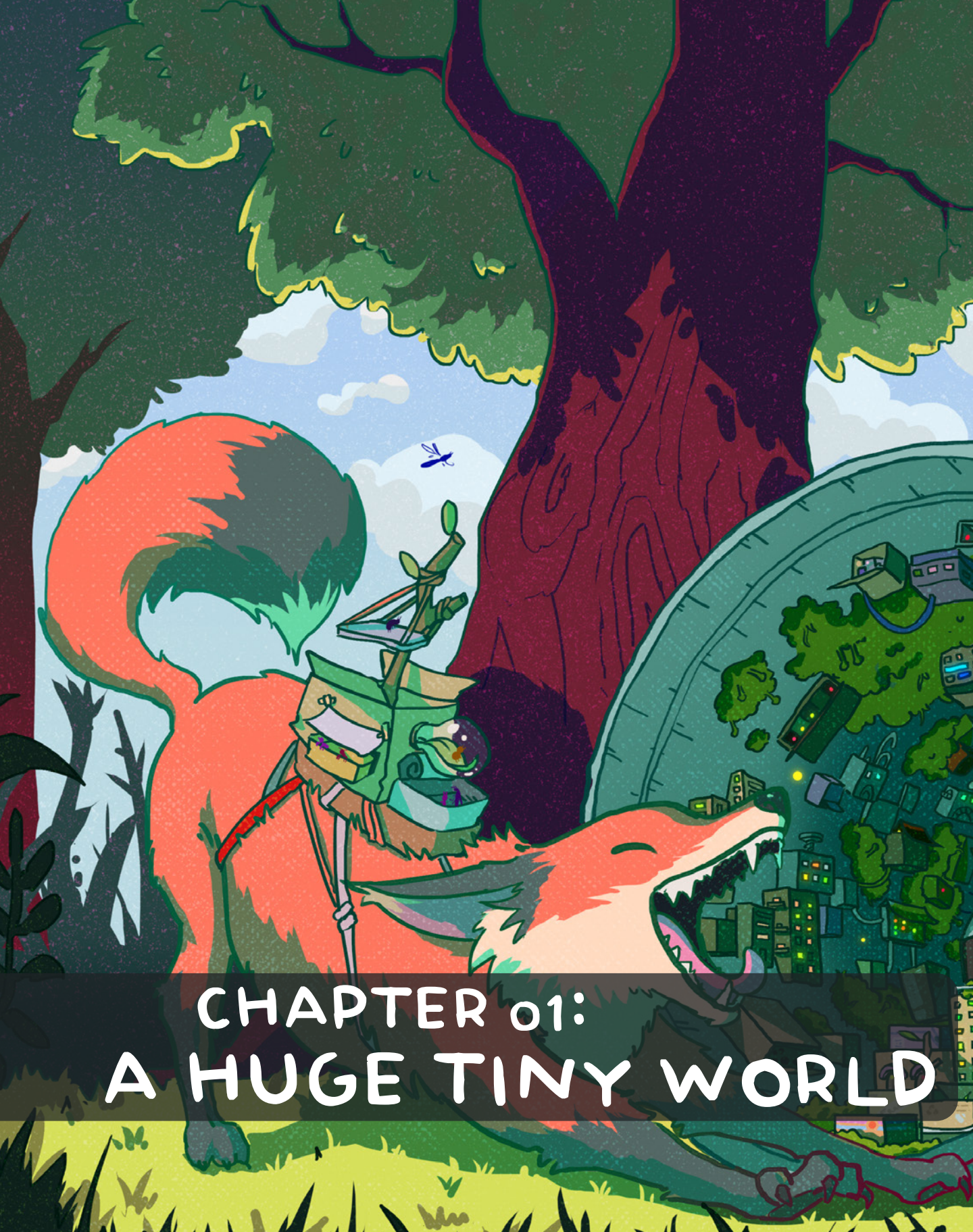
What you have on the page (or screen, if you're going to be all modern) in front of you is the finished version of PICO, a much larger game than I ever had in mind when I first contracted zkarab to draw me some cute bugs back in 2021. This was, after all, as my publisher has pointed out to me numerous times, initially meant to be a quick, 60-page project.

... I may have overshot a little there.

But hopefully you enjoy the end result, so without any additional preamble I'll let the you turn the page and (hopefully) enjoy embodying some tiny bugs.

Good luck, piconauts - its a big world out there.

- Felix


CHAPTER 01:
A HUGE TINY WORLD

CORE CONCEPTS

1. Everyone is bugs. All characters in PICO are bugs, and probably pretty cute. That doesn't mean bad things don't happen, but that they're going to be tiny in scope for the most part.

2. It's a huge world. The counterpart to tiny bugs, the world of PICO is massive - not just in terms of the area there is to explore, but in relative size. Things that bugs make are bug-sized, but things from the old world are sized for humans (or sometimes even bigger).

3. There are no humans left. Is PICO post-apocalyptic? Most definitely. Cans, boxes, houses, and numerous small objects have survived. It wasn't a violent apocalypse - there's no nuclear fallout to deal with, or hideous mutants. Humans are just... gone. Maybe there's a skeleton somewhere but, as far as the bugs are concerned, those are basically just a part of the landscape.

4. Frogs are scary. Other things are scary too. The world of PICO is a dangerous one for travellers, but pretty safe in societies where bug-eating animals are kept at bay. There should be wonder and danger in equal measure.

5. Picotitans are the safest way to travel. When the world seems too big to tackle, get a bigger friend to help you out. Picotitans are things like cats, foxes, moles, or rabbits that bugs can befriend and ride, sometimes making little huts on their back or head to stay safe. Picotitans won't fight bugs for you - they've been trained not to, after all - but they might fight other titanic creatures, or scare away other threats.

6. Cute and weird rule the day. Weird is always good in a Wild Words game, but here it's tempered by cute. The characters, threats, and elements of the world can get strange, sometimes even scary, but there's an adorable underpinning to most situations.

7. The aim of the game is to solve tiny problems. What's a tiny problem? A village being attacked by a squirrel, or a farm needing extra help with the harvest, or rescuing a lost explorer. The hazards and challenges of PICO shouldn't revolve around killing, but rather finding creative ways to solve problems. This doesn't mean no violence, but it *does* mean no cruelty.

THE WORLD OF PICO

Let me tell you a story.

There was a night, many, many years ago, when everything ended. Bugs aren't that great at writing things down, so nobody really thought to record the particulars of the event, but the effects were lasting; no more pesticides, no more deforestation, no more fish hooks or bait boxes or flypaper. Pets ran free from newly quiet houses, and roach motels showed nothing but vacancies.

There's probably a lesson to be learned somewhere there. Something about the fleeting fragility of existence, a treatise on impermanence, and what we might leave behind.

But, as stated, bugs aren't that great at writing things down. They're even worse at existential musing, as a rule.

So the biggest change that most bugs noticed that night was that it suddenly got a lot quieter, especially near those black stone ribbons they'd learned not to cross, and the immense above-ground warrens full of beeping machines and smells so succulent they were almost impossible to resist.

The world hadn't suddenly become safe - there were still stoats to contend with, and lizards, and snappy little plants. A bug might still meet their end on the beak of a bird, or (if they were particularly unlucky in the lottery of life) under the playful claws of a feline deity. But it had become *safer*, and though bugs may not be great at recording history, they're pretty damn good at making the best of whatever situation they find themselves in.

So bugs, on the whole, flourished.

And the world opened up to them in return.

THE MYSTERIOCALYPSE

Where did all the humans go?

Don't know. I don't think it matters that much, really.

They were definitely there for a good long while, which is an impressive achievement for things that were so staggeringly big and monumentally slow-moving. You'd have thought they'd get bored at some point and go away. That might even have been what happened.

But to give a more serious answer, it doesn't *matter* where all the humans went, or at least not where *I* think they went. The world of PICO is set out in this book, to an extent, but it's also a world you'll be making together at the table - if 'where did all the humans go' is a question you want to answer as part of your game, feel free to do just that!

There are some things mentioned later that might give a few hints. The figure relaxing in front of the Shining Mountain on page 293 is most definitely a skeleton, for example... Someone that died while watching TV. And whatever happened, it only seems to have affected humans. Maybe that's a mystery to solve.

But really, the end of all humanity that PICO posits is just to get the giants out of the way, a chance for the smaller types to have their moment in the spotlight.

THEMES

PICO may not have answers to every mystery it presents, but it definitely has a few themes. I'll list them here, in no particular order. Let's start with...

COMMUNITY

The world of PICO is massive, especially when you're playing as a character that's probably no more than an inch high. Travelling across a garden might take hours, and a stroll through the forest might be a weeks-long endeavour. Going it alone is a good way to get eaten, so bugs tend to band together whenever they can. There are lone wolves and hermits, as you might expect, but they're the exception - as a rule, the more people you can rely on, the safer you'll be. Get out there and make some chitinous friends!

CREATIVITY

PICO is built using the Wild Words Engine, which means (among other things) that the narrative comes first. You describe what you're trying to do, or what your intentions are, and *then* the rules come into play.

This comes into its own when the bugs have a problem to solve. It's not just that there's no one way to succeed at something, but that there's usually no right way - or every way is right, perhaps. When the bugs come face to face with a toad barbarian, maybe they pelt it with stones, or brandish tiny swords. Maybe they run for the hills, spinning up dust-storms in their wake. Maybe they cook it a hasty meal to distract it, or baffle it with riddles, or try to make friends with it, or just sic a nearby fox on it and watch the ensuing carnage. As a rule, interesting approaches should garner interesting results.

ADVENTURE

It comes with the territory. Literally.

There's a whole world out there to explore, and doing so is going to come with its fair share of challenges. That garden we mentioned? Maybe the locals live in fear of a terrifying feathered beast, the Starling-By-Morning, and need some help scaring it away. Maybe a slug left their favourite bottlecap under the gazebo, and is willing to pay fresh mushrooms to anyone that can go and get it for them. Perhaps there's a conflict between two tiny societies, or an incoming storm that a village needs to bolster itself against, or a spider that's spun a map into their web that they swear leads to an ancient treasure.

As bugs, your job is to explore the world and face the challenges it throws at you. Even the simplest journey can be a grand adventure with the right mindset.

INFLUENCES

Nothing lasts forever, but some things leave one hell of an impression.

PICO wouldn't exist if I'd never read the Discworld books, by Terry Pratchett, which taught me that weird fiction could take itself less seriously from time to time without sacrificing heart and meaning.

There's also very little chance I'd have spent this long making a game about bugs if I'd never played Hollow Knight. And who knows, maybe Silksong will be out by the time this goes to print? *Note: It is, but only just!*

In terms of mechanics, the Wild Words Engine that this game runs on wouldn't have been possible without influence (and occasional nuts-and-bolts course correction) from the following cavalcade of video games and TRPGs.

+ Sunless Sea (and the StoryNexus Engine)
+ Heart, the City Beneath (by Rowan, Rook & Deckard)
+ 13th Age (and the Rogue Elements podcast)
+ Blades in the Dark (and the Six Towers Gang)
+ Tunic, Hyperlight Drifter, and the Legend of Zelda

TONE & CONTENT

PICO is designed to be cute, to be fun, to be reasonably wholesome and, most importantly, not to be taken too seriously. Ideally, I would stop this section here and let you delve deeper into the book with reckless, page-devouring abandon.

But as we mentioned in the 'themes' section, PICO is a game about adventure and exploration in a world that's much bigger than the characters you play as. There's potential danger there - the sting of loss, the fear of death, and the special kind of heartache brought on by the betrayal of a friend. These aren't all things that a bug **must** experience, but they are things that a bug **might** experience.

So before you play, talk to your table. Get together as a group. Do you want your chitinous camaraderie to have a darker edge to it, or are you going to immerse yourself in a warm bath of cute? As long as you're all on the same page, you should be good.

Oh, and there's a snail smoking a cigarette on page 199. He's not doing it because he's cool though, so it's probably alright.

BUGS!

"I met a traveller from an antique land, who said 'Two vast and trunkless legs of stone stand in the desert... Near them, on the sand, half sunk a shattered visage lies - ' but I cut him off with a few pertinent questions. What's a trunk? Like, a thorax, or...? And what exactly is a desert?"

Bugs are small. There are many other things about them that make them special, but the one thing they all have in common is that they're on the tiny side.

Just about everything else is mutable, to an extent. Some bugs have six legs, some four, some eight... Some bugs don't have any legs at all, and just squirm their way from place to place like it's the most natural thing in the world. Eyes are just as varied, in terms of both size and number, and let's not even get started on the variety of shells, colours, and weird little spiky bits. The crawling kingdom is one of endless multitudes, and no two families within it are exactly the same.

Being a Bug

As a human (presumably, anyway), you may have idly wondered what it would be like to be a bug. Well, consider this a crash course in everything insectile, arachnid, and unusually slimy.

Bugs Don't Differentiate

Starting off with a lie probably isn't the best way to do things, but it's what I'm going with. Bugs obviously *do* differentiate, as the differences between, say, a tarantula and a caterpillar are pretty striking. But what they *don't* do is assume character based on physical form. Scorpions may have a reputation for ferocity, but most of them are absolute sweethearts. Pillbugs might seem cute and harmless, but the most famous bounty hunter in the world is three of them standing on each other's shoulders wearing a single jacket between them. Remember the golden rule - just because someone looks like they might eat me, doesn't mean they're actually going to.

Bugs Make Great Friends

Make friends with a bug and you'll have a companion for life - small types stick together.

Since the Mysteriocalypse gave the world a bit of a shake-up, bugs have roamed farther and wider than ever before. But they rarely do it alone - diverse adventuring groups are an increasingly common sight, bugs from different families banding together to explore, solve problems, and seek out tasty treats.

Bugs are Resilient as All Hell

You might think it's the shells, but you'd be wrong. Well, partially. According to the leading voices in bug science, bugs are extremely difficult to kill, or even seriously harm, because 'we're just made that way, better not question it'. While this may be a failure of the scientific method, it's true nonetheless. Bugs can take a lot of knocks before they get sent down for the count, and give them a bit of sugar water and they're liable to bounce right back up again. Especially bees.

What bugs **aren't** is invincible. Bigger threats, especially those with a taste for scuttling sorts, hit with the kind of force that even a bug has difficulty withstanding. The good news is, other bugs can hit back just as hard if the situation is right, especially if they all work together.

Bugly Names

Each bug has two names - the one they use when they're referring to themselves casually, and the one that describes *exactly* what they are. *You'll find more about names on page 168, but here's a brief overview...*

CHOSEN NAMES: There aren't many naming conventions for a bug to follow outside of whatever they think sounds cool. You might travel with Lit Von Chucker, bottlecap golfer extraordinaire, and then sit down for a picnic dinner with Long Dave.

PSEUDOSCIENTIFIC NAMES: These are created from multiple small sound segments that snap together like legally distinct plastic building blocks, each part referring to the particulars of a bug's anatomy (and sometimes the things they habitually carry around). Lit Von Chucker up there is technically a 'hard-shelled small-eyed quadrapod', or 'Anthotoriki Toxromoteva' if you want to get technical.

Bugs are Ingenious

This one has been true since the first bug flopped out of the briny sea and decided to give this whole 'air breathing' thing a go. It's a natural instinct for almost all bugs to not only adapt to their environment, but to adapt their environment to them. Some hunt by weaving elaborate trapdoors, others use their own moulted shells as natural distractions or ornamentation, and a whole load of them can look at two disparate bits of trash and forge them together into a workable tool. And with the smorgasbord of bits and bobs scattered around the post-Mysteriocalypse world, that latter lot have really been given the opportunity to shine.

Bugs are Naturally Inqusitive

Even the most sedate stick insect experiences a brief flutter of passion at the sight of new vistas, or has to hide their enthusiasm for a particularly well-told story of distant shores. There's something baked into the average bug brain that drives them to want to learn more about the world they live in, and the experiences they can gain from it. It may not be universal, but it's common enough to mention it here - the only thing most bugs love more than being presented with a problem to solve is the satisfaction in knowing that they've solved it.

THE SIZE OF LIFE

You'll find references to size are pretty common throughout PICO. I mean, it's right there in the name - it's a game about tiny things! But even in a world where (almost) everything is tiny, *relative* size still matters; one bug might struggle to wade through a pile of waist-high dust while their companion steps over it without breaking their stride. With this in mind, we've given the rest of this page over to a **size comparison chart**, stacking the kind of bugs you'll be playing as against various food items to help with your theatre of the mind.

NANO: Somewhere between a granule of sugar and a grain of rice.
This covers everything from ticks to ants, ladybugs to aphids. Nano bugs are small enough that even things appropriately sized for the scuttling world might be a tad too big for them, but often have the power and gumption to get by just fine regardless. *Speaking pseudoscientifically, some bugs are so small that a human eye (if there were any of those around) would barely be able to see them, like dust mites and bacteria. They technically fit in the nano category too, but don't tend to interact with buggish society.*

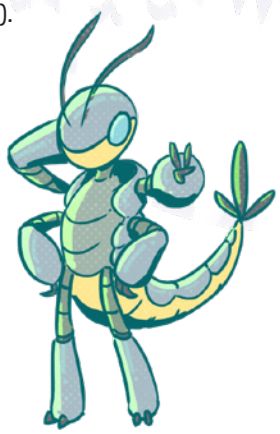
SMALL: Somewhere between the size of a blueberry and a sprout.
This encompasses the average dimensions of a vast majority of bugs, being about the size where one could wield a bottlecap as a shield and a sewing needle as a sword if they so wished. Bumblebees, wasps, various garden beetles, and earthworms are all good examples. *If someone is talking about a bug and they don't specify the size, it's usually safe to assume that they're small.*

LARGE: Somewhere between the size of a post-shrinkflation candy bar and a can of off-brand soda.
Now these are *big* bugs, likely the biggest most of the denizens of the world of PICO would ever hope (or want) to see. Heftier butterflies and very hungry caterpillars weigh in at the smaller end of this category, while tarantulas, centipedes, and the occasional hercules beetle occupy the upper end. *Still tiny compared to a cat or a dog, but giants in the scuttling world; large sized bugs sometimes have trouble moving around in settlements that aren't made to accommodate them.*

HUGE: Maybe the size of a packet of bacon, or a carton of twelve eggs.
Usually reserved for the non-scuttling denizens of the world of PICO, like toads, stoats, and pangolins. *But are there huge bugs out there too? Most definitely, but they're usually the product of weird nuclear stuff, or from learning to be predator rather than prey where beasts are concerned.*

TITAN: Even bigger than a roast chicken.
Not actually pictured on this page because it *literally would not fit*, the titan size is almost exclusively reserved for larger beasts (like cats and foxes). *There are rumours that bugs were once this size, but... Well, let's hope those days are long past for the good of everyone involved.*

NANO



SMALL

LARGE

THE UPPER AND LOWER LIMITS

The characters of PICO, the bugs you'll be making to play this game, **are small size by default**. Options for playing **large** and **nano** bugs exist (and you can turn to page 130 if you want to take a look at those), but we recommend sticking to **small** if you're new.

DOES SIZE REALLY MATTER?

While the size of a bug can sometimes affect the mechanics of the game, it's far more common for it to have an effect on the *fiction*. Remember to make the sizes of various things clear as you play – to a bug, almost everything that hasn't been made by other bugs is probably pretty big!

HUGE

TITAN

ADVENTURING BANDS & REASONS TO ROAM

As we mentioned before, bugs tend to be naturally inquisitive sorts. And, with a world so wide and vast and strange spreading out in all directions, can you really blame them?

So for every few bugs that decide to settle down and carve out a place to call their own, there's another driven by the inescapable urge to *wander*. For this second sort, the horizon isn't just a distant vista, it's an invitation - a challenge. Just how far can you go, and what might you see when you get there? What tales will you take home when you're done, if you ever head home at all?

This feeling, this deep and beautiful wanderlust, is the drive behind the formation of **adventuring bands**: groups of bugs pulled together by the joys of travel, and forged into better versions of themselves by the challenges and opportunities that their journeys provide. And for some of these bands, life really is that simple - you follow the road, or head off of the beaten path, and turn your life into the kind of story that a bard would sing about.

... Or, at least, that's how things would be in an ideal world.

So, for a more balanced view, let's take a look at a few of the other reasons bugs head out into the uncertain dangers of the post-Mysteriocalypse, and what they may hope to achieve while they're out there - some **reasons to roam**. *The reasons on the right are only a handful of common examples - who really knows why any bug does anything?*

For the Excitement of it All

Stable communities have their perks, but even the safest, friendliest environs can feel like a cage if they're all you ever see. For some bugs, heading out into unfamiliar pastures offers the chance at excitement and adventure, the kind of surprises a normal day-to-day just can't supply. *Bugs adventuring for the excitement of it all might...*

- » See themselves as heroes in search of a quest, or a dragon to slay.
- » Be willing to trade boredom for danger... up to a point.
- » Want to take part in a cool story that gets told to grubs at bedtime.
- » Just need a break from the daily routine, the kind of holiday where you might get eaten.
- » Want to prove themselves to the folks back home.

For Treasures or Essentials

Two opposite ends of the same spectrum, the treasure hunter and the selfless gatherer. They're both in it for the pickings, whatever they can scrounge up and take with them, but their motives decide where those picking end up. *Bugs adventuring for treasures or essentials might...*

- » Be trying to provide for a family, or an entire community, back home.
- » Seek specific pieces for a museum or construction.
- » Jealously hoard whatever they can get their little grippers on.
- » Have a shopping list that just needs ticking off.
- » Be in search of something that may not even exist.

For an Opportunity to Learn

There's no teacher better than the open road, or at least that's the sort of thing that bugs wearing open-toed sandals and carrying self-carved walking sticks would say. But they're right, when you get down to it - travel broadens the mind, and the further afield you go, the more you can learn. *Bugs adventuring for an opportunity to learn might...*

- » Have a mystery to solve, or a problem that they're driven to find the answer to.
- » Want to experience different cultures, and learn from bugs and beasts that they'd never normally meet.
- » Be writing a book or travel-guide, taking notes on everything that catches their eye.
- » Have a hunger for sights unseen, foods never before tasted, songs never before played.

For a New Place to Call Home

Not exactly the happiest of reasons for joining or forming an adventuring band, but hardly a rare one either. Some bugs, due to circumstances they may or may not keep to themselves, just need to find a new place to hang their hat. *Bugs adventuring for a new place to call home might...*

- » Have left their home settlements voluntarily, or been exiled due to some hideous faux pas.
- » Have a destination in mind, maybe even one they visited a long time before.
- » Be trying to earn acceptance from their travelling companions along the way.
- » Just need a fresh start. Hey, it happens.

"Why are we out here? Well, that's a big question. Julien, they're after a picotitan of their very own, Paarl's on some sort of quest, and Gnash... Well, I think Gnash just might be hungry."

Mondo the Swift, Snail Wayfinder

Going on Adventures

"One more step, Mr. Bofro, and I'll be the farthest from... Oh bugger, I've lost count."

The winding road. The sun-kissed horizon. The smell of an unfamiliar dish. Adventuring is, as most bugs would tell you, definitely *where it's at*. But what actually *is* an adventure, when you get right down to it?

Well, it's a chance to explore the world! To see things you haven't seen before, to do things you wouldn't normally do. To take risks, and to face challenges. To learn, and to overcome tough situations alongside the rest of your adventuring band. To make friends, and maybe even enemies. *Below you'll find a little guidance on what your bugs will likely end up doing as they traverse the world of PICO in an adventuring band, starting with...*

Solving Tiny Problems

A band of punk locusts that keep eating the nearby crops before they can bloom. A mole tunneling under the foundations of an insect metropolis. A lost grub that sniffles out a request for help.

These are tiny problems, the kinds of thing a roving party of boisterous bugs are just the right sorts to solve. Everywhere you travel you'll find new tiny problems to solve, and when you solve enough of them, you might end up...

Solving Bigger Problems

You see, the average person just wants to live a life that they can enjoy. Bugs want that even more than most.

The core loop of PICO focuses on just that - bringing a measure of harmony back to places that have gone just a little bit wrong. Most bigger problems are really a slew of tiny problems bundled together, and once enough of those little issues are solved, you'll find that life improves for locals and travelling bugs alike.

Getting into Scrapes

That doesn't mean it's going to be easy! The problems may be tiny, but so are the folk trying to solve them. There's danger out there in the big wild world, the kind that's best faced with friends at your side and a hastily-thrown-together plan in your brainbox. Some encounters are physical, some social... and others are just plain weird. But they can all be solved if you push the right buttons, talk to the right people, and sometimes knock a few heads together if you really have to.

Learning Stuff

They say a change is as good as a rest, and while that has very little to do with learning, I felt obligated to shoehorn that bit of wisdom in there somewhere. Bugs are small, but their dreams and ambitions tend to err on the bigger side of things - learning how to achieve their goals, and how to help others do the same, is the butter to adventuring's bread.

Visiting New Places

But where do you find these problems, these scrapes, these folk from which to learn? New places, of course! Travel broadens the mind (a quote that actually fits this section, much better than that last one I used), and it also brings with it a festival of challenges to face and obstacles to overcome. For the average adventurer, a day where you find a new place, solve some problems of both the tiny and bigger variety, and get a little reward at the end? That's the best kind of day you can have.

Do you need to have a goal?

So you've got your band of bugs together and you're ready to head out, but you don't exactly have an idea of where you're going. That's totally fine! You're small folk in a world so stuffed with wonders that you could barely hope to see a fraction of them in a hundred lifetimes, so if you're just looking for new experiences, pick a direction and get moving! You're sure to find things to do along the way.

SETTLEMENTS

"Wherever I lay my hat, that's where my hat is."

Travel, danger, and adventure are the salt, pepper, and indeterminate spice of life, and friendship is the meat (possibly). But every good dinner needs a helping of potatoes, and the potatoes of the bug world are settlements - solid, safe, and a great place to relax in.

... Ideally.

Okay, that's what we *want* to say. More accurately, most bugly settlements hit about one and a half to two of those three benefits listed above, depending on their location, the bugs that live there, their neighbours (in terms of both beast and environment), and the cultures and practices of each place.

Don't expect five-star lodgings, essentially.

SETTLEMENTS OF PARTICULAR NOTE

Bugs get everywhere, but they don't *stay* everywhere. For bugs to make a place their home, there usually needs to be something special about it - an existing defensive structure, a useful natural resource, or even something as simple as an incredible view. Here are a few settlements that have sprung up in the years since the Mysteriocalypse, the kind that bugs would pass rumours of around a campfire as the night draws in.

BIG SHADE

A spiralling city that climbs up and around the outside of an oak tree out in the true wilds, in the shadow of the branches almost every moment of every day. Big Shade is known for explosive and sudden local festivals, signalled to start whenever the movement of clouds, leaves, and branches gives them more than a few seconds of direct sunlight - it's not unusual for a Big Shade festival to start with zero preparation and last less than a minute (though it's impressive how much dancing and drinking can be done during that time).

RIVERBOOF

A bit of a mistake, this one was. The bugs that founded it were particularly short-sighted, and the 'river' they took as a source of great travelling potential was actually a large pond with a continual whirlpool in the centre. The water runs, but it won't take you anywhere other than back around to the town or down the central drain. Legends speak of an underpond city below Riverboof, a refuge for surfers eaten by the swirl and unable to reach the surface again.

THE COLA MOONS

A series of old soda cans hanging from a tangle of washing lines, each can converted to a home or storefront accessed only from above. Not the kind of place one explores without a good head for heights, and maybe a bit of silken safety rope.

CRANIOPOLIS

Named, apparently, for the yellow-white monument that stands in the central plaza, this is a city of hard work and impressive architecture. Tin cans, cardboard boxes, and twig shelters all blend together into one bugly urban sprawl, with salvaged bulbs strung up at various points ensuring a 24/7 active lifestyle.

LILY'S LOOK

Built on the sloping expanse of an old megastructure's roof, the bugs of Lily's Look split their time between moss-farming and politics. The local jackdaws ceded some slates to the bugs in the early days, but relationships have been strained ever since.

THE BRASS SECTION

Heard for a hundred strides in all directions, the inhabitants of this instrumental graveyard go through their entire lives with cotton wool strapped to whatever they have that acts as ears. Windy days are particularly difficult to stand, especially for visitors.

GRASP

Not a place for the faint of heart, the entire village of Grasp is built into the open maw of a titanic venus fly trap. Hardly the most easygoing place, local ordinances have a particular focus on preventing any activity that might cause their predatory foundation to close. Why don't they live somewhere else? Because bugs don't give up, that's why!

... AND THE CHANGING TIMES

Some habits may die hard, but change is the name of the game when considering the chitinous future.

Old world bugs pretty much kept themselves to themselves. Oh, they mingled, sure, and sometimes even cooperated, but most had a hive, nest, or mound to go home to that was filled with family and very little else. Part of it was practical, as comfortable living conditions for an ant are little more than a series of doorframe-related head trauma opportunities for a praying mantis. But some of it was good old-fashioned self-preservation, and a somewhat unhealthy lack of trust.

But in the bright age of friendship and camaraderie that typifies most of the modern bugly world, those insular generational instincts have been cleaned away like so many cobwebs (sorry, spiders). Now the majority of bugs are born in diverse scuttling societies, settlements made with the teamwork of many different clades and families working together.

THE COMFORTS OF HOME

So with such a big exciting world out there, why would bugs spend any time in the more cityish portions of it? Let's count some ways...

TO TRADE

One of the biggest benefits of a stable community is that it brings opportunities for trade, and trade brings connections and trust. Howling Gutter needs stone, but can give water in return? That's an opportunity for travellin' bugs to snaffle up a whole load of stone and take it to the gutter for a big, watery reward.

TO EAT

Campfire food is good, but you can work wonders with a full kitchen. Restaurants, eateries, and street-carts are all a common sight in bugly settlements, and cafes serving tiny pastries and thimbles of coffee can give a wanderer a good zesty kick before they head back out into the big wide world.

TO LEARN

The road teaches harsh lessons, and sometimes one wants a classroom with a little less danger and a little more in the way of dust and chalk. There aren't many centres of higher learning, but lots of settlements have a master or two within them that's willing to teach their skills for odds and ends from exciting locations, or for a bit of wood-chopping (or whatever other odd jobs need doing).

TO PREPARE

While this doesn't sound quite as fun as the other options, it's definitely a good idea. Preparing before a long journey might come in the form of trading away older bits and bobs for fresh new ones, kitting yourself out with special tools that will help on the road ahead, or hiring a picotitan to make longer, more difficult journeys significantly easier. Information is power, too - rumours and uncovered mysteries passed around by the locals might make the difference between stumbling upon a beautiful, refreshing waterfall and stumbling *into* the den of some cannibalistic spiders.

"The open road? Nah, forget it - all the excitement I could ever want is here, at the CAPGOLF ANNUAL FEBRUARY FRENZY TOURNAMENT, BABYYYYYY!!!!!"

Lit Von Chucker, Five-Time Capgolf Champion

Letting off steam

Ever had a massage from a millipede? It'll change your life. Whether a massive bugtropolis or a tiny insect hamlet, there are always a couple of ways to blow off steam once you're safely insulated from the wilds, enough to give this particular comfort a special section all of its own. When taking a break from the wide open world, you might want to seek out...

Festivals

A time to let your metaphorical hair down and forget the troubles of the road, bugs really know how to usher in a festival atmosphere. Even smaller parties can do you a world of good, as long as you aren't the kind of bug that stands in a corner nursing a single sip of Nectar for an entire night. Or maybe even if you are!

Taverns

An excellent way to combine the useful task of gathering information with a cool drink and a game of ball-bearing pool, pubs, bars, and gardens allow you to revel in (relative) safety and leave with a positive mood. Just try not to drink to excess or, if you do, make sure you've got a friend to carry you to whatever temporary lodgings you've managed to secure.

Performances

From theatre troupes to battling bands, from jugglers to eager dancers, civilization is where the money is when you're a performing type. You might even find a mime, though I have no idea why you'd want to - there are enough horrors out there off of the beaten path.

Sporting events

After tangling with deadly foes and defying danger at every turn while out beyond the realms of the civilized, sometimes it's good to turn all that skill and passion toward a safer outlet, one with more rules and less chance of being unexpectedly eaten.

Races, team games, and tests of skill have long been staples of bugly downtime, and when exploring a settlement, you might find the chance to engage in...

- **Capgolf**: An absolute classic, throwing bottlecaps at distant hoops and walking oddly long distances.
- **Bugby**: A game of bugby typically ends when only one team's members are left standing. Scores are sometimes kept, often ignored.
- **Spoutclimbing**: A favourite of spiders, a combination of rhythm-based karaoke and rapid ascension.

NOT-BUGS

"Variety's the very spice of life. And cinnamon of death, if you ask me. Can't stand the stuff."

With so many different kinds of bugs in the world, you'd be forgiven for assuming that they're the default. It's a veritable world of bugs, after all - surely there's not space for anything else?

Well, hypothetical ruminator, that's where you'd be wrong.

While the characters in the world of PICO are bugs, and most of the NPCs that players will engage with will likely be bugs as well, the Mysteriocalypse was the herald of many strange and wonderful things, some of them having the capacity to get up, walk around, and ask questions about stuff.

The rest of this page is given over to a brief overview of some of the 'big players' in the world of PICO that aren't bugs. None of them are inherently evil - this isn't that kind of game - but some of them *are* inherently dangerous, just due to the essential reality of a bug's size or habits (and possibly their tastiness).

FROGS

And toads. Maybe even axolotls, too.

Amphibious and hungry, even the friendliest-looking frog should be treated with caution. It's a food chain thing, you see - bugs ARE delicious, and frogs ARE hungry. All the time. It's just part of being a frog.

But friends come in unexpected packages, and if you manage to form a good bond with a frog you'll have an ally for life.

There are also, it's rumoured, almost as many kinds of frog as there are kinds of bug. Some of them probably aren't actually frogs, when you get down to the scientific end of the scale - what even *is* a salamander, anyway? - but they're all potential dangers, all potential friends.

It's a lot like real life, when you think about it. Humans in real life, not frogs. But maybe also frogs.

MICE

Now this is a curious one. Some mice are intellectual types who love to hide in walls with a mug of cocoa and read up on ancient history. But others are all swift and wild, never saying a word and caring only about the hunt, the chase, the food, the warmth. You can still befriend them, sort of, and some bugs even ride them if they manage to form a deep enough bond of understanding, but an encounter with a mouse is never one you should take lightly.

DOGS

Ah, the boundless innocence of canine life. To dogs, the world is an endless heaven of intriguing scents and muddy puddles, mysterious holes to explore and really impressive sticks to show off.

At the end of the day, dogs are as variable in mood and attitude as bugs are, but they do tend toward the cheerful end of the spectrum. They also make fast friends, remembering good deeds done on their behalf for the rest of their lives, and they always pay their debts without complaint.

RACCOONS

Back in the pre-Mysteriocalypse times, raccoons had something of a bad reputation - the word 'grabby' was used often, as was the word 'pest'. But times have changed, and in the bugly world raccoons tend to be collectors and traders of antiquities, the sort of beasts that can purloin anything a bug might need... For the right price, of course.

BATS

Bats are far more straightforward. They only usually come out at night and they love eating bugs, and unless a bug can *prove* that they're worth more outside of a bat's stomach than inside it, that's probably where they're going to end up.

... And they should probably prove it quickly.

Fish

Very little is known about fish in general, thanks to their habitat of 'oh god only water, please don't put me on land'. There are a few fragments that bugs have picked up over the years, though - they sometimes spit water at people, they appreciate gifts of food, and don't ever mention hooks around them.

Squirrels

The royalty of the deep woods! Each group of squirrels has a complex, court-like system where every one of them has some sort of noble title. You might meet a Duke of Nuts conversing with an Earl of Broken Branches, or be bundled up and carried into the court of a Wild-Breeze Kaiser for stepping under the shadow of the wrong tree.

It's probably pointless to try to understand the intricacies of their society, as the most esteemed bugly scholars have come to the conclusion that a lot of them just sort of make up these names on the fly, but squirrels respect the effort when you give it a go.

Oh, and they will sometimes also try to eat you.

Snakes

Things can be tricky when it comes to issues of the serpentine. Like bats, they have an almost insatiable hunger for bugs. Unlike bats, they also hunt larger, furrier types that would also happily make a meal of your average insect. Danger and salvation, two sides of the same scaled coin.

Birds

Birds are punks. That's just the truth.

Some of them are the cool kind of punks, who buck trends, love bright colours, and treat the world with an unexpected level of kindness and care.

Some of them are the less cool kind of punks, who steal things out of bicycle baskets, snack on delicious-looking bugs, and poop on everything.

When interacting with feathery types, just remember this ancient wisdom, handed down from the earliest days of exploration.

Never judge a bird by its cover.

CATS

*Of **course** they get a special section of their own.*

Cats deserve a special mention here, as the apex predators and undisputed overlords of the world of PICO. There are bigger beasts, and there are faster beasts, and there are even smarter beasts, but there's nothing that's bigger, faster, **and** smarter than a cat.

Cats are important enough to get a few subheadings, so we'll throw those down below.

General advice? Don't underestimate them.

Specific advice? *Run*.

CATS GO WHERE THEY WILL

Think you're safe underground, or in a tree? Guess again. Cats roam the world of PICO without any sense of bugly boundary or border - the entirety of the post-Mysteriocalypse is their territory, and only complex deals made with other cats stay their travelling paws.

CATS KNOW EVERYTHING

Okay, they don't know *literally* everything. But cats can remember the time before the Mysteriocalypse, even if they hardly ever speak about it to anyone except for other cats, and they hold answers to mysteries that bugs haven't even thought about yet. If you need a question answered, they say, ask a cat. And bring a gift.

A really impressive gift.

CATS HAVE 99 LIVES

This one hasn't been completely proven yet, but students of the feline complexities are very, very sure that no cat has ever died. How does this work? No idea. But it's definitely true that cats rarely seem to get hurt by anything and, even if they do, they bounce back up to full strength in a week or two.

CATS ARE MADE OF MAGIC

It's the only explanation when you really think about it. Their bodies *look* like that of any other beast, with tails and whiskers and some rather worryingly sharp claws, but they *act* like some sort of furry liquid. Cats turn up in the strangest of places too, often relaxing in spaces they shouldn't be able to fit into at heights that would induce vertigo in all but the bravest of birds. And if you've ever tried to keep a cat out of a particular space you'll know that, somehow, they will always end up exactly where you don't want them to be.

CATS DON'T EAT BUGS... USUALLY

But don't breathe that insectile sigh of relief just yet. Scuttling types might not be on the menu for the average cat in terms of food, but they often fall into the category of 'living toy' instead, which can be just as dangerous.

CATS HAVE ODD ATTENTION SPANS

Sometimes so long that they can watch a mousehole from sunup to sundown, and at other times so short they probably wouldn't even make it through this sentence. Whether something can hold a cat's attention very much relies on an intersection of interest and opportunity, with a dash of influence from whether there's a good patch of sunlight to lounge in.

CATS ARE NOT GODS

So, this last one is to reign you in a bit after all of that majesty. Cats are as mundane as bugs when you get right down to it - they eat, they sleep, and they sometimes fall off of things unexpectedly. For all of their impressive traits and hidden secrets, they're not infallible - they can be tricked, they can be fought, and they can even sometimes be beaten (even if it is only temporarily). If socialized with bugs early on, they can even be befriended!

Felines of particular note

There are more cats in the world than any bug could ever count, not that any bug would ever attempt such an obviously foolhardy task (though now we've said that, there's a good chance someone will). Some are famous, some obscure; some friendly(ish), others nothing but trouble. Below is a quick cat-alogue of some notable felines, powerful entities that might be found by enterprising adventurers who don't have quite enough danger in their lives.

MIRA, THE MIDNIGHT BITER: An instant disclaimer is probably needed here - as incredible as it would be, Mira cannot actually ingest pure darkness. That doesn't stop her from trying, though.
DIDI, THE ADORED: Found posing regally atop a supposedly velvet cushion, surrounded by bugly attendants.
TINY STINKFACE: A surprisingly good-natured cat cursed with a constant-yet-adorable scowl.
CLOUSEAU: An investigator of some repute, but something of a bumbler.
CATTY: Known to stalk gardens and claw at blankets, renowned for a voice far deeper and rougher than their appearance would suggest.
JUJILIOUS JUJON: Keeper of the single brain cell on days that end in a Q.
SAMSON: Sometimes mistaken for a badger due to the lack of tail and overall bulk, but softer and sweeter than he appears.
PIMPI: Adorable and amusing in equal measure.

Picotitans

The world of bugs is a pretty friendly one, all told. There are fights, scuffles, disagreements, all those usual things, but most bugs get along with each other as long as they're not actively trying to eat one another.

The world of beasts? Not quite so much. Fights are more frequent, territory is wider-ranging and more aggressively defended, and the weakest are often left to fend for themselves.

That last bit is important - what's weak for a larger beast is still extremely strong in bugly terms, and over the uncounted years since the Mysteriocalypse groups of bugs have taken to giving these abandoned beasts a home, teaching them that bugs are friends first and food a distant second, and using them as titanic mounts.

These picotitans, as they're called, range in size from ferret to fox, but no matter how large or small they may be to other beasts, they're a formidable ally for any set of insect adventurers.

Here Kitty Kitty

It takes skill to earn an abandoned animal's trust before it flees, crushes, or eats you, but bugs are known for their skill in the art of convincing others. Or at least, they like to think they are. In actuality, what the initial steps of training a picotitan require more than anything else is food, specifically the kind of food that looks a lot more appetizing than the one handing it over.

But it's not always that easy. Sometimes a beast just doesn't understand enough about tiny sorts to realize that they're trying to help, and a little strategy - or straight-up trickery - is required.

Beastly Drawbacks

Once you have a picotitan on side, one of the things that a lot of would-be beast trainers forget is that it needs somewhere to live. This is less of a problem for nomadic sorts, who move through the world on a whim, but anyone that wants a place to hang their little hat is liable to find their house mistakenly crushed by a playful titan within the first week. Larger communities of bugs often have a 'stable' of sorts just for this purpose, or are built near larger structures or natural features left over from the pre-mystery times that trained beasts can call their own.

Beastly Benefits

But when all that's taken care of? Well, you're golden - a picotitan, as long as you keep it fed and happy, can do anything from transport messages to carry an entire castle around on its back, allow the crossing of otherwise impassable terrain to coming to the defence of their tiny friends in a tough situation with a wilder beast.

The one thing they'll never do, however, is harm a bug - it's an essential part of the process, convincing these massive beasts not to snack on those around them, so asking it to gobble up other bugs you don't like (or other bug-sized things) is dangerously confusing, and best avoided.

Common Picotitans

Something of a misnomer, as no giant beast can ever really be called common. That said, here's a list of some of the grand beasts sometimes rescued and trained by tiny sorts...

Cats: Remember how majestic, how full of secrecy and haughty airs the average cat is? Turns out that stuff isn't innate. A cat raised by bugs is generally a friendly, playful beast, and settlements that have one often slumber to the sound of deep purring and the occasional contented mew.

Foxes: A classic for rural bugs, excellent at going off-road through densely forested areas and forging new paths that even a bug couldn't find.

Otters: Never underestimate a strong swimmer - otters keep their riders safe from hungry fish, which is a very useful thing to be safe from.

Raccoons: Cute faces and grabby hands!

CHAPTER 02:
BASIC RULES

Told By Wild Words

PICO runs on a version of the Wild Words Engine, tinkered with just enough that the basic principles are the same but that it also fits a massive world of tiny adventurers.

But what do you need to play a game of PICO? We'll get that out of the way first, with a quick list below...

A Weaver (GM)

The **Weaver** (or, if you want to get technical, Weaver of Very Engaging Stories Involving Bugs) is PICO's GM figure. Why call it a Weaver, rather than just a GM? Because bugs have no masters, but they do tend to get caught up in the strands of stories bigger than themselves. One person at the table takes the role of Weaver, playing NPCs, presenting the world, and helping to guide the story when it needs it.

Some Bugly Characters (Players)

Everyone at the table is a player, when you get down to it, but some are more player-y than others. **Characters** in PICO are all bugs of various kinds, and it's these little bugs that drive the story forward.

Some Sheets (Character & Roaming)

At the very least, every player at the table with a character needs a **Character Sheet** - a way to record information about their bug, to see what skills and special parts they have, and to track how they develop.

You'll also need a **Roaming Sheet** - this is a place to record the important features of your picotitan (if you have access to one), and also information on the wider world around you. The Roaming Sheet is shared by all players, so you only need one for the table. *Though if you explore large swathes of the world, or manage to befriend multiple picotitans, you might actually need more than one roaming sheet in the end. One's a good start, let's just say that.*

Some Dice (D6s)

Every player at the table, and the Weaver, needs a bundle of d6s. Six of them is a good number, but you might want to bring a couple more just in case one rolls under a chair or something.

It happens.

STRUCTURE

A game of PICO follows a particular structure... Sort of. Play is broken up into three distinct types - **scenes**, **montages**, and **journeys** - which each have their own rules, and can happen in pretty much any order. Two scenes in a row? No problem! A journey, with a montage in the middle, and then another journey? Absolutely fine.

SCENES

Scenes are pretty freeform. Scuttle around, get into trouble, have a good time or a bit of a scrap. The spotlight (more on that in a second) moves from player to player freely as they take actions and reactions that affect the world, and the Weaver will slide in now and then to describe things, embody NPCs, ask questions, or ask for particular rolls.

***Example**: A band of bugs are exploring a curious sandcastle on a lonely beach, taking their time to explore each salt-scented room and picking their way through hazardous collapsed areas. The moment-to-moment decisions they make matter, so the Weaver handles this experience with a scene.*

MONTAGES

These are a little more structured. In a montage, every bug gets the chance to do a single 'task', a long action condensed down into a sentence or two of description (and maybe a roll of the dice). This helps longer, slower periods of in-game time pass more quickly out here in the real world.

***Example**: That same band of bugs are getting ready to leave the sandcastle, having bested (and then befriended) the titanic crab in its deepest chambers. But before they go, each of them has something they want to do; grabbing a particular type of resource, maybe nursing some wounds. The tasks matter here, but not the moment-to-moment play, so it's a montage.*

JOURNEYS

The most structured of all - journeys let bugs move from place to place, encapsulating long treks, camps, and scouting expeditions, as well as the hazards and mysteries found and faced along the way.

***Example**: This beach? It's just as lonely as it first seemed, no point in hanging around for too long. The bugs are going to make their way inland as night falls, hoping to reach the nearest bugly settlement in time for a good hearty supper. The Weaver works out roughly how many strides the journey will take, and then puts a track down for them to fill with their movement (as well as a ticking clock to measure the passing of time) - a classic journey.*

THE SPOTLIGHT

As you might have guessed, **the spotlight is a game term for when the attention of the table is on you**. When the Weaver describes a location, they have the spotlight. If a player breaks in to ask a question, the spotlight swings to them and their bug. A raving badger charges in? That's probably a moment worthy of the spotlight, yeah.

In **scenes**, the spotlight swings wherever the action dictates. If things get really dramatic or hectic, the Weaver might start tracking the spotlight to ensure everyone gets a fair shake at play (see *Who Goes Next?* on the next page).

In **montages**, every bug gets the spotlight once (to do their task), and some might get it more than once (usually because they have an ability that lets them use multiple tasks, or if whatever they were doing needs a bit of a narrative follow-up before the conversation continues).

In **journeys**, the spotlight will mostly be on the Weaver as they describe the world and bring encounters into play, but bugs will also have their moments as they make **Lookout Rolls**, take important decisions, and natter about their days.

WHO GOES NEXT?

In most situations, the swing of the spotlight is obvious. One bug throws something down a deep well, and the spotlight swings to the Weaver to describe the satisfying splash it makes when it hits the water. Then somebody else does something, and the spotlight swings to them. Easy enough, right?

But in situations where time is of the essence, or where everyone should have a fair amount of time centre-stage, the Weaver can make a **Spotlight Track** on a bit of scrap paper to see who has had the spotlight for actions (tracked with an A) or reactions (tracked with an R), which helps determine who should probably have it next. Here's an example...

Darius: ARA
Celia: RRA
Uther: AR

In the above example, Darius and Celia have both had the spotlight three times in the scene. Uther has only had it twice, so the Weaver might prompt them to take an action or challenge them with a reaction. If Uther wants to hang back a bit, Celia should probably get it next (as she's taken two reactions, which means she's had a bit less agency than Darius with his two actions). As long as these tracks stay *vaguely* balanced, everyone should get a piece of the spotlight pie!

THE CONVERSATION

It might seem silly, pointing out how important the conversation is - I mean, you can't really play a group-focused TRPG without one. But the conversation is *particularly* important in a narrative-focused game like PICO - it's where players and Weaver get together to ask questions, take actions, make decisions, and move the spotlight from person to person so everyone gets some time and attention.

Even when the spotlight isn't being explicitly tracked, the conversation should help decide who goes next. Someone's been a bit quiet, or not had their time to shine in a while? Anyone at the table can help bring them back into the story, not just the Weaver. PICO is, at its heart, a team game, and you're all there to have fun.

It's also important to bring a couple of safety tools into the conversation, especially early on. Mute topics that you don't want to turn up, and make sure that everyone is on board with the intended tone of the game - you'll find more about that on page 193.

TRACKS

A track is a set of boxes (technically circles, but I'm not splitting hairs here) linked together in a line. Quick, there goes one now!

o-o-o-o-o

Tracks are used in a whole lot of different ways in PICO, but the most common use is to measure steps along the path to something happening. Because of the 'something', most tracks come with a name attached to them, like the one below.

The Croaklins Approach o-o-o-o-o

Think of a track as somewhere between reminder, book-keeping aid, and abstract story. The one above tells you that croaklins are approaching (thanks to the name), and that five things are probably going to happen before they get here (thanks to the number of boxes).

MARKS

Marking a track is as easy as putting **a diagonal line** through one of the boxes. *Here's our five-box track, but now with a single mark...*

The Croaklins Approach /-o-o-o-o

But what does that mean? Usually that whatever the name of track hints at is **one step closer to happening**. In the case of the track above, every mark represents the croaklins drawing ever closer.

Tracks can be marked in a variety of ways; through successful actions, passing time, failures and missteps, sometimes even at the Weaver's whim. But here's something that's always true...

When a track is fully marked, *something* happens.

***Example**: The noise of Jin's shout reverberates through the valley, and the Weaver marks the final box on their track. Moments later, the first croaklin head appears!*

Burns & Clears

If a mark is a simple line, a **burn is cross** - a second line that crosses the first, forming an x shape. *Here's a track with two marks and one burn...*

The Croaklins Approach

Think of a burn as some kind of *super mark*, an indelible change that's impossible (or at least really difficult) to clear. Why is this important? Because some tracks don't just count up! Marks can be **cleared**, erased from a track to set progress back. And how do marks get cleared? It all depends on the track!

***Example**: The bugs are trying to win the affections of a wily raccoon, and the Weaver sets them a track to fill to represent their progress. Giving gifts and doing favours mark the track, but offending or angering the raccoon clears a mark.*

This is where burns come in handy, representing progress that's probably not going to reverse.

***Example**: One of the bugs gives the raccoon a discarded mitten, his favourite objet d'art. The raccoon is so happy with this gift that the Weaver burns a box instead of marking it, to represent a positive feeling toward the bugs that the raccoon will never forget.*

Breaks

A break in a track can be represented by a special vertical line in between two boxes. *Here's an example of a four-box track with a break halfway through.*

The Croaklins Approach

Breaks are a limiter on how many boxes can be filled at once. While most tracks will be marked one box at a time, some (such as tracks representing damage) might take a whack of a few marks at once. **If those marks would go past a break, they stop instead - any extra marks to be made are ignored**.

Breaks can also be used to represent changes in the world, or a hazard, even before their track is filled. Maybe a hermit crab crawls about the place quite happily until its track is marked up to a break, then retreats into its shell while the rest of the track is being marked.

- Tracks Example -

Weaver: Squirrels are famously patient, but their king won't wait forever. I'm starting a track, called *The Hunt for the Acorn* - it's got three boxes, then a break, then three more.

Layla: Let me guess - if the track gets fully marked, the squirrels are going to come after us?

Weaver: Oh no, that would be terrible! Actually, when we reach the break, the squirrels are going to come after you. When the track is fully marked, that's when the squirrel king loses his patience entirely and tries to track you down himself.

Bicco: Ah... That sounds less than perfect. How do we mark it? Or rather, how do we avoid marking it, as this seems like the kind of track we want to keep as clear as possible?

Weaver: Speed is key here. I'll mark the Hunt for the Acorn track at dawn each day, so you've essentially got six days to get things done, three of those without hulking monsters on your tail.

Dunf: Hey, that's actually pretty generous! I'm pretty sure we can find that acorn in six days, right folks? Maybe even three?

Layla: And *I'm* pretty sure we should get going! Come on gang, it's journey time. To the Hogwild!

To Mark or Not To Mark?

Remember, **not every track is one you're going to want to fill!** A track representing the damage your bug takes, for example, or the arrival of a rampaging titan, is probably one you're going to want to leave as empty as possible! *Tracks you want to avoid filling might be cleared with a successful action, rather than marked.*

Open and Hidden Tracks

What, you thought the Weaver was just going to tell you everything, every time?

Most tracks in PICO are **open**, out in front of everyone for the whole table to see. But some can be **hidden**, where only the Weaver can see how many boxes and marks there are. If you ever see the Weaver make a little pencil mark and smile to themselves, there's probably a hidden track.

ACTIONS & DICE

"Not only does god play dice, but he sometimes throws them where they cannot be seen. Ever had a massive cube just drop out of the sky near you? It'll give you pause for thought, I tell you that."

Picture the scene: you're out on an adventure, days away from home, and you come across a sleeping scorpion. It's big enough that it fills almost the entire path, and scorpions are notoriously light sleepers - whatever you do here, you're going to risk waking it up. You could try to sneak past, you could double back a little and find another way to your destination, you could wake it on purpose and try to make friends, or you could charge in for a fight and attempt to take it off guard.

Whatever you decide, you're going to be doing what PICO refers to as an **action** - a moment where the story brings an element of skill, choice, or randomness into play. And how do you deal with this?

By rolling some dice.

WHEN DO YOU ROLL?

Not all actions require a roll. Going to open your own front door under normal circumstances? Yeah, you can probably manage that without reaching for the dice. As a handy set of guidelines, you should **roll the dice when an action you're attempting is**...

DIFFICULT

The door has been barricaded from the outside, and you have to push it open with great force.

If an action requires a lot of effort, so much that you may or may not succeed, roll the dice to find out what happens.

DANGEROUS

The door has been rigged with an exploding shell - somebody really doesn't like you.

If an action's outcome might involve harm or serious consequences, roll the dice to find out whether you suffer them or not (and how bad they are if you do).

DRAMATIC

The door isn't the problem, it's the adoring crowd waiting outside that you need to impress. Make a scene!

If an action involves a big dramatic moment, either in-world or as part of the game's narrative, roll the dice to see how you fare. Stories need drama, after all!

HOW DO YOU ROLL?

Once you've determined that a roll is required, it's time to grab dice. PICO uses a **d6 dice pool system** - you roll a number of d6s, and then you read off the **highest number** as your **result** (and **doubles** matter, too).

But how many dice are you rolling?

That depends on the situation you're in and how you've built your bug. Almost all rolls in PICO follow the same basic structure:

Skill + Aspect + Advantage

... Meaning that the **maximum number of dice you'll ever have in your pool is six**.

The box below breaks down the three factors behind your dice pool, but if you're ever not sure whether you need to roll or not, or how many dice to use, check with the Weaver. And in some instances, the Weaver will just straight up ask you to roll!

SKILL DICE [up to 3d6]

Skill dice come from the skills your bug has access to. All bugs have a number of special skills, which can give a bonus of **1d6, 2d6, or 3d6**.

ASPECT DICE [up to 1d6]

All bugs have a number of aspects, representing special body parts and unique tools. You get a bonus of **1d6** if you have an aspect that suits the situation.

ADVANTAGE DICE [up to 2d6]

Advantage dice are more situational. You can gain a **maximum of 2d6** advantage on your roll if you...

- Have the environment, a POI, or a discovery working in your favour, which can give a bonus of **1d6**.
- Have help from another nearby bug (though if things go wrong, they'll face consequences just like you), which can give a bonus of **1d6**.
- Use some of your bits or bobs, odds and ends you pick up on your travels, for a bonus of **1d6**. Using bits and bobs as part of an action *might* consume them if a roll goes well, but will *almost definitely* consume them if a roll goes poorly. *See page 160 for more guidance on using bits and bobs.*

READING RESULTS

So you've rolled your dice - what happens next?

There are two important takeaways from your rolled dice. There's the **result**, which is the **highest number** you see, and there's the **twist**, which you earn from having **doubles** of *any* of the numbers you see.

***Example**: Celia rolls 4d6, and gets 1, 3, 4, and 6. Her result is 6, and she doesn't have a twist.*

***Example**: Cedrico rolls 3d6, and gets 1, 1, and 4. His result is 4, but he also gets a twist from the double 1.*

Different results have different names and effects which can vary based on the type of roll you're making - we're focusing just on **Action Rolls** for now, covered by the table to the right, but there are other kinds of rolls you'll be making too! *You'll learn more about those later.*

When you've worked out your result, **announce it to the table!** That's when the conversation takes over again, and the game continues based on the result you've just rolled.

AN EMPTY POOL

If you ever want (or need) to roll when you have **no way of getting dice** for the pool, **roll a single d6 and count triumphs as conflicts**. *This might happen when you're trying something that's way out of your comfort zone, but even then you should look to scrape up some kind of advantage to help out.*

ACTION ROLL RESULTS

6

5
4

3
2
1

doubles

TRIUMPH

Everything goes according to plan! If you're affecting a track, this lets you mark or clear a box (whichever makes more sense for a good outcome in your current situation).

CONFLICT

It's still a success, but it comes at a cost. If you're affecting a track, you *might* be able to mark or clear it, but there's probably going to be a drawback of some kind to deal with as well.

DISASTER

Things go about as badly as they possibly could. If you're affecting a track, you don't mark or clear a box, and there will definitely be some kind of drawback to deal with.

TWIST

Something unexpected happens, in addition to the usual result! This extra outcome can be suggested by anybody at the table, but the Weaver has the final say. *See page 37 for more information on twists.*

Actions vs. Reactions

Most of the time, an action is something you choose to do just because you want to. You're in control, and you choose what you're doing and how you're going about it.

But, sometimes, the Weaver will ask you to make a **reaction** - they throw the spotlight in your direction, usually accompanied by some kind of immediate danger, challenge, or choice, and you have to work out what you're going to do in response. You're still in control of how you're going to get something done, but the 'what' is a little more limited based on the context around the reaction.

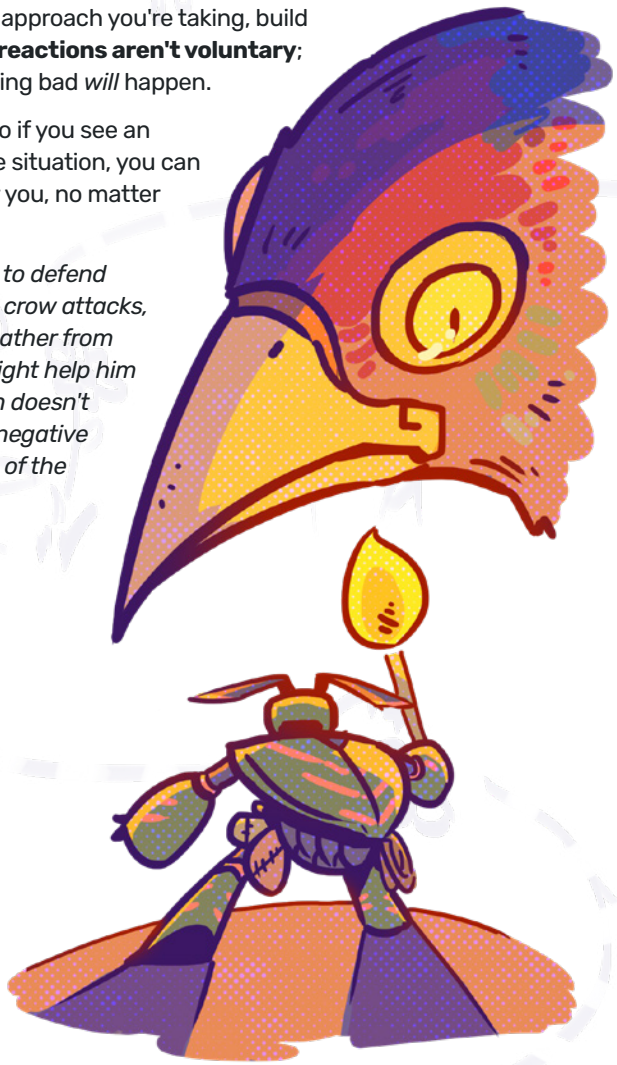
***Example**: Rexi is engaged in a rumble with an angry crow, the two of them trading blows as they scamper and thrash among the dense branches of a bramble bush. The crow leaps forward, beak open, for an attack, so the Weaver asks Rexi to make a Reaction Roll. The context of this roll is that Rexi's in danger, and should probably get out of the way or find some way to blunt the crow's attack. Whatever he chooses to do for his reaction should address this situation in some way - maybe dodging away, trying to block the beak with his tail, nipping behind a thorny branch, or leaping right at the crow with a counterattack. All are applicable to the situation, and that's what really matters.*

Appropriate Reactions & Wild Cards

Mechanically, reactions work just like actions - you decide what approach you're taking, build your dice pool, roll, and read your results off. But unlike actions, **reactions aren't voluntary**; you *are* in the spotlight, and if you don't act accordingly something bad *will* happen.

But maybe that's alright! The spotlight is on you for a reaction, so if you see an opportunity to get something done that doesn't quite match the situation, you can still attempt it. It just, you know... might turn out pretty badly for you, no matter how well you roll.

***Example**: In the above situation, the Weaver expects Rexi to try to defend himself in some way, or at least get a bit of damage in while the crow attacks, but he doesn't have to. Rexi might use this reaction to steal a feather from the crow as it savagely pecks at him, gaining a resource that might help him later on down the line (if he survives). But, because this reaction doesn't do anything to protect him from the incoming attack, he'll take negative consequences from it as if he'd rolled a disaster, even if the rest of the reaction goes well in terms of stealing that feather.*



Luck Rolls

A special roll that the Weaver might call for from time to time, when you make a Luck Roll you simply **roll a single d6**. Instead of having to check a pre-made results table, the Weaver will tell you exactly what the result means for that particular situation (probably before the roll is made, but you never know). How exciting!

***Example**: Tambori and Felkin are facing an angry cat that's about to lash out. The Weaver asks them to make a Luck Roll, telling them that the higher the result, the better. Tambori rolls a 3, and Felkin a 5 - Felkin's higher result keeps her safe in this situation, and the cat springs at the unlucky Tambori instead.*

Twists

When a player rolls doubles, they've almost always got the option of choosing a twist - an unexpected happening suggested by any other player at the table, and decided upon by the Weaver. These can be positive, negative, useful, harmful - it all depends on the situation and the creativity of the players!

Narrative vs. Mechanical

Twists are narrative by default, suggestions of what happens in the story of the game. There can be a mechanical side too, but that's up to the Weaver to add if they feel it's right for that particular moment. This helps regulate the power twists can have on both the wider story and the immediate situation.

***Example**: Jenkins, a spiderish sort, rolls a twist while they're climbing a crumbling garden wall. One player at the table suggests they find a useful seed lodged in a crack, another that Jenkins manages to spot something interesting in the distance due to their height. The Weaver has two decisions to make here - which twist feels right for the situation, and whether either of them has an immediate mechanical impact. If the Weaver goes with the first suggestion, they might reward Jenkins with a new bit, Suspicious Seed. If they go with the second suggestion, they'll only give information that might lead to a later benefit - a completely narrative outcome, but still a potentially useful one.*

Power!

Twists can be game-changing, but they shouldn't be game-breaking. Noticing a new weakness in a foe mid-battle would be a great twist, but defeating that foe instantly would be far too strong. As a general rule, **a twist should offer nothing more powerful than a good triumph could achieve**.

Some Go-To Twists

When suggesting a twist, the possibilities are literally endless (or rather simply bound by the creativity of the table), but there are a few tried-and-true twist outcomes that work for almost all situations.

- A bit or bob is found, or lost.
- A piece of hidden information is gained.
- A useful thing is spotted, or suddenly removed.
- Unexpected aid (or danger) arrives.
- The character achieves something that would usually take another Action Roll.

- Rolls & Twists Example -

Weaver: The outskirts of the Hogwild aren't too dense, but it's going to be hard travel once you're under the boughs. Is there anything you want to do to prepare, or are you going to head right in?

Layla: I think surveying the immediate locale wouldn't be the worst idea. Is there anything tall I can climb nearby that'll get me a good look into the forest, higher than the undergrowth?

Weaver: There's an old pre-M signpost nearby - it's broken, but still pretty tall. Looks like it won't be too hard a climb, either.

Layla: Then I'll head up there. I've got Climb, and I think my limbs aspect helps out here... That's a 3, a 5, a 6, and a 6! A triumph with a twist!

Weaver: You make it up the signpost no problem, getting a commanding view of the first section of the forest. And there's a path, hidden by bushes, that you'll easily be able to find now that you've seen it from this height.

Layla: Result! But what about the twist?

Weaver: Let's throw it over to the table. Anyone?

Dunf: Ooh, maybe the path has some old lanterns strung along it, meaning it'll be bright even under the canopy.

Layla: I love that! Can we go for that?

Weaver: We definitely can - I'll stick that in my notes as well, so I don't forget once the trees close in.

A Twist, or...?

The results table for Action Rolls on page 35 lists a twist as the only outcome of doubles, but there's actually a lot of other stuff you might do instead if the situation is right. Some specific actions in a game of PICO have alternative options you can choose from when you roll doubles, but you can almost always default back to a simple twist if you want to.

***Example**: Yasmin is in a rumble, using her candy axe to attack a beastmouse that got a little too bitey for her liking. She rolls a double as part of her attack and because of the situation, she can either take a twist or treat the roll as a critical (as described on page 58).*

CUT

It's all so easy, you're thinking to yourself - I've got loads of dice to roll!

And yes, that's true... But when times get tough, you might not have as many *results* as you expect.

Cut is how PICO measures increasing difficulty, a method of lowering the chances of you getting perfect results from your rolls. When you cut, you **remove a number of results from the dice you've just rolled, starting with the highest number**. That 6? it's gone now. Maybe that 5, too!

***Example**: Clarendo is about to roll with 5 dice, but the Weaver informs him he has a Tough Cut of 2. He still rolls all 5 dice, getting 2, 3, 5, 5, and 6, but then that Tough Cut comes into play - he removes the two highest dice, the 6 and one of the 5s. Not only has his triumph dropped to a conflict, he's lost his twist! Tough break, man.*

TYPES OF CUT

Cut is applied when *something* makes an action harder to excel in than usual, and there are a few different *somethings* you should know about. These are the **five types of cut**, and we'll describe each of them below...

TOUGH CUT

The most common type, applied by the Weaver when an action is just tougher to pull off cleanly. Tough Cut might be applied thanks to poor positioning, illness, unfamiliarity, stubbornness... *It's the most general type of cut, and can be hard to avoid or reduce without changing your approach.*

ARMOUR CUT

Usually only encountered during a frenetic combat or serious scuffle, this is applied by the Weaver if you're using an action against a heavily armoured or well-defended target. *You might remove Armour Cut by denying a target of defences, or finding a hidden weak point.*

SPEED CUT

This is applied by the Weaver when you're trying to do something faster than usual, or targeting a really swift creature as it zips by. *You might remove Speed Cut by immobilizing a target, or by finding a faster, easier method of achieving whatever you're trying to achieve.*

CAMO CUT

This comes into play when things get murky, and a lack of visibility makes life harder - camouflaged hazards will use this to their advantage too. *You might remove Camo Cut by shining a light on the situation (literally), or by dousing an invisible hazard in something garish or paint-like.*

COMPLEX CUT

Most often applied in situations that are unpredictable, or that need extreme precision, quick-thinking, or impressive logic, like solving a crossword. *You might remove Complex Cut by slowing down and taking your time, or by attempting an ingenious approach to a problem.*

- ACTIONS & CUT EXAMPLE -

Weaver: Okay Swift, the spotlight's on you - what are you doing here?

Swift: Well, we need that acorn, and I think I'm the one best-equipped to get it. I'm going to scamper out over the branch and try to grab it.

Weaver: Sounds like an Action Roll - you remember how to put that together?

Swift: Yep! I'm going to go with Climb, which is 2d6, and my Manypod Scuttlers should give me 1d6 of advantage too.

Bicco: I'd love to help, but heights are really not my thing. Good luck though!

Weaver: He's going to need it - I'm adding a Tough Cut of 1 to this, just so you know, to represent the sway of the branch in the wind.

Swift: A cut of one's not too bad, but... I think I'm going to use a resource too, for that extra 1d6. I've got Spider Silk - can I use that to help anchor me to the branch as I move?

Weaver: You can. Cross the Spider Silk off and roll!

Swift: Righto, that's 4d6... A 1, a 1, a 4 and a 6. Excellent! Oh wait, with a cut of one. That takes the 6 off, but leaves the 4 as my highest result. That's a conflict, with a twist!

Weaver: Definitely! The good stuff - you make it out to where the acorn is without a problem. But the bad stuff? That acorn is securely attached to the branch, so you can't just grab it and be done. Now, any ideas for the twist?

Layla: Maybe the branch is weak out there, so Swift can't grab the acorn, but might be able to send the end of the branch down to the forest floor, and the acorn along with it?

Swift: Ooh, I like that.

Weaver: Me too! Let's go with that then. Dunf, you're looking up at the acorn when you hear a creaking, snapping sound from near Swift...

Dunf: I'm ready to catch it if I need to! Or him!

THE 'WHEN' IS STILL IMPORTANT

Like impact, cut is typically declared by the Weaver **before a roll is made**, as a player is describing their action or assembling their dice pool. This gives a player time to think about whether they want to take a different approach due to the difficulty of the impending roll, or about whether they might want to try to rustle up some extra advantage dice by calling on their friends for aid or using a bit or bob.

Sometimes though, the Weaver may choose to leave the cut as a 'nice surprise' for the player once the dice are rolled. We don't recommend doing this often though - it's good for shock value now and again, but overusing it feels cheap.

REMEMBER - CUT STACKS!

If you suffer an Armour Cut of 1 and a Speed Cut of 2, that means you'll be cutting your three highest results. That's pretty nasty, so we recommend (unless you're *really* confident) that when the cut on a roll gets to three or more you should *probably* consider a different approach. **If you're ever cut down to zero results, that's an auto-disaster!**

IMPACT

Impact is a measure of how effective an action is, both in terms of how it affects the world around you and in how many boxes are marked on a track. *The Weaver usually determines impact based on how effective an action you're about to take is likely to be.*

There are four levels of impact an action can have in PICO; **no impact**, **low impact**, **normal impact**, and **giga impact**. This might sound like a lot, but don't worry; if you play to your bug's strengths and make good decisions, only two will turn up in regular play.

The boxes below cover the narrative and mechanical implications of each level of impact, and each is illustrated with an example of Gnash, our little bug pictured to the right, using an action to open a door.

NO IMPACT

A complete non-starter. If the Weaver tells you that an action you're taking is going to have no impact at all, that's a sign for you to re-think your approach - **you won't mark any boxes on tracks at all**, and any other effect you might on the world will barely be perceptible and change absolutely nothing.

***Example**: Gnash pushes against the 'door' to no avail, not realising that it's actually a wall.*

LOW IMPACT

Not exactly an impressive display. Your action is successful, but it only has a very small effect on the situation. If you're affecting a track, mark **one box fewer than usual** (normally meaning you mark zero, but your action might still have other effects).

***Example**: Gnash manages to open the door... but it's torturously slow, or it sticks and scrapes repeatedly. Either he's too weak, or the door is just too heavy.*

NORMAL IMPACT

That's more like it! When affecting a track you can mark **the usual one box**, and any additional effect you have on the world is likely both useful and noticeable.

***Example**: Gnash doesn't much care for doors. Others might push it open gently, or even just open it up like a regular ol' person and saunter through, but Gnash chooses to barrel through with a holler; it's just the kind of bug he is.*

GIGA IMPACT

If you have **giga impact**, then all bets are off! Your effects are titanic and, if you're affecting a track, you mark ***every* box up until either the end of the track, or the next track break**. Giga impact solves problems quickly!

***Example**: With this level of impact, Gnash can pretty much do what he wants where this door is concerned. He might knock it right off of its hinges, break it into pieces, or even smash through the middle, leaving a bug-shaped hole in his wake. It's a true demonstration of peak bugly power!*

THE BASICS OF IMPACT

Let's get this on the page right now, to prevent any confusion (and to hopefully speed things up): **if the Weaver or a special rule for your bug hasn't told you otherwise, the impact of any action you take is going to be NORMAL.**

Why? Because wrangling over the impact of *every* action at the table would get dull fast, especially in a lighthearted game like PICO. Instead, you should check your probable impact with the Weaver only if you're doing something that you think might be outside your capabilities. Lifting a pebble? You probably have normal impact. Lifting a boulder? Low impact, or even no impact, might be more appropriate. *Basically, only check when you're in doubt.*

As a quick rule of thumb...

- **Low Impact** represents roughly the amount of effort a **little grubling** could put into something.
- **Normal Impact** is about right for the **average bug** doing something they're pretty confident in.
- **Giga Impact** is usually reserved for things that are massive and impressive, like **cats and other titans**.

A SLIDING SCALE

A quick reminder here that 'low impact' is not synonymous with 'failure', nor 'giga impact' with 'success'. - that's all in the dice. A triumph on a low impact action to grab the attention of a crowd, for example, might have you attract one or two useful individuals. In contrast, a disaster with giga impact might have you at the centre of attention for everyone there, but for all the wrong reasons. **Impact augments your Action Roll results, it doesn't replace them.**

- IMPACT EXAMPLE -

Weaver: Dunf, the acorn is tantalizingly within your grasp now, but there's a problem - it's still attached to the branch that fell.

Dunf: Oh, fair enough! I'll just pull it off then.

Weaver: Ah, it might not be that simple. The acorn's pretty fresh, so it's still strongly attached to its little cap, and the branch. It'll be a low-impact action if you just try to pull it out.

Swift: Right, let's think logically about this. How do we get a bit more power behind Dunf's action here?

Bicco: Well, I'm down there too, because you're never going to catch me waltzing around in the treetops. Dunf, is there any way I can help? Strength isn't really my forte, but I could try to pull it with you...

Dunf: Oh, don't you have those Smelling Salts? That might pep me up enough to put some extra power behind my pull. Weaver?

Weaver: Oh, definitely! I'll always reward a good use of bits and bobs, you know that. Bicco, how does that sound to you?

Bicco: A lot safer than trying to join Dunf for that action, definitely! Being rolled over by an acorn is not on my list of things to do today.

Weaver: Ha, sounds good. In that case, with the aid of the Smelling Salts, you can bump that impact up to normal, Dunf. But be warned - if the roll goes wrong, Bicco might lose those salts.

"Safety in numbers? You really think we're out here because we want to play it safe?"

Florenzini Capgrato, Mantid Explorer

So, what's my impact?

It happens to the best of us - we've got this brilliant plan we're about to put into action and the Weaver leans in to go "just so you know, you're *probably* going to have lower impact there than you think..."

Don't think of this as an impasse though, and definitely not as a punishment. In an ideal world, that's the Weaver pointing out that you might want to change what you're doing, or that there may be something you haven't considered. **If your impact is going to be higher or lower than normal, the Weaver should (almost) always tell you before you roll.** This gives you time to consider other actions, or even alter your approach entirely.

***Example**: Rexi is a tough-talking, leather-jacket-wearing scorpion, currently trying to intimidate a group of mice that stole a grub's bike. He wants to use his Swagger skill, but he's massively outnumbered - low impact, the Weaver tells him. But Rexi's player has an idea - if they used their Sizzle skill, they have an aspect chosen at character creation that lets them treat Sizzle as Gigasizzle when dealing with foes that have the 'Beastly' keyword. These mice are as Beastly as they come, so this seems like a perfect opportunity to splash a bit of venom around and instill fear into some furry bike thieves. It might even scatter some of them, leaving them wide open for a future swagger!*

Of course, sometimes you might not *want* to change what you're doing. In those cases you can either roll with lower impact **or** ask the Weaver if there's anything you can do to increase it - who knows, you might be able to cut a deal.

What increases your impact?

Increasing your impact is pretty tough - fictionally, there's a reason bugs don't wander around doing most daily tasks with the speed, strength, or effectiveness of cats! But 'tough' is not the same as 'impossible', so if you're angling for increased impact we recommend...

- **Asking the Weaver**: They *might* offer you some kind of deal, along the lines of 'if you do this riskier thing or use a resource, you can bump your impact up by one step'. This is pretty situational though (and it slows the game down), so try not to rely on it too often.
- **Using Certain Aspects**: Your bug's aspects (detailed in full on page 104) are the building blocks of your character, and each comes with special rules. Some aspects allow you to increase your impact in a certain situation, or when using a particular skill.
- **Choosing the Right Approach**: Using your bug's best skills helps with dice rolls, but high impact is more about whether what you're doing suits the situation. The perfect action may be rewarded with increased impact from the Weaver, even if you haven't asked!
- **Using Combos and Finishers**: Found on page 46, these are teamwork-style moves that lead up to an action with increased impact. They don't come without a cost, though...
- **Targeting Weaknesses**: When facing a hazard, using a skill they're weak to increases your impact by one step (a great way of getting reliable giga impact).

What decreases your impact?

Unfortunately easier than increasing your impact, these are things the Weaver will be taking into account when you describe your action - and you should keep them in mind too! When your impact is lower than you'd hoped, you might be...

- **Overreaching**: Maybe what you're trying to do is just a *bit* too ambitious. There's nothing wrong with shooting for the stars, but you are still a tiny bug at the end of the day!
- **An Unhelpful Environment**: Navigating a field during a lovely sunny day? No problem. Navigating that same field during a thunderstorm, at night? Good luck. Bad environmental conditions might cause cut (as detailed on page 38), but they can just as easily lower your impact.
- **Choosing a Less-Than-Optimal Approach**: We don't want to say that your ideas are terrible, but there's a reason people don't often try to break rocks with a blancmange.
- **Targeting a Resistance (or Immunity)**: Most hazards have resistances, which drop your impact by one step (the exact inverse of a weakness). Some hazards also have immunities, resulting in even a perfect shot having no impact at all! Learn about your foes and use the knowledge to your advantage.
- **Hitting an Unexpected Drawback**: Sometimes a surprise wrench gets thrown in the works. *See the next page for info on 'secret variables'.*

SECRET VARIABLES: WHAT TANGLED WEBS!

Just about the only time you **won't** be warned of a drop (or increase) in impact **before** you roll is when there's a **secret variable**, something you just don't see coming (and therefore can't prepare for) that either raises or lowers your impact. *The only extra advice for the Weaver we have on secret variables is, in brief, 'use these sparingly'.*

***Example**: Oboe is a slug on a mission, attempting to win the favour of a mighty sleeping cat. She's rolling to present the cat with a gift, and has a track to fill - 'Winning Mittens Over'. The roll goes well, and she holds a morsel of meat aloft, but the cat's eyes flicker open and then narrow with disgust - who would have expected Mittens was vegetarian? The Weaver reveals that the action has low impact and the track isn't marked, but Mittens has still been woken (as even for low impact, actions can still have other effects). Now, if only Oboe had some carrot sticks...*

TRUTHS

The Mysteriocalypse definitely had some serious effects on the world of PICO, but nobody can quite explain what they *were*. It put bugs at the top of the pecking order (thematically, at least - realistically, birds are still the masters of pecking), and it for sure removed a particularly common species of two-legged titans that loved building unexplainable things, but the how and the why are lost in... Well, in mystery.

But there are some things that a bug can grasp, if they put their minds to it: these are **Truths**, unusual facts about the world of PICO that travellers will discover as they explore, learn, and strive for answers.

ESTABLISHING TRUTHS

Truths are established by players pursuing their bug's mystery, a question decided during character creation and then chipped away at through the process of making first small, then grand, **discoveries**. When a grand discovery is made, the Weaver records it on the Roaming Sheet (page 172), as these truths affect more than just the character that introduced them - they're now a fact of the world! *More on these discoveries can be found on page 164, so for now we'll just give an...*

***Example**: Ryan is a bearded fly, part of a band of bugs wandering the vast, gloomy interior of the Shadow House. He has a mystery to solve, 'How can glass be so strong, yet so clear?', which is pretty appropriate for a fly when you think about it. During his adventure he makes several small discoveries; he realises that glass dulls sound (but doesn't stop light), that it makes a satisying clinking noise when other glass hits it, and that if a sound is high-pitched enough, it can make glass shatter completely. With these three small discoveries under his belt, he takes the spotlight to make a grand discovery - that glass is, in fact, solidified music. The Weaver records this grand discovery on the Roaming Sheet as a new Truth of the post-Mysteriocalypse, and Ryan gets to choose a new mystery to figure out in the future.*

CHANGING THE WORLD, ONE TRUTH AT A TIME

When a truth is recorded on the Roaming Sheet it becomes a fact of the world of PICO, something both Weaver and players can draw on through the rest of a game or campaign as they play. See the following page for how these truths can be used, but also heed this warning first...

Truths are *powerful*.

Quite apart from the mechanical benefits we're about to explain, a truth can affect the **direction** of a story and the **flavour** of the world. It's good practice to have a group discuss a grand dicovery, and the truth it will impose on the story moving forward, before making it official.

And one final pointer - truths don't have to make sense to us, but they *do* need to make sense to a bug.

USING TRUTHS

There are two main ways a truth can be used once it's been established, the first being as **a source of environmental advantage**, the second as **a method of creating twists without rolling**.

... AS ENVIRONMENTAL ADVANTAGE

Because a truth is a fact of the world, that often means it has some interplay with the physical environment that bugs might travel through. **That means truths can be called upon as an environmental advantage in the right situation**, if it makes sense for the action. *Advantage is detailed on page 34.*

***Example**: Joachim, a bug in Ryan's group, is trying to scare an overly curious bird pecking on a nearby window. He uses his Dazzle skill to make a big, showy performance of being scary, and also describes how he scrapes his antennae along the windowpane to set up a discordant screech from the inherently musical glass, gaining an additional 1d6 from doing so.*

... AS A WAY OF GAINING A FREE TWIST

Twists almost always come about as the result of a dice roll, specifically a dice roll showing a set of doubles somewhere within the result. But what if there was some other way of getting them, a way that didn't involve you touching any dice at all?

Well, we've got some good news for you!

Each player can have their bug call on a truth of the world to generate a free twist, once per session. Unlike a normal twist, the effects aren't decided by the other players at the table, and this doesn't need to be part of any kind of roll - instead, **the player that called on the truth decides on the effect** (though they still need to get the okay from the Weaver, as with any twist decision). *Twists are detailed on page 37.*

***Example**: Joachim is still being hassled by that bird, but they have an idea - music is essentially just screaming with a bit of a tune, and glass is reflective as well as musical. He calls on the truth Ryan revealed to spin a twist out of the air, deciding that the bird's reflection in the window opens its beak and squawks, completely independent of the bird's own actions. If that doesn't give it a scare, nothing will!*

- TRUTHS EXAMPLE -

Weaver: I've got to be honest here, things aren't looking that great for you - the bugbarians aren't giving up the chase, and those axes look awfully sharp.

Dunf: On reflection, I probably shouldn't have asked them all of those questions about their fur collars. But in my defence, I thought they really were quite fashionable!

Layla: You definitely had good intentions, but we're probably going to have a talk, if we get out of this scrape, about what topics of conversation are relevant when we're facing people that look really, really angry.

Swift: Wait... Reflections! That's it!

Dunf: What's it? Did I do something right?

Swift: You definitely did! Weaver, one of our truths is 'The sun is a deadly laser', right?

Weaver: Yep, you can thank Dunf for that one too.

Swift: After this, I will! I'm going to call on that truth for a free twist, holding up my Shiny Mirror bob as we run. Because if I angle it just right, it might just catch some of that sun-based power... Does that sound doable?

Weaver: Oh, it definitely does! Awesome use of that Truth, too. Tell us what happens, Swift!

Combos & Finishers

Sometimes the odds are against you; you're tiny, and the world is a big, big place. But with a little teamwork and a lot of effort, your band of bugs might be able to pull off a **combo** - a sequence of linked actions that lead to an extremely impressive outcome, a **finisher**.

When the Weaver sets a **track that the bugs have to fill in order to achieve something big** (such as taking down a vicious hazard, or achieving an important and immediate goal), they may **also** set a smaller, **3-box Combo Track**. The setting of a combo track is **always a Weaver decision**.

Filling the Combo Track

When taking actions with a Combo Track in play, a bug can **burn a box on one of their aspects as they perform an action**. This represents the bug putting in extra effort to contribute to a combo, and the aspect is burned whether the action is successful or not. *It's always the player's choice whether to burn in order to add to a combo.*

But if this action *is* successful - **a conflict or triumph** - it marks a box on the Combo Track in addition to any usual effects (even if it doesn't mark any other tracks). The combo is in full swing, and a finisher is just around the corner!

3 Hits & a Finisher

When a band of bugs manages to **mark all three boxes on a Combo Track**, the next action taken in that scene becomes a **finisher**! Teamwork equals power, people!

But what does a finisher do? Well, that's up to you!

A finisher can have one of two effects, chosen from the list below...

Option One: Boost your Impact

When you choose this option, whatever action you take as finisher is treated as if it's a step higher than normal in terms of impact. A no impact action would become low impact, a low impact action would be treated as a normal action, and an action that already has normal impact would increase to giga impact! *Impact is detailed on page 40.*

Option Two: Ignore All Cut

The fruits of your planning are revealed, as you find a way to bypass every negative that would usually bring you down! Ignoring all cut on an action allows you to triumph (hopefully) when a conflict or disaster would otherwise be assured. *Cut is detailed on page 38.*

Pick Your Moment

Because burned boxes on an aspect can be difficult to heal while out adventuring, combos aren't the kind of thing you can rely on the entire time. They're best saved for dealing with overwhelming situations (where you're facing a good amount of cut on multiple rolls, and really need a triumph), with longer tracks (where a giga impact hit would fill many boxes and save considerable time) and when tussling with titans (where many actions wouldn't normally mark their track, but can still fill a Combo Track and unlock an instance of useful giga damage that *will* have an effect).

- Combo & Finisher Example -

Swift: I leap at the clankercat's face - I know I can't do any real damage here, because the thing is, well, titanic, but I'm going to burn a box to add to that Combo Track. I'm trying to distract it as a set up for someone else to come in and get a solid hit in.

Weaver: Nice, and one more mark unlocks a finisher. Make your rolls, you need a conflict or triumph.

Swift: Yep yep, that's dice from my Leap skill and my Centapod aspect... A triumph! Yes!

Weaver: Your leap has you ricochet off of one of the titan's glass eyes, and it lets out a reverberating yowl as it tracks you. No damage, but the combo track is entirely filled now.

Swift: Dunf, it's your time to shine!

Dunf: You want a finisher? Well, I've got a finisher for you. I take out one of my bobs, my Lost Screw, and charge at the clankercat's nearest paw.

Weaver: Ooh, what finisher are you going with? The clankercat has some impressive defences thanks to that Armour Cut, but a lucky giga hit could turn the tide of this fight...

Dunf: Yeah, it's a tough choice. I think it fits the fiction better if I go for boosted impact here, and take that giga damage.

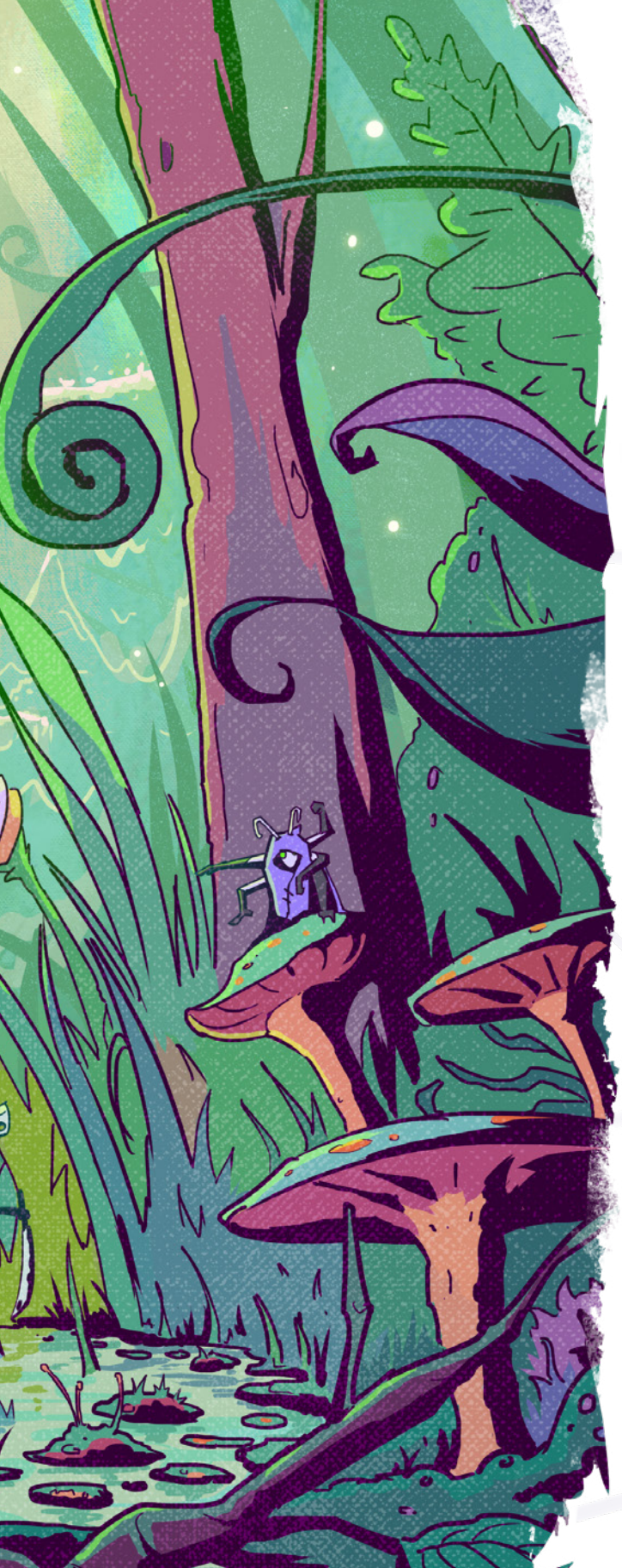
Bicco: That works for me! Hit this where it hurts, Dunf!

Dunf: I'll do my best...

Weaver: Make your roll, Dunf, and remember - this finisher is going to have giga impact, but you've still got an Armour Cut of two to get past. Let's hope for some sixes...

Dunf: That's a... Oh yeah! I mean, it's not perfect, but it's good enough for me - two sixes, which I lose to the cut, but a 5 and a 1 as well. That's a conflict with giga impact, aimed right at that metal paw it keeps batting us with!

CHAPTER 03:
PLAYING SCENES



SETTING THE SCENE

Scenes are made for freeform play - you can do pretty much anything in a scene (or at least attempt pretty much anything, you're still going to have to rely on the dice if your actions get difficult, dangerous, or dramatic).

Scenes should start with the Weaver as they literally 'set the scene', making it clear...

- **WHERE** the scene takes place
- **WHEN** the scene takes place
- **WHO** is in the scene
- **WHAT** is happening before anybody acts
- **WHY** the scene is happening

This might sound like a lot to remember, but it doesn't all have to be delivered at once. Questions from the players can help flesh out some of these points, and if one of them gets missed accidentally - eh, it happens. It's not the end of the world.

Really, all you're aiming for is for everyone at the table to have a clear idea of what's going on, which in turn gives them a good basis for thinking about the things their own bug might do.

***Example**: As the sun begins to set, the streets of craniopolis get a little quieter. There are still bugs out and about, but they move faster, spend more time in the shadow of awnings and close to tin walls. It's easy to see why - every now and then, a shrill chirp from high above hints at the presence of bats in the rafters. It's after a particularly close-sounding chirp that you hear another bug hissing at you from a nearby saloon doorway - 'Hey, travellers, this way'.*

The example above is only a few sentences, but it hits the where, the when, the who, and the what. The why will likely become apparent when the group interacts with the NPC that's just been introduced.

But players could ask questions too, before they make any decisions. Questions like 'What kind of bug is this hissing guy?', or 'Just how far up are those rafters?', or 'Remind me, do bats eat bugs?'. It helps keep everyone on the same page, metaphorically speaking.

Exploring

"Exploration is really the essence of the insect spirit."

Did we mention how big the world is? I think we might have, a couple of times...

There are two sorts of exploration that are important here. For heading out into the world, going to new places, and travelling through unfamiliar terrain, you're going to want the Journeys chapter (starting on page 83). But right here we're thinking smaller-scale - learning more about **the place you're actually in**, and using it to your advantage.

Points of Interest

One of the easiest ways to define a location is to think about what's there that is interesting, either to your bug as a character or to you as a player. These are **points of interest**, sometimes abbreviated to **POIs**.

When the Weaver sets the scene, listen out for points of interest that you might be able to use as you play.

***Example**: The Weaver describes a scene that starts in the forest. As she does, she tells the group about a thicket of bracken nearby, about some weird-smelling flowers, and about a beehive up in the branches high above. These three things can all be considered points of interest.*

Using POIs

Points of interest aren't just useful for setting a scene, they can have **mechanical benefits** too! Once a POI is established, it can be used for **environmental advantage** when making an Action Roll, or as something to investigate when **gathering bits and bobs** (more on those very soon). *Points of interest might be dangerous too, or make some actions more difficult by adding cut or reducing impact. Find out by playing!*

Adding New POIs

But it's not just up to the Weaver to populate a scene! Before anybody starts taking actions or making choices, players can **ask questions** about things that might be important to them. A player whose bug loves to swim might ask about any water in the area, and one who is playing a tiny gourmet might ask if there are any amazing smells wafting around.

***Example**: Jace's bug is a digger by nature, and loves burrowing underground when they get a chance. Jace asks the Weaver what the forest floor is like, and she adds that it's mostly soil and moss, but there are a few jagged stones sticking out in some places. Suddenly, new POIs! Those stones might be useful for hiding behind, the moss could be collected and kept, and the soil floor sounds perfect for Jace's bug to dig down into.*

Adding Even More POIs

And don't think that all of this stuff has to happen right at the start of a scene - these questions can be asked at any time, really.

The only guideline we'll give here is an important one...

Not every scene will have POIs that work for you.

If they did, the game would get boring pretty quickly. Always feel free to ask, but the answer from time to time might just be 'no'.

The Theatre of the Mind

If you've been playing tabletop games for a while, you're likely familiar with this term. PICO is a game where almost all of the 'action' takes place within the theatre of the mind, a fancy way of saying 'you imagine stuff happening as you talk about it'. Locations don't have their own little maps, you don't have miniatures (although we admit that would be disgustingly cute), and the fiction of what's going on is only constrained by a combination of rules and story.

When you use the theatre of the mind, you have licence to be a little flexible with what is and isn't in a scene. Those points of interest? Maybe there's a cool one that you 'missed' talking about, because it would make the immediate play more interesting. If that's the case, ask the Weaver if you can stick it in a scene. Need a sudden NPC to do X? Ask the Weaver if there's anyone around that can, conveniently, do X.

When using the theatre of the mind, everything you say is a flag to both the Weaver and the other players about what you understand, what you assume, what you're thinking, and where you might be going with it.

It's a collaborative story, at the end of the day. There's power in leaning into that.

Moving Around

Once you've established your POIs and know what the scene looks like in terms of the theatre of the mind, it's time to move! Take actions, do stuff, hop on things, hop *off* things. Those points of interest are there, you may as well clamber all over them.

Exploring a scene can take the form of careful study, but it's more likely that you're going to **wander about the place and make a general nuisance of yourself.** It's a great way to learn more about your environment, and learning is key! And you want to do something **difficult**, **dangerous**, or **dramatic**, that's when you **make an Action Roll**!

***Example**: As the group starts moving around, Jace takes an Action Roll to have his bug try to burrow down under one of the sharp stones - just how deep do they go, and what might be below them?*

- Exploring Example -

Weaver: The pondside is pretty quiet. You don't see any of the croaklins that were rumoured to be in the area. What you do see are lilypads floating on the water, with tall bullrushes nearby. You'd need a good jump to get onto one, but there's a little wooden jetty that leads a stone's throw out over the lake that might be useful. Other than that there's a faint smell you recognise, algae, and another that might be less familiar - smoke.

Layla: Are we the only bugs here? It's definitely quieter than I expected.

Swift: Yeah, sounds like we missed the action.

Weaver: There are - out on the other side of the pond you can see two fireflies orbiting each other. It might be a dance, it might be an argument, it's hard to tell at this distance.

Bicco: We seem pretty exposed here. Are there any rocks around, anything that might act as shelter? We did hear rumbles of thunder earlier, and we don't want to be caught in that storm if it heads our way.

Weaver: There are a few pebbles and things, but nothing that would be of much use. What there is, though, off to the left, is what looks like an oar sticking out of the pond, with a net hanging off of it. You don't see a boat around, and it's definitely not bug-sized - a Mysteriocalypse leftover, most likely.

Bicco: Oh, that's cool! I'm going to head over that way, see if anything interesting got snagged in that net over the years.

Layla: Don't wander too far! I think I might investigate the jetty. Swift, Dunf, you coming?

Dunf: I don't know... are there fish in the pond?

Weaver: You don't see any telltale fins, but there are ripples that definitely don't come just from the movements of the wind.

Dunf: Yeah, I might stay here for a bit then. Away from the water. Where I'm not going to get eaten.

Swift: I'll go with you, Layla. I've never actually seen a fish, so I'm all in for new experiences...

GATHERING

"A penny saved is a penny that you have to work out how to roll home. And that's not as easy as it looks, believe me. What are you even doing with a penny, anyway? What, you want some kind of really expensive dining table?"

Almost every scene will have opportunities to grab useful (or useless) stuff to take with you, as long as you have the space to hold it. These things come in the form of **bits and bobs** - you'll get a full run-down on how these work, and how many you can carry, on page 160, but for now all you need to know is that **bits are biological oddities** and **bobs are artificial scrap**.

GATHER ROLL RESULTS

6

TRIUMPH

You get exactly what you want! Put the bit or bob you were going for into one of your carry slots, or give it to one of your other group members for them to hold in one of theirs.

5
4

CONFLICT

You get what you want, but it's not as nice as you were expecting OR there's some downside to acquiring it. Depending on the situation, you might gather a bit or bob with a negative tag, or take some damage (or some other consequence) while collecting your prize.

3
2
1

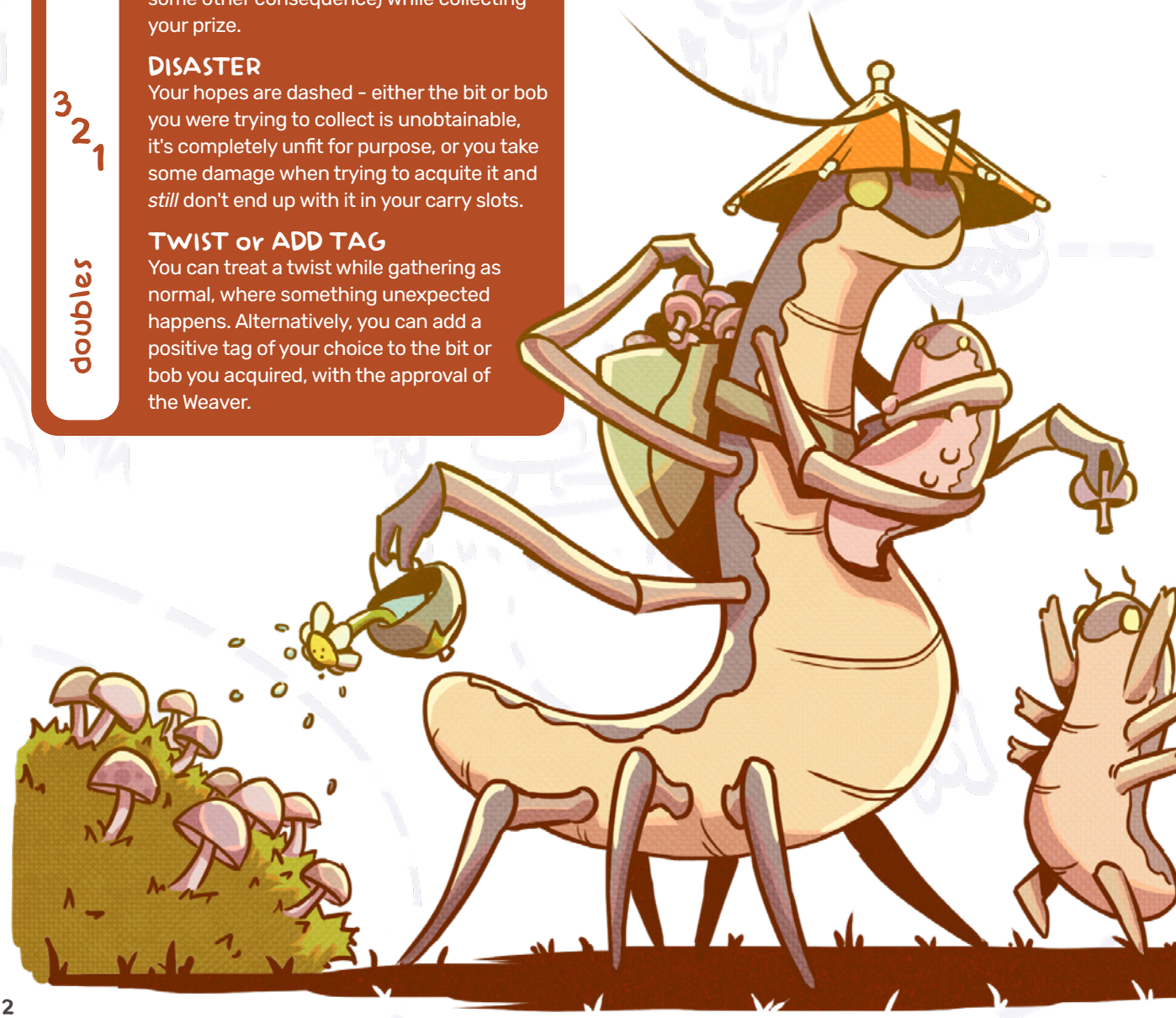
DISASTER

Your hopes are dashed - either the bit or bob you were trying to collect is unobtainable, it's completely unfit for purpose, or you take some damage when trying to acquite it and *still* don't end up with it in your carry slots.

doubles

TWIST or ADD TAG

You can treat a twist while gathering as normal, where something unexpected happens. Alternatively, you can add a positive tag of your choice to the bit or bob you acquired, with the approval of the Weaver.



Getting Bits & Bobs

See that flower over there? I bet it's got some really cool pollen inside of it. But how to get it out?

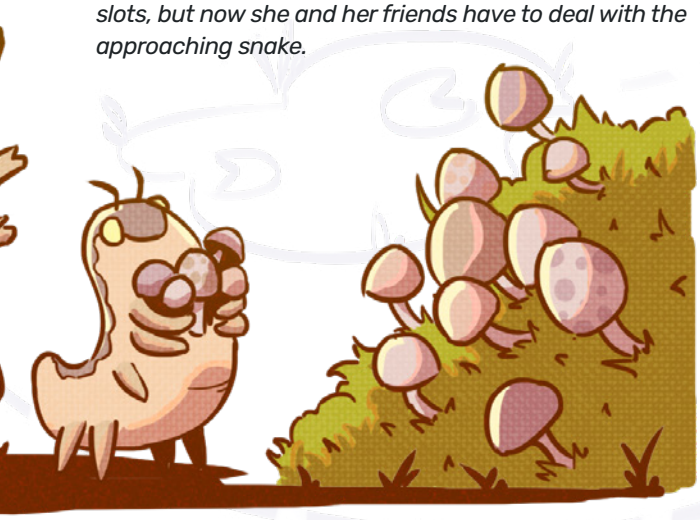
Just like when you move around, grabbing something from your surroundings is as easy as announcing what you're doing to the group, and then describing it in the fiction of the game. Easy, right? Well... Sometimes.

To Roll, or Not?

If there's no element of randomness or challenge to gathering a bit or bob, you just *get it*. No rolls required - stick it straight into a **carry slot** and continue with the scene. *You'll find information on carry slots, and how many bits and bobs you can hold, on page 161.*

But If the act of gathering would be **difficult**, **dangerous**, or **dramatic**, you might have to roll for it. This is where **actions** come in, coupled with your **skills** (the skills Hunt and Rummage are particularly useful here). The table on the previous page shows a special set of dice results you can use when taking an action to gather, too!

***Example**: Sasha sees a penny half-buried in the mud of a riverbank. She loves shiny things in general, and she has carry slots free, so she decides to try to take it with her. The Weaver asks her to roll, pointing out that the penny is pretty firmly stuck in the mud. Sasha does, and gets a conflict with a twist. The Weaver describes that in the course of pulling the penny out, she alerts a nearby snake on the other side of the river, that slips under the water and heads in her direction. But she does get the penny, and with the twist she adds a positive tag, Golden, deciding that this penny is made out of pure gold. She adds the Golden Penny to one of her carry slots, but now she and her friends have to deal with the approaching snake.*



- Gathering Example -

Bicco: What do I find in this net then, Weaver?

Weaver: Ooh, don't get too ahead of yourself! It's dark in the shadow of the oar, and it's tough to see past all of the netting draped down around it. You do, however, notice something as you draw closer - you're definitely not the first bug to investigate this place.

Dunf: Oh dear...

Weaver: Oh dear is right - Bicco, when you draw close to the net you see the shells of many bugs tangled up in it. And some of those tangles look suspiciously purposeful - is this a decoration of some kind?

Bicco: I am... Suddenly less enthused.

Weaver: Well, that's a pity, because it's not the only thing you see there - poking just through the net, near the bottom, there's a beautiful speckled feather. It's white and brown, but it really stands out against the rather macabre backdrop of the decorated net.

Bicco: I'm so torn right now!

Layla: Bicco...

Bicco: Yeah, I'm going to go for it. I scuttle up and try to grab the feather, before whatever's been decorating this net notices me. I roll for that?

Weaver: It definitely sounds potentially dangerous, so I'm going to say yes. Take a Tough Cut of one for the feather being tangled in the bottom, but apart from that you make your roll how you like.

Bicco: Okay, I've got 1d6 for my rummage skill, but I actually think I'm going to go a little left field here and use Slash - it's 2d6, and I'm going to try to cut the net to free the feather. I'll use my Toothpick spear to help, that's 3d6 with a cut of one. A... Hmm, a conflict. Could have been worse.

Weaver: I love your thinking! You slice at the net and the feather comes free - add Brown Speckled Feather to one of your carry slots. But the downside? From the darkness under the oar floats a low voice - "Hello, little friend..."

Bicco: ... Oh.

INTERACTING

"Three simple rules: never ask a mantis how their spouse is, never talk spores with a cordychap, and NEVER talk politics with a squirrel."

We'll keep this one short and sweet, as conversing with NPCs in the world of PICO is a pretty simple process. Just like any other action, striking up a conversation or shouting something to a potential ally (or enemy) is as simple as saying you're doing it, **unless the situation threatens danger, difficulty, or drama**. How would a conversation invite those things? Let's count some ways...

DANGEROUS TALK

Not every bug you meet is going to be friendly, and that goes triple for beasts. Saying the wrong thing, bringing up the wrong topic, or being rude - either accidentally or on purpose - might lead to a scuffle - maybe even a full-blown scrap! When you're interacting verbally with something hostile, you should probably roll the dice to see how the conversation goes.

***Example**: A band of piratical caterpillars are hanging out at the bar, their long bodies blocking every stool. Asif wants to take a seat and grab a relaxing drink, but he's going to have to ask them to move first. He looks at his friending skills and chooses Yap to help his action, hoping to be a sparkling enough wit for them to want him around and make some room so he can sit. But if it goes wrong, he may well just be their next target!*

DIFFICULT TALK

Difficulty in interaction might come from the topics of conversation, but it might also be thanks to what you hope to get out of an exchange. Trying to persuade an NPC to act in your favour, to do something out of character for them, or to act against their best interests, is going to be *hard*.

You can also roll to try to determine whether someone's telling the truth or not, though you'll have to work in some interrogative questions into your speech to take advantage of this type of interaction. *Expect some Tough Cut in situation like these, especially if the individual you're talking to is particularly wily.*

***Example**: Herve and his gang of friends are on the trail of a wily fox, a titan that's stolen one of the tin cans that their home settlement uses as a kitchen. As far as they can tell, the fox has crossed a nearby river controlled by zealously mercantile spiders, who'll take other bugs back and forth in their silky barges - but only for an exorbitant price. With no bits or bobs valuable enough to pay the toll, Herve uses his Dazzle skill to try to persuade one of the spiders that letting them cross for free now will bring riches in the long run, but it's going to be a hard sell.*

DRAMATIC TALK

Sometimes the dice are used for an interaction not because it's dangerous, or difficult, but because it's a big pivotal point in a story - the outcome being uncertain adds a spice of the unexpected to proceedings.

***Example**: Lucy is bargaining for the release of an old stag beetle smith, a long-time prisoner of one of the squirrel kings. She's in the good graces of the court, so there's no immediate danger to her, and the king's quite fond of her already - but think about the ramifications if it got out that they were letting prisoners go. Lucy rolls the dice, but uses the Think skill to try to find a good logical way to argue the squirrel king around to her position.*

How to Make Friends

There's a whole cateogry of skills devoted to interacting with NPCs, known as the friending skills. *You'll learn more about them on page 149, but we'll do a quick run-down of how each might help you during a social interaction here too...*

- **Yap**: For chatting, gathering information, and putting bugs and beasts at ease.
- **Swagger**: For making yourself seem tough or cool, often by playing up your physicality or presence.
- **Dazzle**: For showing off and grabbing the attention of crowds, and for confusing others with clever wordplay.
- **Scare**: For inspiring *fear*! Like Swagger, your physical presence can work in your favour here, but alliances built on fear don't tend to last.
- **Care**: While primarily used for healing, making people feel valuable and safe is a great way of instilling positive feelings in them.
- **Tame**: For interacting with wilder bugs and larger beasts, those that might not share your ability to speak, but can still be soothed or reasoned with.

But don't think that it's only these skills that can come in useful! You might be able to endear yourself to an individual by sharing a passion with, or by demonstrating knowledge or understanding of something they hold dear.

***Example**: Heinrik is trying to forge an alliance with a curious bird, so uses his own skill at flying to establish some common ground.*

... and Influence People

Wouldn't it be nice if every problem could be solved with a lovely, calm chat? Unfortunately for the bugs of the Mysteriocalypse, things haven't changed *that* much; sometimes the best way to get what you want is through throwing a bit of intimidation into the mix, maybe even making some threats.

Friending skills can still come in useful here (like Scare), but **don't be afraid to try other skills too** - absentmindedly crushing a pebble between your claws with the Bash skill during a conversation is going to lend some weight to fighting words, even if you're not the most eloquent speaker.

- Interacting Example -

Weaver: Bicco, you see shape from the darkness under the oar push closer to the light, brushing up against the rather morbid netting. You get the impression of talons, feathers, and a short, but wickedly curved beak, but then a pair of eyes open wide and you find yourself transfixed.

Layla: Oh gods, that's a ground-owl isn't it? I've heard about them. I'm not even close enough to notice this yet, am I? Does Bicco know what one of these is?

Weaver: Nope, you're out on the jetty. Bicco, have you ever seen a ground-owl before?

Bicco: Never, though I guess this new feather I'm holding came off of it?

Weaver: It did indeed. The owl leans forward and presses against the net, eyes flashing in the evening light. "Would you be so kind," it asks you, "as to cut away a little more of this net? I've been stuck for a frightfully long time, and nobody else has managed it".

Bicco: I don't know if I believe that, so I'm going to ask. "But you're so big, surely you could cut your way out on your own?" I'm going to roll for that too, using Yap.

Weaver: The owl's eyes narrow as he considers your words, and he cocks his head to one side. Let's get the result of that roll, Bicco - he obviously doesn't like being questioned...

What, No Special Roll Table?

Not this time! NPC interactions should be as varied as the NPCs themselves, and the classic triumph / conflict / disaster / twist spread is easy to adapt to whatever outcome a conversation or chance meeting might have. You don't need special rules to make a meeting special, just a bit of creativity at the table!

RUMBLING

"This mustn't register on an emotional level. First, distract target, then block his grabby tongue. Counter with wing to left cheek. Discombobulate. Dazed, he'll attempt a wild hay-maker - employ shell block, and body shot. Capacity to lick all my nice food, neutralized."

Bugs don't fight - that would be so *uncouth*! But from time to time they do love a **rumble**, where mandibles snap, toothpick-blades slice, harsh words are unleashed, and both shells and pride are often dented.

That's right, rumbles are the bugly equivalent of a combat scene! The next few pages delve into forms a rumble might take, the special rules both Weaver and players can use during this type of scene, and how to leverage your skills and aspects to take hazards on head to head!

MORE THAN JUST A FIGHT

Don't get us wrong here, the rumble rules definitely cover a bites-and-blades style combat. But, in a game of PICO, **violence is entirely optional**, and these rules can *also* be used to represent a variety of encounters with the dangers of the world. A rumble might take the form of...

- **A scuffle between bugs** as they compete for a delicious prize, or a bit of useful territory.
- **A tense exchange of words and gestures**, the kind of argument where something's got to give.
- **A deadly encounter with a beastly threat**, where losing probably means becoming someone's next meal.
- **A frantic chase through the undergrowth**, with a pursuing party drawing ever closer.
- **A contest of strength or skill**, where prizes are decided in advance and winning is more a matter of honour than survival.
- **An all-out brawl in a tin-can bar**, where bugs drunk on pollenmead throw tiny chairs at one another.
- **A match of cap-golf**, or any of the other bugly sports popular among the residents of the post-Mysteriocalypse.
- **A nighttime ambush on weary travellers**, stealthy froglins rushing in to sieze what they can and scarper.

... Or any combination of the above!

THE HALLMARKS OF A RUMBLE

In a rumble, **you're usually working directly to defeat an opponent in some way**. That means there will usually be at least a few of the following elements...

- A **Heart Track** to fill, as explained on page 57.
- Opportunities to specifically **attack** and **defend**, with special rules on page 58.
- A lot of **damage** being thrown around, which can be enhanced or mitigated with **weaknesses** and **resistances** as shown on page 60.

TRACKS IN A RUMBLE

Tracks are just as useful in a rumble as they are in other modes of play, as an excellent visual reminder of a scene's current goal. **The usual progress tracks as described on page 32 can still be used** (and are great for things like changing environmental conditions, the time taken for reinforcements to show up, or the amount of distance left to cover in a chase or race), but there are three types of track that are particularly useful in a rumble: **Spotlight Tracks**, **Combo Tracks**, and **Heart Tracks**. *Not every rumble will use these tracks, so don't feel obligated!*

SPOTLIGHT TRACKS

PICO doesn't have an initiative system beyond 'whoever is doing something should probably get some spotlight next', but with actions and reactions coming thick and fast in a rumble, it can help everyone if the Weaver keeps a Spotlight Track - a way of recording who has acted and reacted, and how many times.

As described on page 31, a Spotlight Track is as simple as putting down the name of each bug (or player) and then putting either an **A** or an **R** next to their name each time they get the spotlight, representing actions or reactions. If a player hasn't had the chance to take actions recently, the track will make that clear, and the Weaver (or another player) can use the narrative to swing the spotlight round to them. *If there's a hazard involved in a scene, or NPCs, you may or may not add them to the Spotlight Track according to the group's tastes, or the amount of bookkeeping the Weaver wants to do.*

HEART TRACKS

Though most tracks are represented with linked circles (because they're easy to draw at the table), some tracks within this book look a little different. A little... heartier?

Heart Tracks work **exactly the same way as any other track**, they just look a little different (with a heart representing a box and a little dot representing a break).

Why? Because they're there as a visual indicator that this particular track is *perfect* for soaking up damage during a rumble (though, like all tracks, they can be marked in other ways). *You don't have to represent these tracks using hearts at the table, though, especially if you find them harder or slower to draw. And some Weavers might not even have the Heart Track of a hazard visible, especially if the threat is unknown to the bugs in the band!*

You'll find Heart Tracks on your character's **aspects** (on page 104) and, if you're the Weaver, on the statblocks for **hazards** (starting on page 201).

COMBO TRACKS

Particularly useful if the bugs are facing a really tough hazard, a Combo Track (as described fully on page 46) lets characters burn some of their own boxes as they act to set up a high-damage finishing move. Teamwork is even more important in a rumble than in most scenes, so when the Weaver puts a Combo Track down you should try to get some use out of it!

- RUMBLE TRACKS EXAMPLE -

Weaver: You might, Bicco, have expected a harsh rejoinder - maybe even a threat. Unfortunately for you, it's going to be a lot worse than that. The ground-owl surges forward toward you screeching, tearing the net from the oar and scattering shells everywhere.

Swift: Do we all see this?

Dunf: Oh, I think you all see this!

Weaver: Yeah, especially with the sudden screeching, you're all very aware that something bad is happening. Dunf, I'm going to ask you for a Reaction Roll in a second, but first of all I'm going to lay out a couple of tracks.

Dunf: Oh, this might get serious then!

Weaver: Certainly seems like it! I'm keeping the Heart Track for the ground-owl hidden behind my GM screen for now, but I'll stick this Combo Track out on the table for you.

Bicco: That's three boxes leading up to a finisher, right?

Weaver: That's right. If this gets hectic I'll start tracking the spotlight too, but for now let's focus on Dunf - my friend, are you ready to make that Reaction Roll?

ATTACKING AND DEFENDING

Any action used in a rumble has the potential to mark tracks and affect the world, just like it would in any other scene. Bugs that aren't combat-focused can still be just as useful as they normally would be, it just takes a bit of quick thinking and some creative uses of their existing skills!

***Example**: Spidal isn't a fan of scuffles, but when danger comes knocking he's determined to hold his own. His frying pan can be used as a Bashing weapon, his Cook skill is great for throwing salt or spices into the eyes of opponents, and even his Care skill might come in handy as he distracts combatants with the delicious smells of a hearty meal... long enough for one of his allies to sink tiny fangs into them.*

But, for the fightier bugs among you, there *are* two special types of action (with unique results tables) that are perfectly suited to rougher situations - **attacks** and **defends**.

The results of an Attack or Defend Roll are tuned with combat in mind, all about taking or avoiding the damage and effects of dangerous moves. You don't need to specifically call out that you're attacking or defending (though we suppose you could if you wanted to, it would certainly give a very anime-fight-scene vibe to proceedings). Instead, it's usually on the Weaver to determine whether the normal rules for an action, or the special rules for an attack or defend, suit the situation better.

ACTIONS TO ATTACK

An attack is usually an action specifically intended to harm a target in some way, or at least to make their life somehow worse. The rumble skills Bash, Bite, Slash, and Sizzle are all prime candidates to help with a roll here, as are any aspects that might make you stronger, more menacing, or particularly spiky. *The rumble skills get a full explanation on page 151.*

But as we mentioned above, these scenes don't expect the more pacifist bugs to stand aside and let others have all the fun. **Any skill can be used to attack**, and many foes will actually have specific weaknesses to non-rumble skills, increasing the amount of marks made on a Heart Track!

***Example**: Froglins are weak to both the Tame, because they're so rarely shown kindness, and Yap, because they can't stand seeing their friends get insulted or made fun of (by anyone that isn't them).*

The damage an attack deals is always equal to the action's impact (so a normal-impact attack would deal one mark of damage if successful, whereas a giga-impact attack would deal enough marks to fill the target's Heart Track completely, or at least until the next track break), and **the damage type is the same as the skill used for the roll**. *We'll give some extra rules for damage, and how it's affected by a target's weaknesses or resistances, on page 60.*

ATTACK ROLL RESULTS

6

TRIUMPH

Your strike lands true! You deal **damage** to your target, and hit them with an **effect**.

5
4

CONFLICT

You hit, but it's either a glancing blow or something with additional complications. Choose one of the following...

- You deal **damage** OR an **effect**,

OR

- You deal a mark of **damage** AND an **effect**, but **you're also hit** with damage or an effect from your target.

3
2
1

DISASTER

That did not go as planned. Your attack **misses completely**, letting your target take the opportunity to **hit you** with both damage AND an effect of their own.

doubles

TWIST or CRITICAL

You can treat a twist while rumbling as normal, where something unexpected happens. Alternatively, you can choose to deal an **extra mark of damage** to your target, which gets applied right after the first instance of damage (if you're dealing giga damage and hit a track break, this additional mark is made *after* the break).

REACTIONS TO DEFEND

Defending is a great use of your time if some nasty hazard has lined up a shot against you. In fact, **the Weaver will throw the spotlight your way whenever you become the target of an attack from a foe**, specifically to let you use a reaction to defend yourself!

There are a couple of skills that are absolute classics when it comes to defending, in the shape of Dash (for getting out of the way quickly), Dance (for elegantly evading), and Shield (for weathering an incoming blow as best you can). But, just like with attacks, **any skill can help you make a Defend Roll if it fits the situation!**

***Example**: Layla, upon being attacked by the ground-owl, usually uses her Dash skill to help her defend herself. She might use Dance instead though; it could give her a situational cut on the roll, but would let her change to a new position as part of the flowing movement. Bicco prefers to stick with Shield, relying on his hard shell to help out.*

Hazards don't treat impact in the same way that bugs do, so sometimes you'll have some truly *terrifying* amounts of damage coming your way. What's important to remember here is that you're sturdier than you think, and unless you specifically choose to be, you're not in danger of death no matter how dire things get. Other consequences though? Oh yeah, they'll hit you **hard**. *The rules for taking damage are on page 62, and death is discussed on page 66.*

DEFEND ROLL RESULTS

6

TRIUMPH

Your defences are unparalleled! You turn aside whatever attack is incoming, and you **completely ignore** any **damage** or **effects** that were heading your way.

5
4

CONFLICT

You manage to mitigate whatever harm is on course for you, but you don't stop it entirely.

The Weaver gets to choose whether you take the **damage** of the incoming attack, or the **effect**. The plus side? When you *do* take damage, **you can choose** which of your aspects gets marked.

3
2
1

DISASTER

Well, that went about as poorly as it possibly could have. When you roll a disaster, you take **both** the **damage** and the **effect** of whatever was aimed at you. **You still get to choose** which aspect takes the damage.

doubles

TWIST or COUNTER

You can treat a twist while defending as normal, where something unexpected happens. Alternatively, you can counterattack the foe that just tried to take you down! If you choose to counterattack, deal **normal impact damage** to your attacker (usually one mark).

DEALING DAMAGE

When you're engaged with a hazard or hostile force of some kind, damage comes from **any action that brings the rumble closer to a conclusion**. This usually comes in the form of **attacks**, where bugs try to deal damage directly to an opponent in the form of marks on their Heart Track, but also covers...

- Actions that make an opponent **less likely**, or **less able**, to keep rumbling.
- Actions that **trap** an opponent, or that let the player characters get closer to escaping.
- Actions that **confuse** or **demoralize** an opponent, making it more likely that they'll give up.

MAKING THE MOST OF YOUR DAMAGE

Impact is important here. Heart Tracks in a rumble are like any other track in this regard - the more impact your action has, the more boxes you're going to affect. Giga impact tends to end rumbles pretty quickly against all but the most titanic foes!

The quality of your rolls matters massively too. Both **triumph** and **conflict** results are a reliable way of getting some damage in (though conflicts also usually involve you taking some damage yourself), and avoiding **cut** where possible makes these results more probable.

ADDING EFFECTS

When you have the opportunity to deal damage, you'll almost always have the choice of trading it for an **effect** (or adding an effect on top of the damage you deal). While there are a few specific effects that have pre-defined outcomes, most will be **freeform** - an extra bit of narrative weight to your action that changes something about you, your opponent, or the rumble as a whole. Don't discount effects just because they may not mark tracks directly; PICO is a narrative first game for a reason! *Effects, both specific and freeform, are discussed in full on page 64.*

ACTIONS, SKILLS, & DAMAGE TYPES

The damage an attack deals always has a **type**, usually **the same type as the skill that was used for the Action Roll** (so a roll with the Sizzle skill would naturally cause Sizzle Damage).

There are ways to alter this though, if it makes more sense for the fiction of the game. A clever use of a bug's **aspects**, any **bits and bobs** they have on hand, or the **environment** they're in (including any established POIs) might all make another damage type more appropriate than the one that matches their skill. *The final example on the next page gives a scenario where the skill used and the type of damage it deals may not match up.*

But what does this really mean?

That there's no such thing as being useless in a rumble.

Even the gentlest bug can achieve something in an out-and-out fight through clever use of their skills, resources, and the world around them. Yeah, maybe combat-themed bugs might still get the biggest, splashiest moments, but it's always a team effort.

WEAKNESSES & RESISTANCES

You can't have a damage type system without some weaknesses to exploit, or resistances to avoid! Many hazards will have at least one weakness and one resistance on their statblock, and the rules for these are pretty simple...

- **If you hit a target with a damage type they're weak to, increase your impact by one step** (from no to low, low to normal, or normal to giga).
- **If you hit a target with a damage type they're resistant to, decrease your impact by one step** (from low to no impact, or from normal to low, or from giga to normal).

IMMUNITIES

Some hazards even have immunities, types of damage that just have no effect on them whatsoever. In these cases it doesn't matter what your impact is, or how well you roll - you can't mark their track with a damage type they're immune to. You can still use effects though, so keep this in mind. *Hazard statblocks are found in chapter 10, starting on page 200.*

LIMITS? THERE ARE NO LIMITS!

In practice, **any skill a bug has access to might be able to cause damage in the right situation**. Some skills are definitely easier to use than others though; as we mentioned on page 58, the Bash, Slash, Bite, and Sizzle skills are perfect for dealing straightforward damage.

***Example**: Noah launches themselves at the beastmouse, hitting it with a solid Bash that adds a mark of damage to its heart track. As that marks the track's last box, the Weaver steps in to describe how the beastmouse staggers back, eyes crossed, and manages a comical pirouette before slumping over with its tongue hanging out.*

But careful planning or an ingenious approach can reap unexpected rewards, and Noah definitely has access to more skills than just Bash! Below are a few examples of how that scene might have played out differently if Noah's player had used a different skill, or a more unexpected approach - you should never feel like the only option is bonking something on the head.

***Example**: Wanting a more dramatic end to the fight, Noah rolls with their Scare skill, rising up into the air on beating wings and shouting a string of threats that would turn a caterpillar's bristles white. It might not deal physical damage, but it still marks the beastmouse's track; the Weaver explains that the sudden wave of fear is enough to send the mouse scampering away, squeaking wildly.*

***Example**: Noah grabs a capsule of Sleepy Gas from one of their carry slots, a bob they picked up in a previous scene. They make their roll and describe how they use the Tame skill to get in close and crack the capsule, releasing the gas right under the beastmouse's twitching nose. Even though they aren't harming the foe, they're definitely robbing it of the will to keep fighting! The Weaver marks the final box on the track with Tame damage and imitates a long, loud snore as the mouse hits the deck.*

***Example**: Noah takes the spotlight, but is pretty far away from the beastmouse. That doesn't mean Noah doesn't have a plan, though - rather than rushing in, they use their Hunt skill, along with one of their aspects (a crown of nano-spiders), and describe how they're rolling to spit some web in an arc over the beastmouse's current position, attaching it to a low-hanging branch and then yanking on it. The roll goes well, and the Weaver describes the beastmouse looking confused for a moment as leaves drift down around it... And then taking a high-velocity acorn to the head from above. That's a mark of Hunt damage, appropriate for Noah using the environment as a makeshift trap (though the Weaver may also have counted it as Bash damage for the hardness of the acorn).*

TAKING DAMAGE

Taking damage is quite a lot like dealing it, though likely not quite as fun.

Playable bugs in PICO all have a number of **aspects**, like the one below...

MANDIBLES (Maka) ♥♥♥•♥♥ PART
Perfect for nibbling, chewing, and gripping, the most common bugly mouth style.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when biting other bugs.

These aspects highlight your bug's most important features and give you special benefits based on them, but see that up in the toppish rightish bit? That's a **Heart Track**, just like the kind the Weaver uses to record damage on a hazard. That's because **any damage your bug takes goes straight onto an aspect**, and when that aspect is fully marked you lose the benefits it usually gives (until at least one heart is unmarked).

You'll learn more about aspects on page 104, but for now all that matters is how they take damage. Imagine the owner of this particular aspect, a bug we'll call Gnash, is attacked by a hazard. They use a reaction to defend themselves, but roll poorly - something bad is about to happen, and it comes in the form of marks!

***Example**: Gnash's disaster means that the hydra he's fighting lands a solid hit, and the Weaver asks him to take a mark of Bite damage. Ouch!*

When a character takes damage, the player decides which aspect it gets marked to. This allows for some tactical damage-taking, and gives the ability to spread damage out over various aspects to keep your benefits around for as long as possible. There are two important rules here though...

» **The aspect you mark damage to has to make fictional sense.** So if the fiction of the game describes you taking damage from grabbing something, you're probably going to mark it on an aspect related to your little hands!

» **You can't split damage from one source over multiple aspects.** Hazards and environmental threats don't treat impact the same way as you do, and often dish out anywhere from one to six marks at a time. If you get hit with four marks of damage, they all have to go on the same aspect.

MAKING YOUR MARKS

So you've been hit with some damage - what does that look like?

Well, probably something like this! **Remember, marks are always made on a track from left to right.**

MANDIBLES (Maka) ♥♥♥•♥♥ PART
Perfect for nibbling, chewing, and gripping, the most common bugly mouth style.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when biting other bugs.

But what if that hydra did a little more damage? Well, in this particular case, that's when **breaks** come into play.

***Example**: Another hit from the hydra - Gnash is really taking a beating! This time it wraps his head in plastic coils and squeezes, dealing four marks of Bash Damage. What should Gnash do now?*

Fictionally, the hydra's attack should probably still deal damage to Gnash's mandibles aspect - it's the 'headiest' aspect he has, after all. But with only four unmarked hearts left on the track, does that mean Gnash will lose access to the benefit it gives?

MARKS & BREAKS

Nope, because he's only going to take two of those marks thanks to the track break!

MANDIBLES (Maka) ♥♥♥•♥♥ PART
Perfect for nibbling, chewing, and gripping, the most common bugly mouth style.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when biting other bugs.

It's still a good chunk of damage, but **once that break is hit, any other marks that would normally be made are ignored**. It's another element of the tactical side of play, absorbing and nullifying large instances of damage by using track breaks where possible. *But remember, keep it consistent with the fiction! The Weaver might sometimes request marks be made to a specific aspect (usually because a hazard has a special rule that lets it do that), but it's almost always on you as a player to make that decision.*

Taking Burn

While few hazards deal burn directly, it will turn up in a rumble if you take a lot of damage in a short time. That's because **when you mark damage to an aspect, any that goes over the END of the track wraps around and starts burning hearts.**

***Example**: A final attack from the hydra, this time an electrical shock delivered straight to Gnash's chompy little mandibles. Three marks of Sizzle damage, but the mandibles only have two marks left - looks like someone's getting burned!*

MANDIBLES (Maka) ✕//•// PART

Perfect for nibbling, chewing, and gripping, the most common bugly mouth style.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when biting other bugs.

In the example above, the three marks of damage Gnash takes wrap around - the first two are taken as normal marks, on the fourth and fifth hearts of the Mandibles track, but the last mark is converted to a burn and overwrites the first heart's existing mark.

In a way, this is useful - it means that **unlike most tracks, an aspect's Heart Track can absorb double the usual amount of damage by converting existing marks to burns**. But burn can be difficult to heal outside of a bugly settlement, and the track being fully marked means Gnash has already lost access to the benefit it gives.

Burn & Breaks

But there's always good to go with the bad. **Burn is stopped by track breaks on an aspect, just like marks would be**. And, if you want to play it a bit fast and loose, **you can choose to overwrite existing marks with burns even before a track is filled**, which can keep some hearts entirely clear and thus keep a track's benefit around for longer. Risky move, though!

Resistances & Weaknesses for Bugs

Some aspects give your bug a resistance or weakness, but it works a little differently when you *take* damage than when you *deal* it. As a character, **having a resistance against incoming damage allows you to take half the usual marks (rounded down). Having a weakness forces you to take double the usual marks.**

- Actions & Damage Example -

Dunf: Right, reaction time! I'm going to defend - I'm using Dash as my skill and having my hexapod legs aspect give me a bonus too. That's 3d6 - any cut here?

Weaver: A Tough Cut of one as the folds of the net fall around you - it wasn't a decoration, but a trap!

Bicco: Okay, that's a six! No, wait, I've got cut - that's a 4. A conflict! Do I take damage or effect?

Weaver: Bicco, the ground-owl's beak slams down but you manage to scramble out of the way... and right into the folds of the net. You're stuck there, unable to escape for the moment, but you managed to avoid the damage.

Layla: And that would have been some hefty damage too, from a beast that size. We have to help him!

Weaver: Spotlight is open, people...

Swift: And I'm going to take it! I'm far away, on the edge of the jetty - I don't think I have time to get up close. But you know what I do have? This Razor Bottlecap. I'm making an attack as I run toward the ground-owl, throwing my bottlecap ahead of me. That's going to be Slash, and a d6 from the bottlecap - do I get advantage from the ground-owl being tangled in the net too?

Weaver: You don't, BUT I am going to *not* give you an Armour Cut for the net being in the way, as you're already using Slash. Roll it!

Swift: We're coming, Bicco! That's a 6 - no, wait, that's a 6 with doubles! A triumph with a twist! I'm using it as a critical, dealing extra damage.

Weaver: Nice hit! Describe it for us.

Swift: The bottlecap flies true, clonking the owl on the head and bouncing off - where it rebounds from the oar and hits it again! Two marks of damage, who's up next?

EFFECTS

Whenever you take an action, you're probably looking to have an effect on the world in some way. And in a rumble, when you're rolling to attack or defend, that effect is handled separately from the damage you deal, take, or avoid.

An effect can be anything from grabbing someone to knocking them over, jumping to a new position to whispering in someone's ear. They don't deal or avoid any additional damage, but they **can have a big impact on the narrative of a scene**, and might change how an enemy reacts or what opportunities your allied bugs have.

***Example**: Jojo body slams an approaching wheely-grub with a triumph, dealing a mark of damage with his Bash skill and gaining the opportunity to inflict an effect. He uses it to push the wheely-bug off course, smashing it into a wall and stopping its incessant zooming - the Weaver declares that the next bug that attacks it may not take the usual cut imposed for the wheely-grub being so fast, but it'll recover soon enough!*

FREEFORM EFFECTS

Most effects in PICO are going to be freeform, where you describe what you want to do and the Weaver comes up with an associated narrative or mechanical outcome to match it (whatever fits the situation). An effect might deny a hazard cut, temporarily remove one of their moves, change your location on the battlefield, create a new POI... the possibilities are pretty much endless! *There's additional guidance for the Weaver on how they might mechanize effects on page 198.*

SPECIFIC EFFECTS

Some effects happen often enough that they get a special name, and may even be referenced by certain rules. These effects, in fact!

PUSH & PULL

Pushing a target sends it away from you, and pulling it brings it towards you. It's as simple as that!

***Example**: Javier rolls a conflict for his attack against a nearby beastmouse, and decides to go for an effect rather than a mark of damage. Why would he do this? Because the beastmouse is standing on the edge of a convenient cliff! The push might send it right over or leave it dangling, needing help to get back up.*

STUN

Another easy one, but without the flexibility of pushing and pulling. When a character stuns a hazard, **it can't take the spotlight next** (usually meaning that an ally can leap in with an immediate follow-up action). This is the same in reverse, with a stunned character not being able to take the spotlight next (for an action or reaction). Why is this bad? Because **if you can't react to something, that's an auto-disaster!**

***Example**: A beastmouse stuns Javier, a blow from a tiny club sending him reeling. Another mouse follows up with a wicked bite, which the stunned Javier takes the full force of, as if he rolled a disaster.*

GRAB

A grab entangles two individuals until the grabber lets go (which can be done at any time) or the grabbed breaks free (which will usually require a roll to achieve, or to stop from happening).

There are few hard-and-fast rules for a grab - this isn't that kind of game - but there are a few important conventions you should follow, based on the relative sizes and positions of those involved in a grab. **Bigger individuals can easily move or throw smaller ones**, and **smaller individuals can ride or climb around on bigger ones** (but usually only if they're the grabber).

***Example**: Javier decides to grab a hulking beastmouse chieftain, and leaps onto the creature's back. From here he plans to cover the beastmouse's eyes so that his allies can get some good hits in - but he'll have to hang on tight!*

SWALLOW

Only available to hazards, and even then quite rarely, this allows them to gulp down a bug and keep them trapped until their teammates help them escape... Or until the bug finds a way back out!

- EFFECTS EXAMPLE -

Layla: Time to bring in the big guns, and almost literally! I'm going to use one of my bobs, the Alchemical Firework, and roll with Hunt to aim a shot at that ground-owl!

Weaver: Ooh, roll it! Just so you know, if this hits I'll probably have it deal Sizzle damage rather than Hunt damage, because of the bob you're using.

Layla: That's fine with me. I get a... Hmm, a 4. That's a conflict, so I could have it do damage, but...

Weaver: But?

Layla: I think I might go for an effect. Dunf is still tangled up in the netting, right?

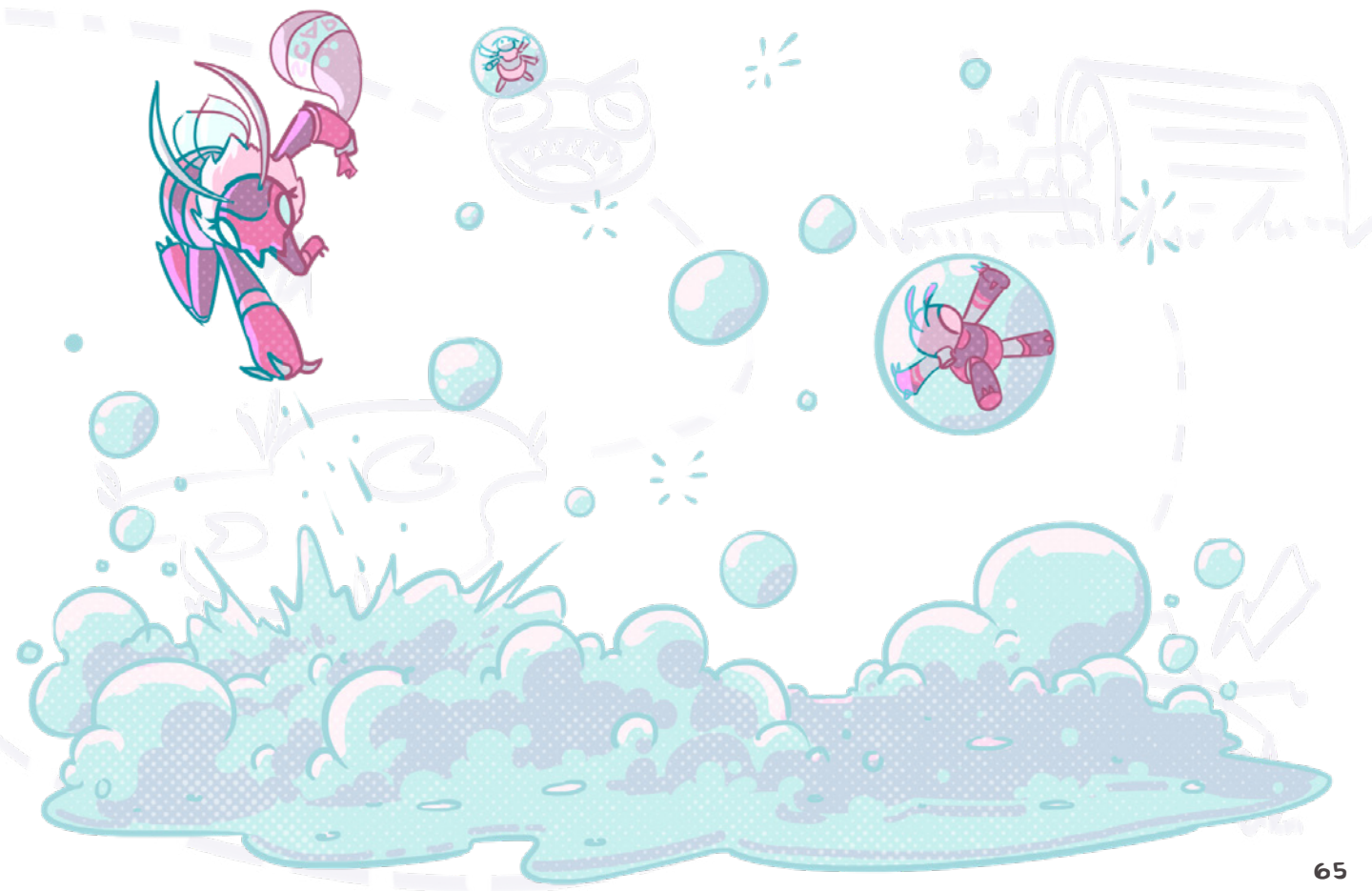
Dunf: I definitely am!

Swift: Well, what if the firework bounces off of the ground-owl, but sets the net alight? That might make it easier for Dunf to get free when the spotlight swings his way.

Dunf: I like it!

Weaver: I like it too, but there may be some downsides if that fire spreads. As long as you're aware of that, I say both go for it and describe it. And Dunf, you can re-roll 1s on any roll to get you out of that net from now on.

Layla: Well, it starts with the sound of the blue touch paper lighting...



DEATH & DEFEAT!

PICO is a pretty upbeat game, but it's not without its darker moments, and it's definitely not without consequences for unfortunate events.

What 'winning' looks like in a rumble depends entirely on the nature of the scene – what exactly *does* happen when that track is finally fully marked? If it's a chase, someone will probably get caught; if it's a sporting event, there will likely be a losing team... And if it's a real, proper scrap, then someone's going to end up hurt.

Use the **Safety Tools on page 193** to determine how much of this kind of stuff you want to show, and what level of detail the table is okay with in terms of description.

But what if the worst does come to pass, and for one of the player characters? When every heart they have is burned, or when they're in a narratively deadly situation? Well...

DEATH, AVOIDED

Death in PICO is a player choice.

You *can* die, but the mechanics won't force you to. Instead, **if you fully burn all of your aspects, you can curl up into a ball and hide for the rest of the scene**. Then at the start of the next scene you completely clear a single heart for free and can act normally again (though you're still extremely banged up).

This is the standard way of things, but we encourage you to deal with death (and avoiding it) in a way that suits your table. They're your characters, after all, and it's your story – I just wrote this book. You might consider...

- Having a character **curl up and hide when all of their aspects are marked**, rather than burned.
- Having each character have one '**lucky escape**', and then suffering permanent death the next time they're in the same position.
- Ruling that fully burning an aspect **removes it from that bug forever**, so death isn't a concern, but loss of power and progress is.

Tips, Tricks, & General Advice

When tiny fists start flying and beastly fangs are bared, the situation may seem overwhelming at first. If that's the case, keep the following tips and tricks in mind...

Too Much Cut? Lower It!

Some of the hazards in this book have pretty hefty defences of their own, including the ability to impose multiple kinds of cut at once (such as a swift, iron-plated beast imposing both Speed and Armour Cut on actions taken to damage it).

But as bugs, you have *multiple* options open to you where lowering cut is concerned, and the Weaver has a couple of their own as well. You could...

Use **effects** to put a target into a state where its cut won't apply. That iron-plated beast? It's going to have a weak point somewhere, so use an effect to find it and then future attacks to focus on it.

Change your **approach** when you need to. Bugly heads are famously bad at smashing through brick walls, but a clever approach can deny an opponent certain kinds of cut even without an effect in play. If you're not sure, ask the Weaver for some cryptic advice!

Choose **aspects** carefully when progressing your character! Many of the aspects that make your bug unique have special rules that allow you to ignore cut in certain situations, or bypass some types of cut entirely.

Be **open with the Weaver** if a fight is too tough, or is dragging on. Page 208 has rules for kicking things up or down a notch, allowing the Weaver to adjust combat difficulty on the fly without bending the rules. It's a game - even the toughest fight shouldn't feel like a slog.

Create and Use POIs

Points of interest are there to make scenes more interactive, and to give players the chance to have their bug do things that wouldn't usually be possible. They're an excellent tactical tool, and clever use of a POI can change the course of a rumble completely.

Focus on a Hazard's Weaknesses

Once you've found a weakness, exploit it for a steady source of giga damage for as long as it lasts. Some aspects allow you to detect weaknesses in others, but common sense goes a long way too!

Work as a Team

The obvious application of teamwork in a rumble is to fill Combo Tracks (page 46) and get some big, solid hits in, but it goes far beyond that. Set up opportunities for your fellow bugs, and work to get them out of trouble where you can. Keeping a united front in a rumble can overcome just about anything.

Use Giga Impact!

Even a single instance of giga impact can dramatically change the course of a rumble and, in some cases, end it in an instant. It's not always easy to achieve, but with **Combo Tracks**, **weaknesses**, **points of interest**, **special aspects**, and **clever approaches**, your bugs are *far* stronger than they might first appear. Just because you're small, doesn't mean you're not mighty!

So... Are These Rules Just For Rumbles?

Well, it's funny you should ask that!

No.

While attacking, defending, taking damage, and inflicting effects work really well as a baseline for rumbles, they can also be thrown into any situation where they would be appropriate. Want to test your strength at a bugly carnival as part of a montage? The Weaver might ask you to treat it as an attack! A choice on a journey leads to worrying consequences? Well, that's probably going to deal some damage to one of your aspects.

And, similarly, not every action you take in a rumble is going to be to attack or defend, or will have the opportunity of marking a track.

Think of all these special rumble rules as useful **options for simulating dangerous, high-tension situations**.

The rules for other types of scenes, like the aforementioned montages and journeys, begin just a page-flip away.

CHAPTER 04:
PLAYING MONTAGES

TAKING SOME TIME

A montage is a **special type of scene**, a long period of time condensed down into a single moment in spotlight for each bug, a way of skipping over the boring (but necessary) bits and getting right back into scenes and journeys.

You might take a montage...

- Before you set out on a long journey
- When you get to a new settlement
- When you need to go shopping
- When you want to moult, and improve your bug
- When you're camping in the middle of a journey
- When you need to heal up after some tough times

TASKS

The long action you'll take during a montage is known as a task. It's just as freeform as a normal action - there are some special types, but most of the time you can pretty much describe what you're trying to achieve and, if it's difficult, dangerous, or dramatic, you'll have to roll.

MONTAGE RULES

There are a few special rules that apply to montages that mostly come into play when you're doing a specific type of task. We'll cover those over the next few pages.

The **most important rule** is just there to keep everyone equal - **in a montage, your bug can only take one task**.

FREEFORM TASKS

"They say a diamond is a piece of coal that stuck to the job. Unfortunately I don't know who 'they' are, or what a diamond is, or where I'd find coal. But it sounds good, right? Sounds really motivational."

When your group takes a montage, all bugs can perform a single task. Some of these tasks are defined - recovering, scrounging, and mysteryizing all have their own special rules and results shown over the next few pages. But there are *loads* of other tasks a character can take part in, from chatting with other bugs to get information to tending to a small beast, from wandering around the nearby environment to explore to poring over maps and charts to learn a little bit more about the world.

These **freeform tasks** usually give a benefit or outcome decided by the conversation, or the Weaver, and they only require a roll if they're **difficult, dangerous, or dramatic**.

GOING FREEFORM

Here are a few examples of what a freeform task might achieve when you're taking a montage...

» Carlosa wants to find more information on the problems this new settlement his crew have arrived at is facing, so he uses a task to wander off and find some kind of bounty board, or a knowledgeable NPC that can clue him in.

» Maka wants to get a better idea of their surroundings, so they use a task to climb up a nearby tree for a commanding view. This might make the next leg of their journey easier, or reveal a new landmark on the horizon.

» Elsbeth wants to hire a picotitan for an upcoming journey, so she spends her task searching for a nearby stable.

RECOVERING

Bugs are pretty good at bouncing back from various maladies, anything from a damaged scuttler to being partially eaten by a fox. They can rely on their natural healing, which is slow and steady, or get a bit of a bonus from medicine, repairwork, or hearty food, which gets a poorly bug back up and out into the world a lot faster, but with a bit more of a variance in efficacy.

NATURAL HEALING

Sometimes, slow and steady really does win the race. You can **use a task to sleep, which pulls your mood positive.** Alternatively, you can **use a task to heal, clearing one mark of damage on any of your aspect tracks** (part, tool, or buddy). This represents a lazy time in the sun, tinkering with your gear, or ministering to your even-tinier-than-you companion.

***Example**: Sasha took a couple of knocks in her last encounter, so she uses a task to recover. She clears a mark of damage from her shiny shell, buffing it until it's almost as good as new.*

HEALING IN SETTLEMENTS

If you're in a settlement, you can remove burns just as easily as marks (whether through natural healing or by rolling, as shown below). But burns can't usually be removed out on the road, or in the wilds.

ROLLING FOR RECOVERY

There's also the option of speeding the process **by using a bit (to heal a part or buddy) or a bob (to heal a tool)**. If you choose to consume a bit or bob, you can **use a task to roll on the table at the top right of this page** (the Care and Make skills might help out here). This is riskier - a bad roll might not have you heal at all, but a good roll can get you several hearts cleared at once. Luckily though, using the required bit or bob **does give advantage** on the roll!

***Example**: Pinto has a delicious bit of cucumber he's been saving in his bits and bobs slots, and he uses it to try to heal faster. He uses the Make skill to prepare it and rolls on the table, 2d6 for the skill and 1d6 for using the delicious bit. He gets a conflict with a bump, healing two marks at once.*

DOCTOR DOCTOR

You can also use a task to make this roll for another bug, if you're a doctoring type. You need that bug's permission though, and any benefits you roll apply to that bug rather than you.

RECOVERY ROLL RESULTS

6

TRIUMPH
You're feeling much better! Clear two marks of damage from one of your parts, gear, or buddies, **OR** clear one mark of damage and pull your mood to positive.

5
4

CONFLICT
It could have been better, but nothing went dramatically wrong. Clear one mark of damage from one of your parts, gear, or buddies, **OR** pull your mood to positive.

3
2
1

DISASTER
Which bit goes where again? Eh, at least I got to sit down. You don't clear any marks, but you do pull your mood to neutral.

doubles

TWIST or BUMP
You can treat a twist while recovering as normal, where something unexpected happens. Alternatively, you can add a bump to the healing, either clearing one more mark of damage from any part, gear, or buddy (even if it wasn't the target of the Recovery Roll), or pulling your mood another step toward positive.

- RECOVERY EXAMPLE -

Bicco: Well, I feel great! A bit banged up, but still great!

GM: You did really well there actually.

Dunf: Yeah, but you probably need a bit of a patch-up.

Bicco: That I do. I'll use a task this montage for natural healing, and clear a mark.

Swift: Hey, let me help you out there too - I'm going to roll Care and use some of this Witch Hazel we picked up... a triumph! Do you want to clear two marks, or clear one mark and improve your mood?

Bicco: I'm already pretty happy, so I'll take both of those clears instead. With that two, and the one from my natural healing, my Scuttlers are back up to full strength! Excellent job Swift, thank you.

Swift: Hey, you really came through for us in that last rumble. You deserve it.

SCROUNGING

"Just remember what Mary used to say, before that unfortunate umbrella-related accident - a spoonful of sugar is extremely hard to carry, even if you've got particularly large pockets."

Bits and bobs are easy to come by if you know where to look, but the *right* bits and bobs might be tougher to find in a pinch. Using a task to go scrounging for resources might cover rustling around in nearby grass, fishing in a pond, ransacking cupboards, or visiting market-stall traders, and the fact that you're taking your time to do it actually makes it a little more reliable than gathering during a scene.

WHAT DO YOU WANT?

When scrounging for something, the first thing you do is **state what *kind* of thing you're looking for** - for example, 'something spicy', 'something sweet', or 'something hard'. If what you're looking for is easily found, you'll likely get it without needing to roll **just by using a task**. You'll still need some empty carry slots to put the resulting find in though, so don't just go hunting for stuff that you don't have room to carry (though you could always give it to another bug in your band to hold onto in a pinch).

***Example**: Clay, a chefly bug, wants a new ingredient. She's looking around a pantry and states that she wants something sticky. The Weaver informs her that there's honey there, and that she can take a glob if she likes. She does, and adds this to one of her carry slots.*

There's no approved list you need to pick from when specifying the kind of thing you're after, but be warned - **if you make your request too narrow, you're almost definitely going to have to roll thanks to the difficulty**. It's possible, for example, to look for 'something diamondy', but how likely are you to actually find that? *Unless you're in some kind of abandoned jewelry store, in which case looking for 'something diamondy' is actually oddly appropriate.*

ROLLING TO SCROUNGE

If there's an element of **danger, drama, or difficulty** to an attempt to scrounge, **it will likely require a roll**. If this is the case, the table on the right of this page has a special spread of results related specifically to the gathering of bits and bobs. The 'finding' skills may all be useful here, but other skills could also be used depending on the situation.

***Example**: Pinto wants to grab some cucumber from a farmer's field, but there's a wide gulf between the sweet treats and the safety of the hedgerow Pinto is currently hiding in. He might roll with Sense or Hunt to represent finding the best cucumbers, or with Slink or Dash to try to cover the ground quickly and get back with his prize in relative safety.*

TRADING

Another way of getting new bits and bobs without having to roll is to trade them, exchanging an existing bit or bob for something new. This might be difficult in the wilds, without other friendly mercantile sorts around, but should be easy enough in a settlement. To keep things simple, trades are (by default) give one thing and get one thing back.

SCROUNGE ROLL RESULTS

6

TRIUMPH

Well, would you look at that! You find exactly what you were looking for, a bit or bob that relates directly to your stated wants.

5
4

CONFLICT

Hey, I can probably use this! You find something close to, but not exactly, what you want, **OR** you find exactly what you want, but it has a negative tag chosen by the Weaver.

3
2
1

DISASTER

I'm going to pretend to know what this is. You find a bit or bob, but it's nothing to do with what you were looking for, and might even be the complete opposite.

doubles

TWIST or ADD TAG

You can treat a twist while scrounging as normal, where something unexpected happens. Alternatively, you can add a positive tag to whatever bit or bob you find.

SCROUNGE OR GATHER?

Scrounging is a lot like gathering (found on page 52) in that it gives a bug a nice new bit or bob if it goes well, but there is an important difference. When scrounging, you don't have a clear idea of what you want - just a notion of the **kind of thing** it might be. When gathering, you have a precise goal in mind; you want that thing right there.

Both are useful in different situations, but scrounging gives the Weaver more freedom to supply you with something unexpected.

- SCROUNGE EXAMPLE -

Layla: I've got a lot of empty carry slots at the moment, so I should probably get out there and find more stuff for the future. You can do that with a task, right?

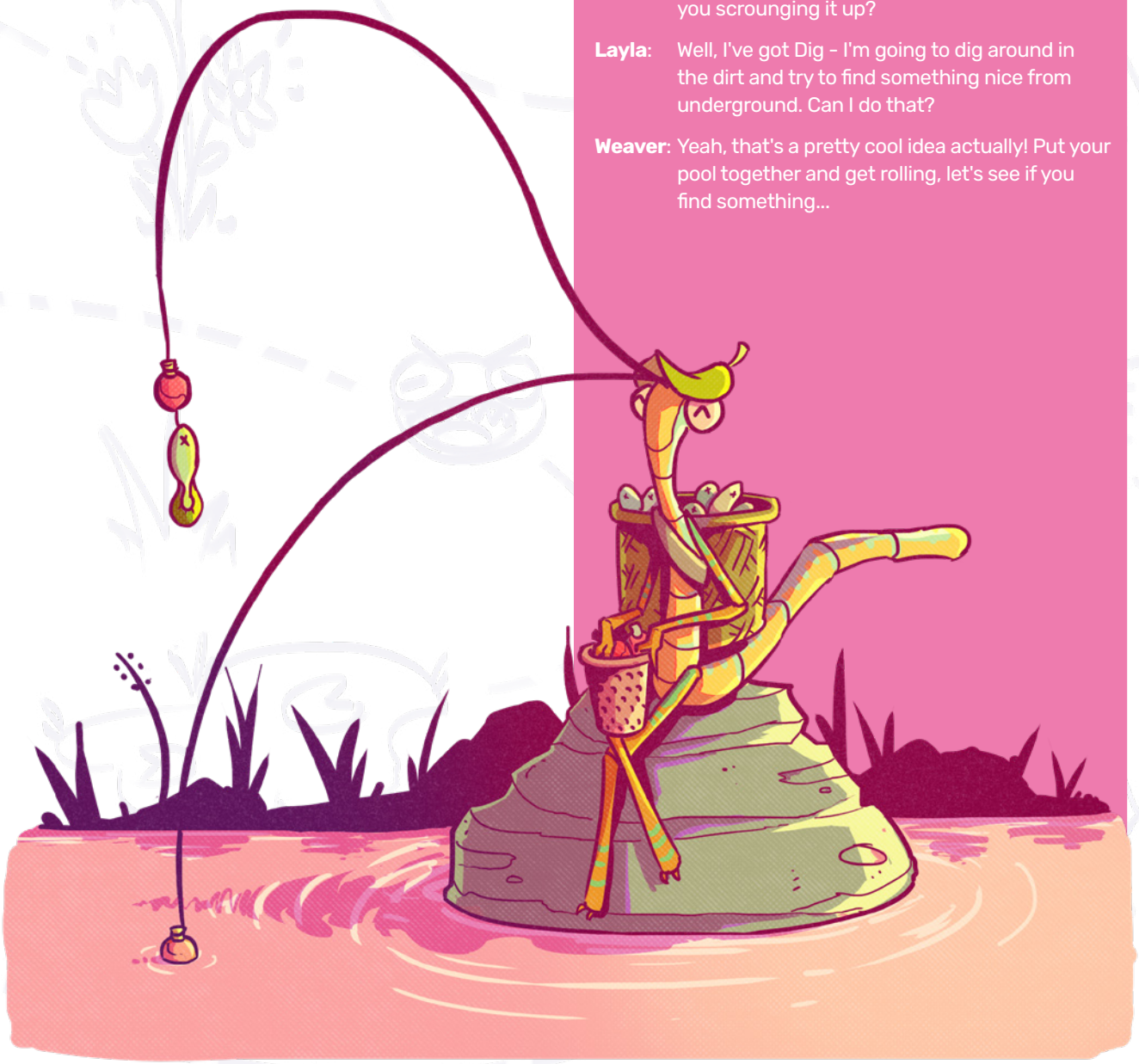
Weaver: You can indeed! What kind of thing are you looking for? If it's something that's really common around here, you might not roll.

Layla: Something... Hmm, soothing, I think.

Weaver: Okay, that one's going to need a roll! How are you scrounging it up?

Layla: Well, I've got Dig - I'm going to dig around in the dirt and try to find something nice from underground. Can I do that?

Weaver: Yeah, that's a pretty cool idea actually! Put your pool together and get rolling, let's see if you find something...



Mysteryizing

Some mysteries are just too juicy to be left alone! A bug can use a task to go searching for something that might be relevant to the mystery they're currently investigating, hoping to make a small discovery that brings them closer to the truth.

Looking For A Sign

While slowly uncovering mysteries happens naturally through play (usually during scenes and journeys), mysteryizing during a montage helps speed up this process dramatically. Because of this, mysteryizing in this way **always requires a roll**, and **uses a task**.

It's up to the Weaver to supply the situation or moment that helps a bug get closer to solving their mystery, but it's up to the player to interpret it and draw whatever conclusions they wish - solving mysteries is a personal endeavour, after all. *The Weaver might have to check the bug's current mystery before they give the situation, and that's fine too.*

Rolling For Mysteryizing

The table on the right shows specific results for mysteryizing during a montage. Because solving mysteries doesn't usually require a roll, the skill used to aid the roll should suit the situation presented by the Weaver - it might be Think, for considering what's seen, one of the moving skills for finding whatever might be revealing, or even a friending skill to have a companion of NPC drop a hint that leads to a small discovery.

***Example**: Leroy has a mystery they want to solve, and they have a montage where no other jobs are pressing. They decide to mysteryize, and the Weaver informs them that a nearby artist has some pictures on display that might spark their interest. They roll with Rummage to sort through all of the pictures until they find one that speaks to them, but they could also have used Sense or Think to consider the contents of the art and how it might reveal something about their mystery.*

- Mysteryize Example -

Dunf: Well, I've still got one task left, and I'm going to get deep with it. I'm going to mysteryize!

Weaver: Okay, tell me more! You solved your cats question, what mystery are you chasing now?

Dunf: Why is the grass green?

Weaver: Ooh, nice! Well, there's no grass around, but there is a glint in the near distance - a shiny green bottle, sticking up out of the sands.

Dunf: I'm going to roll for that then, and I'm using Sense - I'm looking at the play of light coming through the bottle, seeing if it goes in yellow from the sun and comes out green from the glass. Maybe that's what happens...

Weaver: Okay, make your roll and tell us what you find out!

Mysteryize Roll Results

6 — **Triumph**
A revelation! You find something that spurs a small discovery for you that relates to your current mystery, and can immediately announce that small discovery.

5, 4 — **Conflict**
A revelation, but not for me! You find something that doesn't speak to you, but it might well speak to one of your allies. Another bug in your crew can make a small discovery based on what you find, if they wish.

3, 2, 1 — **Disaster**
A false alarm. You thought there might be something there, but there's not - you don't make any small discoveries, and neither do your allies.

doubles — **Twist or Rabbit Hole**
You can treat a twist while mysteryizing as normal, where something unexpected happens. Alternatively, you can choose to go down the rabbit hole, allowing the Weaver to announce a sudden small new truth about the world that your own bug has just realized.

"There are far more questions in this world than there are answers, that's just a fact. But what I've found in my travels is that most questions don't actually NEED an answer. And, if you ignore all of those, the scales almost balance out."

Rexi Makismo, Introspective Scorpion Adventurer

Cooking

*"A few mushrooms, a dash of pepper, a strip of cured badger, and a garnish of tooth-onions. Now **that's** a dish."*

Nothing beats a home-cooked meal. Luckily for adventuring bugs, a campfire feast is a close second.

When a bug uses a task to cook, they consume **two (or more) bits** with a roll of the dice to create a **meal**, a special consumable that offers one of the following benefits when a bug decides to eat it...

- **Temporary Resistance:** Gives a bug **resistance to a particular damage type** related to the ingredients used, which halves the damage they take from that type (rounded down), as detailed on page 63. An excellent momentary defence!
- **Temporary Skillification:** Gives a bug **+1 rank to a particular skill** related to the ingredients used. This can't take a skill above rank 3, but it's great for accessing skills a bug wouldn't normally have or giving their current spread a bit of a bonus. You'll find the skills overview on page 144.
- **Temporary Undercut:** Gives a bug the ability to **reduce the amount of a particular type of cut by one**, related to the ingredients used (either Armour Cut, Speed Cut, Camo Cut, or Complex Cut, as described on page 38). A meal can't reduce the amount of Tough Cut a bug faces though, and this reduction doesn't apply to cut a bug chooses to take - only cut that's imposed by the Weaver.

Choosing Benefits

The effects of a meal or portion should have something to do with the bits used as ingredients. Look at the tags a bit has, or think about their flavour and properties - maybe a spicy soup would give resistance to Sizzle, or a medley of scramble-mushrooms allow a bug to reduce Speed Cut. *Work with the Weaver if you're not sure what effects might be suitable.*

Rolling To Cook

A lot can go wrong during meal prep - because of this, cooking **always requires a roll**, and **uses a task**. *The Make and Care skills will likely be useful here.*

You can use the table on the right to find out what results a meal will have once cooked, but there's another important question to answer - *who gets to eat what you make?*

Meals & Portions

A meal made with two bits is enough for one bug, but **for every bit past the initial two** that you add, you **gain an extra portion of that meal with exactly the same benefits**.

Once the Cook Roll has been made, you decide who gets a portion of the resulting meal - maximum one per bug! *Meals/Portions are added to the Creations section on the Character Sheet.*

Cook Roll Results

6 — Triumph
A culinary masterpiece! Choose either a temporary resistance, skillification, or undercut. A portion of this meal grants this benefit on all relevant actions and reactions **for the rest of the scene** in which a bug consumes it.

5, 4 — Conflict
Useful and edible! Choose either a temporary resistance, skillification, or undercut. A portion of this meal grants this benefit **on the next action or reaction** it would affect within the scene a bug consumes it.

3, 2, 1 — Disaster
Should have used a recipe. The resulting meal is edible, technically, but it doesn't give any benefits when consumed.

doubles — Twist or Depth
You can treat a twist while cooking as normal, where something unexpected happens. Alternatively, you can add a depth of flavour that even a master chef would be proud of - with a conflict or triumph, choose an additional temporary resistance, skillification or undercut for portions of this meal to grant when consumed, **OR have each pull mood positive when consumed**.

- Cook Example -

Layla: You know, it's been a while since we had a good meal. Bicco, would you be up for cooking us something during this montage? I can give you a few ingredients if that helps, I've got bits to spare.

Bicco: Oh yeah, I can do that! What would be useful for us in terms of effects?

Dunf: Well, we are about to tackle that cactus, and climbing isn't really my specialty. Maybe something that gives us all a rank of Climb?

Layla: I've actually got a bit that seems relevant too, Creeping Vines. They're good at climbing. For plants, I mean.

Swift: And I've got this Non-Equine Glue from the museum we escaped last week. That's a sort of ingredient, right?

Weaver: Might not taste great, but definitely edible.

Bicco: Yeah, both of those sound great. And all we need to do is bulk that meal out with a few more bits so we have enough portions for everybody.

Swift: I'm actually a pretty good climber - I've already got 3 ranks in it, so I won't need a portion. But it'll be great to have you guys climbing alongside me rather than lagging behind me for once, so I say go for it!

CRAFTING

"My new invention is guaranteed to fail, but what a spectacular failure it's going to be!"

Crafting follows the same kind of structure as cooking, but with a very different outcome. When crafting, a bug consumes two (or more) **bobs** with a roll of the dice to create a **contraption**, a temporary creation that mimics the benefits and drawbacks of an aspect the user wouldn't normally have access to.

A contraption can mimic any aspect from the aspects section of this book - parts, gear, or buddies, all can be mimicked by some temporary mechanical marvel if the right bobs are combined.

CHOOSING AN ASPECT

The aspect a contraption mimics is up to the inventor, but it should have something to do with the bobs used as components. Think about the physical properties of your bobs, and what they might be repurposed to do - an alligator clip might serve to help create the Mandibles part from page 108, or a bolt of fabric help to make some Dronewings from page 124. *Work with the Weaver and the rest of the table if you're not sure what aspects might be craftable with the bobs you have to hand.*

ROLLING TO CRAFT

Tinkering with bobs is rarely a smooth process - because of this, crafting **always requires a roll**, and **uses a task**. *The Make, Think, and Rummage skills will likely be useful here.*

The table below and to the right shows what results an invention will have once pieced together, but there's another important question to answer - *which lucky bug gets to be a test subject once the contraption is up and running?*

- CRAFTING EXAMPLE -

Swift: So climbing that cactus went surprisingly well, but we need to get up to the sprinkler system now. And that's... well, that's quite a jump. Anyone really, *really* good with the Dash skill?

Bicco: Not me, and none of us are confident flyers either... We probably should have planned a little better for this.

Dunf: Planning? Ha! Who needs planning when you've got me? Weaver, I'm going to put a contraption together - something to mimic a pair of wings, with copies for everyone.

Weaver: Well, I... I don't want to dampen that enthusiasm, but are you any good at crafting?

Dunf: I picked up a rank of Make last time I moulted, and I've got a few bobs that might be able to act as wings in a pinch. I think it's worth a go!

Layla: Dunf, I believe in you. Let's see what contraption you come up with.

Weaver: That's a really positive attitude, Layla.

Layla: Yeah, I think I hid my terror well. Let's do this!

CRAFT ROLL RESULTS

6 — **TRIUMPH**
A singular work! Choose one aspect to mimic. A prototype gives a copy of this aspect that works from the first time it's used for a benefit of some kind **until the end of that scene**.

5 4 — **CONFLICT**
Serviceable! Choose one aspect to mimic. A prototype gives a copy of this aspect that works... **once**, and then falls apart.

3 2 1 — **DISASTER**
Great advances require great failures from time to time. Your bobs are ruined and you gain nothing from the process.

doubles — **TWIST or AUGMENT**
You can treat a twist while crafting as normal, where something unexpected happens. Alternatively (alongside a conflict or triumph), you can add an augment to your mimicked aspect, giving it an extra benefit taken from any of the augments listed in chapter 6.

CONTRAPTIONS & COPIES

A contraption made with two bobs is enough for one bug to use, but adding more bobs to the crafting process allows you to make additional copies to hand out to your (probably quite nervous) comrades.

Crafting with **two bobs** gives you **one copy** of the resulting contraption. **For every bob past the initial two** that you add, you **gain an extra copy**. Once the Craft Roll has been made, you decide who gets a copy of your contraption to use! *A bug can only hold one contraption at a time, and contraptions are added to the Creations section on the Character Sheet. They can even be used to give 1d6 to the aspect section of an Action Roll!*

WHERE ARE ALL THE TRACKS?

Contraptions differ in one important way from the aspects they mimic - **they don't have tracks**. If a bug's contraption needs to be marked or burned in order to give a benefit, **it works once and then immediately falls apart**. Same goes for if a bug wants to use it to absorb damage - it'll eat one hit of any size without harming the bug holding it, and then collapse into unusable pieces.

Naturally this means that some aspects work better as contraptions than others. We recommend experimenting as you play to find which work for you and your bugly allies. And who knows, if a bug likes a contraption enough, they might even grab a permanent version from the aspects chapter when they next moult!

MOULTING

"It's a new dawn, it's a new day, I'm a new bug... And I'm feeling good!"

A very special task that only becomes useful for longer-term play, moulting allows a bug to **ingest some of the Nectar they've found** (PICO's character creation and advancement resource), spin a little cocoon around themselves, and then **emerge at the end of the task with a shiny new feature to show off**! They might come out with new skill ranks, or a new aspect, or an extra augment on one of their existing aspects. Isn't nature wonderful?

There are no dice rolls to make while moulting, and there's no risk of failure – it's a 'good stuff only' kind of situation.

WHEN TO MOULT?

There are three criteria you need to meet in order to moult, which we'll run through below.

» **1: You need a safe space**. Most montages are taken in reasonably safe locations, but not all – if you're using a montage to explore some kind of hostile territory, splitting up and leaving one bug behind to moult is a pretty terrible idea. There are some situations, like when you're camping during a journey, that might have a potential element of danger to them. Moulting here is fine, and even if your camp is raided by bugbarians, the fiction should assume that the moulting bug completes the process just as they arrive. They might be a little groggy, but they'll be fine.

» **2: You need enough Nectar to afford a character advancement.** Moulting essentially allows you to purchase new ranks in a skill, or a new aspect or augment, mid-game. You'll find the cost for these different types of advancement both on page 102 (which also tells you more about Nectar) and on the very next page, at the top left. But if you haven't accrued enough Nectar to choose one of those options as you moult, you can't even spin the cocoon to start the process.

» **3: You need to know what you want.** This is a simple but important rule: moulting shouldn't slow the game down more than any other task. Don't choose to moult and then leaf through the book, deciding which options might appeal – that'll be boring for everybody. A better way is to plan out roughly what you're going to take in advance, so that when you get the chance to moult you can add it to your Character Sheet as the other bugs in your band perform their own tasks.

"They say a good night's sleep cures just about anything, but I'm not so sure. I went to bed with a headache, and woke up with an entirely new set of wings. Still got the headache, too."

Irrigo Samson, Moth Mathematician

ADVANCEMENT COSTS AND OPTIONS

When you moult, you'll have the chance of purchasing a skill rank, an aspect, or an augment. *You'll find more information on each of these character features starting on page 100.*

The costs, in Nectar, are as follows...

- Add an **Aspect**: 3 Nectar
- Add an **Augment**: 2 Nectar
- Increase a **Skill Rank**: Nectar equal to the rank you're attaining (with a rank 1 skill costing 1 Nectar, an upgrade from rank 1 to rank 2 costing 2 Nectar, and an upgrade from rank 2 to rank 3 costing 3 Nectar).

If you have a *lot* of Nectar to spend, **you can choose multiple options at the same time**, but you **can't choose the same option multiple times during one moult** (so you can increase one skill rank, add one aspect, and add one augment with a single task).

- MOULTING EXAMPLE -

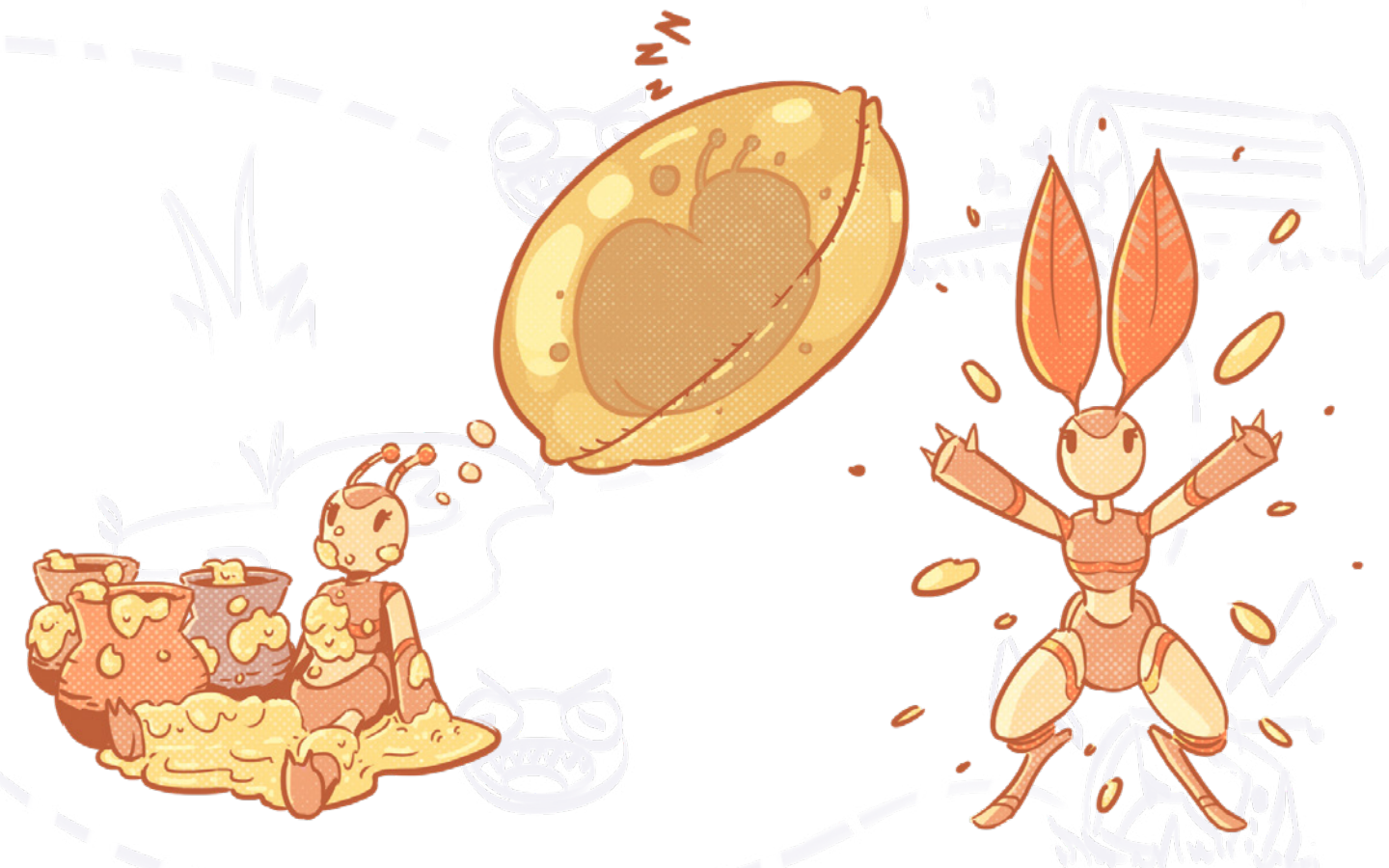
Bicco: You know, I've had enough Nectar to grab an aspect for a while now, and it's time to take the plunge - I'm going to moult for this montage.

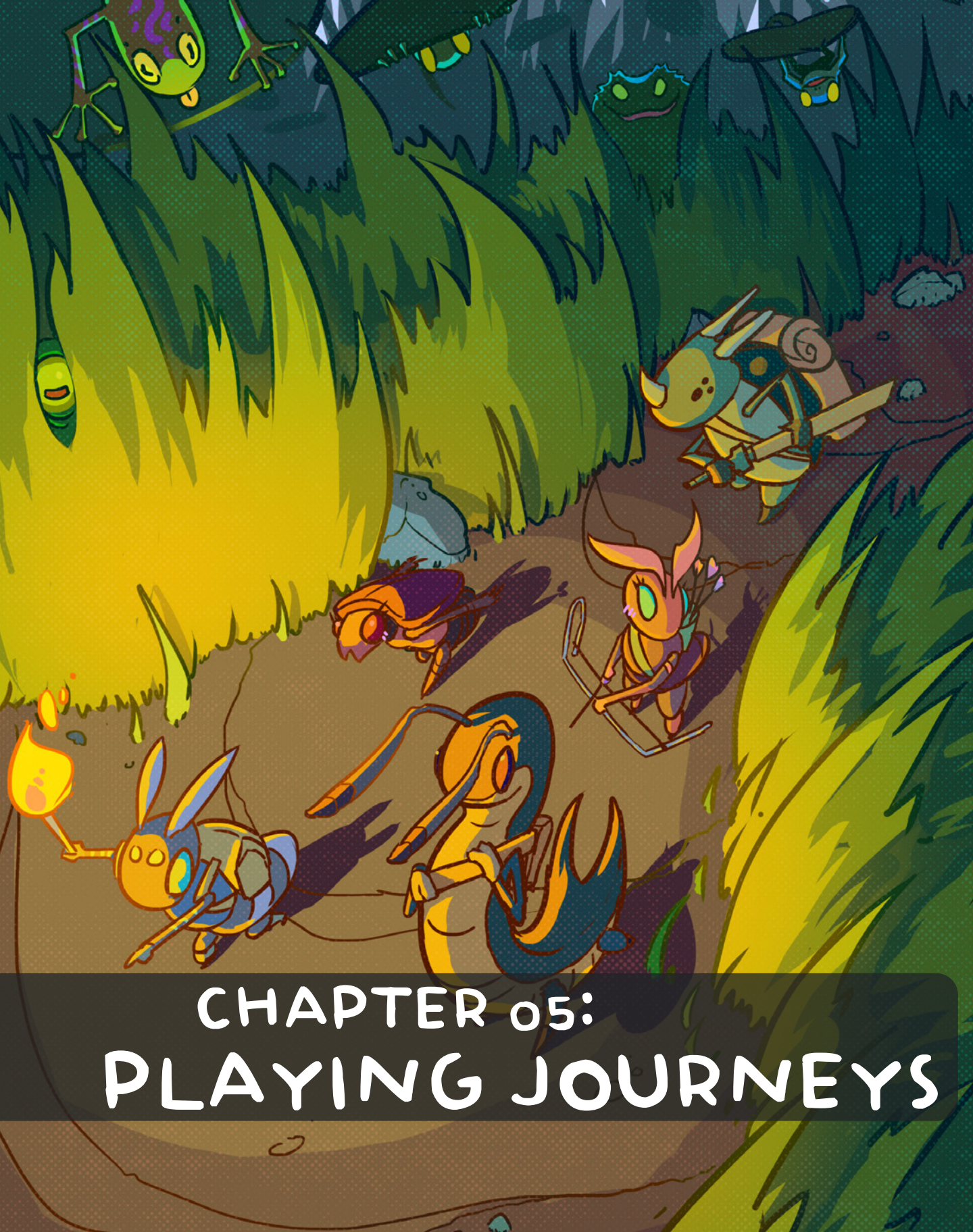
Layla: Oh wow! I can't wait to see what you pick.

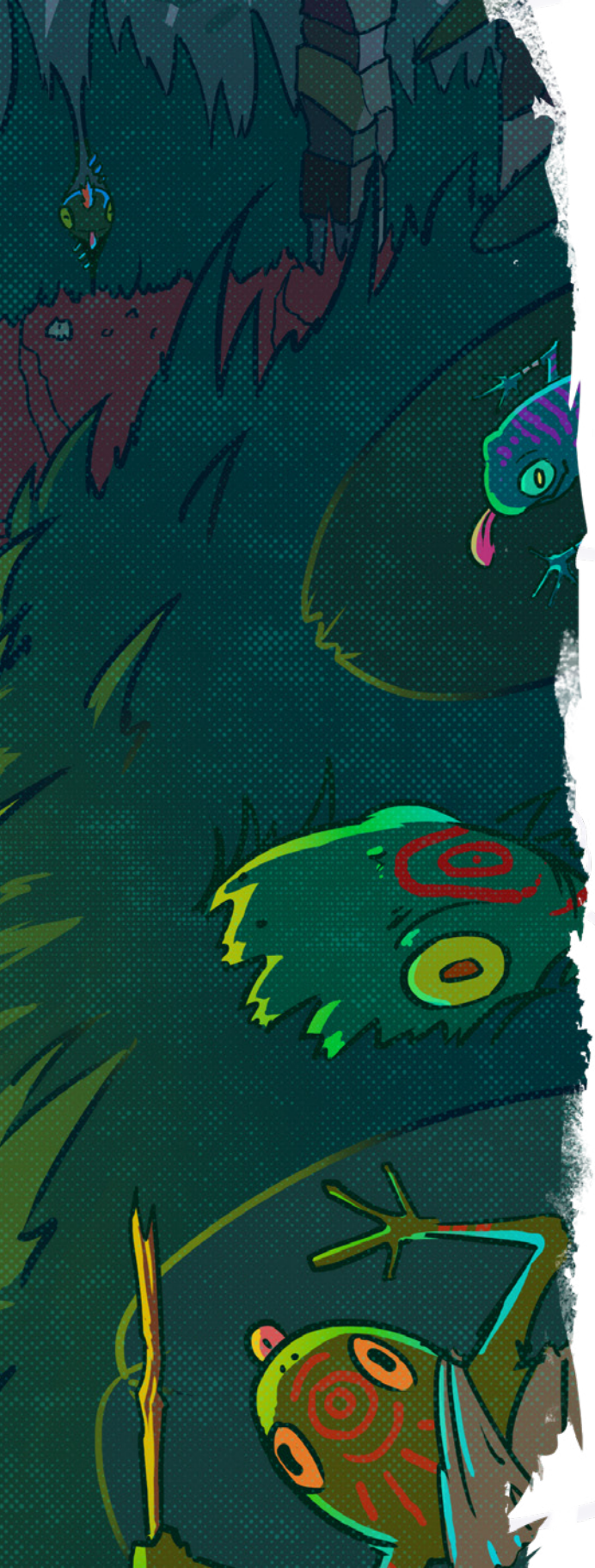
Weaver: Same here! Bicco, describe the start of the process and we'll come back to you when everyone else has taken their tasks.

Bicco: Gotcha. While Layla stokes the fire and Dunf does... Well, whatever it is that Dunf does, I'm going to quietly curl up in the warm and chow down on some Nectar. Soon it's like I'm wrapping myself up in a blanket of silk, snuggling up in the warmth and dreaming of what I'm going to be...

Layla: Aww!




CHAPTER 05:
PLAYING JOURNEYS



GET OUT & SEE THE WORLD

A journey is a **special type of scene** that lets bugs travel from one location to another. You don't need to use a journey if the band are just walking down the road, or going from one bugly house to a nearby park - that kind of tiny jaunt can happen completely off camera, smoothed over with a single line of description from the Weaver.

No, journeys are there for the big ones - the dangerous road from settlement to settlement, the search for a dungeon in the distant, dense forest, or the hunt for a predator the bugs have sworn to bring to justice.

JOURNEY RULES

Like montages, journeys run on different rules than typical moment-to-moment play. Time and Distance are suddenly important (though are still measured loosely, so as not to burden the Weaver with too much book-keeping). **Picotitans** also have a huge impact on play here, with even the newest picotitan speeding progress through a journey significantly. *You'll find a full chapter on picotitans starting on page 171.*

ROLES

There are certain times during a journey that players will be asked to decide which bug is taking on a specific role, which usually requires making a decision that will affect the entire band.

We recommend assigning roles as a group to whoever is happy to take them in that moment. You could also leave it up to the Weaver to decide, or have a system of 'I did it last time so I'm choosing you to do it this time'. Whatever works for your table is fine, but every now and then a player's bug will have a benefit or two, or a skill, that make them more suited to a particular role.

And if you've got strengths, why not play to them?

LIGHT & WEATHER

With the time-based mechanics that journeys introduce, light level and current weather come into play (and may persist into other scenes taken as part of, or after, a journey). *You'll find rules on light and weather at the end of this chapter.*

THE BASICS OF TRAVEL

The fear of being far from home, balanced with the excitement of the new? That's just bread and butter to a bug.

Bugs band together in small groups when they travel, setting off from one place and crossing the big, dangerous world with a specific destination in mind (usually, anyway - there's value to wandering about the place aimlessly from time to time).

Some of them do it on foot, covering huge distances at a quick march and stopping to camp when they're tired, grilling tasty bits over an open fire as they tell stories with their friends. Others take the faster route, buying or raising a picotitan to travel on - a huge but helpful creature that's strong enough to carry a little bug house on its back, the height of mobile luxury.

Travel works pretty much the same way whether you're using a picotitan or not, in terms of mechanics. But, as a rule, travelling with a titan is faster and safer than going it alone.

WHY GO ON JOURNEYS?

For some bugs, staying within the safe walls of a settlement is the most sensible course of action - they're not adventuring types, after all. They want a quiet life with the comfort of home, and maybe a tiny mug of cocoa at the end of each day.

But those aren't the kind of bugs that PICO helps you tell stories about.

The bugs you're playing as are adventuresome types - they might still be afraid of the wider world, but they're willing to face that fear and get out there, to see sights and smell smells that others could only dream of.

They're the *cool* ones, essentially.

As an adventuresome bug, you might undertake a journey to...

- Discover a new place
- Escape the routine
- Aid your home community
- Solve a grand mystery
- Discover an exciting new thing to eat
- Challenge yourself
- Help those in need
- Find cool stuff
- Bond with your picotitan

Journeys in PICO usually need a **destination** - a physical place you're heading to - but sometimes, venturing out on a journey with nothing but a nebulous goal in mind is fine. I guess you'll just keep going until you find what you want!

TIME & DISTANCE

These are the two most important components of a journey in PICO - the **distance** you cover, and the **time** it takes to cover it. The Weaver keeps a watch over both of these, but you should probably know how they work as a player too - they are tracked out on the table for everyone to see (usually, anyway).

STRIDES

Distance is measured in **strides**, an arcane length that's difficult to precisely judge for the average bug, but works well when you're guessing, giving vague directions, and telling tall tales.

At the start of any journey, the Weaver will set a **Journey Track**, a set of linked boxes representing distance. **One box on this track is the length of a stride**, and when bugs get a wiggle on and make progress, these boxes are marked. **When all boxes are marked, the journey is over** - you've covered enough strides to reach your destination!

The Weaver decides the length of a Journey Track by choosing how many boxes to add - the longer the track, the more strides you'll have to cover, the further away your destination is! Because they're tracked out in the open, most of the time the Weaver should also give them a name (usually based on where you're journeying to).

Here's an example of a Journey Track where the bugs have covered three strides so far...

TICKS

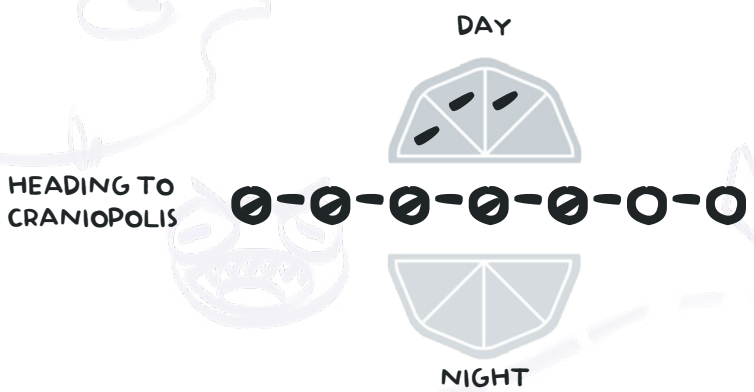
Time is measured in ticks, which would be wonderfully accurate if bugs carried pocket watches around.

They don't.

Each day in PICO is split up into eight ticks, **four of them taking place during the day and four of them taking place during the night**. At the start of a journey, once they've set the journey track, the Weaver will also set a **ticking clock** - a physical representation of passing time shown by a half-circle above the Journey Track, and another half-circle below. **The segments of these half-circles are marked clockwise as time passes, one for each tick**, just like the face of a very scribbled-upon clock.

Every in-game sunrise, the marks on the ticking clock are erased and **a new day begins**. Some benefits and special abilities are stronger during light or darkness, and some things can only happen once per day!

So here's that same Journey Track from above, but with the ticking clock added. Now the bugs are five strides along their journey, and we can tell by the ticking clock that they're in daylight - mid afternoon, to be exact.



TICKING CLOCKS & MAKING STRIDES

Ah, the open road.

Once the Weaver has set your Journey Track and ticking clock, it's time to start making some progress!

Your band of bugs, whether astride a picotitan or moving on foot, makes progress as a group - heading off solo in a world of predators is hardly the wisest idea, after all! But groups can get a little messy when everyone wants to take charge, so PICO requires the group to assign a special role at the beginning of a journey - the **leader**.

THE LEADER

When you're chosen as the leader, the power is in your hands! It's your job to decide on the **travel actions** your band of bugs takes throughout the journey, setting the pace and deciding when it's time to rest. *A group might decide that a journey has one leader for the duration, or that the leader changes every time they make camp, or even that the leader changes after the current leader chooses a single travel action, so everyone gets a turn at the head of the band. We recommend discussing how you're choosing the leader, and how often that role changes hands, before you play.*

ONCE YOU HAVE A LEADER...

Then they can choose a **travel action, from the list on the right.**

Each travel action takes **a certain amount of time** (measured in ticks) and covers **a certain amount of distance** (measured in strides).

- **For every stride it covers, mark a box on the Journey Track.**
- **For every tick it takes, mark the ticking clock.**

Some of these travel actions are focused on movement, getting you to your destination as quickly, or as safely, as possible. Others are based around rest and relaxation, offering you a bit of a break from the constant movement and letting time slip by.

EVERYBODY ELSE

So what does everybody else do while the leader is setting the pace? Well, they're all **on the lookout** - keeping their eyes open (if they have eyes, of course) for any interesting things the band might encounter during a particular leg of the journey. *We'll learn more about Lookout Rolls, and surprise, on pages 88 to 91.*

TRAVEL ACTIONS

RAMBLE

Your group advances at a gentle pace, taking in the surroundings as you do.
Lookout Rolls: Yes
Surprise!: No
Distance Covered: 1 stride
Time Taken: 1 tick

MARCH

You move swiftly and seriously, making good progress in a surprisingly short amount of time.
Lookout Rolls: Yes
Surprise!: Yes
Distance Covered: 2 strides
Time Taken: 1 tick

WAIT

You stay in one place, and you stay alert.
Lookout Rolls: Yes
Surprise!: No
Distance Covered: None
Time Taken: 1 tick

CAMP

Your group takes a breather and sets up camp, starting a **montage** (details found starting page 69). All bugs can spend a task as normal during this montage, or any number of bugs can choose to spend their task being *on the lookout*. If there are no bugs on the lookout, you'll get surprised by any visitors or events. If there are bugs on the lookout, you won't be surprised.
Lookout Rolls: Maybe
Surprise!: Maybe
Distance Covered: None
Time Taken: 2 ticks

Making Progress

Rambling and marching both allow your little band of bugs to make headway on a journey, trading some time and effort for marks on the Progress Track.

But which should you use? That depends very much on the situation, and the experience you want from your journey.

Rambling is the safest way to make progress, but it isn't exactly fast. You'll be covering one stride at a time; great for spotting oddities and opportunities along the way, not so great if you're on a time crunch of some kind. The biggest benefit of rambling is the ability to choose how (or even if) you engage with what you encounter, a reward for taking it slow.

Marching is the opposite of rambling, in that you move with speed but pay for it with an increase in danger. Covering two strides at a time gets you to your destination faster, and also means you'll have fewer encounters along the way. Unfortunately, the pace you keep means that some of those encounters you'll likely blunder right into the middle of, as you'll have no time to prepare in advance or skirt round the edge of whatever is happening. *This is covered more on page 91, under the **Surprise!** heading - but you'll need to learn about Lookout Rolls first, on the next page.*

- Travel Actions Example -

Weaver: The interior of the Shadow House is dark and cool, almost perpetually so. You can see your objective in the distance, the door to the kitchen, but it's going to be a long road. I'm setting the Journey Track at 8 boxes.

Layla: Oof, that's quite a trek. We'd better make a move, especially if we want to get there by tomorrow's dawn. Who's going to lead us here?

Dunf: Ooh, not me! I want to keep my eyes on the surroundings, I like it here.

Swift: I'll take the lead if nobody objects.

Weaver: Doesn't look like they do! Alright Swift, you're at the head of the band - what pace are you setting here?

Swift: There's a temptation to march - we do want to get to the kitchen door by a certain time, after all - but we'll start off a little slower. Ramble, I think, in the interests of not being surprised.

Weaver: Ramble it is! I'm marking one stride on the Journey Track and a segment of the ticking clock. Everybody else, get your dice ready for some Lookout Rolls!

Travel By Titan

Journeys are where Picotitans *shine*.

If your band of bugs has access to a **friendly picotitan**, crossing vast distances is both quicker and safer. The creature itself can move faster across terrain than even the swiftest bugs (even if that's simply due to a disparity in size and stride-length), and if you've got a **titan-den** built onto their back that gives you a solid, safe place to camp out when it's time to rest or sleep. Some picotitans even have special benefits that make travel even easier!

We'll save most of the specifics for the Picotitan chapter, starting on page 171, but there are two rules that are important for right now...

Picotitans are Fast!

Riding a picotitan lets bugs cover ground at an impressive clip. **When choosing a Ramble or March travel action**, the leader can decide whether your band rides the picotitan or not. If you do, you can...

» Increase the amount of strides a **Ramble** covers to **2**

» Increase the amount of strides a **March** covers to **4**

What does this mean? Journeys go quicker, and with fewer interruptions - simple as!

Titan-Dens are Safe!

What better to ensure a good rest than a soft bed on the back of a friendly titan? **When choosing a Wait or Camp travel action**, the leader can decide whether your band uses a picotitan's titan-den. If you do, you can...

» Ensure that you **can't be surprised** by an event or hazard, **as your picotitan will notice and warn you**

What does this mean? Basically that you don't have to have a bug assigned as a lookout to prevent being surprised.

ON THE LOOKOUT

What, you thought the leader was going to get all the fun?

When you're rambling, marching, or waiting during a journey, every bug that isn't the leader is **on the lookout**. This means they're keeping their eyes open for anything that might be useful, interesting, or potentially dangerous - it's how you find friends, foes, and happenstances while journeying through the world of PICO. Mechanically, bugs that are on the lookout each get to make a **Lookout Roll** when the leader chooses the ramble, march, or wait travel actions for the group.

***Example**: Kale, Inigo, and Melody are three bugs journeying through the rough terrain of the Hogwild. Kale takes the position of leader, so he makes the decisions as to whether they ramble, march, wait, or camp. Inigo and Melody are then on the lookout as they all travel, so it's up to them to keep watch as they move. When Kale chooses to move them into a march so they get to their destination a little quicker, Inigo and Melody both make a Lookout Roll to see what they encounter along the way.*

Lookout Rolls are automatically taken whenever a band of bugs rambles, marches, or waits. If you're taking the camp action on a journey, a bug can spend a task to go on the lookout (which allows them to make a roll), but it's not mandatory. Think of going on the lookout while camping as going on watch, letting others busy themselves with personal stuff while you keep your eyes open for danger.

LOOKOUT ROLLS

Each bug that goes on the lookout gets to **roll 2d6 - the Lookout Roll**. The results of this roll determine what that bug notices as their band moves or rests.

- **If the results of this roll are two different numbers, you haven't spotted anything**. Not anything worth talking about, anyway - you may see some cute scenery or drifting clouds, but nothing worth more than some idle chatter. But...
- **If the results of this roll are doubles, of any value, you've spotted something interesting!** You can check the table on the right to find out exactly what you've managed to see, but it'll likely lead to an **encounter** or **choice** (you'll find details on page 90).

Remember, Lookout Rolls are always taken by every other bug when a leader chooses the **ramble**, **march**, or **wait** travel actions, but are optional during a **camp** action (requiring a camper to spend their montage task).

SPECIAL SENSES

Some bugs are better at Lookout Rolls than others, rolling additional die or gleaning extra information with certain results. A few can even take additional actions when they're on the lookout, like snaffling down a bit for some healing without it distracting them from their surroundings. But remember, even if your bug is particularly adept at going on the lookout, you can still take the leader position from time to time for a bit of a change. Niches are good, but so is personal choice!

LOOKOUT ROLL RESULTS

6 6 — AN UNEXPECTED LANDMARK
A ruin, a dwelling-place, or a wonder of the natural world - who knows what you've found! *The Weaver knows, luckily.*

5 5 — A TROVE OF STUFF
Bits, bobs, and materials galore! This is an excellent place to pick up random (but useful) stuff.

4 4 — AN EVENT IN PROGRESS
Bugs have a habit of wandering into situations that probably shouldn't concern them.

3 3 — A CHANGE IN THE WEATHER
Clear skies rarely last - there's a storm coming (or a gale, or an earthquake, or any other kind of weird weather effect). *You'll find a list of weather types on page 95.*

2 2 — AN NPC
There are more bugs in the wild than stars in the sky, and you probably just met one of them. *Though it could be a beast, too...*

1 1 — A LOOMING HAZARD
Something wicked this way comes - a rival band of bugs, a beast from the wilds, a dangerous part of the landscape, or maybe even a titan!

- LOOKOUT ROLLS EXAMPLE -

Bicco: So, Lookout Rolls... How do they work again?

Weaver: Well, Swift is the leader of your band for the moment, so he doesn't need to make one. For everyone else, grab 2d6 and look for any doubles.

Dunf: And doubles mean there's something we can engage with, right? Like an encounter or something?

Weaver: Well, technically yes - it means you've *seen* something you can engage with. There might be more going on than you notice, though. And given that you're rambling, so you can't be surprised, you'll have the choice of engaging or not... But that's something you'll have to judge for yourselves.

Bicco: Got it! Let me grab that 2d6.

Dunf: Yep, I'm ready too. Layla?

Layla: Well, not to show off, but I'm actually rolling 3d6 for my Lookout Roll! I've got the Many-Eyes aspect, which lets me roll an extra die and then choose two to keep. But yeah, I'm ready too - let's roll!

ENCOUNTERS & CHOICES

After you've made your Lookout Rolls, it's the Weaver's job to tie those results into the fiction of the game. Some steps of a journey will pass without incident, others might require a **choice** to be made, and the most involved will have the Weaver presenting the bugs with an **encounter** of some kind. *We'll deal with the Weaver's portion of journeys on page 92 - don't worry, we haven't forgotten you.*

If part of a journey passes without incident - with no doubles on the Lookout Roll, and with no additional elements added by the Weaver - then you simply mark whatever needs marking on the Journey Track and ticking clock, then take another travel action if you've still got some distance to go. But life is rarely that simple, especially when doubles are rolled...

CHOICES

Sometimes a lookout result will prompt the Weaver to give your group a choice. This might affect a bug, the entire group of bugs, or the wider narrative, and might be decided by everybody at the table or a single individual (whatever seems to work for the moment). A choice on a journey might look something like this...

***Example**: Luther managed a double 6 on his Lookout Roll, which means he spotted 'an unexpected landmark'. The Weaver sees this as a good opportunity to give Luther a personal choice to make - either the landmark reveals something troubling (but useful to know) about the area they're travelling through, or destroying the landmark will give the band a high-value chunk of resources that they might use to improve their picotitan. This essentially gives Luther's player the chance to either take a guaranteed benefit (with a frisson of associated antisocial behaviour), or a more nebulous bit of information that might help them down the line.*

Some choices might be between two beneficial states, others two negative outcomes. Some might even be a choice of instantaneous or future reward. The important bit with these choices is that **they're made in place of an encounter** - whatever's been spotted shouldn't be investigated further after the choice has been made.

ENCOUNTERS

More complex than choices, an encounter is essentially a small scene that plays out before the next travel action can be chosen. This might involve Action Rolls, acquiring resources, overcoming challenges, or even facing hazards - an encounter can be anything related to what's been spotted (or what additional elements the Weaver might add). Let's wind time back a little and look at that same example, but this time as an encounter rather than a choice...

***Example**: Luther managed a double 6 on his Lookout Roll, which means he spotted 'an unexpected landmark'. The Weaver sees this as a good opportunity to give the group an encounter to navigate - the landmark spotted, a miniature castle made out of tin cans and wire, is ineffectually guarded by a sleeping termite in an ill-fitting hat. The group might choose to ramble on by, to wake the termite with questions, to storm the castle and hope for riches inside, or any one of a hundred other approaches they think of. The Weaver has presented the situation, and it's up to them to decide how they act and how much narrative weight they give what they've found.*

Encounters are open-ended by nature, and usually contain potential benefits and drawbacks. They might pass by quickly or, if the bugs really get stuck in to a situation, take up a decent chunk of the session.

CHOICE / ENCOUNTER THEORY

What's this, a sidebar on game design? Not quite - more of a pointer on how best to use choices and encounters within a session, for both Weavers and bugs. Choices on a journey are a bit like montages in scope - they condense what might otherwise be an encounter down into a few sentences of back and forth, which is great for keeping the pace of a game high when that's needed. Encounters are more like scenes, where a lot can be accomplished through creativity, but longer exchanges might take up quite a bit of real-life time. The Weaver can use choices and encounters to help control the flow of a journey, and may even tailor which is offered due to the group's interest in certain elements of the world or whether they have a time-sensitive goal.

Do you engage?

An important question, this one. If the Weaver presents you with an encounter, you've got an important decision to make - or, to be more accurate, you *might* have an important decision to make.

When **rambling**, **waiting**, or **camping with someone on the lookout**, the bugs will often have the chance to **decide how they're engaging** with a spotted element, or even if they engage at all! They've seen it from a distance, after all - they've got time to prepare, and maybe to avoid it entirely.

But when **marching**, or **camping without a lookout**, any new elements introduced will be a surprise - the bugs have either blundered straight into something or they have an unexpected visitor at the campsite, and they're **forced to engage**.

Surprise!

When bugs have no time to prepare, or are caught off guard, they're briefly in a state known as **surprise**. Some hazards have special benefits that only activate when they have the element of surprise on their side.

It works both ways too though! If the bugs are prepared, and can choose how they engage with a spotted element, they might choose to take the element of surprise themselves with a dramatic entrance!

Having the element of surprise may increase your impact, give you extra dice on an Action Roll, or allow you to achieve something that wouldn't normally be possible when there are eyes on you. But **surprise only lasts for a single action**, so make the most of it.

But what's the Weaver's role?

If you're a player, you can skip the next two pages; they're focused on what the Weaver does during a journey to make sure that everything goes as smoothly as possible.

THE WEAVER'S ROLE

Once the Lookout Roll results are in, the spotlight passes to the Weaver. They have two jobs to do each time a travel action is chosen and lookout results come in, the first being optional (**adding special results**) and the second being mandatory (**describing progress**). We'll tackle how to do both of these right now!

ADDING SPECIAL RESULTS

Lookout Rolls are great at telling you what bugs have spotted, but that's not the whole story. The world of PICO is a living, breathing one (sometimes literally), with a whole lot more going on than even the finest bugly eyes or the quiveriest of antennae could ever hope to capture.

To represent this, the Weaver can add one or more **special results** during each section of travel, things that are happening in the world (and that will likely affect the band as they make progress) but that the lookouts may not have spotted on their first sweep. These results can be added purely **at random** or **in secret**, semi-randomly according to the **local likelihood**, or without any hint of randomness with the aim of telling an **unfolding story** in mind.

ADDING SECRET AND RANDOM RESULTS

This is especially useful if the band of travelling bugs is a small one (in terms of number - we kind of assume they're small in terms of size). If there are only one or two bugs making Lookout Rolls then doubles will turn up less frequently, and a few additional results help keep journeys feeling less empty.

To add secret random results, simply roll a d6 secretly (if you have a GM screen, this is the perfect time to use it) and treat whatever the result is as a double of that number, then check the lookout results table as normal.

***Example**: A bugly duo makes their way across the blasted plains of the Skyglass Dome. With only one leader and one lookout, they won't get doubles that frequently, but the Weaver rolls an additional random d6 for each of their ramble and march actions, giving them more potential encounters to engage with. They might not always notice what's happening nearby, but it sure notices them!*

ADDING LOCAL LIKELIHOOD RESULTS

Some areas are just more likely to contain particular encounters - beasts out in the wild, NPCs and looming hazards in the night-time streets of a dangerous bugtropolis.

If you want to spur more lookout results that suit the area, you can choose and add a single 'floating number', from 1 to 6, that is added to all Lookout Rolls. This floating number can be counted as part of a double if it matches any of the naturally rolled results.

***Example**: Onio's band are travelling through the deep woods, picking their way between drifts of fallen autumn leaves. The Weaver decides that the area they're travelling through is a veritable treasure box of potential resources (even if they are mostly hidden by the leaves), so adds a floating 5 to all of the Lookout Rolls made in the locale. This considerably increases the likelihood of a double 5, making the 'Trove of Stuff' lookout result far easier to obtain.*

ADDING UNFOLDING STORY RESULTS

Particularly useful for groups that are less keen on randomness and have a strong narrative drive, this is really just a dressed-up way of letting the Weaver decide exactly what each stage of a journey brings without having to rely on the dice - excellent for when there's a particular story that they want to tell.

What's important to remember here is that the Weaver's chosen story-based encounters don't *replace* lookout rolls entirely, they're instead *flavoured* by them.

***Example**: Lyra and her companions have been on the trail of a horde of beastmice, barbarian rodents rampaging through a series of small insect communities. While on a journey to try to catch up with them, Lookout Rolls take place as normal, but the Weaver also has a few pre-made encounters, landmarks, and choices they want to throw into the mix. These help the bugs gather information about the beastmice as they travel, and keep the flow of narrative consistent and the current goal of the party at the forefront of play.*

DESCRIBING PROGRESS

Once the Weaver knows what's been spotted (through a combination of Lookout Rolls and any secret results they've added), it's their job to describe the group's progress. This is partly informed by the environment the bugs are moving through - maybe a thicket in the middle of a forest, or a dried-up riverbed - and partly by those recently rolled results. This gives the Weaver a chance to introduce any new situations or challenges that a travelling band might face, combining the mechanical outcomes of dice rolls, the fiction of the world, and a hefty dose of upcoming player choice (whether the bugs engage with what they find, which is dealt with on the next page).

If you're new to GMing, that might sound intense. Don't worry too much - we'll break it down for you below.

» **If nothing was spotted** during a round of Lookout Rolls, the Weaver has free reign to introduce whatever they like - or to say that a segment of the journey has passed without incident.

» **If one lookout spotted something**, the Weaver can describe the element in more detail and the players decide whether they want to engage with what they've found, or pass on by. Engaging may require anything from a simple decision to an entire scene being played out before the journey continues.

» **If multiple lookouts spotted something**, the Weaver combines the results into a single element - the bugs then make a choice as to whether they engage with it or not (duplicate results might mean multiple bugs spotted the same thing, or that there are multiple instances of that thing nearby).

Example: *The Weaver describes how the band are passing through the hollow of an ancient, fallen tree. One of the bugs on lookout rolls a 6, to spot something interesting, and then a 3 on the lookout results table - a change in the weather. The Weaver describes how the bugs can see the leaves above them begin to rustle, then fall; there's a gale building up, but they're safe for now within the wooden battlements of the fallen tree. Once they go outside, though...*

WEATHER

"Clams crossed by storms, a storm for every clam. Sorry, calm. Damn. Messed that one up."

From wind to rain, from heat to cold, the weather of the world wreaks havoc on tiny creatures. When raindrops are the size of your head, finding shelter becomes not just a matter of comfort, but a matter of survival.

DECIDING THE WEATHER

Three different forces can change the weather in the world of PICO...

- **The Results of a Lookout Roll**: A lookout roll of double 3s signals a change in whatever weather the bugs are currently experiencing, but it might be one they can avoid by taking shelter (especially if they're not surprised). *Remember, the lookout result might change the weather for the better or for the worse, but there are some special abilities within this book that give players a little more control.*
- **Entering a Microclimate**: Some of the realms within chapter 11 of this book have special rules where weather is concerned (and for light and darkness, which we'll tackle on the next page). *A place directly beneath a sprinkler system may always be rainy, for example.*
- **Through the Will of the Weaver**: Sometimes, the heavens just change. The Weaver can, at any point, bring a new weather type into play (or end an existing one). *They might do this to add a layer of challenge to an otherwise standard encounter, to ratchet up the tension, or to throw in some thunder-and-lightning based drama... Or simply because after a few days of rain, everyone at the table is up for some sunny skies.*

WEATHER AND MOOD

A bug's mood (page 156) is often affected by the weather - whenever a new weather system comes into play, the Weaver may hit every bug in the band with a positive or negative mood pull. The direction of the pull isn't hard-coded though - a rainstorm might usually pull moods to the negative, but if it comes after days of scorching heatwave it might be a positive-pulling relief!

WEATHER SYSTEMS

When a new type of weather comes into play, it usually brings some special rules with it. Each weather system has a few different rules that a Weaver might use (except for Calm Skies, as you'll see below) to represent the mechanical effects it might have on scenes, montages, and journeys. These are split into positive and negative effects (**+** and **-**), and some bugs are lucky enough to avoid the negatives of various weather types altogether.

So when the skies change, a band of bugs might have to contend with...

CALM SKIES

The sun shines, clouds move, and all is right with the world. Calm Skies is the default position for weather, with no special rules for bugs or Weaver to follow.

RAINSTORM

The heavens open and the rains pour down, while the skies fill with dark clouds that seem like they'll never lift.

Liquid Lunch (+): Treat disasters as conflicts when gathering liquidish bits and bobs.
Drenched (-): Spending a scene, montage, or two strides of a journey in the rain pulls mood negative.
Cloud Layer (-): The world is plunged into darkness, even if it's technically meant to be daylight.
Wet Ground (-): Travelling becomes more difficult - ramble and march travel actions both add an extra tick to the ticking clock. In scenes and montages, all movement-based actions take a Tough Cut of 1.

HEATWAVE

The air is close, heavy, and hard to push through. It's a good time to rest, a bad time to walk.

Pleasant in the Shade (+): Using a wait travel action clears one heart on any Heart Track for each bug in the party, as long as you have a picotitan or natural feature of the landscape to cast some shade.
Dragging Feet (-): It's hard to move. Using the march travel action deals Gigasizzle damage to all bugs.
Just Too Hot (-): After spending a scene in a heatwave, roll a d6 for each liquidish bit or bob you have. On a 1, that bit or bob has evaporated into nothingness, and is completely lost.

COLD SNAP

Breath mists in the air, water freezes, and everything starts to slow down.

Torpor (-): So... damn... slow... All actions taken to move or attack take a Speed Cut of 1.
Too Cold To Camp (-): Even with a tent or titan to rest in, the wind cuts like a knife. You can't take wait or camp actions unless you have a heat source nearby.
Freeze (-): I mean, it's in the name. Every bit or bob you have that's liquid gains a new tag, *Frozen*. It takes a whole day (8 ticks) to thaw out after the cold snap ends.

GALE

The winds pick up, moving at speeds terrifying for a light, tiny creature like a bug.

TALLY HO! (+): The wind is blowing in just the right way. Ramble and march actions cover one more stride than usual, and all actions taken to fly, leap, or fall always gain 1d6 advantage from the environment.
Crosswinds (-): Back and forth, back and forth - the gusts are unpredictable and annoying. All actions requiring concentration and precision take a complex-cut of 1.
Driving You Back (-): The winds are against you as you travel. When you use the wait or camp travel actions, roll a d6. On a 1-3 you're pushed back, losing a stride from your Journey Track.

SPORENADO

A scatter of growth, greenery, pollen, and seeds.

Land's Vigour (+): Everything grows better in a sporenado. Count disasters as conflicts when gathering plantish or mushroomy bits and bobs.
Chunky Air (-): At least they're not parasitic! Take a camo-cut of 1 on all actions that rely on being able to see further than the length of a pencil.

DAYLIGHT & DARKNESS

"It was written I should be loyal to the nightmare of my choice. That's bats, for me. Scary buggers, bats."

Some bugs wake up at the crack of dawn, pulling back curtains (if they have them) to witness a wash of gold and orange spreading over the huge world around them. Night birds retreat, the air gets warmer, and numerous dangerous creatures head to bed.

But bathing the world in glorious light is a stressful job, so for about half of every day the sun takes a little break from shining and goes and hides somewhere out of sight. Come on - it's earned it. And some bugs *prefer* that period of darkness; it's more dangerous, yes, but it's also somehow simultaneously more serene.

All this is to say that the world of the many-legged doesn't stop for night or day, it merely marks their passing. Both come with their rewards, their challenges, and their dangers... and that's what these pages are all about.

LIGHT IS IMPORTANT (DARKNESS IS TOO)

Every scene or montage your bug takes part in will happen either in daylight or darkness and, when you head out travelling on a journey, you'll probably experience both multiple times. There are no **inherent** rules to remember that distinguish between daylight and darkness, but there are many cases where an aspect, a location, or a hazard might have rules that change depending on the level of light. A particular stretch of path might be safe by day, but overrun by foxes at night. A draconic starling might only strike at midday, screaming down at prey from the cover of the sun overhead. And a bug that seems sleepy and torpid from dawn to dusk might suddenly come alive at night, gaining extra dice on their rolls and having their mood shoot up in delight.

Going Underground

There are some places where the rhythms of the world fade away, places deep beneath the surface that have never felt the touch of light save what's shed by luminescent mushrooms and fast-burning matches.

When bugs head into a place that has a roof or ceiling that cuts off the sky and no strong light source, they're assumed to be **in darkness** constantly - even if it's daytime up above.

This is great for some bugs, but *terrible* for others (especially those used to swanning around on the surface world). Luckily, there are a few ways around it...

- Finding an area with luminous mushrooms might allow a bug to count themselves as under daylight for a short time, if the mushrooms are bright enough.
- Lighting a match or torch can provide a brilliant burst of brightness at the right time, and definitely counts as daylight until it fizzles out. Remember, it might not look impressive to you or I but, to a bug, that's an incandescent flare they're holding.
- Finally, some bugs can make their own light! Some have shells that shine like a beacon, others have weird glowing glands, or leave trails of iridescent slime... it takes all sorts to make a world, and it takes *these* particular sorts to let their friends bask in false daylight for a bit when necessary.

Eyes & Vision

I bet you thought we'd get to this one sooner! Well, there's a reason that we haven't. For ease of use, all bugs are assumed to see just well enough in the dark that it doesn't make rolls or actions any more difficult to pull off.

This is a baseline though - just like any other part of the world, personal choices trump general rules. Some bugs might elect to take a set of eyes that's particularly powerful at night, giving them increased visual acuity in darkness, but that leaves them constantly dazzled during the day. Another might go eyeless, ignoring light-based effects entirely. A particular predatory beast's coat might even let it blend in under the cover of darkness, or turn light to a hypnotic surge...

Basically, if you want daylight and darkness to affect your bug on a personal level, reflect (hah!) that when you choose your aspects.

- Daylight & Darkness Example 1 -

Weaver: By the time you stumble out of Mama Silk's parlour, night has fallen. It might be a good time to get as far away from here as possible, but you could also choose to camp - or anything else, really. What are you lot feeling like doing now you've cheated death?

Layla: I wouldn't quite say 'cheated', I don't think I'm going to get those webs out of my fur for a month. We could take a montage here maybe, then set off at a march to get away from this place? I don't want to leave unprepared, but I don't want to stay here any longer than necessary.

Bicco: Sounds like a solid plan to me. And if we are taking a montage, you're all in luck - everyone that heals near me gets an extra heart healed.

Weaver: Nice, what part of you lets you do that?

Bicco: My Radiator Shell - if it's cold or dark, anyone healing near me heals an additional heart.

Dunf: Aww, nice one Bicco! That's a really team-focused pick, I love it. I'm going to snuggle up and get some health back, if you don't mind...

Bicco: You're more than welcome, feel free!

- Daylight & Darkness Example 2 -

Swift: Well, that hurt! What the shell was that?

Weaver: As you recover from the impact, you catch a glimpse of a dark shape moving in the shadows among the grass beside the path, just for a moment. You can't tell much more than that, but there's definitely something out there...

Dunf: But the darkness doesn't make it any harder for us here, right? Mechanically, I mean?

Weaver: Well, normally you'd be right. If it was a frogllin or a band of gubs out there, you'd see them no problem. But this thing is made for the darkness, so it actually inflcits Camo Cut on any rolls you make to find or attack it.

Layla: Then maybe a different way forward would help - I stand up as tall as I can and shout "Hey, dude - we've got food here that we're willing to share! If you, you know, don't eat us instead..."

CHAPTER 06:
MAKING A BUG 1
(SPENDING NECTAR)

Buying Basics

This chapter contains the first half of the instructions for how to build a character for the world of PICO, a tiny bug with big dreams - the part where you get, and spend, **Nectar.**

If this is your first time making a bug for a game of PICO...

- **Skim** through this chapter AND the next chapter, so that you understand the whole process.
- **Check** with the Weaver to see how much Nectar you have to spend.
- **Spend** your Nectar on purchasing aspects, augments, and skills from this chapter.
- **Decide** on the other features of your bug in the next chapter, starting on page 153 (those ones don't require you to spend Nectar).

If you've made bugs for PICO before, grab whatever you want from wherever you want in any particular order - attack this character creation buffet as you like! Aspects, augments, and skills are in this chapter, and everything else starts in the next chapter on page 153.

Two whole chapters?

PICO's character creation system requires a mixture of spending Nectar and making choices. All of the Nectar spending is in this chapter, all of the other choices are in the next chapter.

Size

All bugs are SMALL by default, but there are a few aspects that allow you to alter your bug's size on page 130. We don't recommend new players use these, as they may have some unintended effects on the fictive side of the game, but hey - we can't really stop you!

How To Make A Bug (part 1)

"The leg bone's connected to the... Oh wait, what's a bone? We've messed that up already."

This is where you get to let some of that creativity shine - a chance to build a completely unique bug, one that's just for you. We can *almost* promise that no other player in the world will have a bug that's exactly like yours, which seems appropriate given the vast number of weird little bugs in our own world, and the inherent strangeness of the post-Mysteriocalypse world.

There are eight steps to making a bug, which may or may not sound like a lot, depending on how good you are at counting. **This chapter covers the first four steps**; where you get your Nectar, then spend it on aspects, augments, and skills. In fact, to break it down in a more useful way...

Step One: Get Your Nectar

Nectar is essentially a character creation resource, which can be earned during play for advancement but is also given out in bulk by the Weaver before you make your bug. The more Nectar you have to spend, the more choices you can make and the more powerful your bug will likely end up being. **Larva bugs begin with 25 Nectar, Imago bugs begin with 50 Nectar.**

You'll get your starting Nectar on page 102.

Step Two: Purchase Your Aspects

Aspects are parts, gear, and buddies that define your bug, which can be purchased with Nectar. Each comes with a name, a track, and some sort of special rule that makes you unique. These aren't the only things you're going to be spending Nectar on, so don't go crazy here! **A single aspect costs 3 Nectar.**

You'll find an overview of aspects on page 104, and grouped sets of aspects to purchase with Nectar starting on page 108.

Step Three: Purchase Your Augments

Aspects can be improved by adding augments, extra little rules that help make them more distinct. Each group of aspects comes with some suggested augments, but you can really add them on from anywhere as long as you can justify the fiction of it. There are also special augments that can help theme your bug in a certain direction! **Each aspect can have a maximum of two augments, and each augment costs 2 Nectar.**

You'll find an overview of augments on page 106, and then a set of augments that suit each aspect group starting on page 109.

Step Four: Purchase Your Skills

The last thing you'll be spending Nectar on, skills give you general competencies that let you perform different types of actions. Each of your skills has a rank, starting at zero, and can be raised to rank one or rank two by spending Nectar. **It costs 1 Nectar to take a skill from rank 0 to rank 1, and 2 Nectar to take a skill from rank 1 to rank 2 (it also costs 3 Nectar to take a skill from rank 2 to rank 3, but that's disallowed for starting characters).**

You'll find an overview of how to choose and use skills on page 144, then a list of skills divided by category starting on page 148.

PiCO
Character Sheet

Short Pic-nic

[Player Name]

1

NAME

Pseudo [ ]

[description]

[pic-ture]

4

SKILLS

Max Rank: 3

Moving
- Dash
- Climb
- Dig
- Slink
- Fly
- Swim

Friending
- Yap
- Swagger
- Dazzle
- Scare
- Care
- Tame

Finding
- Sense
- Hunt
- Rummage
- Think
- Make
- Chart

Rumbling
- Bash
- Bite
- Slash
- Sizzle
- Dance
- Shield

2 & 3

ASPECTS

... and augments

MOOD

[ ] [OK] [ ]

BITS & BOBS

[Carry Slots: Start 6 / Current]

MYSTERY

[?]

CREATIONS

NECTAR

"... They who control the Nectar control the Picoverse. The Nectar must flow."

Nectar is a delicious, golden liquid that fills bugs with exactly the right kind of energy they need to develop - to gain new aspects, to augment existing aspects, and to boost their skills. It's a character creation and advancement resource, essentially, but one that's actually tangible in the world of PICO. We'll delve in to how you might acquire Nectar on the next page, but for now we're concerned with your...

STARTING NECTAR

Before making a character for a game or campaign of PICO, your Weaver will hand out a certain amount of Nectar to each player. This starting Nectar allows you to build the basics of your bug. You can spend this starting Nectar as you like, but we recommend **about 50% of it should go towards skills and about 50% towards aspects and augments**.

This starting Nectar also defines the game's power level - the more Nectar a bug has to spend, the more advanced they are, the more cool stuff they can do, and the more of the world of PICO they've likely already seen. The Weaver can technically give out any amount of Nectar for players to build their bugs, but we suggest choosing from one of the two options below...

LARVA (25 Nectar)

With 25 Nectar, a bug will likely have two or three aspects (with a couple of augments for good measure) and a spread of rank 1 and 2 skills. This is perfect for players new to the world of PICO and those planning longer-term games, as it keeps starting rules complexity low (while still giving a good amount of options to choose from) and gives plenty of room for growth. *Bugs starting at 25 Nectar are usually new to the world and probably know very little about it (though there's nothing stopping you from playing a more experienced traveller that just happens to not have found much Nectar along the way).*

IMAGO (50 Nectar)

With 50 Nectar you can build a much more competent individual, a rugged bugly adventurer with four or five aspects (and one or two augments on each) and a wider spread of skills, with many at rank 2 - and maybe even some at rank 3, if the Weaver and the group are in agreement. This might suit experienced players that want a more powerful start, or a one-shot experience for those who have quite a few hours of PICO under their belt already and just want to try a new kind of bug. *Bugs starting at 50 Nectar have usually travelled a bit, been on a few adventures, and know how the world of PICO operates (though there's nothing stopping you from playing a young bug who just happened to hatch rally, really strong).*

SPENDING YOUR STARTING NECTAR

We'll remind you of these costs again in the future, but for the sake of completeness you'll be spending Nectar on...

- **Aspects**, at 3 Nectar each.
- **Augments**, at 2 Nectar each.
- **Skills**, with a rank 1 skill costing 1 Nectar, an upgrade from rank 1 to rank 2 costing 2 Nectar, and an upgrade from rank 2 to rank 3 costing 3 Nectar.

Finding More Nectar

Nectar is the sweetest, most delicious, most brain-tingling substance in the world of PICO. Going far beyond the sweetness of pollen or even cola, nectar is a golden liquid produced by flowers when they witness something truly spectacular. Impress a flower with a heroic deed and they may just disgorge Nectar, releasing a glob of the stuff to be eagerly snaffled up by nearby bugs for later use.

Your starting Nectar gives you enough to build a character before the game begins (or during a session zero, see page 192), but Nectar is addictive stuff - bugs can't help but seek it out once they get a taste. So where might you find more?

Nectar found during play is essentially a gift from the Weaver, a reward for besting a challenge or completing a session. It can't be gathered or scrounged up - it's far too powerful for that - but might be given out...

- After the band of bugs defeat a difficult foe
- After the close of an important arc of the story
- After a particularly daring or complex plan works
- After surviving a tough situation

When Nectar is gained, all bugs gain the same amount. You *could* run a game with varying power levels from bug to bug, and Nectar handed out in different amounts to different characters, but 'rules as written' everybody gets the same amounts at the same time. **1, 2, or 3 globs of Nectar per session is usually perfect.**

Constant Growth

If it suits your group, the Weaver might also hand out Nectar at the end of every completed session. This ensures bugs will be constantly growing and changing as they adventure (as long as they moult to take advantage of it).

If you're going to do this, we recommend not giving out more than 1 or 2 Nectar at the end of each session if you're ALSO giving it as mid-session rewards, and no more than 3 or 4 if you're only giving Nectar at the end of each session.

Moulting

Once a game begins, Nectar can be used by spending a task during a montage and **moulting**, shedding your old bugly skin and emerging stronger. *You'll find more details on moulting on page 80.*

- Nectar Example -

Weaver: The clankercat stops, blinks, and slowly topples sideways with a crash.

Bicco: Wait - we did it? We actually did it?

Weaver: You actually did it, yeah! Scrappy-looking gubs spill out of the machine's open mouth once it hits the floor, the last of them stopping to pat it sadly on the nose before scrabbling away.

Layla: Well, now I just feel bad.

Dunf: I don't know, I don't think I'm going to shed too many tears. It was trying to eat us, remember?

Layla: ... Point taken.

Weaver: Dunf is right, this is definitely time for some celebration. And a present to go with it - one of the machine's headlamp-eyes springs out of its socket and breaks on the floor in front of you, spilling a golden-yellow substance from its interior.

Layla: I'm very glad that's not a real eye.

Dunf: Me too, but I'm even more glad that, unless I'm mistaken, that stuff is...

Swift: Nectar! Oh yeah, this is the good stuff - how much do we each get, Weaver?

Weaver: Well, you did take down a mechanical titan today, which is a pretty big deal. Let's say you can each scoop up three Nectar before the remainder dries up or seeps away through cracks in the floor.

Bicco: That's enough for a new aspect, if I recall correctly.

Swift: It is indeed, but I think I'll leave aspects until later. I've got a skill I want to rank up first!

Dunf: I don't even know what I'm going to spend mine on yet...

Weaver: Don't worry too much right now, you've all got a little time to think before you'll get a chance to spend it. Those gubs might come back with reinforcements to drag the machine off for repairs, and you probably don't want to be here when they get back.

Layla: Very true. Let's go find a safe place for a montage so we can moult!

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

"Brevity is."

The combination of aspects and augments are what makes your bug unique. **Ideally, you should spend about half of your starting Nectar on your aspects and augments** - maybe a little more if you want to keep your skill list on the minimalistic side. **There's also a hard limit of six aspects per bug, but you won't get there for a while!**

ASPECTS

Your aspects are the body parts, carried gear, and little companions that make you *you*. Aspects can be used again and again without ever being lost, but they do each have a **track** - when that track is fully marked, you don't get the benefits of an aspect again until at least one of the boxes has been cleared.

Aspects are used to...

- **Absorb Damage**: Their tracks absorb any damage you take in the form of marks, and some even have breaks to be able to better absorb giga damage. **If you ever take more damage than a track can absorb, start converting some of those marks to burns** until all the damage has been absorbed. An aspect's track has its boxes in the shape of **hearts**, just to remind you that they're there to represent some kind of insect health.
- **Gain Benefits (and Drawbacks)**: These are special rules that break the general rules of the game, often in your favour (but not always). Some aspects have benefits and drawbacks that are always active. Other have ones that only activate in certain situations, or ones where you need to mark (or burn) an aspect's track to have them come into play, or meet a certain condition. Unless an aspect explicitly tells you something special needs to happen before its benefit or drawback can be used, assume that it always applies.
- **Help You With Rolls**: Aspects also have a narrative component that lets you grab a bonus 1d6 when you're making a roll where the aspect might be relevant. A roll to turn aside damage will definitely be helped if you have a shell of some kind, for example, and you might even describe how you're using some piece of gear or helpful buddy to absorb an incoming blow. **You can only get a bonus of 1d6 from aspects** on any roll though, even if more than one of your aspects might help out.
- **Give You a Pseudoscientific Name**: Some aspects can also help you name your bug, giving you some insight into how absent pre-Mysteriocalypse scholars might have talked about your diminutive form. You'll learn more about names on page 168.

ASPECT TYPES

Aspects are split into three types - parts, gear, and buddies. *You'll find an example of each kind of aspect on the right.*

Part aspects are literally parts of your own bugly body that are particularly distinctive - they don't describe every facet of you, but they do describe the bits that are worth paying attention to.

Gear aspects are pieces of the world that you've grabbed and kept until they're as much a part of you as an arm or a leg. Bits and bobs are used, eaten, or lost, but gear is forever.

Buddy aspects are little friends (little even in terms of bugs, usually) that travel with you and help you out in a pinch.

MANDIBLES (Maka) ♥♥•♥ PART

Perfect for nibbling, chewing, and gripping, the most common bugly mouth style.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Bite.

GEARHAMMER ♥♥ GEAR

Made from the innards of an old clock, reinforced with pride and accomplishments.
Benefit: The first attack you make with a Gearhammer in each scene deals giga damage.

GLADPOLE (Ribab) ♥♥♥ BUDDY

Proof that nature and nurture both matter, and also that froglins might once have been pretty cute.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut imposed by *lackeys*.

SPECIFIC OVER GENERAL

Many aspects have benefits that can change how you play the game, and some that even change how fundamental parts of the game work. In these cases, **your aspect's benefits and drawbacks always trump the general rules laid out in this book**.

For example, the general rule for healing burns on your aspects is that you can do it in a settlement by using a task. But the Straw Hose aspect (shown below) specifies that you can remove burns on its track by spending a task near a source of water, and that being in this situation removes all burns at once.

STRAW HOSE ♥♥♥ GEAR

Filled with water, which can be spurted out droplet by droplet or in a wash of extreme force.
Benefit: Burn to drench an area instantly, putting out fires and washing away dirt. Whenever you take a montage near a source of water (such as a tap or a pond), clear all burns on this aspect's track.

The specifics here override the general rules on burns, and how many you can clear at once. They also change the way certain montages work for this aspect's owner.

AUTONOMOUS

Buddy aspects have fewer hearts on their track than most, but they all have an unwritten special rule - **they have minds of their own**, and can often wander around the environment of their own accord. They're still a part of your character though, at the end of the day - just keep it in mind for roleplay and clever actions.

- ASPECTS EXAMPLE -

Weaver: The froglin croaks loudly to get everyone's attention - he wants you to see this! Once you're all looking, he makes a show of lighting up one of the matches that he stole from you, and throws it into the field you're standing in!

Dunf: No! The crops!

Weaver: The crops indeed - the fire quickly begins to spread as the froglin hightails it away, flames racing towards you. I'm starting a track, Fighting the Fire, and I'm giving it three boxes.

Swift: Okay, okay, we can do this - Bicco, you have that Straw Hose you moulted for a few sessions ago, is that going to help us out?

Bicco: It's fully burned! We've been away from water for too long!

Layla: Wait, wait, we can still do this - I've got my Radiant Wings, I'm going to use those, and my Fly skill, to try to fan the flames away from the rest of the crops. That's... A conflict!

Weaver: Nice move! I'm going to mark the track, as you've stopped them from spreading for the moment, but you're also going to take one Sizzle Damage from the intense heat.

Dunf: I think I can help here too! I've got my Whirligig Shell, so I'm going to stop, drop, and roll over the spreading flames! I know it's going to hurt, but it should help to put some of the fire out.

Weaver: That could work! Give me a roll, Dunf, let's see how useful that shell of yours can be...

AUGMENTS

Aspects start off pretty good, but we're aiming for *amazing*. That's where augments come in.

Augments are special extras that can be added to an aspect, making its Heart Track longer and adding new benefits (and maybe drawbacks). *Each augment also has an additional bit of pseudoscientific name for your bug, but we'll deal with that later.*

Each aspect you purchase can have **a maximum of two augments** attached to it, and once they're on, they're there to stay! The augments add extra hearts (and sometimes breaks) to the aspect's track, and their benefit is pinned under the existing benefit from the aspect.

GROUPED BY ASPECT

The augments in this book are all grouped by the kind of aspect they work best on, so you'll find augments like 'Venomous' and 'Crushing' in the Chompers section. But don't feel held back by this - **any augment can be added to any aspect**, even if it comes from a different section. Want a venomous backpack? Be our guest.

Here's an example of an augment, on the left, and that same augment added to one of the example aspects from the previous page, on the right.

CRUSHING +♥

Built-in hydraulics, for when a normal bite just doesn't cut it.

Benefit: Burn to treat Bite as Gigabite for an action.

CRUSHING MANDIBLES ♥♥•♥♥ PART

Perfect for nibbling, chewing, and gripping, the most common bugly mouth style.

Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Bite.

Benefit: Burn to treat Bite as Gigabite for an action.

THE NEXT 36 PAGES

... Are dedicated to aspects and augments, grouped by themes: **Chompers, Suckers, Peepers, Shell, Slime, Feelers, Scuttlers, Grippers, Wings, Glands, Tails, Build, Brain, Companions, Mounts, Tools, Weapons**, and **Threads**.

Yes, on reflection, I may have gotten slightly carried away.

Once you've spent about half of your starting Nectar on aspects and augments from these 36 pages, head to page 144 and spend the rest of it on some skill ranks! You can always hold a few globs of Nectar back if you can't make a decision yet, but there's no mechanical benefit to not spending it when you get it.

Feeling overwhelmed by the amount of choices? Well don't worry, that's exactly why we put together...

ASPECT & AUGMENT QUICKSTARTS!

If you're a first-time PICO player, it might be worth aiming to make a particular kind of **real-world bug**. That way you'll have a good idea of what you look like, and a firm foundation for all of your other future choices. With that in mind, we've given over the page on the right to detailing some **aspect and augment combinations that represent classic real-world bugs**, and the Nectar cost you'd pay for grabbing them. You don't *have* to use these - feel free to turn the page and explore the aspects and augments on offer for yourself. This is just an optional shortcut!

And remember, you'll be paying...

3n for an aspect

2n for an augment

Ant 11ᑎ

Known for immense strength (for their size, at least) and a regimented sense of order.

- » Megamuscled Mandibles (pages 131 and 108)
- » Hexapod (page 120)
- » Infratennae (page 118)

Bee 11ᑎ

Reputed to be the last thing standing in the way of total environmental collapse. Was it the bees that brought the Mysteriocalypse in the end, or were they just as surprised as everyone else?

- » Sweetling Proboscis (pages 111 and 110)
- » Stinger (page 128)
- » Dronewings (page 124)

Butterfly 13ᑎ

A lord of the skies, almost impossible to catch (without the aid of a big net).

- » Mask-Patterned Flutterflaps (pages 125 and 124)
- » Sweetling Proboscis (pages 111 and 110)
- » Compound-Eyes (page 112)

Centipede 9ᑎ

An excellent choice for when you're asked 'how many legs would you like?' and you simply answer 'yes'.

- » Centapod (page 120)
- » Scissorjaws (page 108)
- » Infratennae (page 118)

Cockroach 11ᑎ

The benefit of pure survival can't really be overstated - if you never actually die, then on a long enough timeline you'll end up achieving just about any goal you can set your mind to.

- » Chitin-Layered Hardshell (pages 115 and 114)
- » Broomtennae (page 118)
- » Hexapod (page 120)

Cricket 13ᑎ

The lord of the dance, and of the organic fiddle.

- » Double Knee'd Sonorous Quadrapod (pages 121, 121 again, and 120)
- » Grinders (page 108)
- » Dronewings (page 124)

Dragonfly 13ᑎ

Distinguished hunters that move quick as lightning.

- » Calculating Holoptics (pages 113 and 112)
- » Jinky Vibrawings (pages 125 and 124)
- » Aerotail (page 128)

Earthworm 9ᑎ

Have a reputation for turning up to social events too early, and getting eaten despite their efforts.

- » Zeropod (page 120)
- » Barricade Plasm (page 116)
- » Split Brain (page 132)

Fly 11ᑎ

Okay, you might be a pest. But you're an *effective* pest.

- » Compound-Eyes (page 112)
- » Vibrawings (page 124)
- » Dribbly Sponge (pages 111 and 110)

Pond-skater 11ᑎ

Swimming? That's *so* last season.

- » Skimming Quadrapod (pages 121 and 120)
- » Ghostshell (page 114)
- » Difference Engine (page 132)

Praying Mantis 13ᑎ

Fear the reaper.

- » Double-Edged Crescent Scythes (pages 123 and 122)
- » Many-Eyes (page 112)
- » Serene Hypergland (pages 127 and 126)

Scorpion 14ᑎ

Nature's spiky little tank, a scorpion balances offence and defence like a pro.

- » Poisonpoint Stinger (pages 129 and 128)
- » Ramshell (page 114)
- » Snappin' Claws (page 122)
- » Arachnopod (page 120)

Snail 13ᑎ

Wherever your shell is, that's your home. Literally.

- » Armoured Kilotonshell (pages 115 and 114)
- » Telescopic Peeping Stars (pages 113 and 112)
- » Foultrail (page 116)

Spider 13ᑎ

Pedants will point out that you're not an insect. Then you'll eat them.

- » Hardpoint Arachnopod (pages 121 and 120)
- » Spinneret (page 126)
- » Venomous Chelifangs (pages 109 and 108)

Stinkbug 11ᑎ

A lord of the skies, almost impossible to catch (witut the aid of a big net).

- » Hardshell (page 114)
- » Unappetizing Gloomspout (pages 127 and 126)
- » Widewings (page 124)

CHOMPERS

OVERVIEW

Something about your mouthparts is special - they draw the eye, or give you abilities one wouldn't normally expect. When you take a set of Chompers as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want food, or biting, to be a big deal for your character.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you don't have a mouth! A bug with no distinctive Chompers might have anything from a little set of nibbling mouthparts to a big, goofy smile - but whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE CHOMPERS?

- Because food is important to you
- Because you want to eat something specific
- Because biting things is fun
- Because you want to look scary

ASK YOURSELF...

- Is there a particular type of food that you're drawn to, or one that you stay away from at all costs?
- What's the most impressive thing you've ever eaten, and what made it so gosh-darn impressive?
- It's okay, you can be honest - have you ever eaten something that you *really* weren't supposed to?

MANDIBLES (Maka) ♥♥•♥ PART
Perfect for nibbling, chewing, and gripping, the most common bugly mouth style.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Bite.

CHELIFANGS (Vixo) ♥♥♥•♥ PART
The heights of horror, these wickedly curved fangs definitely set a bug on the 'predator' side of the predator/prey divide.
Benefit: When rolling with Bite, a triumph boosts it to Gigabite for that action.

GRINDERS (Katkata) ♥♥♥♥ PART
These chompers were made for the toughest of meals!
Benefit: You can consume bobs, as well as bits, when healing marks on your parts during a montage.

GNASHERS (Chicho) ♥•♥♥ PART
Over there, a good place for a picnic!
Benefit: When you make a lookout roll without finding any doubles you can consume a bit to pull your mood positive if you wish.

SCISSORJAWS (Snapo) ♥•♥♥ PART
Hinged for quick, decisive snaps.
Benefit: When countering with a rumbling skill, gain giga impact damage rather than the usual normal impact damage.

FOUL MOUTH (Yapski) ♥♥•♥ PART
The insults you know would turn a greenfly blue.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Yap.

DELISHERAE (Mumu) ♥♥♥ PART
You revel in the exquisite whenever you can.
Benefit: Pull your mood positive whenever you consume a crunchy bit or bob for any reason.

MEGAMAW (Gnom) ♥♥ PART
This is a bite that'll go down in bugly history.
Benefit: Once per scene you may burn to steal the spotlight for an immediate Bite action that ignores all cut and treats your Bite skill as Gigabite.

SPIKE-SPITTER (Yoma) ♥•♥ PART
If they won't come close enough for a good solid munch, you'll just have to send the bites to them!
Benefit: You can attack distant hazards with Bite or Sizzle without incurring cut or lowering impact.

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for some marvellous mouthparts, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, a Chomper can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

CANNIBALIZING (Chuchu) +♥♥

You take that out of your mouth right now!
Benefit: You automatically heal a heart when you successfully hit a bugly target with a rumbling skill.

CRUSHING (Chakro) +♥

For when a non-hydraulic bite just doesn't cut it.
Benefit: Burn to treat Bite as Gigabite for an action.

DIVINING (Ohmi) +•♥♥♥

An oracle of snapping jaws.
Benefit: When you break a hazard's track with a rumbling action, you learn a secret about the target (supplied by the Weaver).

FOGHORN (Blaa) +♥

Flared for maximum volume.
Benefit: Burn to treat Yap as Gigayap for an action.

GRABBY (Tova) +♥♥

Never let me go!
Benefit: Re-roll dice pool results of 1 when trying to maintain or escape a grab.

SNEAKSTRIKE (Slisli) +♥•♥

Chompers? What chompers? Oh, THESE chompers?
Benefit: Once per scene, increase any skill you use to attack to its giga version when your target is unaware of you.

MESSY (Sle) +•♥

Nobody ever taught you to chew with your mouth closed, huh?
Benefit: When you would consume a bit for any reason, instead give it the 'Chewed' tag and keep it. If you consume a bit with the 'Chewed' tag, it's gone forever.

TOOTHY (Ketake) +•♥

Bugs can have teeth? Well, you learn something new every day.
Benefit: When you roll a twist with a Bite action, gain a bit or bob appropriate to the situation as well as any other usual rewards.

TWEEZER (Cligu) +•♥♥

Extreme length and extreme precision come at a cost.
Benefit: You ignore Complex Cut when using Bite.
Drawback: Double any Armour Cut when using Bite.

VENOMOUS (Sizo) +•♥

Some might say that it's cheating, but for you it's just part of the hunt.
Benefit: Choose a hazard type: *Bugly*, *Beastly*, *Scaly*, *Slimy*, *Feathery*, *Leafy*, *Shroomy*, *Clanky*, or *Ghostly*. Treat Bite as Gigabite when attacking targets with the keyword of your choice.

VORACIOUS (Chacha) +♥

You're a machine! Not literally, obviously - you're a bug. But those mouthparts certainly work like a conveyor belt when food is involved.
Benefit: You can consume an edible bit during a montage without spending a task, healing one heart on this aspect.

XENIC (Xeno) +•♥

Like that thing from that famous movie!
Benefit: Any hazard that pushes, pulls, or grabs you takes inescapable Bite damage.

SUCKERS

OVERVIEW

You'd be the terror of the lollipop stand, if such things still existed (and maybe they do, who are we to say?). When you take a Sucker as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want slurping and digesting to be a big deal for your character.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you don't have a tongue! A bug with no Sucker might still be able to hoover up bits at an alarming rate, and lick the world in annoying ways - but whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE SUCKERS?

- Because taste is important to you
- Because you want to slobber on stuff
- Because spitting makes you look like a delinquent, and there are benefits to being avoided
- Because you have a good supply of tissues

ASK YOURSELF...

- What's your opinion on gobstoppers? Hideous abomination, or worthwhile challenge?
- Do you eat in private, or wolf stuff down in front of everyone else?
- Have you ever found anything unpalatable, and why?

PROBOSCIS (Bulmu) ♥♥ PART

A slim tube for delicate eaters. Might be arrow-straight, carefully curved, or spiral-style!
Benefit: Reduce all cuts by 1 when gathering bits.

VACUUM (Shulpq) ♥♥♥•♥ PART

A little mouth-trumpet that vacuums up everything nearby, flared for maximum efficiency.
Benefit: When gathering, a twist pulls your mood to positive as well as any other usual effects.

SPONGE (Hoblq) ♥♥♥ PART

The height of bugly luxury - why chew when you can simply absorb?
Benefit: Pull your mood positive whenever you consume a soft bit or bob for any reason.

CHURNBELLY (Ghili) ♥♥♥ PART

Nobody's going to tell you what you can and can't eat!
Benefit: Choose a type of usually inedible bits or bobs (such as stones, electricity, or metal). When you consume a bit or bob of this type, pull your mood to positive and clear a mark from one of your tracks.

LEECHER (Blik) ♥•♥ PART

The less said about this one, the better.
Benefit: Treat conflicts as triumphs when attempting to start or maintain a grab.

NEUROSTALK (Theu) ♥♥•♥ PART

Nobody ever said the brain had to be *inside* the body. Let's get some classic horror going here!
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Think.

TENTATONGUE (Jozi) ♥♥♥ PART

A wiggly 'tongue' made for seeking out recalcitrant food.
Benefit: Ignore Camo Cut when using a rumbling skill.

LONGSHOT (Hyaq) ♥♥♥ PART

A spring-loaded licker with impressive range, a bugly knock-off of a scaly classic.
Benefit: Ignore any cut that would be applied for attempting to grab or pull a distant (or flying) target.

NEEDLER (Siqu) ♥♥♥ PART

It's the itch that gets you...
Benefit: Ignore Armour Cut on beastly hazards.

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for a grand gullet, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, a Sucker can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

ACIDGLAND (Splurk) +♥

Putting the 'cute' in 'corrosive' (it's lucky bugs are terrible at spelling).
Benefit: Burn to treat Sizzle as Gigasizzle for an action.

BITTER (Uru) +♥

Take that acid, stick it in words.
Benefit: Choose a hazard type: *Bugly*, *Beastly*, *Scaly*, *Slimy*, *Feathery*, *Leafy*, *Shroomy*, *Clanky*, or *Ghostly*. Treat Yap as Gigayap when attacking targets with the keyword of your choice.

DELICATE (Doshi) +•♥♥

The refined palate of a bugly gourmand.
Benefit: Treat conflicts as triumphs when making an Action Roll with a finding skill.
Drawback: You're weak to any damage caused by strong tastes or smells.

DRIBBLY (Raugi) +♥

Endearingly disgusting.
Benefit: Pull your mood to the negative to treat a disaster as a conflict while using a friending skill.

ERUPTIVE (Bomi) +•♥♥

Best not to think about what this one might look like.
Benefit: You ignore Speed Cut when using Sizzle.
Drawback: Double any Complex Cut when using Sizzle.

FLOODGATE (Jushu) +•♥

How much stinging saliva can one bug produce? Wait, do bugs even *have* saliva?
Benefit: When this aspect's track breaks, ignore Armour Cut for the rest of the scene.

MISTING (Lo) +♥

You sneeze a fine corrosive mist that reacts with sunlight - best keep tissues handy.
Benefit: When in light, reduce any Armour Cut you and your allies suffer by 1.

POISONCOAT (Soza) +♥

A little extra kick they won't be expecting.
Benefit: Once per scene, pull your mood to the negative to ignore all cut on an action using a rumbling skill.

SHADOWKISSED (Pata) +♥

Some things are more impressive under the cover of inky darkness.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut on friending skills when in darkness.

SWEETLING (Fwasomi) +♥♥

Sugar, pollen, honey - nothing beats a shot of mid-afternoon adrenaline quite like sweetness.
Benefit: Healing by using a sweet or sugary bit clears double the usual amount of hearts.

STICKIFYING (Globa) +♥

The emergency superglue of the bugly world.
Benefit: Burn to treat Make as Gigamake for an action.

SYRINGE (Khaso) +♥♥

You're in it for that sweet, sweet blood!
Benefit: You automatically heal a heart when you successfully hit a beastly target with a rumbling skill.

WHISPERING (Vefi) +•♥

You speak softly, but your words carry weight.
Benefit: Treat results of 1 as if they were results of 6 when using a friending skill.

PEEPERS

OVERVIEW

You might not have beautiful eyes, but they're certainly pretty striking in some way. When you take a set of Peepers as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want sight and awareness to be a big deal for your character.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you don't have eyes! A bug with no distinctive Peepers might have anything from several small eyes to light sensitive patches - but whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE PEEPERS?

- Because you're angling to be artistic
- Because you want to take in all the details
- Because eyes mean eyebrows (theoretically), and eyebrows mean poignant and meaningful brow-based expressions

ASK YOURSELF...

- What's something you've seen that you were never meant to see? Has a glimpse gotten you into trouble?
- Is there anything your eyes are particularly suited to noticing, such as movement or colour?
- What sight of the bugly world is on your bucket list?

COMPOUND EYES (Dio) ♥♥ PART

You see the world in a multifaceted spin, a whirl of incredible detail.
Benefit: Mark to have the Weaver supply a detail of the current scene that you and your allies have missed.

MANY-EYES (Lato) ♥•♥ PART

Windows to the soul? You have a whole house of them!
Benefit: When you're on the lookout during a journey you roll 3d6 instead of the usual 2d6, and take any two of the results you prefer.

HOLOPTICS (Toto) ♥♥♥ PART

The biggest eyes around, all the better to see you with...
Benefit: If you would be caught unaware or by surprise, instead steal the spotlight for an action.

TINY EYES (Dai) ♥•♥ PART

Size isn't everything - these eyes are all about precision.
Benefit: When you gain a bit or bob, mark to add a positive tag of your choice.

ABSENT EYES (Hada) ♥♥♥•♥ PART

Okay, so you might *not* have eyes. But you're not going to let that hold you back!
Benefit: You are immune to Dazzle.

STEMMATA (Hoble) ♥•♥♥ PART

It's an eye, technically, in kind of the same way that a dog is a wolf.
Benefit: Once per session, when another bug makes a small discovery, you can *also* make a small discovery of your own (based on completely misunderstanding the situation that prompted it).

PEEPING STARS (Staastaa) ♥♥ PART

An unusual shape, but then who can really say what's usual and what isn't in the post-Mysteriocalypse?
Benefit: Choose either light or darkness. Ignore Tough Cut on any vision-based rolls during your chosen time.

GLINTOCULARS (Miku) ♥♥ PART

Attracted to shiny things like a bugly little magpie.
Benefit: When in light, any bob you come across gains a positive tag (supplied by the Weaver) if it wouldn't already have one.

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for some enticing eyelets, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, Peepers can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

BULGING (Ongo) +♥

Bigger than average? You skew the average, baby!
Benefit: Burn to treat Rummage as Gigarummage for an action.

CALCULATING (Psyo) +♥

You can detect the smallest movements, giving you the chance to react to things almost before they happen.
Benefit: Once per scene, steal the spotlight when a hazard makes a move toward a nearby ally.

CARTOGRAPHIC (Mapi) +♥

An eye for geological and natural detail.
Benefit: Burn to treat Chart as Gigachart for an action.

CLOUDED (Uzi) + •♥♥

The bug who mistook his wife for a hat.
Benefit: You're resistant to Dazzle and Swagger.

CUTE (Jiko) +•♥

Sometimes a flutter of lashes is all you need.
Benefit: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 when trying to charm a foe or defuse a situation.

HEADLIGHT (Poi) +♥♥♥

Biologically, eyes that produce light are kind of useless. But they're damn cool!
Benefit: You can shine light at a nearby spot (or a nearby bug, or target).

HEAVY-LIDDED (Grawa) +♥♥

You're not sleepy all the time... Just while you're awake.
Benefit: Clear all marks from this aspect's track when you rest during a journey.

LONGOCULAR (dubo) +♥♥♥

Who looks far ahead? Planners and hunters, most likely.
Benefit: When a scene begins, ask the Weaver to name a single bit or bob you catch sight of that nobody else notices.

PIERCING (Dola) +♥

Your eyes were meant for glaring and staring.
Benefit: Once per scene, pull your mood to the negative to ignore all cut on an action using a friending skill.

SENSITIVE (Ahi) +♥

Practice interpreting the vague shapes of the world has trained your eyes past the bugly average.
Benefit: Treat results of 3, 2, or 1 as the same number when checking for doubles while using a finding skill.

TELESCOPIC (Woapa) +♥♥

Stick them out when you need that bit of extra range, and retract them if you glimpse anything suspect.
Benefit: You can peek out from safe or hidden spots without being seen, without needing a roll.

WEEPING (Buhu) +♥♥

Someone far away is cutting onions, you swear.
Benefit: As a task, you may pull your mood negative to gain a bit, either 'Salty Tear' or 'Eyecrust'.

WIDE-SPECTRUM (Ocuro) +♥

Lights and colours? There are so many more than most ever expect!
Benefit: Ignore any cut caused by biological camouflage (like colour-changing scales).

SHELL

OVERVIEW

Insides matter, but outsides matter too. The shell that protects you is special in some way, a reliable bastion or complex covering. When you take a Shell as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want defence or safety to be a big deal for your character.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you don't have a shell! You might have a covering that's a little on the drab side, but still entirely functional, or you might be one of the worm-types that gets all pulse-ish and slidey. But remember, whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE A SHELL?

- Because you want to look impressive to others
- Because safety is your number one concern
- Because the world is a big, scary place
- Because you want to look rough and tough

ASK YOURSELF...

- Do you decorate your Shell with paint, or some other kind of mark?
- What's something your Shell has saved you from in the past, a foe or calamitous event that might have totalled a lesser-shelled bug?
- Do you carry any distinctive scars on your covering, or is it as fresh as the day that you moulted?

HARDSHELL (Athro) ♥•♥♥ PART
A classic carapace that any bug would be proud of.
Benefit: Choose two from Bash, Bite, Slash, or Sizzle. You are resistant to the chosen damage types.

SOFTSHELL (Gombu) ♥♥•♥ PART
Growing up with a thin skin helps you consider the feelings of others a little more... maybe?
Benefit: Choose two from Yap, Swagger, Dazzle, or Care. You are resistant to the chosen damage types.

GHOSTSHELL (Actra) ♥♥♥♥ PART
That's all you've got? What if there's a strong gust of wind, or you suffer a mild shock?
Benefit: You are invisible to those that hunt by sensing tremors, and don't set off pressure-based traps.

KILOTONSHELL (Joro) ♥♥ PART
Bugs don't know what a kiloton is, but it certainly *sounds* heavy.
Benefit: You are impossible to push, pull, pick up, throw, or swallow against your will.

RAMSHELL (Capra) ♥♥•♥ PART
There's only ever one answer - charge!
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Bash.

STONESHELL (Doko) ♥♥•♥ PART
You're naturally rock-like, an impregnable little fortress of a bug that can shrug off big hits with ease.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when defending with Shield.

HORNSHELL (Ispro) ♥•♥ PART
They say the best defence is a good offence, and you've really taken that to heart.
Benefit: Ignore Armour Cut when using a rumbling skill.

SHIELDSHELL (Govi) ♥♥♥•♥ PART
An unsettlingly mobile crust.
Benefit: When you roll a disaster while trying to defend yourself from a hazard's attack, that hazard takes an inescapable mark of Shield damage.

HUSKSHELL (Guroi) ♥♥♥•♥ PART
Wait... That's not a shell, that's a seed!
Benefit: Each time the weather changes either pull your mood to positive or clear a single mark from this aspect.

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for some classic chitin, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, a Shell can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

ARMOURED (Katra) + •♥♥

Crunch upon crunch.
Benefit: You're resistant to Care and Slash.

BROKEN (Isata) + •♥♥

It might be a hole in your defences, but it's definitely toughened you up over time.
Benefit: The first time in each session you take damage that would break or fully mark one of your tracks, ignore that damage instead.

CHITIN-LAYERED (Aka) + •♥♥

Shell upon shell upon shell.
Benefit: You're resistant to Bash and Scare.

FERRITE (Ynda) + •♥

Too much time playing video games, I'd wager.
Benefit: Burn to magnetise your shell for a moment. If you do this while being attacked with a metal weapon, stun your attacker.

ORNATE (Zala) +♥•♥♥

Some shells are just... *chef's kiss*.

PIECEMEAL (Cakla) +♥

You tend to pick things up as you go.
Benefit: You automatically heal a heart when you successfully hit a Clanky target with a rumbling skill.

RUBBERISED (Boi) + •♥♥

An antikinetic coating.
Benefit: You're resistant to Dance and Fly.

RUGGED (Ko) +•♥

Hard-wearing, but not hard to wear.
Benefit: Once per session, ignore a single instance of damage.

SEGMENTED (Kli) +♥♥♥

Long and flexible, your shell is a series of segments made to twist and curve.
Benefit: Mark a heart to *grab* a nearby target without having to roll as part of any action.

SHINY (Hin) +♥

You reflect light in unusual ways, your kaleidoscopic carapace polished to a near-reflective sheen.
Benefit: When in darkness, reduce any Camo Cut you and your allies suffer by 1.

SPIKY (Kiri) +•♥

Ouch!
Benefit: Any hazard that pushes, pulls, or grabs you takes inescapable Slash damage.

TRANSPARENT (Whi) +♥

Your insides are inside - you know this for a fact, because you can see them.
Benefit: Burn to treat Scare as Gigascare for an action.

WIDE (Gibu) +•♥

For protecting friends.
Benefit: Each ally can use your Shield skill ranks in place of their own once per scene, as long as they're nearby when they do so.

WOOLLY (Fwafwa) +♥

You're soft to the touch, with a downy covering like a pillow of dreams.
Benefit: When other bugs rest near you during a montage, they heal one additional heart.
Drawback: Whenever you would take Armour Cut, increase it by 1.

WHIRLIGIG (Teko) +♥

Curl yourself into an armoured ball when threatened!
Benefit: Burn to treat Shield as Gigashield for an action.

SLIME

OVERVIEW

The great leveller, if rumour is to be believed, there's nothing that gets people as unexpectedly horizontal as unexpected slime. When you take Slime as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want slipperiness or stickiness to be a big deal for your character.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you're not slimy! You might have a thin coating of gunk, or leave a trail in your wake that quickly dries. But remember, whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE SLIME?

- Because you want to be wormish, and you don't care who knows it
- Because you enjoyed slip'N'slides as a child
- Because splashing about shouldn't be restricted to the pondside
- Because you want to be the most disgusting kind of stealthy

ASK YOURSELF...

- Do you clean up after you've passed through?
- Do you revel in warm environments, or avoid them for fear of drying out?
- What colour is your own personal slime?

SPAWNCLOAK (Hachu) ♥•♥•♥ PART

Carrying your family with you as a slimy cloak grants a great deal of moral support!
Benefit: When this track breaks, choose an ally. They ignore the next instance of damage they'd take.

FOULTRAIL (Boo) ♥♥♥ PART

Okay, that genuinely is disgusting.
Benefit: You're impossible to swallow, and gain resistance to Bite.
Drawback: Increase any Tough Cut you suffer while using a friending skill by 1.

HALLUCINO-GLOP (Buh) ♥♥•♥ PART

All the fear of a scarecrow packed into a tiny bugly package.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Scare.

KLEPTOTOXIN (Yoiku) ♥•♥ PART

You want to use poison? *On me?*
Benefit: Whenever you would take damage from a poison or toxin, either clear a mark on this aspect or steal the spotlight to immediately deal a mark of inescapable Sizzle Damage to a nearby target.

CAPSUCCINO (Haca) ♥♥♥ PART

A slime of spice and bitterness.
Benefit: Pull your mood positive whenever you consume a spicy bit or bob for any reason.

GOOEYSHELL (Splaga) ♥♥♥♥ PART

Not actually a shell, more a coating of slimy you-stuff that holds the rest of you inside it.
Benefit/Drawback: You're a slippery customer - you can't be grabbed or held by friend or foe!

VENOMCOAT (Saasa) ♥♥•♥ PART

Better to keep the acid on the outside, don't you think?
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Sizzle.

BARRICADE PLASM (Enga) ♥♥ PART

Mixed precisely to nauseate a particular threat.
Benefit: Choose a hazard type: *Bugly*, *Beastly*, *Scaly*, *Slimy*, *Feathery*, *Leafy*, *Shroomy*, *Clanky*, or *Ghostly*. You are resistant to damage from your chosen hazard type (no matter the damage type they deal).

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for some gratifying goo, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, Slime can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

ACRID (Ghavi) +♥♥

Smelled out from a mile away.
Benefit: Consume a bit to confuse the noses of any nearby hazards.

BEADING (Grei) +♥♥

A natural orbacular process.
Benefit: As a task, you may pull your mood negative to gain a bit, either 'Condensed Glop' or 'Slime-Pearl'.

CLAMMY (Wova) +♥♥

The sensation, not the mollusc.
Benefit: Mark a heart to render a nearby target incapable of pushing or pulling you or any allies (until they dry themselves off).

GOOPIFYING (Bleu) +♥♥

Your shell is coated with a thick layer of slime.
Benefit: Mark to render a nearby target incapable of grabbing you or any allies (until they clean off your goopy slime remnants).

GRITLING (Gere) +♥♥

Now, do you want more or less friction? I can do either!
Benefit: Re-roll dice pool results of 1 when trying to push or pull, or resist being pushed or pulled.

HAZED (Hazu) + •♥♥

Words and teeth, equally mazed.
Benefit: You're resistant to Bite and Yap.

MAGNIFYING (Mushu) +♥

When your slime catches the light just right...
Benefit: When you roll a twist with a Rummage action, gain a bit or bob appropriate to the situation as well as any other usual rewards.

REACTIVE (Riri) +•♥

There are warning signs for a reason.
Benefit: Any hazard that pushes, pulls, or grabs you takes inescapable Sizzle damage.

REFRACTIVE (Glisu) + •♥♥

A scattering sort of slime.
Benefit: You're resistant to Sense and Hunt.

SLITHERY (Xori) +♥

Low to the ground, a master of slipping by undetected.
Benefit: Burn to treat Slink as Gigaslink for an action.

SPICED (Tibo) +•♥♥

Too strong for you, am I?
Benefit: A conflict or triumph when using Sizzle instantly frees you from any grab, in addition to any other effects.

SQUISHY (Oo) +•♥

You? You couldn't be dangerous, look how *cute* you are!
Benefit: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 when trying to change a stubborn individual's mind.

STREAMLINED (Skree) +♥

Perfect for slipping through water without leaving a trace.
Benefit: Burn to treat Swim as Gigaswim for an action.

TOXIC (Zi) +♥

There's plenty for everyone.
Benefit: Choose a hazard type: *Bugly*, *Beastly*, *Scaly*, *Slimy*, *Feathery*, *Leafy*, *Shroomy*, *Clanky*, or *Ghostly*. Treat Sizzle as Gigasizzle when attacking targets with the keyword of your choice.

FEELERS

OVERVIEW

When eyes don't quite do it for you, there's always the choice to get a more outre with your sensory organs. When you take a set of Feelers as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want to be the kind of bug that notices things others don't manage to.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you don't have any feelers at all! Antennae are a common sight in the bugly world, yours just might not give you much in the way of an advantage - remember, whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE FEELERS?

» Because you want to see with more than your eyes
» Because you might not have eyes, but don't want to miss out on the wonders of the Mysteriocalypse
» Because they look kinda cute
» Because you love tickling people from a distance

ASK YOURSELF...

» What threat or opportunity have you sensed that others in your little crew missed?
» Do you use your Feelers to augment your personal style at all, through positioning or adornment?
» What sense do you not have, but really really wish you did?

INFRATENNAE (Lifo) ♥♥♥♥ PART

Why confine your senses to the world of boring old eye-based vision?
Benefit: You 'see' heat as well as others see colour.
Benefit: Reduce any Camo Cut inflicted by hazards by 1.

WHISKERS (Ludo) ♥♥♥♥ PART

A combination of sensory organ and fashion statement, waving whiskers that demand to be preened.
Benefit: You 'see' through vibrations, as long as you're in contact with the ground.
Benefit: Mark this track when you would be surprised by a ground-based hazard to ignore the effect.

BRISTLEMANE (Leo) ♥♥♥ PART

Ever wanted a little biological ruff to wear? Well your prayers have been answered.
Benefit: You 'see' the world through the movement of the very air around you.
Benefit: Mark this track when you would be surprised by an aerial hazard to ignore the effect.

PSYTENNAE (Labo) ♥♥ PART

Seeing the past, the present, and the future? Tough gig.
Benefit: Once per scene, you may pull your mood negative to identify either a weakness, resistance, or immunity of a hazard you can see.

MUSTACHIOTENNAE (Lega) ♥•♥ PART

Luxurious, the soup strainer of a true gourmet.
Benefit: When you would gain a bit, you may mark to remove a negative tag from it (if it has one).

BROOMTENNAE (Logi) ♥•♥ PART

The second oldest form of feelers.
Benefit: When you would gain a bob, you may mark to remove a negative tag from it (if it has one).

PINPOINTENNAE (Zio) ♥♥•♥ PART

It's not that you never miss, it's that your enemies *assume* you never miss.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Hunt.

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for some scintillating sensors, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, Feelers can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

DANCING (Abra) +♥

There's pleasure in gesture.
Benefit: Triumphs while using friending skills pull your mood to either positive or negative (your choice).

DETACHABLE (Oopsi) +♥

Better to flee and live another day.
Benefit: Mark this track to prevent your band from being surprised during a journey.

DUNGOURMET (Kako) +♥♥

No point letting waste go to waste...
Benefit: Your mood pulls positive and you clear a mark from any heart track whenever you encounter animal... 'leavings'... in the wild (is that the most polite way to say this?).

FEATHERY (Awa) +•♥

More soft sensations for your bugly buck.
Benefit: Treat disasters as conflicts when reacting to traps and environmental hazards.

HAIR-TRIGGER (OBERO) +♥

Even the slightest disturbance is a beacon to you.
Benefit: Burn to treat Sense as Gigasense for an action.

OVERHANGING (Aba) +♥♥♥

A naturally evolved source of shade.
Benefit: Mark to count yourself as being in darkness for the rest of the scene, regardless of your surroundings.

QUIVERING (Jali) + •♥♥

Trust is a commodity difficult to earn.
Benefit: You're resistant to Climb and Tame.

RADIANT (Rai) +♥♥♥

Hang those lamps, captain!
Benefit: Mark to count yourself as being in light for the rest of the scene, regardless of your surroundings.

RAZOR-EDGED (Xei) +♥

Your feelers have that dangerous feeling to them.
Benefit: Choose a hazard type: *Bugly*, *Beastly*, *Scaly*, *Slimy*, *Feathery*, *Leafy*, *Shroomy*, *Clanky*, or *Ghostly*. Treat Slash as Gigaslash when attacking targets with the keyword of your choice.

SUREFIRE (Batra) +♥♥♥

Once you've got something in your sights, you almost never let it go.
Benefit: Mark to treat a disaster as a conflict when attacking.

TARGET-LOCK (Zizo) +♥♥

Dead to rights.
Benefit: Mark to lock on to a single hazard you can see for the rest of the scene. While locked on, ignore any Speed Cut or Camo Cut that hazard imposes.

UMBRELLISH (Dryo) +•♥

Flared and channeled to keep the bug below them dry.
Benefit: You suffer no penalties of any kind from rainy or stormy weather, instead pulling your mood to positive whenever this kind of weather begins.

SCUTTLERS

OVERVIEW

While some make their way from A to B by being dragged, pushed, or carried (usually as food or an honoured guest, maybe both), many prefer to get their scuttle on. Your legs aren't just there, they're notable - when you take Scuttlers as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want movement and motion to be a big deal for your character.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you don't have legs! Lots of bugs have scuttlers that don't stand out at all, even if they come in vast (or unexpectedly small) numbers. But remember, whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE SCUTTLERS?

- Because you want to dance with the best of them
- Because speed is important to you
- Because the best way to deal with danger is to run
- Because you want to show a bit of ankle, not that bugs actually have ankles

ASK YOURSELF...

- Do you have the same number of Scuttlers now that you started with? The world's a dangerous place, after all...
- When you move, is it with the grace of a trained athlete or the ungainly totter of a librarian holding too many books?
- Do you wear boots? Do you know what boots are?

HEXAPOD (Gorzo) ♥♥•♥ PART

How many limbs? The usual six, please!
Benefit: Choose either *Push* or *Pull*. You're immune to the chosen effect.

ARACHNOPOD (Gyaxa) ♥♥ PART

Eight legs is more than most, but it's just right for you.
Benefit: Whenever you stop to camp on a journey, take two tasks instead of one during your montage.

CENTAPOD (Kyato) ♥♥♥ PART

Fifty pairs is rather greedy, don't you think?
Benefit: When rolling with Dash, a triumph boosts it to Gigadash for that action.

MILLIPOD (Brato) ♥♥♥ PART

You have more limbs than you know what to do with!
Benefit: Ignore cut of any type imposed by facing a swarm or an overwhelming number of hazards.

QUADRAPOD (Tetro) ♥♥•♥ PART

Four? Really? Alright...
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when defending with Dance.

BIPOD (Grifo) ♥♥♥•♥ PART

Now this is just getting ridiculous.
Benefit: When you're grabbed by a hazard, you can immediately relocate the two of you to a new position (even if you're the smaller, weaker party in the grab).

ZEROPOD (Brani) ♥•♥♥♥ PART

You don't have legs in the traditional sense, but you can slide and slither with the best of them!
Benefit: When you're leading the band on a journey, ignore weather effects that would slow your progress.

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for some legendary limbs, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, Scuttlers can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

ADRENALIZED (Chaba) +•♥♥

Rest is for the weak!
Benefit: Reduce Speed Cut by 1 when using a moving skill.

AWKWARD (Kiwi) +♥•♥•♥

Grace is just another five-letter word to you.
Drawback: Increase any Speed Cut you suffer by 1.

BARRELDOWN (Choji) +♥

It's not just speed, but when to accelerate.
Benefit: Choose a hazard type: *Bugly*, *Beastly*, *Scaly*, *Slimy*, *Feathery*, *Leafy*, *Shroomy*, *Clanky*, or *Ghostly*. Treat Bash as Gigabash when attacking targets with the keyword of your choice.

DODGY (Oosu) +•♥♥

Momentary movements mitigate mashing.
Benefit: You're resistant to Slink and Shield.

DOUBLE-KNEE'D (Kachun) +♥

Knee, ankle, knee... Wait, what?
Benefit: Burn to treat Dance as Gigadance for an action.

HARDPOINT (Kizi) +♥•♥

Like a biological set of pitons.
Benefit: Treat conflicts as triumphs when climbing difficult surfaces.

PNEUMATIC (Qlado) +♥

Aren't all buggish limbs pneumatic, at the end of the day? I should probably research that one...
Benefit: You gain three extra slots for bits & bobs.

POISED (Redi) +♥

If you had heels, you'd be rocking on them.
Benefit: Treat results of 3, 2, or 1 as the same number when checking for doubles while using a moving skill.

PROSTHETIC (Khle) +•♥

One or more of your little limbs has been replaced by a wooden stand-in, either knocked together in an afternoon or delicately carven and formed.
Benefit: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 when tackling difficult terrain.

SKIMMING (Swoo) +♥

Sometimes you just want to break a few natural laws.
Benefit: You can walk on the surface of water as though it were solid ground.

SONOROUS (Lala) +•♥

Boy, those legs can really sing!
Benefit: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 when performing music.

STOMPING (Bakomi) +♥

Footfalls so heavy others might mistake you for a beast.
Benefit: Burn to treat Bash as Gigabash for an action.

WHEELED (Rolo) +♥

How did you manage to evolve these?
Benefit: Burn to treat Dash as Gigadash for a single action.

GRIPPERS

OVERVIEW

Sure, you could make do with a spike or a nub, but there's something tantalizing about the concept of opposable thumbs (or a really big claw). You don't just have legs, you've got noticeable arms - when you take Grippers as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want grasping, thwacking, or manipulating to be a big deal for your character.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you don't have arms! Lots of bugs have claws or little grabbing-bits. But remember, whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE GRIPPERS?

- Because you want to hold many things
- Because you always wanted to play the piano
- Because the world is an easier place when you can throw people a quick thumb's up
- Because claws are cool, and scary!

ASK YOURSELF...

- Are your grippers fully functional, or really just for show?
- Do you have arms in the traditional sense, or merely Grippers attached to one (or more) of your pairs of legs (if you even have legs)?
- Have you ever lost a single glove?

SNAPPIN' CLAWS (Snik) ♥♥♥ PART

Sharper and more simple than a hand could ever be.
Benefit: When rolling with Slash, a triumph boosts it to Gigaslash for that action.

CRUSHIN' CLAWS (Cala) ♥♥♥ PART

For situations where pressure matters.
Benefit: When rolling with Bash, a triumph boosts it to Gigabash for that action.

PINCERS (Snoli) ♥♥♥ PART

You choose your moment and choose your mark, then unleash a snappy flurry.
Benefit: Ignore Complex Cut when using a rumbling skill.

BULLET-SNAPPER (Joi) ♥♥♥ PART

Fast enough to boil water, or so they say.
Benefit: Ignore Speed Cut when using a rumbling skill.

CRESCENT SCYTHES (Skai) ♥♥♥ PART

Shaped like the cruelest mantid moon.
Benefit: Ignore Armour Cut when in darkness.

FINGERLINGS (Yezo) ♥♥♥ PART

Some say it's unnatural for a bug to have fingers. They're probably right, to be fair, but you can't deny their usefulness.
Benefit: Treat disasters as conflicts when gathering or scrounging.

TARSALS (Tar) ♥♥♥ PART

A classic insect claw, hard enough to break incoming strikes.
Benefit: Any damage you assign to this aspect is reduced by one mark.

TENDRILS (Squirmu) ♥♥ PART

This is certainly a choice, evolutionarily speaking.
Benefit: Once per scene, pull your mood negative when near an NPC that trusts you (or a stunned hazard) to 'liberate' a small bit or bob from their person without them noticing (supplied by the Weaver).

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for some masterful manipulators, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, Grippers can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

CARRYING (Hevo) +♥♥

A bugly Sisyphus, if you replace the rock with some shopping bags.
Benefit: You gain one extra slots for bits and bobs, and begin the game with two additional bits and bobs of your choice.

CHURNING (Voli) +♥

You learned from the moles.
Benefit: Burn to increase Dig to Gigadig for a single action.

DOUBLE-EDGED (Awawa) +♥♥♥

If I go down, I'm taking you with me!
Benefit: Once per scene, burn to ignore all cut on an action using a rumbling skill.

INDEXED (Xera) +♥

Everything has a place it should be, and you delight in making the world just a little bit more ordered.
Benefit: Triumphs while using finding skills pull your mood to either positive or negative (your choice).

HEALING (Sai) +♥

You tend to make others feel at ease.
Benefit: When you help to heal another bug, increase the amount of hearts they clear by 1.

HOOKED (Lupi) +♥

Ever felt like just hanging around, taking some weight off? You'd be surprised how relaxing it is.
Benefit: Burn to increase Climb to Gigaclimb for an action.

SCAMPERING (Kidiki) +♥

Hey, that's what legs are for!
Benefit: Once per scene, pull your mood to the negative to ignore all cut on an action using a moving skill.

SOOTHING (Ekoa) +♥

You talk with your hands, and your words are honey.
Benefit: Treat results of 3, 2, or 1 as the same number when checking for doubles while using a friending skill.

SORTING (Saso) +♥♥

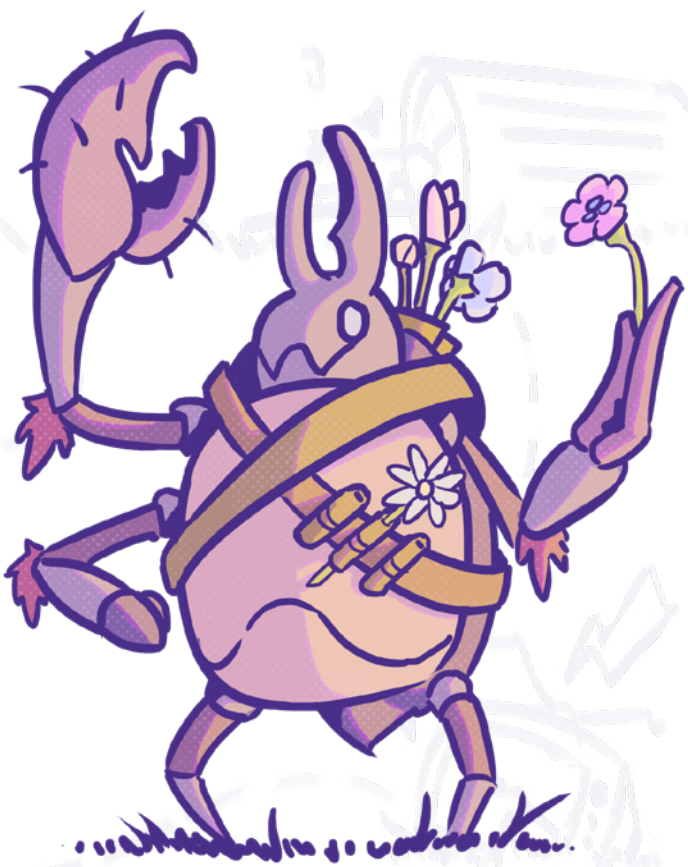
That one here, that one over there, that one for future categorization...
Benefit: Reduce Complex Cut by 1 when using a finding skill.

STICKY (Glop) +♥

There's an old saying about sticky fingers.
Benefit: Whenever a bit or bob would be consumed for any reason, mark this track to keep it instead.

TENACIOUS (Tarka) +♥

One hundred pounds of pressure... Maybe.
Benefit: When you roll a triumph against a grabbed target, pull your mood positive.



WINGS

OVERVIEW

There's something alluring about the skies, especially if you're a confident sort that can ignore the terror of being a moving snack on a big blue dinner plate. When you take Wings as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want movement, flight, and brilliance to be core components of your bug.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you don't have wings! Lots of bugs have stubby winglets, or fly through stranger methods. But remember, whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE WINGS?

- Because you want to soar
- Because aerial dominance is a fast track to victory
- Because one of the best ways to exit an embarrassing situation is to just shoot straight up into the sky
- Because wings are undoubtedly impressive

ASK YOURSELF...

- Do you fly as a matter of course, or only on special occasions?
- How do you deal with aerial predators?
- What's your wing-based self-care routine? Do they take much maintenance?

DRONEWINGS (Erono) ♥•♥♥ PART

Notable not for their appearance, but the ominous sound they produce and the weight they can hoist.
Benefit: You gain two extra carry slots for bits and bobs.

WIDEWINGS (Rogi) ♥♥♥ PART

Perfectly designed to spread out in an emergency.
Benefit: You can land from any height without taking damage, even if your fall was unexpected.

FLUTTERFLAPS (Roza) ♥♥ PART

Steady flight? There's no such thing.
Benefit: You are impossible for hazards to grab or pull while airborne.

VIBRAWINGS (Dandan) ♥♥ PART

Twitch reflexes in transparent form.
Benefit: Ignore Speed Cut when defending yourself.

SILK BALLOON (Uswi) ♥♥♥ PART

Not actually a wing in any way, shape, or form, but still a method of getting airborne!
Benefit: When camped, mark to rise into the air without using a task, getting a 360 degree look at your surroundings and preventing surprise attacks.

COPTERS (Heli) ♥♥♥ PART

Part of you spins fast enough to send you airborne. Let's hope it's not the head.
Benefit: You take no cut while flying when carrying a grabbed individual (friend or foe).

BOMBERWINGS (Neio) ♥♥•♥ PART

For swift dives and heavy impacts.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Fly.

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for some fantastic flappers, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, Wings can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

CARAPACE-COVERED (Cabra) +♥

A shiny shell covers your wings, hinging out of the way when you need to fly.
Benefit: Damage dealt to this track by rumbling skills is reduced by one mark.

EVER-BEATING (Ka) +♥♥♥

Solid ground is for suckers.
Benefit: As long as you have two empty carry slots, you gain immunity to Dig damage.

FEATHERBRACED (Grii) +♥

One bird's loss is another bug's gain.
Benefit: You automatically heal a heart when you successfully hit a feathery target with a rumbling skill.

HYDROPHOBIC (Splek) + •♥♥

Like water off a bug's back.
Benefit: You're resistant to Sizzle and Swim.

ICARIZED (Relio) +♥

I'm not going to warn you again.
Benefit: Burn to increase Fly to Gigafly for an action.

JINKY (Eji) + •♥♥

Gotta get outta the way!
Benefit: You're resistant to Dash and Dig.

MASK-PATTERNED (Tenco) +♥

If you were on stage, the audience would be gasping.
Benefit: Burn to increase Dazzle to Gigadazzle for an action.

SHADOWED (Nocto) +♥

A living eclipse.
Benefit: When flying in darkness, ignore Tough and Complex Cut on any actions involving movement or stealth.

SHATTERING (Fwapo) +•♥

They say a bug can break a man's arm with the beat of a wing, but I might have remembered that wrong.
Benefit: Any hazard that pushes, pulls, or grabs you takes inescapable Bash damage.

SHELTERING (Rufo) +♥

Come huddle where it's warm.
Benefit: When you use a task to heal (either naturally or by rolling), choose one ally to receive the same amount of healing you manage for yourself for free.

SILENT (Shewn) + •♥

There's a lot to be said for speed and silence combined.
Benefit: Treat disasters as conflicts when trying to be stealthy while airborne.

SOLARPUMP (Helio) +♥

It may be radiation, but it's *enervating* radiation!
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut on moving skills when in light.

GLANDS

OVERVIEW

You know that weird, wobbly internal process that defies explanation? We're 90% sure that's a gland of some sort. Don't fact-check this one though. When you take a Gland as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want the creation and unexpected uses of bits and bobs to be a core feature of your character.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you don't have... uhh... Glands? Most bugs probably have a gland or two, it's just that these are really special. But remember, whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE A GLAND?

- Because you want an extra dose of mysterious biology
- Because it's what's on the inside that counts
- Because you want to break a few rules and blame it on evolution
- Because the biggest mystery, at the end of the day, is always in your own heart (or spleen)

ASK YOURSELF...

- Is your Gland visible, or purely internal?
- How does it look, and is the function obvious from its appearance?
- Have you always had this Gland, or is it oddly recent?

HYPER-GLAND (Yayo) ♥♥ PART

Such speed! Such terrible, awesome speed!
Benefit: Consume a sweet bit to treat any skill you're using to move with speed as a gigaskill for an action.
Benefit: Mark or use a task to produce a bit, either 'Cold Sweat' or 'Adrenaline Droplet'.

GLOOMSPOUT (Asho) ♥♥ PART

An organic volcano of darkness.
Benefit: Consume a shadowish bit to plunge an area into darkness for the rest of a scene.
Benefit: Mark or use a task to produce a bit, either 'Shadow Grains' or 'Curling Smoke'.

BIOBATTERY (Volto) ♥♥ PART

BZZZZTTT!!!
Benefit: Consume a sparkish bit to douse an area in flickering light for the rest of a scene.
Benefit: Mark or use a task to produce a bit, either 'Living Spark' or 'Crackling Arc'.

LACTOZZLE (Lakto) ♥♥ PART

Something about this makes other bugs uncomfortable.
Benefit: Consume a milky bit to deny a nearby hazard either Armour Cut or Camo Cut for an ally's action.
Benefit: Mark or use a task to produce a bit, either 'Bug Milk' or 'Chitin Cream'.

SPINNERET (Wei) ♥♥ PART

Beloved by spiders all across the post-Mysteriocalypse.
Benefit: Consume a sticky bit to set a trap, which stuns a target if they blunder into it.
Benefit: Mark or use a task to produce a bit, either 'Raw Silk' or 'Sticky Glob'.

OVIPOSITOR (Ovo) ♥♥ PART

A pouch and a tube is all you really need.
Benefit: Consume an eggish bit to add a new weakness to a nearby hazard, which lasts until that hazard's next track break.
Benefit: Mark or use a task to produce a bit, either 'Grub Egg' or 'Royal Jelly'.

MELLIFLUX (Mo) ♥♥ PART

Surely you're sweet enough already?
Benefit: Consume a sweet bit to benefit from a fully marked aspect track until end of scene.
Benefit: Mark or use a task to produce a bit, either 'Flowing Honey' or 'Leftover Pollen'.

TOXOPUMP (Vui) ♥♥ PART

Handle with care, or (more sensibly) not at all.
Benefit: Consume a poisonish bit to boost the impact of your Sizzle actions until end of scene.
Benefit: Mark or use a task to produce a bit, either 'Toxic Droplet' or 'Poison Barb'.

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for some brilliant biology, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, a Gland can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

APOSEMATIC (Iska) +♥

A clash of vicious colours.
Benefit: Ignore the first instance of damage dealt to you by a hazard in each scene.
Drawback: Whenever you would take Camo Cut, increase it by 1.

BIOWISE (Biozo) +♥

You know which bits go where... Usually.
Benefit: Burn to increase Care to Gigacare for an action.

CORRECTIVE (Fao) +♥

Nothing that a bit of spit and polish can't fix.
Benefit: When you take a montage, you may use a task to convert a burn on either yourself or an ally into a mark (without rolling, or using any bits or bobs).

JITTERY (Jiji) +•♥♥

Always on high alert, perpetually burning out.
Benefit: Treat conflicts as triumphs when making an Action Roll with a rumbling skill.
Drawback: Take a mark of Sizzle damage and pull your mood negative whenever you roll a disaster with a rumbling skill.

OVERACTIVE (Boxo) +♥•♥

Why turn it off when it's a useful feature?
Benefit: When using a finding skill, you can choose to treat a triumph as a conflict to add a twist to the roll (even if there were no doubles).

OVERCHARGED (Neovo) +♥

An unexpected move, just in the nick of time!
Benefit: Once per scene, steal the spotlight to move to a dramatic position with a similarly dramatic yell.

PHEROMONAL (Yaga) +♥♥♥

A comforting aura, literally and chemically.
Benefit: Once per scene, burn to ignore all cut on an action using a friending skill.

SELF-ABSORBED (Io) +♥♥

As hard as a spoon.
Benefit: Re-roll dice pool results of 1 when trying to stun, or to resist being stunned.

SERENE (Halo) +♥

The wind in the trees, the sun on your shell...
Benefit: Using a task to heal (either naturally or by rolling) allows you to pull your mood to positive in addition to any other effects.

SUNBURST (Tri) +♥♥

Sometimes, an explosive burst of sweet and sticky liquid is just what the doctor ordered.
Benefit: Mark a heart to render a nearby target incapable of swallowing you or any allies (until they clean the stickiness from their chops).

TRUMPETING (Tocka) +♥♥♥

A taste in the air - the flavour of unlikely success.
Benefit: Once per scene, allow an ally to treat a disaster as a conflict.

UNAPPETIZING (Blid) +•♥♥♥

You're unexpectedly bitter, perhaps?
Benefit: Any foe that attempts to swallow you (whether successful or not) takes inescapable Gigasizzle damage.

TAILS

OVERVIEW

A bit of an odd one, this - no bugs *really* have tails, but quite a few of them have exoskeletal pieces that work a lot *like* tails, or that vaguely resemble tails, or that are, you know, at the back of their body. So, in the interest of simplicity... tails! When you take a Tail as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want length, balance, or stinging danger to be core components of your bug.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you don't have a tail! Who knows, you might just have a long body, or a tailish bit. But remember, whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE A TAIL?

- Because you want something to whip back and forth when you're impersonating a cat
- Because you want to keep the venom as far away from the rest of you as possible
- Because they're an excellent statement piece
- Because it's better to lose a tail than a head

ASK YOURSELF...

- Come on, be honest - is it really a tail?
- Does dragging that thing around leave a trail for others to follow, or do you hold it proudly aloft?
- If you have a stinger, what colour is the tip? Does it drip toxic stuff? Does it make an audible sizzling sound?

WHIP-TAIL (Engah) ♥♥•♥ PART
Perhaps not the intended purpose, but offers quite a *cutting* answer nonetheless!
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Slash.

CONSTRICTOR (Tero) ♥♥•♥♥ PART
Encircling is easy, it's the squeeze that takes effort!
Benefit: Burn to stun a target you have grabbed.

STINGER (Joza) ♥♥ PART
An absolute classic, beloved by scorpions and bees.
Benefit: Criticals with a rumbling skill give you extra giga damage rather than the usual single mark.

SHOVELSTUB (Girino) ♥♥♥ PART
You've learned from the moles, even if they didn't mean to teach you.
Benefit: You are impossible for hazards to grab or pull while tunneling.

STEGOSLAPPER (Stega) ♥♥ PART
Made for wide sweeps and wider swishes.
Benefit: Treat disasters as conflicts when targeting a hazard with the Lackey keyword.

FLAGELLUM (Flage) ♥♥♥♥ PART
Flagellums may have fallen out of fashion over the years, but you've never been one to abandon a trend.
Benefit: Ignore any cut caused by the direction, temperature, or speed of water while swimming.

AEROTAIL (Ago) ♥♥♥♥ PART
Long and slim, built for the kind of balance that a cat might take for granted (if they could fly).
Benefit: Ignore any cut caused by crosswinds, temperature, or windspeed while flying.

PEACOCK (Kromi) ♥♥♥♥ PART
There are only so many colours you can cram into a small space before things get confusing.
Benefit: Burn to stun a nearby hazard.

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for an extended exoskeleton, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, a Tail can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

BALANCED (Evoi) +♥

Allows for quicker turns and defter strikes.
Benefit: Treat results of 3, 2, or 1 as the same number when checking for doubles while using a rumbling skill.

BARDED (Gakla) +♥♥

An armoured layer to keep everything intact.
Benefit: You're immune to Slash.

CLUMSY (Musmus) +♥

Slam into enough stuff and eventually something interesting will fall into your lap.
Benefit: Pull your mood to the negative to treat a disaster as a conflict while using a finding skill.

COILED (Rebia) +•♥

A naturally-grown spring for storing power.
Benefit: Treat results of 1 as if they were results of 6 when using a moving skill.

LACONIC (Lazo) +♥

Nothing shows you don't really care quite as much as a lazy tail-stretch.
Benefit: Burn to increase Swagger to Gigaswagger for an action.

POISONPOINT (Skri) +♥

Little wisps of smoke escape when you stretch. No touching, please!
Benefit: When you're attacked by a foe up close, roll a d6. On a 6, they take inescapable Gigasizzle damage.

PUFFBALL (Osala) +•♥

The cutest possible burst.
Benefit: Once per scene, when this track breaks, allow one of your allies to clear every mark on one of their own aspect tracks.

QUICKSHED (Zono) +•♥

Let me slip into something more zoomable.
Benefit: When this aspect's track breaks, ignore Speed Cut for the rest of the scene.

SCYTHING (Rexi) +♥

Sharper than a razor's edge.
Benefit: Burn to increase Slash to Gigaslash for an action.

SWEEPING (Wusu) +♥

Sometimes it's just a numbers game.
Benefit: Adding Speed Cut to an attack using this aspect allows you to hit multiple nearby targets with a single roll, with a cut of 1 for each additional target.

TRAILING (Dragna) +♥

Needs cleaning often, but look at all that stuff!
Benefit: When you roll a twist while gathering or scrounging, gain an additional bit or bob appropriate to the area (supplied by the Weaver).

TWITCHIFIED (Dididi) +♥•♥

A lucky escape! There but for the flick of a tail go I...
Benefit: You're resistant to all damage from traps, and pull your mood positive whenever you encounter a trap.

BUILD

OVERVIEW

Bugs come in all shapes and sizes, but something about the way *you're* built inspires others to gawp, or at least take a second glance. When you take a Build as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want your physical measurements to have a tangible impact on your play experience.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you're built badly! ***ALL BUGS BEGIN AS SMALL SIZE****, and while the fiction of your character might give you some unusual spatial properties, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.*

WHY CHOOSE A BUILD?

- Because you want to be bigger, or smaller, than the average bug
- Because you want your silhouette to send a message
- Because you want to grab and lift more than most
- Because titans and dust motes can't have all the fun!

ASK YOURSELF...

- Have you always looked like this, or did your size or shape change dramatically after moulting?
- Do you act in accordance with the first impressions you give, or is your build misleading in some way?
- Is this form something naturally bestowed upon you, or something you've had to work at over time?

TANKLING (Ponza) ♥•♥•♥ PART

Some grow tall, but you grew *wide*.
Benefit: Your size is Large, rather than the usual Small. *You can't take any other aspects that permanently change your size.*

DIMINUBUG (Kule) ♥♥♥♥♥ PART

Too small? No such thing.
Benefit: Your size is Nano, rather than the usual Small. *You can't take any other aspects that permanently change your size.*

TALLTOWER (Totio) ♥♥♥ PART

What's the weather like up th... Oh, you've heard that one before, have you?
Benefit: Add an extra 1d6 to lookout rolls taken in clear or good weather.

THIMBLEFRIEND (Ibu) ♥♥♥ PART

You're not *actually* any smaller than the average bug, but there's something about you that just screams 'disarmingly twee'.
Benefit: Boost any offensive action taken against a surprised target.

SWARMFORM (Mimi) ♥•♥♥ PART

You're not actually one bug, you're multiple tiny bugs moving and thinking as a team.
Benefit: You gain an extra task to spend whenever you take part in a montage.
Benefit: Mark to scatter into many nano-sized bugs for a moment, immediately escaping any grab or trap before you reform.
Drawback: You must consume an additional bit to benefit from any bit-based healing.

ANGULOMORPH (Sebiko) ♥♥ PART

A study of your anatomy would baffle even the most worldly and observant.
Benefit: You gain a resistance to all damage from physical long-ranged attacks (like thrown stones and long, grabby tongues).

BLOCKOMORPH (Conco) ♥♥ PART

Rumour has it you moved an arm once, but to most observers you're basically a living statue.
Benefit: You gain a resistance to all damage from physical close-ranged attacks (like chompy bites and being whacked with a stick).

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for a singular scale, you can spend **3 nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, a Build can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 nectar** more.

ACRO (Bata) +•♥

You may wobble, and you may even fall down, but you're going to have a great time doing it.
Benefit: Pull your mood positive whenever you get grabbed or thrown by a hazard.

EXAGGERO (Exa) +♥

You have a singular feature that's far larger than expected. *Don't let it go to your head.*
Benefit: Any benefit on this aspect that would usually require you to mark or burn can be used without doing so once per session of PICO.

FLAT (Sin) +♥♥

Why walk through a door when you can slip under it?
Benefit: Mark to slip through a gap that's far, *far* too small for you.

HENCH (Ugo) +♥

It's all about the shoulder width. Now, if only you could work out what shoulders are...
Benefit: Mark to increase your impact on any friending or rumbling skill when interacting with a hazard that has the Lackey keyword.

HOLLOW (Don) +•♥♥

There's almost nothing to you, physically.
Benefit: Treat conflicts as triumphs when making an Action Roll with a moving skill.
Drawback: You never count as the larger force in a grab.

MEGAMUSCLED (Stro) +♥

Such power should be impossible for a tiny bug!
Benefit: Burn to pick up and carry a chunk. This can be used to help build a titan-den, or be thrown at a hazard for gigadamage (of a type appropriate for the chunk).

INFLATING (Mutino) +♥

Pick on someone your own size!
Benefit: Your size is Small, like most bugs, but you can mark to embiggify your size by one step (to Large) for the rest of a scene. *You can't take this augment if you have any other aspects that permanently change your size.*

ROTUND (Bwunu) +♥

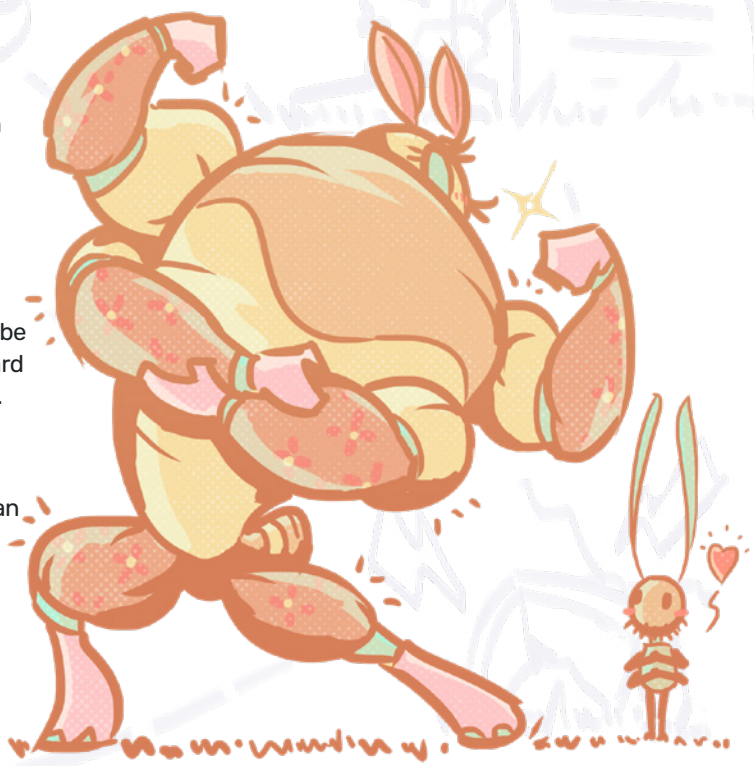
You're the kind of bug that confounds predators and powerlifters alike - so weighty it's impressive!
Benefit: While you can still be grabbed, you can't be pushed, pulled, or thrown by anything smaller than a titan.

SHRINKISH (Mutini) +♥

You look entirely averagely sized, for a bug... Until the time comes for a dramatic and diminutive reveal!
Benefit: Your size is Small, like most bugs, but you can mark to smallificate your size by one step (to Nano) for the rest of a scene. *You can't take this augment if you have any other aspects that permanently change your size.*

STRONGBACK (Ahoni) +♥♥

You have a tendency to overload yourself, which (while impressive) often ends in tears.
Benefit: You gain eight extra slots for bits & bobs.
Drawback: Whenever one of your bits or bobs would gain a negative tag, destroy it completely instead.



BRAIN

OVERVIEW

All bugs can think, but there's a difference between thinking and thinking. Your thoughts are larger, stronger, and deeper than average. When you take a Brain as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want logic, deduction, or even extranormal mental powers to be a big deal for your bug.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you don't have a brain! You've probably got a perfectly fine one, it just isn't what people know you for. But remember, whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE A BRAIN?

- Because knowledge is power
- Because you want to put that college degree to use
- Because you've never found a problem you can't think your way out of
- Because you're a bit of a nerd, and nerds are (so we desperately keep telling ourselves) cool

ASK YOURSELF...

- What's the biggest thought you've ever had?
- When did you realize that thinking was an asset you could leverage, rather than a byproduct of existence?
- When you sleep, do you dream of the world as it is now? Or of how you want to shape it?

MEDI-LOBE (Krosu) ♥•♥ PART

A working knowledge of buggish anatomy actually takes up a surprising amount of brain-space.
Benefit: Treat conflicts as triumphs when rolling to heal the parts or buddies of other bugs.

CHRONEURON (Hekon) ♥♥ PART

Just a little more time to think.
Benefit: Ignore Complex Cut when defending yourself.

SPLIT BRAIN (Akzu) ♥♥ PART

It's amazing where you can cram thinky bits these days.
Benefit: Whenever you would pull your mood to the positive or negative, mark this track to keep it where it is instead.

MIND PALACE (Shishu) ♥♥ PART

Your head is stuffed with a world's worth of knowledge - perhaps not the world you actually live in, but that's just a technicality.
Benefit: Whenever you take a montage, gain a secret about your location (supplied by the Weaver) without using a task.

PSI-PULSER (Psio) ♥♥♥ PART

Now this one's weird, even for a bug - the ability to move objects with your mind!
Benefit: Mark to levitate an object you can see, manipulating it as if you were holding it until end of scene (or until you choose to drop it).

EUREKALING (Urika) ♥♥♥ PART

Constantly dodging apples.
Benefit: Whenever you make a small discovery, gain a bit or bob with a positive tag related to the discovery you've made (supplied by the Weaver).

LOGIC CENTRE (Abace) ♥♥♥♥ PART

Big head? Big brain.
Benefit: Once per scene, you may mark to learn a secret about your current situation from the Weaver.

DIFFERENCE ENGINE (Igi) ♥♥♥ PART

Infinite probabilities, neatly catalogued.
Benefit: Once per session, request a twist to the current situation (this doesn't have to be attached to a roll, but is still decided and developed in the usual way).

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for some neural nodes, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, a Brain can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

DEEPTHOUGHT (Usmi) +♥•♥

Pausing to think for a moment would solve about 90% of impending problems.
Benefit: Pull your mood positive and clear a mark from this aspect whenever you make a small discovery.

INCISIVE (Pifi) + •♥♥

Good data leads to good conclusions.
Benefit: The first time you land a hit on a hazard in each scene, identify either a weakness, resistance, or immunity of that hazard.

LOGICAL (Jide) +♥♥♥

The world is but a complex schematic for you to read.
Benefit: Ignore all cut when trying to safely disarm a trap in the wild.

LUDDITIC (Lud) + •♥♥

Progress? Not on my watch!
Benefit: You're resistant to Rummage and Make.

PATIENT (Tikon) +♥

It's a virtue, but not a particularly enjoyable one.
Benefit: Once per scene, pull your mood to the negative to ignore all cut on an action using a finding skill.

PRECOGNITIVE (Jahi) +♥♥♥

It's going to be right there, trust me.
Benefit: Once per scene, burn to ignore all cut on an action using a finding skill.

PUFFING (Pipo) +♥

Your own little natural thinking-pipe.
Benefit: Burn to increase Think to Gigathink for an action.

SALVING (Rido) +♥•♥

Ahh, now that's a welcome relief.
Benefit: Treat conflicts as triumphs when rolling to heal your own parts or buddies.

STUDIED (Zara) +♥

So much to learn, so little time!
Benefit: Choose a hazard type: *Bugly*, *Beastly*, *Scaly*, *Slimy*, *Feathery*, *Leafy*, *Shroomy*, *Clanky*, or *Ghostly*. Treat Think as Gigathink when attacking targets with the keyword of your choice.

THRUMMING (Done) +♥♥

A byproduct of the deepest cogitations.
Benefit: As a task, you may pull your mood negative to gain a bit, either 'Brain Goo' or 'Crystallized Thought'.

UNKNOWABLE (Auru) + •♥♥

They can't predict your next move if you don't know what it's going to be yet.
Benefit: You're resistant to Chart and Think.

WAVERING (Huso) +•♥

It's not working out how to follow a path that takes effort, merely which one needs following.
Benefit: When this aspect's track breaks, ignore Complex Cut for the rest of the scene.

COMPANIONS

OVERVIEW

All of the options up until now have been parts of you, essential bits of your bug that really stand out.

A Companion is a little different, in that it's not actually a part of you at all! As a 'buddy' aspect, a Companion is a diminutive pet or friend that accompanies you as you roam, anything from a tamed predatory flower to an ever-faithful rock.

As buddy aspects, Companions work almost the same as parts and gear. They're healed the same way, they have the same rules when it comes to tracks and taking damage, and they can be augmented.

Where a companion differs is in matters of...

AUTONOMY!

Companions give you a bit more **narrative freedom** than a body part or piece of gear - they're an extra set of eyes and ears, an extra little scampering scout you can send out there. While they don't allow you to take any extra actions or double up on rolls, they *do* give you the narrative permission to say things like 'I'm going to send my Companion over there to take a look' or 'I think my Companion could squeeze in there...'

*If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that... Well, for once that actually **does** mean you don't have a companion.*

That doesn't mean you don't have friends, but it does mean that you don't have a travelling partner that's dedicated completely to you.

WHY CHOOSE A COMPANION?

- Because a buddy is a bug's best friend
- Because the road gets lonely
- Because you enjoy paying loyalty back with kindness
- Because you want to know something always has your back

ASK YOURSELF...

- Where did you meet your Companion?
- Do they have their own opinions, or do they simply agree with whatever you say?
- Have you ever blamed something on your companion that was definitely your fault?

GRUBLING (Cuti) ♥♥♥•♥ BUDDY

'Help' from a Grubling is often more accidentally dangerous than interference from a foe.
Benefit: When you roll a disaster while trying to defend yourself from a hazard's attack, that hazard takes an inescapable mark of Care damage.

PETALMAW (Miskoi) ♥ BUDDY

It's not easy to domesticate a plant that wants nothing more than to taste your sweetest bugly meats, but somehow you've managed it.
Benefit: Treat conflicts as triumphs when attempting to start or maintain a grab.
Benefit: Ignore Armour Cut on bugly hazards.

PEEPLIZARD (Pyq) ♥♥ BUDDY

Small enough to keep inside a bug-sized jacket's pocket, a truly tiny reptile on high alert at all times.
Benefit: Ignore Camo Cut when defending yourself.

DUST BUNNY (Nico) ♥♥ BUDDY

A hopping, flopping sentinel.
Benefit: When in darkness, any bit you come across gains a positive tag (supplied by the Weaver) if it wouldn't already have one.

GLADPOLE (Ribab) ♥♥♥ BUDDY

Proof that nature and nurture both matter, and also that froglins might once have been pretty cute.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut imposed by Lackeys.

PET ROCK (Neb) ♥♥♥♥♥♥ BUDDY

I mean... it's a rock. What were you expecting?

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for a faithful follower, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, a Companion can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

BLOODTHIRSTY (Ogra) +♥

Release the buddies of war!
Benefit: Triumphs while using rumbling skills pull your mood to either positive or negative (your choice).

ENTOURAGE (Wibi) +•♥

Nodding along in all the right places
Benefit: Boost an action taken to make a surprising accusation or enter dramatically (once per scene).

MEDICATED (Oko) +•♥•♥

Of dubious efficiency and unexpected effect.
Benefit: When you reach a break in this track, roll a d6. On a 6 clear all marks of damage from the entire track.

OVERBURDENED (Grabi) +♥♥

All the benefits of extra limbs with none of that pesky weight to worry about.
Benefit: You gain two extra slots for bits and bobs.

PRANKSTER (Hee) +•♥

Are you the only one that finds this funny?
Benefit: Your mood pulls positive and you clear a mark from any heart track whenever you surprise a target.

PROTECTIVE (Amra) + ♥♥♥

Don't worry friend, I've got your back!
Benefit: Mark to treat a disaster as a conflict when defending.

SIGHTSEEING (Evici) +♥

Ooh, would you look at that!
Benefit: Choose either *landmark, trove, event, weather change, NPC,* or *hazard*. When you or an ally spot your chosen lookout result, pull your mood positive.

SNARING (Suapo) +♥

One of you is the net, the other the tripwire.
Benefit: Burn to treat Hunt as Gigahunt for an action.

SNIFFING (Snuf) + •♥♥

What have you found there, lad? Oh... Oh no.
Benefit: You are resistant to damage from traps (no matter the damage type they deal).

THOROUGH (Twiku) +♥♥

Less than perfect, but better than most.
Benefit: When you roll a conflict while scrounging or gathering, any negative tags added are chosen by you rather than the Weaver.

TIRELESS (Lyno) +•♥

Still bopping long after others have thrown in the towel.
Benefit: When you are part of a wait travel action, gain the benefits of using a rest task for free.

WILD (Xio) +•♥♥

Can't put this one back in the can! Can't really aim it, either, just release and hope.
Benefit: You ignore Armour Cut when using Slash.
Drawback: Double any Speed Cut when using Slash.

ZOOMISH (Ezoi) +♥•♥

You just try to keep up.
Benefit: Once per journey, you and all allies can re-roll your lookout dice, ignoring any original finds and relying on the new results.

MOUNTS

OVERVIEW

Much like Companions, Mounts are buddy aspects - not a part of you, but something that works almost exactly like it *is* a part of you in terms of PICO's rules.

But where Companions are small and cute, Mounts are big and... Uh... Still probably cute. But less cute, on the whole.

And big is a relative term - the largest of the Mounts presented here is the size of a mouse, which makes them kind of horse-like in a world of bugs. Which is appropriate, given that the purpose of a Mount is for you to get on and...

RIDE!

Mounts give you bit more **narrative freedom** than a body part or piece of gear - they're an extra set of eyes and ears, and an extra set of legs under yours that likely move a bit faster than those of the average bug. While they don't allow you to take any extra actions or double up on rolls, they do give you the narrative permission to say things like 'I'm going to spur my Mount on for a burst of speed' or 'I'm pretty sure my Mount can carry that thing in its mouth for a while'.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, then you don't have a Mount - you're doomed to walk everywhere you go.

Unless your party has access to a picotitan, of course. Then you can sit back, relax, and watch the world fly by.

WHY CHOOSE A MOUNT?

- Because your legs hurt
- Because you really love westerns, and riding into unfamiliar towns looking cool
- Because you want to figure out how to sit side-saddle with six legs to manage

ASK YOURSELF...

- Did you have to train your Mount, or did you trade for it at some kind of stables?
- How does your Mount feel about picotitans, and their massive size?
- What's your Mount's favourite food, and how often do you give it treats?

NIGHT-MOUSE (Muni) ♥♥♥ BUDDY

Raised to run tunnels and sneak through the inside of ancient walls.
Benefit: Ignore Speed Cut when in darkness.

SCAMPERFLOWER (Feko) ♥♥♥ BUDDY

Revels in the light and heat of the sun, even when carrying a just-out-of-reach snack.
Benefit: Ignore Speed Cut when in light.

HUMMINGBARD (Dolaso) ♥♥♥ BUDDY

Wherever there's nectar, there's music to be found.
Benefit: Whenever you use a task to Moult, all allies can pull their mood to absolute positive if they wish.

MAGNAPIKE (Mabra) ♥♥♥ BUDDY

An acrobatic darter with metallic scales. Unusually for scaly sorts, this beast seems to prefer air to water. Is it even really a fish?
Benefit: You can use the Swim skill to move through the air as if it was water (essentially allowing you to mimic flight without using the Fly skill).

WARM-WHEELZ (Vrumi) ♥ BUDDY

The extreme style points this car bestows upon you are enough that few realize you're pushing it along with your own feet.
Benefit: Rolling a double on an action using one of the Moving skills allows you to increase your impact in place of taking a twist if you wish.

ACCEL SPINNER (Supunu) ♥ BUDDY

A colourful spinning top that you can just about balance on, known for increasing childlike joy.
Benefit: Whenever an ally marks the combo track, either turn one of your burns into a mark or pull your mood to positive.

ASPECTS & AUGMENTS

If you're in the market for a spectacular steed, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from the page on the left. Once purchased, a Mount can be boosted with up to two augments found below, each costing **2 Nectar** more.

ANTSY (Sunei) +♥

Is this one good enough? How about this one?
Benefit: Once per scene, pull your mood to the negative to add a tag of your choice to any bit or bob you find.

BLOODHOUND (Sugu) +•♥

Just hold on and ride out the snuffles as best you can!
Benefit: When this aspect's track breaks, ignore Camo Cut for the rest of the scene.

BOUNDING (Heku) +•♥

Homeward direction entirely optional.
Benefit: Boost an action taken to leap (once per scene).

COURSING (Gu) +•♥♥

First the nose, then the teeth...
Benefit: You ignore Camo Cut when using Bite.
Drawback: Double any Armour Cut when using Bite.

DUNEKISSED (Kasko) +•♥

A mount made for the sands, if you ever find them.
Benefit: You suffer no penalties of any kind from hot or windy weather, instead pulling your mood to positive whenever this kind of weather begins.

FABLED (Lokrio) +♥•♥

A steed known throughout the lands.
Benefit: Treat conflicts as triumphs when attempting to intimidate or impress a bugly target.

FEISTY (Ah) +♥

Down, boy!
Benefit: Mark to re-roll a single die result from any rumbling action (you must take the new result, no matter the outcome).

FRIENDLY (Suso) +♥

Hey there, little fellow.
Benefit: Burn to increase Tame to Gigatame for an action.

FUZZY (Foo) +♥

You couldn't possibly harm something so adorable!
Benefit: Reduce all damage taken from elites by 1.

PRANCING (Pora) +♥

Sometimes it's just nice to be out and about.
Benefit: Triumphs while using moving skills pull your mood to either positive or negative (your choice).

PREENING (Quivo) +♥♥

Nothing like a dust bath and a good long drink.
Skill: As a task, you may pull your mood negative to gain a bit, either 'Trail Grit' or 'Mount Sweat'.

REASSURING (Tosi) +•♥♥

A gentle presence in every way.
Benefit: Treat conflicts as triumphs when making an action roll with a friending skill.
Drawback: Once per session, you take immediate Gigascare damage when surprised.

SADDLEBAGGED (Ouros) +♥♥

It's not what you hang there, but how you hang it that matters.
Benefit: You gain four extra slots for bits and bobs.
Drawback: Increase any Speed Cut you suffer by 1.

WELL-TRAINED (Hove) +♥♥♥

Precise and orderly, just as you like it.
Benefit: Once per scene, burn to ignore all cut on an action using a moving skill.

TOOLS

OVERVIEW

Bobs come and go, but tools are forever - or at least, as close to forever as a bug can manage. Tools are used to manipulate the world around you in ways that would usually be beyond you. When you take a Tool as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want scrapping and ingenuity and smarts to be a big deal for your character.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, you're certainly not without the ability to piece together random, short-term creations - there's a whole section about it on page 78. But it does mean you don't have any technology that won't, at some point, fall apart. But remember, whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE A TOOL?

- Because biological adaptation is impressive, but there are some marvels even the most advanced body parts struggle to imitate
- Because you like tinkering with things
- Because it's more than your job's worth
- Because you fancy yourself an engineer

ASK YOURSELF...

- Where do you keep your tools, and how do you maintain them?
- Are your Tools self-created, or adapted from the junk leftover after the Mysteriocalypse?
- Do you know what this stuff was *really* for, or are the secrets of the old world less important than the uses of the new?

BACKPACK ♥♥ GEAR

No more balancing bits and bobs on your shell with this new application of science - the BAG!
Benefit: Gain four extra carry slots for bits and bobs.

BOUNTY PAPER ♥♥ GEAR

This town ain't big enough... Literally. That's just a statement of fact.
Benefit: Burn to lock on to a single hazard you can see for the rest of the scene. While locked on, any triumphs rolled against that hazard gain increased impact.

BUBBLE BOTTLE ♥•♥♥ GEAR

Containing liquid that bugly science can't define.
Benefit: Mark or use a task to produce a bob, either 'Floating Bubble' or 'Rainbow Droplet'.

DISPLAY CASE ♥•♥ GEAR

For the proudest of finds.
Benefit: Pull your mood to positive when you find a bit or bob while gathering or scrounging.
Benefit: You gain one extra slot for bits and bobs.

DOCTOR'S BAG ♥•♥ GEAR

I'm sure I've got something in here somewhere...
Benefit: When you roll for recovery during a montage, it doesn't require the consumption of a bit or bob.
Benefit: You gain one extra slot for bits and bobs.

DUCT TAPE ♥♥♥♥ GEAR

Repairs are easy if you don't mind too much about the materials being used.
Benefit: You can consume bits, as well as bobs, when healing marks on your gear during a montage.

HIKING BAG ♥•♥ GEAR

For all those shiny things you find on the way.
Benefit: You gain three extra carry slots for bits and bobs.

HOOK & GRAPPLE ♥♥•♥ GEAR

For added momentum without the loss of safety.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Climb.

LODESTONE ♥♥ GEAR

There's a certain attraction to the forces of attraction.
Benefit: You 'see' both magnetic forces and electrical charges, and treat conflicts as triumphs when reacting to attacks with metal weapons or objects.

ONLY ASPECTS

If you're in the market for some tiny technology, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from these pages. Tools have no associated augments, but up to two augments from elsewhere in this chapter can be added for the usual cost.

LONGSTEM PIPE ♥♥•♥ GEAR

For a meditative puff now and then.
Benefit: Consume a fragrant bit to treat Think as Gigathink for a single action.

MEDUSAN MIRROR-SHARD ♥♥•♥ GEAR

Won't turn things to stone, but can shine a really annoying light in their eyes.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when defending with Dazzle.

MORTAR & PESTLE ♥♥•♥ GEAR

You need to put your back into it! But not literally.
Benefit: When you would consume a bit for any reason, instead give it the 'Powdered' tag and keep it. If you consume a bit with the 'Powdered' tag, it's gone forever.

PICOPANTRY ♥♥ GEAR

You can always be relied upon to rustle up some grub.
Benefit: You gain two extra slots for bits and bobs, and start the game with six extra bits.
Benefit: Any time you take a montage, gain a new bit appropriate for the local environment for free without spending a task (supplied by the Weaver).

POCKET FAN ♥•♥•♥ GEAR

Obviously made for pockets much larger than your own.
Benefit: When this track breaks, choose a nearby hazard. Immediately push them to any position within the environment that you wish.

RADIATOR WIDGET ♥♥♥ GEAR

There's nothing better than marshmallows round a roaring fire, but you're a close second.
Benefit: Whenever you're in a cold or dark area, anyone that heals near you heals an additional heart.

SCRAWL-JOURNAL ♥♥ GEAR

But that means... Ah! AH-HA!
Benefit: Once per session, you may mysteryize during a montage without spending a task.

TRASHKIT ♥♥ GEAR

No bugly engineer would be seen without one.
Benefit: You gain two extra slots for bits & bobs, and start the game with six extra bobs.
Benefit: Any time you take a montage, gain a new bob appropriate for the local environment for free without spending a task (supplied by the Weaver).

TWIG BATON ♥•♥♥ GEAR

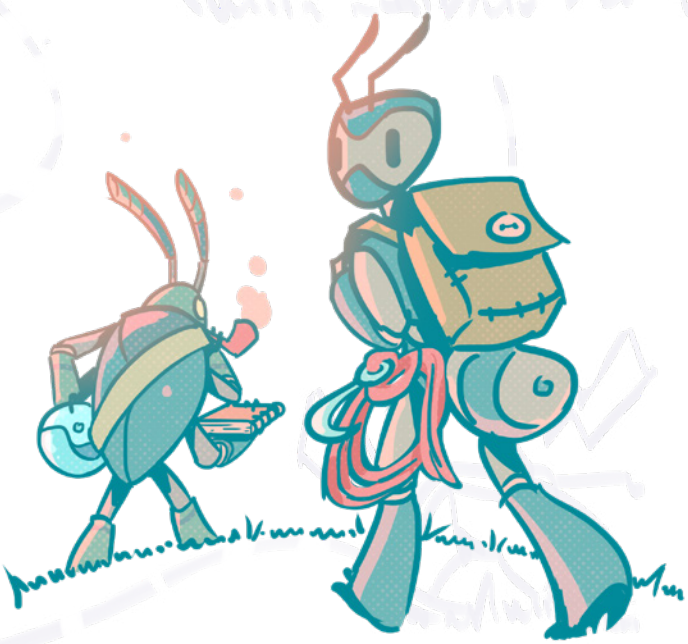
If there's a rhythm to follow, you'll find it.
Benefit: The first time each hazard's track breaks, pull your mood to positive.

WIND-UP KEY ♥♥♥ GEAR

One turn, two turns, three turns, and lift!
Benefit: Consume a mechanical bob to treat any skill you're using to demonstrate strength as a gigaskill for a single action.

VACUUM PUMP ♥♥ GEAR

You're the kind of bug that helps around the house.
Benefit: Reduce all cuts by 1 when gathering bobs.



WEAPONS

OVERVIEW

The world is a wide and worrying place from time to time, and though violence isn't always the answer, it's better to be prepared than to be eaten. When you take a Weapon as an aspect, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want tussling, rumbling, and general combat to be a big deal for your character.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, you're certainly not defenceless - any skill can deal damage in a rumble if you use it right. Maybe you even have something ornamental, an heirloom weapon that looks good but doesn't quite deliver the goods. But remember, whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE A WEAPON?

- Because somebody once told you to carry a big stick
- Because forearmed is forewarned
- Because they are pretty cool to look at, even if they're a bit dangerous
- Because you want to strike fear into the hearts of those who *don't* carry weapons

ASK YOURSELF...

- Did you make your Weapon, or find it?
- What terrifying beast have you slain, or bonked on the head, recently?
- Is your Weapon crafted for a bug your size or adapted from some larger pre-Mysteriocalypse junk?

BOTTLECAP DISCUS ♥•♥ GEAR

Throw it as hard as you like, it'll always come back (if you go and pick it up, that is).
Benefit: You can attack distant hazards with Bash or Slash without incurring cut.

BOTTLECAP SHIELD ♥♥ GEAR

Of dubious effectiveness, and still smells faintly of cola.
Benefit: Ignore Armour Cut when defending yourself.

BROKEN SECATEURS ♥♥ GEAR

The spring is rusty and the handles chipped, but the blades still cut true.
Benefit: Treat disasters as conflicts when attacking a Leafy or Shroomy hazard.

CAN OPENER ♥♥ GEAR

Absurd and unwieldy, but you'd better believe it works.
Benefit: Treat disasters as conflicts when attacking a Scaly or Clanky hazard.

FISHING SPEAR ♥•♥ GEAR

That water isn't as much of a barrier as they think!
Benefit: You can attack hazards lurking underwater without incurring cut while using this aspect.

FLAMESPITTER ♥•♥♥ GEAR

Not much left in the tank, but enough to remind others to stop, drop, and burn!
Benefit: When rolling with Sizzle, a triumph boosts it to Gigasizzle for that action.

HIDDEN NEEDLE ♥♥•♥ GEAR

A most ungentlemanly assault!
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Slink.

GNASH-AXE ♥♥♥ GEAR

Is that a sharpened tooth tied to a stick you're swinging?
Benefit: All actions you take with the Slash skill gain a boost, but treat triumphs as conflicts.
Benefit: Use a task to split one bit or bob into two, giving each the 'Halved' tag (you can't split a bit or bob that already has the Halved tag).

GEARHAMMER ♥♥ GEAR

Made from the innards of an old clock, reinforced with pride and accomplishments.
Benefit: The first attack you make with a Gearhammer in each scene deals giga damage.

ONLY ASPECTS

If you're in the market for some armaments, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from these pages. Weapons have no associated augments, but up to two augments from elsewhere in this chapter can be added for the usual cost.

PAINTER'S BRUSH ♥♥•♥ GEAR

You could be the next Edward Grasshopper!
Benefit: Burn to add a new weakness of your choice to a nearby hazard, once per scene. If the hazard already has an immunity, resistance, or weakness to your type choice, this ability has no effect.

PAPERCRAFT STINGER ♥♥ GEAR

Delivers a whole lot of a nope for such a tiny little jab. And this one's 100% recycled material, too!
Benefit: Consume a paper or ink-based bob to treat Sizzle as Gigasizzle for an action.

PEBBLE-SLING ♥♥ GEAR

Load it up and let 'em fly!
Benefit: Treat disasters as conflicts when attacking a Slimy or Feathery hazard.

SCISSORSWORD ♥•♥♥ GEAR

Pre-Mysteriocalypse craftsmanship of the highest order, a blade as steeped in stories as it is the screams of innocent package-twine.
Benefit: Once per scene you may burn to steal the spotlight for an immediate Slash action that ignores all cut and treats your Slash skill as Gigaslash.

SEWING NEEDLE ♥♥♥♥ GEAR

You bring the danger, darn it!
Benefit: Treat disasters as conflicts when attacking a Beastly hazard.

SHELLHAMMER ♥♥ GEAR

Shell against shell, body against soul!
Benefit: Treat disasters as conflicts when attacking a Bugly or Ghostly hazard.

STEEL-TOE BOOTS ♥♥•♥ GEAR

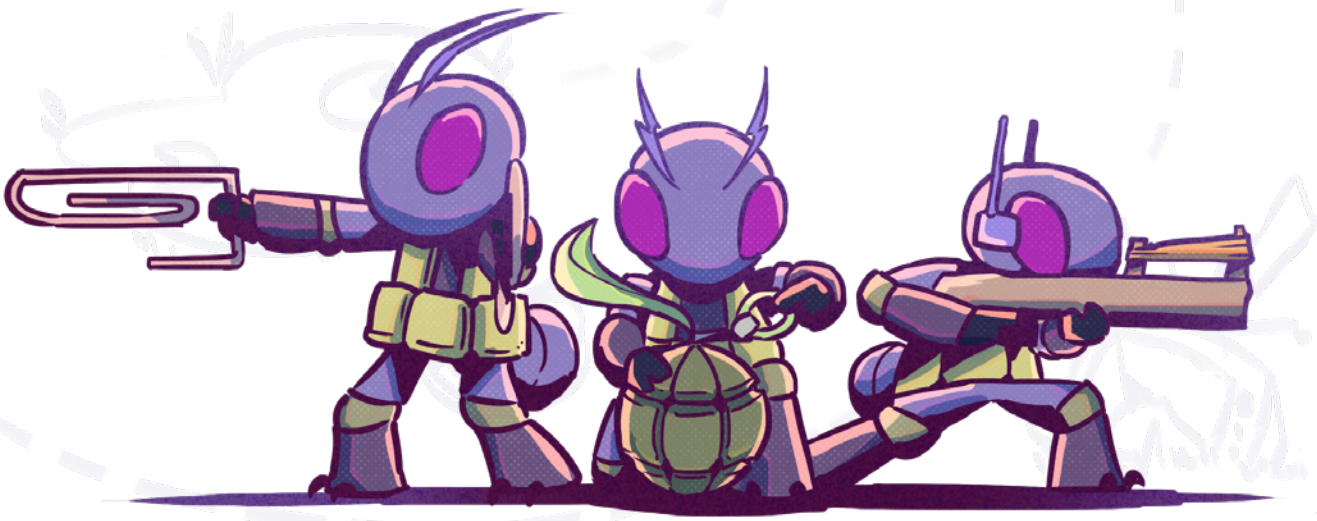
Not suitable for country dances.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Dance.

STRAW HOSE ♥♥♥ GEAR

Filled with water, which can be spurted out droplet by droplet or in a wash of extreme force.
Benefit: Burn to drench an area instantly, putting out fires and washing away dirt. Whenever you take a montage near a source of water (such as a tap or a pond), clear all burns on this aspect's track.

TWIGLING BOW ♥•♥ GEAR

Don't let the simple construction fool you; this weapon is a work of deadly, well-balanced art.
Benefit: You can attack distant hazards with Hunt or Slink without incurring cut.



THREADS

OVERVIEW

Hats, jackets, boots... None of them are truly *necessary* for a bug, but that doesn't stop them from being popular. When you wear a set of Threads, you're flagging to the rest of the table that you want fashion, showing off, or pockets to be a core part of your bug.

If you don't end up choosing an aspect from this page, that doesn't mean you don't have anything fashionable on you - you might have a feather tucked behind one of your antennae, or a little badge you made out of some tinfoil. Tiny stuff, you know? But remember, whatever you have, it won't give you any mechanical bonuses unless represented by an aspect.

WHY CHOOSE THREADS?

- Because you want to look stylish as you adventure
- Because you want to be ready for the weather
- Because hats are fun
- Because you want to demonstrate a particular aesthetic to those around you

ASK YOURSELF...

- Do you weave these clothes yourself, or loot your garments from adventurers less fortunate than you?
- Do you know what bits and bobs were used to dye the Threads you're wearing?
- What do you do, or who do you turn to, when something frays or breaks?

CROSSBONES FLAG ♥♥♥♥ GEAR

YARRR!!!!
Benefit: Whenever you win a fight with dirty tactics of some kind, pull your mood to the extreme positive.

DRAMATIC POCKET ♥ GEAR

First, the distraction - then, the real trick.
Benefit: Consume two bobs to steal the spotlight, disappearing from your current location and reappearing somewhere else within a stone's throw without seeming to cover the intervening space.

GOGGLES ♥♥♥♥♥ GEAR

It's a very specific look that was never quite in style.
Benefit: You can't be deprived of sight.

INTELLECTUAL SPECTACLES ♥♥•♥ GEAR

Okay, it's a trope. But tropes have power...
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when defending with Think.

KITE-COLLAR ♥•♥ GEAR

Can be flared open to catch the wind in a pinch.
Benefit: Ignore negative effects caused by gales.
Benefit: Boost your impact on actions that use a gale for an environmental advantage.

LEAD WEIGHTS ♥•♥♥♥ GEAR

Slow and steady stays alive.
Benefit: You count as the larger force in a grab with any hazard that isn't titan-sized.
Drawback: Increase any Speed Cut you suffer from hazards by 1.

LEAFY HAT ♥♥♥♥ GEAR

Just like a tiny Robin Hood!
Benefit: You're immune to negative mood pulls caused by any kind of weather.

LEATHER JACKET ♥•♥ GEAR

I'm not here for you, and you know it.
Benefit: Whenever you would take damage from a hazard with the Lackey type, either clear a mark on this aspect or steal the spotlight to immediately deal a mark of inescapable Swagger damage to a nearby target.

MAGICIAN'S HAT ♥♥ GEAR

Nothing up my sleeves, nothing up my sleeves...
Benefit: Once per scene, pull your mood positive when near an NPC that trusts you (or a stunned hazard) to 'liberate' a small bit or bob from their person and display it proudly (supplied by the Weaver). They'll probably be confused enough to let you keep it.

ONLY ASPECTS

If you're in the market for some cool clothing, you can spend **3 Nectar** for an aspect from these pages. Threads have no associated augments, but up to two augments from elsewhere in this chapter can be added for the usual cost.

MITTENS ♥•♥ GEAR

Who needs fingers?
Benefit: Ignore negative effects caused by cold snaps.
Benefit: Boost your impact on actions that use a cold snap for an environmental advantage.

MUSHROOM CAP ♥♥♥ GEAR

A sign that you have fungal friends, maybe?
Benefit: Treat conflicts as triumphs when interacting with shroomy things, whether they're ingredients, friends, or foes.

RAINCOAT ♥•♥ GEAR

What did you make that out of?
Benefit: Ignore negative effects caused by rainstorms.
Benefit: Boost your impact on actions that use a rainstorm for an environmental advantage.

SHELL-SHIELD ♥♥•♥ GEAR

One bug's shell is another bug's... uh... Holdable shell.
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Shield.

SPORECARF ♥•♥ GEAR

Haven't we seen this somewhere before?
Benefit: Ignore negative effects caused by sporenados.
Benefit: Boost your impact on actions that use a sporenado for an environmental advantage.

SUNHAT ♥•♥ GEAR

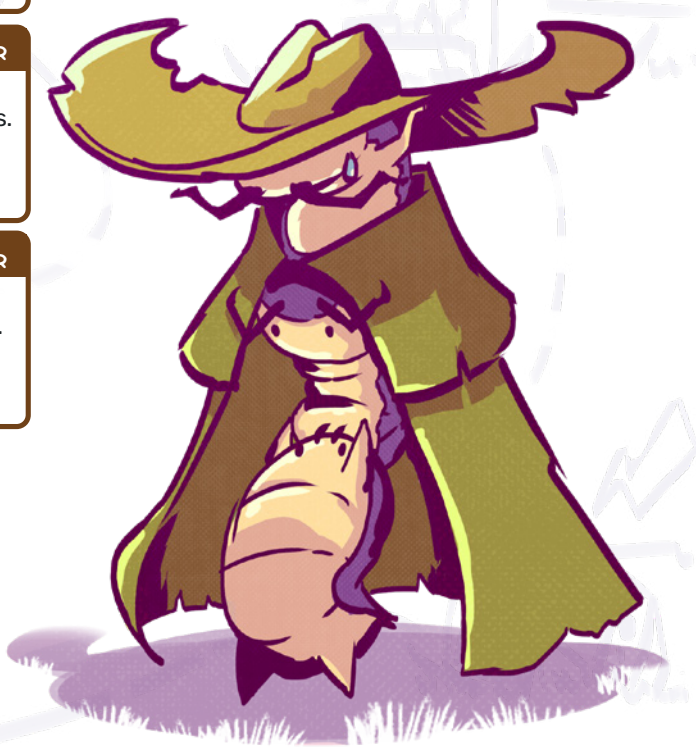
Broad brim and bright colours.
Benefit: Ignore negative effects caused by heatwaves.
Benefit: Boost your impact on actions that use a heatwave for an environmental advantage.

TIN-CAN ARMOUR ♥•♥•♥ GEAR

Packed like one hulking sardine.
Benefit: Choose two from the following list: Bash, Bite, Slash, or Sizzle. You are immune to both of the chosen damage types.
Drawback: Increase any Complex Cut you suffer from hazards by 1.

VISOR-HELM ♥♥•♥ GEAR

For keeping bugs off of your face as you run, even if they're bigger than you!
Benefit: Ignore Tough Cut when attacking with Dash.



SKILLS

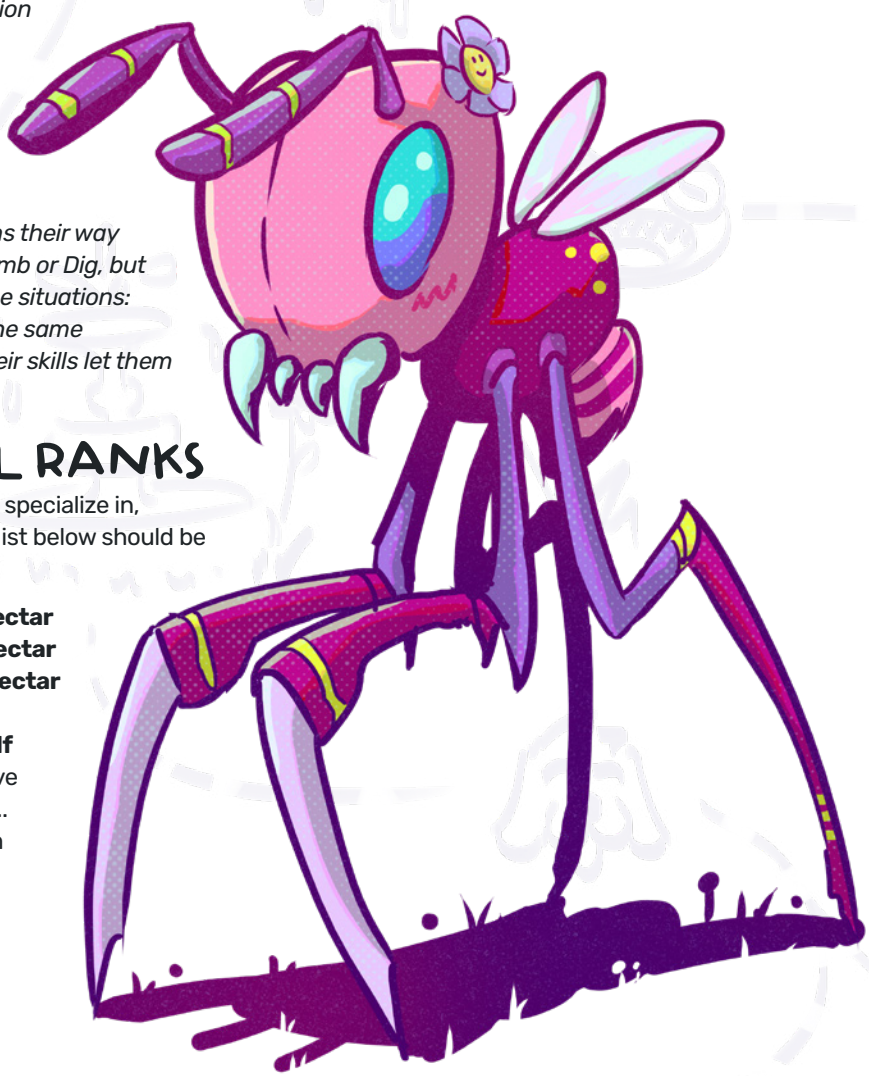
Gold (gold), always believe in your skills...

Once you've chosen your aspects and augments, the rest of your starting Nectar should be spent on skills - useful areas of competence that help your bug interact with the weirdness of the world around them.

There are 24 skills in a game of PICO, and for a starting character each of these begins at rank 0. A rank 0 skill is... well, it doesn't do much for you, let's just say that.

But when you raise a skill's rank, *that's* when it becomes important enough to stick on the character sheet. **When you're taking an action and have a related skill that's at least rank 1, you add dice to your pool equal to that skill's rank** (so a rank 1 skill adds 1d6, a rank 2 skill 2d6, and a rank 3 skill 3d6). You can only rely on one skill for a given action, but the skills themselves are pretty flexible - if you can think of a narratively interesting way that skill would help, it's probably good to go! In fact, your skills should help you decide what kind of actions your bug will take. Play to the skills you have and you'll rarely go wrong, even if it means approaching a situation a little differently than the others in your party.

***Example**: Jace is trying to climb a wall, and has the Climb skill at rank 2. When he makes an Action Roll to climb, he adds the 2d6 granted by his Climb skill - simple, right? Julien also needs to get over the wall, but doesn't have ranks in the Climb skill. What Julien does have, though, is ranks in Dig - they describe how their bug burrows into the soil and stone of the wall and worms their way up that way. Ryan doesn't have ranks in Climb or Dig, but does have a particularly useful skill for these situations: Fly! Even though each of them is tackling the same challenge (a wall that needs bypassing), their skills let them approach it in a completely different way.*



PURCHASING SKILL RANKS

Skills are cheap to acquire but expensive to specialize in, with the cost simple enough that the price list below should be easy enough to remember.

- Increase a skill from rank 0 to rank 1: **1 Nectar**
- Increase a skill from rank 1 to rank 2: **2 Nectar**
- Increase a skill from rank 2 to rank 3: **3 Nectar**

As a general guideline, **spending about half of your starting Nectar** on skills should give you a good spread of useful competencies... As long as you make sure to take them from **different categories**.

SKILL CATEGORIES

The 24 skills of PICO are split up into four different categories (moving, friending, finding, and rumbling), themed around the types of actions they'll most likely help with. Pages 148 to 151 are each devoted to a category of skills, along with examples of when and how a bug might use them, but for a quick-and-handy overview, we've summarized the skills and their categories briefly below...

MOVING SKILLS

» **Dash**: For sprinting and leaping
» **Climb**: For scaling ropes and flatter surfaces
» **Dig**: For burrowing into the ground
» **Slink**: For keeping a low profile
» **Fly**: For taking to the skies
» **Swim**: For cutting through liquids with speed

FRIENDING SKILLS

» **Yap**: For talking, joking, and finding information
» **Swagger**: For throwing your weight around
» **Dazzle**: For impressing and surprising
» **Scare**: For leveraging fear and shock
» **Care**: For tending to plants and injuries
» **Tame**: For putting creatures at ease without words

FINDING SKILLS

» **Sense**: For learning about the world around you
» **Hunt**: For tracking beasts and finding food
» **Think**: For processing information and deducing
» **Rummage**: For finding lost things and useful trash
» **Make**: For building and tinkering
» **Chart**: For finding paths and making maps

RUMBLING SKILLS

» **Bash**: For hitting and barging things
» **Bite**: For sinking your teeth in
» **Slash**: For deft cuts and spiky assaults
» **Sizzle**: For using flames or acid
» **Dance**: For moving with rhythm and flow
» **Shield**: For taking hits like a champ

COVER YOUR BASES

The skills of PICO are split into categories for a reason - bugs are generally more effective in an adventure if they focus on **at least one skill from each category**, as a good baseline. That doesn't mean a character can't dip into multiple skills from the same category (a rough, brawling bug will likely have multiple rumbling skills, for example), but it does mean that a good spread will help out in a variety of situations.

- SKILLS EXAMPLE -

Weaver: The undermouse cackles rather half-heartedly, readjusting his papier-mache skull hat and striking what he thinks is a menacing pose. He's not going to let you pass without a scuffle.

Swift: Well, I'm really not in a scuffling mood right now... I think I'm going to try to convince him to back down. Yap should do it, I reckon.

Weaver: Feel free to try, but you'll be taking a Tough Cut of 1 - the undermouse isn't much of a talker.

Swift: Yeah, I'll still give it a go. That's 2d6 for my Yap skill, and I'm going to add 1d6 of advantage for my pheromones too. 3d6 with a cut of 1 - that's a 5, a 3, and a 2. Ooh, a disaster!

Weaver: Yeah, that could have gone better. The undermouse advances on you, waving a stick around and mumbling what might either be a curse or a poorly remembered grocery list. Either way, it's pretty unsettling - pull your mood negative, Swift, and take a mark of Yap Damage yourself.

Layla: Wait, I think we might be going about this in the wrong way. He's all about the mysticism, right? Well, how about I give him a tarot reading of his own? I'm going to use my resource, Deck of Bugly Cards, and my Think skill as well.

Weaver: Ooh, go for it! No cut here, either.

Layla: Yeah, I think I've got this. That's 3d6 for Think, another 1d6 for the cards - a 6, a 5, a 3, and a 2.

Swift: Nice one, Layla! Swift steps back, bringing you into full view.

Weaver: Tell me how this looks.

Layla: I meet his mumble with a mumble of my own, a vague prognostication of doom as I fling card after card his way until one sticks into the ground right in front of his feet - the hanged man! Hanged moth? One of the scarier cards... I think, anyway, I'm making this up as I go along.

Weaver: I love that! The undermouse rears back and hisses as if burnt, his fear at possible futures laid bare. What if you know your stuff? What if you command the fates? He's not given up completely, but he knows you're (probably) not to be trifled with now!

Choosing your skills

The skills in PICO cover all of the common activities a bug might find themselves engaged in during an adventure. Some of them are quite niche - Swim is probably only useful if there's water around, or something enough *like* water that you won't mind taking a dip in it. Others are broader - Yap covers a whole range of speech related activities, from arguing to telling jokes to talking with your mouth full.

So how do you choose which skills are right for you?

Look at Your Aspects (and Augments): There's a reason we had you pick these first - many aspects and augments relate to a specific category of skills, or sometimes even a single lone skill. If you've got an aspect that lets you treat Dig as Gigadig, probably best to buy at least one rank in the Dig skill so you can use it.

Think About Cool Stuff You Want To Do: When you close your eyes and imagine your bug, what are they doing? Reading peacefully by the fire, knocking back pollenwine in a tiny bar, pirouetting through a battlefield with a tiny sword in hand? Pick skills that relate to the things you want to do once the game begins.

Think About Team Composition: Unless you're playing solo, you're going to have a band of other bugs around you. The best insect adventurers work well together, focusing on different skills and approaches so that no matter the situation, there's always a solution at hand. If you're building characters together, maybe have a discussion about the kind of skills other people are taking.

Dabble In Each Category: You can focus wherever you like, and there's no hard rule saying you need to have at least one each of the moving, friending, finding, and rumbling skills... But it does tend to make life easier, and gives you a much higher chance of having something you're at least *passable* at in every scenario you'll find yourself in.

Using your skills

As previously mentioned, skills are an important component of most Action Rolls (offering a number of dice equal to their rank if related to the action you're taking). But using a skill to get some dice doesn't just give your action a mechanical boost, it gives it *narrative flavour!*

This flavour is a starting point for you to build upon with your description. Okay, you're using that particular skill, but HOW are you using it? Trying to defend yourself against a swooping bird with Shield might have you curling up into a ball, protected by your shell. You might be raising a tool aloft instead, putting it between you and the bird. You might be hunkering down under cover, or flattening yourself out over the ground to make it harder to get scooped up. It's all shielding, at the end of the day, and *how* you describe your actions can have as much impact on the situation as the specific skill you're using.

Skills are flexible

If you're performing an action and a skill might be useful, but you're not sure, ask the Weaver! PICO **wants** you to use skills in weird and interesting ways. Attack a giant beast with Dazzle, distract approaching froglins with Yap, use Scare to tell a spooky campfire story. Don't worry if it's a stretch - if it sounds even *vaguely* possible, it probably is!

You *can* make an Action Roll without a skill, but that should be reserved for really desperate situations where you're **completely** outside of your comfort zone.

SKILLS AS DAMAGE

Skills in PICO also act as 'damage types' when you're affecting a track of some kind (be that the health tracks of a hazard you're facing or a Weaver-set track for a specific situation, like a race or argument).

An action that marks a track usually affects one box, but **some tracks might be affected more, or less, by certain skills**. This might come in the form of one mark more than usual, or even one mark less. It might also be divorced from the concept of marking, and be represented by reading triumph results as conflicts, or by ignoring cut. There are a lot of variations out there to contend with! Here's an example...

Dunf is trying to Bash a heron as it attacks him, but the heron's feathers give it resistance to Bash Damage. His attack hits home, and the heron reacts by staggering back a little, but no boxes on the heron's track are marked - Dunf's usual one mark he would make is lowered by the heron's resistance, to zero.

In essence, you can think of any track - whether it's for a hazard, a situation, or an event - as having the potential to be **weak** or **resistant** to certain skills. Some might even be **immune** to a skill completely, with that skill never making a mark under any circumstance!

GIGASKILLS

Every now and then you'll be able to **treat a skill as a gigaskill**, representing you being so effective with that skill in a particular moment that your power approaches that of a cat rather than the bug you are.

Gigaskills don't just mark one box when they affect a track - they mark **every box,** up to either the next break or the end of the track. **They ignore weakness and resistance too (though not immunity, keep that in mind).** Here's an example...

Dunf, thanks to perfect conditions and a well-chosen aspect, can treat his Bash as Gigabash for a brief moment. The heron trying to gobble him up rears back to strike... And he slams into it with a Gigabash, an entirely unexpected level of power. The heron's track is six boxes long, and every single one of those is marked by Dunf's prodigious attack. The heron staggers back, crosses its eyes, and slumps down in a heap.

"I can sing, I can dance, AND I can handle a sword a little. Now you tell me that's not a triple threat!"

Viceroy Pushelband, Bumblebee Adventurer

MOVING SKILLS

For getting a bug from place to place, in style!

DASH

Whether it's thanks to powerful legs, a light frame, or years of training, your leaps are prodigious and your sprints dramatic. Use Dash to run, jump, and slide at high speeds, leveraging impressive acceleration to cover large distances in short amounts of time.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Trotting along a little faster than most, (Normal) taking a run-up and leaping to clear a crevasse, (Giga) zipping around in the blink of an eye.*

CLIMB

Maybe not as flashy as other modes of travel, but in a world as big as yours, there's always something to climb. Use Climb to scale surfaces others can't, and keep your grip steady in dire situations.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Scrambling up a gravel pile, (Normal) confidently scaling a garden fence, (Giga) being able to tackle slippery walls and smooth ceilings.*

DIG

Anyone can dig if they put their back into it, but you can manage it in a fraction of the usual time. Use Dig to dive under the ground, or to create tunnels large enough for our teammates to use.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Scattering dirt and stones around you to create a shallow pit, (Normal) tunneling through earth or wood, (Giga) boring rapidly through stone or metal.*

SLINK

You're a ghost, a shadow, a leaf on the wind - you're just harder to notice. Use Slink to move quietly, stay perfectly still, or to hide your presence with or without terrain.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Covering yourself with a sheet and hoping, (Normal) blending effectively with the shadows, (Giga) slipping through a crowded room without being noticed, or sneaking right under a predatory beast's nose.*

FLY

You have wings (probably, anyway), and you know how to use them. Use Fly to perform aerial manoeuvres, and to carry other things into the skies with you.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Drifting awkwardly through the air, (Normal) soaring confidently, or being able to get off the ground even under increased load, (Giga) performing show-stopping aerial stunts regardless of wind and g-forces.*

SWIM

You're as happy in and under the water as you are out of it, a rarity in a world of land-bound bugs. Use Swim to travel through liquids, or to hold your breath for long periods.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Splashing around on the surface with goggles, (Normal) diving with confidence and swimming faster than most, (Giga) being as elegant and confident underwater as a fish, or being able to hold your breath for hours at a time.*

FRIENDING SKILLS

For keeping your friends close, and your enemies guessing.

YAP

You're a natural talker, and others feel more inclined to flap their mandibles around you as well. Use Yap to crack jokes, tell stories, and gather information, and to loosen the tongues of recalcitrant NPCs.

Impact Examples: *(Low) Barely holding the interest of a distracted bug, (Normal) joking with a mercantile bug to get better prices, (Giga) convincing a retired hero to fight for you.*

SWAGGER

There's just something about you, something undeniably *cool*. Use Swagger to tell tall stories, act aloof, and pretend you belong, as well as to hide embarrassment and distract from failures.

Impact Examples: *(Low) Sticking out your chest and blustering, (Normal) temporarily convincing others that you're one to follow, (Giga) having a rabid fan club seek you out.*

DAZZLE

Others can't help but be impressed by the things that you do, or maybe even just the way that you do them. Use Dazzle to charm, sing, dance, play music, or put on shows.

Impact Examples: *(Low) Make a dubious balloon animal, (Normal) tell a gripping tale of your band's exploits, (Giga) do something so unbelievable and shocking that foes temporarily forget that they're against you, showering you with praise.*

SCARE

You strike fear into the hearts of others, whether that's warranted or not. Use Scare to intimidate bugs and other animals, and to make yourself look like someone that shouldn't be tangled with.

Impact Examples: *(Low) Just standing there, menacingly, (Normal) striking fear into the heart of a would-be bully, (Giga) seriously unnerving a beast ten times your size.*

CARE

You're at your best when helping others, shepherding or protecting nature, or urging living things to grow. Use Care to heal, put others at ease, make food, and grow plants.

Impact Examples: *(Low) Slapping a band-aid on something and calling it healed, (Normal) being able to coax a plant into healthy growth in less than ideal circumstances, (Giga) creating a feast that would have even the most aloof cat coming back for seconds.*

TAME

Other bugs are nice and all, but there are so many greater creatures out there to forge bonds with. Use Tame to communicate with other creatures, understand animal behaviour, and calm wild beasts.

Impact Examples: *(Low) Convincing a predatory plant to eat you last, (Normal) getting a free ride from a grumpy old mole, (Giga) temporarily calming a feral titan.*

FINDING SKILLS

For learning more about the world, and making it work in your favour.

SENSE

It's a big world out there, and you take in as much of it as you can. Use Sense to see, hear, taste, smell, and feel the environment around you, and to notice things others would miss.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Noticing the smell of cooking bacon, (Normal) being aware of rustles in the undergrowth, and judging how big the creature making them might be, (Giga) being able to pierce the mundane at will, learning secrets from beyond the veil.*

HUNT

It's the law of the jungle, or possibly the overgrown hothouse - there's predator bugs, and there's prey bugs. Use Hunt to search for food, individuals, or information, all of which you may or may not eat once found.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Shadowing a famous bug as they travel, (Normal) following animal tracks through a forest, (Giga) an innate knowledge of when you're being watched.*

THINK

There is no power greater than a well-honed mind, or so you like to tell yourself. Use Think to reason your way through problems, or (if you have the right training) maybe even unleash uncanny powers of the mind!
Impact Examples: *(Low) Solving a ten-piece jigsaw puzzle, (Normal) planning an almost-flawless heist, (Giga) confusing a sphinx with a riddle of your own.*

RUMMAGE

One bug's trash is another bug's much cooler trash. Use Rummage to find valuable things in cluttered places, or to puzzle out what an artefact might be useful for.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Picking out a threadbare rug at a high-end bugly boutique, (Normal) discerning the use of a pre-Mysteriocalypse artefact, (Giga) find a single needle in a world of haystacks.*

MAKE

Mama always said, big things come to those who wait. But you're impatient, and have too many small things already. Use Make to combine small or simple things into larger and more complex things, to prepare food or drinks, or to learn how something works.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Making a fishing rod from twigs and twine, (Normal) creating a working engine, (Giga) perfecting a genuine perpetual motion machine.*

CHART

Who knows what's around the next corner? With this skill, it might be you! Use Chart to find paths, make and read maps, and use environmental clues to predict weather and upcoming challenges.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Predicting a storm just after the first rumble of thunder, (Normal) finding a route through the wilds, (Giga) cartographizing a termite mound.*

RUMBLING SKILLS

For getting into, and out of, trouble.

BASH

Charge in headfirst! A direct approach to danger and difficulty that usually involves percussive force. Use Bash to smash your way through obstacles and injure foes.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Punching your way through a wet paper bag, (Normal) clonking a beastmouse over the head as it charges in to attack, (Giga) managing to land a solid blow on a titan's hide, one strong enough to give them pause for thought.*

BITE

Why grow mandibles if you aren't going to use them? Biting stuff is **fun**! Use Bite to injure foes, eat things, and grab onto stuff with determination - most bugly mouths are just as good at holding things as their limbs.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Seriously menacing a fresh sandwich, (Normal) sinking your teeth into a soft target, (Giga) snapping your jaws straight through tough armour plating.*

SLASH

Some problems are best solved with a keen edge and a shout of triumph, the way the heroes of old did (or so they tell you in the great bugly epics, anyway). Use Slash to cut your way through obstacles and injure foes.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Cutting a silk ribbon, (Normal) snipping through an electrical cable, (Giga) slicing through stone like a hot knife through butter.*

SIZZLE

For the tricksier poison types, and those with an acid tongue or a spark of flame. Use Sizzle to melt or burn your way through obstacles and injure foes, and to make dangerous-looking wisps of smoke.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Playing with campfire sparks, (Normal) piercing a target with a venomous sting, (Giga) releasing a shockwave with the power of a lightning bolt.*

DANCE

With a sway, a wiggle, and a few rhythmic steps, you turn movement into art. Use Dance to avoid danger, dodge incoming attacks, move to music, and go with the flow.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Tapping your feet and almost staying on beat, (Normal) slipping in and out of a combatant's weapon range amidst a scuffle, (Giga) battling a foe with a combination of acrobatic flips and elegant sidesteps, flowing like a mountain stream.*

SHIELD

You let problems break themselves on you. It means you take a few more knocks, yes, but others around you take fewer. Use Shield to weather that which would move you, or to shrug off harm.
Impact Examples: *(Low) Protecting your antennae from raindrops, (Normal) defending a nearby bug from a thrown object, (Giga) turning aside a direct strike from a titan.*

CHAPTER 07:
MAKING A BUG II
(THE OTHER CHOICES)

DECISION TIME!

This chapter contains the second half of the instructions for how to build a bug of your very own - your Nectar is spent, so it's time to make some additional choices!

If this is your first time making a bug for a game of PICO (and you somehow missed this section in the previous chapter)...

- **Skim** through the previous chapter (starting on page 99) AND this chapter, so that you understand the whole process
- **Check** that you've got everything you want from chapter 6
- **Use** this chapter to make decisions on your bug's mood, bits and bobs, starting mystery, and name (none of these require you to spend any Nectar)

If you've made bugs for PICO before, why are you even reading this bit? You know what to do!

How To MAKE A BUG (part 2)

"Did I make six choices, or only five?"

It's time to finish up this bugly design process! By this point you should have spent all of your Nectar on aspects, augments, and skills (unless you wanted to keep some of it back for in-game use, you little hoarder). That means all you have left to do is make a few more choices about your little adventurer, and then you're ready to play!

This chapter covers the last four steps of making your bug, where you choose your moods, your bits & bobs, your starting mystery and, finally, your name. In fact, if we're going to go into a bit more detail...

STEP FIVE: CHOOSE YOUR MOODS

Every bug has three moods, one of which is shared with all other bugs (the neutral 'ok' mood) and two of which are chosen by you. Try to choose moods not only based on the mechanics they offer, but on what you think would be fun to roleplay from time to time. **You don't spend Nectar on these, you just choose one positive and one negative mood.**

You'll find a list of moods to choose from on page 159.

STEP SIX: CHOOSE YOUR BITS & BOBS

Bits and bobs are useful stuff your bug has picked up on their travels, with bits being biological and bobs being artificial. These are gained and lost easily through play, so don't worry about making big dramatic choices here. This section also contains info on chunks, huge versions of bits and bobs that are necessary building materials for a picotitan structure... But you don't start with any of those, and you couldn't carry them even if you did! **All bugs begin with 1 bit and 1 bob (although you could take 2 bits and no bobs if you prefer, or vice versa).**

You'll find a list of bits and bobs to choose from on page 163.

STEP SEVEN: CHOOSE YOUR MYSTERY

Every bug is naturally inclined toward solving mysteries as they travel, weird questions that can be answered to better understand the vast world of PICO. Like bits and bobs, these will change over the course of an adventure, but all bugs begin play with a single mystery to solve to get them going. **Choose 1 mystery that interests your bug.**

You'll find a list of potential mysteries on page 167.

STEP EIGHT: NAME YOUR BUG!

Every bug has two names, one a personal choice and one a pseudoscientific descriptor. **For your personal choice name, choose whatever you like. Your scientific descriptor is taken from the combination of aspects and augments you chose earlier.**

There's guidance on bug names, both pseudoscientific and common, on page 168.

PiCO
Character Sheet

Short Pic-nic

[Player Name]

NAME

Pseudo 8 [ ]

[description]

[pic-ture]

SKILLS

Max Rank: 3

Moving
- Dash
- Climb
- Dig
- Slink
- Fly
- Swim

Friending
- Yap
- Swagger
- Dazzle
- Scare
- Care
- Tame

Finding
- Sense
- Hunt
- Rummage
- Think
- Make
- Chart

Rumbling
- Bash
- Bite
- Slash
- Sizzle
- Dance
- Shield

ASPECTS

... and augments

5

MOOD

[ ] [OK] [ ]

6

BITS & BOBS

[Carry Slots: Start 6 / Current]

7

MYSTERY

[?]

CREATIONS

MOODS

"Life is a rollercoaster; you've just got to ride it."

In PICO, mood is important. Every bug has three of them, one **positive**, one **negative**, and one that's sort of **neutral**. Positive and negative moods are unique to each bug, but that middle mood is the same on every character sheet.

Knowing your mood helps you roleplay your bug, but it has some mechanical weight too - each positive and negative mood has a benefit or drawback associated with it, giving you some extra power or making life just that little bit more difficult.

THE MOOD TRACK

Found on your character sheet, **the mood track is represented by a simple set of five boxes.** The mood track only ever has one mark on it, an × representing a bug's **current mood.** This × moves to the right if a bug's mood is pulled positive, to the left if it's pulled negative. Moods change over the course of a game session depending on both the narrative and your bug's own chosen aspects - if it helps, think of it as a tug of war between the best and worst sides of a bug's nature!

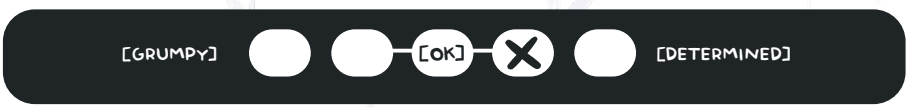
Bugs begin the game with their mood at neutral, which is always represented by the middle three boxes of the track (the ones linked together and marked 'OK'). **Their positive mood is added to the box on the far right, their negative to the box on the far left**. *We've got an example mood track below, in the black box - the more colourful boxes above and below should help explain what each part of the mood track means, and how to use it...*

NEUTRAL MOOD

There aren't any special rules associated with this mood - it's the default, the baseline, the ho-hum-isn't-life-just-fine of moods. It isn't particularly exciting, but doesn't everybody have days like that sometimes?

THE MOOD MARKER

An × that represents your current mood. *In this example, the × isn't in the leftmost or rightmost box, so the bug's mood is neutral (the middle three boxes of the mood track all count as neutral mood).*



NEGATIVE MOOD

When the mood marker is in the leftmost box of your mood track, your bug is cursed with the effects of a negative mood. Negative moods come with both a benefit and a drawback, so they have to be handled carefully if you want to get the most out of them. *This bug's negative mood is Grumpy, which makes friending harder, but fighting more impactful.*

POSITIVE MOOD

When the mood marker is in the rightmost box of your mood track, your bug is blessed with the effects of a positive mood. Positive moods have nothing more to them than a beneficial bonus, so there's no harm in aiming for a good time while out adventuring! *This bug's positive mood is Determined, which lets their player re-roll results of 1 once per scene.*

Changing Moods

A bug's three moods might be chosen at character creation, but it's during the game itself that the mood marker starts moving and shaking!

When a bug's mood is affected by their actions or environment, it **pulls** toward either the positive or the negative. A pull **moves the mood marker** on a bug's mood track by **one box**, toward either the positive or negative end.

Remember, bugs don't receive the benefits (or drawbacks) of their positive or negative mood until the mark reaches the final box on either the left or the right of the track.

So what can actually change a bug's mood? Quite a lot, really, but not so much that it'll happen *too* many times within a single session. Some bugs gain a positive or negative pull based on their **parts or gear** (a bug with a Leafy Hat is immune to negative pulls from weather, for example), and **spending a task on recovery** often pulls mood in some way, but most of the time mood pulls are **handled by the Weaver**. *See the box on the right for more details, but remember that you can always **ask for a mood pull after an important achievement** too!*

We're Alright in the End

The other big mood-changer is a simple but useful one: **using a task to sleep can always pull mood toward neutral if a player wishes**, as great victories fade and big sadnesses pass. In the end, unless anything else happens to change a bug's mood, **they'll always be alright**.

Big Mood

It's rare, but you may be able to achieve **giga impact** when pulling your mood to positive or negative. In these cases, a bug's mood marker moves all the way from wherever it is to either **the extreme negative or the extreme positive mood**, whichever is appropriate. You might get a bit of emotional whiplash, but it's a pretty powerful move if you can pull it off! *Depending on the situation, the Weaver **might** count the 'neutral mood' in the middle of the track as a break, stopping the mood change dead centre instead.*

Mood Pulls

The Weaver might pull a bug's mood when...

+ The Weather Changes

Often pulls toward the positive if it's bright, pleasantly sunny, or beautiful, the negative if the sky lets loose rains, storms, or extreme heat.

+ You Make a Grand Discovery

Usually pulls positive for the achievement, but if solving the mystery involves a sudden flourishing of terrible knowledge, then that might pull negative.

+ You Win a Rumble

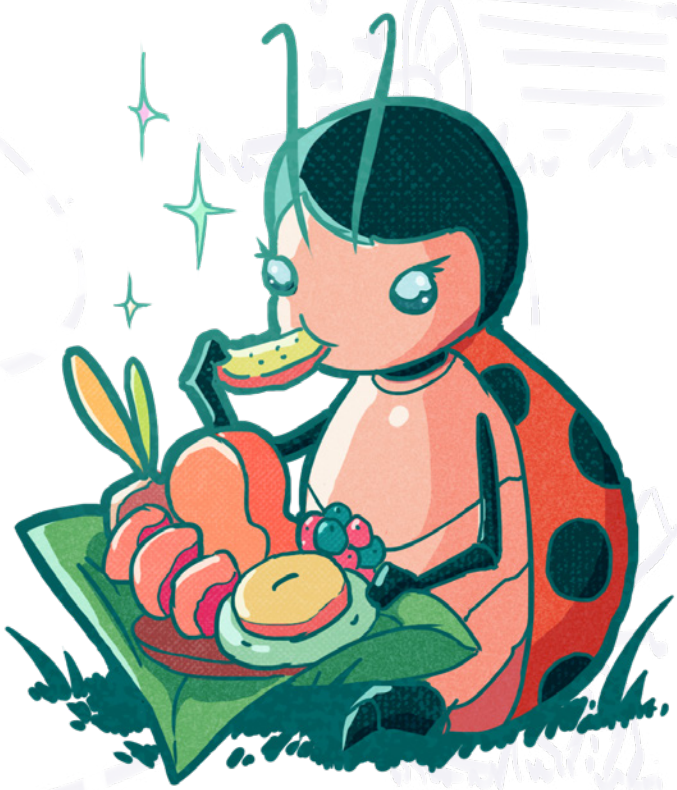
Pulls positive if you bested the danger you were facing, negative if you only barely escaped (or if you had to do something nasty in order to win).

+ You Find an Impressive Location

Pulls positive if it's full of wonder and tasty treats, negative if it's a place of tiny horrors and bitterness.

+ You Finish a Tiny Story

Pulls positive for a satisfying conclusion, and negative for lost threads and questions that will never be answered.



CHOOSING YOUR MOODS

When creating your bug, you choose **one positive** mood and **one negative** mood. Both give benefits of some kind, but negative moods also give game-changing drawbacks for you to contend with.

Think hard before choosing your positive and negative moods - the special benefits and drawbacks they come with can be a source of great power in the right circumstances.

... Or don't, and just go for whichever ones you think you'll be comfortable roleplaying!

***Example**: Sasha is creating a bug for a game of PICO, a praying-mantis-inspired adventurer that she wants to be cool under pressure and impressively wise. When choosing her negative mood, she wants something that plays off of her original idea - she goes for Detached, a mood that disallows friending skills, but makes it likely she'll find something really impressive once a scene. For her positive pick the choice is an easy one - the Focused mood allows her bug to ignore a good amount of cut when attacking, a perfect representation of that cool-headedness she wants him to embody.*

Negative Moods

- Choose one as you make your bug -

Times are tough, and they're getting you down - some less-than-great tendencies are starting to show. Everyone has off days, though, and you'll snap out of it at some point. When things are looking negative, your bug might feel...

- **Abrasive**: You can't gain or spend Picotitan Favour, BUT ignore Tough Cut from hazards of the same type as your picotitan.
- **Angry**: You can't be healed by allies, BUT when you mark a combo track, make two marks rather than the usual one.
- **Detached**: You can't use friending skills, BUT the first finding skill you use in each scene is treated as a gigaskill.
- **Grumpy**: You can't use friending skills, BUT the first rumbling skill you use in each scene is treated as a gigaskill.
- **Haughty**: You are immune to damage caused by friending skills, BUT you also treat all of your own friending skills as if they were one rank lower.
- **Scornful**: You can't use tasks to Cook, Craft, or Scrounge, BUT heal double the usual hearts by using a task to Recover.
- **Selfish**: Take a mark of Scare damage whenever you use or trade a bit or bob, BUT hazard attacks can't steal or damage bits and bobs that you're carrying.
- **Shy**: Take a mark of Think damage whenever you use a friending skill, BUT if the result of a roll is a triumph, immediately set your mood to the extreme positive.
- **Snappy**: You can't heal hearts when camping on a journey, BUT when you go on the lookout you roll one more d6 than normal.
- **Tearful**: Double any damage you take from hazards, BUT when the Weaver wants a hazard to attack you, roll a d6. On a 6, that hazard takes pity on you and passes the spotlight on without attacking.
- **Vengeful**: Take a Tough Cut of one on all actions using moving, friending, and finding skills, BUT ignore all Tough Cut on actions using rumbling skills.

Positive Moods

- Choose one as you make your bug -

Things are great, and you feel great! It's not that nothing could ever get you down again, but right now it's time to bask in the good vibes. When things are looking positive, your bug might feel...

- **Charitable**: Whenever you gain a bob, you can split it in half and give it to one of your allies as well.
- **Cheerful**: Once per scene, treat any friending skill as a gigaskill.
- **Content**: Ignore negative mood pulls from the weather.
- **Creative**: When Cooking or Crafting, gain one extra portion or copy without spending any additional bits or bobs.
- **Determined**: Once per scene, re-roll any dice from a single roll that show a 1. Keep re-rolling until there are no 1s left.
- **Driven**: When you begin a montage, roll a d6. On a 4, 5, or 6, you gain an additional task to use.
- **Energized**: When you lead a ramble or march, cover one more stride than usual.
- **Excited**: Whenever you stop to camp, pull the mood of all your fellow bugs toward positive (if they want it).
- **Exuberant**: Heal one heart whenever you gain a bit or bob.
- **Focused**: Ignore cut imposed by hazards you're targeting with an attack (cut imposed by other sources, like the environment, still apply).
- **Hopeful**: Once per scene, allow one ally to ignore Tough Cut on a single action.
- **Jaunty**: Whenever you spot something while on the lookout, an ally of your choice can pull their mood positive if they wish.
- **Soothing**: Double any favour your picotitan gains due to your actions.
- **Tenacious**: You don't need to burn in order to mark a combo track.
- **Witty**: Once per scene, ignore all Tough Cut on a roll using a friending skill.

Bits & Bobs

"Hey! He's stealin' our bits and bobs!"

Bugs are, for their size, pretty damn strong. Not as strong as the wind, or a particularly large cat, but strong nonetheless.

But what does the average bug do with all this strength? Some climb mountains, some throw bottlecaps, but ALL of them take part in one of the most important bugly rituals - picking up random stuff and carrying it around in case, y'know, it might be useful. At some point. Maybe.

This is where **bits and bobs** come in, the catch-all term for random things that bugs might find along the road and want to keep with them.

What are Bits? What are Bobs?

There is a difference! **Bits are organic** in nature, and **bobs are artificial**. Find a dewdrop? That's a bit. A paperclip? That's going to be a bob right there. On the next page, you'll find a list that gives some examples of each, but essentially, the golden rule is that **if it's small enough to pick up and carry with you, it's either a bit or a bob**.

Why is the Distinction Important?

Good question! Both bits and bobs can be used to craft things, trade, throw at others, and help out when you're performing an action (usually by giving 1d6 and then being consumed). But there are also some actions that specify whether they need a bit OR a bob - healing parts is one, which usually requires consuming a bit. Hopefully a tasty or medicinally potent one, but you never know.

Useful, But Temporary

The most important thing to remember about both bits and bobs is that they're **transient** - they get picked up and put down, lost or thrown away, consumed, used to make other stuff, or fed to wild beasts. They help you out in a pinch, but *they don't define your character* - that's for your body parts, gear, and buddies to do, the things that stay on your character sheet from game start to game end.

Consuming Bits and Bobs

Usually using a bit or bob will **consume** it, removing it from your character sheet. But PICO is a game about stories, and fiction matters - if you're using a bit or bob to add dice to an action you're taking, but that action would logically not consume the bit or bob, **keep it instead**. The Weaver might use the loss of this otherwise safe bit or bob as a negative outcome of the roll if you end up with a conflict or disaster, just so you're aware.

Oh, and some aspects will ask you to consume a bit or bob, with that specific wording - in these cases, it's best not to argue with the book. It's probably a balance thing of some kind.

Chunks

So you know about bits and bobs now, but what's this? An apple? A whole apple? How could you *possibly* carry that?

Well, you couldn't. That makes that pretty simple, doesn't it?

Things that you might want to pick up, but that are way too big to be a bit or bob, are called **chunks**. Chunks are used to build features of your picotitan's titanden (page 184), and picotitans each have the ability to carry at least one chunk at a time (in their mouths or paws, most likely), but they're **way too heavy for bugs**.

That said, if you don't have a picotitan and still want to take a nice-looking chunk with you, either...

- **Drag a single chunk along with you as a group**, tripling all of the ticks you'd make on the ticking clock, or...
- **Break it into pieces!** One chunk might give anywhere from **four to six bits or bobs** (and the chunk is destroyed).

CARRY SLOTS

Now, carrying around a matchstick and a couple of cool-looking petals might not be much to you, but to the average bug, it's a herculean feat. It's all about relative size, you know? And not only that, but there's limited places you can balance things on a shell - pockets are an invention still relatively new to the scuttling domains.

To represent this, each bug has a number of **carry slots**, which represent just how many bits and bobs they can carry around. **For most bugs, this starts at six**, which is actually mightily impressive, but it's possible to have more (or fewer) thanks to the choices you make as you build your bug.

Carry slots are simplified on purpose - yes, a matchstick *is* going to weigh more than a petal, but we're not getting into precise weight here. Instead, **bits and bobs all take up one slot**.

When all of your carry slots are full, **you can't pick up any other bits and bobs**. You could still search for them, but someone else would have to pick them up.

Some aspects *might* give you a bonus for having slots empty, and some hazards might even do more damage or have more dangerous effects if you don't have any slots free, but that kind of stuff will come up pretty rarely - your character sheet, or the Weaver, will point it out to you.

- BITS & BOBS EXAMPLE -

Weaver: The croaklin gives you a final nasty look and slips backwards into the water, disappearing below the surface and leaving the campsite behind. Nice job, people!

Dunf: Oof, that was a tough one! But we can get what we came for now, right? That box?

Weaver: You can indeed! The box is yellow, about the size of you, Dunf, but a lot... Well, a lot boxier. It's got a brown strip down the side, and a big picture of a smiling cat on the front.

Swift: Oh ho, I know what this is! I push it open - what's inside?

Weaver: Long sticks with dangerous blobs on the end - you've found three matches. You can take each of them as bobs if you have the carry slots.

Layla: I'm not touching those, but you guys go ahead! I see fire in our future...

Tags

Particularly special bits or bobs have **tags,** words that are written down next to them that clarify something about them. You might have *Sweet Grass*, or a *Shiny Penny.* Sweet Grass is going to be sweeter than most grass, and that penny is going to be shinier than average!

Tags are most often gained when you receive a bit or bob through a roll with a twist - both the Gathering and Scrounging tables (pages 52 and 72) specifically call out adding tags as a reward for rolling doubles.

***Example**: Mekamus is attempting to scrounge for something salty in the ruins of an old cupboard. They succeed, with a triumph and a twist - they find a Potato Chip, and with the added tag from their doubles they turn it into a Delicious Potato Chip by adding a tag.*

Any bit or bob can have a tag, and some might even have more than one!

Positive and Negative Tags

When a bug gains a bit or bob that has an associated tag, that tag might be specified as **positive** or **negative**. Positive tags, on the whole, make a bit or bob more valuable or useful - negative tags tend to make them a little bit worse.

But the concept of positive and negative tags in PICO is a flexible one, as what might be a positive tag for one bug may well be negative for another. A bug that wants a sweet bit to chow down on to activate one of their aspects might *love* a Mouldering Applecore, arguing that the mouldiness enhances the sweet flavour. So, as a general rule, if the tag would make the bug receiving the bit or bob go 'yay', it's positive. If it would make the bug go 'boo', it's negative.

Explicit vs. Implicit Tags

There may be times when an aspect you choose for your bug, or even the Weaver themselves, asks you to use a particular kind of bit - crunchy, sweet, spicy etc. There'll be other times, like when you're scrounging (page 72), that you might want to search for a bit or bob with certain properties - something hot, something flat etc. You find a bit, but, shock horror - there's no tag! What now? Well, that's where implicit tags come in.

Most tags are **explicit** - they're a word, sitting right there on your sheet next to the bit or bob they add to. But bits and bobs also have **implicit** tags, tags that you can kind of just *assume* that something has. Sugar, for example, is going to be sweet whether it explicitly has the sweet tag or not. *Implicit tags can be decided whenever they become relevant, usually by conversation at the table with both the Weaver and the other players.*

In edge cases, feel free to ask the Weaver and anybody else at the table that might have a helpful (or unhelpful) opinion. An apple could easily count as Crunchy, and you could probably argue that paper would too if you scrunched it up. Silver foil? Yeah, why not! A bone? If you bite it hard enough!

***Example**: Franz wants to light a small fire to keep his friends warm as they wait for the rains to pass. He doesn't have matches, or any other bit of bob that might immediately make one think of fire, but he does have a good supply of twigs from the surrounding area. All he needs now is something to light them with... Luckily, one of his allies offers up a bit from their own pack - a Voltaic Mushroom! This doesn't have any explicit tags that would create fire either, but with a metal pin and some quick thinking the pair manage to create enough of a spark to set the kindling alight.*

"This isn't just any old stick - this is My stick, and there's no other stick like it in the whole wide world!"

Elise Toddington, Adventuresome Grub

Choosing your starting Bits and Bobs

All bugs begin a game of PICO with two bits and bobs of their choice. You might take one bit and one bob, or double up on one or the other if you're feeling in a particularly biological or junkish mood. You can give these starting bits and bobs positive (or even negative) tags if you wish, that's entirely up to you. They're there to be used and replaced as you adventure, so you don't have to put too much thought into this one (and if none of the bits and bobs on offer below appeal, just make them up!).

Some aspects allow you to increase your carry slots, and even to begin the game with additional bits and bobs to hand! You'll find a few of these scattered around the aspects and augments section, but most are on page 138.

Starting Bits

- Acid Droplet
- Acorn Top
- Axeberry
- Blob of Goo
- Candy Shard
- Cheese Curd
- Chocolate Morsel
- Discarded Shell
- Drinkable Smile
- Droplet of Water
- Duck Feather
- Eggshell Piece
- Elite Jelly
- Empty Nut Husk
- Flickering Petal
- Frog Sweat
- Gas Bubble
- Grains of Rice
- Grains of Sand
- Grundlemeat Scrap
- Half a Seed
- Hefty Twig
- Indigo Leaf
- Jam-Brewed Beer
- Jellied Rice
- Leaf-Stem
- Luscious Petal
- Marrow Spread
- Morsel of Meat
- Mold Spores
- Nutchoc Glop
- Olive
- Orange Peel
- Orange Pith
- Phosphorescent Scale
- Poisonous Berry
- Protein Flake
- Pumpkin Mash
- Purple Jam
- Ramnut
- Resin Wine
- Rubber Gum
- Salt Crystal
- Scrap of Bacon Fat
- Simple Bone
- Stone Splinter
- Sugar Cube
- Sweet Grass
- Tiny Flower
- Tiny Skull
- Undermouse Brew
- Vanilla Pod
- Vinegar Bead
- Wicked Pincer
- Wiggly Stamen
- Zap-Juice

Starting Bobs

- Aluminium Scraps
- Bent Needle
- Burning Embers
- Button
- Cassette Spool
- Cocktail Umbrella
- Coil of Wire
- Compass Needle
- Construction Block
- Cork
- Cotton Loop
- Discarded Tin Lid
- Discount Sticker
- Droplet of Oil
- Empty Phial
- Fated Mirror
- Firework Warning Label
- Folktale Pamphlet
- Fountain Pen Nib
- Glass Bead
- Golden Coin
- Gravellin Fist
- Hardened Glue
- Hole Punch Pieces
- Hollow Casing
- Ink Bead
- Knife Edge
- Liquid Bubbles
- Magnet
- Mangled Receipt
- Matchstick
- Metal Offcut
- Milk Bottle Top
- Multifaceted Diamond
- Notepaper Shred
- Opening Tab
- Paperclip
- Pencil Shavings
- Piece of Chalk
- Piece of String
- Pipe Cleaner
- Price Tag
- Scrap of Paper
- Shard of Glass
- Silver Juice
- Small Plastic Sword
- Sticky Tape Sliver
- Strip of Leather
- Stripped Screw
- Thimble
- Tiny Anchor
- Tiny Claw Necklace
- Train Ticket
- Underfloor Fabric
- Weird Fluff
- Wire Guitar

Mysteries

"Any sufficiently advanced mystery is indistinguishable from stuff we just make up on the spot."

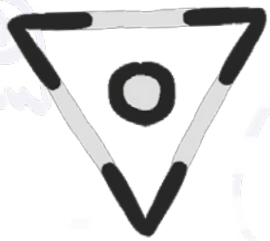
The world of PICO is an unusual one, and not just because it's full of cute bugs. The backdrop of the world, the **Mysteriocalypse**, is something so large and so strange that no single bug can ever hope to understand it. Not completely, anyway.

But bugs are curious sorts, full of wonder and questions, and *who cares* about knowing everything about *one* big event when there are so many smaller mysteries to solve? Especially when those smaller mysteries can make your life better on a day-to-day basis and, in very real terms, let you better understand the world.

This philosophy sits at the heart of PICO's final basic bundle of rules - how to deal with **mysteries**, and how to **develop the world** of PICO by creating new **truths**.

Mystery Triangles

A mystery triangle is a shape representing **an unsolved question about the world**. A shape that looks... Well, a lot like a triangle. Like this, in fact!



Every mystery triangle has **three points** and a **circle at the centre**. Those are the black lines, you can't miss them! But what it also has are some lighter, grey parts - these **connect the points together**, and **sit at the middle of the circle**.

As a bug investigates a mystery, every **small discovery** they make **fills in one of the grey lines** - connecting the triangle's points together, piece by piece.

Once all of the points are connected (so after three small discoveries have been made), a bug can choose to make a **grand discovery** - learning a **truth** about the world and filling in that circle in the middle. Congratulations! Mystery solved!

Small Discoveries

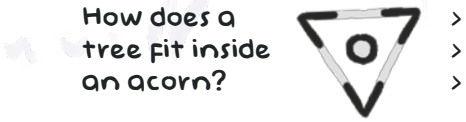
Small discoveries are made by a player **noticing something about the world around them that's relevant to their mystery**, and calling that out to the group - then they can fill in one of those grey lines. But what kind of mysteries are we talking about here?

Early on, it's best to start with some simple questions about the world. Here are a few examples...

- Why are froglins so mean?
- What is the best berry?
- How does a tree fit inside an acorn?

As players get more used to the mystery system, they might tackle bigger topics. Where does the sun go at night? Just what exactly *is* the Shining Mountain?

Here's an example of a mystery triangle with a question attached to it...



See those little arrows on the right? They're places to note down the small discoveries that you make, information relevant to the question that a mystery poses. These don't solve a mystery all at once, but they do bring a bug closer to their grand discovery, piece by piece, like so...

GRAND DISCOVERIES

Small discoveries come naturally through play, as bugs experience situations that relate to the mystery they're trying to solve, but grand discoveries are entirely player-created - **when you've made three small discoveries, it's time for the grand discovery!**

You can make your grand discovery known the next time you have the spotlight by **announcing that you have big news to share**.

So, this is the answer to the mystery, right?

Eh... Maybe.

The world of PICO isn't one of scientific rigour. A grand discovery certainly *feels* like an answer, but it doesn't actually have to make sense.

But whether it makes sense or not doesn't matter - **it still changes the world!**

TRUTHS

Grand discoveries **literally change the world of PICO, giving the players and Weaver a new truth to fold into their story**. This means less time worldbuilding before a game begins and more creativity at the table!

But how does that look?

***Example**: Swift has always been fascinated by the local trees. He knows they come from acorns, but how do they fit in there in the first place? After three small discoveries, he's finally ready to announce his grand discovery to the group - acorns have tiny micro-trees in them, and they burst into full trees when they're given enough water! The group agrees this makes sense, and the Weaver notes this new truth down.*

From that point on, **this is true for the world**. And it might be beneficial, might be detrimental, might be dangerous, might even create new mysteries that need answers! Can enough water make *other* things get bigger? Who knows? Keep playing to find out!

All truths are recorded on the Roaming Sheet, which is shared by all players at the table. This should be a good reminder that **truths can be used by any player, and any bug** - not just the one that discovered them. Once a truth is out in the world, it's fair game for everyone - even NPCs and hazards can use them!

NEW MYSTERIES

When you've made a grand discovery and added a new truth to the world, **erase** your small discoveries and the lines they made and **choose a new mystery**. You've changed the world with your mind, but there's always more to learn and explore!

SENSIBLE LIMITS

With all that said, there are a few mechanical and roleplay-based rules around mysteries, discoveries, and truths. We'll list them here for reference...

- **Making a discovery is an action - you need the spotlight**. Don't just shout out a small discovery when you notice it, or a grand discovery when you've decided what it is. Make sure these things flow with the rest of the game.
- **Truths need general approval**. You're making this world together, after all - posing a possible grand discovery and seeing the reactions of the Weaver, and the other players, is often better than just blurting one out. Only write down the truth that a grand discovery creates when everybody is on board with it, and don't be afraid to workshop if necessary!
- **Discoveries and truths can't invalidate another player's choices, or character**. This is the big one - you can't make a small discovery, grand discovery, or truth that directly affects another player's bug without their full permission. For example, discovering that toffee is actually poison is great flavour for the world, but if you've got a sweet-toothed bug in your party who loves snacking on toffee, you'll probably want to run that by them first.
- **Discoveries and truths should fit the tone of the story**. It should go without saying, but we're going to say it anyway - don't make hideous discoveries if you're aiming for a nice, genial tone, or super-detailed discoveries if you're having a laissez-faire wander through the world.

USING TRUTHS

We've already given a rundown of how truths work on page 44, but we'll give a shortened version here as well for ease of reference. So how do they affect things? Well, you have a choice here - a truth, once established, can be used to...

GAIN A 1D6 ENVIRONMENTAL ADVANTAGE

If a truth might aid your bug in undertaking an action, you can call on it for a 1d6 advantage (advantage is limited to 2d6 per roll, as shown on page 34). *This counts as your environmental advantage, so you **can't** double up for 2d6 by using the environment and a relevant truth.*

GAIN A FREE TWIST, UNDER YOUR CONTROL, ONCE PER SESSION

Though twists are usually only accessed through rolling doubles, each player can call on a truth once per session to add a twist to the story as it unfolds (without needing to rely on luck). This truth-based twist is also unique in that the player that invokes it has control over the effects, rather than the Weaver asking the rest of the table for suggestions. These special twists must still be approved by the Weaver, however. *You'll find more information on twists on page 37.*

- MYSTERIES AND TRUTHS EXAMPLE -

Weaver: The pawprints end at the base of the tree - whatever you were following is nowhere to be seen.

Dunf: I think... I think I just solved my mystery.

Layla: Ooh, tell us!

Dunf: Well, look at my small discoveries. 'Some are the colour of fire', 'They love the night-time', and now 'They can disappear without a trace'...

Bicco: Oh, I remember! Your mystery was '**What Are Cats, Really?**'. That was a good one.

Dunf: Ha, thanks. But now I've filled in the last line of the triangle, I can make my grand discovery, right? Add a truth to the world?

Weaver: Yep, as long as you have the spotlight, which you definitely do at the moment.

Dunf: Then I'm going to do it right now! Dunf look at the prints, then up at the tree, then around at his friends. 'Guys', he says, 'I don't want to alarm anybody, but... I think cats might actually be *ghosts*'.

Swift: ... Damn, I **love** that!

Weaver: Me too - if everyone's happy with that, and it looks like they are, then from now on in our game, *cats are literally ghosts*. And with that established, a spectral yowl drifts down from the branches above...

OTHER CHANGES

While the truths a mystery can lead to are useful in terms of what they can do for a bug in the moment, they often have wider reaching implications. You're changing the very nature of the world here - there are bound to be some knock-on effects.

These might come in the form of...

Changes to Hazards: Using the example on the left, if all cats in PICO are found to be ghosts, feline hazards should also gain the ghostly keyword in addition to the beastly keyword.

Changes to Environments: Perhaps the bugs have found out that everyone, no matter how small, can have a measure of control over the way the wind blows. The Weaver might choose to incorporate that into the environment by adding an element that plays off of it - something along the lines of silk-gliding spiders, or a local weather system controlled by moving a rusted weathervane.

Changes to the Story: If you're really ambitious, a grand discovery and the associated truth might change the course of a story arc the bugs are involved in... Or maybe even one they thought they'd completed. After all, if you establish 'No One Ever Really Dies' as a truth of the world, you might have a very angry conquered foe coming after you once more...

CHOOSING YOUR STARTING MYSTERY

The mystery you wish to solve is entirely up to you - it might be something your bug has struggled with for years, a flight of fancy, an idle curiosity, or even a question that struck you as a player when you first heard about this game, or the world of PICO.

You are entirely at liberty to make up your own unique mystery to start the game with - in fact, we encourage it. But if you'd rather pick from a pre-made list... well, the rest of this page *might* give you a few ideas...

NAMES

"A bug by any other name is a rose. A very crunchy rose."

All bugs have two names. The first is a **common** name, and used among friends. The second is complex, **pseudoscientific**, and multifaceted - the kind of name that might have been used by a pre-Mysteriocalypse scientist when classifying a whole group of scuttling critters, or that a bugly mother might call out after *someone* broke her favourite vase. We'll tackle them in reverse order below - you'll see why soon enough.

PSEUDOSCIENTIFIC

A bug's pseudoscientific name is taken from a combination of their aspects and augments. Each part and buddy aspect, and the augments that improve them, have a **name segment**. String enough of these together, and you've got a name!

***Example**: Garret is purchasing aspects and augments as he makes his bug. He goes for the Hardshell aspect (which comes with the segment 'athro'), along with the Hollow and Spiky augments (with name segments 'don' and 'kiri' respectively). Putting those segments together, he gets the final result 'Athrodonkiri' - the perfect pseudoscientific name for a spiky hollow hard-shelled bug!*

SEGMENT ORDER AND LONGER NAMES

Almost all bugs will have two or more part/buddy aspects they can draw name segments from. We recommend using the first two of these for your pseudoscientific name, along with any augments that add to them, but don't feel like you have to put names together in this way!

The lack of actual scientists in the world of PICO means that other bugs aren't going to question you over the accuracy of your pseudoscientific name. If you want to put a segment from an augment before the aspect it adds to, we're not going to stop you. Want to ignore some parts entirely, or add a flourish of your own? The pen, pencil, or keyboard is in your hand!

***Example**: Garret's not sure about his bug's pseudoscientific name, so he plays with it a little by putting the augment segments before the aspect ones. That gives him either 'Donkiriathro' or 'Kiridonathro' and, liking the sound of the second one, that's what he goes with. He also adds a second part taken from his Razor-Edged Pinpointennae, giving him a final name of 'Kiridonathro Zioxei' - suitably pseudoscientific!*

COMMON

Now you've worked out your pseudoscientific name, your common name might be easier to choose - you could grab a segment of that name and use it, name yourself after an action you often perform or a feature of your body, or just choose a name you think sounds appropriately bugly!

***Example**: Garret has his bug's pseudoscientific name, but it's a bit of a mouthful. For a common name he decides to take his favourite segment of the aforementioned, 'Kiri', and add a second name of his own devising - 'Katroza'. After sounding it out a few times, he decides it's perfect, and Kiri Katroza is born!*

ANYTHING CAN BE A NAME

We don't know if you know this, but all names are ultimately made up if you go back far enough. A party of bugs might contain a Tekino Wildfire, a Goose Gomono, a Castiel the Swift, a Josephina, and a Dave. Don't feel like you have to hew close to any particular naming process with common names, just go with whatever feels *right*.

***Example**: Heru and his friends have gathered to play a game of PICO, but first they need to make their characters. With all Nectar spent and choices made, they start to tackle the last step of the process - finding perfect names. For a few of them this comes easily, as Freya thinks 'Galahad' would be an excellent name for an armoured bug, and Laura names every character she makes after her own cat. Heru is the last to decide, and after toying around with the components of his pseudoscientific name for a few minutes makes the decision to ignore them entirely and call his little bug 'Book'. Why? Because he's holding one in his hand, and he wants to start rolling the dice!*

... And you're done!

"Everything in its right place."

You've now purchased aspects, augments, and skills for your bug, fleshed them out with a few moods, chosen bits and bobs, a starting mystery and, perhaps most importantly, given them a pseudoscientific and a common name. So what else is there left to do?

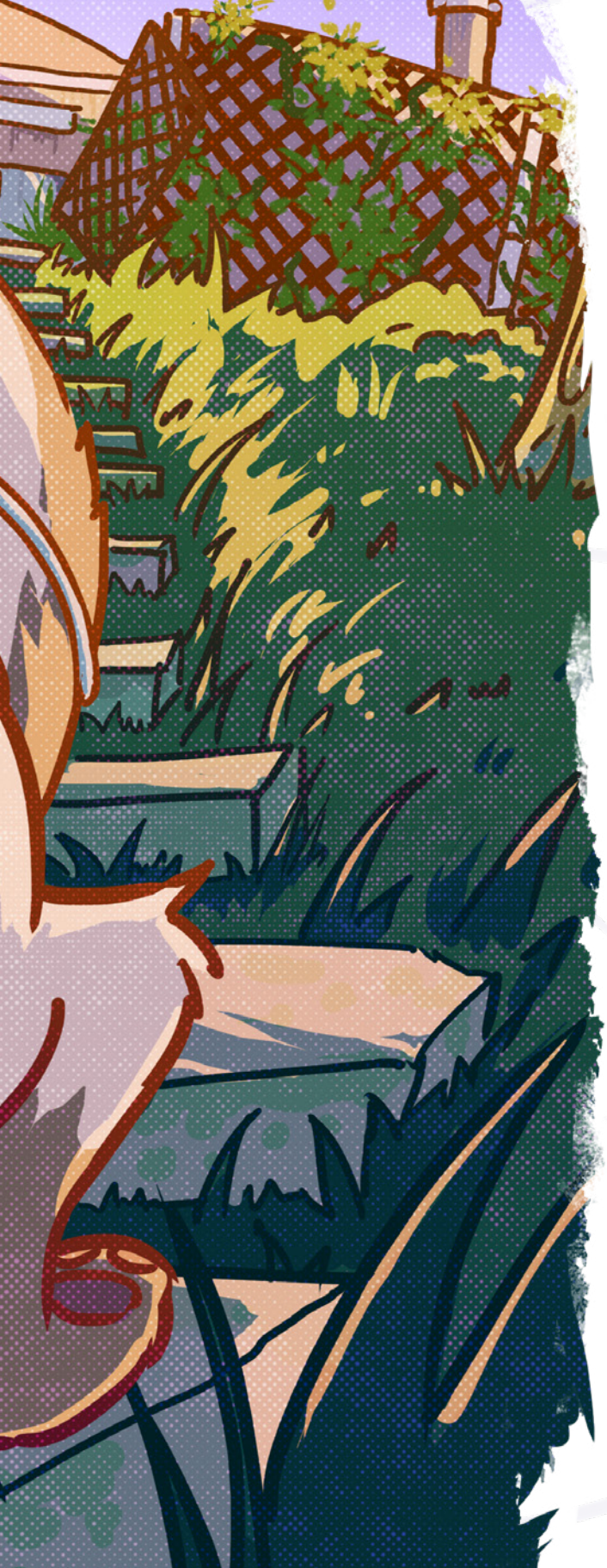
Play the game, that's what!

Change (in the House of Flies)

Bugs develop over time, by earning Nectar and spending it on more aspects, augments, and skills, but they're also changed by the very nature of their adventuring. If one of the more central parts of your bug starts to feel like it doesn't apply anymore (such as a mood, which wouldn't normally change), chat with the Weaver about swapping it out for free next time you moult.

The most important thing about your character, at the end of the day, is that you have fun playing them.

CHAPTER 08:
PICOTITANS



WHAT ARE PICOTITANS?

That chicken with a bakery on its back, scratching dirt just outside of Craniopolis? The munchkin cat with goggles and racing stripes, zooming along the garden path? The golden-furred fox with a watchtower on its tail and a gondola nestled under its chin, having its coat brushed by adoring passengers?

Those are all picotitans - massive beasts that form long-lasting bonds with bugs, acting as helper, vehicle, and roving home.

They're kind of a big deal.

SIZE & TRAINING

Picotitans are much bigger than bugs.

This might seem like it goes without saying, but the concept of relative size is an important one here - they're bigger than bugs, but *smaller than other titans*. In terms of the official size chart on pages 12 and 13, they sit **somewhere between huge and titan size**.

This is because picotitans are most often **the runts of a particular titan litter**, pushed from the nest or abandoned on the forest-fringe when young. Bugs might be friendly, on the whole, but nature is cruel - it happens more than you might think.

Enterprising titan-trainers seek out these abandoned animals (usually not too hard, given the amount of noise they can make), rescue them, and raise them, with most of their efforts going in the direction of instilling a young picotitan with a singular important idea - that bugs are friends you can *trust*, rather than friends you can *eat*.

And as far as anybody knows, titan-trainers have a 100% success rate in such matters. You certainly never hear back from any that have failed.

TITAN-DENS

As fun as it might sound, hanging off of the fur or feathers of a titan as it races across the landscape isn't the easiest way to travel. Because of this, bugly bands often build a **titan-den** on their picotitan - a comfortable backpack-type settlement with a few useful conveniences and a storage-place for the animal's favourite treats. *We'll delve more into building a titan-den for your picotitan on page 184.*

THE ROAMING SHEET

"Everything in its right place."

Below we have a quick breakdown of the Roaming Sheet, at least the bits of it that relate to picotitans.

1 **NAME**: Some picotitans are named by their bugs, while others name themselves, but they all have a name!

2 **ANIMAL**: A base animal that best represents your picotitan (options on page 180 to page 183).

3 **FAVOUR**: A numerical measure of your picotitan's trust, spent to activate picotitan actions.

4 **GAINING FAVOUR**: Ways bugs can spend their tasks on improving their picotitan's Favour.

5 **AURA**: This allows bugs to reduce Tough Cut on actions using certain skills when near the picotitan.

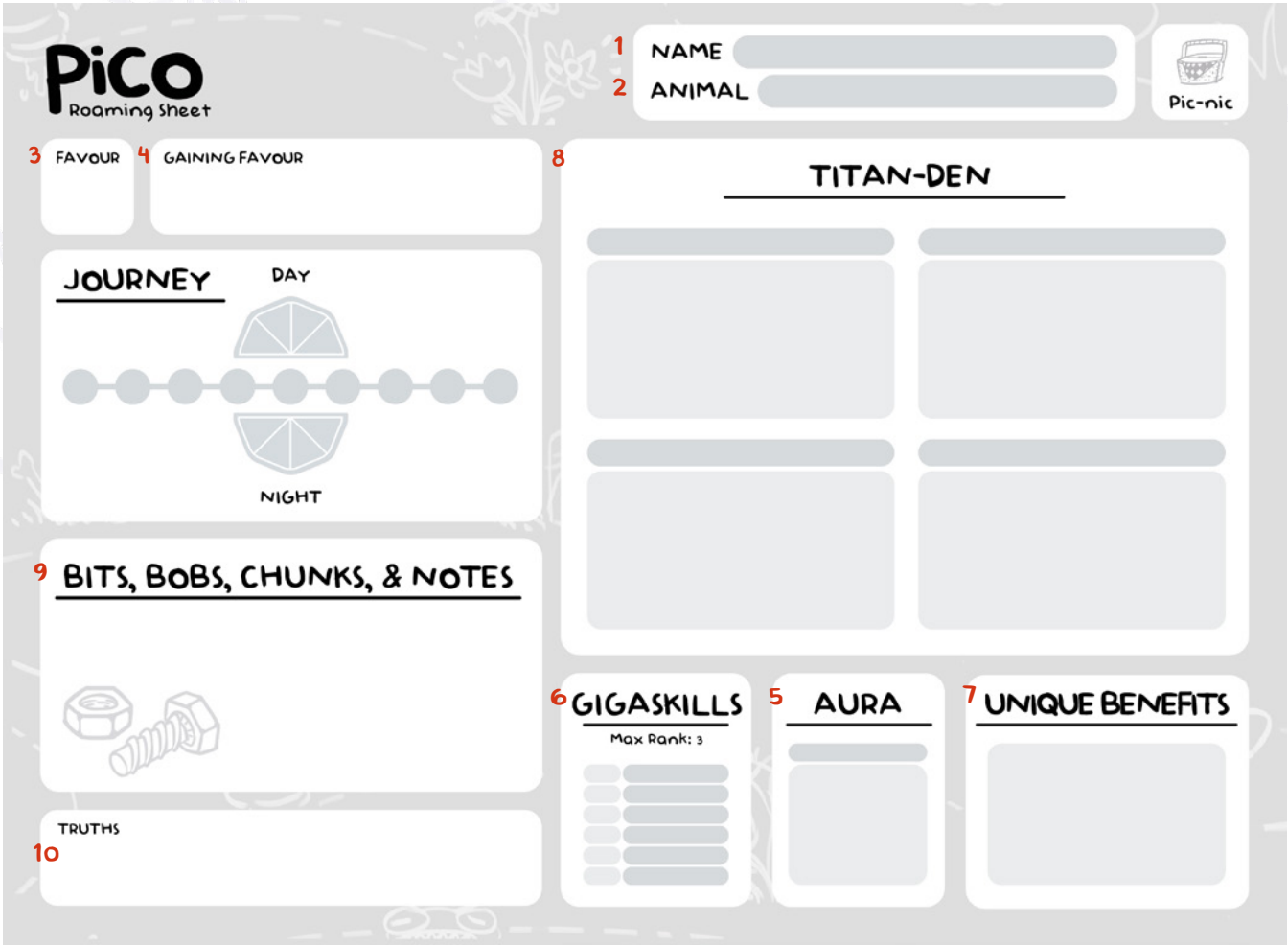
6 **GIGASKILLS**: A representation of your picotitan's innate skills, which can be used by spending Favour.

7 **UNIQUE BENEFITS**: A special benefit unique to your animal type.

8 **TITAN-DEN**: A section for adding structures to your picotitan's back using chunks.

9 **BITS, BOBS, CHUNKS, & NOTES**: A space to record anything your picotitan picks up or stores.

10 **TRUTHS**: Known truths about the world, revealed through grand discoveries.



OBTAINING A PICOTITAN

Some bugly bands might be lucky enough to start their adventure with a picotitan as part of their group. If this is the case for you, you can skip straight to the next page and start learning about what a picotitan actually *does*.

But for other groups (especially those that are playing PICO for a longer, campaign-style experience rather than a one-shot), obtaining a picotitan is the first step to creating your **mobile home-away-from-home**.

But how do bugs go about obtaining a friend that's twenty times their size? There are a couple of options...

TRADING

If you're wealthy sorts you might want to seek out a picotitan trainer (sometimes found in the wild, but more often at picotitan stables in larger settlements). What's the price of a trained picotitan? Invaluable, really, but trainers will likely let one go for **a huge hoard of bits and bobs**.

How many bits and bobs to a hoard? Hoo boy, that's a tough one... It's hard to put a number on it, but let's go with... Twenty? Fifty? Thirty-ish? *It's really just up to the Weaver, but should depend on the rarity of the bits and bobs being delivered - a trainer might accept 10 pre-Mysteriocalypse relics, or 30 delicious bits, or 5 bobs with a spring...*

EARNING

Possessions are great, but hard work is better. Trainers are just like anyone else - they often need things done that they might not want to do themselves. A trainer might gift a picotitan to the first band of bugs that can clear some froglin punks out of a local pond, or retrieve the mysterious ticking amulet on Watchmaker's Hill, or steal into the mustachioed mayor's house in the dead of night and shave his whiskers as a prank.

An impressive adventure nets an impressive creature! *Earning a picotitan usually slots it easily into an ongoing campaign or adventure, or can even be the impetus behind one!*

RAISING

If you want to take the hardcore route, there's nothing stopping you from finding your own titan runt and raising them, over time, to be a loyal friend.

... Is what we *would* say, if it were that easy. It's definitely not. But if that's still something that interest you, it's there as an option!

When bugs want to raise a picotitan, they first need to find a suitable creature and then slowly earn its trust, likely by filling a Progress Track set by the Weaver over a longer period of time (you'll find the rules for Progress Tracks on page 32). Don't expect a firm friend after a single visit, though - training is playing the long game.

INHERITING

Almost as easy as just starting the game with a picotitan of your own!

Picotitans tend to live longer than the bugs that ride them, and can be excellent longstanding family friends. A picotitan ridden by multiple generations of the same bugs is usually the happiest sort, both loved and cared for like a pet and venerated like a wise old uncle.

The journey to inherit a picotitan from a family member in a distant location is an excellent start to a campaign of PICO, an adventure with a tangible and exciting goal.

STEALING

The questions '*can* you steal a picotitan?' and '*should* you steal a picotitan?' have very different answers.

You could certainly *try* to steal a picotitan - they're often left in stables outside of settlements, or to rest under trees in the shade, or at the entrances of warrens and burrows too small for them to fit into. And picotitans are, by default, trained not to eat bugs, and to avoid conflict at almost all costs.

But... You know...

We'll leave the ethics and morals of this situation up to you and your group, but **as a general rule, we advise against starting off a picotitan friendship with theft/kidnapping**. The consequences tend to follow one around.

WHAT CAN PICOTITANS DO?

"The arrogance of some bugs is in thinking that picotitans are in their control, and not the other way around."

Once a band of bugs has a picotitan to call their own, it would be the height of silliness not to bring its best qualities into the limelight every now and then. But what can a picotitan actually do during a game of PICO, and to what extent are they under the control of the players? Let's jump right in and answer some questions with some handy informational text boxes!

ACT INDEPENDENTLY

No matter how strong your bond with a picotitan is, it's a creature with free will and its own wants; **picotitans are controlled by the Weaver**, not directly by any other player at the table.

But that doesn't mean you can't influence a picotitan's actions or behaviour, or have them help out. Narratively you can treat them like an NPC in that regard, but there's also a mechanical element to proceedings: **Favour**. This is a resource earned by feeding, playing with, and grooming your oversized companion, and can be spent on various useful abilities (such as helping you with an Action Roll in a sticky situation). *You'll find rules for gaining and spending Favour on page 176.*

HELP OUT!

There are many ways a picotitan's presence can be beneficial for a band of bugs, both mechanically and narratively. First off, every picotitan has an **aura of competency** around them, allowing for easier rolls of particular skills. Secondly, **Favour can be spent for a variety of benefits** depending on the type of scene you're currently in - and that's not even mentioning a picotitan's own **unique benefits**, special things that each species of picotitan can do to change the rules of the game. They even have their own **innate gigaskills!**

But as useful as these things are, the ability to ride a picotitan gives one additional important benefit while travelling from place to place - speed. **The strides you cover with a travel action are doubled when riding on a picotitan**. Longer legs cover more ground!

And while mechanical upsides are good, there's also the basic narrative benefit you get from having a friendly goliath on side!

BE PRESENT... ISH

If every moment of the game had your band of bugs strolling around with a giant, well-meaning friend in tow, things would get complicated fast. As a rule of thumb, **picotitans don't enter settlements** - they can wait outside or, in fancier places, be settled in a stable for the duration of your visit.

Outside of settlements a picotitan's level of involvement very much depends on the situation. **They won't typically join rumbles**, as they're trained explicitly to avoid causing harm in almost all situations, but they might nose around in the background of a scene or montage while you smaller folk do characterish things, and can often help out merely by being a big, solid, reassuring presence.

By contrast, journeys are where a picotitan *shines*. Though still under the control of the Weaver, **expect a picotitan to pretty much do what you need it to do on a journey** without much fuss (unless your table agrees that having a more wilful companion is something you're all intrigued by). *You'll find rules for using picotitans during travel on page 87.*

CARRY A TITAN-DEN

One of a picotitan's most useful features is the ability to **lug around bug-sized structures with ease**. These titan-dens are somewhere between treehouse, driver's cab, and palanquin, and are often built up and out by bugs over the course of many journeys.

Building a titan-den isn't easy, though; it requires a special type of resource, **chunks** (explained on page 160), and a significant time investment. They're worth it though, especially if you're on the road a lot. *There are rules for creating a titan-den on page 184.*

... AND WHAT CAN'T THEY DO?

Restrictions are important! They set boundaries and expectations, and make sure that everyone is on the same page. Picotitans are pretty powerful compared to the average bug, and if they were allowed to run amok through the world of PICO we'd be playing a very different game in a lot of situations, so there's one rule concerning picotitans that overrides all others...

PICOTITANS CAN'T SOLVE ALL OF YOUR PROBLEMS ALL OF THE TIME

... But solving *some* of your problems *some* of the time is definitely within their wheelhouse.

THE TABLE SETS THE BOUNDARIES

Ultimately, your own group will decide how to handle picotitans, and the power they offer, based on the rules and suggestions in this chapter. This is the kind of thing that's worth talking about during a session zero (if you start with a picotitan) or part-way through a campaign (if it looks like a band of bugs is going to obtain one). *You'll find suggestions for a session zero on page 192.*

Favour

"Vast, Polyphemus-like, and adorable."

This is a measure of how a picotitan feels about the band of bugs riding on its back, and a good indicator of its general mood. The higher a picotitan's Favour, the more helpful it is.

Earning Favour

Each picotitan has several options for earning its Favour recorded in its statblock, ways of making it happy (like feeding or grooming it). These are performed as **tasks**, meaning that the best time to do them is during a montage, but be warned - **a picotitan can only have its Favour increased once per scene**.

Some of these tasks also have additional costs, like finding the right kind of food or taking some damage, but don't worry: these methods of earning favour all represent treats, ways to go above or beyond. It's assumed that a picotitan will be able to find enough food and water to survive, or that your bugs are giving it a comfortable enough existence 'off-camera'.

***Example**: Borku is a canine picotitan, a yappy little sort with a well-stocked kitchen balanced precariously on his back. The bugs he carries feed him bits that don't make it to the pot to gain favour most of the time, but every now and then they take advantage of his 'luxury feeding' Favour option and give him a fully prepared meal as a special treat. They also groom him, which takes two tasks rather than the usual one (so normally just has two bugs from the band working together to accomplish it), but doesn't require any bits or bobs to be consumed in the process.*

Additional Favour

The Weaver can break the usual 'one Favour per scene' rule by **awarding Favour for narrative developments that please a picotitan**. They might also remove a point of Favour if the bugs do something that puts their picotitan in an unusually dangerous or scary situation though - it does go both ways!

***Example**: The band of bugs that rides Borku are making their way through an abandoned pre-M playground, full of rusted climbing frames and faded plastics. But what's that poking out of the dirt over there? Could it be... a rubber bone? Borku is overjoyed, and the Weaver lets them know that he's barely holding himself back. The bugs dismount and let their canine friend play with its new toy for a while, sacrificing some time on their journey but being rewarded by several points of Favour at once - Borku's a happy pup!*

Spending Favour

Once a picotitan has at least one point of favour, the bugs can spend it on **picotitan actions** from the box below. **Each picotitan action costs a single point of favour**, and some picotitans have special actions that are unique to them.

***Example**: The bugs riding Borku spend a point of favour as they travel to use the Titanwatch action, allowing their faithful hound to sniff out a trove of treasures nearby without needing to roll in the lookout phase.*

Picotitan Actions

Titanic Aid

Used in scenes, this allows a picotitan to briefly rush in and aid a bug as they perform an action. If this requires a roll, make it as normal but substitute the bug's usual skill for one of the picotitan's inherent gigaskills.

Titanotask

Used in a montage, this allows the picotitan to perform a single task independent of any bugs (as long as it aligns with one of the picotitan's gigaskills). If this task is particularly boisterous, it might impact bugs who are trying to use elements of the titan-den for their own tasks.

Titanwatch

Used on a journey, specifically while making Lookout Rolls, this allows the titan to spot something that the bugs might not notice on their own. Spending Favour on this action doesn't replace any of the usual bugly Lookout Rolls, and doesn't require a roll of its own either; instead, simply choose one of the lookout results as a group without any element of randomness.

Titanospeed

Used on journeys for a simple but effective outcome; while riding a picotitan doubles the strides a travel action covers, spending a point of Favour triples these lengths for a single action instead.

THE LIMITS OF FAVOUR

Good feelings can only get you so far. The following rules govern a few of the ways picotitans should and shouldn't act within a game of PICO, no matter how much Favour is accrued or spent.

DOWNTIME, ANYTIME

Because a picotitan is under the control of the Weaver, they won't spend the entirety of their time helping bugs outside of journeys. What if there's an exciting smell to follow, or a cool bit of branch to play with? How can they be expected to be on the clock the whole time? That would just be unreasonable.

At the end of the day, picotitans *aren't bugs*. They don't see the world in the same way, and they don't share the same priorities.

***Example**: Borku's bugly friends are struggling to replace a piece of piping on the side of an old farmhouse, working against the clock before an approaching storm floods a drain-hugging settlement. Borku spends most of this scene playing with a bit of the old piping, off to the side of things. It's not that he won't help - in fact, one of the bugs spends a point of Favour on Titanic Aid to have Borku saunter in and hold the pipe in place for a while with his beastly strength. It's just that without Favour being spent on some direct commands, he just doesn't understand the urgency of the situation, or what the bugs are trying to achieve, or why. Dogs aren't renowned for their mastery of plumbing, after all.*

Instead, picotitans will usually do their own thing unless they're directly engaged in the story. Certain scenes might lead to the Weaver having a picotitan take an active role, even helping out without any Favour being spent at all, but this should be reserved for **only when it's narratively appropriate, not just when it would be helpful**.

THE GOODEST TITANS

A huge part of raising and training a picotitan is instilling a general pacifism into it that most beasts lack. **Picotitans don't have Heart Tracks**, as they shouldn't be in protracted encounters as an active participant - they're raised as friends, not fighters. They will, if Favour is spent, leap into a melee when Titanic Aid is used for an Attack or Defend Roll, but **not if this would cause direct harm to bugs (even hostile bugs)**. Other things that don't have the bugly keyword? They're fair game.

If you want a picotitan to be able to take a few hits in a rumble, you can decrease their Favour by one each time they get hit instead of dealing any damage - but discuss this alternate rule with your table first to make sure it fits the tone of your game.

- PICOTITAN FAVOUR EXAMPLE -

Weaver: The cluckatrice in the yard isn't 'yours' yet, though in truth, picotitan ownership is a bit of a misnomer.

Swift: It's more like a partnership, right?

Weaver: Exactly. Anyway, it isn't part of your little band yet, but you've made it clear that you're angling for it to join up, so you can actually start building Favour with it now if you like - it'll help progress the Friendship Track I've set for you, and if you do manage to fill it you'll start with a bit of Favour from the get go.

Swift: Nice, that sounds like a good idea. And on that very same subject, I think we've got something that might be right up this feathered friend's alley...

Layla: Oh, that's right! I've been collecting some bits that it might want, I've got three husks of corn in my backpack I've been saving.

Weaver: Well then, let's slip into a montage. Basic feeding for a cluckatrice takes two bits, and gives one point of Favour - I'll mark the Friendship Track once for that as well, so you're one step closer to having a massive friend of your very own! Layla, cross those bits off of your sheet as the cluckatrice pecks at them.

AURA

Perhaps the simplest benefit of having a picotitan around is their Aura, a general boost to morale and capability for any bugs lucky enough to have a massive friend on side.

All picotitans have one of four Auras, each affecting a different category of skills...

- **Friendly**: Reduces Tough Cut by one on any action using one of the friending skills.
- **Bouncy**: Reduces Tough Cut by one on any action using one of the moving skills.
- **Feisty**: Reduces Tough Cut by one on any action using one of the rumbling skills.
- **Inquisitive**: Reduces Tough Cut by one on any action using one of the finding skills.

... And it really is as simple as that! Being in the vicinity of your picotitan (so probably close enough to see them, and for them to see you) gives you an easy way to reduce Tough Cut on your rolls, without needing to spend Favour or fulfill any other special requirements.

***Example**: Curtis is trying to negotiate with a trader out on the road. The trader drives a hard bargain, and the Weaver adds a Tough Cut of 2 to the roll, but Borko is close by - that Tough Cut is knocked down to one by the friendly pup's Aura.*

GIGASKILLS

Though it often takes a lot of effort or teamwork for a bug to access giga impact, picotitans are just *built different* - with size on their side, feats of herculean strength and skill come easily.

A bug can spend Favour to access 'Titanic Aid', allowing them to use a picotitan's gigaskill for a single action by replacing the dice they'd usually add for their own skill ranks. The resulting action has giga impact by default, and narratively involves the picotitan itself stepping in to physically help out.

All picotitans start with two gigaskills at rank 3 and two gigaskills at rank 2.

POTENTIAL LIMITS

For some tables, it may be worth limiting the number of times a picotitan's gigaskills can be used in a scene (on top of the usual limits that Favour imposes). We recommend discussing this during session zero if it seems like something your table might benefit from.

***Example**: Kylliant, a brilliantly chitinous alchemist, is looking for some subterranean bits as part of a shroom-based concoction they're throwing together. The ground is hard and stony, and they're not exactly an expert on digging in the best of situations... But Borko is! One point of spent Favour later and stones and soil go flying, revealing a mycelial bounty of just the right kind.*

Unique Benefits

Each picotitan comes with at least one inherent benefit, themed around the kind of animal that the picotitan represents. Some can deal damage, others add positive tags to certain bits you find... There are as many unique benefits as there are types of titan!

***Example**: Oskari, a millipede adventurer, has been riding Borko for as long as he can remember. Though a naturally surly type, Borko's unique benefit allows bugs that groom him to raise their own mood in the process; Oskari's player uses this as often as possible to access his positive mood and keep Borko's Favour topped up for the rest of his band to use.*

It doesn't cost Favour to use a unique benefit **unless the text of the benefit explicitly calls for it** (the foxfriend's Binbreaker ability, for example, requires you to spend a point of Favour to access it, but the Catling's Predator Instinct triggers every time you spend a montage without any associated spend). The only additional rule here is that unless otherwise specified, unique benefits (like Auras) require you to be in the vicinity of your picotitan in order to use them.

Titan-den Benefits

Bugs that take the time to construct a titan-den can access many more unique benefits, each related to the kinds of structure being built. Other than the additional cost of time and materials to build these structures, titan-den benefits work exactly the same way as any other benefits a picotitan might give. *You'll find rules for constructing your own titan-den on page 184.*

***Example**: Kylliant's experiments have a habit of blowing up in his face, so he and his group decided to add a bunkroom to the titan-den upon Borko's back. The bunkroom's starting benefit, A Place To Rest Your Head, allows him to spend Favour during a montage to heal entire aspects in one go - useful for the kind of bug that always seems to find themselves in the middle of an explosion!*

Carrying Chunks

In addition to all of the good stuff a picotitan can get from their unique benefits and titan-den, **all picotitans also have the ability to hold a single chunk at a time** (in their mouths, or paws, or maybe balanced on their tail). Because chunks are large enough that most bugs can't move them, let alone carry them, this additional innate benefit is almost essential for the building and upgrading of titan-den structures.

***Example**: When the bugs riding Borko happen upon an entire box of pre-Mysteriocalypse matches, they could split them up between the various members of the band and continue as normal. But they have their sights set on a kitchen, and the matches will provide a useful fuel source - they have Borko pick up the entire box in his mouth as a chunk, keeping it for a construction project later on down the line.*

- Picotitan Benefits Example -

Weaver: Percival cocks his head sideways, looking at the four of you shivering down there on the snowy ground. There's a long, dangerous moment as his avian mind runs through potential scenarios.

Layla: Can we subtly remind him that we gave him all that seed last week?

Weaver: I don't think chickens are known for being subtle...

Layla: Good point. I take out one of my seeds and wave it around, shouting "Come on man, there's more where that came from!"

Weaver: Oddly enough, that actually seems to work. With the promise of a more seed-based future, the titanic chicken ruffles his plumage before lowering his tail-feathers down to the ground. He's inviting you on board.

Dunf: Well, it took a lot of work to get here, but I think that means we have a picotitan of our very own. For as long as we keep him fed, anyway.

Weaver: It does seem that way! Do you climb up?

Bicco: Definitely!

Weaver: Then it's time to reap your first reward - up amongst Percival's feathers, the winter winds don't seem to cut through you anywhere near as much. While you're riding your new picotitan, his Incubation benefit means you won't take any negatives from cold weather.

Dunf: No more frozen antennae? I'll take that win!

CHOOSING A PICOTITAN

"The colour of the fur is peerless. None could find the words to describe it, although one said it was reminiscent of the deepest ink..."

Choosing the picotitan that's right for you is a big deal - you need to think not only of the aesthetics, but the mechanics as well! As shown on page 172, all picotitans come with a few mechanical benefits that bugs can use to their advantage, which are then added to over time by constructing a platform of useful rooms and equipment for your particular band of bugs. Each picotitan entry below contains a **name** and **description**, as well as information on how to gain the titan's **Favour**, the **gigaskills** they can use, the **Aura** they give off, the **speed bonus** they offer during travel, and the **unique benefit** they give to all friendly bugs in their presence.

Choosing a picotitan should be a group choice - if you're going to be riding and caring for the thing for the foreseeable future, might as well choose one that makes everybody at the table happy!

AXOLITTLE (picotitan)

Paradoxically named, because they're actually pretty large compared to some of the amphibians you find around puddles and ponds. Extremely, painfully cute. *Can carry one chunk.*

GAINING FAVOUR

- **Grooming**: 2 tasks
- **Splash about**: Once per scene, requires a nearby body of water
- **Basic Feeding**: 3 slimy bits

GIGASKILLS

- **Rank 3**: Gigaswim, Gigacare
- **Rank 2**: Gigasizzle, Gigadazzle

AURA

Bouncy: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 on moving actions

UNIQUE BENEFITS

Amphibious: The axolittle carries enough air within its ruff to keep bugs breathing underwater indefinitely, as long as they stay reasonably close.

CATLING (picotitan)

A smaller than average cat with only a tinge of the divine presence most larger felines possess, socialized around bugs to the extent that their wicked claws stay sheathed... For the most part. *Can carry one chunk.*

GAINING FAVOUR

- **Grooming**: 2 tasks
- **Playful Hunt**: 1 task, deals a mark of Slash damage
- **Basic Feeding**: 3 meat-based bits
- **Luxury Feeding**: 1 meat-based meal

GIGASKILLS

- **Rank 3**: Gigaslink, Gigahunt
- **Rank 2**: Gigaslash, Gigadance

AURA

Feisty: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 on rumbling actions

UNIQUE BENEFITS

Predator Instinct: It doesn't matter how cute a catling appears, it's still an opportunistic hunter at heart. Your band gains a free bit whenever you take a montage, either "Meaty Present" or "Suspicious Bone".

CLUCKATRUCE (picotitan)

There are many legends about chickens - how they can turn a bug to stone with their gaze, how their eggs are prisons, how their feathers are lucky if they come loose on a Tuesday. Fortunately, anyone that's spent any time around such pecking pests will know that all of these legends are false. *Can carry one chunk.*

GAINING FAVOUR

- **Grooming**: 3 tasks
- **Greet the Dawn**: Once per day, at sunrise, for free
- **Basic Feeding**: 2 bits

GIGASKILLS

- **Rank 3**: Gigafly, Gigayap
- **Rank 2**: Gigaswagger, Gigatame

AURA

Inquisitive: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 on finding actions

UNIQUE BENEFITS

Incubation: Riding a chicken allows you to ignore any negative weather effects that stem from colder temperatures.

DISASTERGOOSE (picotitan)

An elegant ball of barely concealed hatred for everything in the world that is not goose-like, this picotitan only vaguely puts up with the bugs that have chosen to make a home on its back... At least, that's the impression it likes to give in public. *Can carry one chunk.*

GAINING FAVOUR

- **Grooming**: 3 tasks
- **Become the Quarry**: Take a step on a journey without the goose's speed bonus, once per day
- **Basic Feeding**: 1 bit, 1 bob, and deals a mark of Scare Damage

GIGASKILLS

- **Rank 3**: Gigafly, Gigabash
- **Rank 2**: Gigadash, Gigascare

AURA

Feisty: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 on rumbling actions

UNIQUE BENEFITS

Swannish Song: Spend two points of Favour to have the disastergoose produce a hideous honking, dealing inescapable Gigascare Damage to all hazards in the vicinity... And any friendly bugs that happen to be in range.

FOXFRIEND (picotitan)

A flash of russet among the forest leaves? The clanging of a bin-lid? That's a foxfriend alright, the undisputed kings of rummaging. *Can carry two chunks.*

GAINING FAVOUR

- **Grooming**: 2 tasks
- **Sniff & Yip**: 1 task, requires a heavily scented POI
- **Basic Feeding**: 4 bits

GIGASKILLS

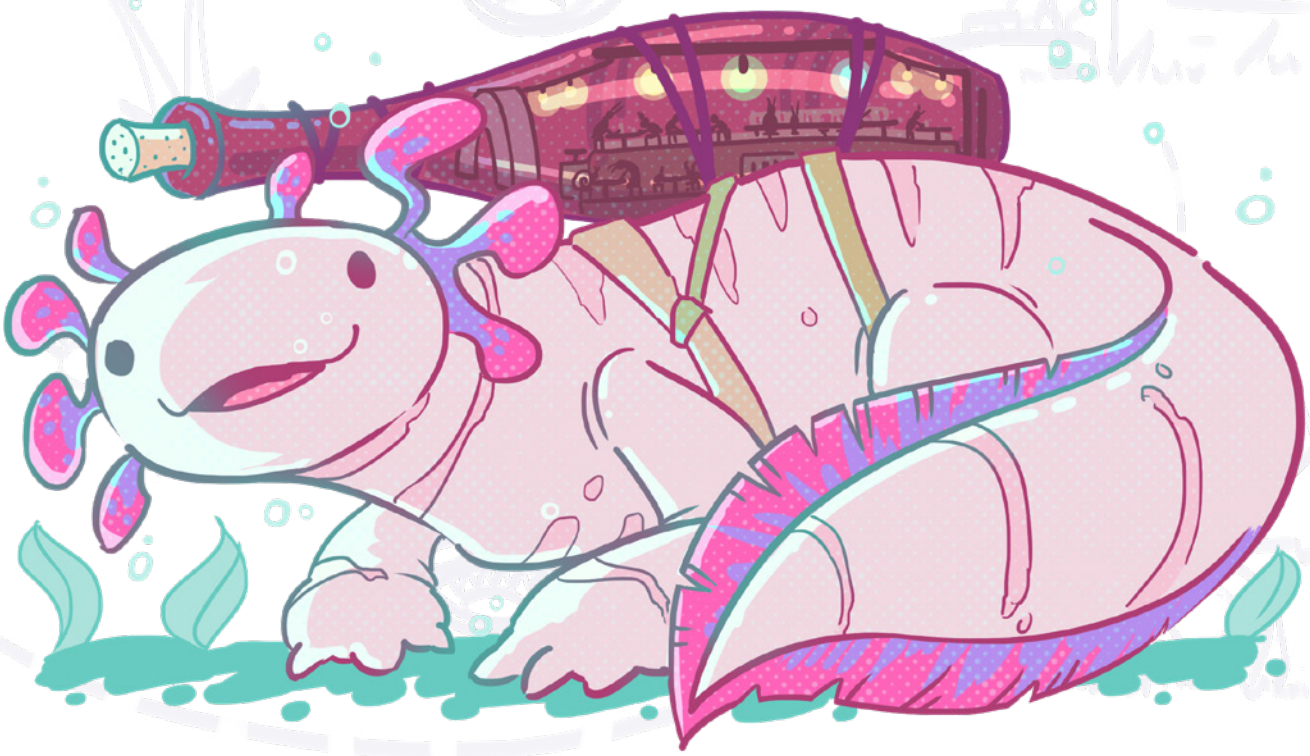
- **Rank 3**: Gigaslink, Gigarummage
- **Rank 2**: Gigathink, Gigadig

AURA

Inquisitive: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 on finding actions

UNIQUE BENEFITS

Binbreaker: From trash to treasure, every time. You can spend a point of the foxfriend's Favour to remove a negative tag from a found bit or bob and replace it with a positive tag (supplied by the Weaver).



HOGLET (picotitan)

Those tusks, that tail, that spring in its step - hoglets are cheerful and easygoing by nature, especially when removed from the truffle-obsessed hierarchy that nature tends to shove them into. *Can carry one chunk.*

GAINING FAVOUR

» **Grooming**: 2 tasks
» **Snuffle**: 1 task, deals a mark of Care Damage
» **Basic Feeding**: 3 bits
» **Luxury Feeding**: 1 shroom-based meal

GIGASKILLS

» **Rank 3**: Gigachart, Gigaslash
» **Rank 2**: Gigashield, Gigahunt

AURA

Bouncy: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 on moving actions

UNIQUE BENEFITS

Old Habits Die Hard: Whenever a bug gains a fungal or shroomish bit, add a positive tag to it (chosen by the Weaver) and that bug clears a mark of damage from any of its tracks.

LAMBKIN (picotitan)

What could be softer than this? It's like floating through the world on a fluffy white cloud (especially if you're blessed with the lack of a sense of smell). *Can carry one chunk.*

GAINING FAVOUR

» **Grooming**: 2 tasks
» **Shearing**: 1 task, gain a bob, 'Soft Fleece', and take a mark of Slash Damage
» **Basic Feeding**: 4 bits

GIGASKILLS

» **Rank 3**: Gigacare, Gigasense
» **Rank 2**: Gigadance, Gigamake

AURA

Friendly: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 on friending actions

UNIQUE BENEFITS

Counting Sheep: Using a task to rest while in the vicinity of a lambkin allows a bug to pull their mood to positive and convert one burn into a mark (in place of the usual benefits).

OTTERKIP (picotitan)

Small even for a picotitan, otters are chosen for their speed, agility, and ability to swim in even the most dangerous conditions. *Can carry one chunk.*

GAINING FAVOUR

» **Grooming**: 2 tasks
» **Whisker-Cleaning**: 1 task, only in darkness
» **Basic Feeding**: 4 bits
» **Luxury Feeding**: 1 fish-based meal

GIGASKILLS

» **Rank 3**: Gigaswim, Gigadash
» **Rank 2**: Gigabite, Gigadazzle

AURA

Bouncy: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 on moving actions

UNIQUE BENEFITS

Aqua Cutter: When going on a journey through a wet environment, or during a storm, increase the amount of steps each journey action offers by 1.

PUPPO (picotitan)

The boundless energy of the canine picotitan is a glory to behold - it's almost impossible to find more positive attitude crammed into a single beast. That wagging tail can pack a hell of an accidental punch, too. *Can carry one chunk.*

GAINING FAVOUR

» **Grooming**: 2 tasks
» **Fetch**: 1 task, 1 bouncy or aerodynamic bob
» **Basic Feeding**: 3 meat-based bits
» **Luxury Feeding**: 1 meat-based meal

GIGASKILLS

» **Rank 3**: Gigayap, Gigabash
» **Rank 2**: Gigadig, Gigachart

AURA

Friendly: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 on friending actions

UNIQUE BENEFITS

Pet the Dog: Any bug that uses the grooming task during a montage can pull their mood to positive.

RACCOONIE (picotitan)

Grabbing hands, grabbing hands everywhere! Raccoons are known hoarders, expert at digging through trash piles and coming away with bits and bobs galore. Whether any of them are useful is an entirely different question. *Can carry two chunks.*

GAINING FAVOUR

- **Grooming**: 2 tasks
- **A Little Gift**: 3 bobs, and all bugs pull their mood to positive
- **Basic Feeding**: 1 bit and 1 bob

GIGASKILLS

- **Rank 3**: Gigarummage, Gigaswagger
- **Rank 2**: Gigaclimb, Gigamake

AURA

Inquisitive: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 on finding actions

UNIQUE BENEFITS

Grab-Hander: During a montage, a bug can use a task to Scrounge with the aid of the raccoon. If they do so, state three things you'd like to find rather than the usual one, and use the results of a single Scrounge Roll.

SERPENT (picotitan)

With glimmering scales and a long forked tongue, the snake is an uncommon but effective choice for a bugly friend. You probably won't get many visitors though. *Can carry one chunk.*

GAINING FAVOUR

- **Grooming**: 2 tasks
- **Venom-Milking**: 2 tasks, deals a mark of Sizzle Damage and each bug gains a bit, 'Snake Milk'
- **Basic Feeding**: 3 meat-based bits
- **Luxury Feeding**: 1 meat-based meal

GIGASKILLS

- **Rank 3**: Gigasizzle, Gigascare
- **Rank 2**: Gigabite, Gigaclimb

AURA

Feisty: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 on rumbling actions

UNIQUE BENEFITS

Anitvenom: Hair of the snake, that's what they say. Whenever a member of the bugly band would take Sizzle Damage, they may spend a point of favour from the serpent to avoid it entirely (no matter the amount).

SHELLCRAWLER (picotitan)

Ah, the tortoise - most majestic of shelled creatures, every movement a step in a dance, every motion a carefully planned expression of grace. You may not get where you're going with great speed, but you'll definitely be prepared by the time you get there. *Can carry two chunks.*

GAINING FAVOUR

- **Grooming**: 2 tasks
- **Spit & Polish**: 1 task, once per day
- **Basic Feeding**: 3 bits

GIGASKILLS

- **Rank 3**: Gigashield, Gigathink
- **Rank 2**: Gigatame, Gigasense

AURA

Friendly: Reduce Tough Cut by 1 on friending actions

UNIQUE BENEFITS

Slow & Steady: Unlike other picotitans, the tortoise doesn't give a speed bonus on journeys. Instead, whenever you take a montage during a journey, all bugs gain one additional task to use.

CREATING A TITAN-DEN

"If you build it, they will come. And they'll take their shoes off too, if they know what's good for them."

Once you have a picotitan that's friendly enough toward you to let you ride it, it's time to build your titan-den!

A titan-den is a collection of odds and ends adapted to fit the needs of travelling bugs, junk and treasure in equal amounts turned to rooms, quarters, and useful equipment - **features**. One picotitan might carry a fully functional kitchen alongside a luxurious set of sleeping quarters, another a cluttered workshop abutted by a bar and a smithy. The possibilities aren't endless... But there are quite a few of them to go around.

MATERIAL NEEDS & IMPROVISATION

All features of a titan-den require **chunks**, a much larger version of the bits and bobs that bugs are used to lugging around. A kitchen, for example, requires a tin can and a matchbox, the first to act as a flame-resistant room and the second to give a source of heat for cooking.

But... What if you can't find a tin can, or a matchbox?

Improvise.

The chunks listed in a feature's entry are kind of a 'best case' scenario, describing the typical presentation of a particular feature. If you don't have a tin can but you do manage to find a broken milk bottle, that'll probably do. No box of matches, but some firework fuses? Stick them in there instead! Using alternate chunks to those suggested will make your titan-den just that little bit more unique, and we heavily advise doing it when you can.

SETTING UP A FEATURE

Once you have the chunks you need (or something that's close enough to them, anyway), it's time to get building! When adding a new feature to your picotitan, you'll need to...

- **Begin** a montage
- **Consume** the required chunks (or stand-ins)
- **Use** a task to construct the feature
- **Spend** a point from your picotitan's Favour reserve

... And that's it, you're done! Add the feature to your roaming sheet, along with any special benefits it gives, and you're in business!

UPGRADING A FEATURE

Once you have a feature in place, you can continue to upgrade it by spending additional chunks. Each feature comes with a set of possible upgrades, and a list of the chunks needed for each one. Upgrading a feature works just like setting one up - start montage, consume chunks, use a task, spend Favour - and the chunks are just as mutable if you've got clever ideas to replace them.

Try to make sure that everyone's happy with a feature before adding it - many of the features offer team benefits, but a few of them are themed around skills or activities that are more specialized.

- CHUNKS EXAMPLE -

Weaver: The moles retreat, casting squinting backward glances in your direction (or at least where they think you probably are). It's a reprieve, but you don't think it'll last long.

Swift: Might be time to get out of here?

Layla: Not a bad idea - is there anything we should grab before we leave?

Dunf: Well, I was thinking... That huge lantern the moles were worshipping. Now that they're gone, is there anything stopping us from, you know... taking it?

Swift: Taking it?

Dunf: Yeah! I bet our picotitan could carry it - would it count as a chunk, Weaver?

Weaver: It would indeed.

Dunf: And we've been looking for a flashlight to upgrade the watchtower on Percival's back, but I think this might do well as a stand-in.

Layla: Dunf, that's brilliant! I think that would work!

Dunf: Time to call our cluckatrice then. And after that, yes, we should definitely start running!

KITCHEN (feature)

What could be finer than a home-cooked meal while out on the road? Campfires are nice and all, but a full kitchen that comes with the benefits of clean work surfaces and a built-in oven? AND a roof to keep the rain off? Well, that's a little slice of culinary heaven right there. *A kitchen comes with the following benefits...*

- **Home Cooking**: Meals made in a kitchen clear a mark of damage from any part track when consumed.
- **Cold Tin Roof**: Ignore all cut on rolls made to cook while in a kitchen that would usually be imposed by weather.

KITCHEN UPGRADES

- **Chimney (Metal Straw)**: With your picotitan near, spend 1 Favour to blast your current area with smoke. The next attack made by a friendly bug counts both bug and target as in darkness, and catches its target by surprise.
- **Leftover Bin (Thimble)**: When you roll a twist while making a meal in a kitchen, keep one of the bits that would normally have been consumed and add the 'Leftover' tag to it (in addition to any usual effects).
- **Larder (5 tasty bits)**: When using a task to cook in the kitchen, you only need one bit to make your roll (as opposed to the usual minimum requirement of two).
- **Feeding Chute (Shoehorn)**: When you roll a triumph while cooking a meal in the kitchen, gain a point of Favour with your picotitan (once per scene).

Required Chunks

Tin Can

Box of Matches

WORKSHOP (feature)

Every good inventor needs a workshop to call their own, a safe and vaguely explosion-proof place to tinker with technology and marvel at mechanisms. The basic workshop is a bit bare of spare parts, but nevertheless provides an excellent foothold on the path to clever creation. *A workshop comes with the following benefits...*

- **Stable Footing**: Prototypes made in a workshop last an extra scene if you roll a triumph, or for an extra action if you roll a conflict.
- **A Place of Study**: Ignore all cut on rolls made to craft while in a workshop that would usually be imposed by weather or time crunch.

WORKSHOP UPGRADES

- **Anvil (Sardine Tin)**: Treat results of 4, 5, or 6 as the same number when checking for doubles while crafting in your workshop.
- **Itemized Junk Pile (Scrap of Paper)**: When you roll a twist while making a prototype in the workshop, keep one of the bobs that would normally have been consumed and add the 'Junked' tag to it (in addition to any usual effects).
- **Overstocked Shelves (5 mechanical bobs)**: When using a task to craft in the workshop, you only need one bob to make your roll (as opposed to the usual minimum requirement of two).
- **Chemistry Set (Jam Jar)**: With your picotitan near, spend 1 Favour to inflict Gigasizzle Damage on any one hazard (once per scene).

Required Chunks

Metal Cage

Squarish Rock

WATCHTOWER (feature)

Far easier than scouting through the undergrowth or attempting to scale the landscape for a better view, a watchtower allows bugs to see further, and in greater clarity, than usual while on journey. *A watchtower comes with the following benefits...*

- **Spotlight**: As long as the picotitan is near, one particular bug or hazard (and the area around them) can count as being in light, even if the environment is otherwise plunged into darkness.
- **Commanding Position**: Whenever Lookout Rolls are made, one bug can upgrade their usual 2d6 to a 4d6 (and choose which two dice to keep for their lookout result).

WATCHTOWER UPGRADES

- **A Glint In The Eye (Ancient Spectacles)**: When Lookout Rolls are made, the picotitan itself also rolls 2d6.
- **Perimeter Alarm (String)**: Spend a point of Favour to set an alarm, meaning any hazard that wanders near while you camp is surprised if an encounter begins!
- **Battlements (Egg Carton)**: Once per scene, you may spend a point of Favour to have one bug that's near the picotitan completely ignore an instance of damage.

Required Chunks

Broom Handle

Flashlight

BAR (feature)

Very little satisfies a bug's thirst like a dram of mulled pollenwine after a hard day of adventuring, and picotitan bars are the perfect place not only to unwind as the night draws close, but to host and impress visitors. *A bar comes with the following benefits...*

» **In Your Cups**: While aboard the picotitan, using a task allows you to drink your sorrows away (or wallow in them), pulling your mood to either positive or negative.
» **VIP Section**: Treat conflicts as triumphs when trying to impress or negotiate with visitors to your picotitan's bar.

BAR UPGRADES

» **The Hard Stuff (Rotten Fruit)**: When using a task to affect your mood with the bar, pull it two steps to positive or negative rather than the usual one.
» **Picoball Table (Leather Wallet)**: A popular game among bugs, picoball vaguely resembles a game of pool if half of the rules were made up on the spot. Using a task to play picoball sets your mood to 'ok', no matter its starting position.

Required Chunks

Bottle of Alcohol

Broken Plastic, China, Porcelain, or Glass

BUNKROOM (feature)

Sleep is for the weak? No, sleep is for the *prepared*. *A bunkroom comes with the following benefits...*

» **A Place To Rest Your Head**: During a montage, spend a task and a point of Favour to completely clear all marks from a single aspect track.

BUNKROOM UPGRADES

» **Luxury Covers (Bolt of Silk)**: If you use a task to recover with natural healing while aboard your picotitan, double the amount of marks you would clear.
» **Mirror (Makeup Kit)**: Spend a task in front of the mirror to build your confidence. The first action you take in the next scene gains boosted impact.
» **Blackout Curtains (Trash Bag)**: While in the bunkroom, you count as in darkness no matter the general light level.

Required Chunks

Shoebox

Sewing Kit

STOREHOUSE (feature)

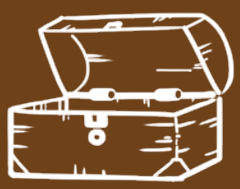
Bits and bobs have a tendency to roll off of a picotitan when it moves, no matter how well you've balanced them. While you *can* usually stop and pick them up again, does anybody really want to spend their grand adventure constantly watching the road gone by? Storehouses are pretty utilitarian compared to a lot of the 'cooler' titan-den upgrades, but they have some uniquely useful properties for collectors of bits and bobs. *A storehouse comes with the following benefits...*

» **Oodles of Space**: When aboard your picotitan, you can transfer bits and bobs from your own carry slots to the storehouse. Use the blank back of the picotitan's sheet to record these - there are no limitations on space.

STOREHOUSE UPGRADES

» **Treasure Room (Padlock)**: Bits and bobs can't be stolen from your storehouse.
» **Chunkstraps (Leather Belt)**: Your picotitan can carry two additional chunks.

Required Chunks



Wooden Box

GARDEN (feature)

There's a pull to the agrarian life that transcends species and culture, a need (in some) to sow and grow and, at the end of the day, look over a little patch of fertile land with pride. And, if they're lucky, one or two massive vegetables growing within it. *A garden comes with the following benefits...*

» **Free Food**: At the end of a journey, one bug in the band gets a free plant-based bit from the garden (supplied by the Weaver, but likely based on the party's descriptions of what they're trying to grow there).

GARDEN UPGRADES

» **Weed-Eater (Bottle of Dangerous Chemicals)**: At the end of a journey, increase the amount of free bits that the garden creates by one.

» **Floral Arrangement (Packet of Seeds)**: A bug can use a task while aboard the picotitan to gain a free flower-based bit.

» **Hammock (Handkerchief)**: If you use a task to recover with natural healing while aboard your picotitan, clear an additional mark of damage from any one of your aspect tracks.

» **Fountain (Small Watering Can)**: Whenever a rainstorm begins, the picotitan gains a point of Favour.

Required Chunks

Wooden Tray

Compost Bags

HOSPITAL (feature)

A place to rest, eat, or relax can all make a bug a little more healthy, a tad more resilient. But the world is big, and full of dangers, and every now and then a bug gets knocked around enough that a short rest isn't really going to cut it. That's where a hospital comes in, for when some serious healing is needed while out on the road. *A hospital comes with the following benefits...*

» **A Place For PROPER Healing**: During a montage, spend a task and a point of Favour to completely clear all burns from a single part or buddy track.

HOSPITAL UPGRADES

» **Doctor's Stash (Bottle of Unidentified Pills)**: When rolling to heal in a hospital, you never need to consume a bit or bob of your own (but still gain a 1d6 of advantage as if you had).

» **Scraping Tools (Rusty Scalpel)**: Treat results of 4, 5, or 6 as the same number when checking for doubles while healing in your hospital.

» **Diluted Nectar Dispenser (Spigot)**: While in your hospital you can spend a point of Favour to immediately heal 1d6 marks on any one of your parts or buddies, but this upgrade can only be used once per scene.

» **Preventative Medicine (Band-Aid / Bandage)**: You can spend a task and a point of Favour to gain a unique temporary augment on any of your aspects, 'Insulated', which adds one break and two hearts to the end of the aspect track. *When the additional hearts are marked or burned, they're removed completely and you lose the temporary augment. You can only have this temporary augment on one of your aspects at a time, and it can't take the number of hearts on an aspect above 15.*

Required Chunks

Old Syringe

Cotton Balls

LIBRARY (feature)

Bugs aren't known for their reading skills, and they very rarely write stuff down, but a titan-den library still communicates an air of comfortable literary safety. And for bugs that *do* enjoy the written word, there are so many secrets to uncover! *A library comes with the following benefits...*

» **Ancient Lore**: Spend a point of Favour while aboard your picotitan to immediately make a small discovery based on the history of the world.
» **Strong Leather Bindings**: Ignore all cut on rolls made to scheme or plan while in a library that would usually be imposed by weather.

LIBRARY UPGRADES

» **Cozy Fireplace (Box of Matches)**: Ignore the negative effects of a cold snap while aboard your picotitan.
» **Scandalous! (Glossy Magazine)**: Use a task while aboard your picotitan to gain a papery bob, 'Fragment of Old-World Gossip'.
» **Secret Passage (Toilet Roll Tube)**: What's a library without a secret passage behind a bookshelf? While aboard the picotitan, a bug can spend a point of Favour to become completely impossible to find by a hostile force for a short time (by scent, sound, and sight).

Required Chunks

Leather-Bound Book

Old Newspaper

"There you go, you're as good as new! Well, not actually as good as new - I wouldn't put any weight on that little leg for a few days, you're going to have a bit of a headache for a while, and if you feel sleepy in the next few hours I wouldn't recommend closing your eyes, just in case. But, metaphorically speaking, you're as good as new!"

Stan Sabrehand, Self-Proclaimed Scorpion Doctor

CHAPTER 09:
THE WEAVER

WEAVING WORLDS

The Weaver is PICO's GM figure, a role that encompasses playing the world as a whole rather than a single character. If you've been the GM of another tabletop game (such as the Keeper of a Call of Cthulhu game, or the Firefly in a game of the Wildsea) then you'll have a good idea of the roles a GM fills. And if you're new to this, don't worry - it's not as tough as it might seem, we promise.

Here's what the Weaver does in a game of PICO...

PRESENT THE WORLD

The Weaver is a window to the world for the other players at the table, presenting the post-Mysteriocalypse world as a place to explore and engage with. When the band of bugs stumbles over something new, you're likely going to be the one describing it.

EMBODY NPCS AND HAZARDS

PICO might be a small world, but it's a busy one - most locations are chock full of NPCs to chat with and hazards to scrap with and, as the Weaver, you give voice and action to all of those. Just how does a grumpy butterfly sound? Well, that one's up to you.

GUIDE AND CHALLENGE PLAYERS

What's a story without obstacles to overcome? As the Weaver, you don't make the story from scratch - it's a narrative exercise where everyone at the table takes part. But it is your job to offer options, to guide when needed, to enforce rules and make judgment calls, and to throw the occasional stumbling block down when the narrative suggests a challenge.

RESPECT THE PLAYERS (AND YOURSELF)

You're all in this together - respect what the rest of the players want, the atmosphere you're all aiming for, and expect to be respected in return. Safety tools (described on page 193) and a solid session zero to set some expectations really help here.

ENJOY YOURSELF!

PICO isn't an adversarial game, at least not in the relationship between players and GM. Challenge and risks are part of the experience, but ultimately everyone at the table should be both contributing to the fun and enjoying the process of playing a game.

SESSION ZERO

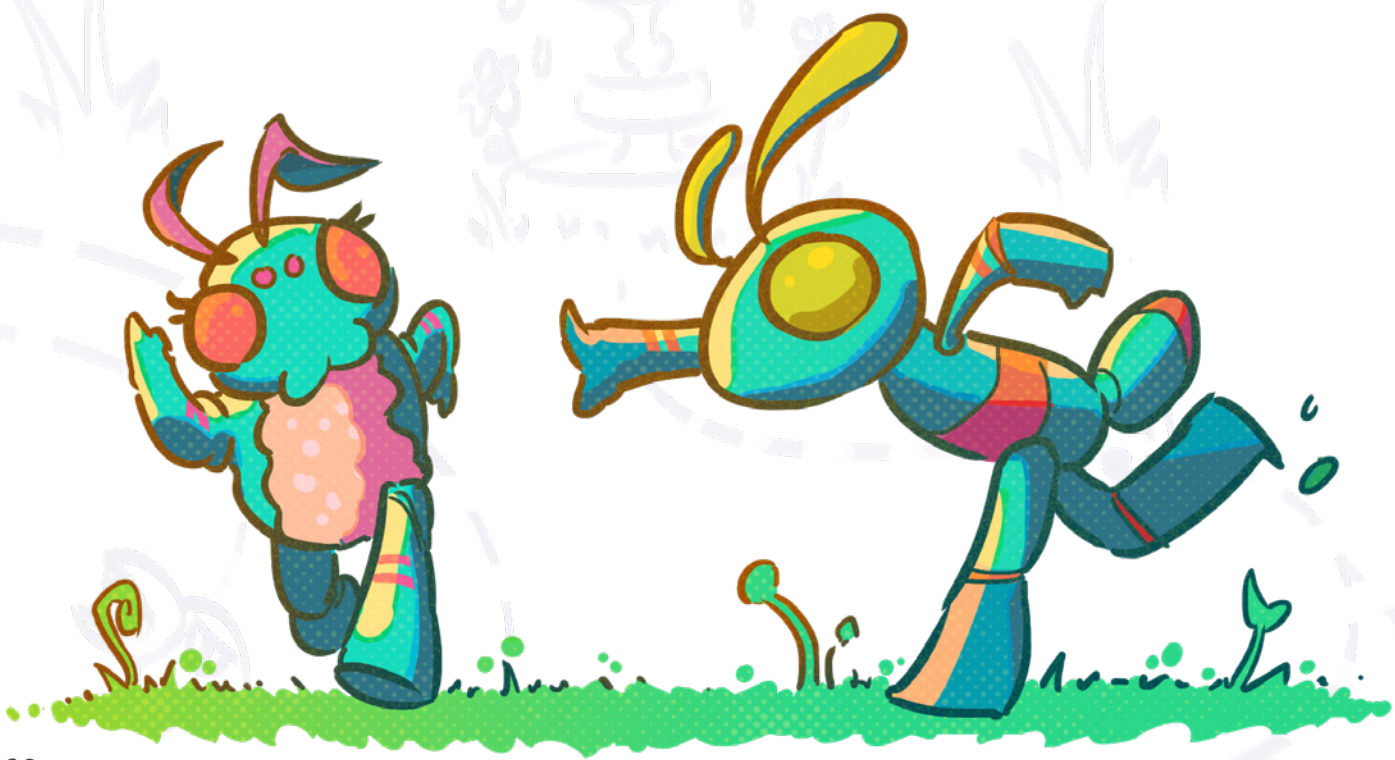
So what's a session zero? In its most basic form it's a short, introductory session where everyone makes pre-game choices (like the character they're going to play) and ensures they're all on the same page in terms of tone and content. In a session zero of PICO, we recommend...

» **Choosing (and Discussing) Your Bugs**: The pre-gens are there to be used, so grab whichever bug looks right for you and give the sheet a read. Once you've worked out how your chosen bug is likely going to play, tell the Weaver, and those around you! Think your bug is going to be a fast-talking brawler? That's good information for everyone to have.

» **Setting the Tone**: Have a quick discussion, Weaver and players, about what kind of tone you're aiming for. PICO is inherently a pretty cute experience, but it's also a weird one - both of these dials can be turned up or down by presenting the world, and the characters, in various ways (each realm in chapter 11 actually has a bit of advice and guidance for playing the game and world in high, normal, and low weirdness presentations).

» **Checking the Basic Rules**: What's a track? How are we rolling? What is this strange cube, and what do these little numbers mean on each side? You'll learn through playing, sure, but a solid base helps things run smoothly. Try a few example rolls once you have your character sheet while you're still in a no-stakes scenario.

» **Going Over Safety Tools**: Even an established group can benefit from reinforcing what they love and hate, what they want and don't. The opposite page's lower section can be easily copied or printed, and acts as a quick-reference sheet for the Weaver to keep in sight as they guide players through a game of PICO. Combine that with the X-card (or some cool arm-crossing gestures) for use when a situation gets away from the established tone, and you can be reasonably sure you're going to have a tonally consistent time.



SAFETY TOOLS

"When you stop having fun, it stops being a game." - Ric Heise

When you've been playing with the same table for a while, things like introductory sessions and safety tools tend to go out of the metaphorical window. You all know each other, right? And of course you know the tone you're aiming for, the way you all play, the things to avoid or edge around during a game.

Well, maybe so - but don't discount the tone-setting, comfort-inviting power of a good set of safety tools and a strong session zero. And if you're a newer group of humans that don't know each other so well, or a one-shot table playing at a convention, or barbecue, or awful child's birthday party, well... This page is *especially* for you.

THE X-CARD

Most often a card placed in the centre of a shared table with a large and prominent 'X' printed on it. If something happens in a game of PICO that you're not comfortable with, reach out and tap that sucker - it's a sign for the Weaver to stop play, establish what's happened that probably shouldn't have, and then rewind the scene a little and take a different path. Better to be open and communicative than to stew with resentment or discomfort, especially in the middle of a game!

If you don't have a physical x-card, more usual when you're playing a game online, cross your arms over your chest or hold up crossed fingers in lieu of tapping. It should get the message across, and is usually more visible than typing 'X' in a chat window (though that can work too, depending on your set-up).

TONE EXPECTATIONS

There are three important questions that a Weaver should ask before a game starts...

- **How cute are we being?**
- **How weird are we being?**
- **How dangerous is the world?**

PICO is a cute game by default (you're tiny bugs, after all), but an innate level of cuteness doesn't have to dial down the weird or the dangerous if that's how your group chooses to play.

So, before you start, it's best to agree on a general level of cuteness, weirdness, and danger: **low**, **medium**, or **high** for each. A low-cuteness game might have bugs engaged in bitter battles over shifting territory, a high-weirdness game might delve into issues of spirituality or bugly philosophy, or even the origins of the Mysteriocalypse itself and the issue of the missing human race.

LINES & VEILS

A simple one, this - if there's a topic you don't want to appear in the game at all, that's a **line** - a hard line that no player should cross. If you don't mind a topic being there, but don't want it to be focused on in gameplay, that's a **veil**. The list below covers some common topics that players may have a problem with if they crop up during play.

- Bullying
- Childhood Abandonment
- Classism
- Dental Horror
- Drug Abuse
- Epidemics
- Eye Injuries
- Graphic Gore
- Harm to Animals
- Harm to Children
- Homophobia, Transphobia
- Mind Control
- Parasitism
- PC Betrayal
- Racism
- Rioting
- Sexual Content
- Substance Abuse
- Slavery
- Spiders
- Starvation
- Suicide
- Torture

Planning

"The best laid schemes o' mice often involve cheese." - Not Ric Heise

So, you're the Weaver. You've got a whole session ahead of you, a group of players at your table waiting to feast on bugly delights (though not literally, unless you're running a very specific type of game). You look down at your notes and find a few circles, a name scribbled into one of the margins that might start with a p or a q, and a doodle of a flower. Just how screwed *are* you?

Luckily, not screwed at all!

PICO is a **low- to no-prep game by default**, with the intention being that you can throw a session together in a few minutes if you need to. As long as your players all have a pre-gen character in front of them and a set of dice, and as long as you have this very document that you're reading right now, you should be absolutely fine. If you want to get all fancy you can have everyone make characters, decide on what the local hazards might be, load up some finely-tuned NPC voices... But don't feel like you *have* to.

Choose a Story Length (Pic-nic or Pic-odyssey)

An average session of PICO lasts for 2-3 hours (though this can easily be modified to suit different groups), but how many sessions do you need to tell your story?

There are two default 'modes' when it comes to playing in the world of the Mysteriocalypse. the **pic-nic** and the **pic-odyssey**. Pic-nics are usually either 1, 2, or 3 sessions long, encompassing one-shots and very short campaigns. Pic-odysseys are far longer (as you may assume from the name), and may sprawl over ten, twenty, or maybe even fifty sessions teling a consecutive story.

Though they work the same way in terms of rules, each of these modes of play has their own special version of the character sheet; a single-sided sheet for the pic-nic, and a double-sided sheet for the pic-odyssey (the latter of which is designed to give players more space for aspects, bits, bobs, and notes as their bugs develop).

Make sure to give your players the right kind of sheet for the game you're intending to play before you begin!

Make Sensible Preparations

But if you want to feel as prepared as possible, or if you're not that used to narrative-based gaming, you can boost your chances of a successful session by...

- **Reading This Document**: Should probably go without saying, but we're going to say it anyway. Make sure you're familiar with the world and rules of PICO before you begin. You don't need to know *everything*, but the less you have to check the book during play, the faster a session will move.
- **Familiarising Yourself With the Player Characters**: Every bug that gets made for PICO will excel in a different way, have a different mechanical or narrative focus to them, and will naturally take centre stage in different types of encounters and situations. Make sure you have at least a passing knowledge of what the players at your table have built their bugs to be good at; that way you'll be able to throw challenges at them with a rough idea of whether they'll breeze through or struggle, helping you keep the game running at a good pace.
- **Choosing a Particular Place or Hazard**: If you're using one of the pre-made realms, read through it thoroughly so you have a good idea of situations, NPCs, or challenges you can throw at players when the time is right. Each has a different feel, so choose one you think the table will enjoy.

It also helps to choose one or two hazards, challenging entities to put in the path of a band of bugs as they explore and adventure. A hazard that plays to the strengths and weaknesses of the band really lets PICO's mechanics shine.

So choose a place for the bugs to start in, and a hazard you know that's nearby - they might go somewhere else and they might never meet the thing you planned for, but it gives you a good solid foundation for the start of a session!
You'll find the beginning of the realms chapter on page 269, and the hazards chapter on page 201.

... But Don't Overthink It

Probably the best advice we can give you here. Wild Words games like PICO tend to fight *against* extensive planning, mostly due to the partial democratisation of traditional GM responsibilities (thanks, twists). They have a habit of making lovely, unexpected narrative pathways, but also of throwing a wrench in the works of an established, pre-written story.

So... *Don't write one.*

You're there to play, at the end of the day, **not to tell**. Let the stories emerge through action and environment, and **enjoy the ride**.

PLAYING

You have a few plates to spin if you've taken on the role of Weaver. Luckily, like spinning plates in the real world, getting a good bit of momentum up with each keeps them in the air for a surprising amount of time. Feel free to unpick that metaphor however you like.

The plates you'll be spinning are...

DESCRIPTION

Of the world, and of the NPC bugs that inhabit it - the post-Mysteriocalypse is what you make of it, both in terms of content and presentation. Using an established realm can help here, but you should also be adding extra flourishes and details where you can. Try to focus on elements that resonate with the entire group as well as those that might matter to a particular bug.

***Example**: Dunf, one of the pre-gen bugs, has a special ability that comes into play when he's on solid ground. While traversing the rushing waterways of King's River that ability will be far harder to use, something you might have to remind Dunf's player about, or spotlight with an extra bit of description or a POI demonstrating how the muddy riverbanks make motion more difficult.*

STORY

As mentioned on the previous page, stories are something that evolve naturally through play in a narrative system - but that doesn't mean you can't give them a bit of help to get going. Have an NPC bug request aid, or confront the group with a problem, and keep track (literally) of how they're doing at solving it.

***Example**: An aged snail within the Fringewood pleads for the band of bugs to help him - the man's daughter has run away into the Hoggish Depths to try to find a legendary truffle of her own. Do the group **have** to help? No, but it's a great start to a small adventure.*

CHALLENGE

This comes from hazards, choices, and the very world the characters inhabit - it's not easy being a small bug in a big world. Challenge the players with things both within and outside of their skillsets, and try to let everyone at the table have some moments to shine.

***Example**: The bugs have been unchallenged for a little while, so the Weaver throws a band of miniature mercs their way - either escaping them, defeating them, or befriending them all serve as besting a challenge.*

HANDLING NPCS

So, you want some memorable NPCs, do you?

The locations in this book each come with a set of single-sentence prompts for NPCs that you can easily slot into a scene, but they're just words - you need to bring these things to life.

When embodying an NPC, think about the following...

How do they sound? Do you use a unique voice for them, or do you describe what they say without playing the character yourself (switching between these methods can help highlight particularly important or noteworthy NPCs, and keep them distinct from less detailed, incidental individuals).

What do they look like? You've got an easy in here, as you can assign even an incidental NPC a very quick appearance by telling the players what kind of bug they are. A firefly is immediately distinct from a centipede, or a bat. But you can go further than that - do they have any other defining characteristics? An object they're holding or interacting with, a particularly snazzy hat?

What do they do? Talk, usually, but a particular gesture or even facial expression can really help make an NPC memorable. Does the ancient spider twirl her fingers as she talks? Does the many-scarred croaklin boss stroke an imaginary moustache?

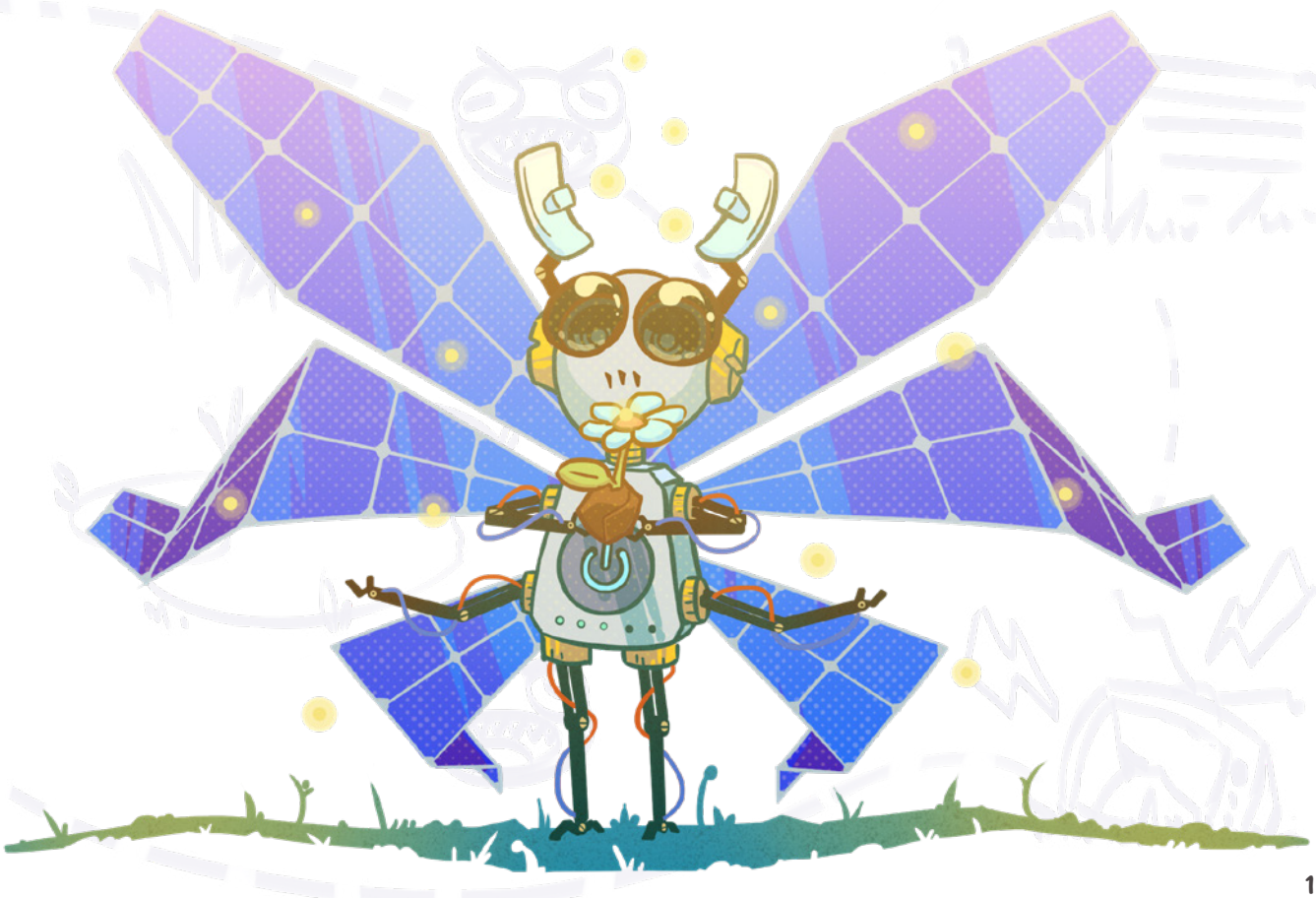
What are they for? It's tempting to introduce NPCs for a singular purpose - to give a quest, to relay some useful information, or to act as a one-off hazard to be overcome. But the world of PICO is a living one, and once you've established an NPC in it, you can (unless they get squashed by something) bring them back again and again if the story calls for it. Why introduce a new villain if the greedy stoat from an earlier session slunk off in defeat, and has been plotting bugly downfall ever since? Or perhaps an NPC that was originally simply there to pass on a bit of information turns out to be a hit with the players - maybe the NPC can accompany them for a little while, let slip some facts about their own life or the world, maybe even set up future adventures or turn into a trusted source of gossip?

THE 'PERFECT' PICO SESSION

... Probably doesn't exist, at least not in a form that will be a proper fit for every table. Some groups want more action, others exploration, and some just want a huge cast of weird NPCs they can crack jokes with for an evening.

But, that said, there is a solid structure you can hew closely to if you're new to PICO, or to Wild Words games in general. If you want a session with a good balance to it that shows off a lot of what the game can offer, you should aim to include...

- **A Scene Where the Bugs Can Explore**: It lets players get accustomed to the world, find a comfortable game pace, and interact with an environment that's not perfectly scaled for them (some players have trouble remembering just how small bugs really are).
- **A Journey, or Dramatic Change of Tone / Scenery**: The world of the post-Mysteriocalypse is huge, and not just in terms of relative scale. A journey, or a transition from the wild outside to the interior of an old structure, gives you a chance to reinforce that size. And if that's not on the cards, a transition from day to night can help instead!
- **A Time for the Whole Band to Chat and Relax**: Adventuring is hard work - let the players use a montage to rest, get a bit of in-character conversation going, and ponder on both what they've done and what's left to do.
- **A Tough Challenge, With Clear Consequences**: Throwing a hazard at an adventuring band is almost guaranteed to make sparks fly, but try to do it so there's more at stake than just the pride of winning or losing.
- **A Chance to Interact With a Memorable NPC**: Polish up those vocal cords and get ready to do some kind of amusing voice - nothing builds player engagement like an NPC or two that make the world feel alive.



REWARDS & RAMIFICATIONS

"We do things not because they are easy... But because we thought they would be." - Ray Chou

One of the benefits of being the Weaver is that you get to dole out rewards from time to time - for good roleplay, for a creative and well-put-together plan, for a brilliant roll in a dire circumstance. You get to do the same with ramifications too, the fallout from bad calls and poor rolls. That power is in your human-sized hands!

But wait - this is important. Rewards and ramifications can be in the moment or lasting, narrative or mechanical. Giving them out is one of the biggest jobs you have, as they help the other players feel that sense of change and progress that all good stories should have. Make rewards cool, make ramifications memorable, and take this little bit of power seriously.

Hoo, that got a bit heavy there, didn't it? But we're not going to throw you in at the deep end without a life raft of advice to cling onto, so without further ado...

REWARDS

Things are looking up! The dice fall on sixes and plans go off without a hitch. When you want to award good rolls, good teamwork, good ideas, or good play, you might...

- **Increase Impact**: It's pretty rare that a bug gets to use giga impact with any regularity, but it makes a great reward for just the right idea, executed perfectly. Boost a bug's skills up to giga for a single action every now and then, and let them make some real impact on the story (see what we did there?). *Giga impact is an excellent reward for when a band of bugs are working as a team to face a tough foe - consider setting a track leading up to a moment of giga impact, like a kind of building combo meter, with a box marked every time one of them successfully performs an action as part of an overall strategy or plan.*
- **Reduce Cut**: A lot of the tougher hazards have ingrained cut as part of their statblocks, and bugs tend to want to do things that are a little bit beyond them (a perfect time to add cut as a ramification). But other times, a brilliant idea or a novel approach might make you think 'wait, that *would* make that way easier'. In those situations, reduce the amount of cut on a roll, or even allow a bug to ignore cut completely for a single action. It'll help the triumphs start rolling in. *Don't do it **too** often, though - cut is the easiest way of adding and modulating difficulty in PICO.*
- **Give Secret Information**: This might not work for every group, but some absolutely love a veil of secrecy between characters. Maybe call one player over to whisper in their ear, pass them a note, or send them a private message with some useful (or useless, but interesting) revelation. You could even tie it to their mystery if you want, or the mystery of another bug at the table!
- **Give a Bit or Bob**: ... or add a positive tag to an existing one. This is a classic reward, and works particularly well at the end of a tough scene or encounter. Everyone loves loot at the end of the day!
- **Treat X as Y**: Best given just before a roll when a bug is taking a long shot, or is going to cut significantly, but their intended action really is a stellar one. Treating a conflict as a triumph is a cool boost for a single roll, and treating a disaster as a conflict works as an excellent safety net too.
- **Reduce Immunity or Resistance**: A great option when the bugs have dealt a serious blow to a hazard, removing an existing resistance (or downgrading an immunity to a resistance) tends to make players feel like they've made tangible process, and that the scales of an encounter just tipped in their favour.
- **A Change in Situation, for the Better**: That NPC that they thought was down for the count? They still have a shred of life in them! A change to the narrative that works for the players rather than against them is a really good reward in situations where the odds are against them. Which, given that they're tiny bugs in a massive and dangerous world, is likely going to be most situations!
- **Free Healing**: Especially if a bug is looking rather banged-up, the removal of a mark (or maybe even a burn, if you're feeling *really* generous) can make their life a tad easier.

RAMIFICATIONS

When things go wrong, they *really* go wrong.

The Weaver has quite a few options when it comes to handing out negative consequences, whether it's for a bad decision, a wilfully dangerous course of action, or simply an unlucky roll. You might...

» **Deal Damage**: As a general rule, 1 or 2 marks is light damage, 3 or 4 medium damage, and 5 or 6 heavy damage. You could also deal giga damage, if you just want to hit a bug hard and ignore their resistances. *Remember to specify the type of damage you're dealing by giving it an associated skill, like Sizzle Damage or Dig Damage, and to match that type to the situation.*

» **Impose Cut**: Either in the moment (for a less than stellar action choice) or in the future (as fallout from a conflict or disaster). Specify the type of cut (Tough Cut, Armour Cut, Speed Cut, or Camo Cut) and the amount of results the bug should be cutting (usually 1, rarely 2). *Remember to add a condition of when the cut is applied, or how it might be avoided.*

» **Affect Bits or Bobs**: Specifically by adding negative tags to them, like *Mouldy* or *Rusted*. You might even completely destroy a bit or bob, usually as a consequence of an unlucky roll.

» **Treat Y as X**: Either conflicts as disasters, or triumphs as conflicts. Like imposing cut, this might be for an impending roll or as an ongoing condition in a certain situation.

» **Give an Immunity or Resistance**: Usually this works well for a hazard, but it could be added to a more general track instead.

» **A Change in Situation, for the Worse**: Not everything has to be mechanical! Sometimes a fictional or narrative-based change for the worse can be a decent enough ramification in itself, especially if it has consequences for the wider story of the game.

- RAMIFICATIONS EXAMPLE -

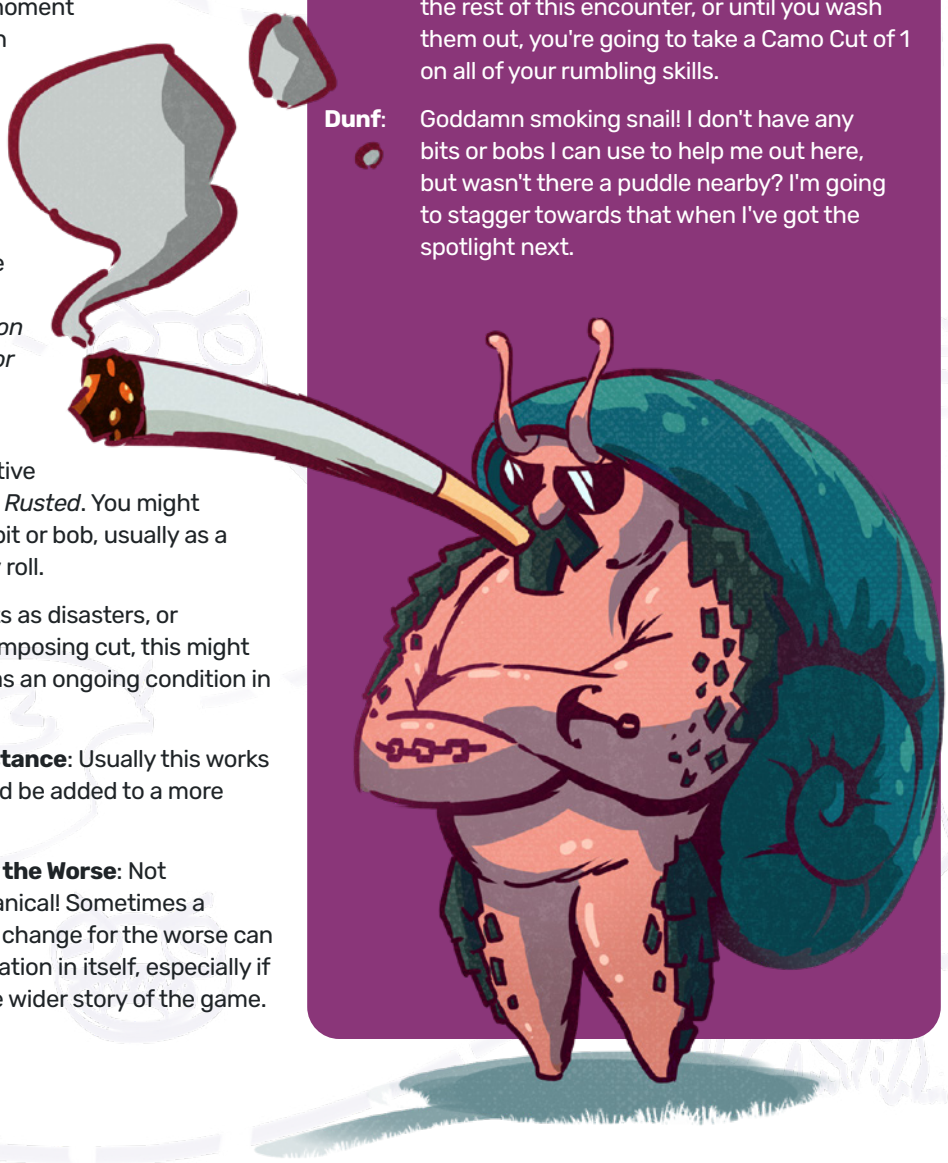
Dunf: ... And that's a 4, a 3, and a 1. With the cut, that's... A disaster. This isn't going to go well, is it?

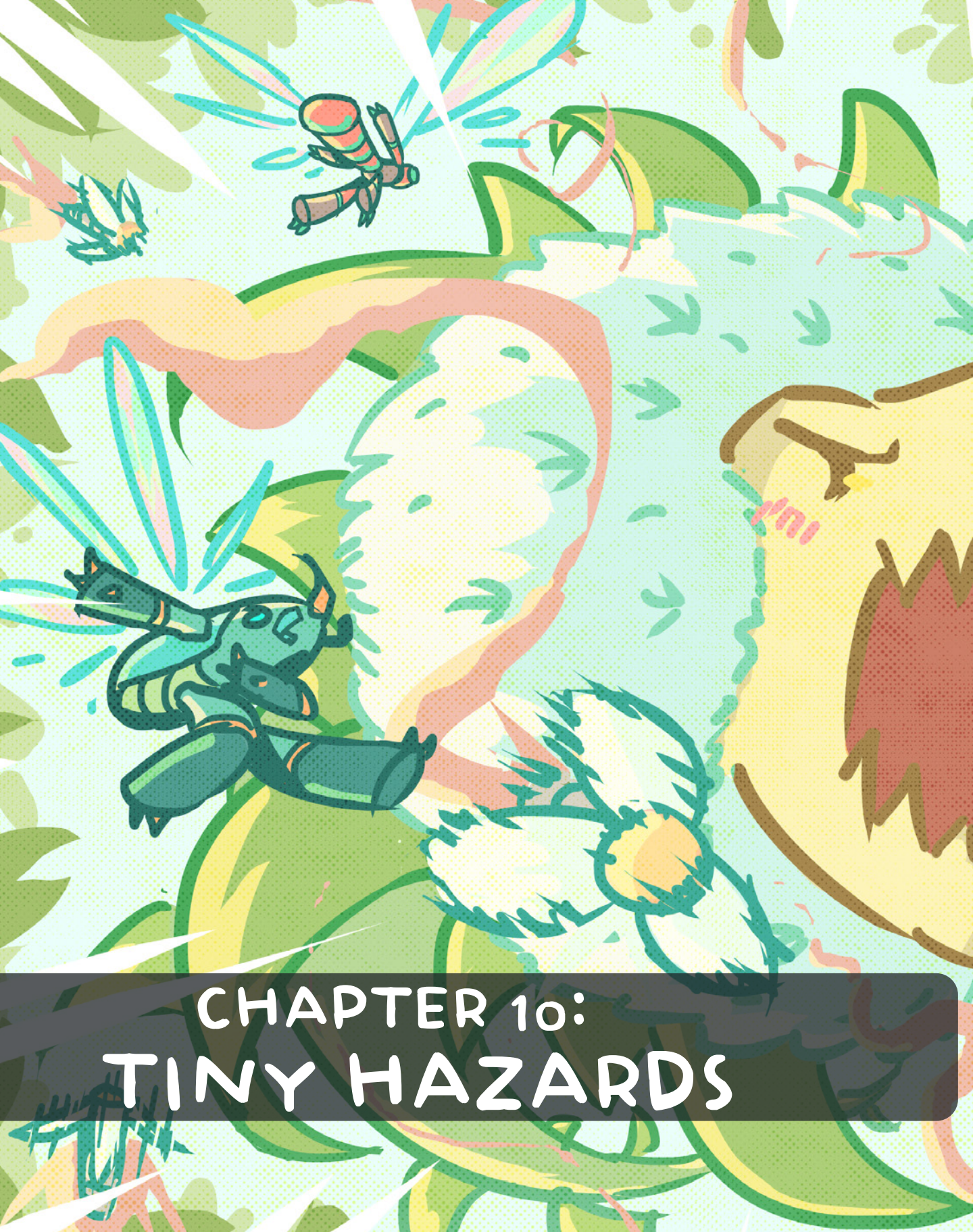
Weaver: No, I'm afraid it's not. The snail turns at the last minute, your attack bouncing off of his hard shell. He turns back toward you as you stagger away, and says "Cool move, hotshot" in a gravelly voice - then takes a drag from his comically large cigarette and breathes out.

Dunf: Blech!

Weaver: Blech is right! You take 2 marks of Sizzle Damage from the hot smoke, but that's not all! Your little eyes sting, welling up with tears. For the rest of this encounter, or until you wash them out, you're going to take a Camo Cut of 1 on all of your rumbling skills.

Dunf: Goddamn smoking snail! I don't have any bits or bobs I can use to help me out here, but wasn't there a puddle nearby? I'm going to stagger towards that when I've got the spotlight next.




CHAPTER 10:
TINY HAZARDS

WHAT IS A HAZARD?

A hazard is anything that might be a potential source of danger to the gang as they travel, something that'll take some quick thinking, teamwork, and exertion to overcome. Most are pretty obvious, like a hungry frog or an angry mouse, but some do get a bit... *esoteric*.

All hazards have a statblock of useful information and potential moves for the Weaver to draw from when they're added to a scene. These are, in order...

- **Name**: Letting you know what to call the thing.
- **Keywords**: Special tags that some aspects might interact with, or that give the Weaver some info.
- **Hazard Track**: Just like the kinds of tracks you'd find on a bug's aspects, a series of hearts with some break points thrown in there for good measure. Can easily be shortened or lengthened to suit the kind of encounter that a Weaver wants to run.
- **Overview**: A brief description of the hazard.
- **Signs**: What the bugs might see or notice as the hazard approaches, or is in the general area - used to clue players in that a challenge is coming.
- **Behaviour**: A quick list of things a hazard might do once introduced, to help set up an encounter.
- **Defences**: Any resistances, weaknesses, or immunities a hazard has to particular skills.
- **Breaks**: Short examples of what might change when a hazard's track breaks.
- **Stuff to Grab**: Bits and bobs that might be gained from fighting, outwitting, stealing from, or otherwise defeating a hazard.
- **Parts & Moves**: The bits that make a hazard special, containing the damage it can deal and any cool unique stuff it can do.

CUTE OR SCARY?

PICO, intentionally, straddles the line between cute and scary in various aspects of world design, and one of the most important things to keep in mind when running a hazard is your group's **stated lines and veils**, and their **expectations of tone**.

You can play PICO with little to no violence by avoiding rumbling skills, treating encounters as hijinks that little bugs get into. You could also play with cut-away violence, where a mouse *might* get attacked with a scissor-sword, **but** it'll just end up with an oversized bandage on after a brief cutaway and a cartoon sound effect. Or you can play with fists flying and teeth bared; if it works for your table, it works for the game.

HAZARD OVERVIEW

Hazards are under the Weaver's control, just like non-threatening NPCs - a hazard might even start out in a scene as a normal NPC, only becoming an active danger when someone steps on their toe, steals their lunch, or accidentally insults their mother.

These next few pages go into detail on how to run scene with a hazard: introducing them, establishing their intentions, using their moves to dish out damage and effects, and handling their tracks and breaks when they take damage themselves. There's also advice later in this section on how to handle **titans**, the largest and most fearsome of post-Mysteriocalypse foes, and some suggestions on how to help newer players that might not be used to cinematic challenges or flexible, non-violent ways of handling encounters.

So, let's get started!

INTRODUCTIONS ARE IMPORTANT

A hazard's overview, signs, and behaviour (found in the hazard entries later in this chapter) should all give you a good idea of how you can introduce a potential foe into a scene, but there are a few additional ways you can ratchet up the drama and tension as danger threatens...

- **Make the Hazard Track Open**: Draw it out where the players can see. This works particularly well for groups that like to know how tough what they're facing is, or how close they are to victory.
- **Show NPCs Reacting**: Do they flee, take cover, wail, or call for help? Maybe some NPC bugs will even stand with the gang against a hazard, helping out from time to time. It makes the world feel more alive!
- **Start with a Bang**: Use one of the hazard's moves to start an encounter off, forcing an immediate reaction from one or all of the players as the threat crashes in.
- **Give a Glimpse of Rewards**: An old video game trick, this one - draw the players' attention to something shiny tucked into a hazard's pocket or shell, or a particularly impressive weapon that the creature might drop if beaten or forced to retreat. Or, a real classic, have the hazard swallow something that the bugs desperately need, only to spit it out when defeated.
- **Bring in the Environment**: Is there a conspicuous chandelier above that might be dropped on a marauder's bonce? A cliff-edge the hazard is dangerously close to? Making sure the environment has some points of interest or additional threats encourages tactical play, and often gets players excited to try out their cool strategies - and maybe get some gigadamage as a reward!
- **Imply Immunities and Resistances**: Simple, but effective in informing players of what might or might not work against a particular hazard. Maybe a heavily armoured bug enters the scene only to be immediately crushed (perhaps by some kind of chandelier, who knows?), but then heaves it off themselves and stands up unharmed. Bash might not be so effective here...

INTENTIONS MATTER

It's good to have an idea of a hazard's intentions when you introduce one to a scene, and to think of some way you might communicate those intentions to the players (even if not immediately, nothing wrong with a bit of mystery). In other words, avoid just plonking every hazard down and expecting a fight.

***Example**: An adventuring band of bugs is passing through a derelict trainyard when they hear scuffling from a heap of trash up ahead. A few moments later, with a rattling hiss and a scraping of limbs, a predatory shape pulls itself free - a binwolf!*

Binwolves are lupine trash-constructs, hunters by nature, so this scene could very well turn violent - but that doesn't mean it **has** to. Here are a few examples of what might happen, based on how the Weaver communicates a hazard's situation and intentions.

***Example**: The binwolf charges forward, pin-like limbs pumping like pistons. It'll be on you in moments - what do you do?*

This is a direct call for action, and some obvious aggression on the part of the binwolf - a scuffle is likely!

***Example**: The binwolf scrapes a screw-shaped paw in the dirt, regarding your band with challenging eyes for a moment before turning away and readying itself. In the distance, a set of immense signal posts are shifting colour, the glare reflected on the binwolf's shining hide. First red, then orange, and the beast tenses up. Green is moments away - is it expecting some sort of race?*

This kind of hazard entrance clearly sets a non-violent option for the hazard's 'defeat', perfect for adventuring bands that prefer to solve problems without violence.

***Example**: The binwolf watches you warily, but doesn't approach. Just behind it you catch sight of a few binwolf pups, each no larger than a grub. And, judging by their yelps, they're pretty hungry...*

What do binwolves eat, apart from bugs? Electricity, probably. This might be the start of a scene where players try to 'charge' the cubs up to earn the binwolf's temporary trust.

***Example**: The binwolf yelps, once, then collapses into its component pieces. They roll down the trash pile, stopping at your feet.*

An example of ambiguity - this might be a ruse to get bugs to drop their guard or a creature in genuine need of help. Maybe this encounter has bugs healing marks on a hazard's Heart Track, rather than making them?

Each one of the examples above shows the Weaver signposting a different type of encounter, suggesting a way that the players might want to engage with this particular threat. And this isn't just true of binwolves, either - **every hazard contained in this chapter can be presented in a variety of ways** to suit the tone of the table, the lines and veils in play, and the flow of the narrative.

... AND INTENTIONS CAN CHANGE

Something else to keep in mind. Just as a player can have their character change tactic, attitudes, or approach at any point, a hazard can change its intentions and behaviour midway through a scene. That last example of the binwolf up there? Maybe the bugs partially reassemble the Clanky threat, and it rewards their efforts by immediately turning on them.

Switch things up, keep players guessing, and don't be afraid to explore various avenues of challenge when you can.

MAKING MOVES

As soon as a hazard is an active threat in a scene, it can start taking the spotlight to make moves. But what's a move? Here's an example, from the munchmeleon's 'Parts & Moves' section on page 249.

Sticky Tongue (Bash 1-2): Normally curled up within the munchmeleon's maw, this gloopy danger can shoot out with incredible accuracy. Reactions take a Speed Cut of 1, and the tongue can *push* or *grab* a bug as well as dealing damage.

- The first bit of bolded text, (**Sticky Tongue**), lets you know the part of the hazard that's being used, or the particular name of the move. *The munchmeleon uses its tongue to make this move.*
- The second bit of bolded text, (**Bash 1-2**), references the skill that the move used to do damage, and how much damage it does. *The munchmeleon is hitting with one or two marks of Bash Damage, depending on what the Weaver chooses.*
- The rest of the text gives both a fictive overview and a rundown of any special rules that the move follows (such as inherent effects other than damage, for example, or whether it imposes cut on a bug's reaction to it). *The munchmeleon's sticky tongue is good at grabbing and pushing (page 64), and it's fast as a whip, imposing Speed Cut.*

DAMAGE GRANULARITY

When bugs take an action, they're usually dealing either one mark (for most actions), or gigadamage (enough marks to fill the hazard's track up to the next break, often unlocked by filling a Combo Track or targeting a hazard's weaknesses).

But hazards work differently - they can usually deal anywhere between 1 and 6 marks of damage to a bug's aspect track with a single move.

It's still always tied to a particular skill and, just like with bugs, 'damage' doesn't always need to be violent (Swagger Damage from a hazard might intimidate a bug, Dig Damage might trap their little feet in the ground so they have to shake themselves loose).

This asymmetrical design is to give the Weaver a few more levers to pull in terms of a hazard's power level.

WHEN TO MAKE MOVES

With even the most tense scenes in PICO running off cinematic spotlight-flow rather than a strict initiative system, as the Weaver it's your choice of when a hazard makes a move. As a good rule of thumb, **hazards should act about half as much as the players do** - so for every two player actions, force a reaction by making a hazard take a move of its own.

If there's more than one hazard in a scene, increase this (or maybe have all hazards act in a row). If a hazard is bigger and slower, it might only act once every player has taken an action, but the move it makes might involve multiple players rolling to react.

Also remember that a hazard making a move can force a reaction from a player that's been out of the spotlight, bringing them back into the narrative. **Hazard moves are just as much a Weaver tool as rewards or NPCs.**

EXTRA EFFECTS

Most moves can have an extra effect of some kind, usually more narrative than mechanical as suits the moment. But some hazard moves have specific extra effects, like changes to the way an Action Roll is read. If this is the case, these extra effects will be noted in the 'Parts & Moves' section of a hazard's statblock.

It's probably a good idea to brush up on the general effects you can throw on a move as well - take a look at the Rewards and Ramifications section on page 198, and the Effects section on page 64.

GOING BEYOND THE STATBLOCK

... Is something we heavily recommend, especially once you're more familiar with running the game.

When you're comfortable with it, think of the moves in a hazard's statblock as examples to be added on top of, with numbers and damage types changing based on the flow of a scene. Maybe a hazard uses a nearby POI to deal an unexpected sort of damage, or perhaps one of the bugbarians the band are facing is *really* into cap-golf, and can throw out long-ranged attacks with ease.

Moves & Reactions

One of the most important things to remember when running a hazard is that **you don't need to be rolling dice** - hazard moves **always** hit, by default, unless the target manages to shield, dodge, or otherwise evade in some way.

How do they do this? With a **reaction**! When a hazard grabs the spotlight and makes a move, ask the target of that move for a reaction. They can then put a **Defend Roll** together using the rules on page 59 to see how the exchange plays out. *As the Weaver, you don't need to roll a reaction when a hazard is hit by a player character, just like you don't roll when using a move to attack.*

If a bug can't react to a move (due to being stunned or asleep, for example), the character treats it as if they had rolled a disaster.

Automatic Damage, and Other Oddities

Every now and then you'll find a move that *doesn't* allow reactions, that deals automatic damage or has a guaranteed effect. These are rare, not just because they're powerful, but because they take the reins away from players in terms of agency. **Use them sparingly**, and if they're having a disproportionate effect on an encounter, kick things down a notch to remove them (you'll find more about adjusting a hazard's difficulty on the fly on page 208).

***Example**: The constant thumping music of the drummingbirds deals automatic damage to any character that takes the spotlight. This is great thematically, but if an encounter goes on for longer than expected, it may wear both characters and players down over time. In situations like these, either use a track break to halt the effect, or let the bugs do something to ignore the effect from that point on, like trading an immunity to it for a lost resource, or an instance of burn.*

HAZARD TRACKS

Every hazard in this chapter has a suggested track in its entry, a measure of how much damage it can take before it's defeated. Here's an example, a track of nine boxes with a break after every three...

Hazard tracks don't tell you how *tough* a creature is; that's mostly down to their parts and moves. Instead, think of hazards as an indicator of *dramatic weight* - the longer the track (and the more breaks it has), the more complex the fight is expected to be.

You can always make an encounter shorter and punchier by reducing the track length, or more important and potentially time-consuming by... Well, lengthening it. They are just examples, after all - I'm not going to tell you what to do!

WHAT MARKS A HAZARD'S TRACK?

Let's bullet-point this one, for ease of reference!

- **Any action that negatively affects a hazard** can mark their track, dealing damage.
- Damage is always tied to the skill used to roll an action. **By default**, an action with normal impact will deal **one mark of damage** to a hazard's track.
- If the hazard is **resistant** to the skill being used, **drop the action's impact by one step**.
- If the hazard is **weak** to the skill being used, **increase the action's impact by one step**.
- If the hazard is **immune** to the skill being used, **no marks are ever made**.
- If an action **deals gigadamage**, it **fills boxes until it hits a track break**.

WHAT CAN MARK A HAZARD'S TRACK?

The more offensive rumbling skills (Bash, Bite, Slash, and Sizzle) are the obvious go-to for when a bug wants to damage a hazard's track, but they're far from the only option. We've talked about it on page 147, in the Skills section, but we'll say it here too - **damage doesn't have to be physical, and any skill can mark boxes on a hazard's track if used in a narratively appropriate way**. If it negatively affects a hazard, or brings the encounter closer to some kind of end, it can deal damage.

***Example**: A band of bugs are facing off against a crew of miniature mercs, who are demanding a bob-based toll for passing through a valley. Some bugs are using Yap, Scare, and Swagger to damage the hazard track, attempting to talk them round or intimidate them. Another is using Slink and Climb to jockey for position on the nearby cliffside, as one of the mercs tries to scramble after them and pull them down. These skills aren't doing physical damage to the mercs, but they're certainly getting close to giving up and letting the band pass just to end the annoyance.*

DAMAGE AND TRACK BREAKS

Hazard tracks have breaks, just like a bug's own aspect tracks. They work in pretty much the same way too, giving the hazard some survivability when hit with a large amount of damage in one go.

***Example**: Heironymoth is using Chart to confuse a swarm of cephalocopters, sending them careening into each other. With the benefit of an aspect she treats it as Gigachart Damage, but the action only deals two marks of Chart Damage before hitting the first break on the cephalocopter track.*

But that's not all they do! Once we've dealt with titan tracks (on the next page), we'll delve a little deeper.

... AND TITAN TRACKS

Titans still have tracks to mark, like every other hazard, but they work a little differently - and look a little different too!

These are **TITAN HEARTS**, easily identified by the swirl in the middle. The track above has only two titan hearts, so it should be easy enough to fill!

... Eh, well, not exactly.

Each titan heart can only be marked by gigadamage, and each instance of gigadamage can only mark a single titan heart.

GIGADAMAGE VS TITANS

A pretty simple one, this. If a bug (or the environment) hits a titan with an action dealing giga impact, a single mark is made on the titan's track. **Filling a Combo Track (page 46) is a reliable source of gigadamage, extremely useful for titan encounters, but some aspects allow a bug to deal gigadamage too.**

***Example**: Klay releases a spurt of acid from their scorpionish tail, aiming some Gigasizzle Damage at the titan they're throwing down with. Klay's player rolls a triumph, so the attack hits home - the Weaver marks a single titan heart.*

EXPLOITING TITAN WEAKNESSES

Just like normal-sized hazards, titans also come with one or two weaknesses to specific skills (and sometimes to other things, like environmental conditions). **Successfully exploiting a titan's weaknesses is another reliable way of gaining gigadamage, enough impact to mark a titan heart.**

***Example**: March, a dung beetle chef, is taking on the titan Brimstocchio (a living clay puppet that just wants to play with fire). While his cooking skills aren't going to do any damage here, his Dig skill can - Brimstocchio has a weakness to Dig, and March exploits it by wiggling inside the puppet's cracked pottery skin and making a general nuisance of himself. March's player rolls a conflict, so March takes some Sizzle Damage as he does so (it's hot in there!), but the beneficial part of the conflict is still enough for the Weaver to mark one of the titan's hearts.*

BUILT-IN TRACK BREAKS

It might look, at first, like titans have more simple tracks than most hazards thanks to the lack of visible track breaks. Well, let me disabuse you of that notion right now - **whenever a titan heart is marked, that counts as a track break.**

Why does this matter? Because when a hazard's track breaks, whether it's a titan or not, the Weaver has a chance to **kick things up or down a notch**.

"Okay, so, I've got a really bad feeling that every hit we land on that thing is just making it more angry."

Keiko Kanaluna, Moon-Moth Sellsword

Hitting the Breaks

The breaks on a hazard's track (and the ones built into every titan heart) do more than just provide a defence against gigadamage - when bugs hit them, that's a signal to the Weaver that it's time for something to **change**. When a hazard's track breaks...

» **The Weaver can kick things *up a notch* or *down a notch*, to represent the hazard being damaged, desperate, or determined.**

» **The hazard immediately *steals the spotlight* for a move of its own, showing off the change as they do so.**

These on-the-fly changes are a rules-approved way of making a hazard or encounter easier or harder, lessening the frustration players may feel if their foe is unexpectedly strong or time-wastingly weak. As the Weaver, the actual mechanical and narrative outcome of this change is completely in your hands; we have a few suggestions below, but there's nothing stopping you from creating your own difficulty changes in the moment, perhaps bringing in elements of a grand discovery that the bugs have made, or involving an NPC or previous plotline they've been a part of.

Kicking Things Up a Notch

Things feeling too easy? Want the bugs to face more of a challenge, more of a threat? Let's **kick things up a notch!** As the Weaver, you might...

» Power up one of the hazard's existing moves with more damage or an additional effect.
» Unlock an entirely new move for the hazard to use for the rest of the encounter.
» Add a new immunity or resistance.
» Impose a situational cut on certain types of actions that the bugs have been relying on.
» Have the hazard redouble its efforts, making two moves at a time for the rest of the encounter.
» If the foe is a boss, bring in a lackey to support them.
» If the foe is a lackey, start a track to summon a boss.

Kicking Things Down a Notch

If the encounter feels like a slog, or the bugs are struggling, it's probably better to **kick things down a notch.** As the Weaver, you might...

» Disable one of the hazard's moves or parts.
» Remove an immunity or resistance, or add an entirely new weakness.
» Remove a source of cut that the bugs are struggling to work with.
» Have the hazard change up its tactics or attitude, maybe beginning to calm or retreat.
» Make an extra mark on the hazard's track each time it makes a move, hurrying the encounter to a close.
» Remove one of the hazard's future track breaks, making gigadamage more effective.

Stealing the Spotlight For a Move

As the Weaver, you don't have to immediately explain the mechanical change that kicking things up or down a notch makes (though you can, if your group enjoys transparency). But what you *do* have to do is give the hazard a **dramatic moment** to show off this change in a narrative fashion, by stealing the spotlight and having the hazard make an appropriate move.

Each hazard entry gives a few thematic suggestions on what a break might bring, to help the Weaver decide. The *Froglins* entry, for example, suggests things like 'Hop to New Positions' and 'a Tangle of Long Legs'. That first one might be kicking things up a notch, with the froglins finding more advantageous positions. The second is likely kicking things down a notch, and might be represented by removing a move that relies on the power of the froglins' well-muscled legs, or removing the usual Speed Cut bugs take when targeting them with rumbling skills.

End of the Line

When all boxes on a hazard's track are marked, the encounter is over and the bugs have won. What does defeat look like? That's up to the narrative. What are the rewards? Well, we have a whole 'Stuff to Grab' section in each hazard entry to answer that!

- Up a Notch Example -

Layla: ... And that's a mark of Sizzle! Nice!

Weaver: It's a track break too - the stoat rears up, clawing the candyfloss free from its face and fixing you with a particularly mean look. It takes one step, then another, all on its hind legs... And settles into a new, pugilistic pose.

Dunf: Oh my god, this thing knows how to box!

Weaver: That it does - Dunf, better get a Reaction Roll ready as it comes in with a one-two punch... Layla too - that second punch is aimed in your direction!

Layla: I have a feeling we might have made things worse for ourselves here...

- Down a Notch Example -

Layla: ... And that's a mark of Sizzle! Nice!

Weaver: It's a track break too - the stoat scrambles back, covered in candyfloss that it can't seem to shake free from.

Bicco: Hey, we might actually have the upper hand here now!

Dunf: Sweet job, Layla! And yes, that pun was intentional.

Weaver: Enraged by the pun, Dunf, it lashes out with its claws in your direction. Put a reaction together for me, but don't apply the Speed Cut of 1 to it - the stoat's still fast, but it has limited vision thanks to all that sticky sugar.

HAZARD KEYWORDS

All hazard entries have a set of keywords nestled in between the hazard's name and the Heart Track. Let's take bugbarians as an easy example - they have the keywords **Small/Bugly/Lackey**, with each of those words telling you something about the hazard's presence, appearance, or behaviour. Some are a little more complex - a quetzalcroakl, for example, is a **Large or Huge/Feathery/Slimy/Elite**.

But what do these mean? Oh, if only there were some kind of handy breakdown of what each keyword implies...

SIZE KEYWORDS

A simple descriptor of the hazard's size. Narratively, this helps the Weaver give players an idea of how large, or small, the thing they're facing is (in relation to both their own bugs and the surrounding world). Mechanically, size only really matters for a few special aspect rules and effects (like grabs, on page 64). The sizes presented are the same as those on page 12, with...

- **NANO** foes being about the size of a sugar granule,
- **SMALL** foes being about the size of a raspberry,
- **LARGE** foes being almost the size of an aluminium can,
- **HUGE** foes being about the size of a generously portioned takeaway noodle container, and...
- **TITAN** foes being as big as, or bigger than, a housecat.

TYPE KEYWORDS

These put hazards into particular categories based on their physical aspects, splitting things like bugs, beasts, and plants into different groups. Many aspects give special bonuses against hazards with a particular type keyword.

The types you'll find within the rest of this chapter are...

- **BUGLY**, for antagonists with insectish properties,
- **BEASTLY**, for warm-blooded mammalian types,
- **SCALY**, for anything resembling a fish, snake, or reptile,
- **SLIMY**, for slippery customers like frogs and eels,
- **FEATHERY**, for those with... well, feathers (whether they can fly or not),
- **LEAFY**, for fruit, vegetables, and bug-eating plants,
- **SHROOMY**, for the fungal and the slow-spreading,
- **CLANKY**, for things crafted artificially, often made of plastic or metal, and...
- **GHOSTLY**, for those that crossed beyond the veil, didn't like it much, and came back for a good old haunt.

THREAT KEYWORDS

The final set of keywords relates to how this hazard presents itself and how their Heart Tracks work (as well as giving a few clues as to how they should probably act). For threat keywords, we have...

- **SWARM**, to represent multiple creatures working as one. Swarms usually have a single long Heart Track with a generous amount of breaks, and rarely retreat from a rumble before being beaten.
- **LACKEY**, used for weaker threats that band together, but lack any real sort of leadership. An encounter with lackeys should have multiple separate Heart Tracks, all on the shorter side, and without a boss present, lackeys will often flee if a band of bugs proves too tough for them.
- **ELITE**, for individual hazards that can take on an entire band toe-to-toe. Elites may appear alone, in pairs, or even in trios, and each elite should have their own Heart Track. When an elite gets low on hearts, it may retreat, bargain, or dramatically change up its tactics.
- **BOSS**, a keyword reserved for the biggest and baddest hazards around. Bosses have a single, long Heart Track with a lot of breaks, and can be accompanied by lackeys or elites for extra muscle. Bosses very rarely stick around if their hearts get low, preferring to retreat and then strike back at a later time with additional forces at their command.

AND WITH ALL THAT OUT OF THE WAY...

Let's see some hazards!

The rest of this chapter is devoted to **a collection of pre-made hazards** for adventuring bugs to tangle with, organized alphabetically. The Realms, beginning on page 269, all have suggestions on which hazards fit them best, but feel free to experiment with presentation and placement as you create your own little slice of the post-Mysteriocalypse.

A final note: the statblocks presented here are suggestions, they're not written in stone. Feel free to change, adapt, or ignore what you need to for the good of your table. It's your Mysteriocalypse, at the end of the day.

Enjoy!

BEASTMICE

[Large/Beastly/Lackey]

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OVERVIEW

Most mice, even the ones that don't get along with bugs too well, are pretty cute. Not so the beastmice, barbarian rodents with grizzled fur and gnashing teeth and altogether too much in the way of arms and armour.

Why are they like this? You can probably blame carbonated beverages before bedtime for that one, and some of them drink so much of the stuff that they get *really* weird.

SIGNS

- Footprints, deep with weight despite their small size.
- Glistening smears, a strong scent of cloves, and the smell of congealed soda and old fur on the wind.
- Other bugs fleeing, shouting something along the lines of 'noooooo, beastmiiiiiiice!'.

BEHAVIOUR

- Rampage around and knock stuff over.
- Shout poorly constructed insults at foes that look too powerful to actually fight.
- Get drunk on off-brand soda.
- Leave sticky marks everywhere they go.
- Go wild for soda, even the smallest drops.

PARTS & MOVES

Bottleglass Weaponry (Bash 3 / Slash 3): Simple and to the point, often literally.

Sticky Paws (Rummage 2): Bugs suffer a Tough Cut of 1 whenever they try to break free of a mouse's grab.

Overpowering Scent (Sense 1-2): Clove soda never really caught on pre-M, but it's in high demand now. Any bug with a Feelers aspect takes 1 mark of automatic Sense Damage whenever a beastmouse draws near.

Bottlecap Shielding (Shield 2): Can be used for a quick and dirty shield bash, but is more useful for defence. Bugs targeting a beastmouse with a physical attack suffer an Armour Cut of 1.

Grizzled Fur (-): Have you ever tried to clean soda out of *your* fur? You can't really hold this one against them. Any bits or bobs used to add dice to an attack targeting a beastmouse are lost, ending up stuck to their fur.

Faster Than You'd Think (-): Even while weighed down and unpleasantly adhesive, a beastmouse can pull off an impressively swift scamper. Whenever one beastmouse takes damage, another can steal the spotlight to reposition for free.

Clove Cannon (Sizzle 5): Now *this* is war. A rare high-pressure cannon that can only be fired once per encounter. Can hit and push multiple nearby targets.

DEFENCES

- **Resistant to Bash, Tame, and Yap**, from a combination of good defences and poor manners.
- **Weak to Sizzle** - singed fur smells terrible.

BREAKS

- Scamper to the high ground! / Screech, point, and bite / Loss of shield / Knock a tooth free

STUFF TO GRAB

- **Bits**: Scrappy Fur, Tensile Whisker, Clove Soda Droplet
- **Bobs**: Thin Metal Shield, Big Clove Club, Colourful Wrappings, Bottleglass Axe

UNDERMICE

After consuming a truly *unhealthy* amount of clove soda, a beastmouse might find their mammalian minds crowding with dark, sticky thoughts that are impossible to escape. This is the Curse of the Clove, an affliction that changes a beastmouse first mentally, and then physically. The resulting creatures (known as 'undermice') abandon their barbarian ways, instead turning to a kind of syrup-based wizardry that few can comprehend.

Confusing Anatomy (-): It's still just a mouse... right? Attacks targeting an undermouse suffer a Complex Cut of 2 instead of the usual beastmouse's Armour Cut of 1.

Bleak Prognostication (Think 3): A jab of a spindly paw and a few words about dark futures are all it takes to strike fear into the heart of even the bravest bug.

Chittering Hex (Scare X): A string of curses and pronouncements, sometimes shocking, sometimes insightful. Deals Scare Damage equal to double the number of small discoveries a bug has for their current mystery.

Crashdown Aura (-): Why suffer a sugar crash when you can force others to endure it instead? When an undermouse joins an encounter, all bugs pull their mood to the negative.

BINWOLVES

[Large/Clanky/Elite]

OVERVIEW

Most predators tend to come wrapped in fur, feathers, or scales, but not so the binwolves - these lupinesque hunters are born of trash-piles and toolboxes, all sharp edges and offcuts and suspiciously effective tactics.

The average binwolf builds itself large and pointy, often using nails or screws as limbs to allow it to scale vertical surfaces in a rush of scrapes and gouges.

SIGNS

- Scratches on walls, floors, and ceilings.
- A rattling howl, first lonely, then joined by others from various directions.
- A brace of whining, corkscrew-headed cubs.

BEHAVIOUR

- Hunt bugs for play, sport, and food. These things just really like a good chase!
- Protect binwolf cubs viciously, if necessary.
- Attack from walls and ceilings where possible.

PARTS & MOVES

Corkscrew Jaws (Bite 3): The spiralling tongue of a binwolf digs into targets, allowing them to initiate a grab on a conflict or disaster from their target's reaction in addition to any other effect. Attempts to break free from a binwolf's grab suffer a Tough Cut of 1.

Scraping Rush (Climb 2 / Slash 2): A swift attack that makes use of every sharp edge a binwolf has. Attempts to react to the scraping rush treat conflicts as disasters.

The Howl (Hunt 1 / Slink 2): Once per scene, a binwolf may release a threatening howl that affects all bugs that can hear it. If the bugs haven't spotted the binwolf yet, they take Slink Damage. If they have, they take a smaller amount of Hunt Damage instead.

Overload (Sizzle 3): Every binwolf is driven by a decaying battery, which they can use to shock a nearby bug with automatic Sizzle Damage once per encounter. Hitting a binwolf with Sizzle Damage deals 1 additional mark of Sizzle Damage to all other nearby binwolves.

Prowler (-): Binwolves inflict a Camo Cut of 1 on all attacks made against them when in darkness.

DEFENCES

- **Resistant to Slink and Climb**, thanks to their innate mastery of both.
- **Weak to Chart**, due to their movements becoming mechanically predictable if studied enough.

BREAKS

- Scamper up a wall / Howl for reinforcements / Shatter a light source / Target a single bug

STUFF TO GRAB

- **Bobs**: Rusty Nail, Threadless Screw, Twisting Tongue, Leaking Battery

BUGBARIANS

[Small/Bugly/Lackey]

OVERVIEW

The most basic of buggish threats are those individuals that never quite adapted to the whole 'live and let live' attitude that typifies post-Mysteriocalypse society. Operating out of the wild, untamed areas of the world, bugbarians raid settlements and caravans for a mixture of food and fun. It probably gets boring out there in the wastes, so can you really blame them?

Yes. Yes, you can.

SIGNS

- A whole mass of hollering from somewhere in the undergrowth nearby, getting louder and closer.
- Barrels of tainted nectar, used as a warrior's draught to get bugbarians in the mood for battle.
- A buggish settlement scarred and ruined, food stores emptied, sticky patches in the streets.
- Crude statues of famed bugbarians from the distant past, most of whom are completely fictional.

BEHAVIOUR

- Smash and grab, emphasis on the smash.
- Take the food, leave the valuables - the only bobs worth keeping around are for armour and weapons!

PARTS & MOVES

Clubs and Torches (Bash 3 / Sizzle 2): To attack under the cover of darkness would be cowardly and, for all of their faults, bugbarians don't lack for bravery. The torches they carry shed light and banish darkness.

Charge! (Dash 2): The average bugbarian prefers the classic combat stylings of running headlong at their targets while screaming. These charges can deal a bit of damage on their own, and bugs defending against them treat conflicts as disasters.

Nectarish Mead (Sense 1): The tainted nectar that bugbarians throw back in unhealthy amounts isn't just for getting them drunk, it's got tactical applications too. A bugbarian can splash tainted nectar over a nearby target, covering them in a sweet sticky residue that inflicts a Tough Cut of 2 on all actions taken that use moving skills (until they clean themselves off).

Chompy Friends (Bite 4): Each bugbarian in an encounter can release a trained predatory plant once, targeting any bug they can see no matter the range.

Tailored Defences (Shield 1): Living out in the wilds has its advantages, one of them being an excuse to focus on effective defence. A bugbarian's gear imposes an Armour Cut of 1 on physical attacks made against them, but is always lost when their track breaks.

DEFENCES

- **Resistant to Bash, Bite, and Scare**, with scrappy yet effective armour turning away sticks *and* stones.
- **Weak to Dazzle** - unexpected surprises tend to bring on headaches.

BREAKS

- Let out a war cry / Quaff some tainted nectar / Light up extra torches / Tackle a problem head-on

STUFF TO GRAB

- **Bits**: Predatory Plant Goo, Scavenged Supplies, Bugbarian Hardtack, Tainted Nectar
- **Bobs**: Matchstick Torch, Battered Drinking Horn, Sturdy Twig Club

CATS

[Titan/Beastly/Boss]

OVERVIEW

We've waxed lyrical about cats at various points throughout this book, and it's not without good reason; to a bug, a cat is the pinnacle of titandom. It's not just about their size (for there are many titans that dwarf them), or even their skills - at the end of the day, what makes a cat so impressive to insect kind is the way it moves through the world as if everything it surveys is its domain, and always has been. That kind of unabashed confidence is hard won, and cats have it in abundance.

It also, unsurprisingly, makes them extremely dangerous foes when you get on their bad side. Earning the ire of a cat will likely gift you an enemy for life, a furred interloper that will turn up to harass you at unexpected junctures (or, somehow, at the precise moments when the addition of a feline force into the mix would be most inconvenient).

That's not to say they can't be countered or outwitted, and no broken bond is beyond repair for a bug... But it is to say that one should tread carefully unless they're very, *very* confident.

Titans follow special rules when it comes to damage, and besting one is an almost impossible challenge for most bands of bugs without planning and forethought.

SIGNS

» Glowing eyes in a distant shadow, eyes that follow you as you move.

» Fur and dust on just about every surface, especially if that surface is fabric.

» The stench of ammonia, a scent of marked territory.

BEHAVIOUR

» Preen, lounge, and hunt for sport.

» Reveal the mysteries of the universe (laconically).

» Engage in a cruel play and unexpected chases with smaller creatures.

TITAN DEFENCES

» **Immune to all except gigadamage and weaknesses stated below** - should you really be doing this?

» **Weak to Swim**. Cats may act all high and mighty, but trick them into a body of water and they quickly lose both regal posture and a good measure of self-confidence.

» **Weak to Scare and Dazzle**. It might not be the kindest approach, but you can definitely shave a few lives off of a cat's absurd counter by giving them a mighty surprise.

» **Immune to Slink**. You're trying to out-stealth a cat? Good luck, dude.

» **Immune to Tame** - even when a cat seems like it's been completely disarmed and befriended, there's still the heart of a hunter beating somewhere deep within.

» **Immune to permanent defeat of any kind**, though it can be beaten back, outwitted, or encouraged to slink off and think about what it's done. Those 99 lives aren't just for show.

BREAKS

» Arch back and hiss / A reactive swipe / Tail thwacking intensifies / Hunker down and get ready to leap / Puff up like a dandelion / Curse in a language of spits and hisses

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Lucky Whisker, Curving Claw, Patch of Fur, Stinky Hairball, Old Mog Tooth, Half-Chewed Treat

» **Bobs**: Strand of Yarn, Hair Elastic, Errant Spring, Broken Bell, Secret Nametag

OUTWITTING A CAT

Squaring up to a titan head-on is a fool's errand, doubly so without a plan. Bugs might approach this encounter by...

- Distracting a feline adversary with enough gifts and toys may well endear the bugs to it as genuine friends.
- Finding a way to scoop the cat, breaking its connection with the ground and denying it graceful movement.
- Pitting the titan against one of its mortal enemies, like a snake, or the dreaded cucumber.

PARTS & MOVES

The Ritual Game (Hunt 3/ Slash 3 / Bite 4): Cats don't fight things the size of bugs, but they may well play with them for a time. Every time a cat takes the spotlight to use this move it can target two nearby bugs at once.

Feline Defences (Shield 2): Through a combination of grace, wit, and matted fur, cats are extremely hard to land a solid hit on. Every time a cat takes the spotlight, roll a d6: on a 1 or 2, the cat imposes a Speed Cut of 2 on incoming attacks. On a 3 or 4, the cat imposes an Armour Cut of 2 on incoming attacks. On a 5 or 6, the cat imposes a Complex Cut of 2 on incoming attacks. *This effect lasts until the cat next takes the spotlight.*

Mercurial (Swagger 2): Cats are talkers by nature, throwing out insults and compliments in equal measure. A bug affected by this move pulls their mood to either positive or negative (Weaver's choice).

True Titan (-): As a titan, the cat has truly impressive defences: Actions with giga impact, or that hit one of its weaknesses, mark one heart. All other actions may still have an effect, narratively, but they won't mark the titan's track. Any heart on the titan's track being marked is also considered a break.

OPTIONAL FELINE LEGENDS

Who knows? Maybe some of those wild stories are true!

Shadowfriend (Slink 3): Cats are completely invisible when in dark areas, save for their eyes. This imposes a Camo Cut of 3 on all attempts to target them with physical attacks.

Whishker (-): Getting ahold of a cat's whisker isn't easy. Getting a cat to willingly grant you a whisker is even harder. But the rewards are worth it - a willingly granted whisker can be given to the universe, consumed in exchange for an immediate *grand discovery* of the wishing bug's own choosing.

The Very Next Day (-): When defeated, a cat disappears with a yowl and a puff of fur. Are they gone forever? Not on your life - they'll return at nightfall the next day, without fail.

Sabretooth (Bite 2d6): Surely such creatures are consigned to the dustbin of history? A sabretooth's bite deals 2d6 marks of damage, and ignores track breaks. *Use this sparingly - it's hideously strong.*

"Do not ask for whom the cat yowls - it yowls for thee!"

Edgar Allen Crow, Feathery Poet-In-Training

CLANKERCATS

[Titan/Beastly/Clanky/Boss]

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OVERVIEW

If you're going to create a machine, why not copy a tried and true design? Such was the thinking of the clankercat engineers, a group of worryingly myopic bugs who were very, very good at bolting a load of scrap together and making it go 'meow', but unfortunately quite bad at visualizing the probable outcome of their endeavours.

They aren't around anymore. *You can likely guess why.*

But the clankercats they created still roam the wilds of the Mysteriocalypse, clanging and rusting and genuinely making a feline-ish nuisance of themselves.

Titans follow special rules when it comes to damage, and besting one is an almost impossible challenge for most bands of bugs without planning and forethought.

SIGNS

» A scrape of metal joints. A crackling hum of power.

» Wait, why are those pawprints *square*?

BEHAVIOUR

» Try, as best they can, to imitate the grace and beauty of the kitties they were built in the image of.

» Dispense information (very infrequently correct).

PARTS & MOVES

Logic Puzzles (Think 2 + Hunt 3): Clankercats are programmed with a huge variety of facts, but lack the computing skills to make sense of them. They'll insistently ask bugs mind-bending questions about the world (dealing Think Damage) and reward answers they deem 'illogical' or long periods of silence with a swipe of their paws (dealing Hunt Damage). *What constitutes an illogical answer is difficult to pin down.*

Stiff-Claw Stagger (Dance 2 / Slash 4): Though they lack the natural grace of flesh-and-blood felines, clankercats do try their best. Any physical attack made against a clankercat takes a Speed Cut of 1.

Random Access Moggery (Think 2): When a twist is rolled in the presence of a clankercat, the Weaver can change a single word in the outcome of the twist... *after* it's been agreed upon by the table.

Whiskazer (Sizzle d6): A last resort, letting the clankercat shock several nearby bugs with electricity.

True Titan (-): As a titan, the clankercat has truly impressive defences: Actions with giga impact, or that hit one of its weaknesses, mark one heart. All other actions may still have an effect, narratively, but they won't mark the titan's track. Any heart on the titan's track being marked is also considered a break.

DEFENCES

» **Immune to all except gigadamage and weaknesses stated below** - should you really be doing this?

» **Resistant to Make and Bash**, due to some solid design principles and a good amount of metal.

» **Weak to Swim, Yap, and Think**. Just like a real cat, but with a higher chance of randomly exploding if it gets wet.

BREAKS

» A bit falls off / Sparks jump between whiskers / State flawed logic / Segmented stretch / Meow, robotically

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bobs**: Metal Whisker, Rusted Claw, Eye-Bulb, Clankercat Cabling, Robot's Tiny Heart

SHUTTING DOWN A CLANKERCAT

Squaring up to a titan head-on is a fool's errand, doubly so without a plan. Bugs might approach this encounter by...

- » Finding a way to trap the clankercat's mechanical mind in a feedback loop.
- » Luring the machine into water, and watching the sparks fly.
- » Attempting to discern whether the clankercat's questions lead to some kind of deeper, universal truth.

COCKERELISKS

[Huge/Feathery/Ghostly/Boss]

♥•♥♥

OVERVIEW

Life as a chicken has never been what you would call *easy*, given their aeons-long position in the food chain being 'delicious treat wrapped in annoying feathers'. But chickens persist, even with a world full of beasts that drool at the very thought of them, and that persistence is largely due to the existence of the cockerelisk - the next step in poultry evolution.

SIGNS

» A scattering of feathers, ranging from barnyard brown to sunrise red.

» Scratched-up ground and scattered seeds.

» Predatory beasts slumbering out in the open, tails and whiskers twitching as they dream.

BEHAVIOUR

» Dazzle and mesmerize those that would threaten their feathered kin.

» Craft dreams of roast dinner and unimaginably delectable sauces.

» Crow at the sunrise to focus their psychic powers.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Scare and Hunt**, thanks to their extrasensory perception and calculating minds.

» **Immune to Dazzle** - it's tough to trick a trickster.

» **Weak to Bite**, because they are, unfortunately, pretty darn tasty.

BREAKS

» Crow for psychic reinforcements / Scratch menacingly / Craft a less pleasant dream

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Heirloom Seed, Floating Feather, Third Bird Eye

PARTS & MOVES

The Henhouse Dream (Dazzle 3): A wave of psychic energy emanates from the cockerelisk's beady third eye, dazzling any in its path. If that Dazzle Damage would result in a track either breaking or being filled, the target is plunged into the Henhouse Dream, an avian-oriented fantasy where they're supplied with all of the chicken they can eat (along with a heft side of tasty trimmings). *The physical form of a character pulled into the Henhouse Dream collapses into a deep sleep, but their dream-self can still take the spotlight to explore this new realm of delicious unconsciousness.*

Nightmare Visions (Scare 1): If the cockerelisk is attacked physically, it can immediately summon 1d6 half-real phantasmal *lackeys* to its aid. Each nightmare vision adds another break and another heart to the cockerelisk's Heart Track, and can attack any bug the cockerelisk can see. These summoned nightmares are nothing more than psychic projections, but they seem frighteningly real. *The cockerelisk may use Nightmare Visions when its track breaks to add 1d6 more projections to the Henhouse Dream, to harass sleeping targets - these deal 2 Scare Damage rather than the usual 1.*

Roost-ire (Think 2): A focused psychic attack against a single bug the cockerelisk can see. This move pulls the target's mood to negative no matter the result of the reaction roll.

Maze of Feathers (Shield 1): The cockerelisk relies on psychic powers for dominance, but its feathery coating can still be tough to crack. All attacks made against a cockerelisk suffer a Complex Cut of 1, and attempts to distract or outwit it suffer an additional Tough Cut of 1.

COMET-NOSED MOLES

[Large/Beastly/Elite]

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OVERVIEW

Speed is a relative term. For a bug, crossing a back garden (a wild and untamed expanse of ponds, trees, and grass so high you could see the world atop a stem) might take a few hours, maybe even a day. For a cat, it would be the work of a moment. Such is the way of things in a world where the huge and the tiny coexist.

Comet-nosed moles aren't that much bigger than bugs at the end of the day, yet they have a turn of speed that would make most larger beasts blush - and they're even faster when they're tunneling. It's like the old saying goes - if you want to get somewhere fast, find a mole.

SIGNS

» A moving channel of earth and stones, swift as the wink of a hummingbird's eye.

» A snuffling, tentacular nose poking out of a hole in the ground.

» Arms and legs spinning like tiny dynamos.

BEHAVIOUR

» Create vast underground tunnel networks.

» Act as a taxi service for bugs on the go.

» Occasionally eat their customers.

PARTS & MOVES

Rolling Around At The Speed of Ground (Dash 4): Comet-nosed moles aren't noted for their combat prowess, nor the depth of their wit - just about every story concerning them has something to do with speed. It's understandable, really - all actions that would require physical contact with a comet-nosed mole take a Speed Cut of 2, as long as they're able to move freely.

Diggin' Claws (Dig 2 / Slash 2): Whether it's being hit with a spray of dirt from errant tunneling or a swipe across the bows when you get in the way, it'll hurt.

Over and Under (Slink 1): Though not especially stealthy when out in the open, having a few inches of dirt between you and someone looking for you really is quite an effective camouflage. Comet-nosed moles can swiftly dig under the ground, and actions to find them from the surface treat conflicts as disasters.

The Comet Wiggles (Think 3): Did we mention the whole mysterious powers thing? We didn't? Well, we probably should now. There's an oddness around the tentacled nose of these moles - they seem to be able to sniff out thoughts, and sometimes even to levitate objects with the twitch of a nasal tendril. Weird stuff!

Coarse Fur (-): Ignore cut when targeting a mole if you have it successfully *grabbed* - but hold on tight!

DEFENCES

» **Immune to Dazzle**, because their eyesight isn't the best. Not terrible - just not the best.

» **Resistant to Dash**, because let's face it - they're faster than you.

» **Weak to Dig**, mostly due to the surprise of encountering another tunnel when they're expecting hard-packed dirt.

BREAKS

» Burrow underground / Scent the air and hone in on a bug / Flare and trumpet / Veer off course / Cave collapse

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Comet-Nose Tentacle, Mole Claw, Patch of Mole-Fur, Tears of the Underground

CORDYCHAPS

[Small/Bugly/Shroomy/Lackey]

OVERVIEW

Polite to a fault, cordychaps are the door-to-door salespeople of the world of PICO. Pleased as punch to have joined the shroomy collective, all they really want is for you to do the same. Not for any nefarious reasons, no, but for a renewed sense of mutual understanding and excellent company benefits. Seven days of mental holiday a week, too!

SIGNS

- A strong and shroomy scent.
- A little face looking up at you, somehow eager and vacant all at the same time.
- A cloud of worryingly pleasant spores.

BEHAVIOUR

- Chat with others about the shroomy collective, and give the gift of spores when asked.
- Scarper if violence breaks out.
- Stay clear of fire!

DEFENCES

- **Immune to Scare**, because depending on your perspective, the worst (or best!) has already happened.
- **Weak to Sizzle**, because if there's one thing spores don't like, it's fire.

BREAKS

- A new argument / Production of helpful literature / Burst!

STUFF TO GRAB

- **Bits**: Collective Shroom, Wiggly Stalks, Friend Spore
- **Bobs**: Shroom-Defending Pamphlet

PARTS & MOVES

Mesmerizing Sales Pitch (Yap 1): You've never considered joining the shroomy collective? Never, you say? But think of all of that you're missing out on... Any bug damaged by the Mesmerizing Sales Pitch lowers the impact on actions taken to physically attack any nearby cordychaps until end of scene.

Promising Spores (Care 2): A cloud of spores that cordychaps release when they're close to new potential members. The spores *can* be used to deal damage, but that would be terribly rude - a more polite approach would be to add a new drawback to one of the target's aspects, '*Can only be used in the vicinity of mushrooms*'. This drawback can be removed by spending a task to have a good old scrub in fresh water... or with *FIRE*.

Ripe for Growth (-): A good sales pitch is all about timing. If the cordychaps are encountered in darkness, in excessively damp conditions, or in the midst of a sporenado (page 95), bugs suffer a Complex Cut of 1 when attempting to use friending skills to reason with them (as their parasitic mushrooms have an even greater level of control than usual).

Final Thoughts (Sizzle 1d6): If the last mark on a cordychaps track is made with a physical attack, the unfortunate individual bursts into a cloud of spores that automatically deal 1d6 Sizzle damage to all nearby bugs. At the Weaver's discretion this may affect other nearby cordychaps too, creating a potentially devastating chain reaction.

Fungal Fashion (-): You have to admit, it looks kind of cool. Cordychaps release a burst of inescapable promising spores when *grabbed*.

MUSINGS ON CHAPPISH NATURE

As far as anyone knows, none of the cordychaps started out as anything more than an average bug - their mushroom-infused nature is, seemingly, a decision they've made at some point (assuming it's voluntary, and given their sales pitch, it at least *seems* to be). Few will talk about their pre-cordyceps life...

But surely some had friends and family that they've left behind?

DRACOBATS

[Huge/Beastly/Elite]

OVERVIEW

A shadow passing across the moon. The swift beating of wings echoing out across the night sky. Tonight, this night, is when the dracobat hunts.

Dracobats are so large that logic itself ignores them, allowing them speed and agility that should be reserved only for the most felinous of deific beings.

SIGNS

» Other bugs running for cover, waving little arms above their heads as if to ward off something above.

» The clap and flap of leathery wings.

» A keening so high-pitched as to be almost impossible to detect.

» An empty space where a bug was just moments ago.

BEHAVIOUR

» Divebomb and grab targets to carry them away.

» Use the night sky as cover.

» Stay in flight whenever possible, unless roosting in a tree or attic-space (hanging upside down, naturally).

» Scream from the darkness.

PARTS & MOVES

Divebomb (Slash 3): A fearsome aerial assault! Bugs defending against a divebomb suffer a Speed Cut of 1, and if the result is a disaster, that bug is also automatically grabbed and lifted into the air. If the dracobat is grounded, the attack becomes a far less effective lunge - decrease damage to Slash 1, and there's no auto-grab effect.

Draconic Scream (Yap 2): Hits any bug that can hear, and deals double damage to bugs with a Feeler aspect. The dracobat can also focus this scream, dealing Yap 3 against a single target instead (with the same double damage rule).

Moon-Powered Flight (Fly 2): Dracobats aren't quite as confident without the moon there to back them up - attackers treat conflicts as triumphs when attempting to target a flying dracobat during the daylight.

Leathershield (-): All Bash, Slash, and Bite attacks against the dracobat take an Armour Cut of 1 when it's on the ground.

Unnerving Aura (-): Buddy aspects don't give their usual benefits in the presence of a dracobat, even if they have unmarked hearts.

DEFENCES

» **Immune to Scare**, as there are certain perks to being at the top of your particular food chain.

» **Resistant to Fly**, given that almost nothing can match their aerial deftness.

» **Weak to Sizzle and Think**, especially while flying.

BREAKS

» Spread wings and shriek / Grounded / Terrifying divebomb / Two morsels at once / Retreat to roost

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Bat-Fur, Wing Leather, Sonic Chamber, Cruel Claw

» **Bobs**: Oversized Flight Goggles (only from a juvenile dracobat still searching for confidence), Hidden Matches

DIRE PICORANHA

[Small/Scaly/Swarm]

OVERVIEW

Many assume that the picoranha swarm any who step (splash?) into their watery domain due to an intense hunger, but looks can be deceiving - it's actually more of a piscine sport, a painful contest to see who can take the biggest bite and then brag about it later. They are still hungry, don't get me wrong, they're just more motivated by the act of biting than the end result.

Still, whatever their motivation, one fact holds unfortunately true: if you see a swarm of picoranha heading your way, you're definitely on the menu.

SIGNS

» Ripples in an otherwise placid pond.

» Candy wrappers with bite marks, floating in a stream.

» An old abandoned antenna that's been used as some kind of toothpick.

BEHAVIOUR

» Stay quiet and hidden in the depths until prey is far from land.

» Swarm targets but take turns to bite.

» Increase the size of each bite, and decrease the time between them, as a rumble progresses.

PARTS & MOVES

Bite and Bite and Bite Some More (Bite 0-6): The average picoranha bite starts off pretty weak, but as they're emboldened by the spirit of competition those bites get bigger and faster. At the beginning of a picoranha encounter, the Weaver should set a six-box track. Every time the picoranha lands a bite on their target, they deal damage equal to the current amount of marks on the track AND the track gets marked.

Frenzy (-): Every time the picoranha's Heart Track breaks, they can make an attack against a nearby target with a Tough Cut of 1 on any reaction taken to defend against it. If the special Bite Track is at 4 marks or more, this Tough Cut increases to 2.

In Their Element (Swim 2): Picoranha swarms can only operate effectively when in water (otherwise they just sort of flop around the place trying to find a liquid to immerse themselves in). While in water, Attack Rolls made against them require triples rather than doubles to generate a twist (or any twist-equivalent).

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Swim** - you're in their territory now!

» **Weak to Care and Make**, but only if they're used to create or brandish impressive foods as bribes.

BREAKS

» Shoal up / Attack from all sides / Chomp down on a nearby bit or bob / Retreat and regroup / Eat the weakest and grow stronger

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Picoranha Scale, A Memory of Fuller Stomachs, Big Bite Medal-Scale

DRUMMINGBIRDS

[Large/Feathery/Lackey/Swarm]

♥♥•♥♥♥•♥♥

OVERVIEW

A single drummingbird is little more than a rhythmic nuisance, tapping a perfect tattoo on branch, stone, or bottlecap. A whole flock of them though? That's a *performance*.

Drummingbirds have very little interest in fighting, preferring instead to wow friends and enemies alike with incredible musical shows (complete with feather-ruffling dance routines). That's not to say there's no danger involved though - the wall of noise they create makes it impossible for anyone nearby to sleep, and a single non-stop show can last days, weeks, or even months at a time.

SIGNS

» The sound of drumming beaks and flapping wings, growing impossibly loud as the hours draw on.

» An enthusiastic crowd of onlookers slowly backing away as the sound grows too intense.

BEHAVIOUR

» Put on the greatest, loudest, most unforgettable show that the world has ever seen, whether you've been asked to or not.

» ... And then perform an encore.

PARTS & MOVES

Crash, Stomp, Smash (Bash 1): Being close enough to a drummingbird swarm to see them deals a mark of automatic Bash Damage to any bugs that can hear whenever they take the spotlight. This is increased to 2 marks if the bug in question has a Feelers aspect.

Personalized Solo (Yap d6): Every now and then one bird will take centre stage, belting out a solo dedicated to a single buggish target it can see. That bug takes a random amount of Yap Damage, but also pulls their mood to positive.

Wingbeat Dance (Fly 3 / Dance 3): A sudden explosion of feathered bodies pulling off gnarly spins and dives, this impressive display is also unfortunately liable to send birds careening into multiple bugs at once. They're not trying to cause harm... but they do. Using Dance to react to this move allows a bug to treat disasters as conflicts.

WHAAAT? (-): Drummingbirds impose a Tough Cut of 2 on any friending skills used to affect them. They're not surly, they just can't hear you.

Sleepless for the Week (-): Camp actions can't be taken on journeys near a drummingbird performance, and the amount of hearts healed by natural rest is reduced by 1.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Fly**, not just because of their own wings, but because of the constantly vibrating air around them.

» **Immune to Dazzle**. The show must go on!

BREAKS

» Pump up the volume / Bring in a new musician / Throw feathers to the crowd like confetti / Start an unexpected pyrotechnic display / Finish on a crescendo, then start right back up again (even louder than before)

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Performer's Feather, Pocked Drumstick

» **Bobs**: Stolen Coins, Electrical Tape, Bottlecap Gong, Percussive Stones

FROGLINS [Large/Slimy/Lackey] & CROAKLINS [Large/Slimy/Boss]

OVERVIEW

In an ideal world, a pond would be a peaceful place. You could have a picnic by one, or skim stones across the glassy surface and watch the ripples spread. A little slice of heaven, if admittedly rather more watery than most imagine heaven to be.

But, unfortunately, ponds in the world of PICO are anything but peaceful - not when the bullrushes hide the hungry forms of froglin gangs, at any rate. You might still be part of a picnic by one, but you probably won't last long enough to shake off the blankets at the end.

SIGNS

- The ribbet of impending doom.
- A shaking of the undergrowth, accompanied by poorly concealed snickers of anticipation.
- A pair of eyes glowing from under a lily pad.

BEHAVIOUR

- Froglins band together in groups for safety against meaner monsters, each headed by a croaklin boss.
- Stay mobile and insulting.
- Lick everything!

FROGLIN PARTS & MOVES

Stub Tongue (Scare 1): Froglins lack the sticky tongue of their more monstrous ancestors, but that stubby little licker is still a dangerous tool! Increase damage by one if it's taken to a part- or buddy-type aspect. *Remember, players choose the aspect that takes damage - let them know about this addition only after that choice.*

Legs For Days (Bash 2): There's a whole lot of power in them there gams! A solid kick from a froglin can send a bug flying back, pushing them into a new position entirely and likely scattering their bits and bobs at the same time.

Here For The Show (Yap 1): Froglin groups are usually hungry for entertainment, and can't help complimenting an impressive display - or insulting a disappointing performance. Any skill used to surprise a froglin counts as a gigaskill.

Leaper's Logic (Dance 3): One hour of hopping practice a day, minimum - that's the froglin way, or so they say. All rumbling actions targeting froglins take a Speed Cut of 1 while they're able to stay on the move.

Riverwise (-): Most froglins spend more than half of their lives in water, be that lakes, rivers, or particularly big puddles. All actions targeting a froglin while it remains submerged suffer a Tough Cut of 1.

DEFENCES

- **Resistant to Swagger** - they've got enough of their own.
- **Weak to Tame and Yap (froglins only)**, as undermining their croaklin leader is likely to make them fold or flee.
- **Weak to Dazzle**, because even the rowdiest bunch can be distracted or pacified by a good show.

BREAKS

- Hop to new positions / Let the croaklin take the lead / A tangle of long legs / Bullies never win

STUFF TO GRAB

- **Bits**: Frothspawn, Flask of Dirty Water, Bullrush Ruff
- **Bobs**: Discarded Cutlery, Croaklin Cloth

CROAKLIN PARTS & MOVES

Croaklins are froglins that have proven themselves enough to rise to the leadership of a gang - they have access to all of the froglin parts and moves, and might also benefit from...

Stompy (Bash 2): You know what they say about frogs with big feet. Croaklins can start a rumble by sending out a shockwave, dealing two marks of Bash Damage to all nearby bugs that are in contact with the ground. They can repeat this during a scuffle by marking one of their own hearts.

Boss-Frog Threads (-): Made from bullrush-fluff, usually wrapped around the neck, waist, and arms to help a croaklin show off. Croaklins gain an extra defence, **Immune to Swagger and Scare**.

Weapons of War (Slash 3): The strongest croaklins are big enough and tough enough to wield ancient weapons of war, gleaming with potential despite years of tarnish. Any bug that takes damage from a Weapons of War move takes an additional effect from the list below.
+ A spoon can *knock* the bug flying.
+ A fork can *grab* the bug automatically.
+ A knife can *destroy* either a bit or a bob.
+ A spork can do any of the above.

Croak of Command (Scare 1): There's no point being the boss if you can't throw your weight around when it matters! A croaklin can mark a heart to call a new froglin into a scuffle. *Don't overuse this - eternal fights are rarely as fun as you'd think.*

GESTALTS

[Large/Bugly/Slimy/Elite/Swarm]

OVERVIEW

Little guys have a reputation for sticking together, and the littlest guys stick together in the most impressive ways. Gestalts are the littlest of guys writ large - thousands, or even millions, of bacteria clinging together to form a sludgy construct of nano-powered destruction.

SIGNS

» Strange, sticky footprints of various sizes.

» Keening battle cries, so high-pitched that even bugs have trouble hearing them.

» The smell of damp and mildew, getting stronger.

BEHAVIOUR

» Bundle up and take a multi-limbed form to take revenge against those that would step on them.

» Scatter and hide when met with overwhelming resistance.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Bite and Slash**. Those microscopic components are great at getting out of the way!

» **Immune to Bash**. Or, more appopriately, a bashing attack might break a gestalt apart entirely... only for it to fully reform half a second later.

» **Weak to Tame, Care, and Make**, but only if there are tasty, distracting treats on offer for it to digest.

BREAKS

» Scatter and Hide! / Get Even Bigger / Glow Baby Glow

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Bacterial Sludge, Mimicked Weapon

PARTS & MOVES

Thousand Hand Smash (Bash 3): The focused fury of manifold microscopic fists gathered into a single, club-like swing. Bugs hit by a hammer-style blow may well be grabbed in addition to any damage taken, and a sweeping backhand can push multiple targets back at once.

Engulf (Swim 5): The gestalt can engulf a grabbed bug, pulling them into its shifting bacterial form while dealing high damage. Engulfed targets count as being swallowed, and take 2 marks of automatic Swim Damage every time they take the spotlight while still within the gestalt's seething body. *The gestalt can only engulf one bug at a time.*

Come In For a Hug (Scare 2): A lumbering charge that allows the gestalt to automatically engulf a single nearby bug if they roll a disaster while reacting (though that bug doesn't take the usual Swim Damage associated with the Engulf move).

Adaptive Armament (Make 3): When hit with an attack from some kind of bit, bob, or weapon, the gestalt can form a bacterial copy of it for itself the next time it takes the spotlight. When used to attack, this copy deals 3 marks of either Make Damage or the original damage type of the bit, bob, or weapon copied.

Nanodaptive (-): The ability to change form on the fly gives the gestalt some unpredictable defences. When it has the spotlight, alongside any other move, the Weaver can roll a d6 and give it a benefit according to the following table of results (these benefits last until the next time Nanodaptive is used)...

1: A Tough Cut of 1
2: An Armour Cut of 2
3: A Camo Cut of 2
4: A Speed Cut of 2
5: A Complex Cut of 2
6: No additional benefit

GRAND RIDDLEMASTERS

[Large/Bugly/Elite]

♥♥•♥♥•♥♥

OVERVIEW

Most bugs are defined, broadly speaking, by their physicality; the shape they hold, the parts that make them, the biology that keeps them metaphorically ticking. But for riddlemasters, it's what's *inside* that counts - specifically what's going on inside a bug's brainy bits.

Aside from their attitudes, riddlemasters rarely have anything in common with each other. One might be a scorpion waiting patiently atop a scorching dune, guarding the only available shade. Another a water strider, poised by the riverside, ready to take eager bugs at least to the halfway mark. Another a mantid, towering, wings spread, a rough grid drawn out in the dirt before it for a high-stakes game of tic tac toe.

SIGNS

» The empty shells of the overconfident.

» Scribbles on notepaper and the lingering smell, somehow, of a school exam hall.

BEHAVIOUR

» Confront bugs with the opportunity to strain their brains for gain, at risk of pain, or face disdain.

» Honour agreements made... for the most part.

PARTS & MOVES

Pose a Challenge (-): After *partially* helping the band out, a riddlemaster will refuse further aid until they've solved some kind of mental challenge. This might be a game of skill, a sequence of logic-based questions, or a chance to solve, as one might expect, a riddle. Failure to do so within a given time limit (represented by a Progress Track set by the Weaver) will result in offers of help being withdrawn, or even impending violence.

Pile on the Pressure (Think/Scare/Chart 1-3): Just because there are rules, doesn't mean you have to play fair. Riddlemasters are experts at intimidating or misleading bugs if they engage with the challenge they pose, dealing inescapable damage to the entire band as the Progress Track gets marked.

Sow Seeds of Doubt (Yap D6): Once a significant move has been made or an important answer given, the riddlemaster will often give the bug involved a 'chance' to make 'better' choices. Even if presented in a friendly manner, this is always a way of making a nervous bug second-guess themselves.

The Mental Muscle (-): Any attempts the bugs make to confuse or befuddle a riddlemaster (or turn the tables on them with questions of their own) are faced with a Complex Cut of 2.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Yap, Think, and Swagger**. Riddlemasters can talk the talk better than those they challenge.

» **Weak to all rumbling skills**, because they're rarely ready for an immediate and straight-forward response.

BREAKS

» Complicate the situation / Offer some 'help' in the form of multiple choice options / Chuckle knowingly / Punish time-wasters / Resort to violence in the face of overwhelming smugness / Capitulate and lend more aid

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Bead of Acrid Sweat, A Tally-Marked Shell

» **Bobs**: Answers on a Hidden Scrap of Paper

GROUND-OWLS

[Titan/Feathery/Boss]

OVERVIEW

You can tell a lot about a bird by the kind of feathers it chooses to show. Crows tend toward darker hues, but they're masters of pigment and dye - it's rare to find one without some sort of cutting-edge bodily graffiti to show off. Parrots, they're as colourful as they are loud, and come in colours as varied as their vocabulary. Robins have a shock of red alongside their more muted whites and browns, speaking to their innately bloodthirsty nature (apparently).

So with that in mind, what feathers does a ground-owl show to the world?

None, because they're always covered in moss, stones, and dirt. There are definitely *some* feathers under all the detritus, but few bugs get close enough (and even fewer owls get clean enough) to establish anything about what colour they might be.

This muddy covering makes the ground-owl an unwitting master of natural camouflage, unusual for a creature so titanically large. But as useful as it is, their earthen facade is more the outcome of accident than design; a natural byproduct of hunting their favourite meal, the comet-nosed mole. It's just like my dear old mother used to say - it's hard to catch a mole without getting down and dirty yourself!

Titans follow special rules when it comes to damage, and besting one is an almost impossible challenge for most bands of bugs without planning and forethought.

SIGNS

» Tunnels scratched through softer ground, disappearing dizzyingly into the dark below.

» Muddy talon-prints that seem to stop next to a mound of earth and stone. Maybe whatever left them flew away?

BEHAVIOUR

» Dive underground like some kind of industrial bore when they sense a comet-nosed mole nearby.

» Gobble up or scare away bugs, whose many legs make annoyingly ground-disturbing vibrations.

TITAN DEFENCES

» **Immune to all except gigadamage and weaknesses stated below** - should you really be doing this?

» **Weak to Fly, Swim, and Dig**, through a combination of jealousy and pride.

BREAKS

» Burrow and surface / Let out an ear-piercing shriek / Toss mud and stones everywhere / Single out a particularly annoying bug / Unearth a mole (a lucky distraction for you, not so lucky for the mole)

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Mud-Covered Feather, Owl Stone, Atrophied Star, Digger's Talon, Eggshell Fragment

FACING A GROUND-OWL

Squaring up to a titan head-on is a fool's errand, doubly so without a plan. Bugs might approach this encounter by...

- Teaming up with some disgruntled comet-nosed moles to strike a blow at their apex predator.
- If the ground-owl has shrieking owlets embedded in its mud, offering to take the kids for a bit and keep them amused would be a *special* kind of challenge.

PARTS & MOVES

Half-Burrow Charge (Bash 2 + Dig 2): The owl lowers its head and rushes forward, spraying stones and mud through the air and leaving a furrow in its wake. Rolls taken to react to this move suffer a Speed Cut of 1. *Can only be used on earthy terrain.*

Stone Shake (Bash 1d6): A move that can target multiple nearby bugs at once, where the owl shakes a scattering of stones free from its camouflaging coat. Damage for each bug is rolled separately.

Night-Owl (Scare 3): The owl's night vision makes up for its unfortunate shortsighted squinting through the daylight hours. In light, a ground-owl gains additional weaknesses to Slink and Dazzle Damage. In darkness, any attempt to hide from or visually trick the ground-owl suffers a Speed Cut of 2.

Earthbound and Loud (Dig 2 / Yap 2): The mud on a ground-owl's feathers makes it too heavy to fly, and it has a particular hatred for *other* flying creatures. Whenever it takes the spotlight during a rumble, any bugs that are airborne pull their mood negative as the owl throws jibes their way.

Quicker Than You'd Think (Dash 1): Whenever a bug would avoid Speed Cut imposed by the owl, the Weaver should roll a d6. On a 1, 2, or 3, that bug suffers the Speed Cut as normal, caught off guard by the owl's brute acceleration.

A Suspicious Mound (-): A ground-owl is almost impossible to distinguish from a pile of mud and stones when at rest - a great opportunity to use 'surprise!', as seen on page 91.

True Titan (-): As a titan, the ground-owl has truly impressive defences: Actions with giga impact, or that hit one of its weaknesses, mark one heart. All other actions may still have an effect, narratively, but they won't mark the titan's track. Any heart on the titan's track being marked is also considered a break.

GROUND-OWLETS

While a ground-owl is hardly the most social of creatures, they do (thankfully) make an exception for their own young. Ground-owlets spend much of their young life, from egg to hatchling, embedded in the protective muddy carapace that forms around their parent's feathers, peeping out from time to time to learn about the world and offer unhelpful commentary on proceedings.

If you'd like to have a set of ground-owlets accompanying their ground-owl parent in an encounter, you don't need to add any extra boxes to the hazard's titan track or treat them as separate creatures. Instead, use the additional moves below to represent the scruffy little kids, and their contribution to proceedings...

Born to Heckle (Yap 1 / Swagger 1): Sticks and stones, but without the sticks. Whenever a bug would burn a box to add to the Combo Track, they must burn two boxes instead unless they take a mark of automatic Yap or Swagger Damage (Weaver's choice) representing a shrill insult from an enthusiastic fledgling.

Ever-Alert (-): Can't beat having extra eyes around tricksy buggish sorts. Any bug that attempts to perform a sneaky or secretive action always pulls their mood to the extreme negative on a conflict or disaster (in addition to any other usual effects).

GROUNDBREAKER HOGS

[Titan/Beastly/Boss]

OVERVIEW

A shambling mountain of hide and hair, with two muddy tusks emerging from a drool-slicked mouth. The groundbreaker hog is a beast of prodigious size and unnatural strength, and they'd likely be the rulers of the Mysteriocalypse if they could A) band together in common purpose, or B) had any ambitions other than dinner.

Luckily for the tinier folk of the new and bugly world, groundbreaker hogs don't give two figs about anything that isn't truffle-shaped. Remember that if you ever find yourself near one - or, a much better plan, try not to put yourself in that situation at all.

Titans follow special rules when it comes to damage, and besting one is an almost impossible challenge for most bands of bugs without planning and forethought.

SIGNS

» Broken ground, trotter-prints, and missing truffles.

» Tree bark gouged and broken, newly-trampled paths.

BEHAVIOUR

» Fight other groundbreaker hogs that challenge them.

» Leave trails of broken ground in their wake.

» FIND TRUFFLES. EAT TRUFFLES. MORE TRUFFLES.

PARTS & MOVES

Trotter Smash (Bash 3): Strong enough to send multiple bugs flying, the Trotter Smash deals damage to up to three targets at a time.

Tusking Terror (Slash 6): A single-target move that also breaks one bit and one bob if the reaction to it is a disaster, in addition to any other negative effects.

Named For a Reason (Dig 4): Groundbreaker hogs can smash their way through earth, wood, and stone like a tusk-shaped knife through butter.

Shag and Bristle (-): The hog's hide imposes an Armour Cut of 1 and a Tough Cut of 1 on all incoming physical actions.

Single-Minded (-): The hog is there for truffles and territory - keeping it fed or distracting it with a rival may allow a bug to deal opportunistic gigadamage.

Caught In the Act (-): Any bug using the Dig skill or stealing a truffle around a groundbreaker hog passes the spotlight to the beast once their action is done.

True Titan (-): As a titan, the groundbreaker hog has truly impressive defences: Actions with giga impact, or that hit one of its weaknesses, mark one heart. All other actions may still have an effect, narratively, but they won't mark the titan's track. Any heart on the titan's track being marked is also considered a break.

TITAN DEFENCES

» **Immune to all except gigadamage and weaknesses stated below** - should you really be doing this?

» **Weak to Tame and Care**, because underneath that shaggy, tusked exterior is a heart waiting to be warmed.

BREAKS

» Scent a new truffle / Squeal and charge / Tunnel at speed / Rear up and expose a classic weak point

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Half-Chewed Truffles, Massive Tusk-Splinter, Hog Hair, Tusker's Musk

FACING A GROUNDBREAKER HOG

Squaring up to a titan head-on is a fool's errand, doubly so without a plan. Bugs might approach this encounter by...

- » Challenging the hog to a truffle-finding competition (where they have a secretive advantage).
- » Trying to rope and direct it away from inhabited areas, like some kind of porcine rodeo.
- » Scaring the hog with fire, though this does risk a wider blaze that may destroy more than they bargained for.

GUBS

[Small/Clanky/Elite]

♥♥•♥

OVERVIEW

There's something appealing about buggishness - a certain devil-may-care attitude, combined with the infinite possibilities of insectobiology and the knowledge of how to knuckle down and get serious when the situation calls for it. Who wouldn't want to be a bug, at the end of the day?

And maybe that's the theory behind gubs, self-organized trash-constructs coming together in markedly scuttlish shapes, organizing their routines and communities around their best guess of how bugs should be.

SIGNS

» An unusual lack of useful bit and bobs, as if they've all been hoovered up for some greater purpose.

» Metallic antennae quivering with interest.

» 'Hives' of old packing peanuts and gathered paper.

BEHAVIOUR

» Gubs are mimics by nature, observers and deployers of typical bugly behaviour (even if they don't always understand the nuances).

» Second to the hobbies of observation and mimicry comes the more mundane but essential goal of propagation; more trash equals more gubs!

PARTS & MOVES

Watch and Learn (Various 2): Anything a bug can do, a gub can... Well, at least they can attempt it. Every gub has the capacity to learn two or three skills, but only after it's seen them being used by a real, honest-to-goodness insect (like the player characters, or a nearby NPC). Once learned, a gub can use these skills however they like, including as a method of dealing damage in a rumble. *Though possible, it's unlikely that the gubs a band encounters will be completely blank slates - when presenting gubbish NPCs, pick one or two skills that they might already be able to use based on local wildlife or environmental features.*

Form (Rummage 2): Being naturally made of bits and bobs affords gubs both a certain level of inherent defensiveness AND the ability to switch up their design on the fly. A gub can consume a bit or bob from the environment (or one offered by a player character) to completely heal all marks on their Heart Track.

... And Reform (Make 3): They also inflict a Complex Cut of 1 on any attacks that try to target their physical bodies, because what really counts as a weak spot when you're fighting something made out matches, screws, and a bit of ancient tin?

Friendly to a Fault (Yap 1): It takes a lot to offend or unsettle a gub. If anything, it's actually quite hard to interrupt their constant stream of friendly patter.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Rummage**. Which is lucky for them, as they're made out of useful bits and bobs.

» **Weak to all friending skills**, because everybody wants to be part of the in-group.

BREAKS

» Stare in awe of something less than impressive / A bit falls off / Make an observation on the topic of a mystery

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits and Bobs**: Anything at all that relates to how a gub has been visually described in a scene.

MUSINGS ON GUBBISH NATURE

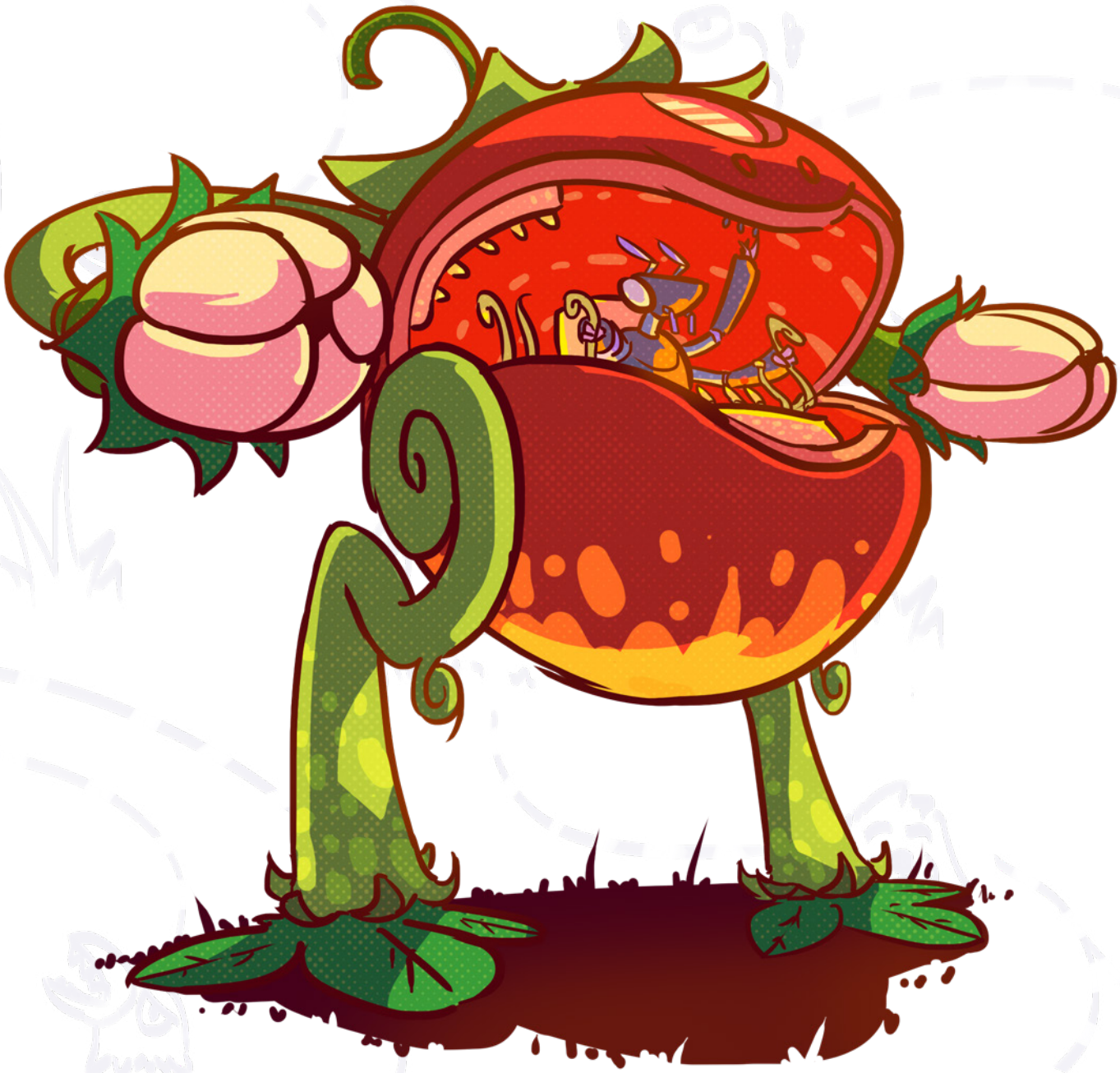
Gubs may not be bugs in body, but they're trying their best. They're held back by the limits of the materials they're made from, by the dangers of a world built to a scale that vastly outstrips them, and by the complex, difficult-to-grasp nature of what exactly an actual bug *is*. They struggle, and sometimes fail, but they always do their best.

And when you get right down to it, is there anything more bug-like than that?

MUSINGS ON VERDANT MACHINERY

The secrets of heirloomer construction are only known to a single bug, the kind of solitary genius that treats requests to show their schematics with mortal horror. Thanks to this level of secrecy, heirloomer pilots rarely (if ever) know how to actually *fix* their machines if they break down, relying on a combination of coaxing, watering, and feverish hope.

Best just to hope that they don't ever break down.



HEIRLOOMERS

[Huge/Leafy/Bugly/Clanky/Elite]

♥♥♥•♥♥♥•♥♥♥•♥

OVERVIEW

There's a scene in a very famous movie about dinosaurs (you probably know the one I'm talking about) where some not-yet-eaten mammalian types detect the approach of an oncoming lizard, a particularly terrible one, based on the ripples in a cup of water.

Scale that scene down a little, and replace the dinosaur with a hollowed out tomato moving on legs of leaf and vine, and you've accurately imagined what the arrival of an heirloomer might seem like to a band of adventuring bugs.

Heirloomers are organic machines, walking fruits and vegetables piloted by renegade bugs that have green thumbs and very intense farming routines.

SIGNS

» A silhouette, somehow both gangly and bulbous, striding over a nearby hill.

» An absent goat-beetle.

» The wild laughter of a bugly pilot as their vegetative vehicle charges into battle with predatory plants.

BEHAVIOUR

» Challenge any foe that might seek to terrorize bugs.

» Settle down to plant seeds and coax new heirloomers into growth (when in a location ripe for planting).

PARTS & MOVES

The moves an heirloomer can pull off in a rumble very much depend on the fruit or vegetable that makes up its main body. Here are a few concrete examples...

Tomato (Bash 2 / Swim 1): A dispenser of sticky juices at close range and rock-hard seeds fired from a distance. Tomato heirloomers impose a Speed Cut of 1 on nearby bugs trying to use moving skills thanks to the liquid they spill.

Hot-Pepper (Sizzle 3): Equipped with spicy lashes sure to send a target running for the nearest source of milk. Hot-pepper heirloomers also deal 1 mark of automatic Sizzle Damage to any nearby bug that takes the spotlight.

Pumpkin (Scare 2): Perfect for Halloween! The pumpkin heirloomer can deal Scare Damage to any bug that can see it, and can also deal 6 Bash Damage once per scene by slamming its grinning face into a target (though this rather spoils the carving, and leaves the pilot exposed).

Mandrake (Slash 1 / Yap 3): The existence of the mandrake was mere speculation before the Mysteriocalypse, but here's a proof to set even the most diehard cryptobotanist salivating. These heirloomers can whip roots out to deal Slash Damage to multiple nearby bugs at once, or scream at a single target for Yap Damage. They also jabber constantly as they move, rendering the Think skill unusable in their presence.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Bash**, thanks to toughened plates of vegetable armour.

» **Weak to all moving skills** - these things were built to tackle plants, a foe not known for their turn of speed.

BREAKS

» New leaves unfurl / Load a special seed-bomb / Pause to recalibrate / Spew sticky juices / Burst and split

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Seed Casings, Fruit-Flesh, Pulpy Bits, Strange Organic Mechanism, Young Sprout, Pilot's Shell

HEKATANTONOPEDES

[Titan/Bugly/Boss]

OVERVIEW

Bugs tend to think of themselves as the ones in charge of the post-Mysteriocalypse, if not in terms of physical size then at least where numbers are concerned - there are a hundred, thousand bugly critters for every single beast or bird, after all. The world, at least recently, has been kind to them. Long overdue, if you ask me.

But every now and then, they'll get a reminder that things might not always have been this way. Not merely a glimpse of the pre-Mysteriocalypse, as there are remnants of that just about everywhere, but of something far, FAR older.

Hekatantonopedes are bugs so large they make a cat look tiny, so heavy that their scuttling limbs start earthquakes, so tough that one could chip away at one's shell for a full year without making a dent. They're rare, they're unexplainable, and they're so old and slow that it takes them several minutes to finish a single sentence.

They're pretty impressive, if we hadn't made that clear.

Titans follow special rules when it comes to damage, and besting one is an almost impossible challenge for most bands of bugs without planning and forethought.

SIGNS

» Rocks jostling for a new position as the ground begins to tremble.

» A sudden exodus of any creature that can move, all in one direction - away.

» Trees with huge, mandibular gouges across their lower trunks. Entire bushes stripped of leaves.

BEHAVIOUR

» Consume any and all vegetation they can.

» Reminisce about how everything was better in the old days, when gas was a penny a gallon and there was much more oxygen to go around.

TITAN DEFENCES

» **Immune to all except gigadamage and weaknesses stated below** - should you really be doing this?

» **Weak to Slink**. Hekatantonopedes find it difficult to focus on small details and going unseen around them is easier than it would be for most titans.

» **Weak to Chart** - was it over there, or over there? I swear they move trees around these days just to confuse us old folks...

» **Immune to Scare**. By the time the beast realizes it should be frightened, the moment has almost definitely passed.

BREAKS

» Chew noisily upon tree bark, sending splinters everywhere / Tell a long, rambling story about the old days / Blunder through a wall or fence, apologizing all the way / Swallow a nearby annoyance as punishment for continued rudeness / Get a little twisted up, exposing a soft, tempting underbelly for longer than usual

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Soggy Splinters, Ancient Shell-Shard, Compressed Dirt, Fruity Drool, Story of Forgotten Lands

TACKLING A HEKATANTONOPEDE

Squaring up to a titan head-on is a fool's errand, doubly so without a plan. Bugs might approach this encounter by...

- Setting traps and snares to immobilize the beast, which might stop the constant earthquakes.
- Providing it with directions, or a guide, to a large enough source of delicious greenery that it overeats.
- Finding a way to get it to chase its own tail, creating a rumbling ouroboros far from bugly civilization.

PARTS & MOVES

Scuttle-Flick (Bash 5): A single twitch of a hekatantonopede's leg is enough to send a bug flying, even with a glancing blow. Rolling a conflict or disaster while defending against this move pushes the target into a nearby POI (which may deal an additional instance of damage, depending on the POI in question).

Chow Down (Bite 6): Though they prefer sweet, juicy plants, a titan of this size won't think twice about swallowing any tiny annoyance that gets too close to its face-hole. Bugs swallowed by a hekatantonopede suffer 2 automatic marks of Sizzle Damage each time they take the spotlight. *Climbing back out of the monster's gullet is possible, but actions to do so suffer both a Tough Cut of 1 and a Complex Cut of 1.*

Ever-Quake (Dig 2): Even the smallest movement of so many legs sets the ground shuddering. Bugs in contact with the ground suffer 2 marks of automatic Dig Damage whenever the hekatantonopede takes the spotlight for a movement-related action.

Not Exactly In A Hurry (-): Performing an action using a friending skill that targets the hekatantonopede requires a bug to burn a box on one of their aspects as an additional cost, representing the frustration of having to slow their speech and gestures down to a pace the creature can interpret.

Prehistoric Carapace (-): Attacks targeting the hekatantonopede's exterior take an Armour Cut of 3, unless specifically aimed at a weak point like the mouth or underbelly (rarely in view for long).

True Titan (-): As a titan, the hekatantonopede has truly impressive defences: Actions with giga impact, or that hit one of its weaknesses, mark one heart. All other actions may still have an effect, narratively, but they won't mark the titan's track. Any heart on the titan's track being marked is also considered a break.

"Franz, Castigo, you take the legs! Swift and I will take the... Uh... The other legs, I guess. Wait, how many legs does this thing have?"

Pushkini Curvehorn, Rhinoceros Beetle Wrangler

HEX-CABLE HYDRAS

[Huge/Clanky/Elite]

OVERVIEW

What is electricity, if not a form of ancient magic? It requires a knowledge of complex diagrams and arcane sigils to fully understand, it leaps and crackles one moment and lies dangerously dormant the next, and it seeps out into the world when you'd least expect it. Magic, 100%.

Perhaps that's what makes the hex-cable hydra such a terrifying foe, its ability to wield a power beyond all but the most battery-brained bugs. Then again, it might be all the snapping mouths and writhing cords, or the ability to burst from an ancient wall and fry a scuttling sort to cinders at a moment's notice.

... Yeah, it's probably that second bit.

SIGNS

- An ominous hum, like a hundred bottled bees.
- A bulge behind crumbling plaster.
- A yawning wall socket adorned with chitinous shells.

BEHAVIOUR

- Writhe, sway, and strike!

DEFENCES

- **Resistant to Bite** due to durable sheathing.
- **Immune to Sizzle**. Some even say that Sizzle Damage *heals* the thing, though such rumours are unconfirmed.
- **Weak to Rummage and Make**: Let's get tinkering!

BREAKS

- Sprout a new plug / Short-circuit / Smoke and glow

STUFF TO GRAB

- **Bobs**: Plastic Cable, Copper Filament, Spent Fuse

PARTS & MOVES

Surge and Falter (Various): The hex-cable hydra is as unpredictable as the electricity it carries. Whenever you use this move, roll 6d6 and then use each result as shown on the table below.

- **1 (Zap Snap)**: Deal 2 automatic Sizzle Damage to a nearby bug.
- **2 (Arcing Sparks)**: Deal 1 automatic Sizzle Damage to a distant bug. If this damage hits an aspect's track break, burn all boxes on the track before that break.
- **3 (Metal-Toothed Chomp)**: Deal 3 Bite Damage to a nearby bug, and grab that same target.
- **4 (Shocking Discharge)**: Stun a nearby bug.
- **5 (Charge Up)**: Clear one mark on the hydra Heart Track. If that clears a heart to the left of one of the hydra's breaks, it spawns a new 'head'.
- **6 (Electrokinetic Savagery)**: Deal 3 Sizzle and 3 Bite Damage to a single nearby bug (each instance of damage can be absorbed by a different aspect track).

Reduce the 6d6 roll by 1d6 every time one of the hex-cable hydra's breaks are reached, representing the hazard growing weaker as it loses more 'heads'.

The Curse of Sparks (Sizzle 2/4): A pulsating wave of electrical energy, affecting all nearby bugs that aren't protected with some sort of insulation. The Curse of Sparks deals 2 Sizzle Damage to bugs in contact with the ground (or that have some sort of rubber protection), and 4 Sizzle Damage to bugs in the air.

Powerful Jaw (Bite 2): The hydra doubles any Bite Damage it would deal when attacking a bug that it has grabbed. *Sizzle Damage is unaffected.*

Water Hazard (-): The hydra isn't technically *weak* to Swim Damage, but it *really* doesn't like water. Any action or attack using Swim, or a liquid, to affect the hydra's Heart Track marks one more box than usual.

YOWCH! (-): Any bug that attacks the hex-cable hydra with a metal weapon pulls their mood to negative after receiving a sharp (but ultimately harmless) shock.

IMMORELS

[Small/Shroomy/Swarm]

♥♥•♥♥•♥♥

OVERVIEW

What do you get when a band of immorels descend on a settlement? The pettiest of dangers, that's what. These mushrooms are masters of knocking over food stalls and throwing harsh words at bearded elders, leather jackets flapping in the breeze as they waddle, cackling, from one act of social disorder to another.

SIGNS

» A general trail of small-time mayhem.

» Pro-myconic graffiti and purposefully spilled drinks.

BEHAVIOUR

» Be as much of a nuisance as possible.

» Insult and evade authority figures.

» Act like they've been falsely accused whenever they're actually caught, shirking responsibility in any way possible.

DEFENCES

» **Weak to Swagger, Scare, and Dash**. Immorels are the natural bullies of the fungal world, and like many bullies are easily overwhelmed when others simply stand up to them.

» **Immune to Care**, but only if they're in a group - a single immorel loses this immunity immediately.

BREAKS

» Create an insulting chant about their opponents / Kick rocks around menacingly / Try to look as intimidating as possible / Make an empty threat

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Moss-Leather Jacket, Immorel Chunk

» **Bobs**: Stolen Keepsake, Tiny Chain, Churning Blob of Congealed Discord

PARTS & MOVES

Low-Level Threats (Scare 1 / Yap 1): The average immorel rarely actually attacks a bug, at least not up close - they prefer to hurl insults over stones. Low-Level Threats also pull a bug's mood to negative in addition to dealing damage.

Shakedown (Rummage 2): When immorels do pluck up the courage to actually attack, it generally takes the form of a lot of shoving and some light pickpocketry. Disasters while defending against a Shakedown result in the target losing a bit or bob in addition to any other usual outcome.

Antisocial Behaviour (-): The presence of an immorel swarm in or around a community puts everyone else on edge. While immorels threaten a bugly settlement, all actions using friending skills treat conflicts as disasters.

PUFFBULLY BOSS

While immorel swarms are more of an annoyance than an existential threat, this all changes if a puffbully comes to town. These much larger mushrooms act as gang leaders, organizing the aimlessly destructive immorels under their command into a band capable of far more heinous acts.

The Wrong Kind of Encouragement (Bash 3): Puffbullies don't mind getting stuck in to a fistfight, though even then they spend most of their time shouldering opponents and grunting obscure threats. The larger danger is their effect on the immorels they lead - in the presence of a puffbully, all immorels double the damage they'd usually deal from the Low-Level Threats and Shakedown moves.

Dark Days (-): Things just aren't getting better. Any bug within a settlement currently under the effects of a puffbully loses the ability to pull their mood to anything more positive than neutral, and the entire settlement is also counted as being in darkness at all times, no matter the actual light level.

LACTOGEISTS

[Huge/Ghostly/Shroomy/Elite]

OVERVIEW

Nothing is crueler than curdled milk - the unexpected glop where there should be a splash haunts the dreams of even the most deific felines. Perhaps it's from these dark thoughts that the lactogeist emerged - an avatar of curdling, a liquid spectre emerging from the glass prison of its milk bottle to wreak vaguely cheese-scented havoc across the realms.

SIGNS

- Spoiled milk in ectoplasmic puddles.
- A closed milk bottle with a vaguely greenish hue, just begging to be opened.
- An urge to dry heave.

BEHAVIOUR

- Wait for the glass to break or the cap to be removed, then ooze out into the mundane.
- Splash milky danger around the place.

DEFENCES

- **Resistant to Bash and Slash**, because ghosts are notoriously semi-substantial. That bottle looks awfully smashable, though...
- **Immune to Sizzle** - it can't get much more toxic than it already is.
- **Weak to Care and Swim**, because a sufficiently skilled cook can turn anything into a bugly feast and a strong swimmer can ride the milky tides with ease.

BREAKS

- No more wishes / Ghost-flood / Curdle enthusiasm

STUFF TO GRAB

- **Bits**: Droplet of Spoiled Milk, Dairyplasm
- **Bobs**: Shard of Glass, Silver Foil Lid, Screw-Cap

PARTS & MOVES

Dairy-Based Wishes (Care 3): Due to its shape (a ghostly figure emerging from a bottle), some bugs mistake the lactogeist for a friendly genie of sorts and come barreling in with wishes aplenty. Interestingly enough, the spirit *can* actually grant wishes (as long as they revolve around something dairy-based), and will often present itself as helpful... Until the consequences of the wishes hit, lactose half-lies twisted into milky mistakes and creamy consequences. *The Weaver is encouraged to give 'rewards' that turn into damaging curses before the bugs have established the truly hostile nature of the lactogeist.*

Curdling Flood (Sizzle 2): A more direct assault, an ectoplasmic wave of spoiled milk that can hit multiple nearby bugs at once. The curdling flood *pushes* bugs back in addition to any of its other more situational effects.

Milk Misfortunes (Scare 1): Any bug that rolls a twist while attacking the lactogeist is out of luck - the results of that twist, while still decided by the table, *must be negative*, and the bug takes an automatic mark of Scare Damage in addition to any other results from the roll.

Bottleglass Armour (-): A casket of glass surrounds the hazard's mouldy heart, imposing an Armour Cut of 1 on any attempts to break the bottle from the outside.

Imprisoning (Slash 1): If the lactogeist manages to grab or pull a target, the milk bottle it lives in makes the perfect prison. Bugs that have been swallowed by the lactogeist face a Camo Cut of 2 on all actions, unable to see through the liquid surrounding them. Attempts to free themselves deal an automatic mark of Slash Damage, whether successful or not.

dandeLION'S MANES

[Huge/Leafy/Elite]

OVERVIEW

There's an old saying about lions, something about taking one by the horns, but nobody can quite remember how it goes. You might think it prudent to ask an actual dandelion about it - after all, who would know better than them? But I'd hold off on that if I were you, especially if you want to keep the same amount of arms and legs you started the conversation with once you manage to drag yourself away.

A dandelion's mane can be identified by three things. First, a body of curling leaves and hardy stems, vaguely feline in posture and completely disconnected from the dirt that plants usually love so much. Second, the mane - a shock of large, distinctively floaty seeds that are guaranteed to bring childish joy to a summer's day. Third, the teeth. And if there's one thing most bugs hate, it's a plant with teeth.

SIGNS

» White-tailed seeds drifting on the breeze.

» A rattling roar, like acorns in a washing machine.

BEHAVIOUR

» Hunt vigorously on windy days, in pairs if possible.

» Leap up high to attack from above.

PARTS & MOVES

Chompy (Bite X): The mane's bite is uncommonly ferocious - roll 2d6, then take the higher result as the damage dealt.

Tracer Seed (Hunt / Sense 1): Mane-seeds are a potent tracking tool, and can be fired from the plant in bursts. The dandelion's mane can mark one of its own hearts to pepper a single target with seeds, forcing that target to treat all triumphs as conflicts on Defence Rolls taken against the mane until the seeds are removed.

Vividarium (Think / Sense 4): When in light, the dandelion's mane can unfurl brightly coloured petals to briefly hypnotize a single target, turning their own mind against them. The target can reduce the damage of this move by 1 through pulling their mood to negative, or by 3 through pulling their mood to the extreme negative.

Drifting Hunter (Dash / Fly / Climb / Dance 2): The plant uses its seeds to keep itself aloft for longer as it moves, making impossible leaps and scaling sheer surfaces with ease as it imposes a Speed Cut of 1 on all incoming attacks. *If the weather turns to a gale, it can leap and drift well enough to essentially fly for short periods of time - increase the damage of all of the dandelion's mane's moves by 2 while it's airborne.*

Single-Minded (-): A mane will ***never*** retreat.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Hunt, Sense, Fly, Dash, and Dance** - nothing moves like a dandelion's mane.

» **Weak to Sizzle and Slash**. They may be swift, mobile, and predatory, but they're still just plants.

BREAKS

» Seed the Area / Let Out a Rattling Roar / Shake Colourful Petals / Gnash at the Air / The Wind's Picking Up...

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Mane-Seed Husks, Burdock Incisor, Medicinal Sap, Drift-Fluff

» **Bobs**: Half-Digested Keepsake, Corroded Needle

MINIATURE MERCS

[Small/Bugly/Elite]

♥♥•♥♥

OVERVIEW

At some point in a bug's journey, they inevitably ask themselves what, for them, is best in life. A fleet horse? A falcon at the wrist? Not likely, given that one of those things is impossibly massive and the other would eat you as soon as look at you. No, for some bugs the answer is worryingly simple - to do a bit of good old-fashioned crushing. Preferably for pay.

Miniature mercs are bugs who take fighting seriously, organising themselves into small groups offering a particular service (tiny violence) for the discerning customer (anyone that can afford them).

SIGNS

» A suspicious air of competence, rare in the bugly world.

» A band of bugs rather too laden down with weapons.

» The sight of a valuable resource changing hands, before many sets of eyes swivel in your direction.

BEHAVIOUR

» Fight for money. Why bother dressing it up?

» Carry out tasks with maximum effectiveness.

» Carouse and boast in between jobs.

PARTS & MOVES

Dervish Attack (Bash/Slash/Bite 2): So many tiny weapons! Whenever a bug targeted by the Dervish Attack move rolls a disaster as part of their reaction, the merc making the move heals a single heart.

Taunt (Swagger 1): Mercs have almost as much training in taunting as they do fighting. In addition to the damage dealt by a successful taunt move, the targeted bug also has their mood pulled to the negative.

The Special Move (Bash/Slash/Bite 4): Once per scene, a single miniature merc can pull off 'The Special Move', an attack that's been practiced and honed in secret over many, many weeks. The precise nature and appearance of the special move is up to the Weaver, but the hefty damage it deals should be enough for everyone else to stop and stare for at least a moment.

Tactical Redeployment (-): As one merc is about to be hit with an attack, another merc can leap in to take its place by marking one of its own hearts. This allows the second merc to take the incoming damage instead. *Don't do this too much - it'll likely get annoying for the players if it happens more than a couple of times.*

Piecemeal Armour (-): The odds and ends collected and worn by miniature mercs give them an Armour Cut of 1 against all Bash, Slash, Bite, and Sizzle attacks.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Scare and Slash**, as armour helps out, and payment tends to weigh heavier than fear.

» **Weak to Swagger**, because respect is earned, but mercs *love* a good show.

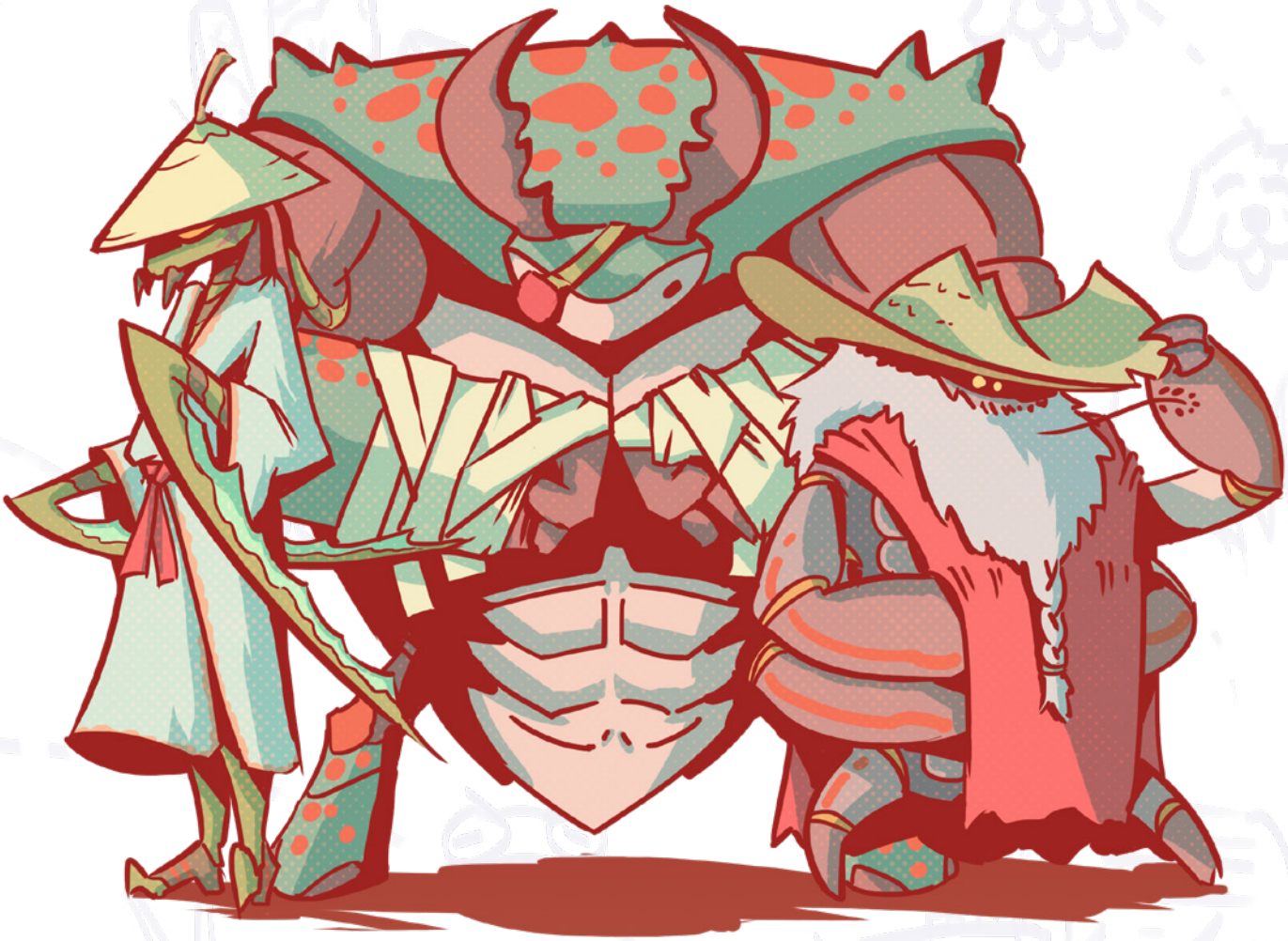
BREAKS

» Hurl some insults / Lose a tiny weapon / Let's come to a new arrangement here / More trouble than it's worth

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Scarred Carapace, Mercenary's Honour

» **Bobs**: Pay From An Old Job, Tiny Axe, Tiny Blade, Tiny Slingshot, Armour Plate, Sketch of a Distant Sweetheart, Battered Flute, Whittled Figurine



SPECIALIST QUIRKS

If you'd like to add a bit of spice to your miniature merc encounter, you can give each mercenary an extra ability from the list below, each one representing a different type of sellsword bug. For even more variety, add a heart or two (or even an additional break) to the tracks of mercenaries you want to pose a more significant threat.

Mantid Blademaster (Slash 3): When making a Mantid Blademaster move, target two bugs at a time and let each make a Reaction Roll. Take the worst roll result of the two and use that to apply damage and effects to both!

Pillbug Cowboy (Bash 2): When making a Pillbug Cowboy move, target a bug at any distance that the cowboy can see, and impose a Speed Cut of 2 on the Reaction Roll.

Smoking Snail (Sizzle 3 / Swagger 1): When making a Smoking Snail move, either target a single bug with a hit dealing Sizzle 3, or deal 1 automatic Swagger Damage to all nearby bugs that can breathe (and that aren't holding their breath). *A merc with the Smoking Snail quirk would be a great choice for extra hearts and track breaks.*

Centipugilist (-): What's worse than one big punch? A hundred tiny punches, probably. Any attacks that target a Centipugilist, or another miniature merc that's near to a Centipugilist, treat triumphs as conflicts (as it catches and deflects all manner of incoming blows).

Hercules Hero (-): Some bugs are too proud to quit, others just too bone-headed. This beetle-themed hero imposes a Tough Cut of 2 on all incoming friending actions, not through mental fortitude but rather a complete lack of understanding (they're the 'orange cats' of the bugly world).

MUNCHMELEONS

[Huge/Scaly/Elite]

OVERVIEW

It would be tempting to say that munchmeleons are often found on low-hanging branches, but the truth is they're actually *found* very rarely - their camouflage is effective enough that a bug can wander inches from them without ever being aware of their error.

And an error it most certainly is...

But not one that's often repeated.

SIGNS

- A feeling of calm that's just a little bit *too* calm, a sense of quiet that somehow *bodes*.
- A sticky patch where a bug once stood.
- A swivelling eye zeroing in on you.
- A blur of colour and movement.

BEHAVIOUR

- Lie in wait for delicious bugs, then grab and yank them with a sticky tongue.
- Munch on softer bugs first, and break harder-shelled bugs with tail and horns.
- Shift colour at a moment's notice, and climb something tall to escape if things go bad.
- Strike fear into the hearts of food.

PARTS & MOVES

Sticky Tongue (Bash 2): Normally curled up within the munchmeleon's maw, this gloopy danger can shoot out with incredible accuracy. Reactions take a Speed Cut of 1, and the tongue can *push* or *grab* a bug as well as dealing damage.

Horns and Teeth (Slash 2 / Scare 2): Pointy and spiky in equal measure. When a bug is grabbed, double the damage and pull mood to the negative.

Grippers (Climb 1): Though they end with little claws, they're not often used to attack - these are climbin' limbs! Used to manoeuvre on branches or walls in a scuffle, and to escape when things look bad. Can carry *grabbed* bugs while climbing, and can move and fight just as easily while climbing as on the ground.

Shifty Skin (-): Munchmeleons can blend in with their surroundings almost perfectly while still, and even while moving they're tough to pin down. All rumbling and finding skills used against a munchmeleon take a Camo Cut of 1, which increases to 2 when it's *trying* to hide.

Rolling Side-Eye (Hunt 2): They see ALL. The munchmeleon is a beast of stealth and camouflage, and imposes a Tough Cut of 2 on bugs that try to use such actions against it. The audacity!

Hyperalert (-): You cannot surprise a munchmeleon, unless it's literally asleep.

DEFENCES

- **Resistant to Bash, Scare, and Tame** - this guy isn't just tough, he's fiercely independent!
- **Weak to Yap**, because nobody wants to chat when dinner is sitting *right there*.

BREAKS

- Focus on a new target / Grab a meal and get to the high ground / A scattering of scales / Tongue-tied

STUFF TO GRAB

- **Bits**: Munchmeleon Horns, Rainbow Scales, Sticky Tongue, Flexing Gripper, Swivelling Eye

PREDATORY PLANTS

[Various Sizes/Leafy/Elite]

♥♥♥♥•♥♥♥

OVERVIEW

What's that rustling over there? Could it perhaps be an *obscenely* toothy plant, all digestive juices and vegetative rage, come to hunt like a beast in the vibrant confines of the post-Mysteriocalypse?

Good guess! That's exactly what it is.

Predatory plants come in a variety of shapes and sizes, but this page represents the most plentiful variant - a crawling snapper, moving round forests and lawns on leglike roots in search of scuttling prey. The teeth are what draws the attention, but they're not what a bug should be the most scared of - no, that's the slopping liquids inside, a cocktail specifically created to maze a bug's senses and draw them, slowly and inexorably, closer to those fibrous jaws. Not the nicest of creations, but hey - that's the food chain for you.

SIGNS

» The alluring scent of sweet acid.

» Little empty shells scattered around the place, some of them with identifiable crunch-marks.

» Creeping roots, moving leaves, and beautiful flowers that seem to sway at odds with the wind.

» A sudden quiet, as if the forest holds its breath.

BEHAVIOUR

» Hunt delicious bugly morsels, using other, less hungry plants as cover and camouflage to do so.

» Bite wildly, splash acid around, and generally make a ruckus - these plants are messy eaters at the best of times.

DEFENCES

» **Immune to Tame and Yap**. Predatory plants don't really understand the language of bugs, and even if they did, they wouldn't much care about what was being said.

» **Resistant to Bite**. Have you seen the size of those teeth? Even the hardest bite a bug manages isn't going to outclass what these plants have going on!

» **Weak to Sizzle**, because leaves and fire don't mix. Or rather they *do* mix, just a little bit too well.

» **Weak to Climb**, especially if you get in under the jaws and hang on for dear life.

BREAKS

» Lose a few teeth / Get leaves caught on something / Slippery surfaces incoming / Grab and swallow something bug-sized / Spray acid everywhere

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Spiny Plant-Tooth, Moving Root, Acid-Brew, Stamen Tongue, Camouflage Leaf

PARTS & MOVES

Snappish Maw (Bite 4): When all you've got is a mouth, everything begins to look chewable. Predatory plants deal an absurd amount of damage if they get a bite in, but they're not built for protracted encounters - every bite move they make, whether successfully avoided or not, marks one of their own hearts.

Hithering Acid (Sizzle 2/Tame 1): A reservoir of digestive slop within the plant's belly, which (rather cruelly) smells delightful. When the predatory plant makes a move with Sizzle, it regains one heart. When it makes a move with Tame, the affected bug pulls their mood to the positive and takes a Tough Cut of 1 against the plant's other moves for the rest of the scene.

Rooted Crawler (Dig 1): The plants may be ambulatory, but that doesn't mean they're very good at it. Predatory plants can't move over stones or metal, but they can cross soil, wood, and other plants just fine. They swim better than you might expect, too.

Enervated (-): Storms bring out the best in some hunters. When the weather is stormy, predatory plants gain a Speed Cut of 1 against all moving skills.

Am-Bush (-): When a predatory plant attacks before being seen (usually from within an area of other, less hungry foliage), it gains a +2 bonus on the damage it deals with any move.

QUETZALCROAKL

[Large or Huge/Feathery/Slimy/Elite]

♥♥•♥♥♥♥♥♥•♥♥

OVERVIEW

Thought to be a product of the strange energies behind the Mysteriocalypse, the quetzalcroakl perches awkwardly on the line between bird and frog; a mass of dripping feathers, rolling eyes, and a sticky, lashing tongue. Though they don't seem capable of spoken language, all who meet them agree that they can radiate scorn like no other.

The average quetzalcroakl avoids a fair fight whenever possible, preferring to swoop down into foes from on high and carry their targets off to distant nests for later consumption. Some even hunt beneath the surface of pools, using their tongues like periscopes to sense approaching bugs.

SIGNS

» Talon-scored footprints with widely spread toes.

» A scattering of slimy feathers.

BEHAVIOUR

» Ambush bugs from high or low, using tree branches and murky pond water to great effect.

» Use hit-and-run tactics, along with their grasping tongue, to split up their prey and prevent teamwork.

PARTS & MOVES

Ambush Strike (Slash / Fly / Swim 3-5): A leap that can hit multiple nearby targets at once while allowing the quetzalcroakl to reposition. If the quetzalcroakl catches a surprised target with this move, the damage it deals ignores track breaks when assigned.

Whiplash Gaze (Scare 2): Any time a bug deals enough damage to hit one of the quetzalcroakl's track breaks, it hits them with an unavoidable Whiplash Gaze for free after it has been kicked up or down a notch by the Weaver (in addition to any other move it might use).

Tonguecuff (Rummage 3): An ensnaring lick! Any bug that rolls a disaster in response to the Tonguecuff is immediately grabbed. Even after being freed, lingering sticky juices impose a Speed Cut of 1 on all movement-based actions that bug takes until the end of the scene. *Only one bug can be grabbed at a time.*

Feather Shield (-): A ruffling of wet feathers creates a near impenetrable shield for a short time - until the quetzalcroakl next takes the spotlight, bugs suffer an Armour Cut of 2 when attacking it physically.

Periscope Tongue (-): The quetzalcroakl can see perfectly even when completely hidden or submerged, and cannot be ambushed or surprised unless asleep.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Swim, Scare, Swagger, Rummage, and Yap**.

» **Weak to Dance**, as the additional movement makes its already rolling eyes go haywire trying to keep up.

BREAKS

» Take to the air / Shake to make feathery puddles / Sudden pinpoint stare / Retreat to nest with prey

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Sodden Feather, Carousel Eye, Sensory Tongue, Quetza Talon

» **Bobs**: Gold Coin Necklace, Tattered Saddle

RESINAUTS

[Small/Bugly/Swarm]

OVERVIEW

The best defence may well be a good offence, but the most impressive defence is just a *really solid defence*. Resinauts have taken this advice to their bugly hearts, encasing themselves in spherical amber and rolling around the place like insectile marbles. Why do this, rather than just stay home? Because the drive to explore is a strong one, and this way lets them see the world of the post-Mysteriocalypse without ever having to actually *touch* any of that messy nature that spins by their windows.

SIGNS

» A sound like a bowl of marbles falling down the stairs.

» Furrows in soft ground, criss-crossing each other.

BEHAVIOUR

» Shout muffled apologies with every impact.

» Stick together, and never stop rolling.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Slash and Sizzle**. Amber may be breakable, but that'll take some effort.

» **Weak to Dance**, as an understanding of rhthym and timing allows one to treat the colliding spheres like unruly dance-partners in a fossilized waltz.

BREAKS

» Not that way! / Cracks in the sphere / An almighty collision / Who put that hill there?

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bobs**: Shard of Amber, Resinaut Capsule-Piece

PARTS & MOVES

Marble Madness (Shield 1d6): When we say a resinaut swarm sticks together, we're close to meaning it literally. Even if they have no malicious intent, their limited ability to steer coupled with their large numbers ensures an encounter with one is confusion of collisions. The swarm counts as a moving point of interest, and any bug that takes the spotlight to begin their action inside it takes automatic Shield Damage equal to the result of a d6 roll by the Weaver. *This damage can't normally be avoided, but...*

Going With the Flow (-): Any bug that grabs the resinaut swarm ends up bouncing around atop the flow of rolling amber until they choose to break their grab (or until they're thrown off by the movement of the pack). While atop the flow, bugs halve the damage taken from the Marble Madness move above, but also take a Complex Cut of 1 on all actions taken to move.

Let's Slow This Down (-): Any bug that takes an action using a bit or bob that's Sticky or Sludgy (or that might otherwise work to slow the constant roll of a resinaut swarm) gains 2d6 from it as an advantage, rather than the usual 1d6.

WHAT WAS THAT??? (-): Any sound-based actions a bug takes (such as those using Yap) face an Armour Cut of 1 due to the thick amber of the resinaut spheres and the constant, marble-like clacking of their impacts. A bug can ignore this cut by attempting to be as loud as possible, but the effort of making yourself heard over the din pulls your mood to negative.

SCAVENJARS

[Large or Huge/Clanky/Ghostly/Elite]

♥♥♥♥•♥

OVERVIEW

Stalking slowly out from the mists, a tall, squidlike shape with a bulbous jar for a head; scavenjars are bug-hunters through and through, but not for any reason as understandable as hunger.

A scavenjar uses tentacles of scrap and wire to snatch up bugly sorts, depositing them inside its glass prison before screwing the lid back on tight. The jars are sometimes empty, but more often filled with exoskeletal husks - unfortunate quarries that couldn't escape in time, their scuttling souls still sadly lingering.

SIGNS

» A mournful call, like clinking glass.

» Ghostly whispers from inside the jars.

BEHAVIOUR

» Scavenjars may not be too stable, but they rarely hunt alone - groups of three or four moving in eerie unison are more common.

» Ensnare and abduct wandering bugs, transporting them to who-knows-where.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Swim and Sizzle**, barely registering any assault by liquids or flames.

» ***Mostly* Immune to friending skills**. If the scavenjars had heartstrings to pluck, you'd be able to see them.

» **Weak to Bash**. I mean, what did you expect?

BREAKS

» Topple, slowly / Lose a lid / Break wide open

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Exoskeletal Fragment, Piece of Bug-Husk

» **Bobs**: Broken Glass, Wiry Tentacle

PARTS & MOVES

Sinuous Tentacle (Rummage / Slash 2): Bugs suffer a Complex Cut of 1 when trying to defend against the Sinuous Tentacle. Additionally, if the damage it deals hits an aspect track's break (or the end of the track), the bug being targeted is instantly whisked up and swallowed, deposited into the great glass prison that makes up a scavenjar's head.

Whispering Grave (Scare 3): A move that can only be used against a swallowed bug, where the scavenjar shakes itself up to rouse the slumbering spirits of previous occupants. *This is the only portion of the scavenjar that has no immunity to friending skills - the spirits inside may seem scary at first, but they're likely just lost little bug-souls looking for a way out.*

Ill-Advised Smash (Bash 5): Rarely used, this allows a scavenjar to mark one of its own hearts to slam its jar down against a single bug to deal Bash Damage. If this marked heart hits the hazard's track break, its jar cracks open immediately.

Midnight Ambience (-): The area around a scavenjar is treated as in darkness, no matter the level of light, and often seems to fill with cold, cloying mist.

Jar of Sorrows (-): The scavenjar can temporarily remove its lid, letting unpleasant echoes escape. Doing so pulls the mood of every bug close enough to hear them to negative. If a bug's mood is *already* at the extreme negative, that bug is stunned instead.

Longlimbs (-): Scavenjars move slowly but surely, and are unhindered by any terrain they can climb over. On the bright side, using Dash to attack or evade a scavenjar allows a bug to treat disasters as conflicts due to their unhurried, ponderous nature.

Knowledge From Beyond (-): If a bug manages to break the jar of a scavenjar, they're momentarily surrounded by thankful insectile spirits. The Weaver should reward them with a free *small discovery*, knowledge gleaned from the whispering of the escaping ghosts.

SCUMDEWS
[Titan/Leafy/Boss]

OVERVIEW

Plants have something of a reputation in the world of PICO, and (despite the fact that some plants *are* a bit bitey around bugs), it's actually a pretty positive one. They produce Nectar, they pump oxygen out into the world, and leaves make great little hats. What could be nicer than a tree's shade on a hot day, or a spritz of scented pollen before an even hotter date?

... And then we come to scumdews.

Think of a nice, plantish thing. Got one? Turn it upside down, make it a negative, and it's probably something a scumdew loves doing.

Titans follow special rules when it comes to damage, and besting one is an almost impossible challenge for most bands of bugs without planning and forethought.

SIGNS

» Pools of bubbling purple sap (that you really shouldn't be touching without some kind of gloves).

» Discoloured air and sickly little bugs. Poor things!

BEHAVIOUR

» Find a place to root, then spew out liquid poison, toxic gases, and general bad vibes.

» Spread thorny vines through every nearby dwelling.

PARTS & MOVES

Vine Whip (Slash 4 / Bash 3): Scumdew vines have a longer range than most assume, stretching and flexing as they snake towards targets. They also inflict a Speed Cut of 1 on any physical attacks aimed at the scumdew.

Poison Factory (Sizzle 3): The scumdew pumps poison out non-stop, filling the air with a sickening miasma that denies any nearby bug benefits that would come from light, darkness, or positive mood. It also creates poisonous POIs, which the scumdew's vines may attempt to push bugs into for additional Sizzle Damage.

Fringed Maw (Rummage 3 + Bite 3): Combining the worst features of venus flytraps, sundews, and pitcher plants. The maw deals both Rummage and Bite Damage, and can swallow a target if they roll a disaster while trying to avoid it. Swallowed targets take 2 Sizzle Damage every time they take the spotlight, but don't suffer the Speed Cut imposed by the plant's vines.

Instinctual (-): The scumdew is completely immune to damage from all friending skills, even with giga impact.

True Titan (-): As a titan, the scumdew has truly impressive defences: actions with giga impact, or that hit one of its weaknesses, mark one heart. All other actions may still have an effect, narratively, but they won't mark the titan's track. Any heart on the titan's track being marked is also considered a break.

TITAN DEFENCES

» **Immune to all except gigadamage and weaknesses stated below** - should you really be doing this?

» **Weak to Sizzle**, but only if it comes in the form of heat, fire, or some sort of defoliant.

BREAKS

» Snare an NPC / Burrow deeper into the ground / Vomit toxins / Uproot and relocate / Release mazing pheromones

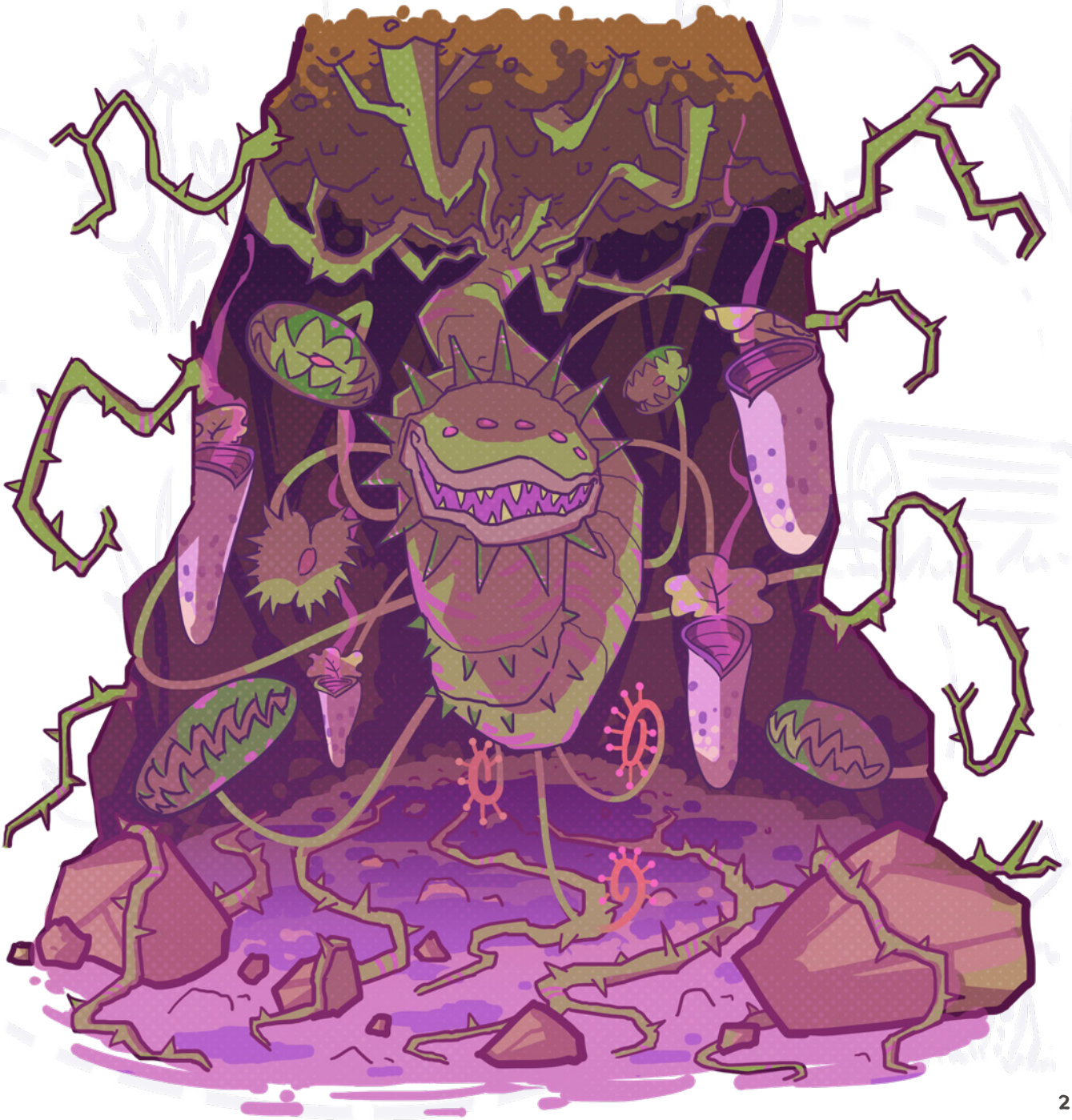
STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Poison Droplet, Scumdew Sludge, Sensitive Frond, Woodish Fang, Root Cutting

SURVIVING A SCUMDEW

Squaring up to a titan head-on is a fool's errand, doubly so without a plan. Bugs might approach this encounter by...

- » Finding a way to neutralize the plant's poison before wading into the danger zone.
- » Attacking the creature from below, dealing with roots and droplets rather than vines and mists.
- » Coming prepared to set the world on fire, taking advantage of the scumdew's only real weakness.



SCUTTLE-HUSKS

[Small/Ghostly/Elite]

OVERVIEW

Skeletons aren't the kind of thing the average bug leaves behind when they head off into the great beyond - a distinct lack of bones, that's probably the problem there. But when all the gooey, squishy bits are gone (we'll leave how that happened up to your imagination), there's usually enough chitinous carapace left for a little bug-shaped monument.

And oh, look who's come to visit!

SIGNS

» A graveyard breeze, ethereal chittering.

» An empty shell staggering drunkenly toward you, grippers outstretched, perhaps lit by the pale blue light of a returned soul...?

BEHAVIOUR

» Wrap up the business they left unfinished in life, or...

» ... make a general ghostly nuisance of themselves.

DEFENCES

» **Immune to *Almost* Everything**. That's right - you can crack some leftover shells, throw some cruel words around, but the spirit of a scuttle-husk will always return until it's been properly sorted. Or...

» **Weak to Sunlight**: tricking a scuttle-husk into a patch of sunlight banishes it for eternity, even if it still has unfinished business remaining.

BREAKS

» Disapparate with a ghostly keening / Collapse into an empty shell / Dissolve for good, thankfully

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Insectoplasm, Chitinous Husk Shard

» **Bobs**: Grave-Ribbon

PARTS & MOVES

BOO! (Scare / Bash 1-3): Scuttle-husks rarely approach a band of bugs in a straightforward fashion. They prefer to hide in the shadows, to follow at a distance, and to unsettle or terrify when they get the chance. This might come in the form of a spiritual shock, a ghostly whispering, or (for those that feel a bit more poltergeisty) throwing bits of their own mortal shell.

Scuttle-husks that have problems they want solving still unsettle those they haunt, but rarely on purpose.

Unfinished Business (-): The hardest part of solving a scuttle-husk's unfinished business is often working out what it is, given their inability to actually communicate in anything more than gestures and vague, almost-but-not-quite intelligible whispers.

Naught But a Haunting (-): The chitin husk of the spirit is tangible, but tends to crumble at the slightest touch (reforming later, if the ghost puts enough energy into it). The interior of the husk, the spirit's true form, can pass through solid matter with ease.

"Wooooooooooooo!!!"

Runthorpe Kleine the Third, Distinguished Scuttle-husk Poet

SHROOMINKS

[Large/Shroomy/Slimy/Elite]

OVERVIEW

What is art? That's the kind of question that has puzzled introspective types since the dawn of recorded time, which, if the most experienced of insectile scholars are to be believed, was at least several weeks ago.

But these ambulatory ink-caps are pretty sure they've come up with an answer to that particular philosophical question, and that answer is 'whatever we douse with colour'. These are the myconic menaces of the guerilla art scene, stealthy and creative, fascinating and deadly.

SIGNS

» Glowing graffiti that hurts the eye to focus on.

» Pools of oil-like ink with a scent of sweet rot.

BEHAVIOUR

» Make the world a more vibrant, colourful place.

» Sneak into places they're not supposed to be.

» Sign their works with a bold stroke, eschewing anonymity and painting with pride.

PARTS & MOVES

Free Expression (Make D6): Shroominks are driven by the singular desire to make the world a more colourful place. At the start of an encounter, the Weaver should roll a d6 - the result is the amount of Make Damage a bug takes if it damages part of the artwork, either accidentally or on purpose.

Spatter (Sizzle 2): The organic ink these fine fungal artists produce can double up as a weapon if they're cornered. Bugs hit with a spatter of shroom-ink treat disasters as triumphs, triumphs as conflicts, and conflicts as disasters for the rest of the scene.

Bioluminescence (Dazzle 1): At night (or in dark areas), a shroomink's art glows brightly enough to allow bugs to treat themselves as 'in light' for their next action by taking a mark of Dazzle Damage.

The Soft Beauty of Ephemeral Joy (-): Shroomink artworks are liable to deal large amounts of damage to bugs trying to destroy them, but there is a way around this - using juices, dyes, and pigments to *paint over* the art blocks the damage from Free Expression.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Sense and Hunt**. The deeper meanings behind their artworks are for them to know, and for others to speculate on endlessly. *Plus, they're kinda sneaky.*

» **Immune to Yap**, because who ever improved by listening to critics?

» **Weak to Chart and Think**. Was that brushstroke really meant to flick there? Isn't that shape a little derivative?

BREAKS

» Squirt technicolour ink / Pull their cap down to hide their intentions / Add a flourish to an existing work / Recreate a nearby bug in caricature / Sigh wearily when their work is misinterpreted

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Lurid Glob of Ink, Fungal Brush-Frond, Crystallized Colour

SNYDRA

[Huge/Scaly/Elite]

♥♥♥♥•♥♥•♥♥

OVERVIEW

Oh, the myths and legends of the snydra! A thousand heads, all hissing in unison; breath of green flame, powerful enough to melt stone; scales like diamonds, impossible to pierce!

Luckily for adventuring bugs, the stories of the snydra are... Well, let's just say they're a *little* embellished. Possibly to the point that your average snydra, while still a fearsome foe if riled, is actually just three quite annoyed snakes that have gotten tangled up and can't seem to un-knot themselves.

SIGNS

» Confusing, S-shaped trails through dirt and sand.

» Sibilant complaints over who gets to be the one choosing the direction they all slither.

» Grizzled veteran bug-knights, eagerly sharing tales of their narrow escape and almost desperately beseeching others not to go and investigate the truth of their claims.

BEHAVIOUR

» Argue. a lot.

» Argue some more.

» Argue a third time, if you can believe that.

PARTS & MOVES

Triple Bite (Bite 4+3+2): A snydra angry enough to aim all of its heads at a single foe can deal huge damage, though luckily the damage from each head can be assigned to a different Heart Track.

Awkward Advance (Slink 2 / Dig 2 / Dash 3): It may take some negotiation, but when a snydra moves effectively, it's fast as lightning.

Hissstoric Grievances (Yap 1): An encounter with a snydra is as confusing for most bugs as it is for the snakes themselves. The constant patter of back-and-forth argument adds a Complex Cut of 2 on all friending and finding skills used against a snydra, which can be reduced to 1 if the bugs manage to convince it to focus all three heads on a singular task.

THE LEGENDS ARE TRUE!

Baleful Flames (Sizzle 4): A jet of burning poison sprayed from the most fearsome of the snydra's triple-heads, the baleful flames can hit multiple nearby bugs at once. It may also set a POI on fire, at the Weaver's discretion, creating a lasting environmental hazard.

Shining Scales (-): Disaster and conflict results on an Attack Roll can never deal damage to a snydra, only a triumph can mark its Heart Track.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Bash and Slash**. They may not be diamond, but those scales are still tough.

» **Immune to Slink**, as at least one set of eyes is always going to see what's going on.

» **Weak to Think, Chart, and Care**, especially useful if bugs try to help the snydra's component snakes untangle.

BREAKS

» Disagree on who to aim for / Bemoan their situation / Reach a consensus / Hiss in triplicate / Burrow and burst

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Snydra Fang, Discarded Scale, Epic Poem

SQUIRREL FLINGERS

[Large or Huge/Beastly/Elite]

♥•♥♥♥•♥

OVERVIEW

The noble courts of PICO's squirrel denizens are, in a word, impenetrable. Not just in terms of membership, as one needs a particularly fluffy tail to even be considered, but in understanding; every squirrel holds a noble title of their own devising, and even a simple mispronunciation can make you an enemy for life.

This complex courtly aesthetic only partially disguises the basic truth of squirrels, though - at the end of the day, they're raucous little beasts that love chucking stuff at innocent bystanders.

SIGNS

» A scattering of bits and bobs under a tree that looks too good to be true.

» Paw-made pennants hanging from branches.

» The sound of trumpets, part regal announcement, part call to arms.

BEHAVIOUR

» Scamper around above ground level and lord it over anyone that can't climb as high as they can.

» Throw whatever they can lift.

» Target winged types first.

PARTS & MOVES

Look Out Below! (Various 1-3): If it can be thrown, you can bet your bottom dollar that a squirrel has tried to throw it. Squirrel flingers will use just about any bit or bob as ammunition (though they prefer bits, found more naturally up in the trees), and an attack can deal damage of any type the Weaver chooses that feels appropriate to the object being thrown. *Rolling a triumph while defending against a flinger's thrown object allows the bug to catch the bit or bob, adding it to one of their carry slots if they wish.*

Tail Shield (Bash 2): A squirrel's tail isn't only a good defence against objects that might be thrown back at it, it's a potent weapon. Ranged attacks made against a squirrel treat conflicts as disasters, and a squirrel's tail can hit multiple nearby bugs at once.

Arboreal Defence (-): When on their home turf, among the branches of a tree, squirrels impose a Speed Cut of 1 against all incoming attacks.

Impropriety (-): Squirrels try particularly hard when targeting bugs that have wings, seeing it as an insult to their climbing skills. Attacks made by a squirrel flinger against bugs with ranks in the Fly skill impose a Tough Cut of 1 on rolls made to defend and, if that bug is actively airborne, add an additional Speed Cut of 2.

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Dash and Climb**, because it doesn't matter how good you are at either, you're not going to match even the laziest of squirrels.

» **Immune to Swagger**. Perhaps no beast outside of a cat is as self-assured as a squirrel.

BREAKS

» Come down to ground level / Scamper up a trunk / Find a bigger thing to throw / Fumble a landing / Leap and grab a flying bug / Call for royal backup

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Ripe Nut, Twig Javelin, Bark Grenade, Captured Raindrop, Tail-Bristles, Secret Name

STRIDING SPIKERS

[Various Sizes/Leafy/Elite]

OVERVIEW

What's tall, ponderous, and difficult to hug? While it might sound like the set-up to a Christmas cracker joke, the answer is anything but amusing - striding spikers, the ambulatory cactoid powerhouses of the Mysteriocalypse's most sun-drenched regions.

SIGNS

» Scratches and gouges on softer material.

» Watery footprints far too large to belong to a bug.

» Cookfires wreathed in deliciously scented smoke.

BEHAVIOUR

» Wander in the heat of the sun, seeing as much of the world as they can.

» Spikers aren't averse to conflict, but they don't go seeking it out either. They are, however, sensitive to rude requests involving their height and the amount of water they're currently carrying.

» Most striding spikers are self-sufficient, and see a hearty meal as one of the finest comforts a traveller can ask for or offer.

PARTS & MOVES

Incidental Spikings (Slash 1-2): Even the most peaceful spiker has to watch their step - they are naturally covered with bug-poking weapons, after all. When a bug near to a striding spiker rolls a 1 as part of any action or Luck Roll, whether the spiker is hostile or not, they take one or two marks of Slash Damage in addition to any of the other effects of the roll.

Fibrous Muscle (Bash 4): When a cactus wants to smash something, that thing tends to get *really* smashed.

One for the Road (Care 2): If a striding spiker takes a particular liking to someone it meets on its travels, it may choose to share some of its sweet cactus water with them - a powerful and immediate curative. *Note that **asking** for cactus water is one of the rudest possible things a bug can do, and will almost always lead to a scuffle at least, and a lifelong enemy at most.*

Natural Elixir (-): Being full to the brim with potent medicinal liquids, a striding spiker clears one mark every time it gets the spotlight during a scene. *Any hearts the spiker has burned cannot be cleared, only marks are automatically healed in this way.*

DEFENCES

» **Resistant to Sizzle and Care**, though sometimes they wish they weren't.

» **Weak to Slink and Yap**, because the naturally sedate pace at which a strider lives their life is shattered by quick-talking, sneaky little bugs.

BREAKS

» Stumble while striding / Drop a treasured ingredient / Shockwave stamp / New spines burst forth! / Spring a leak

STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Bead of Sweet Water, Cactus Spine, Strider's Promise, Scented Meats of Mystery, Cactus Flower Petal

» **Bobs**: Iron Cookpot, Sand Pouch

VARIANT QUIRKS

Why limit yourself to *striding* spikers? If you have an encounter with multiple cactoids, maybe add a few of the variant quirks below...

Overthorned (Slash 4): What else would expect from something with the word 'spiker' in its name? Overthorned striders can swing their limbs wildly, dealing Slash Damage to multiple nearby bugs at once, and also automatically deal that damage against any bug that tries to Bite them.

Blossoming (-): Soft-edged doesn't necessarily mean warm-hearted. Blossoming striders impose a Camo Cut of 1 on any trying to attack them physically, and are immune to Dazzle (but weak to Swagger).

Leaking (-): A crack in the strider's fibrous form allows sweet water to slosh out from time to time. Any bug that rolls a triumph in their presence can downgrade it to a conflict in order to obtain a bit, Bead of Sweet Water (though if the cactus catches them doing it, they may not be impressed).

Cactamari (Slash 3): This cactus's spines are longer than usual, and furred with detritus picked up during their travels (most of it accidental). Grabbing or breaking free from a Cactamari's grab always deals 3 marks of Slash Damage to a bug, and their squatter frames and faster ways of living gives them a Speed Cut of 1 on attempts to catch them.

ZYGAR, THE ALL-CONSUMING

[Titan/Beastly/Boss]

OVERVIEW

Squirrels claim their own titles, and countless bugs consider themselves emperor of their tiny domains, but titans rarely acknowledge any kind of hierarchy outside of 'us big, you small'.

... Except when the ground shakes, the skies darken, and Zygar comes lolloping over the horizon.

Zygar, the All-Consuming. Zygar, the End of Days. Zygar, a singular ant-eater titan of prodigious size and unmeasurable power.

Zygar, the king of beasts.

The All-Consuming is a king among titans - do not tackle this beast without a solid plan, a lot of practice, and some good NPC back-up. The Weaver may also consider setting two Combo Tracks at once to give bugs more of a fighting chance, especially if multiple NPCs aid in the encounter.

SIGNS

» All creatures, even other titans, running and hiding.

» An earthquake, growing stronger with each step.

BEHAVIOUR

» Zygar has few desires other than to eat, walk, and sleep. He cares nothing for titles, trinkets, or respect. Still, legends assure that he can be bargained with.

PARTS & MOVES

The Stickiest Tongue (Rummage 3 / Sizzle 1): Any bug that rolls a conflict or disaster when defending themselves against this move is automatically grabbed. This grab **cannot be escaped by normal means**. Instead, when one of Zygar's titan hearts is marked, a single grabbed bug (chosen by the Weaver) can wriggle free. *Any bug that takes the spotlight while grabbed takes 1 mark of automatic Sizzle Damage - juicy!*

Crushing Blow (Bash 4 + Slash 2): A downward swipe with Zygar's massive, wire-wound paws. In addition to any damage dealt, a bug hit by the Crushing Blow adds a negative tag to one of their bits or bobs.

Picky Eater (Swim 2): When a bug ends its time in the spotlight while grabbed by Zygar, they roll a d6. On a 1, they are swallowed. Swallowed targets take 2 Swim Damage every time they take the spotlight, but don't suffer the usual Cut imposed by Zygar's Shaggy Hide.

Shaggy Hide (-): All physical attacks made against Zygar's outer body (excluding those made against the face or tongue) take a Tough Cut of 1 and an Armour Cut of 1. *A frontal assault is essentially doomed.*

True Titan (-): As a titan, Zygar has truly impressive defences: actions with giga impact mark one heart. All other actions may still have an effect, narratively, but they won't mark the titan's track. Any heart on the titan's track being marked is also considered a break.

TITAN DEFENCES

» **Immune to all except gigadamage** - the All-Consuming has no inherent weaknesses.

BREAKS

» Stomp the ground / Vacuum inhalation / Spit out a bug / Trumpet, far too loudly / Acknowledge skill or bravery

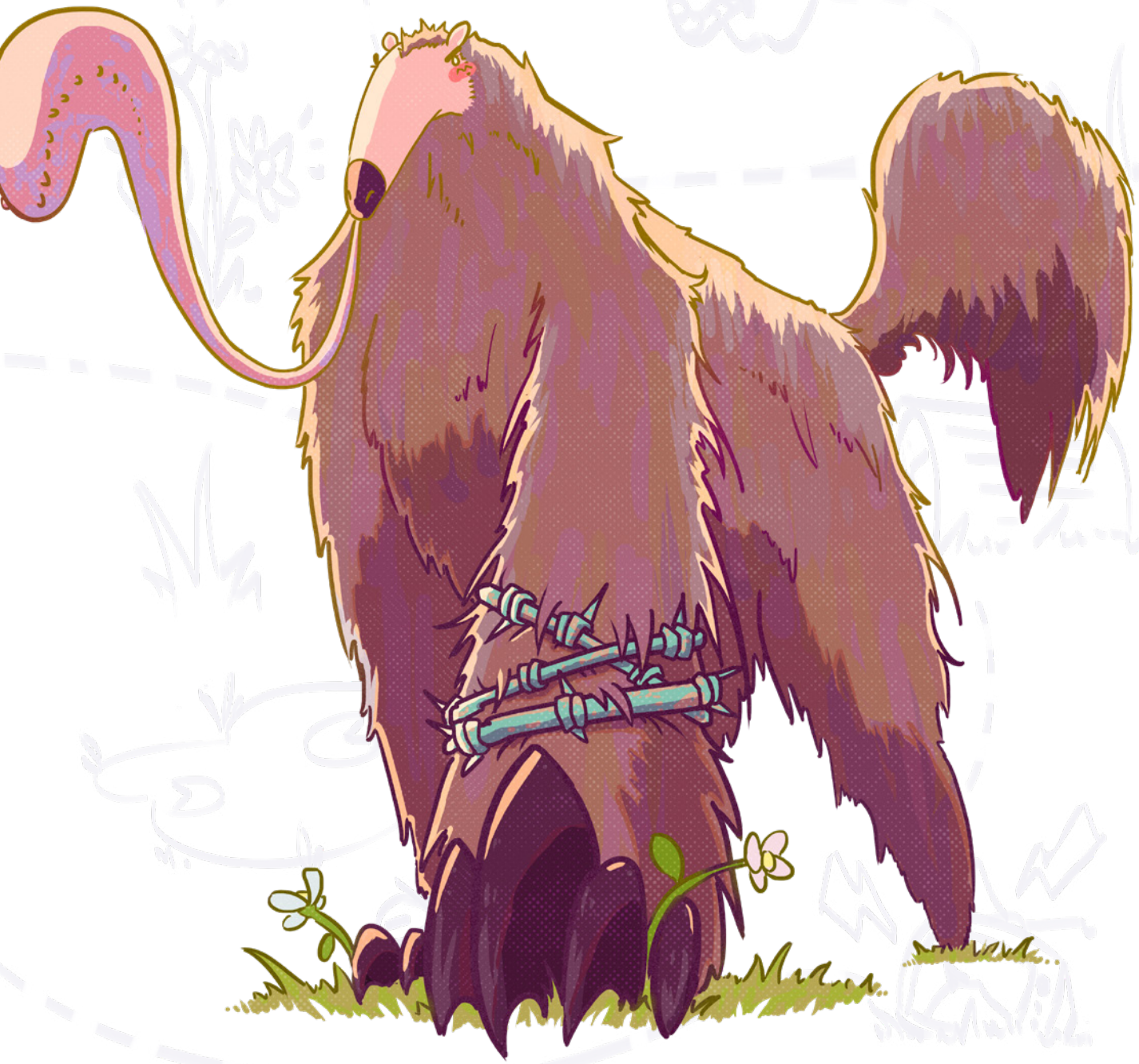
STUFF TO GRAB

» **Bits**: Anteater Spit, Pelt-Hair, A King's Salty Tear

Besting the All-Consuming

Squaring up to a titan head-on is a fool's errand, doubly so without a plan. Bugs might approach this encounter by...

- Providing Zygar with a feast fit for a king, in the hopes that it will spare buglier morsels.
- Gathering a force of brave NPCs to stand in opposition to the monstrous threat the All-Consuming presents.
- Preparing for a 'spirited' debate, avoiding physical attacks and deploying cunning or trickery whilst avoiding the creature's lashing tongue and pounding paws.



HELPING PLAYERS OUT

It's a trope as old as TRPGs - part of the GM's job is to teach the game as they run it.

Well, Weavers are no different - PICO may be a pretty collaborative experience as tabletop games go, but you're still likely the one with a copy of the book and the ability to push your glasses up your nose and start a sentence with the words 'Umm, actually...'.

And we're here to help you out with that, with this short section dedicated to general advice for Weavers and a few tips on dealing with common player hang-ups and mistakes, especially when danger enters into the mix.

IF A HAZARD FEELS TOO TOUGH...

Maybe it is! That can happen, and it shouldn't be seen as a roadblock either; just a problem to be solved. You could...

- Kick things down a notch when the bugs reach the hazard's next track break.
- Have NPC aid arrive to help in an encounter, or have the weather/environment begin to work in the band's favour.
- Have the hazard retreat, and set a track for its return so the players have some time to prepare.

IF A HAZARD FEELS TOO WEAK...

Hey, that can happen too - there are definitely some aspect and augment combinations that can give a bug a real edge in certain situations. You could...

- Kick things up a notch when the bugs reach the hazard's next track break.
- Have a hazard's lackeys show up to support their boss, or have an entirely new (and more dangerous) hazard appear, eat the old one, and become the new main threat.
- Have an element of the environment or weather turn against the bugs mid-scene.
- Have the hazard retreat in fear or frustration, vowing revenge, then return scenes later after beefing itself up.

IF A PLAYER SEEMS UNSURE...

Then that's pretty natural, actually. Not everyone's going to have a great idea for every situation. To help, you could...

- Have the hazard target them with a move, giving them an immediate, concrete situation to react to.
- Ask if they have an idea or approach they want to share. Sometimes they might just need a little encouragement!
- Engineer a situation that you know mechanically benefits them, and gently spur them to take advantage of it.

IF AN ENCOUNTER RUNS TOO LONG...

It's surprising how often this one gets overlooked. You **should**...

- End it! It's not a game if people aren't having fun. Have the hazard break away, slip unexpectedly down a hole, or remember that it left the oven on. It can return later (still damaged), or it might never be seen again.

IF A PLAYER FEELS USELESS...

We guarantee that they're not.

This most often happens with players that have a lot of experience in crunchier games, or games that have less flexible skill and action systems. They'll likely worry that they don't have the 'right skill' to do something useful, or that there's 'nothing they can do' in the face of a hazard's cut or resistances/immunities. To counter, you might...

- Teach as you play. Ask them what skills they have access to, and give a few pointers or hints as to what they might do with those same skills (especially non-rumbling skills that could still have a cool effect).
- Remind them that there are lots of things they can do in an encounter that aren't attacking, but that can still mark a hazard track. Scare a hazard? That's a mark. Throw spices in its face? That's a mark. Climb up it and cover its eyes? Hey, that could be a mark. Distract it with something really shiny? You know, that's probably a mark too.
- Remind them that death and defeat are *very* different things. It helps to look for survival or gain, not conquest.
- Remind them that they can ask the rest of the table for ideas too - tap every resource you can!

General Advice

Given their power and toughness, a titan might at first seem like an insurmountable challenge to a group. If needed, remind them that...

All Actions are Valuable

"I can't hit this thing's weaknesses, and I don't have any gigaskills, am I useless now?" Definitely not!

Actions without giga impact can still be *extremely useful* in a titan encounter. They might not have the ability to make marks on a titan's track, but **they can still have effects**! Here's an example...

Jules and her band are facing off against the specimachine, a Clanky titan that's trying to snatch them up to add to its personal collection of scurrying sorts. Jules has the spotlight, and she uses an action to throw a series of bursting berries at the titan. It has boosted impact, but that's still not enough to deal gigadamage, so no marks are made on the specimachine's titan hearts, but there's still a narrative effect from the action. Jules might have the berries smear over the machine's lenses, impeding its vision, or have juice from the berries gum up some meshing cogs to slow it down a little.

There's Strength in Teamwork

It's spelled out on page 46, but the players might need a reminder. **Combos and finishers** allow all bugs access to giga impact with a bit of teamwork and some good rolls, so even if a group lacks the specific skills to target a titan's natural weaknesses, they can still muscle through if they need to. It might even be worth setting a Combo Track at the start of every titan encounter, just as a visual reminder that combos and finishers are particularly useful in these situations (see page 47 for more details on Combo Tracks).

It Doesn't Have to Be a Fight

Yes, we admit, it's pretty cool to stand toe to toe with a beast a hundred times your size and take it down with a rusty nail and some cool acrobatics. But have you, maybe, considered making it a nice cup of tea instead?

Just like regular hazard encounters, tangling with a titan as you attempt to mark its track might take wildly different forms depending on how your group solves problems. *Each titan page has a few suggestions on how bugs might engage with the foe in question, usually ranging from full-frontal assaults to entirely non-violent approaches, which are there to help Weavers set up these encounters effectively and hint at possible solutions.*

The 'Big Bad' Returns!

As the Weaver, throwing a titan at the players isn't something you should do lightly. Consider...

- Having a titan teased early on, so the bugs can start planning their strategies in advance and maybe recruit some outside help.
- Have other events in the world or story affect the titan, whether positively or negatively, even when it's 'off-screen'.
- Have the titan as a reoccuring challenge, where damage the bugs manage to deal stays on the titan track between scenes after it retreats. It's not a buffet, you don't have to eat it all in one go! *On reflection, I may not understand how buffets work.*

CHAPTER 11:
PLACES TO GO

REALMS

The world of PICO is big.

Really, really big.

Part of this, as one might expect, is due to the inherent smallosity of bugs and the relative largification of just about everything else they encounter. The scuttling masses are tiny types, and it's extremely obvious that the majority of the world wasn't constructed with them in mind.

There's also a wider issue of scale at play - even the longest lived, most energetic bugly traveller could spend their whole life on the move and never see but a fraction of the wonders that the post-Mysteriocalypse has to offer. There's just too much ground to cover, and that's not even factoring in the trials and dangers an explorer would encounter along the way.

But is the inability to experience *everything* a good reason to sit at home, twiddle your thumbs, and accept a life of seeing nothing at all?

No, say adventuring bugs. Not in the slightest.

FROM REALM TO REALM

This chapter contains several pre-made **realms**, large locations with their own landmarks, factions, NPCs, and hazards. A band of bugs might spend their entire lifetimes in a single realm, or travel from place to place throughout their adventure, or maybe never see a single one of these pre-made realms at all - it's all up to you, the Weaver, to decide where the game you're running is set. *Though it might be a good idea to ask the other players at your table if they have any thoughts on the matter too - seems like the polite thing to do.*

Each realm on offer here has a distinct tone, from the cold darkness of the Shadow House to the verdant expanse of the Hogwild, but these aren't set in stone - if a few changes to the way a realm is presented would make it a better fit for your group, we say go for it.

And there's always the option, if you have a bit of time on your hands and a penchant for creativity, of making a realm of your very own - more about that on page 271.

THE REALMS ON OFFER

"Exploration is really the essence of the scuttling spirit."

There are five pre-made realms lovingly spread over the next fifrty or so pages, each of them with their own unique tone. Here's a quick primer for what's on offer...

THE HOGWILD (page 272)

A place of vegetative mystery, a vast forest shared by groundbreaker hogs, unstable alchemists, and mercenaries ready to work for whoever has the shiniest bobs.
General Tone: Dark and mysterious, with infrequent but impressive explosions.

THE SHADOW HOUSE (page 286)

A creaking mansion with altogether too many rooms, the interior so rarely kissed by the sun that ghosts consistently vote it their most comfortable holiday destination.
General Tone: Dilapidated, quiet, and 100% haunted.

THE SKYGLASS DOME (page 300)

A world within a world, deserts and jungles enclosed by ancient glass-and-iron defences. The Dome is a breeding ground for conflict and beauty in equal measures.
General Tone: Bright and dangerous, an ever-shifting vibrancy.

THE NEKOPOLIS (page 312)

A city of claw and fur, an urban sprawl ruled over by hissing pseudo-deities on an endless, joyful hunt. The neon-lit streets of the Nekopolis are inherently hostile, but that hasn't stopped a thriving insectile society from forming.
General Tone: Punky and desperate, challenging at every turn.

THE WESTGATE MALL (page 324)

All flourescent lights and mercantile memory, the bright colours and air-conditioned environment hide some surprisingly potent dangers. There are spadefuls of corporate-approved fun to be had!
General Tone: Cheerfully colourful, but somehow still subtly worrying.

USING PRE-MADE REALMS

Each realm presented in this chapter follows a specific formula, designed (hopefully) for it to be as easy as possible for a Weaver to dip into the pages, grab something that appeals, and slap it into play at a moment's notice. Witin each realm write-up, you'll find...

An Opening Splash: A large piece of art you can show players to help get everyone in the same tonal headspace.

An Overview: General info with a section specifically on the vibes of the place.

A Set of Particulars: With optional rules, pre-written mysteries for bugs to pursue, page references for local hazards that might turn up, and a pre-made list of bits and bobs that are common to the area.

Some Local Factions: And some NPC suggestions for each, great for adding goals and drama.

A Travel Guide: A set of three or four fully fleshed out locations, each with notable features, landmarks, and bugly settlements for a band to explore. Each location also comes with a short set of random tables for the Weaver to roll on, providing inspiration for landmarks, NPCs, and events the bugs might run into as they travel.

CREATING A NEW REALM

Oh, *we* get it - none of the options presented here are perfect for your table? A real failure on our part, that one.

We're joking, of course. One of the deepest joys of tabletop RPGs is seeing what a book offers, mulling it over, and then leaping off into left field to make your own stuff. Maybe you have an idea that you just can't contain, or you know the tastes of your table after many years of gaming together, or perhaps you want a load of bugs tromping around some other established fantasy world and trekking mud all over their nice clean carpets. Whatever the reason, if you want to make a new realm for your players to explore, you have our complete and total blessings. And also our help!

Below are a few 'best practices' for creating a realm from scratch, questions you should answer for yourself as you develop your own little slice of the post-Mysteriocalypse.

WHAT'S THE CENTRAL THEME?

A strong core theme gives you some solid boundaries to work within while creating factions and NPCs, and also allows you to throw in some spice by adding elements that run counter to that theme from time to time.

WHAT'S THE LOCAL CONFLICT?

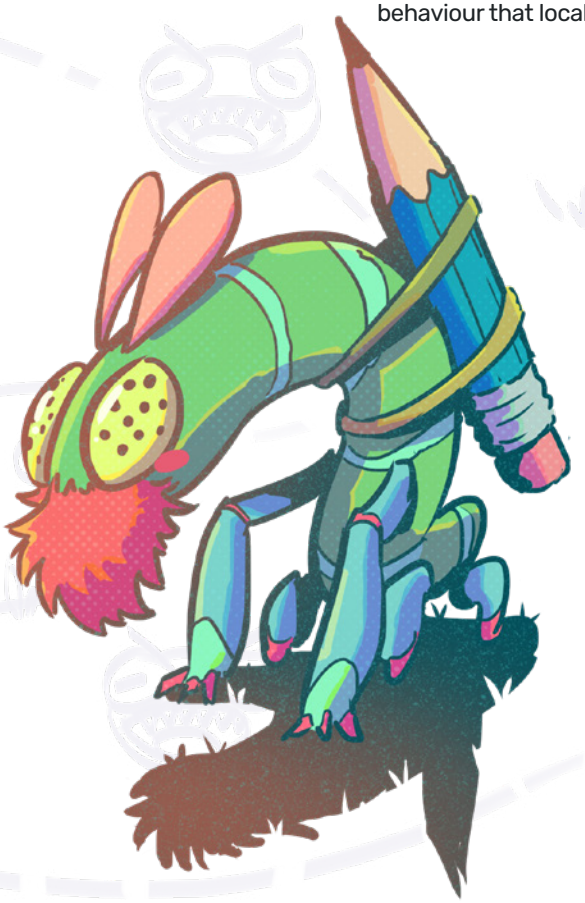
Wouldn't it be nice if everyone was nice? No, it would be deathly boring. A conflict (between factions, attitudes, or traditions) doesn't need to be deeply divisive, and certainly does't need to be represented by violence, but should give points of friction that you can exploit while running the game.

WHAT'S ABUNDANT?

Knowing what an area has an excess (or at least a good supply) of should inform the cultures residing there, as well as the local art and architecture. Living in a sandpit? Probably going to build some stuff out of sand!

WHAT'S IN SHORT SUPPLY?

The world of PICO has enough resources for all, but they may not always be distributed in the right way. Don't feel like you need to limit yourself to physical resources either, especially if the bugs in your table's adventuring band show strong leanings toward certain types of behaviour that locals to your realm might lack.



THE HOGWILD

OVERVIEW

There are dangers in the darkened depths of the Hogwild, dangers that the average bug dare not speak the name of.

Oh wait, yes they do. Sorry, I was thinking of somewhere else entirely.

There are dangers in the darkened depths of the Hogwild, and just about *every* local could give an itemized list of them. There are feral cats, terrifying mercenaries, golden-horned vipers and, worst of all, the enormous hungry hogs that give the woods their name.

But even without those thinking things, the Hogwild would be a tough place to travel. Sudden rains bring difficult-to-escape deluges of freezing water, sticky-leafed plants snag at legs and antennae, and spores drift lazily in the early morning breeze. It's not a place for easy living, attracting the kind of bugs that don't get too unsettled when life gives them a few knocks, or their grandmother gets eaten by something.

But there's treasure there too, down among the roots.

... Probably, anyway.

VIBES

Overgrown: It should probably go without saying, but there really isn't much going on in the way of forest maintenance post-Mysteriocalypse. The hogs leave their own paths (which you might follow, if you're very hurried or very brave), but a lot of travel is going to involve pushing through undergrowth that towers above the head of the average bug.

Secret-Filled: The deeper into the wilds you get, or the farther away from established settlements, the more mysteries of nature and history you're likely to run into.

Musky: There are smells in the forest like you wouldn't believe, smells that tell stories of porcine wars and dragonfly dances and fresh flowing water.

Serene: Yes, there are scary things in the thickest part of the wilds, and yes, you run the risk of being snuffled up by a hog if you stray too far off of the path... But there's such a sense of peace when things *aren't* trying to eat you.

HOGGISH PARTICULARS

What makes the Hogwild so special? Let's find out together... *These pages cover optional rules, notes on tone, and resources for the Weaver to use in a pinch.*

OPTIONAL RULES

When bugs are going on tiny adventures within the realm of the Hogwild, consider bringing the following special rules into play. They're not entirely necessary, especially for newer groups, but they should bring some spice into proceedings for more experienced explorers of the world of PICO.

DAPPLING (optional rule)

The soft play of sunbeams through branches, the brief slips of darkness as leaves move in the breeze - the eaves of the Hogwild are an ever-changing tapestry of light and shadow. *When in areas with a thick layer of moving leaves above them, light and shadow get pretty muddled. When a bug takes an action in this kind of area, they can choose whether they're in **light** or **darkness** (if it matters for their aspects).*

LANGUAGE BARRIERS (optional rule)

If a beast can speak, it's assumed to be able to speak the same language that the bugs are speaking (whatever that is, probably something exceedingly cute or chittery). Nothing saying that has to be the case though! *Beast-type hazards from the deeper areas of the Hogwild may not speak the same language as the player characters (or other NPCs from nearer the edge of the wilds), making verbal communication impossible, but mime, gesture, and intention all the more important. Maybe smells could help here too?*

NUTFALL (optional rule)

Wind pushes, raindrops sting, and a leaf on the breeze might as well be a storm-tossed trampoline... But nothing compares to the sudden, explosive impact of a hognut fallen from one of the region's towering trees. *Strong winds or scuffles that shake a tree or branch might also bring nutfall, a scatter of bug-crushing boulders falling at random. Nutfall impacts should deal Gigabash Damage, and are a great opportunity for the Weaver to call for Luck Rolls to see who gets hit (details on page 36). Remember, falling nuts can damage hazards too!*

LOST OR HIDING? (optional rule)

With long grass and fallen branches, mouldering leaves and scattered wildflowers, the Hogwild is a great place to get lost in - and a great place to hunker down and hide! *Trying to find paths through the Hogwild without a suitable vantage point always comes with a Complex Cut of 1, and actions taken to hide or conceal yourself ignore cut.*

HIGH OR LOW WEIRDNESS?

The Hogwild is a pretty normal place by the standards of PICO, a large forested area with a few signs of old humanity left there to be overgrown and wondered about. Even so, you've got a few different options when deciding on the level of local weirdness you want to exhibit.

For High Weirdness: Those leftovers of the old world? They're still powered, even without a power source. A tree's hollow might contain a working arcade machine, or a stream be fouled brown (and delicious) by drips from a suspiciously coffee-maker-shaped island. Maybe the hogs even know how some of these old machines work...

For Medium Weirdness: Bring the beasts of the Hogwild into the story as much as possible, showing off that their ways and cultures, while understandable with some practice, may differ greatly from those of the average bug.

For Low Weirdness: Everyone knows what a forest is like, even if you don't spend much time wandering around one in your real life. To get that authentic forest feeling, throw in lots of local bugs that are entirely happy living the way they live, and they don't need any meddling outsiders coming in with big city ideas, thank you very much!

WILD MYSTERIES

If your players would like to change the world with revelations relevant to the Hogwild, the following list of potential mysteries is a good place to start. *When a player makes a grand discovery and needs to choose a new tiny mystery for their bug to explore, you can suggest one from the list below.*

- Who made the first tree?
- What do hogs eat when nobody's looking?
- Why do rivers flow one way and not both?
- Do nuts and leaves know when they're about to fall?
- Why do moles live underground?
- What the heck was an ITSY BITSY MART?
- What's the most explosive liquid?
- How do the branches know when to sway?

USEFUL LOOT

There are bits aplenty in the Hogwild, a range of edibles that are at least 70% safe for the majority of bugs to stick in their face-holes. Bobs are a little less common, but there are still hordes of oddities to pick up. *The following lists of both should help if you ever need to give a reward to the players for exploration and rummaging about.*

Local Bits: Cracked Nut, Sticky Sap, Forest Dust, Leaf Rubbings, Tiny Shoot, Plucked Feather, Petal of Many Colours, Rich Wet Dirt, Bullrush Fruit

Local Bobs: Buried Hairpin, Tarnished Coin, Broken Glass, Empty Matchbox, Tiny Beaker, Ancient Shopping List, Miniature Goggles, Polished Geode

POTENTIAL HAZARDS

They say you're never more than a step away from something that thinks you look mightily delicious. *Danger in the Hogwild might come in the form of...*

- **Groundbreaker hogs** scooting from place to place on their search for fun and truffles (page 234)
- **Comet-nosed moles** racing through their underground tunnels (page 221)
- **Predatory plants** slinking around the long grass and in amongst the fallen leaves with a singular purpose (page 250)
- **Miniature Mercs** in the pay of the highest bidder, or relaxing in their downtime with... Well, with more fighting, probably (page 246)
- **Drummingbirds**, feathery noisemakers trying to put on the show of a lifetime (page 227)
- **Froglins & Croaklins**, waterside bullies arranged in petty gangs (page 228)
- **Lion's Manes**, usually confined to hunting around the wood's edges, but sometimes leaving their natural grassy habitat to pursue prey among the boughs and roots (page 245)

"They say if you're good at something, you should never do it for free. And I'm good at fighting. But I wouldn't be anywhere near AS good if I hadn't done a lot of it for free, so... Is that a paradox? Can anyone tell me? I'm genuinely asking here."

Roland DeSola, Miniature Mercenary Philosopher

LOCAL FACTIONS

Wide, deep, dark, and fecund, the wilds are the perfect breeding ground for innocent misunderstandings and petty squabbles. Can you even lay claim to a tree, or a bit of old gorse? Some seem to think so. *The following pages detail the main factions of the Hogwild, the **Two-In-Ones** and the **Itsy Bitsy Mercenaries**.*

THE TWO-IN-ONES

General Mood: Overly enthusiastic, slightly singed
Home Turf: Fringewood

What could one do with the limitless resources of the wider world on one side of them and a steady stream of oddities from the depths of the wood on the other? Well, turns out the answer is 'just about anything, if they put their mind to it'. The Two-In-Ones are self-styled (and self-taught, and often self-defeating) alchemists.

THE UNEXPLODED COLLEGE (landmark)

Pride of the Two-In-One elders, the college is safely contained within a mud-sunk wellington boot. *Maybe...*

- Only those that can go a full year without exploding are invited to further their studies at the college. They have a reputation to uphold, after all.
- If the complaints of nearby neighbours are anything to go by, the name might not be as applicable as one might hope.
- The boot has been reinforced with additional rubber from a tyre-pile within the Hoggish Depths, but more is always needed.

IN WITH A BOOM (feature)

Membership of the Two-In-Ones is earned through alchemical experimentation. Note that this is different from alchemical *prowess* - you don't actually have to be very good at what you do to join, you just have to show the right level of shell-searing, antennae-burning, potentially explosive eagerness. *Maybe...*

- The Two-In-Ones are on a constant search for ingredients taken from the Philisopher's Tree, said to grow at the very centre of the Hogwild, a mighty oak with leaves of pure gold and bark of darkest lead.
- No Two-In-One accepts payment of any kind for the concoctions they create, but they also don't guarantee results - at least, they don't guarantee desired results. Most have waivers for you to sign, scrawled out on the back of old shopping lists.
- **Cogtooth Carlisle** is the most experienced alchemist around, a caterpillar that's refusing to turn into a butterfly until they''ve perfected a serum that will let them fly without wings.

SIZZLIN' SAM'S (landmark)

The ancient script above Sam's little outpost reads 'F R WOR S', and it's definitely a bit of truth in advertising; if you're not the kind of bug that enjoys being blown up in a shower of coloured stars as you eat, a stop at Sizzlin' Sam's is indeed far worse than continuing on your way. But if you've got a spark of pyrotechnic joy in your eyes and a hunger in your belly, there's no better place to light the blue touch paper and run for cover. *Maybe...*

- Most of the employees are waiting for the return of the eponymous owner, last seen rising above the treeline strapped to a rocket of her own design. They don't get paid until she's back, either.
- Quite a few of the Two-In-Ones get their start working in the kitchens at Sizzlin' Sam's - if they can survive that, they can survive anything!
- Sam's is kind of a 'restaurant of Theseus' at this point, having burnt down and been rebuilt more times than anyone can remember.

AN INTRIGUING MIX (npcs)

It's not that there aren't members of the Two-In-Ones that can brew up an impressive potion, because there definitely are. They're simply outnumbered by the number of adherents that just want to make weird liquids go boom.

- **Mah-Mah**, a ladybird chemist with a focus on healing salves made from carnivorous plant extracts.
- **Libette**, a water skimmer who prefers to conduct her experiments in the middle of a nearby lake.
- **Skavamander**, a self-styled 'revenantologist' who's sure to make a breakthrough in the field of insect zombification any day now.

ITSY BITSY MERCENARIES

General Mood: Ready to scrap, for the right price
Home Turf: The Hoggish Depths

The world is a dangerous place for a bug, especially one wandering the depths of the Hogwild - sometimes a little protection, coupled with some good old local knowledge, goes a long way. That's the idea behind the Itsy Bitsy Mercenaries, a band of bugs notable for their bulging muscle, their scarred chitin, and their flexible interpretation of morality when coin is involved. *To run the mercenaries as a hazard, use the miniature mercs entry on page 246.*

IN IT FOR THE MONEY (feature)

While they can come off a little surly and boastful at first, the mercenaries aren't often a danger unless they're being paid to be one. *Maybe...*

- A longtime enemy of the gang has hired the mercenaries to rough them up a little.
- They may be guns for hire, but they've got principles. No merc ever takes a job where the target is defenceless.
- A particular commission is giving the mercs some trouble, but they can't back out now. How exactly does one drive off an immortal cat, anyway?

ITSY BITSY CAGE (landmark)

When they call themselves cage fighters, they're being oddly literal; the home base of the mercenaries is an overgrown shopping cart half buried in the mud of the deep woods. *Maybe...*

- The cage is impervious to titan attacks, a perfect fortress in a hog-filled world.
- Some of the mercenaries are tired of fighting, and dream of converting part of the cage into an artisanal bakery. They'd need supplies, though.
- The current fashion trend in the cage is for eyepatches, even if you still have the full complement of eyes.

LOCAL TALENT (npcs)

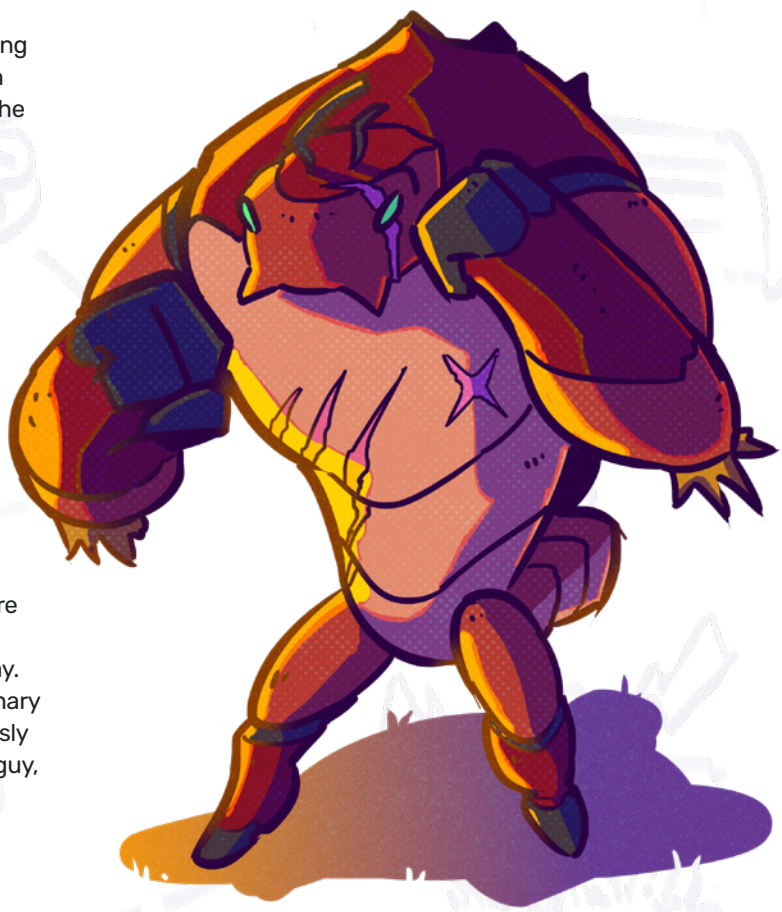
Make a name for yourself and soon enough work comes looking for you!

- **Sycamore**, a mercenary craftsman who forges cannons out of 'gifts' from Sizzlin' Sam's. Some are even small enough to be (vaguely) portable.
- **Hugo Heaves**, a tarantula who never skips leg day.
- **Lombrero**. Thinks he's fooled every other mercenary into believing that he's a bug, despite him obviously being a *very* small bird. But hey, he's a stand-up guy, so they're not going to make a big deal out of it.

THE ETERNAL RULES (feature)

Red Morris, the current mercenary tsar, has a few rules in place that they expect to be followed at all times (though he refuses to write them down, and seems to change them whenever he feels like it). *Maybe...*

- Morris is clear, you should never break what can't be mended.
- No hats on a Tuesday, that's an obvious one.
- Smuggling truffles into the cage, *especially* by using the secret entrance to the Den of Roots, is an offence punishable by exile.



A WILD TRAVEL GUIDE

Visiting the Hogwild, are you? Well that's certainly a choice.

Though the edges of the wood, where trees falter and fields take over, are easy enough for a bug to traverse, heading into the deeper areas takes a strong heart and an even stronger sense of direction. It's easy to get turned around under the canopy, and predatory plants aren't exactly known for giving the best directions. *The following entries all represent distinct areas of the Hogwild that a band of bugs might stumble upon as they travel, as well as the features and landmarks they could encounter.*

FRINGEWOOD

Stepping into Fringewood means two things above all. One, that the vast, deep expanse of the inner Hogwild is only a stone's throw away (if you're a very big person with a very large stone, which is highly unlikely) - that's why there's such a scrum of dwellings and traders around the place, supplying travellers heading under the leafy sky and buying wonders off of those who manage to make it out again.

And two, there's still time to turn back.

ROADS FROM FIELD TO FOREST (feature)

There are many ways to enter the Hogwild, but the roads leading to, and through, Fringewood are the safest bet. *Maybe...*

- The roads are never empty - adventurous types sing as they head toward the woods, rickety wagons haul goods to and fro, and winged bugs crisscross the skies above as they carry messages of greeting and market manipulation from convoy to convoy.
- A set of flags on poles have been erected at the side of the main Fringewood road, with the colour of the flags changing to indicate the growing danger before they're swallowed by the depths beyond the fringe.
- It's not one road, as you might have heard, but a collection of smaller paths all twining together from various parts of the wider world.

TEKSO QUAILHEART (titan)

Foxes are known for cunning rather than bravery. It's an old trope, and perhaps that's why it doesn't really apply to Tekso - he's a fox that's neither cunning nor brave. *Maybe...*

- Tekso lost a chunk of his bushy tail somewhere in the forest, but is too scared to retrieve it himself despite his size. If any bugs are going that way, they might consider bringing it back for him?
- This fox loves stories, and will happily trade tales of the deeper wood with travellers intending to enter. Whether his words ring true is up for you to decide.
- He has the capacity for bravery, he just hasn't grown into it yet. Maybe he's stronger than he knows?

STUMP LAKE (landmark)

Straightforward in its naming, Stump Lake is a... well, I'll let you work that out for yourself. *Maybe...*

- The stump at the centre of the lake holds an ancient hatchet, buried deep into the wood. Whosoever frees this weapon from its resting place is theoretically crowned king of the lake, though they'll first need to work out how to lift something fifty times their size.
- Enjoyers of watery pursuits tend to steer clear of the lake, unless they have an understanding with the local froglins.
- **Cassius Carvexo**, a silver-backed carp living within the lake, only ever surfaces to watch the night of colours - but last week was notably absent.

THE LAST BAZAAR (landmark)

Clustered around the base of the very first tree one comes to on their way into the wilds (if you take the rut-scarred trader's path, anyway), the bugs running the Last Bazaar are in it for the loot, not the glory. *Maybe...*

- A betting pool is set up whenever any particularly tough-looking adventurers head into the forest. Just how long will *this* lot last, do you think?
- There's so much stuff piled on various tables that a bit of jostling in the wrong place can start an extremely expensive cascade of glories.
- At least half of the stalls sell some kind of 100% guarantee hog defence - an amulet, a spray, a special dance. Not many of them have endorsements from happy customers, though.

A NIGHT OF COLOURS (feature)

Fringewood isn't all trading and preparation - sometimes the locals like to let their hair down (metaphorically, of course) and engage in some good old-fashioned celebration. Once a week, to be precise!

The Night of Colours is a Fringewood festival hosted by the Two-In-Ones (page 276), usually centred around Sizzlin' Sam's and the nearby Stump Lake. It's a time for revelry and explosions, fireworks and sparklers, nut wine and roasted truffles. And there are hardly ever any deaths! *Maybe*...

- The central attraction of the Night of Colours is an alchemical contest, open to all who bring their own ingredients. The goal? Craft a new colour; the more vibrant, the better!
- Bugs come from far and wide for the festival, partly for the enjoyment but also for the temporary safety. Local beasts keep clear of the celebratory noise, but return with a vengeance the next morning.
- The truffles consumed during the Night of Colours are traditionally of the highest quality, and obviously come from deep within the Hoggish Depths... But nobody ever sees them being delivered.

ONE MORE TRY! (landmark)

A fallen disposable camera is a good place to build a little shelter, but a *great* place to set up a photo studio. The bugs in charge move mirrors around on a tiny crane to help the skyward lens capture something other than clouds, but only when paid in tasty tasty bits. *Maybe...*

- The mirror used to angle One More Try's shots was stolen from a titan living deep within the Hogwild, and they want it back.
- One More Try usually charges for pictures, but it'll take one for free of every adventuring group that makes it back from the Hoggish Depths with a bounty of truffles to share.
- The camera's film was spoiled long before the bugs got ahold of it. That doesn't stop an enterprising businessbug though, and One More Try employs local artists of variable skill to paint what they imagine the lens might be seeing. The results are often inaccurate, but always cute.

EXPLORING THE FRINGEWOOD

When a band of bugs travels the fringes of the forest, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

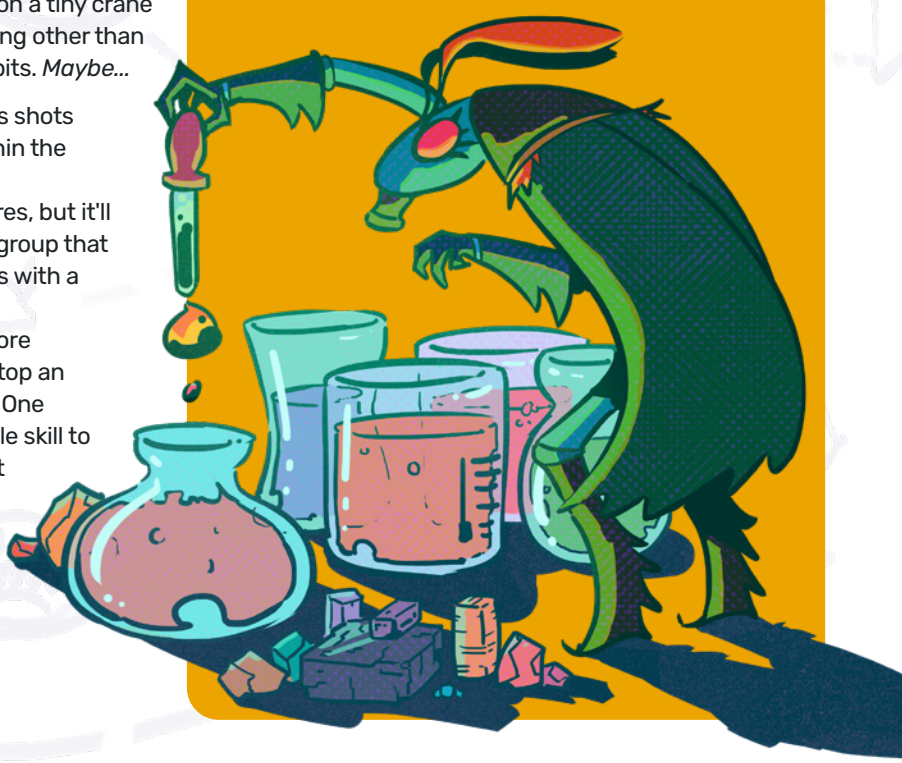
1: A broken spade leaning against a tree.
2: Lakeside houses on matchstick stilts.
3: An old bootprint, now used as a swimming pool.
4: A trader's cart stuck in the mud, never to move again.
5: A bird's nest full of delicious-looking eggs.
6: A mapmaker's shop in a compass' interior.

NPCs

1: **Gol & Galo**, two slugs that can see the future.
2: **Long Lavaka**, a praying mantis monk on a long jaunt.
3: **Sanjiv**, a tobacco beetle selling local medicines.
4: **Oboe**, a millipede farmer taking a break.
5: **Cedric Calo**, a seller of hog-charms and oddments.
6: **Lady Giis**, an exiled member of dragonfly royalty.

Events

1: A Two-In-One celebration of spreading flames.
2: An argument between two traders.
3: A group of grubs on a school trip to the wood's edge.
4: A minor quake, and a slight dimming of the sun.
5: A makeshift tent collapses, their neighbours jeering.
6: A chef offering free samples of dirt-fried dirt.



THE HOGGISH DEPTHS

A thicket of dense brush and towering trees, which local bugs and visiting explorers share with both the groundbreaker hogs and a huge variety of predatory plantlife. It's not the easiest place to make a home (at least not for those that want a good, long life), but the depths are chock-full of opportunities for a brave traveller. There are secrets in the scents, if you have the olfactory nous to sniff them out, and the overgrown forest floor hides relics of a bygone age half-swallowed by centuries of verdant growth.

GREAT, GREEN, & DARK (feature)

The road peters out. The traders' shouts are forgotten. The light dims, and the air cools. There are other bugs here, and predatory beasts, and hungry plants, but they're all hidden behind a veil of tangled green that stretches out in all directions. *Maybe...*

- Smell is a better way of navigating through the Hoggish Depths than sight, by far. It's how the pigs and moles do it, and they seem to know what's going on around here.
- Local bugs have built small watchtowers peeking out of the brush, rising through bracken and jutting out of long, tangled grass. They let a bug get the lay of the land, but they also make one very, *very* visible.
- The canopy of leaves above throws the depths into near-permanent shadow, save for deific rays of sunlight piercing the foliage in unexpected bursts.

WATCH WHERE YOU STEP (feature)

The rich loam of the depths is the perfect base for a variety of bug-eating plants. *Maybe...*

- Globs of sticky sugar water turn out to be the eyes of a rustling predator rooted below.
- Ambulatory flytraps scurry about the densest areas, ravenous and toothy.
- The Itsy Bitsy Mercenaries have a standing contract with local explorers to deal with predatory plants however they see fit.

TUSKING ROUTES (landmark)

A relief from the thick undergrowth, these natural paths are carved by hogs as they snuffle. They're walkable, but bugs won't be the only ones walking there. *Maybe...*

- The paths are deeply churned and muddy, spotted with bits of bark and mushroom from where the hogs thrash their tusks around as they search.
- Each path leads, if you follow it for long enough, to a truffle-rich burrow.
- The routes are jealously guarded by elder hogs, shocks of white tufting around their shroom-stained jowls and indignant rage in their piggish eyes.

EVERY BUG FOR THEMSELVES (feature)

Territory is hard to carve out here, and even harder to defend from the manifold dangers of the deep wood. A dose of healthy suspicion is a sensible survival trait when you're on the menu. *Maybe...*

- Small families of bugs guard their little lands with vigour, throwing nuts and twiggish spears at any interlopers that might come to steal their secrets.
- It's oddly quiet for a place that must be thronging with so much life. Everyone just keeps themselves to themselves out here.
- Local bugs gather for only two reasons this deep into the wood - festivals and funerals. Both are raucous, and both may also involve drinking pitcher-nectar straight from the source.

GROUNDBREAKER HOGS (titan)

Bugs are pretty literal when it comes to naming things, and perhaps nowhere is this more true than with the groundbreaker hogs. These porcine terrors stalk the tangles on the Hogwild, grunting and squealing battle cries the moment they see a delicious-looking edible. And while those that can fly or swim might be able to outclass them if they're quick enough, natural diggers are out of luck - a groundbreaker hog's tusks are as potent a tool as they are a weapon, gouging great gouts of earth away in an instant to reveal tunnels and warrens once thought safe (you can use the entry on page 234 to run a hog as an active hazard). *Maybe...*

- Sometimes an injured hogling can be nursed back to health and made a friend to bugs, but the average piggly beast is more interested in eating than greeting.
- Hogs are actually less interested in bugs than rumours would have you believe, partly because the average bug is small enough that they barely register as a blur to a hog's tiny eyes, but mostly because the search for truffles is all-consuming.
- Some hogs bear palanquins upon their backs, transporting contracted digging bugs that aid them in their search for truffles below.

SUCH AMAZING TASTES! (feature)

You can't beat fresh truffles with a side of roasted hog nuts! It's the variety of flavours and quality of ingredients that keep culinary explorers coming back to the depths, despite the dangers. Is it worth it? They definitely think so. *Maybe...*

- Everybody comes here for the truffles, hogs included, but the *real* bounty of sweet, sweet syrup is in the bellies of predatory plants. Luckily, that's exactly where those very same plants want to put you! Unluckily, they're not keen on letting you out again.
- The travelling gourmet, **Anton De La Venom**, is a legend among those that frequent the depths. This tarantula operates a one-bug kitchen using nothing but locally sourced produce, all gathered by his own eight arms (or possibly legs, it's hard to tell).
- The truffles may be delicious, but they're not always safe to eat. Some bugs find themselves oddly shroomlike if they consume too much of the forest's bounty, driven to head deeper and deeper in search of something they can't quite name.

EXPLORING THE HOGGISH DEPTHS

When a band of bugs travels the depths, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

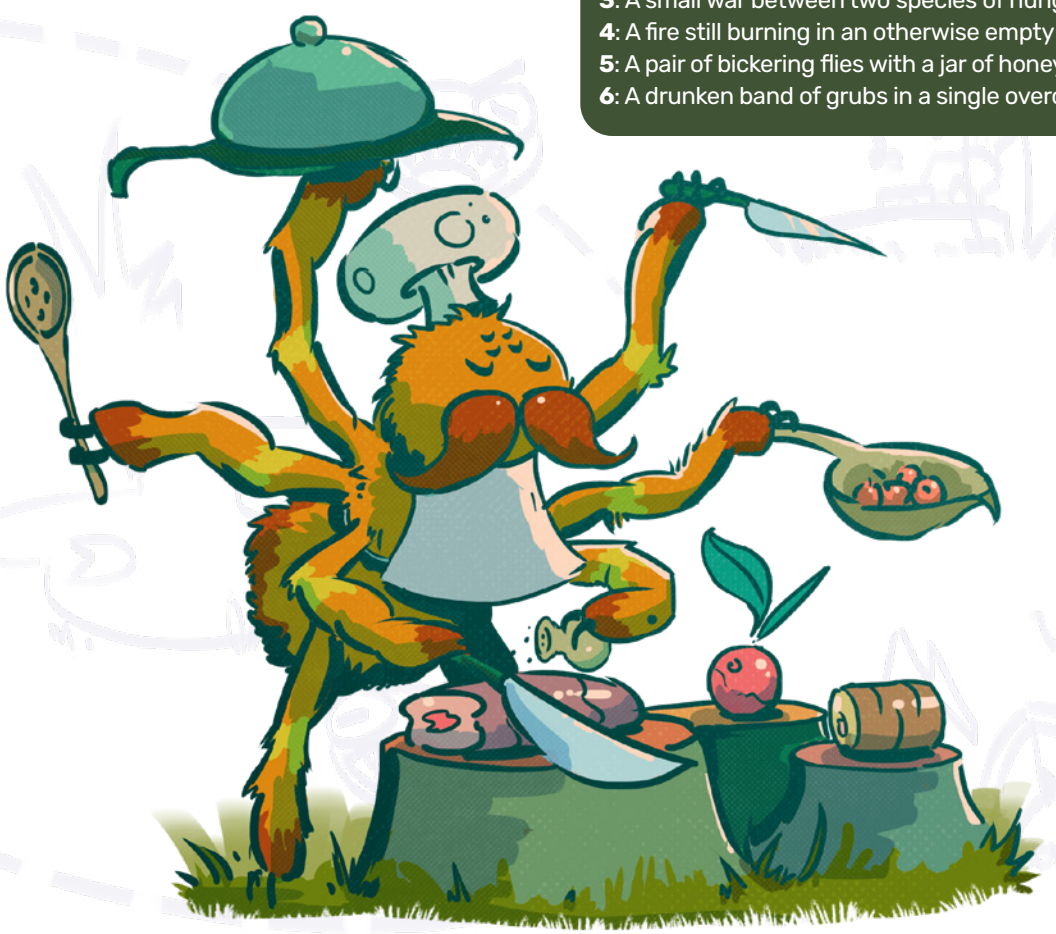
1: A slim tower made from a fallen branch.
2: A puddle deep enough to require swimming through.
3: A hog's skull daubed with crude graffiti.
4: A fallen tree trunk with a village carved into it.
5: An abandoned pile of tyres, a rubber mountain.
6: A platform hanging over a pit, stacked with truffles.

NPCs

1: **Hobart**, a scheming butterfly thief.
2: **Min**, a weeping centipede that's lost in the depths.
3: **Californio**, an elegant stick insect with a grudge.
4: **Ka-To-Ka**, a mapmaker on the run from her father.
5: **Honto**, a sleeping elephant beetle.
6: **Dave**, an entirely average bug, definitely not a ghost.

Events

1: A groundbreaker hog pursued by a band of pillbugs.
2: An illicit truffle-heist in progress.
3: A small war between two species of hungry plants.
4: A fire still burning in an otherwise empty camp.
5: A pair of bickering flies with a jar of honey.
6: A drunken band of grubs in a single overcoat.



NEWFOUND PLACES (landmarks)

It may be all about the flavour where the pigs and gourmands are concerned, but there's more to the Hoggish Depths than good food and dangerous company. In the years since the Mysteriocalypse more and more unusual places have been identified within the forest's deepest regions, each attractive to a different type of explorer. *A band of bugs might find...*

- **The Temple of Long Words**, a stack of books left to moulder out among the trees by some long-dead librarian with a grudge. A band of woodworms have taken ownership of the pile, chewing their way through a lifetime of knowledge on a daily basis - they'll share, but only in exchange for that same truffly goodness the hogs love so much.
- **Grand Snapper** is a venus flytrap the size of an umbrella, large enough that even the hogs stay clear. Its absurd dimensions actually make it more of a blessing than a curse to nearby bugs, and a small town has been built up in the shadow it casts, safe from the ever-yawning jaws above.
- **Itsy Bitsy Cage**, the secluded metal fortress of the Itsy Bitsy Mercenaries (see page 277 for more details).
- **Edenseed**, an all-natural, open-air settlement where bugs and froglins live in surprising harmony. A good place to go for eye-opening, mind-altering experiences.
- **The Bottle Bank**, a huge repository of glass owned by a scarred feline hoarder. Rarely ever visited more than once.
- **Chainsaw Ridge**, an abandoned tree-cutting device turned experimental garage/race track. The Two-In-Ones sometimes make pilgrimages to the Ridge, drawn by the allure of newly created chemical contraptions that *don't* blow up (or, at least, blow up with far less frequency than their own).
- **Balfax Puddle-Spread**, an area of soggy ground that's difficult for a bug to cross on foot. The locals move around by springing from leaf to leaf, and occasionally swinging on tiny vines.
- **Hollowtree Fort**. Built, very much as one might expect, into the innards of a hollow tree, this fort is a well-defended metropolis with a bustling insect population. The upper reaches of the tree hold their own kingdom of squirrels, but the fort's residents have a longstanding pact of mutual peace with their furry neighbours.

ALWAYS MORE TO SEE (feature)

Tusking routes can only take an explorer so far - to claim the fame of finding something truly special, one has to leave the trotter-beaten paths behind and forge out alone. What might be out there, in the depths of the wood? And, an even scarier thought, what might be *beyond* it? *Maybe...*

- Exploring bugs are singular, isolated sorts, jealous and suspicious of anyone that might try to muscle in on their oncoming glory.
- Discovery is a team game, with multiple explorer guilds working together to find the safest ways to access untouched regions.
- Some explorers bribe the comet-nosed moles of the Den of Roots to zoom them out as far as possible, surfacing through molehills into lands never before touched by bugly feet.

THE DEN OF ROOTS

What better salve could there be for the vast greenosity of the Hogwild than to dip beneath it, to wrap yourself in comfortable darkness and chart the roots of its mighty trees? Cocoa, you say? Fie on you, blast and fie!

The Den of Roots sits below the hoggish forest, a pitch-black realm of comet-nosed moles and twisting pathways, earthen tunnels and underground streams. Call out as loud as your bugly lungs can manage, and your echo might just find you there in the black.

MOLE-PATHS & ROOTROADS (feature)

While you can walk the dirt of the caverns if the mood takes you, the fastest way to traverse the Den is by using either walkways of knotted wood that spiral down from the ceiling (in larger, open spaces) or tunnels left by travelling moles (to move from chasm to great underground chasm). *Maybe...*

- There's a faster way, if you're good at bartering or making friends. Comet-nosed moles have little interest in eating surface-bugs, and might let you hitch a ride as they scramble from place to place.
- Useful paths along the hanging roots are picked out with lit matches, glow-in-the-dark stickers, or luminescent fungus. *But who has taken so much care to light the way, given that most bugs can see in the dark just as well as they can in daylight?*
- The interior portions of larger roots have been hollowed out, acting like massive waterslides. Great for descending, but a real pain to climb back up on.

UNDULATE (landmark)

This is where the worms live! Not all of them, obviously, but a pretty large amount. The walls of Undulate are made from scavenged stones and reinforced wood, and no mole is permitted within shouting distance of the city. *Maybe...*

- There's an agreement between the comet-noses and the denizens of Undulate, that earthworms are off the menu if they pay the right kind of tribute.
- The city is on constant alert against furry, burrowing beasts, but throws its gates wide open for buggish visitors that might bring news of the world above. Unless... You're not a mole in disguise, are you? Worms don't have the best eyesight.
- Undulate might not look too big from the outside, but the tunnels beneath it stretch throughout the entirety of the Den.

EXPLORING THE DEN OF ROOTS

When a band of bugs travels the dark spaces beneath the forest, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: A root shaped like a prancing horse.
2: A chasm with an underground stream at the bottom.
3: A huge field of glowing mushrooms.
4: A buried trowel, turned into a good-luck shrine.
5: An opening to the world above, harsh and bright.
6: A fossilized rabbit holding the tatters of a map.

NPCs

1: **Gleeb**, an earthworm of no particular note.
2: **Lonestar**, a trio of termites with a self-made revolver.
3: **Massif**, a mole on the hunt for golden treasure.
4: **Betsy**, an earthworm artist in search of a muse.
5: **Oscar Traquino**, a flatworm hunter.
6: **All on Course**, a silent termite judge.

Events

1: A swift stampede of comet-nosed moles.
2: A grinding of stone on stone in the darkness.
3: A root animates, lashes out for water.
4: A group of earthworms defend themselves, poorly.
5: A runt mole left alone and weeping.
6: A great movement of earth - something huge is burrowing nearby, bigger than a mole by far.

KING'S RIVER

Though the Hogwild tends to hide its dangers behind curtains of long grass and thickets of thorns, King's River stands proud and deadly without the need for obfuscation; a winding blade of water that slices the forest in two, rapids strong enough that even the hogs don't dare swim them.

One might expect bridges to have been built, and in truth there are a couple of crossing points (a fallen tree that's half-submerged, a beaver dam with rickety scaffolds). Even so, for the majority of bugs the most reliable way to cross the churn is with the aid of the local dragonfly kingdom. Safety doesn't come cheap, though...

DRAGONFLY RAFTS (feature)

Made from old tupperware and refurbished takeaway containers, the rafts are pulled from one side of the river to the other by a cadre of elite dragonfly aeronauts clutching triple-wound strings. *Maybe...*

- The safety record of the rafts is second to none, the aeronauts taking their job extremely seriously.
- Passage on the rafts is paid for mid-stream. A lack of appropriate payment might lead to an unfortunate accident that definitely wasn't planned in advance and heavily hinted at with a lot of winking, nudging, and pointed gesturing.
- Though the river presents a clear and present danger, it's actually the other creatures that call the area home that represent the real threat.

THE ODONATSAR (npc)

More commonly known as the **Dragonfly King**, this high-minded monarch has immersed himself (not literally, that would be ridiculous) in the river's profit-making opportunities. None can deny that the kingdom is flourishing, though even some dragonflies whisper that they might be taking things too far. *Maybe...*

- The king's first decree was to begin charging bugs to cross the river via dragonfly raft, a service that under previous monarchs had historically been free.
- It's not the king's fault that his policies are so mercantile - if anything it's the fault of the advisors, who keep him isolated from the views of the average bug and present all payment the kingdom receives as 'willingly given tribute'. Does he even suspect what's happening in his own lands?
- The seat of dragonfly power, a hanging castle known as **Lush**, inches closer to the raging waters beneath every week. Sabotage? No, merely the weight of all of the raft-payments weighing down the branch it hangs from.

CROAKFUL HOLLOW (landmark)

You can't have a profitable industry without a few rivals springing up to steal your thunder. Croakful Hollow is a reed-and-bullrush dock built on the banks of King's River, the froglin populace casting many a baleful glance toward the hanging palace upstream. *Maybe...*

- Froglin raiders will occasionally attack rafts as they make their way across the river, poking holes in them from beneath with sharpened chopstick spears.
- If one doesn't trust the mercantile leanings of the Odonatsar and his rafters, the froglins of Croakful Hollow present a useful alternative - any one of the amphibious clade dwelling within it could theoretically take a bug from shore to shore, and they don't even ask for payment. *So what's the catch?*
- A secret pact exists between the king of the dragonflies and the Hollow's head honcho, with the froglins paid to look as mean and surly as possible in order to drive bugs toward the official rafting service.

EXPLORING KING'S RIVER

When a band of bugs wishes to cross the river, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

NPCs

1: **Squire Gerald**, a dragonfly aeronaut that lacks tact.
2: **Aesop**, a scorpion that's just trying to cross the river, thank you very much, prejudice be damned.
3: **Kabalon**, a water skimmer running a one-bug ferry.
4: **Petering**, an architect trying to study beaver dams.
5: **Sayo**, an arachnid extreme sports enthusiast.
6: **Natalia**, a severe dragonfly census taker.

Events

1: A raft has been lost to the rapids, crew along with it.
2: A froglin hunting party closes in.
3: A dam collapse upriver fills the water with sticks.
4: A minor revolution brewing in the dragonfly kingdom.
5: A goliath beetle is dejected, too heavy to cross.
6: The river bursts its banks due to a recent storm.

THE SHADOW HOUSE

OVERVIEW

What possible purpose might the Shadow House have fulfilled, before the Mysteriocalypse? Chamber after vast chamber, an interconnected layer of obstacles and detritus hidden from the sun by thick wooden walls and billowing curtains. One might spend a lifetime exploring arcane cable-paths beneath the floorboards, or simply sit and wile away the hours in the glow of the great and shining mountain.

VIBES

Abandoned: Despite the presence of both bugs and beasts within the walls of the Shadow House, visitors and residents alike agree that, of all of the places in the known world, it feels the most like it was meant to be something else. There isn't just darkness, but a keen absence of light - not just silence, but the sense that sound is on an extended and unplanned vacation. Was this place simply a casualty of the Mysteriocalypse, or is something stranger at play here?

Haunted: Whether or not you personally believe that ghosts exist, the house certainly does. Creaks and unexplained groans cut the omnipresent quiet from time to time, and there are footsteps where no feet can be seen to fall.

Gloomy: If one could but open the tattered curtains... The interior of the Shadow House is, for the most part, locked in an eternal night. There are places in the attic where the sun peeps through, if you believe the tales of travellers, but such spots are few and far between.

Complex: Room after room filled with shroud-covered furniture, ransacked cupboards, mouldering desks. It's not just the clutter that makes navigation difficult though, but the layout of the house itself. Some stairways seem to lead up further than they have any right to, other corridors to connect to rooms that surely couldn't take up that amount of physical space. It would be tempting to say it was a trick of the light, if there was any light around to trick you with.

SHADOWED PARTICULARS

What makes the Shadow House so special? Let's find out together... *These pages cover optional rules, notes on tone, and resources for the Weaver to use in a pinch.*

When bugs are going on tiny adventures within the realm of the Shadow House, consider bringing the following special rules into play. They're not entirely necessary, especially for newer groups, but they should bring some spice into proceedings for more experienced explorers of the world of PICO.

ALL IN DARKNESS (optional rule)

As you might expect, the interior of the Shadow House sits in a near-perpetual state of gloom, broken only by the brief shift of a curtain or the flickering light of an ancient screen. *While shafts of sunlight and televisual glows can count as **light** for various bugly aspects, most areas within the Shadow House are counted as being in a state of permanent **darkness**. It is in the name, after all.*

SCAVENGER'S WONDERLAND (optional rule)

A house built for human-sized inhabitants is titanic to a bug, and the junk and old furniture filling the ancient rooms acts as obstacle, homestead, trap, and treasure trove all at once. Bobs of mysterious purpose are often found lying around the shadow house, but bits are harder to come by unless one finds a larder, kitchen, or long-abandoned plate. *Add a Tough Cut or Camo Cut of 1 to all actions taken to locate or gather bits, and consider giving out positive tags along with any bobs that are found as well.*

WEATHER REPORT (optional rule)

Draughts, burst pipes, and malfunctioning radiators all combine to create a sort of 'internal weather system' for the Shadow House, but it's far more predictable than the weather out in the wilds. *Weather-based events within the house are more locational than time-based - that fireplace is going to keep pumping out heat whether you're there or not.*

THEY SAY IT'S HAUNTED FOR A REASON (optional rule)

Bugs don't tend to dwell on issues of the soul, but anyone that spends enough time in the Shadow House will find their minds drawn to the subject. It's hard to brush off fleeting pale shapes and phantasmal chittering as 'a trick of the light' when there's so little light to begin with. *Page 298 gives a special set of rules for a specific 'Manifestation' track, one that would suit bugs and Weavers wanting to explore beyond the veil or play up the potential horror elements of the area - feel free to use it in any part of the Shadow House for a spookier feel!*

HIGH OR LOW WEIRDNESS?

The Shadow House is going to be an odd sort of place to explore no matter the tone of your game, but the level of weirdness is still easy enough to adjust to fit the way your group sees the world.

For High Weirdness: Play up the haunted elements of the location, and bring them into the physical building as well. Some corridors are cavernously large, others barely big enough for a bug to fit through, yet others seeming to twist against gravity as bugs traverse them. The house is a labyrinth, a lovecraftian structure that follows abstract rules.

For Medium Weirdness: Include as many 'ancient relics' as you can. The Shining Mountain (page 293) and Winter's Tower (page 297) are both a good start, but think of the trouble you could cause with a malfunctioning microwave, a remote controlled car gone haywire, or a laser pointer.

For Low Weirdness: The house is big, sure, but it can still be understood easily enough. Mouseholes lead to spaces within the walls that are perfect for bugs to crawl around in, the flooded basement is a good source of water, and you can even head up to the attic if you want a dose of healthy sunlight through the crumbling roof.

MANSION OF MYSTERIES

If your players would like to change the world with revelations relevant to the Shadow House, the following list of potential mysteries is a good place to start. *When a player makes a grand discovery and needs to choose a new tiny mystery for their bug to explore, you can suggest one from the list below.*

- Who built the Shadow House?
- Are ghosts even real?
- Where is that creaking coming from?
- Is electricity safe to eat?
- What message does the Shining Mountain bring?
- Can skeletons still move?

POTENTIAL HAZARDS

It's never that easy. *Danger in the Shadow House might come in the form of...*

- **Scuttle-husks** looking for warmth (page 258)
- A nest of **hex-cable hydras** on the prowl (page 242)
- A warren of **beastmice** scrabbling around for soda in an old kitchen, or living within the walls (page 212)
- **Cordychaps** hoping to find new converts (page 222)
- **Bugbarian** pirates sailing the dingy waters of the basement sea (page 215)
- **Dracobats** in the attic at night (page 224)
- **Lactogeists** trapped in an old fridge (page 244)
- **Scavenjars** tottering in the uncanny mist (page 255)

USEFUL LOOT

There are bobs galore to be found throughout the Shadow House, but bits are a bit thinner on the ground. *The following lists of both should help if you ever need to give a reward to the players for exploration and rummaging about.*

Local Bits: Lost Toffee, Discarded Lollipop, Mousetrap Cheese, Mouldy Sausage, House Mushroom, Carpet Spore, Chocolate Coin

Local Bobs: Soda Fluff, Bent Wire, Carpet Fibres, Fridge Magnet, LED, Teaspoon, Bent Nail, Rusted Screw, Wooden Splinter, Twisty Bottlecap, Old Receipt, Shiny Nickel, Fork Trident

LOCAL FACTIONS

Vast and sprawling, the bright points of life scattered among the Shadow House's rooms stand out like beacons in the dark (sometimes literally). *The following pages detail the main factions of the Shadow House, the **Indomitables** and the **Sparkchompers**.*

THE INDOMITABLES

General Mood: Brave and fearful in equal amounts
Home Turf: The Hundred Chambers

Few actually see ghosts traversing the Hundred Chambers, but if legends are to be believed, the chance is always there. The Indomitables (and yes, they named themselves, and yes, they were being very serious) are a group of treasure-hunting bugs that search the rooms of Shadow House for mysterious goodies. This is made more difficult than one might expect due to each of them wearing something to cover their eyes at all times, ranging from a blindfold to a bag over the head. Remember, if you can't see a ghost, it can't see you either. That's *science*, that is.

A HOUSE WITHIN A HOUSE (landmark)

What better place for the Indomitables to call home than a smaller version of the structure they spend their lives exploring? While some high-ranking Indomitables have bases and outposts of their own, most start their training in the House Within a House - a doll's house left on a table within the Hundred Chambers that's almost the perfect size for bugly inhabitants. *Maybe...*

- The known ghosts of the wider house (if they exist) are represented in candlewax miniature within this tiny reclaimed replica. They move on their own, too...
- Some say that the layout of the Shadow House changes over time. If it does so, the same must surely be true of the Indomitables' seat of power. But would they even notice?
- The Indomitables are actually pretty brave, in their own way - they may have an irrational fear of spirits, but they can take on every other danger of the house even with their eyes closed (literally). A lot of this is thanks to the rigorous training offered at the House Within a House.

SIGHT BEYOND SIGHT (npcs)

The newest Indomitables stay close to the doll's house they call home, marking their paths with string to avoid getting lost. The most experienced, though, are a different breed entirely.

- **Olgenfrold**, a scorpion who keeps their stinger in front of their eyes at all times. Not known for their directional savvy, but unexpectedly wise in the history of the pre-Mysteriocalypse.
- **Pease Pottage**, a wise and snailish sage that styles themselves the leader of the Indomitables, hasn't emerged from her shell in over a thousand years. *This one's almost definitely not true, just to be clear*.
- **Li Cheng** is the House's number one expert in ghosts and hauntings, though - as you might expect - he's never actually seen a ghost himself. He's sure felt their presence though, and with bell and matches sent them plunging right back into the deeper shadows beyond (or so he says).
- **Cassandra**, the only member of the Indomitables who shuns their eye-covering practices.

TREASURE HUNTING (feature)

There's a rich history behind the wanderings of various Indomitable groups - with enough fumbling, you're bound to find something of great interest! *Maybe...*

- The House Within A House holds a small museum where the Indomitables display their greatest finds to visitors. If they weren't wearing eye coverings, they'd probably have realized that half of the display cases are empty - doubtless the work of an experienced cat burglar with little regard for tradition.
- There's a whole city of Indomitables inside a broken drawer in one of the chambers nearest the old front door, found by one of the first wanderers. Why leave the doll's house for a drawer? So they don't accidentally fall off the edge of anything, most likely.
- Every now and then, an Indomitable stumbles upon an exit to the Shadow House. The relics they bring back from the world outside are some of the most highly prized of all.

THE SPARKCHOMPERS

General Mood: Hungry!
Home Turf: The Cable Maze

Bugly delicacies are as varied as bugs themselves. Some chow down on roasted mushrooms, where others prefer a well-aged acorn brew. Plastic might not be the tastiest thing in the world, but you can bet some bugs go mad for the stuff. To put it simply, whenever there's something that could theoretically *be* eaten, you'll find a bug somewhere that's evolved *to* eat it. That said, Sparkchompers are still regarded as a little odd by most other bugs. "It's so spicy" they say, and "you don't know what you're missing" - but creating an entire society around the desire to chow down on things that make you go *bzzzt* is still quite an odd thing to do. It takes all sorts to make a world, I suppose!

AN UNCOMPLICATED LOT (feature)

While the Indomitables survive the Shadow House with strict rules and discipline, the general opinion of the Sparkchompers is that they might just be too bone-headed to die. *Maybe...*

- Sparkchompers are on to something - once you get past the immediate sizzle of live current, the underlying taste actually *is* deliciously spicy.
- It takes a particular kind of bug to wolf down cables without any ill-effects. Neophyte Sparkchompers are wrapped in insulating rubber and only drip-fed the tiniest fragments of voltage, allowing them to slowly build up a tolerance to the real thing.
- Though they look like bugs to the casual observer, anyone that spends time around Sparkchompers will slowly realize that they're actually tiny constructs powered by the electricity they consume.

LIVE BRIGHT, DIE... NEVER? (npcs)

Somehow, these named individuals are still alive and scuttling within the bounds of the Shadow House.

- **Brian Bryte**, a praying mantis who absorbs electrical current through their blackened claws. The people around Brian keep trying to convince him that he's actually haunted by a very visible ghost that looks remarkably like an elderly version of him, but he insists (honestly) that he really can't see or hear it.
- **Galvana**, a long-legged and patiently maternal figure whose children head out into the Cable Maze to gather her bushels of voltage. What does she do with them? Why, cooks elaborate and electrifying meals, of course!
- **Storm Solo**. There are very few bugs that have a reputation for being inherently cool. Storm Solo definitely is *not* one of these few, though desperately wishes she was.

A HAUNTED TRAVEL GUIDE

A jaunt through the Shadow House? Not for the faint of heart, I tell you that.

There are, some say, two Shadow Houses. The physical one, that's solid but creaking, damp and ancient, dark as a tomb and almost as quiet? That's the one that's easy enough to traverse, if you take advice from the locals and steer clear of rifts in the floor. But the other house, the one that's somehow more shaded, more spectral? That's the one you might wander into if you go chasing ghosts, or follow a noise you can't quite place... And it's far harder to escape. *The entries below all represent distinct areas of the Shadow House that a band of bugs might stumble upon as they travel, as well as the features and landmarks they could encounter.*

THE HUNDRED CHAMBERS

Bugs are, as I think we've previously mentioned, not exactly natural mathematicians - accurate counting just isn't in their wheelhouse. They're also very small, tend to be easily impressed, and are extremely prone to exaggeration.

I want you to keep these facts in mind when I tell you that the Hundred Chambers (or so bugs call the interconnected rooms, closet, stairways, and cupboards of the Shadow House) really are very, *very* large, and far more numerous than most tiny explorers imagine.

AFTERNOON TEA (landmark)

A tabletop town built up around a dusty teapot and a terminally chipped set of china. The inhabitants of Afternoon Tea are friendly to visitors, as long as they bring news of the bright outside. *Maybe...*

- The teapot's interior is still warm even after all these years, and every week a festival is held where locals and visitors alike can drink the elixir within.
- The mayor, one Cassius Crumpet, has wrapped themselves up in a ceremonial doily and refuses to take it off.
- The town is in shambles after the theft of a silver teaspoon, one of their most prized possessions. No single bug could be strong enough to lift it - is there a gang of thieves at work on the streets of Afternoon Tea, or is the problem of a more titanic nature?

UNSTABLE FOUNDATIONS (feature)

Though the House is grand and imposing from the outside, the decrepit state of its interior rooms shows a slow but sure slide toward enduring entropy. *Maybe...*

- Rotten planks and gaping holes spoil the hardwood floor, leading down to a sloshing, basement-level sea (see page 297 for details). Either that or ancient shag carpet, a fibrous jungle taller than a bug's antennae.
- Dust-coated furniture, some partially covered in old sheets like ghostly billowing monuments. Who knows what terrors, or mysteries, lie in the deeper darkness beneath them?
- The planks creak like an old ship in a storm... Most of the time, at least. In moments of unexpected silence, all of the local bugs run for higher ground.

THE SILKEN RAILS (feature)

With the chamber floors clogged with detritus and often less than perfectly preserved against rot, many bugs choose to travel by sideboard and tabletop as they venture from room to room. For those in a rush, or that want to travel in style, a network of silken rail lines run by local spider engineers (suspended between the various items of furniture scattered around) is a godsend. *Maybe...*

- The spiders don't need trains to carry passengers, preferring to load up spinneret palanquins instead.
- The rail lines are technically owned by the Indomitables (see next column), and the arachnid engineers that put them together did so while blindfolded - with interesting results.
- You can ride the rails without buying a ticket, but few that try to do so ever reach their destination. They definitely end up somewhere, though...

THE SHINING MOUNTAIN (landmark)

The most famous relic of the pre-Mysteriocalypse, the Shining Mountain is a wood-and-metal behemoth with a glowing glass screen, endlessly playing ancient and colourful propaganda. *Maybe...*

- The TV's glow is bright enough to cut through the Shadow House's usual veil of gloom, but also acts as a dangerous, mesmerizing distraction.
- The images are colourful, but the mountain is on mute. Maybe finding the fabled remote could change that (it will definitely be down the back of a sofa).
- A picnicking cult of moths has taken up residence on the bony legs of a giant skeleton, a sightless watcher of the world's last broadcast reclining upon a sofa facing the screen. A little morbid? Perhaps, but the spread they offer is *delicious*.

CASPIAN THREE-CLAWS (titan)

A local cat king that haunts the darkest shadows beneath side tables and ottomans - he can be bargained with if you can find him, but what he longs for more than anything is the thrill of a good (and potentially lethal) hunt. *Maybe...*

- Caspian's name comes from the three golden claws on his front left paw. Could they be rubbed to grant wishes? Probably not, but you know how rumours spread these days.
- Caspian likes to portray the image of an aloof hunter, but really he spends so much time under the furniture of the Hundred Chambers because he's lonely and doesn't know how to make friends.
- Caspian has a collar, if you look deep among his wild mane of fur, and the name inscribed upon it is definitely not 'Caspian'.

EXPLORING THE HUNDRED CHAMBERS

When a band of bugs travels the House's sprawling rooms, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: A threadbare dust cover blowing in the wind.
2: A candlestick with a single candle still somehow burning, shedding a pleasing glow.
3: A rift in the floorboards, and the gleam of water below.
4: An Indomitable outpost marked with a blank flag.
5: A pile of ceiling-stuff, all foam and flecks, on the floor.
6: A once-luxurious sofa that's slowly decomposing.

NPCs

1: **Sightless Saloma**, an Indomitable aphid loot-seeker.
2: **Ramo**, a bandit spider banned from the Silken Rails.
3: **Federis**, a thornbug salesman with a cart full of ghost-hunting equipment.
4: **Kraa**, a mukade fisherbug on a mission.
5: **Nina**, a would-be Sparkchomper searching for cables.
6: **Robenbork**, a many-legged inventor and tinkerer.

Events

1: A group of Indomitables fleeing a low growl.
2: A wisp of silk floating - or, wait, is that silk?
3: A corridor leading somewhere it has no right to lead.
4: A sudden crash as an ancient table collapses.
5: A patch of sunlight through a curtain, with bugs from distant chambers throwing an impromptu festival.
6: A local guide, peepers covered but antennae wiggling.

THE CABLE MAZE

Found within the partially hollow walls of the Shadow House, the maze is a vertical tangle of old electrical cables, sparking machinery, and exposed nails. While the interior of the walls is larger than one might expect (for a bug, at least), there are still places that are a mighty tight squeeze for even the smallest explorer.

The upside of these small spaces is a lack of titan-sized predators, but unfortunately the almost comical dangers of a space full of arcing discharge and choking dust render that point partially moot.

SPARKS & DUST (feature)

More than one gang of adventuring bugs has gotten hopelessly lost within the Cable Maze by trying to avoid the most obvious electrical dangers. Unfortunately, straying from the flickering (and potentially deadly) light of frayed wires and malfunctioning connections leads one into little else but dust dens and darkness, no matter how good a pathfinder you have in your band. *Maybe...*

- The 'maze' is actually pretty easy to navigate if you follow the cables. It's going off-piste that gets you.
- Living dust motes swirl in the lightless corners of the maze, hungry for stories from the light-filled world outside (and maybe more). Are these what people call ghosts, these will-o-wisps trapped here in the dark? Or is that something else entirely?
- Local legends speak of the Dust Devil, a monster stalking through the maze of wires and old nails on an endless hunt for bugs to... Eat? Steal? Clean? The legends really aren't that clear.

EXPLORING THE CABLE MAZE

When a band of bugs moves within the walls, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: A spark-wreathed fusebox.
2: The empty exoskeleton of a huge insectile ancestor.
3: The remains of a cable-fire, scorched plastic and exposed wiring.
4: A set of splintered boards in the inner wall.
5: A patch of pulsing phosphorescent mushrooms.
6: A scaffold of mouse bones.

NPCs

1: **Ganache**, a stag beetle with intricate tattoos.
2: **Lemuel**, a moth with choice paralysis.
3: **Pyotr**, a glowing, Sparkchomping slug.
4: **De La Day**, a crafter of lamps and torches.
5: **Skaldir**, an eerie songstress cricket in white robes.
6: **Foothold**, a flat-headed caterpillar.

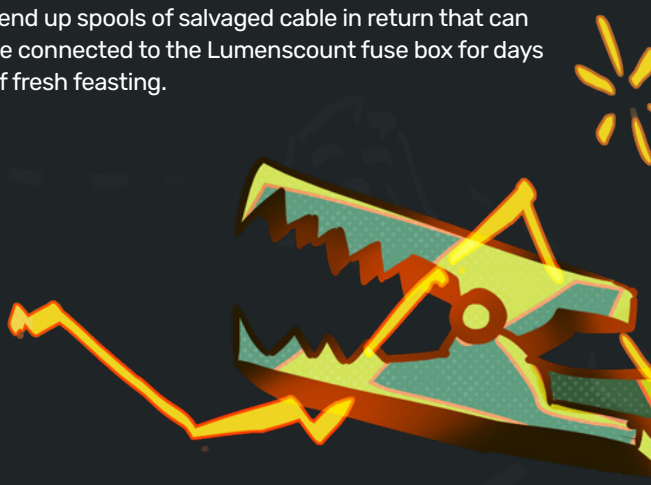
Events

1: A whipping nest of hydra cables inching closer.
2: A yowl from somewhere far away.
3: Dust motes coalescing at the edge of your torchlight.
4: A Sparkchomper feast plunging rooms into darkness.
5: A standoff, Sparkchompers versus Indomitables.
6: A chill in the air - a ghost is near.

LUMENSCOUNT (landmark)

The capital city of the Sparkchompers. This ever-bright citadel is clustered around a damaged fuse box, but the seemingly endless power it supplies is still carefully rationed out to the hungry populace. *Maybe...*

- Millicent Teska, the city's ruler, is a stag beetle hailing from a far-off land of leaves and sunshine. It was she that first discovered the joys of edible electricity.
- Most of the inhabitants don't know it, but the city is actually on its last pack of fuses. When they're blown, the lights go out... forever.
- A healthy trade exists between the local Sparkchompers and the Toolbox Pirates that sail the Underboard Ocean. The former recharge the batteries for their figurehead flashlight, and the latter send up spools of salvaged cable in return that can be connected to the Lumenscount fuse box for days of fresh feasting.



LITTLE LOST THINGS (feature)

They don't call it a maze for nothing - a few wrong turns and you're looking at weeks of frustrating backtracking, or a lifetime of dead ends. *Maybe...*

» You find **Wernerus Harkstrombolini**, a knight of the Iron Order, who has been banished to the maze as punishment for the loss of his ceremonial weapons. He spends his time searching for a scrap of metal or an old nail worthy of being reshaped into a replacement blade - only when he's found one will he leave the Shadow House and venture back out into the light.
» Some say that the earliest Sparkchompers were driven to their cable-chewing habits not by choice, but by desperation - with precious little to eat within the maze, a band of terminally lost bugs long ago became the genesis of the culinary culture that dominates the area to this day.
» If you need a map, find **Mavis Maeves**, wanderer of wires and cartographer of cables. Just follow the trail of pheromones she leaves behind!

A MATTER OF MOUSEHOLES (feature)

There aren't that many ways to get into the Cable Maze from the rest of the Shadow House... Unless you're willing to brave one of the mouseholes in the skirting board. *Maybe...*

» These holes are long-abandoned by the furry beasts that chewed them, and are now instead policed by a particularly grumpy group of Sparkchompers demanding tribute for passage into their realm.
» The interior walls are just as much a land of mice as they are of bugs, and with precious little infighting too - nowhere else are furry friends and chitinous chaps on such even footing.
» Sparkchomping bugs keep to the upper portions of the maze, and wall-chewing beasts to the lower levels. That's the way it's always been!

ATTICUS RISE

Few inhabitants of the lower floors dare speak of the Shadow House's grand, sprawling roof space - bugs can be a superstitious lot, and the scratching, cawing, squawking, scrabbling sounds up there tend to hold tongues still (do bugs have tongues? Better research that one).

Is this fear warranted? Hard to say, as few that venture there ever return with details. But maybe that's an answer in and of itself.

MISSING SLATES (feature)

The Rise is one of the few places in Shadow House that has a natural day and night cycle, thanks to the large holes in its roof. As to what made those holes, let's hope it was a storm. *Maybe...*

- Atticus Rise is contested territory, the local bugs spending their days scampering from place to place while hoping to avoid the attention of the great feathered predators watching them from the trees outside.
- The roof space is in a constant state of bestial imbalance, with mice ruling the daylight hours and bats taking over when the sun goes down.
- The fear really *is* unwarranted - the creaks and scratches are from branches brushing up against the roofslates.

EXPLORING ATTICUS RISE

When a band of bugs travels the space beneath the roof slates, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: A dusty christmas tree with shining ornaments.
2: A broken stepladder.
3: A suspiciously stained wooden table.
4: A stack of ancient cookery books - delicious!
5: A lone lightbulb swinging perpetually in the breeze.
6: A ragged tear in the roof high above, revealing stars.

NPCs

1: **Reginald**, a friendly dracobat with a broken wing.
2: **Kent**, a fungal gardener who works by moonlight.
3: **Abae**, an arachnid archaeologist.
4: **Gert**, an owl-loving artist with no paints left.
5: **Hibiscus**, a butterfly convinced she's an elfen fae.
6: **Pakaranda**, a trader of ancient literature.

A SALVAGER'S PARADISE (feature)

The attic is even more cluttered than the Hundred Chambers below, full of mouldering boxes and stacks of information-dense magazines. *Maybe...*

- A local settlement is strung with reclaimed Christmas lights, its denizens enjoying a constant yuletide atmosphere.
- Old toolboxes and worktables scattered throughout the attic are an excellent source of pre-Mysteriocalypse electrical components, highly prized by the volt-eating bugs within the Cable Maze.
- A functional racetrack of old model cars keeps the local mice entertained, but all hell breaks loose if the power ever goes out.

THE GREAT FEATHERED ORACLE (titan)

An owl the size of a large dog, wearing sellotaped spectacles and an expression of infinite (if slightly strained) patience. Those seeking the oracle would do well to arrive with a literary gift. *Maybe...*

- The oracle of the attic can be bribed for cryptic information about possible futures, drawn from glossy advert divinations and interpretations of outdated newspaper horoscopes.
- The box that the oracle lives upon is stacked high with prophecy-dense magazines - maybe a glimpse of the future can be stolen, rather than bartered for?
- The oracle is actually a puppet controlled by a team of bugs, made of feathers drifting down from the skirmishes of the rafter castles high above.

THE UNDERBOARD OCEAN

A murky mirror of Atticus Rise, this area is rarely found on purpose - more often a travelling band of bugs will slip through one of the rotten planks of the upper house's hardwood, falling for half an age before entering the ocean with an almighty and rather unpleasant splash.

Escape from the ocean is possible - there's a stairway leading out of the basement, back up to one of the Hundred Chambers - but getting there might require some impromptu sailing, or a very dangerous swim.

TOOLBOX PIRATES (feature)

A band of piratical bugs floating around the great dark ocean in a toolbox bristling with unique, self-made mechanisms. The raiders aren't interested in gold (not that bugs tend to carry that kind of thing around), but they go crazy for springs, buttons, and wires. *Maybe...*

- The pirates aren't exactly subtle types - a powerful flashlight mounted on the front of their clanging ship announces their presence even before their ribald shouts and challenges can be heard.
- The ship they sail, a rusty old toolbox, isn't exactly fit for purpose. While half the crew wave little swords and shout insults, the other half is frantically bailing water over the side.
- The ship is a distraction - the real danger is a submarine made from an old soda bottle that haunts the nearby depths, rising only to strike and plunder.

PUMP TIDES (feature)

The level and flow of the ocean's dark waters change with every surge and dampening of the Shadow House's ancient electrical generator. *Maybe...*

- If the basement's aging pump was given enough juice, the entire Underboard Ocean might drain away in a few days.
- Multiple islands are only above sea level at low tide, populated by local frogs and bubble-carrying water spiders living under an uneasy truce.
- There are rumours of a titan that slips quietly from place to place beneath the dark waters - scaled skin, a long snout, and far too many teeth to be considered polite.

WINTER'S TOWER (landmark)

A fridge in the corner of the basement serves as a grand fortress against the dark, its open door spilling chill brightness out into the surrounding waters. *Maybe...*

- There are no bugs living in Winter's Tower, due to the extreme cold, but managing to scale the mountains of old food and gathered ice inside might just lead an intrepid explorer to the very top (where a way into the Cable Maze might be found).
- A family of woolly bear caterpillars dwell within the crisper drawer, and will protect their frozen kingdom with zeal.
- The pre-Mysteriocalypse food within Winter's Tower has been there long enough to evolve, and is unsettlingly mobile - especially when the fridge's interior light begins to flicker.

EXPLORING THE UNDERBOARD OCEAN

When a band of bugs travels the great basement sea, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: A stack of shelves half-submerged.
2: A colossal teddy bear, now a floating island.
3: A mangrove-like swamp of mushroom stalks.
4: A mechanical angler fish, rusted into place.
5: A window to the outside world, caked in grime.
6: An unmoored wooden boat large enough to fit a horde of cats inside.

NPCs

1: **Ombre**, a brave pond skimmer with a head torch.
2: **Once Through**, an old dragonfly bounty hunter.
3: **Telepen**, once a toolbox pirate, now marooned.
4: **Zeppit**, a bumblebee fisherman who just wants a quiet life.
5: **Bo Usmano**, a pirate-obsessed froglin.
6: **Eska**, a hive-mind of ants in a rather cute lifejacket.

THE MIST-MANSE

If you've ended up here, something has gone **terribly** wrong.

The Mist-Manse doesn't sit within the crumbling walls of the Shadow-House, not exactly - in fact, some bugs would posit that it doesn't actually exist within the bounds of the physical world at all. As best as anyone can figure out it's a kind of limbo, a version of the real Shadow House picked out in silver mist and vague suggestions.

Finding yourself in the Mist-Manse doesn't mean you're dead... But it's not a place for beating hearts and air-breathing spiracles.

THROUGH A HOUSE, DARKLY (feature)

The Mist-Manse (as far as anyone can tell) is a warped reflection of the Shadow House. It has the same furniture (though somehow even dustier), the same corridors (that now twist off into oblivion), and the same feeling of dangerous abandonment (with altogether too many distant noises to make that entirely believable). But how much more is there to the Mist-Manse's mysteries? *Maybe...*

- Every bug from the Shadow House has a duplicate in the Mist-Manse, a subtly different version of themselves that may or may not have a moustache.
- The Mist-Manse is completely empty of all life save those that get lost there... Or taken there by force.
- Escaping the Mist-Manse is far harder than entering it. Retracing steps rarely works, cartography is next to useless, and if one finds themselves in the gardens or attic without first escaping the uncanny mist they might discover that the sun refuses to rise.

TRIP OF A LIFETIME (feature)

There are a couple of ways one might enter the Mist-Manse on purpose, though why a bug would actually want to go there is anyone's guess. *Maybe...*

- Scavenjars seem to treat the mists of the manse as their home, and they're eager to bring guests. These unusual constructs venture out into the house from time to time, taking the mists with them for cover, to seal unwary bugs within their jarlike heads. Once trapped, these bugs are taken back to the Mist-Manse to be safely released. *If they're lucky.*
- There's a strong superstition among some bugs that beastmice don't know when to stop tunneling, and will sometimes rip holes right through the fabric of reality without meaning to. Perhaps someone left a clove in there or something.
- You thought sleep was safe? Think again. If travelling bugs nap too close to the undefined border of the manse, the mists may claim them as they wake.

MANIFESTATIONS (feature)

A chill in the air, a breath on your shoulder, a knock at the door but there's nobody there... That's a haunting, no doubt about it.

When bugs are exploring the Mist-Manse (or perhaps even the least-frequented areas of the Shadow House proper), the Weaver might set a 'Manifestation' track of 2 to 4 boxes. This track is marked whenever a player mentions the mist or darkness, or how their bug deals with it, and when full the group are subject to a *ghostly happening* (though whether it's genuine spiritual activity is very much up to the tone of the group).

Take the list below as **examples** - don't be afraid to ask a player what their bug experiences when the last box fills, or even to give different information to different players via notes or whispers to stoke up the fear of the great spiritual unknown. *And remember, ghostly happenings are a great way to pull a bug's mood toward the negative, but relief after realizing something isn't ghostly might just push it positive instead.*

- A sudden chill - or just a breeze.
- A hellish creak... Of settling floorboards. Or perhaps of a scavenjar's limbs!
- A skittering shape caught on the fringe of your senses. Not actually a ghost, more likely a bug.
- Dark laughter, that sounds on closer inspection like water gurgling through an old pipe.
- A knock at the door. A good jumpscare moment, but really usually just means someone wants to come in.
- A real, actual ghost! Oh wait, it's just dust catching the light.

Exploring the Mist-Manse

When an intrepid band of bugs explores a place they *really should not be exploring*, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: A corridor that curves like a millipede's back.
2: A wall riddled with mouseholes, too high and too large to have actually been made by mice.
3: A pile of shell-husks as tall as a chest of drawers.
4: A room full of broken jars.
5: A translucent stand of plants growing from a forest of grey-patterned vases.
6: A huge chunk of fallen ceiling, revealing a perfect mirror of the room below to anyone brave enough to gaze up through the hole it left behind - complete with said watcher, inverted and confused.

Events

1: Scavenjars stride by, but they don't even seem to notice the bugs they pass.
2: The mist in the manse is ever-present, but sometimes it intensifies to the point where it's like wading through a dim grey soup. This is one of those times.
3: The bugs pass a partially-shrouded mirror, but their reflections don't move quite right.
4: Scuttle-husks swarm, whispering secrets nobody should know.
5: Creaking footfalls, drawing closer.
6: Glass breaks. A flash of light. A long, deep sigh.

"I know we took a left at the big table with the stained sheet, and I KNOW that we went through that mousehole too. We haven't gone through any other doors, and we definitely haven't found any other mouseholes, but... Isn't that the same table? With the same stained sheet? And where did all this mist come from..."

Lopun Nescimet, Praying Mantis Scavenger

SKYGLASS DOME

OVERVIEW

The Mysteriocalypse has been termed, by some bugly historians, as the 'end of an age of order', and perhaps nowhere is this more evident than within the transparent confines of the Skyglass Dome. There are echoes of a less chaotic time - workbenches stacked with rusting tools, sacks of sand that would have dwarfed even a picotitan before they split and spilled, the remnants of a fine iron cage standing stark against the outer sky. But that old world is... Well, not gone, not entirely, but certainly thoroughly *reclaimed*.

The Skyglass Dome now stands as an ecological triumph, a contradiction and a living chaos. Desert dunes stretch between lush, fertile flowerbeds, cacti grow in the shade of fruiting vines. The glass panelling that once kept the outside world at bay is bloom-covered, stem-choked, and in some places missing entirely.

Some of the Dome's denizens work to maintain the new order, spiky sorts that revel in the spilled sands and the heat of a glass-focused sun. Others want to speed the spread of vegetative chaos, hatching elaborate schemes to break panes and twist metal, and sowing ever more seeds wherever they'll take. One of these sides may even triumph, one day.

But for now, perhaps it's better not to choose a side.

VIBES

Glorious: From curling iron and shining glass to hyperchromatic flora and succulent fruits, the Dome is the closest thing to a paradise most bugs would ever be able to find. If only it was a little bit cooler...

Rowdy: The clash between the Dome's opposing factions is a constant and inescapable fact of life, and even the most peacefully intentioned visitors have a tendency to become embroiled in skirmishes and disagreements if they're not extremely careful.

Tropical: They say there are only two kinds of weather within the realm of the Skyglass, the raging rains and the searing sun. Neither is without benefits, but both carry their own risks. *Staying out on the Compass Dunes after dark lets a bug experience the freezing cold too, but why would anyone want to do that?*

Colourful: Even more so than usual for the world of PICO, given the vast array of dyes and inks that are drawn from blooming petals and oversized fruit.

VIBRANT PARTICULARS

What makes the Skyglass Dome so special? Let's find out together... *These pages cover optional rules, notes on tone, and resources for the Weaver to use in a pinch.*

OPTIONAL RULES

When bugs are going on tiny adventures within the realm of the Skyglass Dome, consider bringing the following special rules into play. They're not entirely necessary, especially for newer groups, but they should bring some spice into proceedings for more experienced explorers of the world of PICO.

SCORCH & FREEZE (optional rule)

The weather within the Skyglass Dome trends toward the extreme, even on the calmest days - if bugs aren't contending with amplified sunlight, they're likely either huddling together for warmth during the freezing nights that hit the realm's central desert or wading through sudden deluges caused by the dome's still-functioning sprinkler system. *While within the Dome, the default weather throughout the daylight hours is **Heatwave**, and during the night it's **Cold Snap** (page 95). Plus, while the fringes of the Dome protect its dwellers from outside weather like sporenadoes and gales, the activation of the sprinkler system brings a sudden and powerful **Rainstorm** without fail, to the extent that some of the overgrown tropical areas become easier to swim than wade through.*

HOT HOT HEAT (optional rule)

As long as the sun is shining, there's no such thing as 'pleasantly warm' among the central sands and outer jungles of the Dome. *When in areas touched by sunlight that's been focused through the Dome's glass panelling, all Sizzle Damage bugs deal gains increased impact, and all Sizzle Damage bugs take is increased by 2 marks. It's also harder to heal and rest without shade - bugs can't use a task to benefit from Natural Healing unless they've found a spot out of the sun's glare.*

MIRAGES (optional rule)

What's that in the distance? To be honest, I really couldn't tell you! *Mirages and distortions are an everyday part of life while the sun is shining, and it's almost impossible to accurately identify distant objects, structures, or hazards if they're in direct sunlight. Mechanically, the Weaver might add a Camo Cut of 1 to actions requiring clarity of vision over distance, but should also bring this shimmering uncertainty into the narrative as well - judging dimensions accurately is better done at night, and some things glimpsed on the horizon might not even be real at all!*

HIGH OR LOW WEIRDNESS?

The Skyglass Dome is an easy place to crank up the weirdness; you've got wild weather, scuffles between factions, and the inability to trust one's own eyes to play with. That being said, weirdness is still optional - the suggestions below should help you find some appropriate ways to highlight the level of strange your very own version of the Skyglass Dome exhibits.

For High Weirdness: Mirages may not have substance, but that doesn't preclude them from having *intent*. With high weirdness, treat the mirages of the Skyglass Dome's desert as something of a third faction, a band of semi-living illusions with unknown goals and mysterious powers. Do they help or hinder visiting bugs? Where do they go when the sun hides below the horizon? And, perhaps most importantly, are they *hungry*?

For Medium Weirdness: Focusing on the oddities of weather is a great way to set a consistent tone of 'weird, but not too weird'. Play up the sweaty closeness of the daylight air and the isolating cold of the nights, and use the Dome's sprinkler system to change the terrain mid-scene for additional challenges.

For Low Weirdness: Whether a hothouse or greenhouse, the Dome was once a prime location for the growth of plants that wouldn't fit the surrounding climate. For the least weird game possible, remove the sentient cactoids and instead treat spiky plants as an immobile, rather than roving, hazard.

MIRAGES MANIFEST

If your players would like to change the world with revelations relevant to the Skyglass Dome, the following list of potential mysteries is a good place to start. *When a player makes a grand discovery and needs to choose a new tiny mystery for their bug to explore, you can suggest one from the list below.*

- Why does the air shimmer in sunlight?
- Where does glass come from?
- Which stars still shine beneath the Dome?
- How do illusions take shape?
- Do seeds know they're going to be plants one day?
- When will the night end?

POTENTIAL HAZARDS

You mean, apart from the weather? If you need some more tangible and immediate hazards, you might find these useful. *Danger in the Skyglass Dome might come in the form of...*

- **Striding spikers** to represent the Needle-Nobles, the proud architects of the Compass Dunes who will stop at nothing to protect their home (page 262)
- **Predatory plants**, perhaps even more present within the dome than in the outside world due to the perfect growing conditions (page 250)
- **Munchmeleons**, terrifying camouflaged predators with a taste for softened chitin (page 249)
- **Quetzalcroakl** lurking in deceptively placid sprinkler-fed pools (page 253)
- **Heirloomers** patrolling the dunes, their bugly pilots the last line of defence against the local bug-eating vegetation (page 239)
- **Hekatantonopedes**, truly massive bugs that thrive in the tropical areas of the dome thanks to the heat and moisture (page 240)

USEFUL LOOT

While the deserts at the centre of the dome might produce pretty slim pickings in terms or bits and bobs, the more verdant outer areas (as well as the overgrown worktables and flowerbeds) are absolutely rife with stuff to grab. *The following lists of both should help if you ever need to give a reward to the players for exploration and rummaging about.*

Local Bits: Hyperchromatic Petal, Camouflaged Bud, New Sprout, Cactus Spine, Shining Sand Grains, Pepper-Ink, Heat-Split Seeds, Purple Dye, Impossible Fragment of a Living Mirage, Tenacious Frost, Chitineleton Pieces, Fruit Segment

Local Bobs: Pile of Rust Flecks, Iron Splinter, Shard of Glass, Pottery Scraps, Sewn Waterskin, Husk Sunshade, Dye-Grinder, Skyglass Cloth, Refracting Jewel, Empty Seed Packet, Gardening Twine

LOCAL FACTIONS

Some characterize the constant back-and-forth of the Dome as a war; petal versus sand, spine against claw. In actuality it's more like a dance, a tango of order and chaos that swells with the dawn and subsides each night. *The following pages detail the main factions of the Skyglass Dome, the **Needle-Nobles** and the **Bringers of Bloom**.*

THE NEEDLE-NOBLES

General Mood: Patient, prideful yet forgiving
Home Turf: The Compass Dunes

Bugs may consider themselves the inheritors of the post-M world, but among the vast deserts of the Compass Dunes, it's cactoid life that flourishes best. The Needle-Nobles are the spiky green protectors of calm, seeing the golden sands of the Dome's central expanse as a haven of serenity amid the lush madness of the outer grow beds.

AN ANCIENT LINEAGE (feature)

Those are just spiky plants, I hear you cry, *and plants aren't walking around types!* Well, that may have been true in the days before the Mysteriocalypse, but the times? They are a-changin'. *Maybe...*

- The Needle-Nobles consider themselves architects, but very rarely build lasting structures. Instead they throw together temporary dwellings wherever they stop to sleep, specifically engineered to hold the last vestiges of the sun's warmth as the cold sets in. They're even willing to let wandering bugs take shelter with them for a night, in exchange for some good campfire conversation.
- Many Needle-Nobles claim to remember the pre-M years like they were yesterday, giving confusing reports of gloves and tongs and huge, fleshy titans that were too afraid to touch them.
- If you meet one of the Needle-Nobles, you should ask them about the temperature - it's their favourite topic of conversation. Don't expect a speedy reply though, as they're famed for experiencing life at a slightly slower pace than the average bug. *Maybe bring a book?*
- Many cactoids view the incessant seed-planting behaviours exhibited by the Bringers of Bloom with a kind of exasperated amusement. The dunes are not a place for weaker plants, they argue - it's almost a cruelty to expect specimens from the grow-beds to take root in the desert's harsh climate. Some even take it upon themselves to dig such seeds back up from the sand, returning them to the borders of the Shatterpot Scree (where they're inevitably found, rescued, and re-sown in an endless cycle of frustrated expansion).

THE LONG WALK (feature)

There are few traditions common to the Needle-Nobles, as most of them lead solitary, nomadic lives that only rarely intersect with each other. But one that many view as worthwhile is the 'long walk', a journey around the perimeter of the Compass Dunes that lets them see every other clime the Dome has to offer. *Maybe...*

- The value of the long walk is in learning to appreciate what you have. Once one has experienced the rampant tangle of the Verdant Fringe, the glass-and-metal maze of Stormtotter, and the endless industry of Shatterpot Scree, the calm of the desert is hard to see as anything other than a stoic source of stability.
- Some of the Nobles take the long walk to the extremes, leaving the Dome entirely to wander under the open sky. Most return, but not all.

PRICKLY, BUT NOT IN NATURE (npcs)

Needle-Nobles have a certain reputation for fairness and patience, and are typically respected by the other dwellers of the Skyglass Dome (even in the face of ideological differences).

- **Hobie and Heral**, a pair of Needle-Nobles who met during their long walk and never went their separate ways. Utterly devoted to each other, always smiling (or at least making expressions that pass for a smile on a cactus).
- **Patah**, a towering arbiter of sandy justice. Has a courthouse in the Understar Oasis, which she visits on a schedule none can quite fathom.
- **Karabet**, a wandering musician with a thick-stringed guitar. Though he seems as trustworthy as any other Noble, he'll gleefully trick, mislead, and even rob bugs that he comes across on his travels.

The Bringers of Bloom

General Mood: Optimistic, looking to a greener future
Home Turf: Shatterpot Scree

Standing in stark contrast to the sedate existence preferred by the Dome's more cactoid residents, the Bringers of Bloom are a bugly alliance that relish change, chaos, and progress. Every day is a joyful struggle; against the weather, against convention, against scale and danger and sense. The Bringers believe (broadly speaking, as they're not the kind of bugs that hold their tenets as sacred) that if it's not difficult to achieve, it's not worth achieving in the first place - and what could be more difficult than riding the wild flow of nature itself?

Sowing the Seeds (feature)

While the bugs of this faction can be found engaging in dangerous pursuits all across the realm, they're all ultimately in service of a singular goal - to spread life, colour, and growth to every inch of the great glass dome they call home. *Maybe...*

- Some Bringers venture into the Fruiting Jungle, braving both predatory plants and scaled foes to lay claim to the strongest seeds they can find.
- Others climb the gantries, pipes, and cables of Stormtotter, collecting water and stealing scrap from the dizzying heights.
- And, at some point, every Bringer is expected to head out into the deserts and sow their seeds. It's the one thing that they seem to have in common with the Needle-Nobles, their own botanically motivated version of the long walk - a calling to plant and nurture, even in the face of almost certain failure.

Never Gonna Give You Up (npcs)

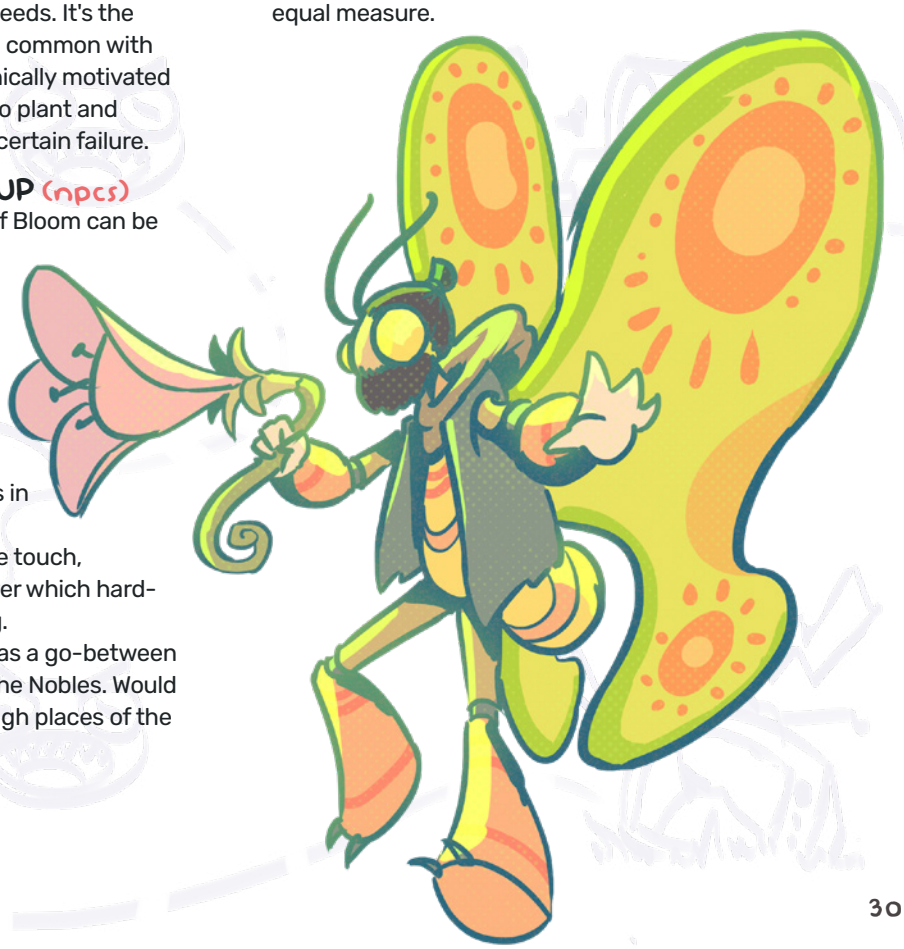
Most bugs belonging to the Bringers of Bloom can be found in their unofficial stronghold, an overgrown workbench nestled among the detritus of Shatterpot Scree... but only when recovering between ill-advised excursions.

- **Makori Spatz**, a water-skimmer determined to adapt to a life of surfing the desert sands with seeds in tow. An excellent flautist, too.
- **Bea**, a large scorpion with a delicate touch, something of a quality controller over which hard-won seeds are released for planting.
- **Frisk**, a spiny green beetle chosen as a go-between when deals need to be made with the Nobles. Would much rather be climbing the wet, high places of the Dome, but rarely shirks his duty.

Creative Outlets (feature)

Sometimes it's nice to tackle tasks that may actually come to fruition. Whenever one of the Bringers gets frustrated at a lack of progress toward their ultimate goal, they turn to art, music, and crafting until the feeling subsides. *Maybe...*

- They attack such tasks with uncommon vigour - no sense in slowing down, no time to truly rest!
- Their products aren't always beautiful, but no one could ever accuse them of a lack of creativity.
- Some of the faction's bugs become so skilled in their chosen outlets that they leave the business of seed-sowing to others, earning them respect and ire in equal measure.



A SWEAT-DRENCHED TRAVEL GUIDE

The Skyglass Dome hosts some of the most extreme weather conditions of the post-M world, and with them a generous scatter of different biomes too; deserts at the Dome's centre, jungles sprouting up from long-untended growbeds at the outer edge, and ever-misty walkways rigged up around the sprinkler system high above. And if you've ever had a hankering for cactoid encounters, you've definitely come to the right place.

The entries below all represent distinct areas of the Skyglass Dome that a band of bugs might stumble upon as they travel, as well as the features and landmarks they could encounter.

THE COMPASS DUNES

Make sure to pack a waterskin if you're heading out among the sands, and a new set of travelling clothes wouldn't go amiss either; shells may be a great built-in defence for most bugs, but they do tend to heat up to an uncomfortable degree under the glass-magnified glare from above.

ENDLESS SANDS (landmark)

Okay, they're obviously *not* endless - the Compass Dunes are encircled by a tangle of jungle on all sides. But when you're out there, with the sun beating down on you and the sand scouring your little scuttlers, they certainly *feel* endless. *Maybe...*

- There are stones among the sands, and sometimes even discarded junk from the pre-M times. These are few and far between, but are excellent at blocking the sun for a spell.
- A striding cactus is easy to spot among the sands, but hard to catch up to.
- Distance is difficult to judge at the best of times, but when the sun is at its strongest, mirages and tricks of the light make it almost impossible to accurately get one's bearings.

THE MERCILESS HEAT (feature)

While the Dunes are cold by night (and occasionally made briefly wet by the malfunctioning sprinklers in the Dome's upper recesses), it's the long, hot days that stick in the mind. *Maybe...*

- Shadow is such a rare find that stumbling upon some lifts moods dramatically. Just don't tarry for too long, as the biting chill of night won't be quite the relief from the elements that you might expect.
- Predatory plants from the jungle areas at the edges of the desert sometimes venture into the Compass Dunes, but don't have the staying power of the local cactesque sorts.
- If there are any permanent sources of water outside of the Understar Oasis, they haven't been found yet. *Or perhaps they have, and someone's jealously guarding them in secret?*

THUNDER-NEVER-SLEEPS (titan)

A hekatantonopede with a distinctive red and black carapace, this grand scuttler only ever appears after a deluge from the Stormtotter sprinkler systems drenches the desert sands. *Maybe...*

- The titan's course is impossible to anticipate, but always takes it from one edge of the Dunes to another. It's logical to assume that it must reside somewhere in the Verdant Fringe the rest of the time, but no bugs local to the area ever report stumbling across it amongst the Fruiting Jungle.
- The appearance of Thunder-Never-Sleeps marks a kind of local festival, somewhere between sport and celebration; daredevils, both spiky and shelled, try to intercept and mount the titan as it steamrolls through the sands. *Not an easy task.*

ALL THAT GLITTERS (feature)

If you've never seen a mirage, it can be hard to understand just how *real* they seem. The longer a bug stays in the desert, the more they come to realize that heat plays tricks on more than just the eyes. *Maybe...*

- A sandcastle in the distance reveals itself to be just another hump among the landscape as travellers draw nearer, but... Wait, what about that one over there? Or there? *Or there?*
- **Ophilian Halfcut** is a flightless dragonfly explorer who's been travelling the Dunes for as long as he can remember. You could even walk with him for a spell, share a meal and a drink, but the moment he's out of your sight it's like he was never there at all. *He's convinced he's real, but he's not so sure that you are.*

THE UNDERSTAR OASIS (landmark)

Possibly the only permanent landmark among the endless sands of the Compass Dunes, a haven of blue and green among the rolling gold.

The oasis is fed by a pre-M artefact, a half-buried hose that, if followed, would lead one all the way to the edge of the Dome and beyond. The volume of water the hose dispenses changes throughout the year, gushing during the summer months and slowing to a trickle as the world outside fades to winter, but it never stops entirely.

It's this single important feature that makes the Understar Oasis the perfect meeting place for both Needle-Nobles and Bringers of Bloom, an area of common ground where the desert's peace still reigns but where seeds can also sprout. Nobles stop here every now and then to suck up as much water as they can before resuming their wanderings, and Bringers are permitted to sow seeds along the oasis' edge to make life a little more delicious for local bugs. *Maybe*...

- Bugs love a good meal, and nobody thirsts quite like a cactus. The local chefs use the water-blessed fruits of the oasis to cater to both, providing flesh and rind creations for their bugly customers and energizingly pulpy juices for travel-weary cacti.
- The oasis is named for a peculiarity of the skies above, where a missing pane of glass allows a breathtakingly clear view of the night sky. Some local businesses rent out blankets and fluffy coats to visitors, allowing them to stay up all night despite the desert cold and stargaze to their heart's content.
- The green-and-copper hose that feeds the oasis is marked with ancient text, but neither bug nor Needle-Noble can make heads or tails of what the writing might mean (if it means anything at all).
- **Patah's Courthouse** is only open when Patah herself passes through, allowing her to sit in judgement of any caught breaking the laws of the Dunes. Exactly what these laws are is rarely talked about, and her schedule for holding sessions is, if anything, even more nebulous.

EXPLORING THE COMPASS DUNES

When a band of bugs travels the great sandy expanse, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: An old soda can full of sand, scorching to the touch.
2: A shrivelled plant husk barely an inch tall, the result of a failed planting.
3: A wooden signpost pointing the way to the Understar Oasis. Can it be trusted?
4: A great pool of water that - eh, it was just a mirage.
5: A tangle of piping and glass shards, fallen from far above.
6: A broken caravan, wood bleached white by the sun.

NPCs

1: **Remon**, a friendly Needle-Noble with purple blooms.
2: **Aster**, a dried-out slug who's really regretting this whole 'desert adventure' thing.
3: **Trousers**, a confused moth chasing a heat-haze.
4: **Hoo**, a cactus ascetic meditating on what their ultimate purpose might be.
5: **Kai**, a cheerful scarab beetle stuffed with local lore.
6: **Musket**, a caterpillar calling weakly for water.

Events

1: A trading party of bugs hauling seeds and silks.
2: A Needle-Noble rears up out of the sand as it wakes.
3: Butterflies with brightly dyed wings protecting a dusty plastic bottle, still holding a few drops of water.
4: The sprinklers sputter into life, heralding a brief but powerful storm.
5: An heirloomer striding boldly in the sunlight.
6: A sandstorm blows through, changing the shape of the dunes like a shifting sea.

STORMTOTTER

The dizzying heights of the Dome are a tangle of old tubing, rusted ironwork, invasive mosses, bug-built gantries, and heat-trapping glass. it's a different world up there, a miniature ecosystem of steam and mists that has more in common with the average sauna that the oven-like deserts below.

It's also unexpectedly *planty*, thanks partly to the overgrowth of the Fruiting Jungle that climbs the Skyglass frame and partly to the efforts of the Bringers of Bloom, frequent visitors to this sweltering realm who find it hard to keep their seed-sowing impulses in check.

Watch your footing, and watch your back - you're not alone up here.

SHAPES IN THE MIST (feature)

A rope-bridge, swinging without any associated wind. Scratches on the inside of a glass panel, close enough to touch. The feeling of being watched, and the low terror of not knowing where from. *Maybe...*

- The predatory plants born of the growbed jungles may not be able to deal with the central deserts, but they thrive just as well up in the heights of the Dome as they do on their home turf.
- Where there's limited visibility and mobility, you naturally end up with bandits - bugs willing to put morality aside and prey upon their fellows.
- Some Nobles take the long walk a little more literally than others, braving the jungles and climbing up the internal iron framework of the Dome. But, once they're up in the heights, it can be difficult to find a way down that doesn't involve a terrifying plunge and a very final meeting with the ground.

THE SPRINKLER SYSTEM (landmark)

Spreading throughout the mists of the Dome's tip, this creaking, gushing, rattling mechanism irregularly dumps massive amounts of water on the realm below in the form of artificial storms. *Maybe...*

- While there's no schedule for these downpours, there is a natural early warning system in the form of a growing gurgle from among the pipes.
- The electrical cables feeding the sprinkler system are worn through by the elements, sparking dramatically each time the 'rains' come.
- Most of the deluge is directed toward the jungles at the rim, but even the Compass Dunes gets a quick wash from time to time.
- The walkways between the sprinklers are enduringly slippery, even on the hottest of days. More than one bug has put a tiny foot wrong without thinking and disappeared over the edge, swallowed by the mists.
- As dangerous as they are, the tubes that feed the sprinkler hold fresh, clean water.

NOT UP TO CODE (feature)

If Stormtotter's tangle of walkways and pipework were ever the subject of regular maintenance, that ended with the Mysteriocalypse. *Maybe...*

- Multiple walkways just *end* in midair, without warning sign or safety rail.
- The visiting bugs do their best to patch things up from time to time, but they don't have the architectural skill of the desert denizens down below.

EXPLORING STORMTOTTER

When a band of bugs traverses the heights of the Dome, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: A broken sprinkler-head that never stops dripping.
2: A corkscrew walkway without any handrails.
3: A tangle of vines mingling with the pipework.
4: A missing pane offering access to the outside world.
5: A shrine to climbers, full of soaked gear.
6: A cluster of blooms hiding a sheathless cable.

NPCs

1: **Hektar**, a dung beetle explorer with a jaunty cap.
2: **Min Mato**, a ladybug artist with a blue and black shell.
3: **Albonz**, a squat cactoid with a love for free-climbing.
4: **Moz**, a venus flytrap wrangler with wooden scuttlers.
5: **Quipt**, a termite laden with water-collecting pans.
6: **Kreptin Kurestin**, a long-legged spider bandit preying on visiting bugs.

Events

1: A gout of steam bursts from a sun-bleached pipe.
2: The mists clear, just for a moment. What a view!
3: The walkway you're on creaks and shifts alarmingly.
4: Bringers rush by, dragging chunks of stolen iron.
5: A lithe, vined shape swings through the haze below.
6: The sprinklers shudder into life, drenching everything.

SHATTERPOT SCREE

A small but busy haven near the doorway to the Skyglass Dome, usually the first place stumbled upon by visitors from the outside. The heat is less oppressive here thanks to the breeze from the outside, though it still hits like a hammer when the sun is at its highest.

THE GRAND WORKBENCH (landmark)

A resting place for the Bringers of Bloom, in the scant moments of rest they allow themselves. The workbench is overgrown with colourful flowering plants and cluttered with seed-jars, with bolts of silk and canvas wound between them to offer some shade throughout the day. *Maybe...*

- Though most of the seeds filling the workbench's jars come from the jungles rimming the Dome, fledgeling plants and agricultural knowledge from the wider world are highly prized - visitors bearing such prizes openly can expect to be mobbed by enthusiastic Bringers the moment they reach the bench-top.
- The **Cael Brothers** send regular caravans to the Understar Oasis, allowing bugs from Shatterpot Scree to trade their dyes, cloth, and ceramics for samples of water more pure than the Stormtotter sprinklers can provide. *They'll try to trade seeds too, given the chance, but the Nobles tend to politely ignore them.*
- The open drawers of the bench have been converted to sandy seed-beds, with locals trying out various plant stocks in the hopes of finding some that will take root and flourish out in the dunes. They haven't managed it yet, but it does give younger Bringers the chance to hone their planting skills.
- **Haricot Mace** was a seed-finder once, a frequenter of the grow-bed jungles to either side of the Scree. But those days of fancy are behind them now - they've found a more important calling, which they indulge within a secret compartment at the base of the workbench. *Haricot is one of the few bugs skilled enough to create heirloomers, striding fruit-and-veg based constructs that can be found on page 239.*

THERE ONCE WAS A TOWER (feature)

Shatterpot Scree is named in the classic bugly style of looking around and stringing together whatever words seem most appropriate for the landscape. In this case, it's the massive amount of broken pottery, huge shards of it sticking up among both jungle and sand. It couldn't have been that a group of overly ambitious bugs once tried to rig up some kind of monstrous ceramic bucket-system to catch and channel water from the sprinklers above, could it? No, of course not. That would be absurd! *Maybe...*

- Yeah, that's *exactly* what happened, and it went about as well as you might expect. What few know is that there was actually some help from a secretive collection of Needle-Nobles, needed for their pot-moving strength. Some even whisper that the collapse of the ceramic tower wasn't an accident at all, but some kind of cactoid sabotage!
- **The Patterned Labyrinth** is a local hangout for bugs that leave a bit of their heart in the desert, a collection of painted pottery pieces curving over elaborate sand-floored tunnels. A few bugs swear that mirages hang around there as well, taking well-earned breaks from the desert heat, but that sounds about as possible as it is likely. *Still, the world is more mysterious than many assume...*
- There are no guards posted around the edges of Shatterpot Scree, likely due to the local bugs not being a fan of such sedentary pursuits. This does, however, have the unfortunate side-effect of allowing predatory plants to sneak in from the nearby jungles, but what's life without a little danger?

"The desert's harsh, but that's 'cause it's impatient - it's waiting for us, don't you see? To teach it how to breathe, and burst, and bloom!"

Ixarus Cael, Millipede Orator (and Seventh Brother)

THE FRUITING JUNGLE

A verdant fringe around the rim of the great glass dome, where scaly types frolic and hekatantonopedes thrash. The mulch that makes up the jungle's flooring is artificially placed, remnants of pre-M growbeds that once hosted orderly lines of twine-wrapped tomato plant, cucumber patches, and bright red pepper plants. Things have taken a turn since the world changed though, and while those plants remain, it's in a vastly different form - as a thick, dark tangle of thorn and heat that's inherently hostile to anything bug-sized.

Hostile, but *delicious* - there's no better place to find succulent fruits than in the Dome's wild outer jungles. Unfortunately for the culinary ambitions of those passing through, you're far more likely to end up *as* dinner than with it - the jungle's lizardish locals and voracious ambulatory plantlife will see to that.

FRUIT, VEG, AND DANGER (feature)

In equal amounts! Almost everything that grows within the Fruiting Jungle can be eaten, if you try hard enough, but a good portion of those edible plants will be trying to eat you back. *Maybe...*

- The local predatory plants have evolved much differently from those outside the Dome, often acting as ambush hunters that draw bugs in with sweet scents and ripe-looking berries before ripping free of the mulchy floor and leaping in to strike.
- The plants are a secondary concern, a definite danger, but not the most pressing one. For that, you'll want to look in the direction of munchmeleons... if you can somehow find them. With their natural colour-changing ability and extreme patience, a bug might not know they've wandered in range of one of these creatures' sticky tongues until it's wrapped right around them.
- The hazards of the jungle are overblown, to a certain extent. If you stray deep into the foliage there's a good chance you'll be lost or snaffled up, but staying on well-trodden jungle pathways leads to an altogether more pleasant experience (if you can stand the heat).

A DAMP SORT OF HEAT (feature)

With the sprinkler storms from above and the near-constantly magnified sun keeping the jungles tropically wet, the air below the leaves is almost thick enough to drink. Great for plants, amazing for the formation of rivers and waterfalls, but not so comfortable for the average spiracle-breathing bug. Altogether now: it's not the heat that gets you - it's the humidity! *Maybe...*

- There are certain areas of the jungle that are so wet they're more suited to swimming than scuttling, though climbing through the leafy canopy above might also be a decent way of getting around if you're sure-footed.
- Can bugs sweat? It's a hot (HA!) topic among those readying themselves for the Jungle's embrace. Might be best to bring a towel, just in case.
- While the Dunes drop to freezing temperatures when the sun goes down, the Jungle's canopy traps heat enough to last throughout the night.
- It's only the top layers of mulch and soil in the growbeds that hold water, as there's a good amount of plastic sheeting just underneath them. If a bug could dig down through that, they might even find cool, dry tunnels to explore for a change of pace.

EXPLORING THE FRUITING JUNGLE

When a band of bugs travels the Dome's overgrown rim, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: A rusted watering can that's been taken over by parasitic tomato plants.
2: The skeleton of a titan, half-buried in the mud.
3: A mound of wet earth that has no plants growing from it, for no apparent reason.
4: An abandoned camp, still sticky with lizard saliva.
5: A string bean plant that's grown so high it scrapes the very top of the dome. Could it be climbed?
6: A waterfall feeding an idyllic lake.

Events

1: An overripe courgette falls, the sticky debris annihilating a well-worn trail.
2: The earth parts, the air sours, and a scumdew pushes its way up from the growbeds.
3: A flash of bright colour above - was that Mint Skelato?
4: Sunlight streaming through a warped pane of glass sets some of the jungle canopy aflame.
5: Vines encircle your camp, ever so slowly.
6: A hekatantonopede scurries past like a steam train.

MINT SKELATO (npc)

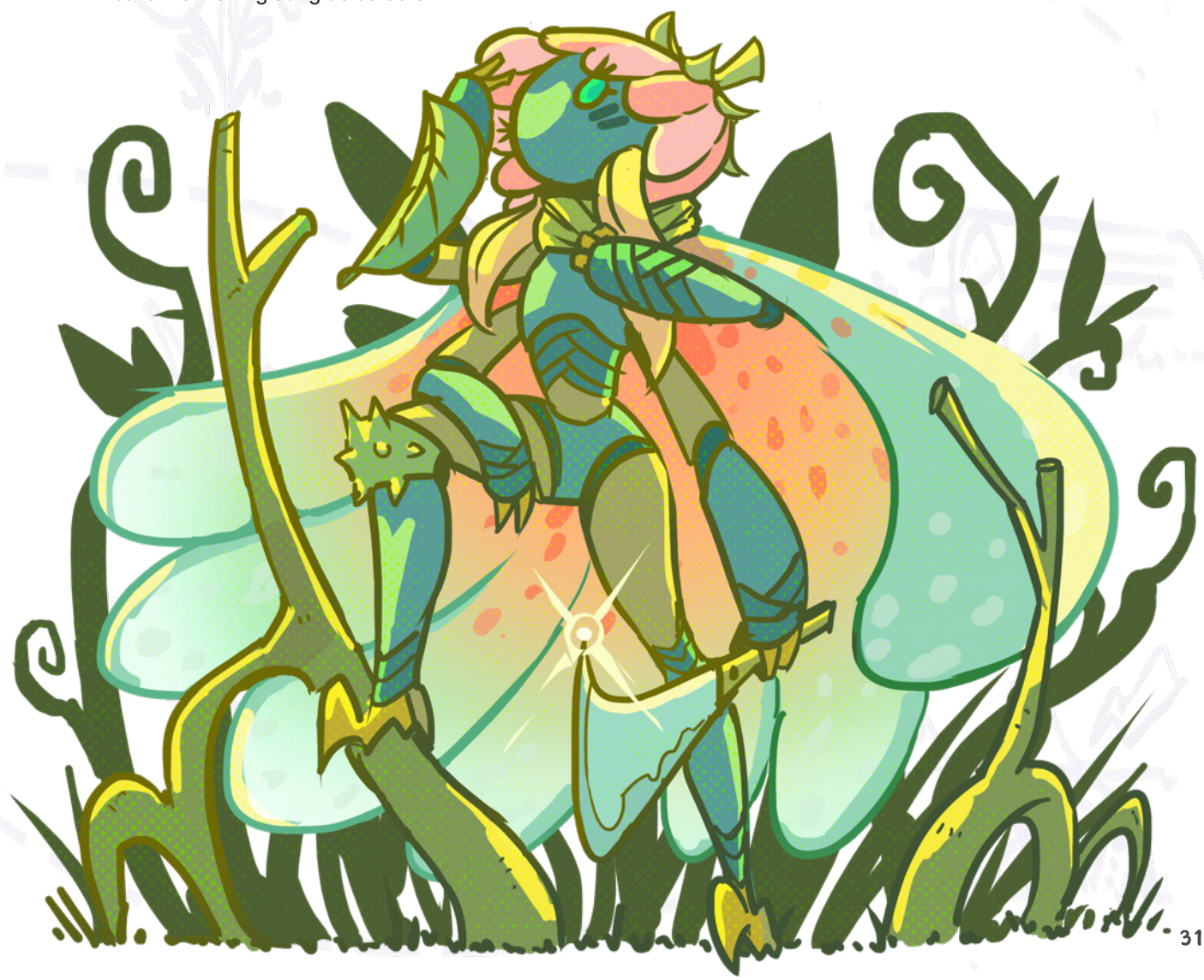
A renowned poet, swordsbug, ranger, and treasure hunter, Mint is the subject of a hundred tall stories across the sands and beyond. Though she most often travels the darkness of the overgrown jungles alone, she's been known to swoop in to save bugs that get out of their depths with the local wildlife - and she's earned a legion of adoring fans through doing so. *Maybe...*

- Mint despises her celebrity status among the other residents of the glasshouse, but she also can't stand to see another bug in peril.
- Though her skill with a blade is unparalleled, her poetry does feel a bit forced. She can't find a rhyme for 'tomato' either...
- Her altruism may not be all that altruistic - what secret is Mint hiding, and why does she refuse to leave the Fruiting Jungle's borders?

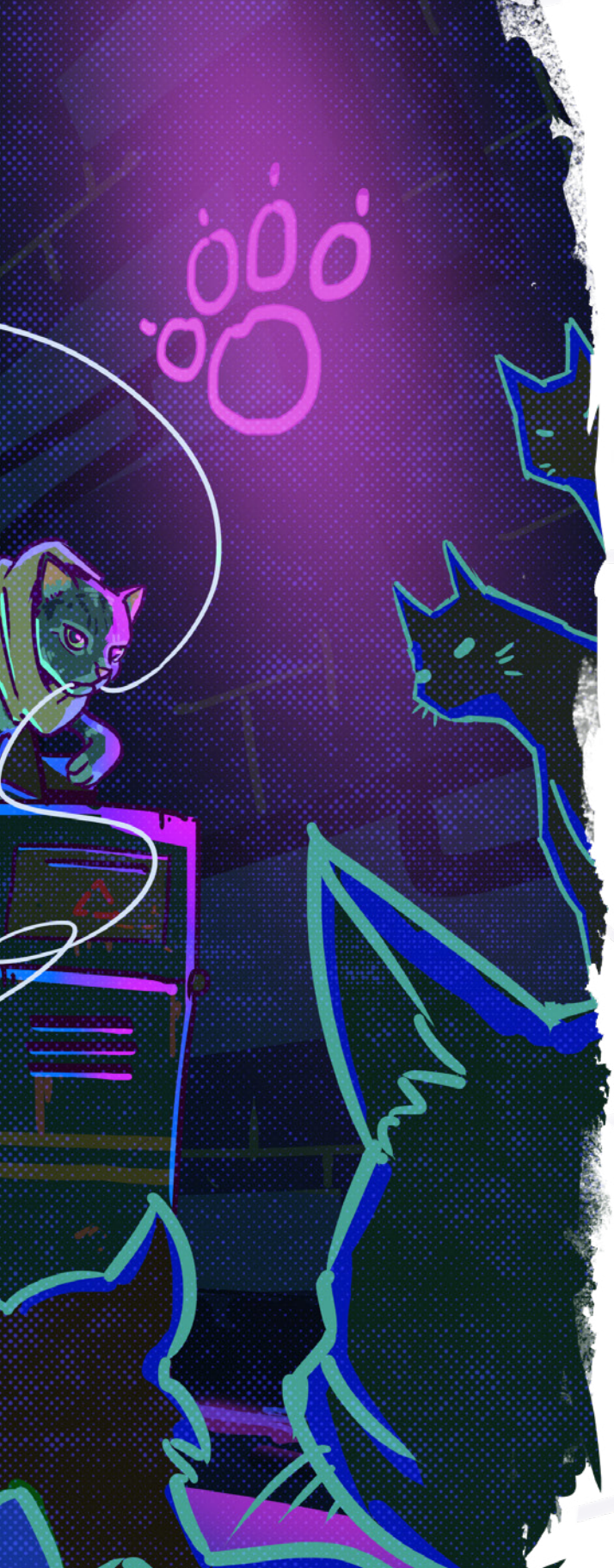
THE STRONGEST STOCK (feature)

The Jungle also acts as a secret testing ground for **Haricot Mace's** creations, the organic pseudotitans known as heirloomers. Piloted by bugs, carefully constructed from the strongest specimens of fruit and vine, these impressive fibrous machines have a purpose that may be best left undiscovered. *Maybe...*

- Haricot intends to use the heirloomers as seed delivery systems among the dunes, protecting their pilots from the Skyglass heat as they work.
- ... Or maybe Haricot's intentions are more warlike in nature. What better way to take over an oasis than through a show of vegetative force from the rarely travelled jungles?



THE NEKOPOLIS



OVERVIEW

An urban environment somehow more wild than the deepest woods, the Nekopolis is a monster of concrete and neon, a haven for fur and claw. Cats rule this labyrinth of shadowed alleyways, holding court between crumbling tenement blocks, hunting and lounging and politicking without fear.

But how do bugs fit into this world of feline titans? By taking the spaces too cramped to host an invasion by all but the smallest of kittens, that's how. Where there are sewer pipes, metal gutters, and basement rooms, the scuttling masses endure.

VIBES

Soaked With Light: How can a place so shadowed be so bright? The neon signs of the Nekopolis provide a constant light, even during the deepest, darkest nights. The only places that experience true darkness are the rooftops, once the sun's gone down, and the deepest recesses of building and sewer.

Ruined: Crossing the Nekopolis is as much a climb as it is a hike, with rubble-choked streets and collapsed walls requiring a zig-zag pathway from even the most hardcore trailblazers. Slipping beneath the city allows for straighter, if damper, progress, but comes with additional perils of its own; the cats may be a danger, but at least they're a *known* danger.

Hostile: The bugs of this realm still outnumber the cats ten to one, but when you think about it, that's actually a really low ratio of scuttler to prowler. More cats make their homes in the Nekopolis than you could shake a stick at, even if you found a really shakeable stick.

Glorious: Adventuring bands that roam the Nekopolis talk, when they're safely ensconced within sewerside bars or basement settlements, of a worrying pull at the mind. Bugs weren't designed to spend so much time around the sleek, playful, murderous godlings of the streets above, and some of them get a bit *weird* about it all. Listen for the jingling of bells, they say, and move the other way.

URBAN PARTICULARS

What makes the Nekopolis so special? Let's find out together... *These pages cover optional rules, notes on tone, and resources for the Weaver to use in a pinch.*

OPTIONAL RULES

When bugs are going on tiny adventures within the realm of the Nekopolis, consider bringing the following special rules into play. They're not entirely necessary, especially for newer groups, but they should bring some spice into proceedings for more experienced explorers of the world of PICO.

NEON SUNS (optional rule)

There are plenty of dark areas for a bug to slink around in throughout the Nekopolis, but very few of those are out in the open. Between the daytime sun and the flicker of nightly neon, the streets manage to be at least partially illuminated at all times. *When out above ground during the day, the streets of the Nekopolis are treated like any other area - most of them will be bathed with light, with a few pools of shadow acting as darkness. But the ever-glowing neon signs play tricks on the eyes at night - areas lit by neon once the sun goes down count as being **in light AND in darkness** at the same time, a confusing state for some that pass through them.*

CATELEPATHY (optional rule)

Cats aren't gods, we made that clear all the way back on page 24. But the Nekopolis is very much their domain, and feline inhabitants do seem, in some way, to draw power and knowledge from this home turf. *Cats of all shapes and sizes seem to be able to share information without the need for words (or yowls) while prowling the streets, allowing them a kind of feline telepathy. This uncanny ability doesn't seem to work throughout the sewers though, which bugs might be able to use to their advantage.*

SCRAPS AND SCRAPS (optional rule)

What used to happen here, before the big M? No bug seems to know, and if the cats are aware, they're not keen on telling. But, whatever it was, it left a veritable bounty of both bits and bobs for sticky-fingered bugs to collect. *The first time each player rolls a set of doubles while Gathering or Scrounging during a scene, they can take both the twist and the special outcome rather than having to choose one or the other. Additional rolls to Gather or Scrounge are treated as normal, though.*

HIGH OR LOW WEIRDNESS?

While the cats are the defining feature of the Nekopolis, they're plenty strange already. To tune the weirdness of the realm to a level that suits your group, it's better to focus on the properties of the city itself - the dimensions, the lighting, and the overall feel of the place.

For High Weirdness: The glow never dies! Neon signs fizzle but never go out, merry music plays from disused shopfronts, and street-cleaning robots scatter grumpy cats before them as they try to keep some semblance of order. The streets seem to turn too many times, spiralling in on themselves, and the sewers run deeper than any city would have need of.

For Medium Weirdness: The towering buildings won't stay that way forever. Every storm sends cats and bugs alike into hiding, and falling air conditioners and aerials crack streets that will never be fixed. The supply of fish heads from various pre-M butcheries will, eventually, run dry.

For Low Weirdness: The giants that inhabited the crumbling city are long gone, and the cats rule in their place. Though some are feral, a few remember and still long for their once-domesticated lives. Cat trees, jingly balls, and food bowls have been dragged out into the alleys to make it a bit more homely for these unfortunates, but the city's on a timer - more and more neon is failing, and the power grid threatens to short out any day now.

Feline Mysteries

If your players would like to change the world with revelations relevant to the Nekopolis, the following list of potential mysteries is a good place to start. *When a player makes a* grand discovery *and needs to choose a new tiny mystery for their bug to explore, you can suggest one from the list below.*

- What powers the neon signs and streetlights?
- Where do the sewers finally end?
- What signals do the rooftop antennae still catch?
- Is catelepathy something a bug could learn?
- Where do new cats come from?
- Why do neon signs fizzle from time to time?
- Who keeps replenishing the butchery bins?

Potential Hazards

The cats won't admit it, but they might not be as secure in their position at the top of the food chain as they like to appear. *Danger in the Nekopolis might come in the form of...*

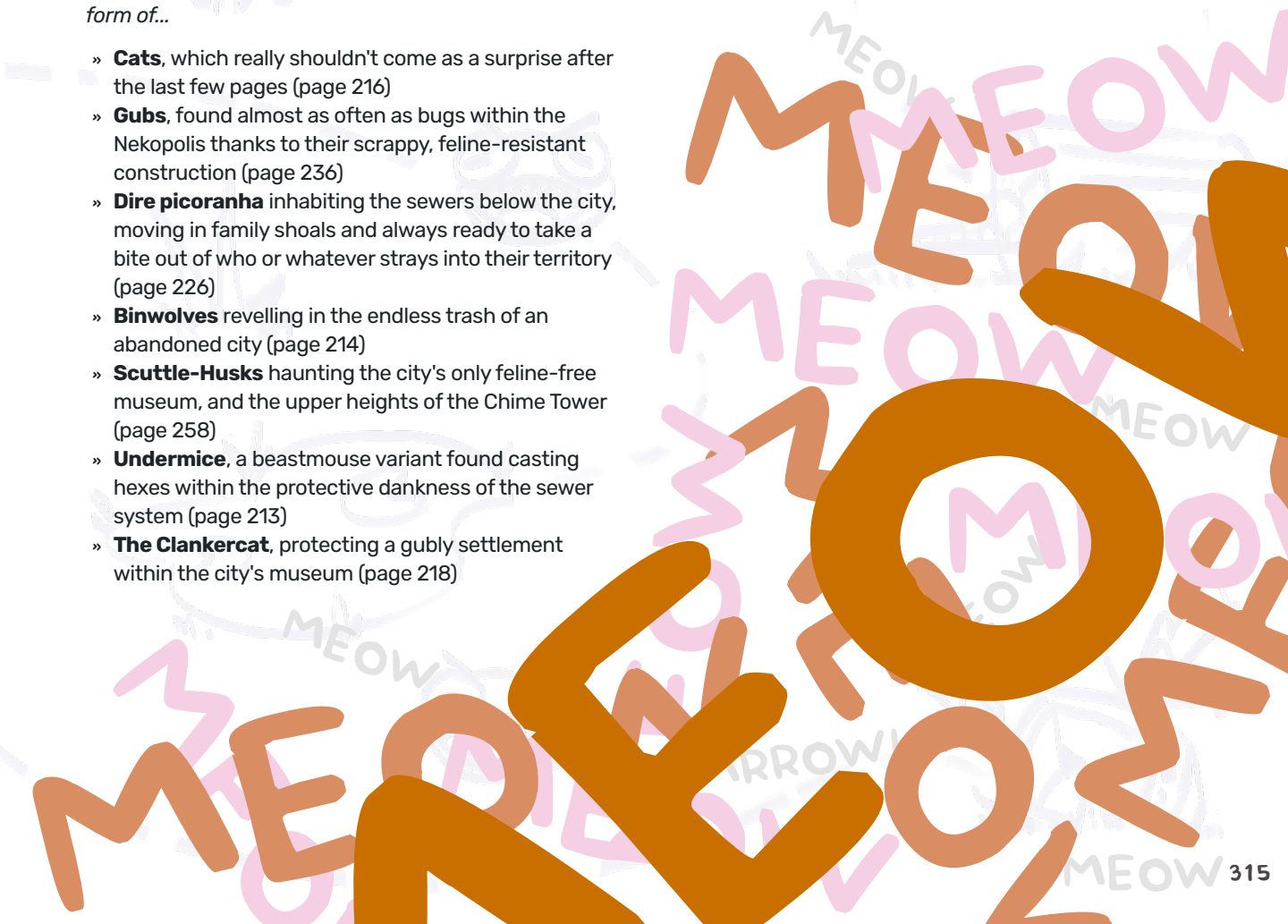
- **Cats**, which really shouldn't come as a surprise after the last few pages (page 216)
- **Gubs**, found almost as often as bugs within the Nekopolis thanks to their scrappy, feline-resistant construction (page 236)
- **Dire picoranha** inhabiting the sewers below the city, moving in family shoals and always ready to take a bite out of who or whatever strays into their territory (page 226)
- **Binwolves** revelling in the endless trash of an abandoned city (page 214)
- **Scuttle-Husks** haunting the city's only feline-free museum, and the upper heights of the Chime Tower (page 258)
- **Undermice**, a beastmouse variant found casting hexes within the protective dankness of the sewer system (page 213)
- **The Clankercat**, protecting a gubly settlement within the city's museum (page 218)

Useful Loot

Bits and bobs are both plentiful in the ruined city, and bugs are more liable to trip over resources than they are to have trouble looking for them. There's heavy competition when it comes to looting though, as the feline rulers of the Nekopolis try to hoard the most entertaining or delicious pieces for themselves. *The following lists of both should help if you ever need to give a reward to the players for exploration and rummaging about.*

Local Bits: Fish Eye, Lost Claw, Wet-Dry Food, Moggie's Morsel, Rice Paper Decoration, Soggy Chip, Drain Thistle, Chicken Bone, Freeze-Dried Liver, Roasted Coffee Bean, Mouse Skull

Local Bobs: Neon Liquid, Discarded Bell, Squeaky Bone, Plastic Ball, Shard of Roof Slate, Aerial Cable, Clothes Peg, Tyre-Rubber, Unusual Mechanism, Shreds of Collar, Yarn Loop, Digital Quartz, Whisker-Sabre


MEOW
MEOW
MEOW

LOCAL... FACTION?

With the streets overrun with titanic individuals of a decidedly feline persuasion, there are no warring factions within the boundaries of the neon-lit city. What bugs deign to live there realized long ago that survival was the only metric by which one should measure success. *The following pages detail the singular bugly faction of the Nekopolis, the **Ding-Dong-Ditchers**.*

THE DING-DONG-DITCHERS

General Mood: Perpetually anxious
Home Turf: Boltholes all across the city

Most commonly referred to as 'Ditchers', 'D3s', or '3Ds', the Ding-Dong-Ditchers are a loose coalition of survivalist bugs from different communities that, rather than cower and hide from their feline overlords, have instead developed proven strategies for staying alive.

Well, one strategy.

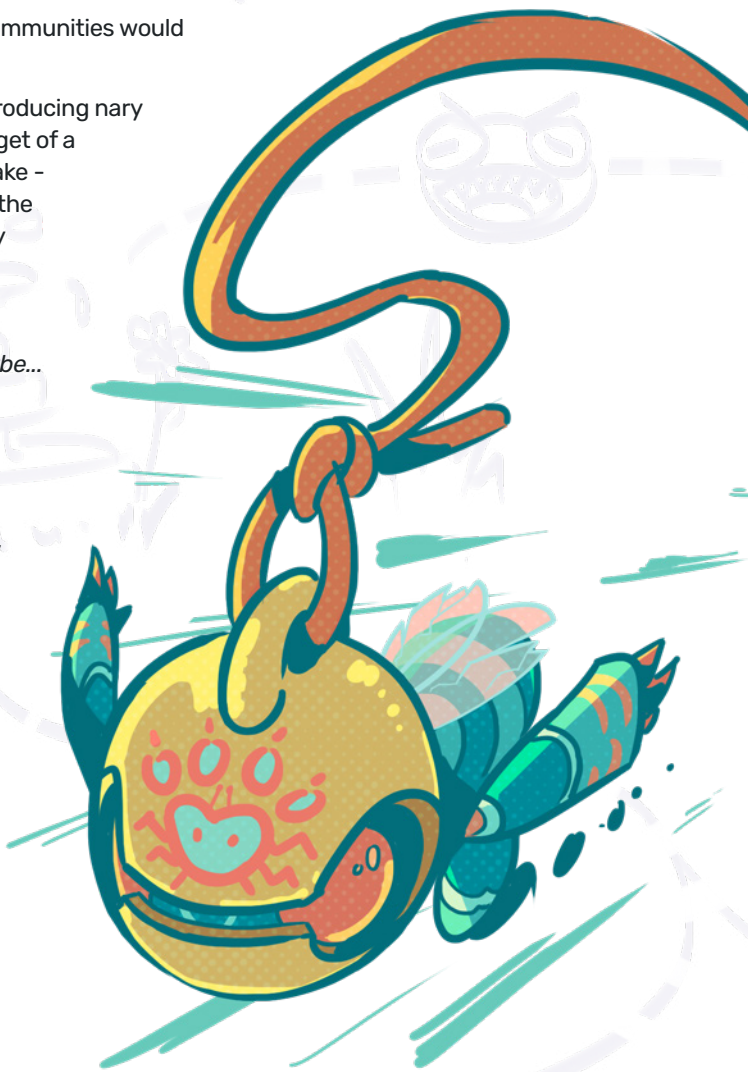
Sort of proven.

BELL-BEARING (feature)

No Ditcher stepping out of one of their safely isolated communities would dream of doing so without a bell on their person.

These bells are muffled by default, the clappers inside producing nary a jangle until a ditcher feels that they've become the target of a titan's hunt. It's at that point that they earn their namesake - they unmuffle the bell and make a run for it, dashing for the nearest area too small for a pursuing cat to squeeze fully into while clanging and clonking with every step to draw as much attention as possible. Then, at the last second, they ditch the bell and dart for safety, relying on a cat's inherently distractable nature to see them through. *Maybe...*

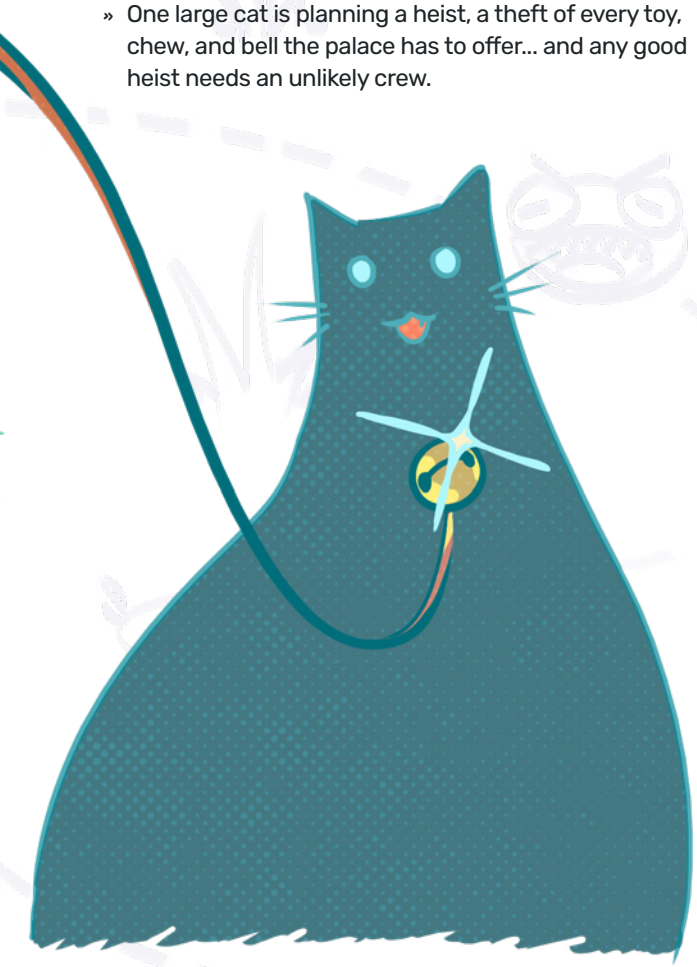
- Some Ditchers, the fastest and bravest, are used as roving distractions that keep particular areas of the Nekopolis clear of kitties so larger groups of bugs can scavenge and trade for a time. These purposeful attention-grabbers often carry multiple bells at once, ready to scatter them in all directions if needed to distract an entire clawed horde.
- The bells are worn as a kind of helmet, offering not only the benefits of a sound-based lure to keep others safe, but a second chance at life if one is caught up in a set of titanic jaws - many a cat has ended up with nothing but a mouthful of metal after what they thought was a successful chase, the bug they caught shedding its 'head' before scampering away to safety.
- A bell and a piece of muffling ribbon don't do much in the hands of an amateur, but an experienced Ditcher can herd cats on command. All they need is a high place, a few bits of tasty bait, and a well-planned escape route.



THE PILGRIMAGE (feature)

Bells don't come cheap! Every Ding-Dong-Ditcher is expected to make a journey to the Palace of Jingly Things at some point, to choose a bell of their very own (and to hopefully grab a few spares to replace the recently discarded). But the journey isn't easy - the palace is guarded by some of the most terrible, and eagerly playful, feline titans that the Nekopolis has to offer. *Maybe...*

- The palace is what remains of an old pre-M pet store, and many of the bells inside were specifically designed to appeal to cats. The place is under guard not by the feral cats that own the streets (who are far too haughty to show interest in such a location), but the descendants of the kittens once sold there.
- It's said that a bug can't just choose any old bell. When a D3 enters the palace, they hear the ringing of a chime, a singular object that's somehow made to be the perfect weight, balance, and timbre for them.
- One large cat is planning a heist, a theft of every toy, chew, and bell the palace has to offer... and any good heist needs an unlikely crew.



THE MOST DANGEROUS GAME (npcs)

Though most Ditchers see their scampering journeys as a necessity, there are a few that have risen to prominence for treating the extreme danger of streetside travel like a sport. For them, the titans are sparring partners, respected opponents distinct enough to name. Some even swear that a particular cat will seek them out for a chase, night after night. *Maybe...*

- **Swiftflight McLeggerton**, a slinky-framed tabby with a kink in his tail. McLeggerton spends most of his free time lounging on an old parasol with a good view of several streets, which also conveniently gives him an excellent pseudo-springboard for the start of his chases.
- **Dicey** is sympathetic to the Ditchers, but she's still a cat - there are appearances one has to maintain. It's a matter of feline decorum to give chase if a small thing runs, but Dicey makes sure to let just enough go free so as to not rouse the ire of her compatriots.
- **Big Mog** is the kind of cat that other cats give a wide berth, a titan large enough to almost need a new descriptive word for its size. Mog can barely fit through an open window, and is more likely to smash through a fence than climb it.

CHIME TOWER (landmark)

A leaning monument slung with neon signs and old timepieces, any bug that's caught and consumed while ditching is laid to rest within its hallowed halls. *Maybe...*

- Most 'burials' are more symbolic than anything, as catling titans aren't known for leaving leftovers after catching an edible little bug. The bells are what gets buried, often dented and toothmarked, but decorated with painted narratives describing the bearer's greatest achievements.
- Chime Tower must have been *for* something once, but what that might be has been lost to time. Cats stay clear of it once the sun goes down, birds won't land on it no matter the time of day, and even the sewer beneath it is oddly free of enthusiastically bitey fish. When the Chime Tower clocks sound, the echoes take too long to fade.
- If the palace ever runs out of bells, the Ditchers have an emergency plan in place that involves requisitioning bells from the Tower and bringing them back into service. Nobody wants to be the one to go and get them, though - much better to get a band of outsiders to tangle with whatever ghosts might be hanging around a place like that.

A CLAW-MARKED TRAVEL GUIDE

Most bands of bugs avoid treading the illuminated streets of the Nekopolis, but you're obviously made of a different kind of chitin!

From the dusty stillness of old apartments to the cat-patrolled streets, from the darkness of the sewers to the moonlight-bathed rooftops, and beyond; one could spend an entire life exploring the Nekopolis and never see everything it has to offer. *The entries below all represent distinct areas of the Nekopolis that a band of bugs might stumble upon as they travel, as well as the features and landmarks they could encounter.*

THE TWISTING STREETS

Every alleyway an ambush, every intersection a courtroom; the cats of the Nekopolis are in total control of the surface-level streets.

But still, bugs endure. Ditchers scamper from cover to cover as merchant salvagers rifle through spilled trash cans, and adventuring bands scuttle through the gutters with a hundred feline eyes tracking their every move. To be a bug in the Nekopolis is to live life on the edge, perpetually.

PREY OR PLAY? (feature)

Cats are mercurial at the best of times, creatures of indiscernible mood and twitching tails. One encounter might end in a frantic chase, another in a contest with arcane rules, and a third in a furred titan offering friendship and aid - perhaps the same one that attempted to eat your companion on a previous night. *Maybe...*

- The Nekopolis cats keep their actual predation of the local bugs as low as possible, worried about scaring them off for good if they're too aggressive. And what would they have to amuse themselves then?
- Some visitors, more used to cats from the wider wilds, believe that carrying a complement of gifts to give out will keep them safe. While it's not the worst idea, it's hardly a foolproof plan.
- The local titans have a mysterious etiquette about them, some unspoken rules of engagement to keep things interesting. A bug might even learn some of these rules if they're a keen observer, and use them to their advantage for safer travels.

THE BOLTHOLES (landmark)

A series of closed metal guttering and abandoned mouse-made mazes running through the walls of various Nekopolis structures, used as a (theoretically) safe way to move around without catching the attention of a titan. Travel through the boltholes can be a tight squeeze sometimes, even for a bug, but the narrow passageways ensure that nothing larger than a questing paw can fit. *Maybe...*

- The mice that made the vast majority of the boltholes have long since fled the upper city, pushed out by the ever-growing population of cats. At least, bugs hope they fled - the alternative is rather grisly, and not something you should dwell on for too long.
- The bolthole network actually runs far deeper into the city than even the local cats know, with carved tunnels connecting to both pipes from the old sewer system and sunken cable-channels for the failing electrical grid.
- Mice still guard and patrol the lower boltholes, extorting heavy tolls from travelling bugs.

THE THREE FATES (titans)

The undisputed rulers of the Nekopolis, each of the three fates counts a different part of the city as their kingdom. As far as anyone can tell, the three only gather on nights where the neon burns low and the moon shines full. *Maybe...*

- **The Fate of High Rooftops** is a climber by nature, spending as little time at ground level as possible. They lure visitors higher with dangled yarn, fishing for excitement and company when they're not lounging under the stars.
- **The Fate of Dusty Places** slips from room to disused room like a shadow, and is said to know the layout of every apartment, the number of steps in every stairwell, and the contents of every cupboard.
- **The Fate of Every Crossroad** rarely moves when observed, but always seems to be waiting at a nearby intersection when they're needed. Legend has it that they've *never* given a straightforward answer.

HACKLEBACK JUNCTION (landmark)

While the furry denizens of the Nekopolis like to pretend that each of them is tsar of their own domain and could get along just fine without anybody else, thank you very much, there's actually a surprising amount of trade and logistics that goes into keeping the city functioning. Fish heads need harvesting from old markets and distributing to less piscine areas, feline safety officers string ribbons up around broken streets and broken sewer grates, and a whole cadre of kittens keep water bowls filled until they can be trusted with more exciting work.

Hackleback Junction is where goods are exchanged for promises and services, and is important enough to operate under an amnesty-style treaty; the cats run the market, but it's open to four-leggers and six-leggers alike. *Maybe*...

- Titan entrepreneurs sell bits and bobs out of open biscuit tins, shrewdly price-gouging all who browse for too long before buying.
- Visiting bugs walk the junction with a kind of reverent awe, surrounded on all sides by titans that have decided, just this once, to at least pretend to treat them as equals.
- **Goldfeather** is one of the Junction's most esteemed figures, a brewmaster pigeon who has achieved the lofty honour of being regarded as an honorary cat by all in attendance.
- An oft-frequented stall selling forbidden pre-M literature, mostly picture books too large for a bug to carry that depict bright, sunny city scenes bearing little resemblance to the neon-blanched streets outside of the junction.

EXPLORING THE TWISTING STREETS

When a band of bugs is brave enough to tackle the streets of the trillion-clawed city, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: A broken cat tree sitting on a curbside.
2: A pile of abandoned bells.
3: A convenience store with broken windows, the interior a heaven of sugary treats.
4: A camouflaged entrance to the boltholes underneath a faded swing set.
5: A lamppost covered in scratches and gouges.
6: A pile of trash that looks suspiciously like a throne.

NPCs

1: **Long Johnson**, a munchkin cat who was definitely not named for the length of his legs.
2: **Revigar the Clean**, petty dictator of the Nekopolis trash-heap.
3: **Tiskaro**, a centipede obsessed with electric lighting.
4: **Milk-Face**, whose thirst can never be quenched.
5: **Barisse**, a whisker-collecting ladybug.
6: **Scrimpandesti**, a gub made of faded ribbons wrapped around an old transistor.

Events

1: A cat waiting patiently outside of the Hackleback boundaries for its prey.
2: A musical trio of bugs cowering in a drainpipe.
3: Seven cats, as still as statues, facing each other down at sunset.
4: A tree with a classically trained feline occupant.
5: A neon sign fizzles out, plunging an area into shadow.
6: A rare meeting of all three fates.

"Got to be honest here, that is a lot more cats than I was expecting."

Gnash Gakash, First-Time Nekopolis Visitor

NEON RISE

The higher you climb in the Nekopolis, the more colourful it gets. The walls of almost every building are draped in glowing signage (and the electrical cables that feed it), and the space over each street slung with overburdened washing lines. Greenery, scarce on the harshly lit ground, takes hold as the altitude increases - fire escapes and rooftops, once barren, now host sprawling gardens growing wild under the stars.

THE CLANGING GARDENS (feature)

There's very little earth for plants to grow from up on the rooftops, but as a famous scientist once said 'Life, uh, finds a way'. The vines and bushes of the upper Nekopolis take root in whatever they can, breaking through metal sheeting and cracking concrete with a kind of silent, vegetative glee. *Maybe...*

- One species of flower native to the city has learned to feed almost entirely on metal, rusting whatever it grows on to the point of dangerous fragility.
- Locklin's Grove is a bugly settlement with its own feline protector, an unusual set-up that flies in the face of the city's usual power dynamics. Could the local bugs have found a way to mesmerize their titan guardian, or is it simply an oversized picotitan that they've raised from kitling to catling?
- A colony of pigeons has taken up residence on top of the city's station, purposefully sowing the seeds of plants that cats find particularly distasteful. Visiting bugs often approach these birds as potential allies... a dangerous assumption to make.

EXPLORING NEON RISE

When a band of bugs scales the old Nekopolis walls, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: A cluster of broken bulbs, still sparking.
2: An air conditioner covered in cobwebs.
3: A pigeon-made statue honouring flight.
4: A tangle of washing lines. Gnarly!
5: A billboard advertising a genuinely delicious-looking cat food. Wait, is that cat a famous local?
6: Scratches on the lip of a rooftop fence.

Events

1: A walkway covered in rust-flowers groans and shifts.
2: Line-surfers speed by, whooping and hollering.
3: A hideous yowl echoes across the city.
4: Sounds of performance issue from the Brightside movie theatre. What's on this evening?
5: A rainstorm drives rooftop bugs into new crevices.
6: Bugly merchants selling sticky toffee popcorn.

BRIGHTSIDE (landmark)

A buggish stronghold built into the interior of a movie theatre advertisement, each glowing bulb acting as a miniature home. *Maybe...*

- The advertisement that contains Brightside acts as an interesting repository of pre-M history, proudly displaying the names of the movies that were on offer at the time of the world's great change. What deep truths may have been revealed by 'The Great Hand Returns', 'Entomoloko', or 'Catch Me If You Flange'?
- Living inside of a lit bulb is far from comfortable, but the locals see it as better than the alternative. When they can see at all, that is - spending half their time inches away from a white-hot filament requires some heavy-duty eye coverings if one wants to get any decent rest.
- Several times a week, bugs from Brightside head into the abandoned theatre below them on scavenging runs. The most desired material on these trips is popcorn, kernels so large that they take two bugs to haul back home, and so buttery that another three are required to help the first two stabilize their prize.

LINE-SURFING (feature)

A local alternative to ditching that requires 100% fewer bells, line-surfers rush down washing lines and use pegs as distracting percussion to enrage and titillate the titans below. *Maybe...*

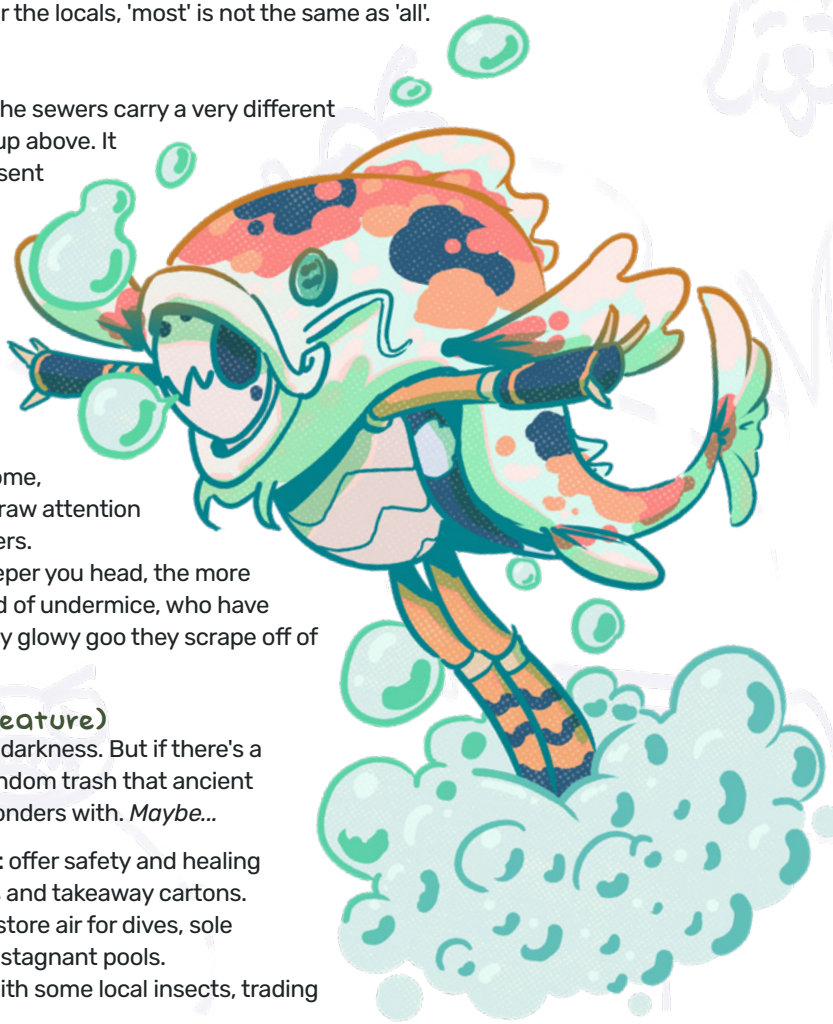
- Ditchers are brave, but they're not exactly *cool*. Line-surfers tend to corner the market where bodaciousness is concerned.
- Some clever kitties actually encourage line-surfing in their territory - the unexpected bursts of movement and noise keep them sharp for any genuine titanic threats that might show up, and if a line-surfer chooses the wrong washing line (one that's a little too close to the street, for example) then they've essentially made a delicious, bug-based sushi conveyor by mistake.
- **Wenningham Hax** is the most famous line-surfer of all time, a stick insect who can slip through the eyelet of a peg without slowing down.

THE SEWER SYSTEM

There are few genuinely safe places for bugs within the Nekopolis, and the sewer system... Well, it doesn't *quite* qualify as one of them. Don't get us wrong, the cloying dark of slime-coated tunnels are safer (if smellier) than the neon-lit streets up above, and most cats wouldn't be caught dead dipping a paw into the waters down there (even with multiple lives to spare). Unfortunately for the locals, 'most' is not the same as 'all'.

99% CAT FREE (feature)

Drips, splashes, and weird, echoing clanks - the sewers carry a very different ambience to the chorus of hisses and yowls up above. It would be tempting to think that the ever-present darkness down there was entirely free of tooth and claw, but life within the Nekopolis boundaries is rarely so kind. *Maybe...*



- While the deeper tunnels are relatively safe, anywhere accessible by grate or manhole is a potential hunting ground for fisher-kittens, younger cats immune to the social stigma of clinging dankness.
- A particular brand of D3s call the sewer home, dressing as bright, scale-flashing fish to draw attention away from the less combative local scuttlers.
- Cats are the least of your worries - the deeper you head, the more likely you are to find the sewer's own brand of undermice, who have traded their usual clove soda for worryingly glowy goo they scrape off of old pipework.

LIFE AMONG THE REMNANTS (feature)

If there's one thing the sewers are rich in, it's darkness. But if there's a second, far more excitingly, it's the kind of random trash that ancient titans didn't care for, but that bugs can do wonders with. *Maybe...*

- The friendly bugs of **Delivered Piping Hot** offer safety and healing within their labyrinth of soggy pizza boxes and takeaway cartons.
- Scavenger bugs spend weeks learning to store air for dives, sole recipients of the detritus at the bottom of stagnant pools.
- A band of beastmice have forged a pact with some local insects, trading protection for salvaged bottle-glass.

EXPLORING THE SEWER SYSTEM

When a band of bugs travels the pipes of the Nekopolis sewer system, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: An open area lit by a half-open manhole above.
2: A collection of childish scrawls using glowing dye.
3: A section of pipework entirely coated with caustic slime, leading to previously unexplored depths.
4: A glowing, almost hypnotic whirlpool.
5: A fortress of pizza boxes, with corrugated battlements manned by vividly purple slugs.
6: A cat's claw embedded in an iron pipe.

Events

1: A fisher-kitten paw stabs down from a grate above, scraping blindly but eagerly.
2: A rush of foul water as a sluice-gate opens.
3: A sharp cry, the ominous screech of an undermouse.
4: A band of bugs huddled round a mushroom-fed fire.
5: A member of the Ding-Dong-Ditchers flashes by, carp-scales glinting like the sun.
6: A nearby piece of corroded pipework collapses.

THE MUSEUM OF UNNATURAL HISTORY

There are places within the Nekopolis that cats can't go, spaces so tight that even the most liquid ball of fur can't squeeze through. There are others that they choose to avoid, mostly for reasons of hygiene - few cats want sewer-stink clinging to their whiskers, after all. But there's only one place that the local titans seem to truly fear; the Museum of Unnatural History.

THE NOT-QUITE-BUGS (npcs)

Some bugs do make a home in the museum, revelling in the lack of predatory titans (ones that aren't stuffed and in display cases, anyway). But they're vastly outnumbered by the amount of *gubs* that call these echoing halls a home, bug-shaped collections of odds, ends, and trash that do their best to mimic their shape-cousins. *You'll find a hazard entry for gubs on page 236 and, maybe...*

- The gubs bear no ill will toward any bugs that settle within the museum - quite the opposite, in fact. Local bugs often find gubs watching them from a distance, writing down their observations in a never-ending quest to be more convincingly buglike.
- **Bighand Luca** stands as the current leader of the museum gubs, an imposing figure hewn from fossilized claws and ancient bandages. Luca knows every inch of the museum, from the crawlspaces below the reflective floor to the pigeon-haunted slates of the roof, and it's from that knowledge that she forbids her kin to tarry too long near certain exhibits.
- **Onifex** is Luca's most trusted assistant, never found without a quill and paper in two of his seven tiny hands.

AN AGE LONG PAST (feature)

Bugs aren't archivists, by nature, as they tend to concern themselves more with the here-and-now, the what's-that-over-there, and the is-that-thing-going-to-eat-me-or-maybe-be-my-friend. Gubs are more drawn to writing than their bugly almost-kin, but they too prefer to focus on the present and future rather than the distant past. Maybe it's being surrounded by so much history that makes it feel too big to be recorded?

But the museum's inhabitants, bug and gub alike, do maintain a healthy respect for the exhibits they live alongside. With the museum itself seemingly built for (and in some rooms *containing*) creatures that dwarf even the largest of known titans, it's almost impossible not to feel a sense of reverence and wonder; room after artefact-filled room point to a catalogue of guesses and fossils and dreams. *Maybe...*

- The interior is a welcome break from the shadow and neon of the outside streets, with high skylights letting sun and moonlight illuminate each exhibit however they see fit.
- Bugs can't read old words very well - the letters are far too big to keep too many in your mind at once, you know? But even with that hindrance, one exhibit has been named and identified without any trouble: the mammoth, a shaggy-haired beast whose frozen tusks almost scrape the ceiling. Visitors rarely miss the mammoth. It tends to loom.
- The waxed floors are great for sliding on, but they do tend to echo. Wait... was that a footstep?

EXHIBITS AND ARTEFACTS (landmark)

There's a fine line between awe and terror, and the museum's exhibition halls offer great big dollops of both. *Maybe...*

- Several rooms hold a collection of pre-Mysteriocalypse mammals, all patched coats and glassy eyes. There are overtoothed cats and motionless, snake-tongued anteaters, entire display shelves filled with the bones of beasts that could snap up a thousand bugs with a single bite. None of these relics have moved in living memory, but that doesn't mean they're not going to. They must be getting hungry after all this time...
- Very little is known about the cultures and practices of the huge, two-legged titans often represented in pre-M photographs, but they definitely liked dressing up. Many gubs remove fabric from within old display cases to fashion themselves wings, cloaks, and particularly stylish hats.
- Some bugs claim to be able to navigate the museum by scent alone, relying on antennae to point them to a given destination. Each period of history, they say, has a fragrance that's unique, and they wonder what their era will smell like once they're reduced to dust and memory.
- There's one exhibit so popular that bugs from distant realms will brave the city in order to glimpse it - the Arthropleura, a plastic and resin recreation of an ancient millipede-like bug that could swallow a titan.

THE GIFT SHOP (landmark)

While the museum's main entrance has been barricaded from the inside, the glass doors from the gift shop to the city outside stand wide open. *Maybe*...

- The gift shop plays a catchy little tune at the beginning and end of each day, a useful signal to bugs in the deeper, windowless rooms that they should make or break camp.
- A society of gubs separate from those within the main portion of the museum treat the gift shop as their home turf, their bodies built from colourful plastic and old coins.
- **Spade Spadir** is the gift shop's most ambitious merchant and crafter, a gub that spends their nights creating incredible contraptions from whatever they find on the shelves and their days hawking it to passing adventurers for a tidy profit. The lack of sleep will probably take a toll at some point.

THE CLANKERCAT (titan)

The highest triumph of the museum's gub population, the Clankercat is an artificial titan constructed from a variety of century-old materials. *Maybe*...

- The Clankercat is just a shell, a titan with no mind or soul of its own. It takes twenty gubs to pilot the machine, and it's the only vehicle they trust to take them into the neon-lit city beyond the museum.
- The Nekopolis mogs are all aware of the Clankercat, the brush-whiskered, iron-plated imposter that staggers awkwardly around while mewing mechanically. While they could likely pull it apart at a moment's notice, they find it far more amusing to pretend they *haven't* realised that it's not one of their own kin.
- When the Clankercat was first designed, it was little more than a marionette. But shape begets function, and form is a powerful thing - just as the gubs have become more buglike throughout their existence, the Clankercat now performs certain feline rituals whether crewed or not.

EXPLORING THE MUSEUM

When a band of bugs shuffles the storied halls of history, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: The Arthropleura exhibit, and the dreams it brings.
2: Gub communities built into electric chandeliers.
3: A ransacked cafe with a wide variety of coffee beans.
4: A lookout post standing empty.
5: A spiral staircase leading onto the roof.
6: The bones of an ancient lizard, still standing proud despite its amusingly tiny arms.

NPCs

1: **Pitzi**, a gub with a colourful eraser for a head.
2: **Ocksu**, a butterfly explorer looking for lost kin in the lepidoptery rooms.
3: **Ralphs**, twenty pillbugs that move in unison.
4: **High Stepper**, a binwolf herder.
5: **Nancy Scuttledown**, a spider that spins webs near the breeze running through the gift shop.
6: **Jo**, a gub that genuinely believes he's a bug.

Events

1: A group of patchwork gubs crowd the characters, asking frantic questions on the nature of bugliness.
2: An ancient skull falls, crushing the settlement below.
3: A group of criminal gubs breaks out of the museum case repurposed to hold them.
4: The Clankercat stalks by on autopilot, worried gubs in hot pursuit.
5: Spade Spadir needs a particular, unusual component.
6: A senseless war breaks out between gub and bug.

WESTGATE MALL
A GUEST REALM, BY MIKEY HAMM
STORE
PIC PETS
DRESS

OVERVIEW

They say this place was once a market for the gods - sparkling, reverberant, a cathedral stretching for countless meters. Where tall, sticky-fingered titans went to shop, to play, to walk around and eat a pretzel.

Those original titans are gone now, along with most of the pretzels. The escalators are frozen. The signs are faded. The lights are on, but dimly.

But the Westgate Mall isn't dead. If anything, it's more alive than ever. Lichen speckles the walls. Duckweed spreads across the waters of flooded shops. Birds nest and frogs sing and wild grass grows from the tile.

And bugs live here. By the thousands. Bugs whose ancestors lived in the walls since their construction. Bugs whose forebears arrived after the Mysteriocalypse, drawn by promises of food, shelter, and dead things to start a family inside.

And bugs like you.

Drawn by the promise of adventure. Of glory. Of knowledge. Of money. Drawn by tales of drowned relics in the green waters of the dragonfly empire, or the crowded bazaars of the Food Court's slums, or the storied battlegrounds of Buggy's Funzone. Whatever your journey, this is the destination.

I mean, you can get anything at the mall, right?

VIBES

Teeming: Civilization blooms like algae in the comfort and prosperity of this place. An oasis that turns settlements into cities, and armies into empires.

Empty: And yet, this place is hollow, built too large for this age. Endless halls that will never crowd, massive chambers that will never fill, and dizzying heights visited only by echoes.

Bustling: Everyone has big plans and lots to do. Big dreams and endless energy. Bugs here are industrious and easily bored. Art and commerce, war and crime and feasting - life goes hard here. Keep up.

Still: But apart from its inhabitants, this land has no pulse. A dead place without wind, nor seasons. The ground does not breathe, and Gaia does not dwell here.

MERCANTILE PARTICULARS

What makes the Westgate Mall so special? Let's find out together... *These pages cover optional rules, notes on tone, and resources for the Weaver to use in a pinch.*

OPTIONAL RULES

When bugs are going on tiny adventures within the realm of the Westgate Mall, consider bringing the following special rules into play. They're not entirely necessary, especially for newer groups, but they should bring some spice into proceedings for more experienced explorers of the world of PICO.

AIR CONDITIONING (optional rule)

Even with the walls beginning to crumble and the glass roof broken, the Mall's confines are gloriously resistant to the weather of the outside world. Huge ventilation units, running on ancient generators in the basement, provide a cool flow of filtered air at all times. *The area within the mall is treated as having Calm Skies at all times... until the air conditioning malfunctions. In such periods, the weather may change to Gale or Cold Snap with very little warning, and stay that way for days at a time (or even until the generators in the basement have been tinkered with, resetting the central air control units and providing another long period of cool, placid calm).*

EVERYTHING HAS A PRICE (optional rule)

If there's one thing the bugs within the Westgate Mall understand, it's commerce. How could they not? There are examples all around them, tantalizing in their faded glitziness. Very little is given for free, especially not when there's a profit to be made. *Whenever bugs are trading bits and bobs within the Mall, they can expect to get a slightly lower value piece in return for whatever they give away in all but the most exceptional circumstances. This might come in the form of giving two bits and bobs away in exchange for one, giving a tag-less bit or bob away in exchange for one with a negative tag, or having a trade rely on some kind of additional service being performed (even if it's a simple one that can be wrapped up with a single rolled action). Even when using this rule, feel free to ignore it if the bugs form some genuine connections - friends try to stay fair, even if it means breaking the habits of a lifetime.*

CLOSING TIME (optional rule)

An ancient machine ritual, the 'locking up', is still going strong within the fluorescent-flavoured halls of the Mall. Be careful how you wander around at dusk, unless you don't mind making camp for the night in a temporary prison. *Old security systems still close shutters and lock doors to various shopfronts when the mall's internal clock deems it time, usually as the sun sets outside. Some might have spaces large enough for a bug to slip through - others might be uncomfortably airtight.*

HIGH OR LOW WEIRDNESS?

With such high human traffic in the pre-M times, and so many colourfully confusing oddities left behind on dusty shelves, the area is *ripe* for high weirdness. But does it *have* to be that way? No, there are always other options - especially at the Westgate Mall!

For High Weirdness: Bugs still practice rituals handed down from the times before the Mysteriocalypse, informed by sleepy, long-lived titans and frazzled machines. The Mall is more awake, more vibrant, more *active* than it's ever been before, but you'd be wrong to think of it as more 'alive'.

For Medium Weirdness: The Mall is a place of malfunctioning technology, dying batteries, and old, yearning dreams. Local pre-M machines are reliably unreliable, just like the power grid.

For Low Weirdness: If there was ever a spirit here, it's gone now. The locals keep up appearances, and there are still gaudy decorations on display, but neither quite distract from the creeping dissolution the place is experiencing.

Flouresent Mysteries

If your players would like to change the world with revelations relevant to the Westgate Mall, the following list of potential mysteries is a good place to start. *When a player makes a grand discovery and needs to choose a new tiny mystery for their bug to explore, you can suggest one from the list below.*

- What are the white spheres for?
- Why does fire make food better?
- What is a mannequin?
- How do buildings form?
- Where does music come from?
- Where do frogs come from?
- What are around dogs' necks?
- Which faded paperback holds the deepest secret?

Useful Loot

The Mall is a place of excess and abundance, but also crime, tolls, and aggressive vendors. You'll find bits and bobs without trying, then lose them just as easily. But stay wiley and you may make it out of here richer than you were. *The following lists of both should help if you ever need to give a reward to the players for exploration and rummaging about.*

Local Bits: Popcorn Kernel, Salt Packet, Magpie Feather, Razzleberry Syrup, Broken Lollipop, Old Price Sticker, Lotion Dollop

Local Bobs: Mirror Shard, Lost Wallet, Travel-Size Hand Sanitizer, Pair of Lego Bricks, Arcade Token, Scented Diffuser Stick

Potential Hazards

Mall or maul? Depends on what you run into first. *Danger in the Mall might come in the form of...*

- **Grand Riddlemasters**, hermitting in the Concourse or dwelling quietly amongst the archivists of Book & Coffee (page 231).
- **Froglins & croaklins**, relaxing in the bathhouse and terrorizing the nearby village (page 228).
- **Hex-cable hydras**, rumoured to occasionally spring from the rotting wiring around Buggy's Funzone (page 242).
- **Dire picoranhas**, spotted by divers in the murky waters of Fountain Plaza (page 226).
- **Gestalts**, occasionally rampaging through the overflowing garbage of the bins and spilling out into the rest of the Food Court (page 230).
- **Miniature mercs**, forming bands of brigands on the Concourse and hanging around Buggy's Playzone (page 246).
- An oversized **Snydra**, slumbering at the bottom of the Soft Play ballpit (page 260).

"Hey! Hey, you over there, ever wanted a tadpole that can do a somersault? How about this golden candy, only a teensy bit nibbled on? Come on, a feather from a bird that can sing like a tambourine? No? Really? Heh, you drive a hard bargain, outsider... I can see you're going to do well here."

Wheezy Wallman, Associate of the Merchant's Guild

LOCAL FACTIONS

The Mall could hold a billion bugs, but space is still (somehow) a concern. Where there's commerce, there's product, after all, and where there's product, there's scarcity - even if it is artifical. *The following pages detail the main factions of the Mall, the **Merchant's Guild** and the **Shining Empire**.*

THE MERCHANT'S GUILD

General Mood: Hedonistic, transactional, pragmatic
Home Turf: The Food Court

This place was built for commerce. The ghost of trade haunts these halls. Sale stickers fade in display windows. Murals line the Concourse, depicting beautiful gods in half-price jeans. The gods may be gone, but the spirit remains, stewarded by an aggressive merchant guild that governs the city of Manna and controls nearly all mall trade. If you sell something in the Mall, the guild will know and be happy to do business with you... or else.

MONEY IS POWER (feature)

The Merchant's Guild has controlled the Mall's economy since the founding of Manna, and the larger that economy grows, the more power they have. *Maybe...*

- The Guild has a long-standing claim on Dog, as much as anyone can do such a thing. No one and no thing comes aboard without being tallied and taxed by a certified quartermaster familiar with the rules of canine-transported commerce.
- Beyond trade routes, The Merchants have also taxed, levied, purchased, and loaned their way into so much crucial infrastructure that Maridane Kilsher could collapse Fountain Plaza's entire economy with the stroke of her tiny pen.
- Suspecting the Shining Empire to be meddling in the mini-golf war, the Merchants have started sending financial aid to The Purple Ants. What the empire stands to gain is unclear, but their actions are undoubtedly a threat to business.
- Rumour has it that Long Lickerton, a caterpillar trader from the draughty tunnels of the Mall's air conditioning system, traded a substantial amount of electronic components for the rights to place the apostrophe in 'Merchant's Guild' exactly where he wanted it. *No take-backs.*

TYCOONS AND HUSTLERS (npcs)

While the Guild offers (demands) membership from anyone selling anything, only the richest members have any power over lasting business decisions. *Maybe...*

- **Maridane Kilsher**, a decorated orb-weaver spider who holds the position of guildmaster. She used her silver tongue, golden touch, and (supposedly) platinum spinneret to not only survive Manna's downfall, but amass huge amounts of wealth doing so. She cares not for actual wealth, of course, only the power it buys... And she's bought it all.
- **The Fassle Twins**, Maridane's right (and left) hand bugs, a caterpillar and centipede respectively. Tomas Fassle knows numbers and markets. Timothy Fassle knows people and politics. A pair of geniuses who have made only a single error - believing Maridane to be their puppet.
- **Gideon Kilsher**, Maridane's drunken, overly entitled son, interested only in decadence. Often found tangled in his own webs.
- **Pal Horden**, a small-time cloth merchant with a pushcart, a house filled with grubs, a garage filled with inventory, and a head filled with dreams of having his own trade route.

THE SHINING EMPIRE

General Mood: Arrogant, militaristic, principled
Home Turf: Fountain Plaza

When famine struck the city of Manna, a band of dragonflies led an exodus of hungry citizens out of the merchant-controlled Food Court and into Fountain Plaza, where they spawned a marshland empire.

A STRONG ARMY (feature)

In order to survive in the deadly waters of Fountain Plaza, the Empire has spent generations cultivating a nation of warriors and culture of battle. Of honour and glory. Of steel and stinger. They arrived prey, but the flowing waters of the fountain have carved them into a legion of dragonfly heroes. *Maybe...*

- The Emperor leads through pure strength where possible. The bugs of Fountain Plaza rely on a scuttling army to protect them from frogs and fish and brigands. They may fear the Emperor's soldiers, but they fear their absence moreso.
- The Empire's army is larger than it ever has been, well-armed and at the ready. With a word, the Emperor could send a swarm of soldiers to casually occupy half of Manna before dinner.
- Suspecting The Merchants to be meddling in the mini-golf war, the Empire has started sending military aid to The Green Ants. What the Guild stands to gain is unclear, but their actions are *undoubtedly* a threat to the shining seat of Varian's power.

A BRITTLE THRONE (npcs)

This empire was built on the shoulders of strong leadership and steadfast council... Neither of which remain today. *Maybe...*

- **Emperor Varian**, recent inheritor to the throne. Varian is young, squeamish, and nothing like his venerated dragonfly father. He is paralyzed by even small decisions and is sure of only one thing - he's always wanted to be a painter.
- **General Nebrixis**, is an advisor as impatient as he is ruthless. Despite increasing stress-molting, the General is loyal to the throne and determined to guide Varian to a victory befitting an emperor.
- **Magister Cassian**, a challenger to the throne. Cassian thinks the Emperor is weak, thinks the General brutish, and believes Fountain Plaza deserves better. *He's not going to say that out loud, of course.*
- **Domina Marice**, sister of Imperator Justice, a commander exiled to the Concourse for disagreeing with the previous emperor.

A Consumer's Travel Guide

Ever had the urge for ice cream, inoffensive elevator music, and endless tiled floors? Then you're heading in the right direction, little bugs!

The Westgate Mall has seen better days, from a certain perspective, but the spirit of mercantile endeavour is stronger than any Mysteriocalyptic shake-up. One thing's for sure: there's no better place to hunt for a life-defining bargain. *The entries below all represent distinct areas of the Mall that a band of bugs might stumble upon as they travel, as well as the features and landmarks they could encounter.*

The Concourse

The Plaza, Food Court, and Funzone are separated from each other by Westgate Mall's main shopping area, a quartermile of white porcelain tile, gleaming aluminium benches, and rows of shuttered boutiques. A wide expanse where any brave bug can roam free (though they're likely to be instantly eaten by birds), this 'Concourse' is a desolate, haunted place.

A Desert of Porcelain (feature)

Crossing the Concourse is very difficult, and not something the average bugly citizen would ever consider. What few expeditions set out that way are the stuff of fables, the travellers that make them up typically falling into one of two camps: the exceptional, or the desperate. *Maybe...*

- Traveling on foot out in the open is a bugly death sentence. Over a dozen chickadees nest here, living on a steady diet of wanderers and fools. Travelers without some kind of cover, concealment, or existing agreement with the birds will be targeted within a few minutes of venturing out across the tile.
- So why not take the Undertiles? A hidden network of tunnels, vents, and crawl spaces is rumoured to run beneath the Concourse, tightly controlled by scam artists and rough-shelled gangs.
- The safest, most reliable way across the concourse is on Dog, who visits each area once per day as part of his routine. Passage on Dog requires payment to both the Merchant's Guild *and* the beast's native flea population.

The Chickadees (npcs)

Named for their battlecry, this clan of small black and white birds has occupied this territory since before the fall, when two-legged herd animals would leave them seed offerings. *Maybe...*

- The chickadees perch on shop signs and hop along handrails during the day, looking for prey. At night they nest higher up, near the skylights.
- They may be songbirds, but they hunt like raptors. Though smaller and weaker than the birds of the greater wilds beyond the Mall's walls, chickadees have been known to fend off large predators through sheer numbers.
- The Concourse is their land, and they'll defend their home to the last, but the chickadees have little interest in the other parts of the Mall. Food has dwindled since the development of the Undertile network, however, and some younger members of the clan have their eyes set on new territory.

Sugar Haven Clip Joint (landmark)

Whether you travel above the tile or below, on foot or by canine express, you are likely to stop at the toppled soda machine known as Sugar Haven, a clip joint designed to wring your purse dry in exchange for brief shelter, crummy supplies, bad food, worse company, and as much high-proof fermented soda as you can handle. **Keep your wits about you.** *Maybe...*

- Beds, toilets, entertainment, water - nothing here is free except the soda. You pay for your table and then for your chair. You pay to get in. You usually pay even more to leave.
- **Dasani** is a glasswing butterfly who dances after dinner, chats briefly with (paying) guests, then hurries out through a secret corridor before the stroke of midnight.
- The owner, **Sierra Mist**, is as charming as she is devious. She's always accompanied by her favorite bodyguard, a snail who goes by the name of **Crush**.

DOG (npc)

Dog is big and fluffy. Dog wears a neat vest. Dog waits happily for his long-absent owner to return, trotting around the mall in a steady routine, completely oblivious to his central role in the bug transport and shipping economy. *Maybe...*

- Dog starts each day by peeing against the side of the Clip Joint, during which desperate travelers may find a brief window to hop aboard.
- Next he heads to Fountain Plaza to swim, drink, and bark at frogs. Cargo and passengers exit into the water and are retrieved by boat. New goods are loaded by a specialized fleet of dragonflies, loyal to the Shining Empire.
- Soon Dog gets hungry and walks to the Food Court, where his breakfast has been left in a special bowl near the Bazaar's freight yard to facilitate loading and unloading while he's distracted.
- In the afternoon, Dog makes his way to Buggy's Funzone to chew on golf balls and nap in Soft Play. Teamsters wait near a well-worn indent on his napping mat.
- After his nap, he heads back to the Food Court for dinner, where freight workers load the day's final cargo and passengers prepare for overnight travel.
- Finally, Dog returns home to the Concourse, where he looks wistfully at the moon and falls asleep on his owner's coat.
- *There's a good chance that, given Dog's general lack of observational prowess, he may not even have noticed the coming of the Mysteriocalypse, and the world-shaking changes it heralded. This has worked out well for the bugs of the Westgate Mall, and there's a general agreement between all parties that talk of the Mysteriocalypse anywhere near Dog's shaggy ears is strictly forbidden - just in case.*

EXPLORING THE CONCOURSE

When a band of bugs treks across the Concourse, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: A cracked tile.
2: A haunted heap of bone-white mannequins.
3: A jewelry store display window, and the corpses of greedy bugs who couldn't find their way out.
4: A convincing mirage.
5: RC car transmitter, dislodged battery.
6: Toppled stroller.

NPCs

1: **Brightly**, a chickadee outcast who doesn't like the taste of bug.
2: **Ratter**, a centipede who will take you under the tiles for a price. Charges per tile.
3: **Wild Cherry**, a bubbly gossip working at Sugar Haven.
4: **Lum**, a merchant who fell off the wagon, then off the Dog, then probably off the wagon again.
5: **Mallet and Ann**, deserters from the Funzone hoping to become brigands.
6: **Imperator Justice**, an exiled dragonfly commander feared by all chickadees.

Events

1: A chickadee collides with a display window.
2: The Mall's intercom crackles on and a mysterious announcement echoes out.
3: A chickadee family stops hunting to hold a funeral.
4: Dog crosses the Concourse.
5: A band of brigands crashes Sugar Haven.
6: Dozens of terrified bugs begin evacuating the Undertile.

THE FOOD COURT

Legends say the gods left behind a feast. Mountains of food heaped on plastic trays, warming in metal basins, and siloed away in deep garbage bins. From that bounty, the glorious city of Manna was born. Word of its comfort and prosperity drew bugs from all over. The city boomed - population surging and purses growing fat. It was a time of decadence, a time of hubris, a time that could not last.

When the food ran low, Manna collapsed under its own weight. Many left, more starved, and a lucky few became very, very rich. Today, the city is a sprawling slum, entire neighborhoods shuttered and necrotic. A wealthy merchant class rules from their luxurious countertop villas, the rest of the citizens scratch out lives for themselves below, every morsel hard-won and twice-stolen.

THE BAZAAR (landmark)

The pride of Manna. Humming with wingflutter, ringing with crowdcall, and smelling of everything - spices and nectar, mulch and wasp paper, brass polish and raw meat. A pulsing marketplace five tabletops across, connected with crowded bridges, and surrounded by the villas and estates of the rich above, and the slums and shanty towns of the poor below. *Maybe...*

- Looking to buy? The Bazaar has anything you need, plus everything you could ever want. Fried bread and stickmeats and fresh waterlilly juice. Shellshines and foot rubs and pan flute lessons. Batteries. Lighter fluid. Overpriced imports from Book & Coffee. It's all there, from bits to bobs to bolts of spidersilk.
- Looking to sell? You can apply with the Merchant's Guild to receive trade papers and a market stall. Or throw down a blanket, lay out your wares, and take your chances! Colorful items sell well here, as do flavours from far-flung locales.
- Looking to go somewhere? Twice per day, the Dogport opens. You can take the afternoon ride to Buggy's Funzone for a handful of bits and bobs, or the overnight to Fountain Plaza for a significantly larger handful of *shinier* bits and bobs. If you aren't keen on dogs or need to avoid The Merchant's Guild, you may find Undertile routes across the Concourse by asking around The Bins.

THE BINS (landmark)

It's just like all the locals say: if you want to see the *real* Manna, head along down to The Bins. Where the alleys smell like garbage. Where the street food can't be beat. Where music breeds and laughter spills. Where hope takes effort and dreams are for sleep. Where the Guild takes your dinner and the gangs lick your plate. Where life is what it is. Where things are what they are. Where clotheslines cross and walkways sway. Where a stranger is equally likely to be mugged or invited in for tea. *Maybe...*

- It is hard to go unnoticed here. Visitors are easily recognized and closely observed. Be prepared for pickpockets, territorial gangs, and swarms of curious school-grubs asking you questions.
- The Merchant Guild's lenders routinely come through town to shakedown residents, sometimes clashing with gangs who were in the middle of doing a less veiled version of the same.
- On Feast Days, any stairway will eventually lead to what **must** be the best party in town, where you're sure to be welcomed in as long as you know how to have a good time. Even in the off-season you can usually find some action by following the music or asking the right person.

TEMPLE KITCHEN (landmark)

Temple Kitchen is operated by an order of cockroaches that called the Food Court home well before the Mysteriocalypse. They guard their secrets tightly, work new hires to the bone (metaphorically speaking), and spend every hour of every day preparing for the next feast. *Maybe...*

- The Temple is always hiring. Scullions and spicers, greaslings and mop-bugs - the work is unpleasant, but at least it pays bad.
- The most dangerous job is, of course, frost mining, where brave fools are sent into walk-in freezers with picks and saws to harvest chunks of frozen food.
- Although Temple staff guard their ingredients closely, there are usually enough scraps, spills, and unattended pans for stealthy chefs to do a bit of unsanctioned cooking.

FEAST DAY (feature)

Manna was founded in a time of plenty. And while the cornucopia is little more than legend, each month the residents still do their best to pretend, celebrating their history with an elaborate ritual feast. *Maybe...*

- In the days leading up to Feast Day, people busy themselves with party preparation. Decorating, cooking, planning games and rehearsing plays. A friendly spirit of competition arises as Manna's citizens all try to throw the best party.
- On Feast Day, everyone skips breakfast to attend a very solemn, sacred blessing ceremony which naturally could go wrong in any number of ways considering the amount of candles and robes.
- After the ceremony, the feast begins. Celebrants go from house to house, party to party, meal to meal, eating and drinking their way through their neighborhood and partying until daybreak.

EXPLORING THE FOOD COURT

When a band of bugs gluttonifies the Food Court, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: Two abandoned mining carts filled with chunks of thawing food.
2: A toppled stack of lunch trays.
3: A grease-stained shanty town made from overturned to-go containers.
4: A decorated soda can with something jangling inside.
5: A darkened kitchen with an icy draft.
6: A strange, gurgling floor drain.

NPCs

1: **Poss Funtly**, a rich buffoon saying "now see here" between bites.
2: **Rex**, an easily provoked guard with beautiful beetle-green armor.
3: **Pith**, a knowledgeable street urchin picking pockets in The Bins.
4: **Trash and Switchblade**, low-level gang members determined to feel bigger than the few people smaller than them.
5: **A Temple worker**, tattooed and constantly smoking.
6: **Allison, Mackenzie, and Bee**, sloppy festival-goers who got separated from the group because *someone* just had to get their face painted, huh Allison?

Events

1: An exceptional fruitfall year promises the biggest Feast Day in years.
2: Food shortages and trade issues threaten second great famine.
3: Dog does not show up for his meal today, shocking the marketplace.
4: A trash fire rips through The Bins.
5: An expedition returns with news of a newly discovered freezer, filled with valuable inventory.
6: *The rats arrive*.

Fountain Plaza

A pair of mossy escalators lead down into the green waters of Fountain Plaza, a smaller, lower section of the Mall, entirely flooded due to an unmaintained water feature. Rushes, duckweed, and other aquatic vegetation have turned the Plaza into a flourishing wetland.

Greenwater (landmark)

Between the escalators and the fountain, a friendly boomtown hums with activity and buzzes with mayfly wings. Farmers grow pondweed and algae, diving beetles hunt for sunken treasure, and the nurseries lovingly churn out today's generation. The townsfolk are plucky, hard-working, and tragically gullible, constantly taken advantage of by the Plaza's more predatory residents. *Maybe...*

- Because of mayflies' short lifecycle, there is a new mayor each day, complete with an election, a swearing-in ceremony, new laws, broken campaign promises, and some kind of corruption scandal by dinner time.
- Houseboats, fishing boats, rafts, and barges jockey for prime anchorage and bicker over territory, uniting routinely to fend off pirates or welcome newcomers.
- Farmers deposit their harvest into a large storehouse built on top of a half-submerged mall directory. Some is sent to the nursery, some is sold in the market, and most is put aside for Fountaintop's tax-collectors.

Fountaintop (landmark)

All water comes from Fountaintop. A single sparkling rivulet running over the lip of the fountain's marble basin and into the pond waters below. Fountaintop is the Plaza's seat of power, an aristocracy dominated by a lineage of highborn dragonflies. *Maybe...*

- At Fountaintop's entrance, artisans, soldiers, and imperial servants hurry about on a series of delicate bridges and walkways spanning the fountain's basin. Below, silver coins shimmer on the bottom of a crystal pool.
- Imperators, damsels, courtiers, and nobility gossip and scheme behind a curtain of water on Fountaintop's second tier.
- The Emperor himself resides in a partially constructed glass palace on the top tier of the fountain. Materials are salvaged from the Mall's chandeliers and mirrored paneling, and the entire structure is so delicate that the penalty for speaking above a whisper is death.

Bath & Body (landmark)

The west side of the Plaza is home to a flooded beauty shop, fragrant and intoxicating. It is now a decadent bathhouse where well-moisturized amphibians luxuriate in scented froth, absorb chemicals, and slowly go mad. A trail of candlelit lily pads leads inside, where you are greeted, offered a complimentary eyeliner cap of sparkling wine, and required to change into the provided silk robes. *Maybe...*

- The calming waters of the bathhouse keep the patrons docile and happy to talk, if only for their own amusement. They are sponges for gossip, adore Westgate's politics, but their moods have been known to shift unpredictably. *Beware*.
- A one-eyed newt named Soapwright works diligently in his apothecary. He can brew almost any potion, as long as you bring him the right ingredients.
- The bathmaster, Big Bubble the Bullfrog, is so relaxed he can't remember his own name. He only gets upset when food runs low and he's forced to rouse his lazy underlings and go raid Greenwater.

Book & Coffee (landmark)

Across the Plaza is a flooded bookstore, where snail archivists crawl over (and under) islands of wet pages, deciphering runes and puzzling over ancient texts. Vendors call to you from flotillas of paper cups, pushing curios, relics, secrets, and spells. *Maybe...*

- The archivists will buy knowledge from strangers, but are much less willing to sell it back. The market vendors on the other hand, have plenty to sell, although it's hard to guarantee quality.
- A large goldfish named Glub sleeps on the pond floor, surfacing once per enoch to state a single truth about the past world. Some say he is immortal, absorbing the water's knowledge through his skin.
- Teams of diving beetles from Greenwater come here to sell their haul to the vendors. They know the depths better than most, but you have to prove yourself to come with them.

Exploring Fountain Plaza

When a band of bugs splashes through Fountain Plaza, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: A dangerous whirlpool responsible for the sinking of countless vessels.
2: A lighthouse keeper mans his repurposed LED reading lamp.
3: An algae farm established on an old plastic bag, the logo emblazoned upon it faded yet cheerful.
4: A bobbing bar of vanilla soap.
5: An old fishing boat caught in the watergrass.
6: A duck nest, as terrifying as expected.

Events

1: A mayfly reaches the end of its life mid-sentence.
2: Greenwater is raided by great-smelling frog berserkers.
3: A fishing crew catches something that should have stayed down there.
4: A spurned aristocrat challenges a powerful rival to a duel.
5: Fountaintop stops flowing.
6: Duck sightings panic the entire population.

NPCs

1: **Mayor O'Connor the Nine Hundred Seventy Fourth**, promising change!
2: **Merry Gary "The Ferry" McClarey**, a fisherman who will give anyone a ride.
3: **Pibbles**, a salty old diving beetle on a lifelong search.
4: **Sallabathius Ebenamattahem**, a snail archivist who talks real slow and loves formal introductions.
5: **Dame Julia**, a nervous damselfly burdened with dangerous court gossip.
6: **Baronet Witmore**, an easily offended fop with one of those big wigs.

"whoever made this 'd' letter look almost the same as this 'b' letter should be ashamed of themselves. And that's saying nothing of 'q'..."

Zip Spiratron, Frustrated Snail Archivist

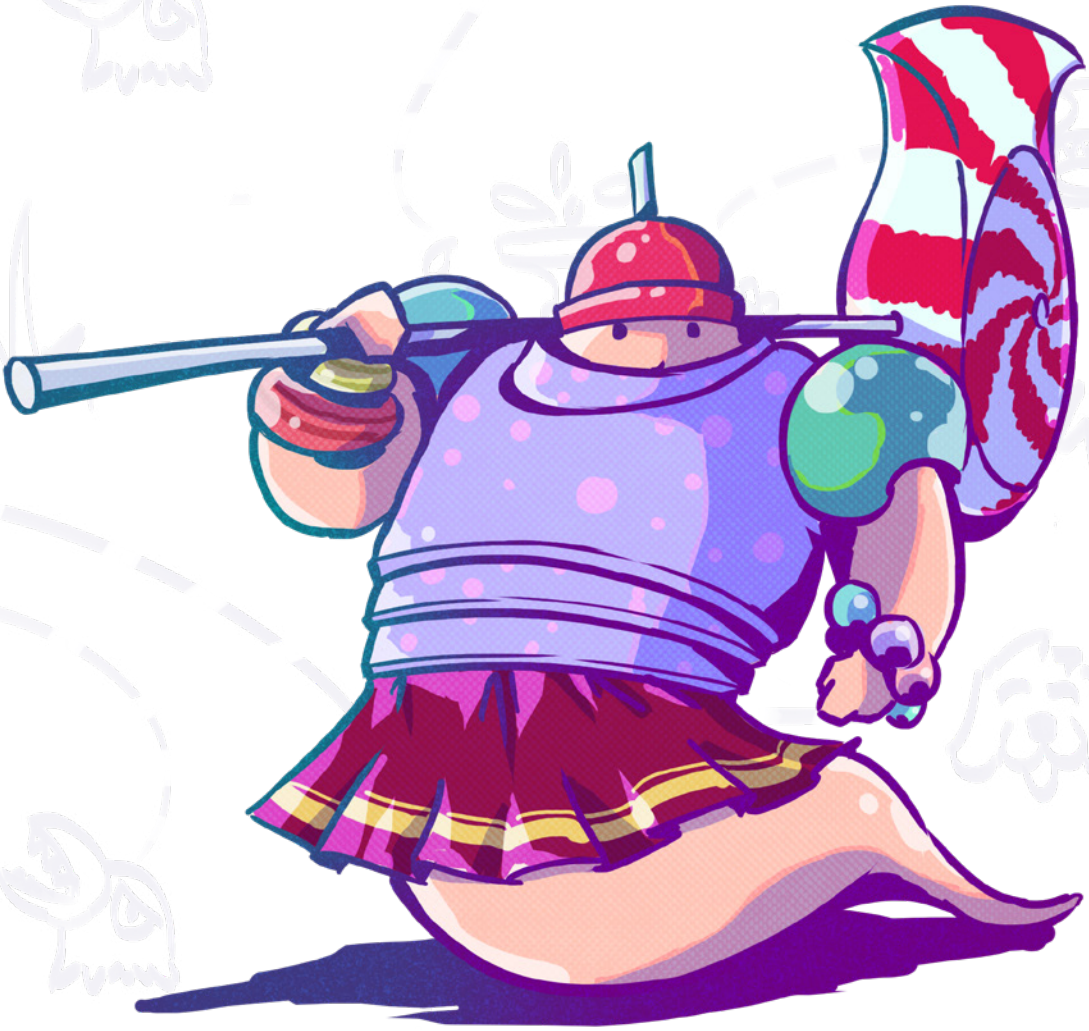
BUGGY'S FUNZONE

As you enter the Funzone, you're greeted by the graven image of Buggy himself—a cartoon beetle over four feet tall, worshipped here as a god of war. At his feet is a shrine, densely cluttered with old offerings and portraits of fallen soldiers. As you approach Buggy's motion sensor, his aging animatronics lurch to life while he garbles "Have fun, kids!" through a damaged speaker.

MINI GOLF (landmark)

An eternal battleground, where two nations of ants fight over ownership of pocked white spheres for reasons long forgotten. *Maybe...*

- The eastern half of the course is controlled by The Green Ants, named for the leaking jug of lime snow cone syrup that sustains it. Their territory includes North Bridge, The Windmill, and two spheres. The general is recruiting spies to find information on Purple's next target.
- The Purple Ants, named for a torn sack of grape cotton candy sugar, control the western half. This includes South Bridge, Dino Dan (and his volcano), and one sphere. The general is forever on the lookout for saboteurs, amoral sorts that might be hired to destroy North Bridge.
- A water hazard snakes through the middle of the course, crossed by two plaster bridges. A worldview shattering cache of golf balls lies under a layer of algae, still undiscovered by the navy of either nation.



BUILD-A-TITAN (landmark)

It sounds like an auto shop and smells like burnt sugar. Grisly piles of cotton batting and button eyes cover the floor of this munitions factory, where a sect of hooded artificers assemble bespoke war machines—terrifying constructs of cloth and scrap metal to bolster thy ranks and scatter thine enemy! *Maybe...*

- These weaponsmiths are unfriendly but professional, transactional but pricey. Upon payment, a guide will help you build your own titan, leading you silently through the Seven Stations of Warbirth. At each station a choice is made, and once made it can't ever be unmade - no matter the consequences.
- Malfunctions happen. A rabid stuffed bear with staplers sewn to its hands lurches towards you, stuck in berserker-mode, programmed to exterminate anything in its path. It says 'I love you' when squeezed.
- The elder warsmith, Decimus, has grown introspective in retirement. He has built a hermitage in the display window, where he spends his days sitting meditatively, watching a single weed grow from a crack in the tile. Whether Decimus regrets his many seasons of weaponcraft is the kind of topic that artificers refuse to breach, and visitors would do well to follow their example.
- Some bugs whisper that the snydra coiling around the depths of Soft Play is actually nothing more than stuffing and cloth, an animate horror of the Built-A-Titan factory. Others assure them that the snydra is actually very real, very scaly, and very much full of meat and bones and things, but it takes a lot of sensible talk for a good scary story to wither.

EXPLORING THE FUNZONE

When a band of bugs rollick around the Funzone, the Weaver might want to make a d6 roll on one of these tables to see what they come across...

Landmarks

1: Shoe, right.
2: Dead titan, stuffing everywhere.
3: Old pet store bag, broken terrarium inside.
4: Action figure, unboxed and stripped for accessories.
5: RC car, no transmitter.
6: Giant wad of gum, no survivors.

NPCs

1: **General Helen**, tough, gruff, and paranoid.
2: **Private Alice**, upbeat and positive, despite being completely shell-shocked.
3: **The Prophet Kevin**, proclaiming Buggy is a god of fun, not war.
4: **Samson**, a retired gladiator with a sugar habit.
5: **Hemolymph Mary**, an assassin with a heart of gold, stored in a cooler along with the other hearts in her heart collection.
6: **Jackson Ammo**, an arms dealer with growing scruples.

Events

1: Titans go haywire and rampage toward the Food Court.
2: A betting dispute devolves into war at the Soft Play.
3: Dog drops a tennis ball on the mini-golf course.
4: The Ball Pit snydra needs something bigger to eat.
5: Road warriors on RC cars zoom past, headed for the Concourse.
6: A dragonfly squadron from Fountaintop joins the fray.

SOFT PLAY (landmark)

A colourful indoor playspace where children once came to lick the bacteria off of slides. It's now a den of mercenaries, ronin, gladiators, and budding warlords.*Maybe...*

- This wall of cubbies overflows with abandoned shoes and jackets and now serves as a hostel for rowdy mercenaries. You can book a night in a floor-shoe for next to nothing, but a cubby-level shoe will cost you.
- The Octagon, found at the top of the Soft Play structure, is a large turquoise mat surrounded by eight padded posts and pink nylon webbing. Winners are cheered by bloodthirsty crowds, losers fall down one of three slides. One of those slides opens up over The Ball Pit.
- At the very heart of Soft Play lies the vibrant graveyard of the Ball Pit, a blanket of colorful orbs two feet thick, hiding a carpet of dust, weapons, and the husks of the dead. *The snydra lives here, or so rumour would suggest.*

CHAPTER 12:
THE APP-END-IX

PiCo
Character Sheet

Short Pic-nic

[Player Name]

NAME

Pseudo [ ]

[description]

[pic-ture]

SKILLS

Max Rank: 3

Moving
- Dash
- Climb
- Dig
- Slink
- Fly
- Swim

Friending
- Yap
- Swagger
- Dazzle
- Scare
- Care
- Tame

Finding
- Sense
- Hunt
- Rummage
- Think
- Make
- Chart

Rumbling
- Bash
- Bite
- Slash
- Sizzle
- Dance
- Shield

ASPECTS

... and augments

MOOD

[ ] [OK] [ ]

BITS & BOBS

Carrying Slots [Start: 6 / Current:]

MYSTERY

[?]

CREATIONS

PiCO
Character Sheet

Long Pic-odyssey

[Player Name]

NAME

Pseudo [ ]

n

[description]

MYSTERY

[?]

MOOD

[ ] [OK] [ ]

BITS & BOBS

[Carry Slots: Start 6 / Current]

CREATIONS

ASPECTS

SKILLS

Max Rank: 3

Moving

- Dash
- Climb
- Dig
- Slink
- Fly
- Swim

Friending

- Yap
- Swagger
- Dazzle
- Scare
- Care
- Tame

Finding

- Sense
- Hunt
- Rummage
- Think
- Make
- Chart

Rumbling

- Bash
- Bite
- Slash
- Sizzle
- Dance
- Shield

PiCo
Character Sheet

Short Pic-nic

[Player Name]

NAME

Pseudo [ ]

[description]

[pic-ture]

SKILLS

Max Rank: 3

Moving
- Dash
- Climb
- Dig
- Slink
- Fly
- Swim

Friending
- Yap
- Swagger
- Dazzle
- Scare
- Care
- Tame

Finding
- Sense
- Hunt
- Rummage
- Think
- Make
- Chart

Rumbling
- Bash
- Bite
- Slash
- Sizzle
- Dance
- Shield

ASPECTS

... and augments

MOOD

[ ] [OK] [ ]

BITS & BOBS

Carrying Slots [Start: 6 / Current:]

MYSTERY

[?]

CREATIONS

PiCO
Roaming Sheet

NAME

ANIMAL

Pic-nic

FAVOUR

GAINING FAVOUR

JOURNEY

DAY

NIGHT

BITS, BOBS, CHUNKS, & NOTES

TRUTHS

TITAN-DEN

GIGASKILLS

Max Rank: 3

AURA

UNIQUE BENEFITS

PiCo
Roaming Sheet

NAME

ANIMAL

Pic-odyssey

JOURNEY

DAY

NIGHT

GIGASKILLS

Max Rank: 3

FAVOUR

GAINING FAVOUR

BITS, BOBS, CHUNKS, & NOTES

TRUTHS

AURA

UNIQUE BENEFITS

TITAN-DEN

RULES SUMMARY

While not exactly jam-packed with rules, PICO does deviate from the classic Wild Words Engine in a few important ways. The next few pages give a quick-and-dirty breakdown of the rules of PICO, as well as page references for when you need to see them in context.

GENERAL STUFF

Just useful to know!

THE WEAVER Pg 191

PICO's GM figure, shortened from 'Weaver of Tiny Stories'. They run the game, and keep things moving.

GAME STRUCTURE Pg 30

A game of PICO is split into scenes, montages, and journeys. Each of these different modes of play have a core of similar rules to follow, but also unique rules of their own. We'll devote some space to each of these types of play within this rules summary.

SPOTLIGHT Pg 30

Moves from character to character naturally through play, but can be directed by the Weaver. Can be visibly tracked in tense moments, using A to record actions and R reactions. Can be hijacked by certain moves/abilities, but should usually be given back to the individual it was hijacked from when that move is over.

SIZE Pg 12

Characters can be Nano, Small, or Large. The effects are mostly narrative, but some aspect and hazard rules take size into account. **Bugs are Small unless otherwise indicated.**

TRACKS Pg 32

A series of linked boxes that can be used in a variety of situations to measure progress, time, or damage.

Tracks can be marked with a **/** or burned with a **X** (a burn usually representing a more lasting mark that's hard to clear). When a track fills, something changes.

Tracks can also have breaks, points on the track that signal a change before it fully completes.

Most character actions fill one box on a track. Actions with giga impact fill all boxes up until the end of a track, or until the next track break.

Tracks can also be open (out for everyone to see) or hidden (visible only to the Weaver).

ACTIONS Pg 34

Taken when a player wants their character to do something. If an action is difficult, dangerous, or dramatic, they'll usually require a roll of the dice. You can get dice for this roll from your character's **Skills** (1-3d6), **Aspects** (1d6), and **Advantage** (1-2d6, from environmental, teamwork, or bits and bobs usage).

When rolling for an action, look for the **highest result** and if there are any **doubles**. *Scenes, Montages, and Journeys may require different types of rolls.*

The standard action roll gives...

- A **Triumph** on a **6**, which shows things have gone really well. If you're affecting a track, this lets you mark or clear a box.
- A **Conflict** on a **5** or **4**, which shows things have gone alright, but not perfectly (or that there's an equal mix of bad and good). If you're affecting a track this *might* let you mark or clear a box at the cost of some associated drawback.
- A **Disaster** on a **3**, **2**, or **1**, which shows things have gone awfully wrong. If you're affecting a track, you don't get to mark or clear a box. There will definitely be some kind of drawback.
- A **Twist** on a **double**, where any other player at the table can suggest a small extra detail (either bad or good) that comes about as a result of the action. Twists can give information, a change of fictional position or situation, a bit or a bob... Anything really, as long as it's not too game-altering.

When a character takes an action, they naturally take the spotlight. If another character has the spotlight, don't break in and do an action of your own until they're done!

REACTIONS Pg 36

Like actions, but instead of being decided by the player they're prompted by the Weaver. They work like actions in terms of building a dice pool, rolling, and reading the dice, and usually have the same results spread as shown above, but some reactions have their own special results (more on that later).

CUT Pg 38

Removes a number of results after rolling dice, equal to the cut amount (starting with the highest, to represent an increase in difficulty). There are five different types...

- **Tough Cut**: For a general increase in difficulty
- **Armour Cut**: For rolls made against well-defended targets
- **Speed Cut**: For rolls made against swift targets, or to attempt to complete an action with great speed
- **Camo Cut**: For rolls made against targets that are difficult to see, or in murky conditions
- **Complex Cut**: For rolls made against unpredictable targets, or in extremely complex situations

Different kinds of cut stack together - a Tough Cut of 1 and a Speed Cut of 2 on a roll gives a total cut of 3.

IMPACT Pg 40

A measure of the impact an action or event has on the world. Impact is split into four different levels...

- **No Impact**: For an action that has no effect on the world. Doesn't mark boxes when affecting a track.
- **Low Impact**: For an action that has minimal effect on the world. Marks one box fewer than usual when affecting a track.
- **Normal Impact**: For an action that has the expected effect. Marks the usual one box when affecting a track.
- **Giga Impact**: For an action that has massive, often impressive effect on the world. Marks all boxes on a track, or until a track break is reached.

The basic impact of most actions is **normal**.

TRUTHS Pg 44

Established by solving mysteries, recorded on the Roaming Sheet. Truths are used to gain environmental advantage on a roll if relevant, and can also be called on for a free twist by each player once per session.

COMBOS AND FINISHERS Pg 46

A combo track is a three box track set by the Weaver. When taking an action, a bug can burn a box on one of their aspects - if their action is a Conflict or Triumph, this also marks a box on the combo track. When the combo track is filled, a bug can clear it to either **increase their next action's impact by one step**, or to **ignore all cut on their next action**.

SCENE STUFF

The most common mode of play, with few special rules to take into account outside of those for having a rumble with dangerous hazards.

POINTS OF INTEREST Pg 50

These are useful or important elements of a location, mentioned by the Weaver as they describe a scene or elicited by player questions. POIs are useful for gaining environmental advantage, for gathering bits and bobs, and for allowing a bug to do something that wouldn't be possible with only their own body and equipment.

GATHERING Pg 52

A special type of roll used to gather bits and bobs from the environment. The dice pool is made as normal, but the results are read as follows...

- A **Triumph** on a **6** gives you exactly what you want.
- A **Conflict** on a **5** or **4** gives you what you want, but it's not as nice as you expected (may come with a negative tag) or there's a downside to acquiring it.
- A **Disaster** on a **3**, **2**, or **1** means whatever you were trying to gather is completely unfit for purpose or entirely unobtainable, and you may take damage trying to get it.
- A **Twist** on a **double** can be treated as usual, giving a small unexpected benefit, or can be used to add a tag of your choice to whatever you acquire.

RUMBLE TRACKS Pg 56

When a rumble begins, new tracks might be used. These are...

- **Spotlight Tracks**: Kept by the Weaver to track who has acted in a scene, and marked with an A to represent an action and an R to represent a reaction. *Hazards may be added to a spotlight track if the Weaver wishes, but this is up to personal choice.*
- **Heart Tracks**: Kept by the Weaver to track the damage a hazard takes, or the progress toward the end of a rumble (as a rumble can be won with damage, without damage, or with a mixture of both approaches).
- **Combo Track**s: Kept by the Weaver but visible to every player, these can be filled and then cleared for massive damage or the ability to ignore cut.

ATTACKING Pg 58

Used to attack a hazard. Any skill can be used to attack, and the damage an attack deals is equal to the action's impact. The dice pool is made as normal, but the results are read as follows...

- A **Triumph** on a **6** lets you deal damage and add an effect.
- A **Conflict** on a **5** or **4** lets you deal damage or add an effect (your choice), OR deal both damage and add an effect but also take some damage or an effect yourself.
- A **Disaster** on a **3**, **2**, or **1** means you've missed, and take both damage and an effect from your target instead.
- A **Twist** on a **double** can be treated as usual, giving a small unexpected benefit, or can be used as a critical to deal an extra mark of damage. *If you're dealing giga damage that gets stopped by a break, a critical marks the next box after the break.*

DEFENDING Pg 59

Used when a hazard attacks you. Any skill can be used to defend, and it requires a reaction rather than an action. The dice pool is made as normal, but the results are read as follows...

- A **Triumph** on a **6** lets you avoid all incoming damage and effects.
- A **Conflict** on a **5** or **4** lets the Weaver choose to hit you with either damage or an effect.
- A **Disaster** on a **3**, **2**, or **1** means you take both the damage and effect.
- A **Twist** on a **double** can be treated as usual, giving a small unexpected benefit, or can be used as a counter to deal normal impact damage to the hazard attacking you.

DEATH Pg 66

... Is always a player choice. If you fully burn every box on your aspects, you can curl up and hide until the end of the scene. At the start of the next scene, completely clear a single heart of your choice for free and you're back in the action.

DEALING DAMAGE Pg 60

Damage doesn't have to be physical - actions that trap, demoralize, or scare hazards all still deal damage. Hazards can also be engaged through non-combat means, solving their problems or befriending/ negotiating with them - it all goes on the same heart track, and ultimately counts as damage, so everyone can contribute no matter their skills.

- **Weaknesses**: When you hit a hazard weakness, increase your impact by one step.
- **Resistances**: When you hit a hazard resistance, decrease your impact by one step.
- **Immunities**: When you hit a hazard immunity, it won't take any damage (but can still take an effect).

TAKING DAMAGE Pg 62

Damage is represented by marks made on a character's aspect track, with the player choosing the most relevant track when they take the damage. Hazards don't use the same levels of impact as bugs, and instead deal more granular damage (usually between 1 and 6 marks).

Breaks on an aspect stop damage, allowing for tactical defence. If a bug takes more damage than their aspect track can hold, it wraps around and starts converting marks to burns. You can't split damage from one source over multiple aspects.

If a bug has **resistance** to damage, it takes half the usual marks. If it has a **weakness**, it takes double.

EFFECTS Pg 64

Attacks and actions can also have effects. These are mostly freeform, but some are common enough to have a specific name and some simple rules...

- **Push and Pull**: These move a hazard around the environment.
- **Stun**: These prevent a hazard from taking the spotlight next. *If a player character is stunned, they also can't take the spotlight next and any hazard that attacks them triggers an auto-disaster due to their inability to react.*
- **Grab**: Entangles two individuals. The larger individual can easily move or throw the smaller, and the smaller individual may be able to climb around or ride on the larger.
- **Swallow**: Allows a hazard to trap a character until they find a way to escape.

MONTAGE STUFF

A mode of play used to pass time quickly, while getting useful things done. Every bug in a montage gets a task to use, which can either be freeform or can be used for...

MOULTING Pg 80

This allows a bug to spend Nectar and gain a new aspect, augment, or skill rank, but requires a safe place to moult.

Aspects cost 3 Nectar, Augments 2 Nectar, and Skill Ranks an amount of Nectar equal to the rank you're gaining.

RECOVERING Pg 71

You can use a task to sleep, pulling your mood to positive, or to heal, clearing one mark from any of your aspects. If you're in a settlement, you can clear burns as well as marks. If you choose to roll instead, **consume a bit** and use the results below...

- A **Triumph** on a **6** lets you clear two marks, or clear one mark and pull your mood positive.
- A **Conflict** on a **5** or **4** lets you either clear one mark or pull your mood to positive.
- A **Disaster** on a **3**, **2**, or **1** means youdon't clear any marks, but you pull your mood to neutral.
- A **Twist** on a **double** can be treated as usual, giving a small unexpected benefit, or can be used as a bump on your healing, clearing an extra mark or moving your mood an extra step.

SCROUNGING Pg 72

This works like gathering, gaining you a bit or a bob, but you get a greater degree of control over the type (you can specify what you want, like 'something shiny' or 'something sticky') thanks to using a task. Roll the dice and use the results below...

- A **Triumph** on a **6** lets you find exactly what you were looking for.
- A **Conflict** on a **5** or **4** lets you find something close to what you want, or something that's exactly what you want but it also has a negative tag supplied by the Weaver.
- A **Disaster** on a **3**, **2**, or **1** lets you find a bit or bob that has nothing to do with what you wanted.
- A **Twist** on a **double** can be treated as usual, giving a small unexpected benefit, or can be used to add a positive tag to what you find.

MYSTERYIZING Pg 74

This allows you to use a task to potentially make a small discovery, bringing you closer to solving a mystery. Roll the dice and use the results below...

- A **Triumph** on a **6** lets you make a small discovery.
- A **Conflict** on a **5** or **4** lets you find something that allows an ally to make a small discovery.
- A **Disaster** on a **3**, **2**, or **1** means you find nothing, and nobody gets to make a small discovery.
- A **Twist** on a **double** can be treated as usual, giving a small unexpected benefit, or can be used to go down the rabbit hole, allowing the Weaver to add a new truth to the world.

COOKING Pg 76

Using a task to cook requires two bits, and creates a meal with benefits based on the bits used (adding an extra bit allows for an extra portion of the meal to be made). A meal can offer **resistance to a damage type, +1 skill rank, or a reduction of one type of cut by 1**. Each meal or portion is enough for one bug. Roll the dice and use the results below...

- A **Triumph** on a **6** has the meal/portion grant benefits for the rest of the scene.
- A **Conflict** on a **5** or **4** has the meal/portion grant benefits on the next relevant action or reaction.
- A **Disaster** on a **3**, **2**, or **1** gives no benefit.
- A **Twist** on a **double** can be treated as usual, giving a small unexpected benefit, or can be used to add depth of flavour with a second benefit, or can have each meal/portion pull mood positive when eaten.

CRAFTING Pg 78

Using a task to craft requires two bobs, and creates a contraption that mimics a part, gear, or buddy (adding an extra bob allows for an extra copy of the contraption to be made). Each contraption or copy is enough for one bug, and if its nonexistent track would ever be marked, it works once and then falls apart. Roll the dice and use the results below...

- A **Triumph** on a **6** has the contraption/copy grant the mimic aspect for the rest of the scene.
- A **Conflict** on a **5** or **4** has the contraption/copy grant the mimic aspect once, before it breaks.
- A **Disaster** on a **3**, **2**, or **1** gives no benefit.
- A **Twist** on a **double** can be treated as usual, giving a small unexpected benefit, or can be used to add an augment to the aspect your contraption/copy is mimicking.

JOURNEY STUFF

Journeys let a band of bugs get from one place to another, finding adventure along the way (if they're lucky).

THE JOURNEY TRACK Pg 84

Set by the Weaver, a special kind of track that has both boxes (to measure the amount of strides it takes to get to a destination) and a ticking clock (to represent the time that passes, and keep track of night and day).

Journey track lengths are determined by the Weaver. Ticking clocks are always eight segments, with the upper 4 being day and the lower 4 night.

LEADER AND TRAVEL ACTIONS Pg 86

For each part of the journey, the players should choose one character to be the leader. The leader decides which travel action to take, chosen from the list below...

Ramble: Your group advances at a gentle pace.
Lookout Rolls: Yes
Surprise!: No
Distance Covered: 1 stride
Time Taken: 1 tick

March: You move swiftly and seriously.
Lookout Rolls: Yes
Surprise!: Yes
Distance Covered: 2 strides
Time Taken: 1 tick

Wait: You stay in one place, alert.
Lookout Rolls: Yes
Surprise!: No
Distance Covered: None
Time Taken: 1 tick

Camp: Your group takes a breather and sets up camp, starting a montage. Tasks can be used to go on the lookout as well as usual montage actions; if nobody is on lookout, the band can be surprised.
Lookout Rolls: Maybe
Surprise!: Maybe
Distance Covered: None
Time Taken: 2 ticks

If you're riding a picotitan on a journey, double the amount of marks made with each travel action.

LOOKOUTS AND LOOKOUT ROLLS Pg 88

Each bug that isn't the leader is on lookout, and gets to roll 2d6 to see if they spot anything while travelling. For this lookout roll, check the results table below (if you don't get any of the results below, you've spotted nothing interesting).

- **Double 6**: An unexpected landmark.
- **Double 5**: A trove of stuff.
- **Double 4**: An event in progress.
- **Double 3**: A change in the weather.
- **Double 2**: An NPC.
- **Double 1**: A looming hazard.

The Weaver can add secret or random results to increase the chance of certain lookout outcomes, or can introduce an encounter or choice of their own making regardless of the dice rolled.

ENCOUNTERS AND CHOICES Pg 90

Whether found with a lookout roll or put in the path of the bugs by the Weaver, encounters and choices represent an interesting and potentially dangerous point along a journey.

Choices simply require the bugs to make a decision between two or more options. Encounters usually begin a small scene, taking longer but offering more potential rewards.

SURPRISE Pg 91

Players usually decide whether to engage with a choice or encounter, and can often avoid it if they wish. But if they're **surprised**, they can't avoid it - they have to engage because they're caught off guard or blunder right into the middle of things.

If the encounter quickly becomes a rumble, this state of surprise lasts for a single action (typically the first action taken).

WEATHER AND LIGHT Pg 94

Can change due to a lookout roll, a microclimate, or the Weaver's decision. Each weather type outside of the usual Calm Skies (Rainstorm, Cold Snap, Sporenado, Heatwave, Gale) has possible special rules a Weaver can choose to apply.

Light conditions are either described as Daylight or Darkness. Bugs can see fine in both, but some hazards and aspects interact with one or the other in special ways.

CHARACTER STUFF

Characters are bugs, and bugs can be complex!

NECTAR Pg 102

A character creation and advancement resource, given by the Weaver at the beginning of character creation and also as a bug learns and grows through play. 25 Nectar gives a good starter bug, and 50 gives a more experienced bug.

Nectar can be stored indefinitely, and can be used during a montage to Moult and advance a character's skills or aspects.

NAME Pg 168

Bugs have two names, a **Common Name** and a **Pseudoscientific Name**. The pseudoscientific name is taken from a combination of a bug's aspects and augments, and the common name is decided entirely by the player.

ASPECTS Pg 104

Maximum 6 per bug. Describe the special elements of your bug. Each aspect has a Name, a Track, a Type (Part, Gear, or Buddy), and some Benefits and/or Drawbacks. When a track takes damage, represent that with a **/** for a mark or a **X** for a burn. Fully marked/burned tracks don't give you their Benefit, but they do still give Drawbacks.

Aspects can also have Breaks in their tracks. If marking or burning multiple boxes on an aspect track at once, stop when you hit a break. If you need to mark a track but it's fully marked, convert existing marks to burns instead.

- Part aspects describe something biological, a special feature of your bug.
- Gear aspects describe something important that your bug has found or made, that they'd never be seen without.
- Buddy aspects describe small friends, pets, or companions that are devoted to your bug, and stick by them at all times.

AUGMENTS Pg 106

Added to aspects to give them longer tracks and additional benefits. An aspect can have a maximum of two augments.

Aspects and augments also give an optional pseudoscientific name component.

SKILLS Pg 144

Add dice to a roll that relates to the skill equal to the number of ranks a character has, either 1, 2, or 3. Skills are split into four categories: Moving, Friending, Finding, and Rumbling.

MOVING SKILLS

- **Dash**: For sprinting and leaping
- **Climb**: For scaling ropes and flatter surfaces
- **Dig**: For burrowing into the ground
- **Slink**: For keeping a low profile
- **Fly**: For taking to the skies
- **Swim**: For cutting through liquids with speed

FRIENDING SKILLS

- **Yap**: For talking, joking, and finding information
- **Swagger**: For throwing your weight around
- **Dazzle**: For impressing and surprising
- **Scare**: For leveraging fear and shock
- **Care**: For tending to plants and injuries
- **Tame**: For putting creatures at ease without words

FINDING SKILLS

- **Sense**: For learning about the world around you
- **Hunt**: For tracking beasts and finding food
- **Think**: For processing information and deducing
- **Rummage**: For finding lost things and useful trash
- **Make**: For building and tinkering
- **Chart**: For finding paths and making maps

RUMBLING SKILLS

- **Bash**: For hitting and barging things
- **Bite**: For sinking your teeth in
- **Slash**: For deft cuts and spiky assaults
- **Sizzle**: For using flames or acid
- **Dance**: For moving with rhythm and flow
- **Shield**: For taking hits like a champ

Skills are flexible by design. Each skill can always do what it describes, but can also do other things that may only be tangentially related if the situation feels right (so Swim will always let a bug Swim, but a bug without Swim might try to move through water using something like Swagger or Dance if it fits the situation).

Skills also double as damage types - when a bug deals or takes damage, it's always of a type that matches one of PICO's skills. Some bugs, and some hazards, are resistant, weak, or immune to various skills.

Bits and Bobs Pg 160

Every bug has a number of **carry slots** (usually starting at six, but this can be added to by a bug's aspects). Each carry slot can hold a bit or bob.

Bits are organic things that can usually be eaten, like a drop of syrup or an acorn. **Bobs** are synthetic, inorganic things, and usually can't be eaten, like a paperclip or a rusted nail. *Each bug begins the game with two carry slots full of bits and bobs, but can gain more as they adventure.*

Bits and bobs are used to add dice to rolls, to create things during a montage, or to trade with NPCs. They also often have **Tags**, special words like 'sweet' or 'sticky' that give you more information about them, and might suggest interesting ways they might be used.

Chunks are massive versions of a bit or bob, like an entire orange versus a single orange segment. A band of bugs can only carry one chunk around with them at a time.

Moods Pg 156

Each bug has three moods placed on a five-box track. **OK**, the middle mood that covers the second, third, and fourth box of the track, is neutral - it has no special rules. The first box of the track is given over to a negative mood, and the fifth box to a positive mood (these are chosen at character creation).

The mood track holds a single mark that begins at OK, and pulls negative or positive depending on world events, such as...

- **The Weather** (either direction)
- **Winning a Rumble** (either direction)
- **Making a Grand Discovery** (either direction)
- **Finding an Impressive Location** (either direction)
- **Finishing a Tiny Story** (either direction)
- **Using a Task to Recover or Sleep** (which always pulls the mood marker toward OK).

Mysteries Pg 164

Each bug chooses a mystery at character creation, which can hold three **small discoveries**. Small discoveries can be made when a bug notices something that might be relevant to their mystery, and calls it out.

When three small discoveries are made, a bug can make a **grand discovery** that adds a new **truth** to the world of PICO, maybe even changing reality as it does so.

Picotitan Stuff

Sometimes, having a big friend around is really, really helpful - a picotitan can be acquired through trading, earning, raising, inheriting, or even stealing (if you're an amoral sort).

Special Rules Pg 174

- Picotitans are controlled by the Weaver, but bugs can spend Favour to have them perform specific actions.
- Picotitans have an aura of competency that makes certain skills used in their presence more effective.
- Picotitans have their own gigaskills and unique benefits.
- Picotitans can be ridden during journeys, doubling the amount of strides covered with a travel action.
- Picotitans don't enter settlements and won't typically join rumbles.
- Picotitans can carry a titan-den, built with chunks, which gives additional benefits. A picotitan can carry one chunk at a time.

Spending Favour Pg 176

Picotitan favour can be spent on the following actions...

- **TITANIC AID**: Allows a bug to subsitute their usual skill for one of the picotitan's inherent gigaskills.
- **TITANOTASK**: Allows the picotitan to perform a single task independent of any bugs.
- **TITANWATCH**: This allows the titan to spot something on a journey (gain a free lookout result).
- **TITANOSPEED**: Triples the distance bugs travel with a single travel action rather than the usual doubling.

Titan-Dens Pg 184

Miniature settlements built upon a picotitan, like a travelling base. When adding a feature to a titan-den, bugs need to **begin** a montage, **consume** the required chunks (listed in each feature's entry in the picotitan chapter), **use** one task to complete the construction, and **spend** a point of picotitan favour.

KICKSTARTER BACKERS

Thank you, people, for making PICO possible. May you always find delicious bits and interesting bobs.

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[done :P], CahoonM, Zane Dempsey, John M, Branko Trifunovic, Antón Castro Charlón, Willie WILLIAM, Jakub "Pompejusz" Solecki, Michael Ellars, Elodie Hedera, Lauren & Scarllette, Tabby, Adaliante, Jamesbug, Kaylabug and Rowanbug, Kevin and Tish, BK Benifield, George Blalock, Ethan M, Chris J, Iggy U., Dany Tétreault, Michael S. Parson, Clef Demoncat, Andrew Steinke, Daniel Yamashita, Charlie the Catbug, Steven Watkins, NintendogsOnly, Star Force, Matija Šiško, An Chang, Jérôme Chaniol, Matthew Ayers, Matthew Johnston,

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BUTTERFLIES

Sean O, Evan Ackley, Punny cat, Ninjagnocchi, Rob Leigh, Mason Krakty, Andrea Baka, Jon Hartmann, Dan Harris, Matt Hartwell, Persei Jackson, Teemursu, Andrew Adair, Nick Penman PhD, Ando Ha, Augustas Vaitkevičius, Juniper ducky, Wesley Noble, Robert Alvey, Ryan Junk, Stephen M Palmer, Fangerang, Mateo Williford, Karsing Fung, Francisco Ferrer, Toby White, Joe Maliksi, Gardengnome, Alessia Maiorano, Bears, Alex Guevara, Hyper Harebell, Maxime Amyot, Kit Davis, Lulu, Dreampod, Pedro Arrochela Lobo, Finn Berry, Nao the Kitsune, Devon Kampman, Katiana S., atomjenkins, MacGuffin, Jacob M, James Blair, Brett Syndergaard, Cory J Minor, Drowrin, Trystan L Williams, Ryan Rasey, Eric Li, Johnathan Butler, Tadhg Mackay, Julia Niemeyer, No matter how small, together we are mighty, Anneliese Furlong-Muir, Jacob May

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Greg Higgins, Michael Boothroyd, EnryBS, Jesse S, Frank C., Jack Mann, Yoann Foulon, Maya Alexandria, Adrian Tchaikovsky, Dante Warborn, Mottelz, Sox, Hannah Zoe Hagen, Adam Beltaine, Yes please!, Todda, Daryl Tay, Layla Adelman, Peter Pegues, Jon C, Hollie Zimmerman, Nova, Nigel McClelland, Alex Bookbinder, Pete DiMaria, Peter K., Robert Iken Lee, Max Magana, PJ Underwood, Matthew Snover, Colin “TinMan“ Kulsa, Aurore Durand, Philip Andrews, Jane Vance, Dylan “Toaster“ Sabin, Nathan Jones, Michael Gray, Kelson Smith, No thanks, Francisco J. Navarro., N. Hay, Wren Walden, Liora the Wingyvix, Surumu - A tiny bug in a big world, Ciarán Melarkey, Ada Pitts, Spencer Finewood, B Hughes, Rich & Nina Petch, Thomas law, Rayan Khadeer, Randy “Party of Bards“ Pinion, Team Ling, 142, Izzetmaster, Xeborus, Niels Levert, Anna Lerahk, Rev. M.R. Amy, James W, Sean Daugherty, Matthew Franklin, Roger Eberhart, Jenna Stew, Lucas Mejia, Alberto Valdes, Thomas Family, Ben Fox, Jared Haverkamp, Troper, Tyrama Kreienkamp, Ben Neilsen, Rufus Orsborne, The World Anvil Publishing, Bruno “Varstahl” Passeri, Cort Bouldin, Mike Llaneza, John TC, Hurlebise, Matter, Drew “Secondhand“ Scarr, Jon Beckham, Feepz, Andrew J. Bonham, Jason Schindler, Ellis Archuleta, Frantisek, Fandalf Jirutka, Mel Wray, BoBasho, Josh Rensch, Chris & Charlotte, Rodger Scott, FryGuy456, Daria Rose LeFevre, Tsuyu the Sable, Richard Hammer, Aswabor, Azweepei, Justin Slabaugh, Ben Miller, Bug Fan, TASagent, M. Stephen, Transliminal Tales, Tom Hosking, Julian H., Andy Meyerhoefer, VioletDreamer & DoctorPuppy, Drew W., Angelo Pileggi, Craig “Doc Webb“ Langrall, Haus of Qwert, Can-Ege Tunca, Jesper Cockx, Joseph LeMay, Aisling Jensen, James JC Wallett, Ellabombella, Sam Marshall, Ryan Dale, Yake, Quarx, clax, trashclown, SchiWaRad, Tim Rangi, Joshua “Stormhammer“ Beltz, Jordan Hunt, Fran Gallegos Torres, The O'Malley family, Malek Annabi, Matt Weinberg, Molly Isaacs - still a very proud Sister!, Christopher Kramer, Archie Lamprell, Heptalemma, Grahfvitnir, Richard Warren, Marco “VereorNox“ Tronti, Neal Hinnant, Saw, Richard Podmore, Bryan Weedon, Andrew Grzeszczak, Mark John “LEGO_Nabii“ Stafford, Sean Jack, Tk, Adam Holland, Avarice77, Jack Heidrick, pyphen, Aaron J., Colleen Rose, Josh Beals, JacobPearwood, Padraic Cashin, Becky-Jane Stronach, Linda, Felix's Mother, Pixel - The Great Meme Dragon, Rick, Jon Kenny, like a great contributor, Kara Baker, Simon “Wyldedawg” Wild, Silvern the Dreamer, Marina

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... As Well As All The Typo-Finding Volunteers

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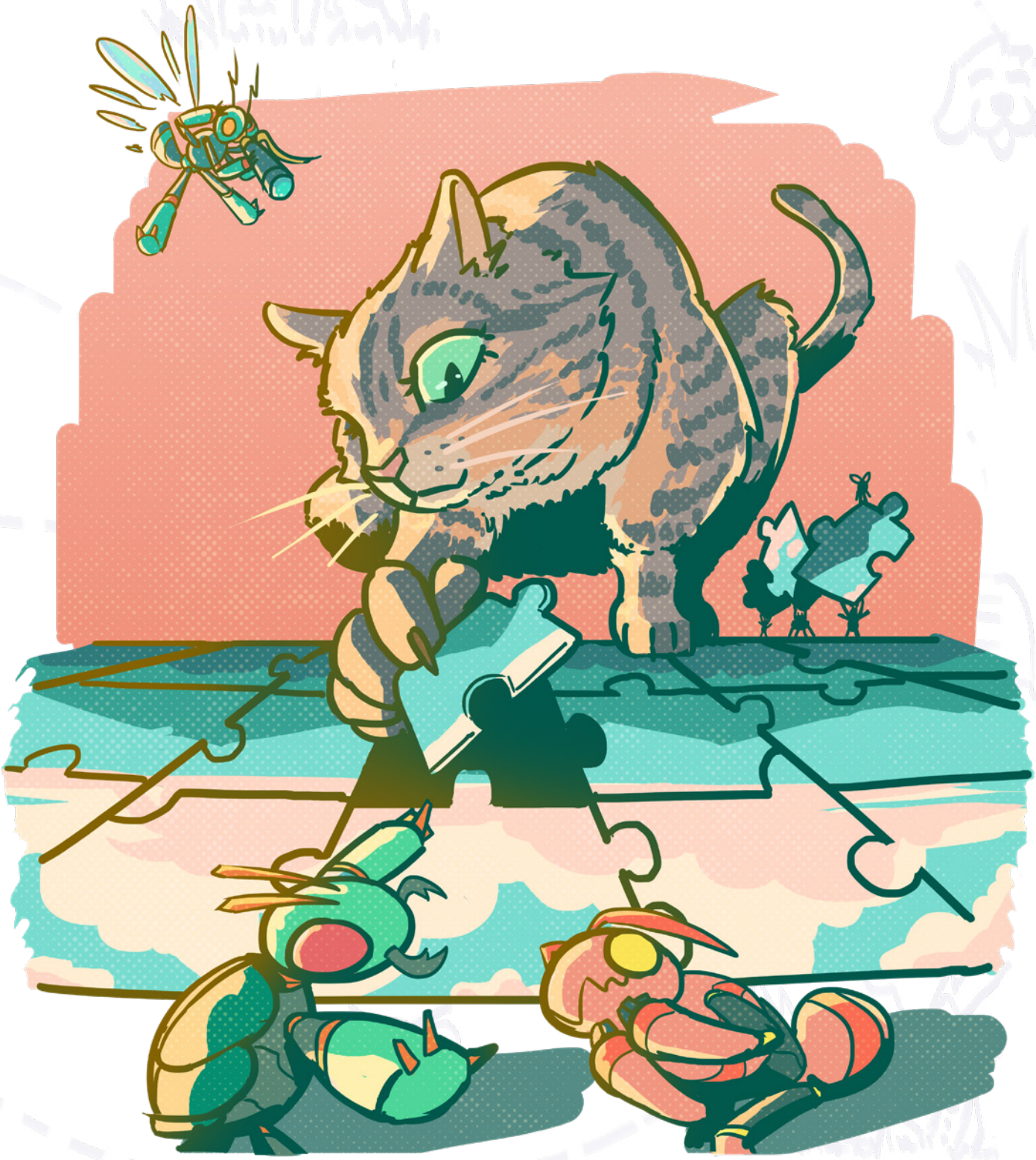
... AND MIRA!

The number one puzzlecat :3



THE TEAM

PICO wouldn't exist without the help and hard work of a variety of people. Many of them are pictured here, but I also want to give a personal shout-out to anyone that's playtested, discussed, and given feedback on the game throughout the last few years of development.

It's strange to see how 'proper' PICO has become - I wasn't expecting the level of support we got, enough to turn a fun little side project into a major release.

So hopefully you understand, little bug, that when I say this I'm being completely serious...

We really, truly, couldn't have done it without you.

- Felix

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*This one goes out to childhood me, and his love of bugs, to Elise and Tiny Felix, who taught me that not **all** small children are dreadful, to Samuel and Archie (both very friendly real-life picotitans), and finally to the members of Team Cherry - the wait was worth it!*

Pico

TINY BUGS, BIG WORLD
Ever wanted to be a scuttling, buggish sort, riding around from place to place on the back of a titanic cat, making deals with frogs and flowers, solving mysteries as you explore the oversized ruins of the post-Mysteriocalypse?
You *have*?
How incredibly specific.
This book may be just right for you.
Juice
TOLD BY WILD WORDS